

The Ancient Age

LINN NA FÈITHE

The Legendarium OF DIA-CHÌR

— The Ancient Age

(An Aois Àrsaidh)

being the Books of the age, the Annals of its years,
a Gazetteer of its towns, and the Appendices
the Vein Era, VE 1 – 5,324

Cuimhnich an teine.

Remember the fire.

cut on Colbh Cnoc chiar

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CHAPTER ONE

OF the MASON and the LIGHTNING

VE I

Bha teine sa chloich. There was fire in the stone.
*The First Part: Of An Clachair's Fire, and the Covering of the
Vein*

I

Of the Dry Spring

This is told at the hearth, on Oidhche an Dealanaich¹, by whoever in the house is oldest, and it begins before the mason ever touched the wedge, in the season when his valley had no water.

The spring under the shoulder of the hill had fed that household and three others since before anyone living could say. It rose out of a fold of rock, cold even in high summer, and ran a hand's width wide down a groove worn into the stone by every year it had ever run. In the autumn of that year it failed. It did not fail all at once. It thinned through the wet months when it should have been running full, and by the dark of the year it was a trickle a child could stop with two fingers, and then some mornings there was nothing in the groove at all but a damp stain and a smell of old moss.

The valley did not starve. There were becks lower down, and the households sent their water-carriers a mile and a half with skins on their backs, morning and evening, in whatever weather the year gave them, which that year was mostly sleet.

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

But a valley that carries its water on its back through a hard winter learns to want a well of its own, dug where the rock holds water even when the sky will not give it, and the households met at the flat stone below the failed spring and talked of digging one.

They did not choose lightly, for the digging of a well in that country was slow and cruel work, done with a wedge of hard stone and a maul of oak, a hand's depth of rock at a time, and the man who did it would be at it through the worst of the winter with his knees in the mud and his back to the wind. They chose Neachdan, because he was the best splitter of stone that any of the four households could put a name to, and because he had said, when the others were still weighing whether the spring might yet come back, that it would not, and had gone to look for a place to sink the shaft while the rest of them were still talking.

He was not yet thirty. He had split more stone in his life than most men split in two, walling folds and lining graves and setting the flat stones that floored every threshold in the valley, and there was not a household in it that did not owe him some doorstep or some byre wall. His father had taught him the trade and had been dead some years. His wife was Sorcha, and they had a house at the low end of the valley with a boy of six named Conall and three littler than Conall, and it was Sorcha who came out to the new-marked shaft on the first morning with a skin of water and stood a while watching him set the first wedge, and said nothing, because there was nothing to say that the wedge and the winter had not already said between them.

II

Of the Wedge and the Rock

he began below the flat stone, on a rise a little east of the dead spring, where the older men of the valley said the rock ran true and would not crack sideways on him and waste his work. It was the dead of the year, past the shortest day, and the light he had to dig by was grey from first light to last, with sleet in most of it.

The way of it was this. He set the hard wedge into a seam of the rock with the flat of his hand, judged it true, and struck it with the oak maul, and struck it again, and went on striking until the rock gave along the seam or did not, and if it did not he moved the wedge a hand's width and began again. A day was perhaps

two hand's-depths of shaft, if the rock ran kind, and less if it did not, and there were days that whole short winter when he came up out of the cut at dusk with nothing to show for it but split knuckles and a wedge blunted at the edge.

The cold did that to him before the rock did. His hands split at the big knuckle and across the base of the thumb, the way a mason's hands always split in a hard winter, and the cuts never had time to close between one day's work and the next, so that by the dark of the year his hands looked older than the rest of him, red-rimmed and cracked and always a little wet, whether from the wound or the weather there was no telling. He wrapped them in strips of hide when Sorcha made him, and lost the wrapping within the hour because a man cannot feel a seam in stone through a hide glove, and Sorcha stopped making him after the fourth time, and only rubbed grease from the sheep-fat pot into the cracks at night while he sat by their own small fire, which in those days on Dia-thìr was no fire at all: a heap of dark stones set out on the south face of the hill to take what sun the day had, and carried in at dusk wrapped in bracken, giving off a heat that was more memory than warmth by the time it reached the house.

There was no other kind of fire on the island. No one on Dia-thìr had ever seen one lit; there was the sun, and there was the lightning, which came and went and could not be carried, and there was the slow patient husbandry of sun-warmed stones and piled skins and bodies packed close, which was how every household on the island had always held off the worst of a winter, and none had ever held off all of it. Old people died of the cold in a hard year, and children died of it, and it was accepted as the weather was accepted, because there was nothing else to do about either.

By the fifteenth day of the digging the shaft was over Neachdan's head, and he worked now with a rope ladder of plaited hide and a leather bucket that Conall's cousin hauled up from the lip, full of chippings, forty and fifty times a short winter day. The rock had begun to run darker as he went down, a grey going to black, harder under the wedge than anything above it had been, ringing instead of cracking clean, so that he had to strike twice or three times where once had done. He did not think much of the darkening. Rock ran however it ran; he had cut through worse.

III

Of the Black Break and the Colours In It

On the morning it happened the sleet had turned half to rain, which was in its way worse, since rain finds every gap in a cloak that sleet only sits on.

He went down into the shaft before the grey light was properly up, because the household wanted water and every day he did not reach it was a day the carriers walked their mile and a half twice more.

A seam ran clean across the face of the cut, a hair's width of a line that his eye, trained on twenty years of stone, told him would open true. He set the wedge and struck.

It went with one blow, which in that hard black rock had happened perhaps twice in the whole digging, and the block came away in his hands heavier than its size promised, and he nearly dropped it. He turned it toward the little grey light that came down the shaft from above.

Every stone he had ever split in his life, in that valley or any other, had broken to the same thing: grey dust, grit, a dull grey face going to a duller grey the longer it lay in the weather. This did not. The break ran black, black as a wet crow's wing, and along it, where the maul had opened the vein, there was colour: a streak that lay gold when he tilted it, the way the sea takes the low sun at evening though he had never seen the sea; a scatter of small points that shone white as frost catches the light before frost has any business shining; a vein of dull red-brown like the true heart of an old oak split for a beam; a thread that ran silver and did not tarnish when his thumb rubbed across it; and, set apart from the rest, a piece that when he turned it slowly held colour after colour after colour, so that he could not have said what colour it truly was, only that it was every one he had a name for and some, he thought afterward, that he did not.

He knelt in the bottom of the cut with the rain running off the shaft's lip onto the back of his neck and turned the pieces over and over in his cracked hands until the cold had taken the last of the feeling out of his fingers and he could no longer tell by touch which piece he held.

He did not know what it was. No one on the island had ever seen coal, coloured or otherwise; there was nothing in any hearth-tale, any wall-lore, any word passed down from any grandfather, that gave this a name or a use or a warning to go with it. He knew only that it was beautiful, and that a man does not leave a beautiful thing in the bottom of a well shaft to be flooded over when the water comes in, so he opened the neck of his tunic and put the pieces inside, against his chest where his own small warmth might keep the rain off them a while, and went on working the seam until there was no more colour in it and only the plain grey-

black beyond, which he left where it was, because a well is dug for water and not for stone.

Midday found him climbing out of the shaft with his tunic heavy and lumped against his ribs and the light no better than it had been at dawn, meaning to show Sorcha what he had found and go back down before the light went altogether. He never went back down that day.

IV

Of the Storm at Dusk

The sky had been low and grey and giving rain in a steady, sullen way since before he woke, the kind of day that does not announce a change in it. The change came in the middle of the afternoon, while he stood at the lip of the shaft chewing a strip of dried mutton that one of the little ones had brought him, and it came the way weather comes on that coast when it means to be taken seriously: the wind backed round from its steady quarter and freshened all in a few minutes, and the low grey overhead thickened from the west into a darker grey that had a green cast at its underside, which the old people of the valley said was a colour a sky takes before it does something worth remembering.

He judged, watching it come, that there was no sense going back down the shaft into a storm; a man in a hole in the ground in a hard rain is a man waiting to be drowned in his own well. He gathered his tools, capped the shaft-mouth with the split boards kept there for it, and looked for shelter, and found it under the lip of a low crag a stone's throw above the shaft, an overhang no deeper than a man is tall, but dry, where the herders of that hillside sheltered their beasts in the worst of a summer squall.

The storm came up the valley like something walking. He watched it from under the crag: the rain-curtain moving across the far slope first, greying it out entirely, then the near slope, then his own; the wind driving hard enough to lean the heather flat and to find its way even under the lip of his shelter and set the rain slantwise against his legs; and the light going to a strange thick yellow-brown, nothing like the grey of an ordinary evening, that made the whole valley look, he said afterward, the way a bruise looks a day after the blow.

Then the sky broke.

There was no other way any teller of it, then or since, has ever said it. It did not thunder first and lighten after, in the ordinary way of a storm working up to its worst; it went from the yellow-brown stillness straight to a white light that filled the whole overhang he crouched in, so bright that for a moment he saw the black rock of the crag above him as though it were noon, and in the same instant a sound came that he did not hear so much as feel in the ground under his knees and in his own teeth, a single crack, as if the hill itself had been struck with a maul the size of the sky.

He was thrown back against the rock. When his sight cleared enough to see anything at all, he saw that the light had not simply flashed and gone, as lightning does. It had gone down. He had watched it, in the half-second his eyes could hold it, run down out of the cloud in a white line no wider than a spear-shaft, and strike the ground below the crag, on the very line of the capped shaft, and vanish into it.

For a long moment he did not move. The rain went on falling. The wind went on. Nothing in the valley below him showed any sign that the sky had just done a thing no one living had words for.

Then he saw the light.

It came up faint at first from around the edges of the split boards over the shaft-mouth, a low reddish glow, the colour a coal takes at the heart of an ember, and it did not fade the way an afterimage fades from a struck eye. It grew. By the time he had got his legs under him and come out from under the crag into the driving rain it was strong enough to throw his own shadow, black and long, across the wet heather in front of him.

V

Of the Thing Alive in the Well

he came to the lip of the shaft with the rain running into his eyes and pulled the split boards aside, and the light came up out of the ground and struck him full in the face, and he knelt there at the edge with the rain hammering his back and looked down at what he had made, though he never afterward believed he had made it, only that he had broken it open and the sky had done the rest.

The whole face of the black seam, as far down as his eye could follow it in the murk of the shaft, was awake. It did not burn the way he imagined fire must burn, if he had ever tried to imagine such a thing at all; it moved low along the vein, a dark flame with red at its root, the colour of peat-water stirred up from the bottom of a bog and lit from within, and it breathed. That was the word he used all his life after, and no other word ever satisfied him or the people who heard him tell it. It swelled and drew in, swelled and drew in, as a chest does, and where it swelled the heat came up the shaft in a wave he felt on his face and on his hands before he felt anything else, a heat with no wind in it and no cold anywhere behind it, the first warmth any living thing on Dia-thìr had ever felt that did not come, however faintly, from the sun.

The rain fell into the shaft in sheets, straight down the sides where the boards had been, and struck the burning vein, and hissed, and the vein did not go out. Rain that should by every reason he had ever been taught have drowned the thing dead went on falling into it and coming off it as a thin white smoke that the wind took away over the hillside, and he could do nothing but watch it, a long while, unable to do anything else.

He put his hands over the shaft-mouth, not into it, only over it, the way a man holds his hands to a fire he has not yet decided to trust, and the warmth came up into his split and blackened knuckles and into the base of his aching thumbs, and something in him that had been clenched since the dead of the year, since the spring failed and the sleet began and his hands began to crack, let go all at once. He knelt in the mud at the lip of his own well with the storm going on over him and wept, not loudly, the way a man weeps who has been cold a long time and has stopped expecting to be warm again, and he was not ashamed of it afterward, though he did not tell it often, and it is the one part of the whole telling that the households of that valley have always agreed was surely true, because it is not the kind of thing a teller invents to make a tale better.

VI

Of the Coal Carried Home

Kneeling there, he could not know whether the thing would live an hour or a year, and it was that not-knowing, more than anything else, that moved

him. A wonder that might go out with the next gust was a wonder that had to be taken while it could be taken.

He found among his tools a flat stone he had set aside from the digging, one of the pale slabs meant for the new well's coping, and he went down the rope ladder into the shaft, into the heat and the strange breathing light of it, with the rain still coming down the sides in ropes, and he chose a piece of the vein near its edge, where the burning had not yet reached its full strength, and worked it free with the antler pry he used to lift split slabs, careful as a man lifting an egg from under a sitting bird. It came away whole, a fist-sized lump of the black seam with the dark flame still moving in it, throwing more heat in his two hands than the whole warmed-stone hearth of his house threw in a night.

He set it on the flat slab. He drew his cloak from around his shoulders, wet through as it already was, and folded it over the burning piece so that only a slit was left for air, the way, without ever having been told to do such a thing, a man's hands simply know to shelter a flame from wind and wet at once; and he climbed the ladder one-handed, *Leac na Fèithe*¹ and its burden held against his chest with the other arm, and went out into the full weight of the storm to carry it the mile down the valley to his own door.

It is the walk that every teller of the mason's tale slows for, whatever else is passed over quickly, because it is the walk on which *Teine a' Chlachair*² on *Dia-thìr* was nearly lost a dozen times before it was ever set on a hearth. He went slant-wise down the hill so that his own body stood between the coal and the driving rain. He stumbled twice on wet stone and each time caught himself with his free hand and never let *Leac na Fèithe* tip. Once, crossing the beck that fed the failed spring, swollen now with the storm's own rain, he waded it rather than risk the stepping-stones in the dark, holding *Leac na Fèithe* high over the water with both arms, the cloak's wet wool steaming faintly where the coal's heat met the flood below it. He said afterward that he had not once, on the whole of that walk, thought about the water in the well or the winter or anything else the household had sent him out that morning to solve; he had thought only of the small red light under the cloak, and of keeping it.

1. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at *Tobar dhìreach*

2. the mason's fire, the first fire

VII

Of the First Hearth

Sorcha had the door open before he reached it, because she had seen, coming down through the rain, a light where no light on that hillside had any business being, low and red and moving with him, like nothing that hillside had ever shown.

He came into the house stooped over *Leac na Fèithe*¹ like a man carrying something asleep that he feared to wake wrong, and set it down in the centre of the floor, on the ring of bare-swept earth kept clear for the sun-stones, and drew back his cloak from it, and the household saw, for the first time in the history of anything that had ever lived on that island, what a flame was.

Conall, who was six, came close enough that Sorcha had to catch the back of his tunic, and the three littler than him stood behind their mother's legs and would not come close at all, and stared at the low red-black light with the wide unblinking look of children who cannot yet tell whether a thing is dangerous by anything but its strangeness. Neachdan told them, because he did not yet know better himself, that it would not hurt them if they let it be, and for that first night it was true, since none of them touched it and it did nothing but breathe its slow dark flame and give off a warmth that reached every corner of the one room they had, farther and steadier than any warmed stone had ever reached it.

He remembered the rest of the coloured pieces still in his tunic and drew them out, one by one, and set them by the burning one to see what they would do, and this is the part of the telling that every hearth in the hill country still gives the same way. Each piece, laid against the fire, caught. Each burned as the first had burned, low and dark-flamed, and as each caught, the colour went out of it: the gold sheen dulled to the same red-black glow as the rest, the white points dimmed, the red-brown vein and the silver thread and the last strange piece that had held every colour at once all burned down, in the end, to one same low dark flame indistinguishable from any other, so that within the hour there was nothing left in the whole burning ring to tell a man which piece had shone gold and which silver and which had held the rainbow.

Neachdan looked at that a long while, turning the last blackened lump with a stick, and he told his children, and told it again at every hearth-night after, that he

1. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhireach

had been sorry for it, a little, the way a man is sorry to see any beautiful thing spend its last; and that he had been glad all the same, more glad than sorry by more than any measure could set between them, because his household was sitting round a fire, red-faced in its light, with the rain still hammering the turf roof above them and none of them cold, for the first time since any of them could remember being alive at all.

VIII

Of What the Fire Taught in One Night

It did not stay a simple wonder for long. A fire, once made, carries its own nature along with its light and its warmth, and that nature had to be learned in the same night it was given, by people who had never had reason to learn it before.

The first lesson came within the hour, when the flame at the heart of the ring began to sink and dull of its own accord. The roof kept the rain off it; it had simply nothing more to take. Neachdan understood, watching it fade, what none of the tellings that came before him could have told him, because there were none: that the thing ate. It had eaten the black rock it was born in, slowly, breathing its heat out of the burning stone, and now the coal he had carried was more ash-grey crust than the black it had been, and the flame under the crust was going the colour of a dying ember rather than the strong dark red it had shown at the shaft.

He broke the crust with the same stick, more from the instinct of a man cracking a nut than from any knowledge, and beneath it the coal still glowed, and the glow strengthened when the air reached it, and that told him a second thing, though he could not have put a name to what it told him: that the thing wanted feeding and wanted air both, and would not simply burn until it was done and stop.

It was Sorcha who fed it heather. No one told her to; there was dry heather stacked by the door for bedding, and a mother's instinct in a cold house is to put whatever will hold heat within reach of the thing giving it. She laid a handful of the dry stems against the failing coal, and the fire took them at once, faster and brighter than it had taken the stone, with a small crackling that made the littlest of the children cry out and back further behind her skirt; and the flame leapt up

gold-white for a breath and then settled, fed, into a steadier light than it had shown since it left the ground.

That was the turn of the whole night, the one the tellers give weight to above all the rest: that the thing they had brought into the house could be fed, and could therefore also, if it was not fed, go out and die, as surely as a beast dies of hunger or a man of cold; and that it was theirs to keep or lose by their own care, in a way that the sun and the wind and the sea had never been anyone's to keep or lose. Neachdan understood it before he could have said it in so many words, and it frightened him more than the lightning had, because the lightning had come and gone in an instant beyond anyone's holding, and this, this small red thing on his own floor, could be lost through nothing worse than an evening's carelessness, and once lost, by everything he had seen and reasoned that night, might never be got again.

IX

Of Sorcha's Hand

The second lesson cost more than the first.

Conall had been told, and told again, to keep his hands well back, and did, being six and old enough to be frightened as well as curious; it was Sorcha, feeding the fire a second time as the night wore on, who reached too far in setting a fresh knot of heather against the glowing heart of it and let her palm brush the crust of the coal itself, the ash-grey skin that looked, to every eye in that room, no different from any dead stone that had lain cold in a wall all its life.

She cried out and snatched her hand back, and for a moment the household froze, because none of them, not even Neachdan who had knelt at the shaft's mouth and put his own hands over the breathing vein, had yet understood that the thing could bite a hand that did not ask its leave first. Her palm reddened at once, and by the time Neachdan had her by the wrist in the low light to look at it, a welt was rising across the base of her fingers, and she held it against her own breast and would not at first let him touch it, more from the shock of the thing than from the hurt, though the hurt was real enough and lasted her the better part of a month.

He put grease from the sheep-fat pot on it, the same grease she had rubbed into his own cracked knuckles through the whole hard winter of the digging, and

it was, he thought afterward, a strange turn that the fire she had helped bring alive should be the first thing in that house to need tending in the old way, with the same jar and the same hands.

From that night the household kept a rule that needed no telling twice: the fire was fed with a stick's length between the hand and the flame, and never, whatever the cold, with a bare palm laid flat against the glowing crust to test whether it still had heat in it. Sorchá herself taught it to the littler children before dawn, holding up her reddened hand for them to see, and it is said, though this the tellers admit they cannot swear to, that it was from that hurt and that teaching, given the very first night the fire lived in a house, that every hearth on the island since has kept its stick, its poker, its tongs, and has never once gone back to bare hands.

X

Of the Household Red-Faced at Dawn

They did not sleep, none of the household, through the whole of that first night; there was too much to watch, too much still to be learned about a thing that had never before existed anywhere any of them or their fathers or their fathers' fathers had ever stood. The storm wore itself out somewhere in the small hours, the wind falling first and the rain going after it to a last thin drizzle and then to nothing, so that by the last dark before dawn the only sound in the valley was the low steady crackle of the fire and, further off, water still running high in the beck from all the rain the hill had taken.

Conall fell asleep at last sitting up against his mother's knee, close enough to the fire to feel it and far enough, by then, to be trusted there; the three littler ones slept in a heap under one cloak on the far side of the ring, their faces, when the flame caught a fresh piece of heather and leapt, going from shadow to sudden red and back to shadow as the light moved. Sorchá sat with her hurt hand wrapped and held loosely in her lap and watched the fire the way a woman watches a sick child through its worst night, not trusting it yet, not looking away from it either. Neachdan sat across from her with the last of the dark, half-burned lump of the rainbow-coloured stone turning slowly in his fingers, its colours long since gone the way of all the others, black and glowing at its heart like any other coal, indistinguishable now from the plainest grey chip he had ever split from a wall.

When the grey light of the true dawn came in under the door, thin and cold and utterly ordinary, the fire was still burning, banked low but alive, in the centre of the floor where no fire had ever burned before. Neachdan looked at it a long while, and then at his wife's bound hand, and at his sleeping children reddened by its glow rather than blued by the cold as every dawn of their short lives had found them until that one, and he said the only thing that any teller of 'Teine a' Chlachair¹ has ever agreed he said, the words that are given, in the short form, before the long reciting of the fathers begins at every hearth on Oidhche an Deal-anaich² even now.

He said it must not go out.

He did not say it as an order given lightly, the way a man tells a child to shut a door; he said it kneeling by the fire with his cracked hand flat on the cold earth beside it, the way a man swears an oath over something he does not fully understand and is afraid, all the same, to lose. Sorcha, from across the ring, said that it would not, not while she had hands to feed it, and held up the one that had already paid the fire's first toll as though it were a pledge rather than a wound; and Conall, waking at the sound of their voices, looked from his mother's bandaged hand to his father's blackened knuckles to the low red heart of the thing between them, and asked, in the plain way of a child too young yet to know what a question like that would cost his whole line to answer, what it was for.

Neither of them had an answer for him that morning. It was nine hundred years, and thirty-four fathers after Conall, before anyone of his line stood in a grove far to the north and asked the same question of a stranger made of smoke, and got, at last, the beginning of one. But that telling belongs to another hearth-night, and this one, the tellers say, ends here: with the rain gone off the valley, the well still uncut to water, and a fire on a swept ring of earth that had not been there the morning before, and has not, by any hearth it was ever carried to, gone out since.

1. the mason's fire, the first fire

2. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

CHAPTER TWO

Of the Fire Given Away

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I

Of the Vein Left Burning

The well-cut above the valley did not fill in. No one would let it. For a hand of years after Oidhche an Dealanaich¹ the broken vein burned on down in the rock, low and dark, and the mason's household kept a path worn to it as a path is worn to a spring. It did not flare as it had flared under the rain; it lay in its crack like a sleeping thing, breathing a small heat, and whoever went to it went quietly, the way a person goes near a sleeping child, not to wake it wrong.

Neachdan would not let the well be filled, and would not let it be dug deeper either, though there were those who came from three valleys off only to look down into it and see the black stone glowing at the bottom like an ember under ash. He set two flat stones across the mouth of the cut, a hand's breadth apart, so that no one could fall in and no rain could quite put it out, and he told his children that the fire in the ground was the same fire as the fire on the floor, and that both must be fed and neither trusted.

There was no counting of the years then, not by anyone on the island, and the household did not say "the third year" or "the fifth". They said "before Ailbhe could walk" or "the spring the ewes came early" or "since the lightning," and let it go at that. But it is told that in the fourth spring after the well was struck, a girl was born to Neachdan and Sorchu at the hearth, so close to the flame that the women turned her a little sideways with their hands lest a spark should catch her hair, and that she was the first child of the island ever to open her eyes by firelight

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

and not by the light of the sky alone. They named her Ailbhe. The hearth was already old enough by then that no one troubled to remark on the strangeness of a birth beside a fire; only the oldest women said, low, that a child born so would know the fire better than her own kin, and it was not meant unkindly, and it was not wrong.

The boy Conall was six when his father brought the first coal home under his cloak, and he grew through those years the way a boy grows near a thing he has been told never to let go out: watchful of it before he was watchful of anything else. He learned to read the fire the way another child learns to read weather. He knew the difference between the low steady red that meant it would keep till morning and the paler flutter that meant it was hungry, and he knew which wood answered it kindly and which spat and starved it, and long before he was a man grown he could tell, walking into a house from the cold, whether its fire had been fed with love or with laziness, by nothing but the smell of the room. His father set him, young, to watch the well-cut through the short nights of summer, when the household's own hearth needed less minding, and he would sit on the two flat stones with his knees drawn up and look down at the vein burning alone in the dark, and think, as a child thinks, that it did not need him at all, and was glad of him anyway.

It is the household's own telling, kept since, that no fire went out in Neachdan's house in all those first years, not once, not even in the wet spring when the roof let water onto the floor two nights running and every ember in the valley but theirs went dark. Whether that telling is wholly true no one now can say; households make of their own beginnings what they can bear to keep. But there is this much under it: that the fire the mason carried up out of the ground did not go out, that Conall watched it with more care than he gave his own hands in a cold winter, and that the vein down in the rock burned low and steady through all of it, unregarded by most of the valley and utterly regarded by one small household, waiting, though none of them yet knew for what.

II

Of the Meat on the Stones

It was in the second winter after the lightning that the household first put meat to the fire on purpose, and the tellers of the high valleys, who give the

carrying of fire and the hut on the heather their full weight, give this its own small place as well, because it changed what a household ate more than anything since the island was new.

They had eaten meat raw all their lives, as every household on the island ate it: cut thin and chewed long, or dried in strips on the wind in the summer and kept for the cold months, or pounded with fat and berries into cakes that kept longer still. No one had ever thought meat wanted anything done to it that the wind and a sharp flint could not do. It was Sorchá, again, who changed it, and by accident, as most of the first things of that household were done: she had hung a haunch of mutton from the roof-beam over the hearth to keep it from the dogs, lower than she meant to, and in the night the heat coming up off the fire browned the underside of it and set the fat dripping, so that the house woke to a smell none of them had ever smelled before and all of them, even the littlest, knew at once for food.

Neachdan cut a piece from the browned side with his flint and ate it standing, and stood a long while after with the taste of it in his mouth, and then cut a second piece for Sorchá and a third for Conall; and that was how the household learned that meat held over a fire was a different thing from meat held in the wind, softer and hotter and easier on an old tooth, and that a household with a fire need not chew all winter on strips as hard as leather. By the spring they were laying mutton and venison on flat stones heated in the embers, and turning it with a stick, and by the next winter a flat stone kept at the edge of the hearth for that one purpose had become as plain a part of the household as the hearth itself.

The neighbours learned it with the fire. It went out with the coal in Ailbhe's pot and in every pot after hers, so that a household begging fire from the mason's line got, along with the coal, the knowing of what to put over it and for how long; and it is told that the first thing a household ever did with a fire newly carried to it, before it thought to warm its hands, was to lay a piece of meat on a stone at the edge and wait to smell it.

There was grief in it too, the tellers say, though small. An old man of the household two doors along, who had lost the last of his teeth the winter before the lightning and lived since on broth of pounded meat and water drunk cold, wept the first time he ate mutton softened over the fire, because it was the first meat he had been able to chew in a year, and because his wife, who had pounded his meat for him every day of that year with her own two hands, had died of the cold in the week before the lightning came and never tasted it.

III

Of the Night the Hearth Died

It went out at last in the fifth year, in the black hour before the earliest light, when Conall was eleven and the household had grown careless the way any household grows careless of a thing that has never once failed it.

There had been three days of rain driving sideways off the high ground, the kind that finds every gap in a roof of turf and heather no matter how well it is laid, and on the third night a gust came down the valley strong enough to lift a corner of thatch clean off the byre and lay it across the yard. Water came through where the thatch had been and ran along a rafter and dripped, patient as a slow thief, directly onto the hearth-stones. Neachdan was from home that night, gone two valleys off to look at a spring some other household hoped might be theirs to claim, and Sorcha slept heavily with the new baby at her side, and it was Conall who woke first, in the deep cold hour, to a darkness in the house that was not the ordinary darkness of night.

He knew before he was fully awake what it meant. Every night of his life he had slept within reach of a red glow on the floor, faint even through closed eyes, and its absence woke him the way a silence wakes a person more surely than a noise. His hand went flat on the hearth-stones and found them wet and cold, and when he raked through the black wet mess with his fingers there was no spark in it anywhere, not the smallest eye of red, nothing.

He did not wake his mother. He has told, since, that he thought of it, and did not, because he could not think what she would do that he was not already doing, and because some part of him, eleven years old and frightened in the dark, wanted the thing mended before anyone else knew it had broken.

The clay pot that stood by the door, the one his mother used for carrying water from the burn, went into his hands, and he went out into the rain in his bare feet with nothing over his shoulders but a fold of hide, and he ran. It was black as the inside of a closed hand and the ground was slick underfoot and he fell once, hard, on his knee on a stone, and did not stop to feel it. He ran the whole way to the well-cut by the path his own feet had worn to it, sure of it in the dark the way a hand is sure of a door it has opened ten thousand times, and he came over the two flat stones and looked down, and the vein was there, low and red and breathing exactly as it always breathed, indifferent to the storm and to him and to everything but its own burning.

He had never taken anything from it before. That had always been his father's work, or his father's father's, though there was no father's father now to remember. He lay flat on the wet stone with the pot in both hands and reached down into the cut as far as his arm would go, and the heat of it came up into his face, and he scraped a burning piece of the vein into the mouth of the pot with a scrap of slate, working fast because his arm was shaking with the strain of the reach and because the rain was trying to fill the pot before the coal could sit in it. He got one piece in, no bigger than a hen's egg, glowing through a crust of grey, and he packed cold dead ash from the rim of the cut in around it, the way he had seen his father bank a fire at night, and he held the pot against his chest under the fold of hide and ran home with it as he had run out, only slower now, every step careful, a boy carrying a small ember of a sleeping thing five years old and understanding for the first time that a fire need not stay in one place at all. It could be moved.

He tipped it out onto the wet hearth-stones and blew on it with his whole chest and fed it the driest tinder he could find by feel in the dark, a fistful of bracken kept dry under the roof-beam for kindling, kept dry, that one night, by nothing but luck. The fire caught slowly and then all at once, the way fire always does, going from nothing to a small red mouth to a flame standing up off the hearth in the space of a few breaths, and by the time Sorcha woke, roused at last by the light on the wall rather than by any sound her son had made, the hearth was burning as though it had never stopped, and Conall was sitting cross-legged before it with his knee bleeding onto the floor and the empty water-pot still clutched in both hands, and he did not know, himself, whether to be proud or ashamed, and so he said nothing, and let his mother think what she liked.

That hearth still tells it, and every hearth fire has reached since has told it too: that this was the night it was learned that fire need not stay where it is born, that it can be carried, a live coal in a clay pot banked round with its own ash, from one fire to light another. Before that night the household had thought of its fire the way it thought of the well-cut, a fixed thing, rooted in one place in the ground. After it, they held a small living thing that could be taken up and moved, and given, if they chose to give it, and a boy of eleven with wet feet and a water-pot had proved it could be done.

IV

Of the Hut on the Heather

The first house to burn stood not half a mile off, at the near end of the same slope, the house of a household that had begged fire from Neachdan's hearth two winters before and kept it faithfully since, tending it as carefully as anyone tends a thing given by a neighbour rather than found by a father's own hand.

It went wrong on an ordinary evening, no storm in it, no blame that anyone could afterwards lay at any one door. The fire had been laid, as fire was laid in most houses then, on a bed of old heather packed down hard over years until it seemed as good as stone, because heather was what lay to hand on that slope and no one had yet been burned badly enough to think otherwise. A coal rolled, or a child kicked at it in play, or the wind found a gap under the door-hide and breathed on it too long while the household slept; which of these it was, the tellers never agreed, and in the end it did not matter. What mattered was that the packed heather under the fire caught from beneath, unseen, and smouldered there for the better part of an hour doing nothing that any waking eye would have marked, and then broke into open flame all along its length at once, under a roof of the same dry heather thatch, and the whole of it went up together, roof and floor and walls of turf, faster than the household inside could rightly understand what was happening to them.

They got out. That much was mercy: a mother, a father, three children, all out into the cold with nothing saved but each other and the clothes they slept in, and they stood in the yard and watched the one warm, dry, safe thing they owned burn itself to nothing in less time than it takes to walk to the burn and back, and the youngest child screamed the whole while, too small to fear the fire, only screaming because her mother's arms were gripping her too hard to breathe in.

Conall was among the first from the near houses to come with water, though there was nothing by then that water could do but wet the ground around the ruin and keep the fire from crossing to the dry grass beyond. Sixteen that year, a young man's height on him already, he stood in the yard in the smoke and the fire-light and looked at the family gathered together in the ruin of their own warmth. His mind went to his own fire on its stones, with the two flat rocks laid over the well-cut a mile off, sitting always on ground that could never catch. Something his father had never quite put into words, though he had lived it every day since the lightning, stood plain before him now: a fire on stone can be fed and watched and trusted, and a fire on heather, however faithfully kept, is a fire lying on its own fuel, waiting only for a moment's inattention to remember what it is.

He said so, that night, to the household that had lost its roof, gently, for grief needs no scolding, and he said it again in the days after to anyone who would stand and listen, and he was young enough that some of the old men smiled at a boy telling them their business. But he had carried a coal alone through a storm at eleven, and there were those who had not forgotten it, and slowly, over that year and the ones after, the word went about the near hearths that a fire wants stone under it if it is to be trusted through a night, not the packed heather of the floor it stands on, and here and there a household began to lay flat stones gathered from the burn-bed beneath the hearth before it lit its fire there at all. It did not happen everywhere at once. Old ways die slowly on a hillside, and there were fires laid on heather for a generation and more after that night, in houses too poor in stone or too far from good rock to do otherwise. But the household that had lost its roof rebuilt on stone, and the near hearths that had watched it burn did the same, and it is from that year, the tellers say, that the custom began, stone under every fire the mason's line has ever given.

V

Of Ailbhe and the Reach to the Northern Moor

Ailbhe grew up beside two fires at once, her mother's on the hearth and the vein's own down in the cut, and by the time she was old enough to be trusted with a pot in her hands she knew both better than any of her brothers did, for she had been set from her earliest years to watch the hearth while the others were sent to the herding or the digging, being the youngest daughter and thought too small yet for harder work. It was said of her, later, and said kindly, that she had learned to walk holding a coal at arm's length before she had learned to walk holding her mother's hand, which cannot be wholly true, but is not far from what those who knew her as a girl believed.

It fell to her, as she came into her growth, to be the one who carried the fire outward, because her brothers were needed at other work and because she had, from watching it so long, a steadiness with a live coal that older and stronger hands lacked. When a household two valleys off sent word that their own fire had died and they had heard, as everyone by then had heard, that the mason's people kept a fire that never failed, it was Ailbhe who was sent with a pot banked in ash and a fold of hide to keep the wind from it, walking the whole way herself, a girl

not yet grown, carrying a small red heart of the family's fire out across country that most of the valley had never troubled to cross on foot before.

Neachdan never once refused it. That, too, is remembered and told, that though the fire had cost him a well he could no longer use for water and a debt of care his household paid every day of its life, he would not hear of keeping it back from any hearth that asked, and told his children plainly that a fire withheld from a cold house was a worse thing than a fire given away and never thanked for. So Ailbhe walked it, spring and autumn, summer when the light let her go further and winter when it did not, to the near valleys first and then, as she grew surer of the ground and the ground grew more used to her coming, further out: south along the slope to households that had only heard of 'Teine a' Chlachair' by report, west to where the burn ran into wider country, and at last, in the year she came fully into her strength, north across the shoulder of the high ground to the edge of the moor that lay at the limit of any household's grazing, a day's walk each way and more if the weather turned.

It was slow work and it was not without its cost. A coal could die in the pot on a hard, wet crossing no matter how carefully it was banked, and there were journeys Ailbhe made twice over because the fire had gone out on her halfway and she would not turn for home without it lit, walking back to the last hearth she had passed to beg a fresh coal rather than arrive empty-handed at the one she was going to. There were households, too, proud or wary, that would not at first take fire from a girl of another valley, thinking there was some obligation in it they did not want to owe; but fire in a cold house wears down pride faster than argument does, and in the end every hearth that Ailbhe reached kept what she brought it and looked for her again.

By the time the fire had been carried, hearth by hearth, as far as the northern moor, no one could any longer say how many households now kept, on their own floors, a flame that had first burned in a well a day and more away. The mason's own fire had not multiplied by magic; it had simply been walked outward, one live coal at a time, by a girl who had grown up believing that a fire not shared was a fire not fully understood, and the valley that had once known one hearth in all its length now knew dozens, none of them less warm for the giving, and all of them, in the telling that mattered most to the households that kept them, still one fire.

1. the mason's fire, the first fire

VI

Of Neachdan's Death and the Long Watch

Neachdan died by his own hearth, an old man by then for that hard country, in the year his grandchildren had begun to outnumber his children round the fire he had carried home under his cloak. In his last years he grew slow and would sit long hours by the flame doing nothing that any onlooker could call work, and those who watched him closest said he was listening to it, the way a man listens to a stream he has crossed his whole life and never once heard the same twice. Near the end he asked to be carried out one last time to see the well-cut, and they carried him, and he looked down for a long while at the vein still burning steadily in the dark of the rock, unchanged in all the years since the lightning had found it, and said, of it, only that it had outlasted him and would outlast his sons too. He was not wrong. That same night he died at the hearth he had lit, with the fire he had carried home burning beside him as it had burned every night of his life since, and the household kept it fed through the whole of the mourning without once letting it fall, because that, by then, was understood without needing to be said.

It was in the years after his death that Conall, grown into the eldest man of a household grown large, set down in words what he had first felt standing in the smoke of a burning roof: that fire belongs on stone and nowhere else, that no hearth in the valley should be laid on packed heather or bare turf if flat stone could be had and carried to it, and that this should stand, from that day, as every household's law that took fire from the mason's line. He said it standing, at a gathering of the near hearths in the dark half of the year, and though he had no more right to command another man's fire than any neighbour has, the households that heard him kept it, for they too had stood in the smoke of the burned roof, or had heard of it from those who had, and a rule that answers a fear already known is a rule that needs little enforcing.

Through all the years after, Conall kept the watch his father had kept before him, sitting by the well-cut through the dark half of every year when the fire in men's houses is most needed and most easily lost, and it became known among the valley's children, long before they knew why, that the two flat stones over the black cut were not to be gone near without an elder by, and that the old man who sat there through the cold months, saying little, watching the vein burn low and red in its crack in the rock, was not to be disturbed at his work, though no child

rightly understood what the work was. He grew old at it. His hands, which had once reached down into the burning cut at eleven with a water-pot and a scrap of slate, grew stiff and slow, and in his last years it was his own son who carried the coals out to him and sat with him through the coldest nights, learning without being taught the same watchfulness his father had learned from his father before that.

Conall died as Neachdan had died, by a hearth, in the fullness of a long life for that country, with the vein in the well-cut still burning as it had burned since Oidhche an Dealanaich¹ and showing, in all the years of his watching, no sign that it meant ever to stop. His son took the watch from him without any word of ceremony, the way a man takes up a tool his father has just set down, and sat that same winter through the dark half of the year on the two flat stones above the cut, and looked down at the fire that had now outlived two of the mason's line, and understood, as his father and his father's father had understood before him, that it was not his to let go out.

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

CHAPTER THREE

Of the Three Wells and the Slab

VE 72 – 226

I

Of the Black Well and the Young Well

By the time Conall's son took up the watch of the well-cut, the fire in the vein was no longer a wonder to the valley. It was a fact of the place, the way the ridge above it was a fact, and the children who grew up within a day's walk of Tobar dhìreach had never known a world where it was otherwise. They knew the two flat stones set across the mouth of the cut, and the low red glow that lay between them if you looked down at the right hour of the evening, and they knew, because they were told it before they could well understand why, that the fire had come down out of a storm and into their great-grandfather's well, and that no other well on the island could say the like.

It was this last claim that other wells began, in those years, to dispute.

There was a household two valleys east that kept its hearth from a black seam of its own, cut into stone so dark it had never wanted for a name beyond the black well, and there was a household further east again, beyond the black well, whose well was young in the way that a spring is young, having been sunk only a father's lifetime before Oidhche an Dealanaich¹, so that everyone still living remembered its cutting. Both had taken fire from the mason's line in the early years, as every hearth for three valleys round had taken it, freely given and never grudging; and

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

both, as the generations turned, began to tell a different tale of where that fire had first been struck.

The loudest of these tellers was a man of the black well named Tadhg, big in the chest and bigger in the voice, who had grown up hearing his grandmother swear that the crack of the lightning on the night it fell had come from directly over their own valley and no other, and who had turned that swearing, by the time he was a man grown, into something very near a certainty. He had never doubted it a day in his life. He did not doubt it now, at six-and-forty, holding up before a gathering at the black well a stone the size of two fists, dark along one face in a way that might have been fire and might, as well, have been nothing but the stone's own colour.

"There," he said, and turned it so the firelight ran along the dark face of it. "There is the mark of it. My grandmother's mother saw the sky open over this valley, not that one, and here is the stone that took the strike, kept in my family since before any of you were born to doubt it."

No one at the black well doubted it, or said they did not, for it was Tadhg's stone and Tadhg's voice, and both were large enough in that small gathering to leave little room for another opinion. Word of it went out along the paths the fire-bearers walked, as word of anything strange or proud will go, and by the following year there were those three valleys over, at hearths that had never seen the stone and never would, repeating that the black well had the truer claim, on the strength of a story told about a stone none of them had held.

The mason's own household heard it and did nothing.

This was remarked on, in its turn, almost as much as the claim had been. There were those at Tobar dhìreach who wanted to send someone east with the truth of the matter, since the truth of the matter was there for anyone to see: the capped shaft with its scorched lip, black to this day where the lightning had run down the rock, a mark no scattered stone could match for plainness. But the eldest of the household, Conall's son grown grey now at the work his father had left him, would not have it argued.

He had his own reasons, and gave them plainly enough to anyone who asked. He had seen, as a boy at his grandfather Conall's knee, how little a quarrel over a well had ever fed a hearth, and he held to the plain shape of the thing: theirs was the fire, and the fire had been walked out to a hundred houses that did not care two straws which valley the lightning had chosen, so long as it kept burning on their own floor. A dispute carried east would cost three days' walking and buy

them, at the end of it, nothing warmer than an argument won. He would sooner spend the three days at the well-cut, teaching his own son the watch, than spend them proving a scorch on a stone to a man who had already made up his mind not to see it.

"Let Tadhg keep his stone," he said. "We keep the well. A man may say what he likes of a fire he did not carry home; it will not make the fire his, and it will not make ours less ours for his saying it." And when his own son pressed him, wanting to know why they should let a false thing stand unanswered, he said only that a fire spoken of by two households was a fire remembered by two households, and that this was no bad thing for a fire to be, however crookedly the remembering ran.

It was not long after that a second claim rose, quieter than Tadhg's and, in its way, harder to answer, for it came without a stone to hold up or a loud voice to carry it. At the young well an old woman began to tell, in the dark half of the year when such tellings are told, that her own mother had stood at the door of their house on Oidhche an Dealanaich and seen the light go down into their own well, newer sunk though it was, and that the mason had only carried fire from his cut because it lay nearer to hand for the carrying, and no other reason. She told it the way the old tell things they have turned over so long they no longer remember whether they were given it whole or worked it out themselves: softly, without heat, as a fact rather than a boast, which is why it travelled further than Tadhg's stone ever did, and outlasted it.

By then there were three tellings abroad in the high valleys, where there had once been one plain fact, and no way left for a stranger passing through to know which well the lightning had truly struck without walking to Tobar dhìreach and looking down at the scorch on the stone himself. Few did. It was easier, and pleasanter, to believe the well one's own grandmother had sworn by, and the valleys settled, without any of them quite deciding to, into three tellings held at once and never set against each other, the way three roads may run to the same market and each traveller swear his own the shortest.

The household at Tobar dhìreach let it stand so. They had the fire. Whatever else was said of it, at the black well or the young well or anywhere a telling might wander to, could not be carried home and put on a floor to warm a child's hands, and it was this, more than any argument, that the eldest man of the line held to when his son asked him, once more and for the last time, whether they ought not answer Tadhg. "Answer him with the fire," the old man said, "the way we have

answered everyone else who ever came cold to our door," and after that the matter of the three wells was let alone at Tobar dhìreach, though it did not stop being told, east and south, for as long as there were hearths near enough to hear it.

II

Of Muirne

The girl who would keep the vein through its last years was born at Tobar dhìreach some forty years after Conall died, a great-granddaughter of his line on the mother's side, in a household grown too large by then to count easily by the fathers alone. Her name was Muirne, and she was given, almost as soon as she could be trusted on her feet, to the woman whose task it had long been to see that the household's floor-fire never wanted for tending, so that she grew up as much at the hearth as in her own bed, and knew the sound a good fire makes settling for the night before she knew her letters, not that anyone in the valley had letters to know.

She was quick, and she was quiet in the particular way of a child who has been let sit still among grown talk from very young, listening more than she was listened to. By the time she was old enough to be sent to the well-cut on her own, an honour and a chore both, granted only to those the household trusted not to lean too far over the two flat stones, she had already spent half her short life near enough to fire to have opinions about it that older folk found, when she gave them, oddly sound. She said once, watching an aunt feed the floor-hearth with wet wood that hissed and sulked rather than caught, that the fire was not lazy, only hungry for the wrong thing, the way a person turns from bad bread and reaches for good, hungry all the while. The aunt, who had never thought of it so, laughed and told it about the valley as a child's saying, and it stuck to Muirne all her life, so that grown folk who ought to have known better than to ask a girl such things came to her, even young, wanting to know what a fire was hungry for, as though it were a question with an answer only she could give.

She grew, too, in a household that had by then forgotten what it was to be small. Where Neachdan had once fed a single hearth with his own hands and Conall had walked a coal to the nearest neighbour and thought it a long errand, the kin at Tobar dhìreach now numbered enough grown men and women that Muirne could go a full day without speaking to the same face twice, and the fire

her forefathers had carried out to strangers was, by her childhood, burning in so many houses along the valley floor that no one troubled any longer to count them. She heard the old tellings at the hearth as every child of that household heard them, of the wedge and the storm and the burning well, and she heard them the way a child hears the lie of the land she was born on, already there before she thought to ask how it came to be.

She took up the true watch of the well-cut somewhat before she was grown, when the man before her, worn out at the work as men are worn by any long watching, began to leave more of the winter nights to her than he kept for himself. No one made a ceremony of it. She simply came to be the one who sat on the two flat stones through the dark half of the year, wrapped against the cold with her knees drawn up as every keeper before her had sat, looking down at the vein in its crack in the rock.

And it was Muirne, more than any who had watched before her, who first let herself see plainly what the fire was doing.

It had burned, by then, for the better part of a hundred and fifty years, *Teine na Fèithe*¹, down in the same broken seam the lightning had first found, fed by nothing but its own store since the night it was struck, for no one had ever thought to feed the vein the way a floor-hearth is fed; it was the floor-hearths that were fed from it, a hundred of them and more by then, walked out hearth to hearth across three valleys and the northern moor besides, each one a small child of that single fire. The vein only burned on, low and dark and steady in its crack as it had burned from the first, and no one who had not sat with it through many winters running would have marked the change in it from one year to the next. Muirne sat with it through many winters running.

She learned, in those years, the small offices of the watch as her forebears had learned them: to lay a broken branch across the mouth of the cut when the wind ran hard down the valley and threatened to worry the flame thin, though she never once fed the vein itself, for that was not the watch's work and had never been; to keep children back from the two flat stones with nothing sharper than a raised hand and a word, the way she herself had once been kept back; to sit still enough, on the coldest nights, that a fox might cross within a spear's throw of her and never know she was there. It was slow work, and lonely work for long stretches of it, and she came in time to prefer it to the crowded warmth of the floor-hearth,

1. the fire of the vein; the burning of the broken vein in the mason's well, VE 1 – 151

where a dozen voices talked over one another and no one voice could be heard clearly. At the well-cut there was only the fire and the wind and, eventually, her own thoughts, turned over slowly the way a knapper turns a flint nodule in his hand, and it was in that quiet, more than anywhere else, that she began to notice what she noticed.

She saw, where her father's father had seen only a fire that had never failed, that the glow between the two flat stones was a little lower each year than the year before. A man rarely marks his own child growing, seeing the same face at the same table every evening, and yet knows well enough, meeting a cousin's child after some years apart, how far the growing has gone; it was in that way, slow and sidelong, that Muirne came to know the vein was failing. She said nothing of it for a long while, for it was a hard thing to say to a household that had built its whole understanding of the world on a fire that did not go out, and she was young yet, and did not trust her own eye against the certainty of her elders. But she kept a private reckoning of it in her own mind, a habit of noticing she never spoke of to anyone, matching this winter's glow against her memory of the winter five years gone, and five years before that, until she could no longer doubt what she saw: that the vein, however slowly, was going the way of any fire that is not fed, and that there would come a night, though she could not have said which, when it would go the whole way and not come back.

III

Of the Last Ember

The wet spring that finished it came when Muirne was near forty, in a year the whole valley remembered afterward for other reasons besides the vein, for the rain that spring stood in the low fields a hand's depth deep and rotted the seed in the ground, and there was hunger enough abroad that the fire's failing was, for once, not the worst thing spoken of at any hearth. But it was spoken of, and by Muirne first.

She had gone down to the well-cut on an evening when the rain had not let up in three days, gone the way she always went, without expecting anything different of the visit than she had found the evening before, and had found the glow between the two flat stones smaller than she had ever seen it and paler, a red gone the colour of an old bruise rather than the colour of living heat. She sat with it a

long while in the wet, not moving, the way a person sits with someone they already know will not see the morning, and somewhere in that sitting, though she could not afterward say at what hour, the glow went out.

It did not go out all at once, with any sound or sign a teller could make much of. It simply, at some point in the dark and the rain, stopped being there, and when Muirne put her hand down into the cut, careful as she had been taught to be careful of a fire that might still bite, she felt only wet stone, cold under the rain the way any stone is cold, and knew before she climbed back up into the storm that the fire the mason had carried home out of the lightning, the fire that had burned in that one crack of rock since before her grandfather's grandfather was born, had burned itself out at last, quietly, with no one there to see the last of it go but her.

She told the household plainly, at first light, for there was no way to tell it that would make it smaller than it was. There was grief in the hearing of it, real grief, though every fire in three valleys still burned bright as it had always burned, fed from floor to floor and needing the vein no longer for its own life; the valley mourned that morning the mark itself, the sign of Oidhche an Dealanaich¹, gone from the world the way the night was already long gone, kept now only in the telling.

It was not many days before someone said what more than one had already been thinking, which was that the fire might be found again if the well were dug deeper, since a vein that had held fire once might hold fire again, further down where the coloured stone was said to run. It was a young man of the household who said it first, and others took it up quickly, for there is comfort in a task even a false comfort, and digging is a task any strong back can offer a valley grieving something it cannot otherwise mend. Muirne let them talk of it two full days before she spoke against it, and when she did, she spoke standing at the well-cut, with half the household gathered in the drizzle to hear her.

"The fire did not come to us out of the ground," she said. "It came out of the sky, into the ground, on one night only, and it is not for us to go looking after it down where it fell, the way a man goes looking for a knife he has dropped. What is down there now is stone the lightning never touched, and stone the lightning never touched will not answer a maul any better than it answered one before the

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

mason ever struck this seam. We did not make the fire. We will not go digging to remake it."

Not everyone in the household believed her outright, that first morning, and there were those who thought, privately, that Muirne spoke more from fear of disturbing a holy thing than from any true knowledge of what lay under the broken rock. The young man who had raised the talk of digging said as much to her face, there in the drizzle, asking what harm a few strokes of the maul could do a stone already broken once by lightning. Muirne did not answer him with anger. She only asked him, in turn, whether he had ever known the vein to grow brighter for any care they gave it, in all the years of the watch, or whether it had only ever burned as it was struck and gone the way it was going now regardless of what hands were laid on it; and when he had no answer to that, the household took her silence for his and let the matter rest. Whether it was her word that stopped them, or only that the wet spring had left few backs strong enough to spare for a well no one could promise would give anything back, the digging was never begun, and within the season even the young man who had first proposed it had let it drop, the way most griefs are let drop once the worst of the winter that bore them has passed.

IV

Of the Slab and the New Well

What the household did instead, in that same wet year, was what Muirne herself proposed once the talk of digging had died down: to leave the broken vein as it lay, and cover it.

They chose a stone for it from the same outcrop the mason had cut his own wedges from, long ago, a flat slab broader than a grown man lying full length, *Leac na Fèithe*¹ that came after to be called *Leac na Fèithe*, and it took six of them the better part of two days to lever it up the slope and set it down across the mouth of the cut where the two smaller stones had lain since Neachdan's own time. Muirne stood by through all of it, past the years when her own back could have joined the lifting, but she watched each stone's fall as closely as she had once

1. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhireach

watched the fire, as though the setting of it mattered as much as the labour that set it.

When it was down, and the last gap along its edge packed with turf so that no rain would run in beneath it, she knelt and put her palm flat on the stone, in the drizzle, the way she had once put her hand down into the cut to feel for a living warmth that was no longer there. Leac na Fèithe gave back nothing but its own coldness, and the wet of the day, and she knelt there long enough that those waiting on her began to wonder whether she meant to speak. She did not. She only rose at last, wiped her hand on her skirt, and said that no water was ever to be drawn beside that stone again, not for beasts nor for washing nor for any use at all, and that this, from that day, was the whole of what the household owed the place: to leave it be, and remember it was there.

The black cut the mason had first sunk with wedge and oak maul, the well itself, gave the household no more water after that, though the water in it had not failed; Muirne simply would not have it drawn from so near the covered vein, fearing, though she never said so outright, that a bucket lowered too near Leac na Fèithe might one day come up holding something other than water. A new well was cut that same season, a stone's throw off across the yard, by men with strong backs and no memory yet worn thin enough to make the digging feel like anything more than an ordinary well-cutting, and it gave good water from the first day, cold and clean, the way any well on that ground gives water when it is cut with care. In time it was this well, and not the black cut under Leac na Fèithe, that the household drew from every day of its life thereafter, so that a stranger walking into the yard a generation on would have taken the new well for the old one, and never known, unless someone troubled to tell him, that the true well of 'Teine a' Chlachair² lay a stone's throw off, sealed and silent under a slab no one drew water beside.

Word of the covering went out along the same paths the fire-bearers had walked for generations, though it travelled slower than the fire had once travelled, for a covering is a smaller thing to carry from house to house than a live coal in a clay pot. At the black well Tadhg's grandsons heard it and said little, for there was less glory to be had contesting a stone that gave off no light than there had been contesting a fire that had; and at the young well the telling of the light going down into their own cut went on being told regardless, since a story that had nev-

2. the mason's fire, the first fire

er needed the proof of a burning vein to be believed was not about to be troubled now that the vein no longer burned for anyone to compare it against. The three tellings held on, east and south, long after the one true well at Tobar dhìreach had nothing left to show but a flat stone and a household that would not draw water near it.

Muirne lived on many years after Leac na Fèithe was laid, long enough to see her own grandchildren old enough to be sent to the well-cut in their turn, though there was no fire in it now for them to watch, only the covered stone and the telling that went with it, which she made sure was told to each of them before they were old enough to forget it wrongly. She told it the same way every telling year after year, standing, as Conall had stood to give the rule of the stone, and by the time she was old her telling had become the one the household kept, unaltered, passed down after her the way the fire had once been passed hearth to hearth: a wonder found, and a wonder covered, and a well that gave water all the same.

In her last years she grew slow on her feet and could no longer walk out to Leac na Fèithe in the worst of the winter weather, and it fell to her grandchildren to go in her place and bring back word of the stone's condition, as though it were a sick relation that wanted visiting rather than a covered well that asked nothing of anyone. She would ask them, each time, whether the turf at the edge still held the rain out, and whether any fool had left a bucket standing near it, and was satisfied only when told the stone lay exactly as she had last seen it, unmoved and unvisited by anything but weather. It was, by then, less a duty to her than a comfort, the way an old woman finds comfort in hearing that a door she can no longer reach is still shut fast.

She died in the household's own house at Tobar dhìreach in the fullness of years the valley reckoned long for that country, and was buried, as the custom of the hill-folk was by then, in the ground near the house rather than carried anywhere else, with no coal and no fire laid beside her, for it was the vein's own fire she had kept, not any hearth's, and the vein's fire she had already given, whole and entire, back to the stone. What was left to the household after her was the telling, and Leac na Fèithe, and the new well giving water a stone's throw from the old, and for some years yet, until another keeper rose to take up the office Muirne had made her own, it was the youngest of her grandchildren who walked out to the covered stone in the dark half of the year, knelt, and laid a bare palm on the cold flat of it, the way she had taught them: for what the stone had once held, not for

anything it gave back now, and because a place that has held fire is never quite the same, to those who remember it, as any other stone.

CHAPTER FOUR

OF THE SNOW ON THE MOUNTAINS AND THE OAK IN THE NORTH

VE 227 – 505

I

Of Conn and the Rising Water

The Abhainn uaine ran narrower in Conn's grandfather's day, or so it was told at the hearths that summered along it, and narrower still in the day before that. No one who herded the high ground doubted it, for the proof of it lay in the gravel of the river's own bed for anyone who cared to walk it and look.

Conn was born to a household of the upper valley some two hundred and five years after Oidhche an Dealanaich¹, a fair way inland of Tobar dhireach and higher up than any household cared to winter, and he grew, as his father and his father's father had grown, following sheep and a scatter of small dark cattle up into the high pastures each year as the snow drew back off them. It was slow, patient work, not glad work and not grim either, the kind that asks little of a man beyond a good eye for weather and the willingness to walk further than he is tired. He had both. By the time he was a young man grown he could tell, looking at the colour of the light on the tops before dawn, whether the beasts would want driving down before noon, and he was seldom wrong, and the older herders of his kin let him choose the ground more often than his years alone would have earned him.

The snow that mattered to Conn was the old snow, lying all the year round in the high corries under the shoulder of the central mountains and fed the river be-

low with its melting, thin in winter when the frost held it fast and full and cold and loud in the first weeks of summer when the sun at last found it. His grandfather's telling held that the snowfields had once come down further, close enough that a man driving cattle to the high grass in an early year might still find drifts of it lying in the shadowed clefts as late as midsummer. In Conn's own boyhood the same clefts showed bare rock by the turn of spring, and every year of his growing the white seemed to draw back a little further up the mountain's shoulder, leaving more grass than before, and more water running down off it than the grass alone could well explain.

He did not think much of the reason for it. A young man following beasts has little use for reasons; he has use only for the ground he is on and the ground he means to reach before dark. But he noticed, the way a herder notices everything about the country he crosses year on year without troubling to ask why, that the river's own bed was widening under him, and that the banks he had walked as a boy were not always the banks he walked as a man.

It was in his twenty-fifth year, the year his kin reckoned by the wet spring that drowned half the low pasture, that Conn first laid hearth-stones on the gravel terrace above the river's summer bend, a day and more up from where the household wintered, in a stretch of ground his father had used before him and his father's father before that. He built the ring the way it had always been built there: a flat stone at the back to break the wind off the water, smaller stones set round in a half-circle, the whole of it a stone's throw above the river's edge and well above, so every herder before him had judged, any water the Abhainn uaine could reasonably be expected to send against it. He kept a coal there from the household's own fire, carried up in a clay pot banked in ash the way every fire on that ground was carried since the mason's day, and he slept by it through the short nights of high summer with the beasts grazing loose around him and the water running on below.

The river rose against him twice in the years he kept that ground. The first time was a small thing, a wet week in an ordinary summer that sent the water a few feet up the shingle and no further, enough to wet the lowest stones of his fire-ring and no more, and he moved his hearth back a body's length without much thought and built it again exactly as before. The second time was not small.

It came in his thirty-fourth year, in a summer that had begun hot and dry and then broken all at once into a run of days when the cloud sat on the high ground

and did not lift, day after day, until even the oldest of the household said they could not remember its like. Conn was two days up from the winter ground with the beasts when the water began to climb. He woke on the third morning of the cloud to a sound under the ordinary sound of the river, a deeper note that had not been there the evening before, and came out from under his hide to find the water already at the lowest of his fire-stones, brown and thick with everything it had torn loose above him, carrying whole branches down at a pace no man could have outrun on the bank.

He had time, though not much of it, and he used it the way a man uses time he does not trust to last: he raked the coal out of the ring first, before anything else, into the clay pot, packed it round with cold ash from the rim, and only then began driving the beasts up off the terrace to the higher shelf behind it, shouting and slapping at the slowest of the dark cattle with the flat of his hand until they moved. The beasts he got up; the fire-ring stayed where it was, and by the time he turned to look back at it, from the higher ground with the pot held against his chest, the water had already taken the lowest stones under and was working at the second row, and by evening, when the cloud broke at last and the river began at last to fall, there was nothing left of the ring he had built at the start of that year but the flat stone at its back, half buried now in silt, with a scour mark on its face showing how high the water had stood.

He built again above it, on the higher shelf where he had driven the beasts, and that ring held through every summer he kept the ground after. But he did not fill in the lower one, and he did not let his sons fill it either, when in his old age he walked that stretch of the river with them and showed them where the water had been. He left the old stones where the flood had left them, half sunk in gravel a stone's throw below his own hearth, and beside them, further down still, a third ring older than either, that his father had shown him in the same way his father's father had shown it: three rings of fire-stones on three shelves of the one terrace, each a little higher than the last, each set there in its own year by a man who had judged, as carefully as Conn himself had judged, how far the water could reasonably be trusted not to come.

"The river climbs," Conn told his sons, standing among the three rings with the water a long way below them all that year, low and clear and ordinary, giving no sign that it had ever meant them harm. "It has climbed in my father's life and it

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

climbed again in mine, and I do not know why, only that the high snow gives it more water each year than it gave the year before, and that a man who builds his fire by a river's edge builds it where the river was, not where the river is."

His sons kept the highest ring after him, and moved higher again in their own time, for the water climbed a little further even in their lives, though never again all at once as it had climbed against Conn. Conn died in his sixty-second year, an old man for that hard country, at the household's own hearth in the low valley. It was the high ground and the three rings on it that his kin remembered him by, and travellers who came that way in years after, following the same summer track up the Abhainn uaine, were shown the terrace and told, in as many words as the teller cared to give it, that a man once built his fire there three times over, each time a little further from a river that would not stay where a man could trust it.

II

Of Eachna and the New Hearths

West of Conn's high pastures, down off the shoulder of the massif and out onto ground that opened flatter and drier than the herding country, there was in those generations no hearth at all. It was good grazing, level enough to run on without looking at one's feet, watered by a burn that ran clean the year round, and it stood close enough to Tobar dhìreach that a fast walker might cover the distance between dawn and midday. But no household had settled there, for a valley that has water and grass and no fire of its own is a valley people pass through on the way to somewhere else, and not a valley people stay in.

Eachna's household changed that, in the year she came into the fullness of her own judgement, some two hundred and eighty years and more after Oidhche an Dealanaich¹.

She was born to a household some way south of Tobar dhìreach, one of the many by then that kept a fire lit from the mason's own, carried to them hearth by hearth in the generations since Ailbhe had first walked it outward, and she grew up knowing the fire the way every child of that country grew up knowing it, as a thing fed and watched and never let go dark, without troubling to ask where the first of it had come from. What she wanted, from an early age, was ground of her

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

own, good open ground for a household rather than a corner of her father's, and by the time she was a young woman she had already walked the flatter country to the west more than once, looking at it the way a woman looks at a thing she means, in time, to have.

She took her fire from Tobar dhìreach the year she went to settle it, walking the day's distance with a coal from the line's own hearth carried in a pot the way every fire on that ground had been carried since the mason first carried his. The household that gave it to her asked nothing beyond the giving; it had been the mason's own rule, kept by his son and his son's son after him, that a fire asked for was a fire given, and by Eachna's day the rule was old enough that no one thought to question it. What she did not carry away, and did not ask for, was any piece of an gual dathach². The line kept that apart, as it had kept it since the vein was covered: the fire it gave to other hearths was ordinary fire, burning ordinary fuel, Teine a' Chlachair³ and no other, and no hearth beyond the line's own ever burned, in those years, so much as a sliver of what Neachdan had carried home under his cloak.

Eachna's first fire on the new ground was laid on a bed of pine brought down from the higher slopes and heather cut and dried through a summer for the purpose, the pine for its quick catching and the heather to hold the heat once caught, banked the way every careful hearth by then was banked, on stone rather than bare turf, for that lesson too had gone out from the mason's own household by her day and travelled as far and as freely as the fire. Round the hearth, in the seasons after, lay the ordinary leavings of an ordinary household's fire: scrapers of grey flint worked from stone carried up from the burn-bed, split and cracked for the marrow in them, the bones of red deer taken on the moor above, a scatter of hazel shells from nuts roasted whole in the embers. No coloured stone lay among them, then or for a long while after, and any traveller who came to that hearth in the years after and dug in the ash of it would have found nothing to mark it out from any other fire of that age, save that it was well kept and long kept, the household growing round it year on year as Eachna's own children and their children stayed on ground their mother had chosen rather than moving on.

The place took its name from the ground before it took any name from Eachna, called simply the straight field by those who first worked it, for it lay level and true between the burn and the rise behind it in a way that little ground on

2. the coloured coal

3. the mason's fire, the first fire

that broken country did; and it kept that name, Achadh dhìreach, after the households round it had grown too many to count by any one head, well after Eachna herself was gone from it.

In her old age it was said of her household, once it had grown large enough to be spoken of as more than one woman's fire, that its hearths kept the beasts closer in at night than the herding kin further up the valley troubled to, for the deer that came down off the moor in the dark months to browse the low ground had grown bold in a country still thin of houses, and more than one calf had been lost to nothing worse than a beast wandering too far from the firelight in a black night. Eachna's sons took to hunting the deer by torch after dark rather than waiting on daylight, a burning brand carried low and a second man behind with a spear, working the herds back from the standing crop toward the burn where the ground was open enough to see them by; it was slow work and cold work, and it did not always answer, though it answered oftener than watching alone had, and it kept, through Eachna's own lifetime and some way past it, more calves alive through the dark months than the valley had thought to expect.

Eachna lived to see her hearth become three hearths and then five, the straight field filling the way a valley fills, household by household, as sons and daughters married out and stayed near rather than moving off, each new hearth lit in turn from the one before it, back in an unbroken line to the coal she herself had carried from Tobar dhìreach as a young woman with more will than patience. She died at Achadh dhìreach in her sixty-eighth year, by her own hearth among her own grown children, and the fire she had carried burned on there after her the way every fire on that island by then was expected to burn on, tended by hands that had never seen Tobar dhìreach and never would, and owing it nothing beyond the memory of where the first of it had come from.

III

Of the Birch That Went and the Oak That Came

It is the grandmothers who keep this part of the telling, more than any single deed of any single household, for it happened the way the snowfields drew back on the high ground: too slowly for any one generation to say they had seen it happen, and plainly enough that three generations set together could see that it had.

The old women of the northern heath, in Eachna's day and after it, told it this way to their grandchildren, sitting by fires their own grandmothers had never known: that when their own grandmothers were girls, the ground north and east of the high valleys had stood thick with birch, pale-barked and quick-grown, and with pine among it on the drier rises, and little else beside heather and the low scrub that birch and pine will suffer to grow beneath them. Fuel from that country was thin fuel, quick to catch and quick to burn away, and a household that wintered near it kept its fire hungry through the cold months and grudged every armful it fed to the flame.

By the time those same grandmothers were themselves old, the telling went, the birch had thinned in places and gone from others altogether, and oak stood where it had stood, broad-crowned and slow-grown, with hazel thick beneath it wherever the light broke through, and the ground under both smelled different in autumn than it had ever smelled under birch alone, of leaf-mould and the sweet rot of fallen mast rather than the thin dry smell birch leaves give as they curl. Fuel from oak was better fuel, slower to catch but far slower to burn away, holding a fire through a night that birch alone would have starved by midnight, and a household that had oak within a morning's walk kept a warmer hearth for less carrying than a household that had only birch, or so every grandmother who told it agreed, whatever else she disagreed on.

No one could say, in Eachna's day or after, why the one tree should give way to the other over so wide a country, or how long the giving-way had truly taken, for it was not a thing any single teller had watched from its beginning to its end, only a thing each teller had watched a portion of and heard the rest from a mother or a grandmother who had watched the portion before. The northern grove that stood furthest into that changing country, far past any household's grazing, was oak already by the time any hearth-teller's grandmother could remember it, standing on ground that the oldest tellings held had once been open heath, bare and windswept, with nothing on it taller than a man's waist; and by Eachna's grandchildren's day it was oak grown tall enough that a man walking under it in summer could not see the sky for the leaves of it, and the ground beneath was thick with a mast of fallen acorns that no one troubled, in those years, to gather. That grove kept, among those few who spoke of it at all, the old name of Doire ghlas, though it lay so far to the north and so far from any hearth that most households of the high valleys had never seen it and never would, and knew it only as a word

in an old woman's telling, a place where, it was said, the trees had once been different, and had changed themselves without asking leave of anyone.

What the change meant, if it meant anything at all, no teller of those generations pretended to know, and the wiser grandmothers did not pretend either. They told it as they told the snowfields drawing back on the high ground above Conn's country, as a thing the world did in its own time and by its own reckoning, neither for the comfort of the households that lived through it nor against them, only alongside them, the way the seasons went alongside a life without ever once asking how that life was going.

IV

Of Luag and the Bare Horn

The households of the northern heath knew, by the time Eachna's grandchildren were grown, that the island did not go on forever in every direction the way a man might once have supposed, from ground he had never left, that it must. Herders following grazing further out than their fathers had troubled to go came back with word of a shore to the north that no fire could be carried past, and of a wind out there that took the warmth from a body faster than any winter in the high valleys, and the word travelled, as word did in that country, from hearth to hearth until it had gone further than any single herder's own feet had carried it.

Luag was the one who went to see, some four hundred and twenty-five years after Oidhche an Dealanaich¹, born to a household of the northern heath, near enough the changing country of birch and oak that he had grown up hearing the grandmothers' telling of it at every dark-of-the-year fire, and restless in a way that his own household found hard to account for, since nothing in his upbringing had marked him out for restlessness beyond any other young man of that country. He herded, as every young man of that country herded, but he herded further out each year than the year before, following the grazing past where his own kin were accustomed to follow it, until by his twenty-fifth year he had walked ground that no one of his household, so far as any of them could tell him, had ever walked before.

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

He set out for the horn in the spring of his twenty-sixth year, alone, with a coal carried in a clay pot the way every traveller of that country carried fire, and dried meat and a hide to sleep under, telling his household only that he meant to see how far the land truly went before it met the sea, and that he would be back before the grazing failed. It took him the better part of four days' walking, out past the last households his own kin had word of, out past the last stands of oak and hazel into country that thinned first to birch again and then to nothing taller than a man's knee, heather and low scrub and bare wet ground that sucked at his feet with every step, until on the evening of the fourth day he came up over a last low rise and saw, for the first time in his life, the open sea.

It was not the sea of the sheltered sounds that the herders of the north had told of, grey water with an island's shape somewhere against the far horizon to give the eye something to rest on. This was open water with nothing beyond it that Luag's eye could find, grey under a grey sky, running in long low swells that broke white on a shore of black rock with no beach to speak of, and a wind coming off it that found every gap in his hide cloak within the first few breaths of his standing there, colder than any wind he had felt in the high valleys even in the dead of winter.

He tried, that first night, to keep his fire as he had kept it every night of the journey out, banked in a shallow scrape with stones set round it for a wind-break. The wind came round the stones as though they were not there at all, and took the flame sideways along the ground faster than he could feed it, and by the third handful of dry heather he understood that the fire he had carried four days across the island to look at the sea was not going to live an hour on that ground, no matter how he built it or how he fed it. He let it go out rather than waste the last of his tinder chasing it, and spent that night in the lee of a rock with the hide pulled over his head and his body curled round the cold pot, colder than he had ever been in his life and too stubborn, or too curious, to turn back for it.

In the days he stayed there, walking the shore both ways as far as the light allowed, he found no hearth-stone, no scrap of charcoal, no sign anywhere on that ground that a fire had ever been kept there by anyone, hill-folk or otherwise, and no tree taller than his own knee standing anywhere he walked, though he went some distance along the shore in both directions to be sure of it. The ground was not poor ground exactly, for there was grass enough in the hollows out of the worst of the wind, and he saw the marks of deer on it and the droppings of hares, but it was ground that would not hold a household, he judged, walking it, no

more than it would hold his own small fire, open on every side to a wind that never seemed, in all the days he stayed, to fully drop.

He stood a long while, on the last evening before he turned for home, on the highest rock he could find above the shore, looking west, for the wind that beat at that coast came off the water in that direction rather than from the north as the worst of the high-valley winters did, and it seemed to him, standing there with his hide cloak snapping about his shoulders, that whatever weather his own country knew, fair or foul, came first across that water from somewhere further out than his eye could reach. He had no word for what lay beyond it, and did not trouble himself hunting for one; that evening it was enough to stand at the edge of ground he could walk no further along without a boat under him, and know, in a way he had not quite known setting out, that the island his own people lived on had an edge to it, here as much as anywhere, and that this was where its edge lay bare to the weather with nothing between it and the open sea.

In the morning he turned for home, walking the four days back by the same track he had come, and relit his fire at the first hearth he reached, a herding household two days short of his own that gave him coal and a meal and asked, as everyone by then asked a traveller from a strange direction, what he had found out there. He told them plainly: no tree, no hearth, no shelter a household could keep a fire in, only rock and wind and grass in the hollows and, past it all, water going on further than a man could see. He told the same, in much the same words, at his own hearth when he reached it, and again at the gathering of the near households in the dark half of that year, and the telling went from there the way every telling of that country went, hearth to hearth, until most of the northern heath had heard, in one form or another, that the land ran out at last in the north-west, bare to a wind no fire could stand against, with nothing beyond it that any of them had ever seen or ever would.

Luag lived on at his own household's hearth for the better part of fifty years after, herding the nearer ground in his later life as his knees stopped wanting the long walks of his youth, and he was known to the end of his days, kindly rather than mockingly, as the man who had gone to the edge of the world to see what was there and come back with nothing to show for it but a burnt cloak and a telling. He died in his seventy-second year among his own grown children, an old man by any measure the high country kept, and the telling he had brought back outlived him easily, kept at hearth after hearth well after there was no one left who had heard it first from his own mouth: that the island had an edge in the north-

west as sure as it had a middle, and that a man could walk to it and stand on it and feel, in the wind that never dropped there, how small a fire truly was against the whole breadth of the weather the sea sent in.

CHAPTER FIVE

OF the DROWNED Neck and the FIRST BOATS

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I

Of Gràinne and the Drowned Neck

There was a time, the north-shore tellers say, when a household could walk dry-shod to Eilean dhubh at any tide of the year, and a time after it when the same walk could be made only at the ebb of the lowest tides, and a time after that when it could not be made at all. No one household watched the whole of that change. Gràinne watched more of it than most, for she was born on the neck itself and she died on it, or near enough to it that the difference hardly mattered to those who buried her.

Her people had kept a hearth on the low neck since before her grandmother's grandmother, on a shelf of dry ground between two arms of shingle where the crossing to the island was narrowest and firmest underfoot. It was good ground for the purpose it was put to: near enough the mainland pastures to run beasts on both sides of the water, and near enough Eilean dhubh itself, where deer grazed thick and un hunted in her great-grandmother's day, that a household settled there ate better in a hard winter than a household settled further inland ever managed. The neck was never a rich place to live, being low and salt-scoured and bare of any shelter but what a household built for itself, but it was never a hungry one either, and Gràinne's people had no reason, through all the generations before her, to think of leaving it.

She was born some eighteen fathers after the mason, as the line at Tobar dhireach would have reckoned it, the youngest of a large household, and grew up doing what every child of the neck grew up doing: watching the tide. It was not a game to her, though it began as one. Her mother could read the run of a spring tide against the last one the way Conn's people, far south of her, read the colour of the light before dawn, and she taught Gràinne to read it the same way, walking the shingle with her at the top of every high water and setting a stone at the mark the sea had left, so that the next high tide could be measured against it. By the time Gràinne was a young woman she kept that watch herself, without her mother telling her to, because it had become a thing she did not know how to stop doing.

The stones told her what the household already half knew without wanting to say it aloud: that each year's highest tide came a little further up the shingle than the year before's, some years so little that only Gràinne's own eye could have caught it, and some years, after a wet season or a run of westerly gales, a stride's length further in one water than it had taken three ordinary years to gain. Her grandmother's telling held that in the grandmother's own girlhood a household could cross to Eilean dhubh on any day it pleased and get its feet no wetter than the mud always made them; by the time Gràinne was grown, the crossing could be made only within two hours either side of the lowest ebbs, and only then by those who knew which channels ran soft and which ran firm, for the neck no longer dried the same way in every place.

She married on the neck and buried a husband on the neck and raised children on it, and through all of that the sea kept its slow account against the shingle, a stride a year in the bad years and less in the good ones, and never once, in Gràinne's whole life, a stride backward. She would not leave. Her sons asked her to more than once, in the years when asking was still a thing that could be done gently, pointing out that the dry ground behind the shelf ran back further than the shelf itself and that a hearth moved a bow-shot inland would still be a hearth on the neck, still near enough the crossing and the deer and the shellfish beds her household had always worked. She heard them out each time and gave them the same answer each time: that she would move her hearth when the sea came into it and not a day before, for a hearth that ran from the water before the water had truly come for it was not a hearth kept by a people who meant to stay anywhere.

It came for it in her fifty-first year, in a spring of hard westerlies that piled water against the whole north coast for the better part of a month. Gràinne woke be-

fore dawn to a sound she had never before heard at that hearth, water moving under the floor of packed earth where her own feet had walked dry every morning of her life, and came out into a grey half-light to find the sea standing in the lowest corner of the house, black and cold and already a hand's depth deep, working its way toward the hearth-stones themselves with each small surge. She did not weep over it, or if she did the tellers do not say so. She raked the fire out into the clay pot her mother had raked fires into before her, and she carried it out past her own threshold for the last time, and she stood on the higher ground behind the shelf while her sons and their wives pulled what could be pulled from the flooding house, and she watched the water find the hearth-stones and put out, in a long hiss she said afterward she could hear over the wind, whatever of the old fire's ash had been left lying loose upon them.

They built the new hearth that same day, on the ground behind the old shelf that had stood dry through every tide Gràinne had ever measured, and she carried the coal to it herself out of the pot rather than let any of her sons do it, and lit it there before dark. She lived twenty-five years more at that second hearth, old even by the reckoning of that hard coast, and she kept the same watch on the tide out of the same habit as before, though by then it mattered less to her personally than it had, for the ground behind the shelf ran back far enough that no tide she lived to see came near it again. But she taught the watch to her grandchildren all the same, walking the shingle with them at every high water the way her own mother had walked it with her, and telling them, in words her household kept long after she was gone from it, that the sea did not forget an inch it had once taken, and that a household on that coast that stopped watching the water was a household asking to wake and find it already indoors.

The deer of Eilean dhubh, cut off from the mainland pastures once the neck stopped drying at all but the very lowest ebbs, grew smaller across the lifetimes that followed, penned as they were on ground too small to feed a herd that had once ranged the length of two islands as one. Hunters who crossed to the island by boat in Gràinne's granddaughters' time, when a boat had become the only sure way across, brought back carcasses lighter than their grandfathers' tellings had led them to expect, and said among themselves, without much wondering at it, that an island shrunk to an island fed its deer accordingly. Gràinne herself did not live to see that told at the hearth; she died at the second house, by her own fire, three fathers after her birth, as the line reckoned such spans, and was buried on the higher ground she had moved to rather than on the shelf that had been her

people's for longer than any teller could reckon, which by then lay under the sea at every tide that came.

II

Of Oisean and the Hide Boat

On the far side of the island, on the south shore where the water ran calmer and the land shelved gently rather than drowning by inches, a young man named Oisean grew up watching the sea for a different reason than Gràinne's people watched it. He did not care what it took. He cared what it held.

Oisean was born some seventy years after Gràinne, to a household of seal-hunters who worked the rocks and skerries of the mainland shore the way their fathers had worked them, waiting for the grey seals to haul out within reach of a spear thrown from dry land, and going home hungry on the seasons when the seals chose to haul out somewhere a spear could not reach. Oisean had watched, since he was old enough to be taken along and told to sit still, the greater number of seals that hauled out on Eilean mhin, the low island that lay off the south coast in plain sight of his own hearth on a clear day, further out than a man could wade and further out, so every hunter of his household had always said, than any boat of that coast could carry a man and bring him back.

There were no boats of that coast, in truth, worth much more than a log a boy might straddle to cross a burn in flood. Oisean's people knew hide, and knew how to stretch it and how to grease it against wet, for every hearth on that shore kept its winter cloaks of sealskin and knew the working of the stuff as well as any household on the island. What Oisean did, in his twenty-third year, was a thing none of his own people had thought to do with that knowledge before him, though afterward it seemed to every one of them a thing that should have been done long since: he built a frame of bent hazel, light and springy, shaped roughly to the outline of his own body doubled, and over it he stretched and stitched hides greased with seal fat at every seam, working alone at first, ashamed to be watched failing at a thing he could not himself have said would work.

It took him the better part of a season to make a hull he trusted to hold, and longer than that to trust himself to sit in it on open water rather than the calm inlet where he had first floated it and found, with some surprise, that it did not sink under him. His household thought him strange for the trying and stranger still

when the trying went on past the point where a sensible man would have given it up; but no one stopped him, for it was known on that coast, as on every coast of the island, that fire and shelter were owed to any kin who asked, and a young man's strangeness was his own business so long as it fed no one badly.

He crossed to Eilean mhin in the calm of an early summer morning, alone, with nothing but the paddle he had shaped and a coil of plaited hide should the boat need mending on the far side, and he was gone from his own shore long enough that his mother had begun, by the tellers' account, to walk the beach and watch for him with a dread she did not speak aloud. He came back before dark with three seals lashed across the frame behind him and the boat riding low enough in the water that he had shipped a hand's depth over the gunwale more than once on the crossing back, and he stood on his own shore soaked to the skin and laughing, by every telling that has come down of that evening, in a way his household had not seen him laugh before.

It was, so far as any teller of that coast or any other has ever claimed otherwise, the first time anyone on Dia-thir crossed open water on purpose, meaning to reach a place he could see but could not walk to, and meaning to come back from it the same day. What Oisean had proved, standing dripping on his own shore with three dead seals and a boat that had not failed him, was a thing simpler than any of his household at first understood it to be: that the water between two pieces of dry land need not be a wall. It could be crossed, if a man built the right thing to cross it in and trusted the building enough to sit inside it once it was afloat.

He did not stop at the one crossing. Within two summers he had built a second boat, larger, with room behind the paddler for a season's worth of dried meat and skins, and he began to camp on Eilean mhin rather than crossing and returning within a single day, staying out among the seal rocks for a stretch of good weather at a time and coming home only when the meat ran low or the weather turned against him. The camp he kept there, a low shelter of driftwood and hide pitched in the lee of a rise above the landing beach, came to be known among his own kin and the kin near them simply as the bothies, and it was kept a season at a time rather than year-round, for no household yet trusted itself to winter on ground with no fresh water of its own and no shelter but what could be carried across in a boat still small enough to upset in a bad sea.

Others followed him across in the years after, first his own brothers and then young men of neighbouring households who had watched the boats being built

and reasoned, as Oisean himself had reasoned, that a thing built by hands could be built again by other hands. By the time Oisean was himself an old man, the crossing to Eilean mhin in the calm months was no longer spoken of as a strange thing a strange young man had once done, but as a thing the shore households of that coast simply did, the way they gathered shellfish or dried fish on racks, and the seal-boathies on Eilean mhin stood, each summer, ready to be thatched again and lived in until the weather sent the boats home. Oisean himself crossed and camped there most summers of his life, and died at last at his own hearth on the mainland shore, in his sixty-ninth year, with his grandsons already building boats of their own beside his, each one, so the tellers say, a little surer in the making than his had been, for they had his to look at and he had had nothing at all.

III

Of Scàire and the Grey Bank

Further along the coast and further north than Oisean ever crossed, the water ran harder and the weather came in worse, and it was there, on the north shore, that a woman named Scàire took the boat further than any of her own people had yet trusted it.

She was born some sixty years after Oisean, into a household that had already, by her girlhood, taken up the making of hide boats after the manner that had spread up the coast from the south, though the boats of the north shore were built heavier and lower than Oisean's had been, for the water off that coast ran seldom calm and seldom warm even at midsummer, and a boat built light for a still southern crossing would not have lived an hour in it. Scàire grew up in those boats rather than merely watching them made, taken out by her father and her uncles from the time she was old enough to sit still and bail, and by the time she was a grown woman she handled a boat in a following sea as surely as any man of her household, which was, on that coast, saying a good deal.

The seals of the north shore did not haul out on any single island a man could reach and camp on in a day, as Oisean's did, but on a scatter of low skerries off Eilean fhada, bare rock standing clear of the water only at the ebb and swallowed whole at the flood, where the grey seals came each autumn in their hundreds to pup on ground no fox or wolf could reach. It was autumn work by its nature, for the seals came with the first of the year's gales and were gone again before the

worst of the winter storms set in, and it was gale work by its nature too, for a crew that waited for calm weather to make the crossing waited, on that coast, for weather that autumn seldom gave.

Scàire went out with her father's crew from her sixteenth year, in boats that shipped water over the bow with every third or fourth swell and had to be bailed continually by whoever was not paddling, and she learned, the way every hunter of that coast learned, to judge by the smell of the wind and the run of the cloud which days would let a crew out and back before the gale that was always somewhere behind the weather caught up with them. It was not judgement any teller could set down as a rule, only as a knowing that a body earned by being wrong about it once or twice early and surviving the wrongness. Some years the judgement failed more often than others. The households of the north shore kept, without troubling to set it down as anything more than a shared memory, a rough reckoning of how hard a year had been by how many of its boats the autumn gales had held ashore rather than let out to the skerries at all, and the year Scàire turned thirty-eight stood, in the memory of anyone then alive, as the hardest of that kind: five boats out of every six kept on the beach the whole autumn through, and the seal harvest that year thin enough that more than one household went into the winter short of oil for its lamps.

She herself was master of her own boat and crew by then, her father dead some years and his place taken by her without much argument from anyone, for no one on that coast doubted, by that time, that Scàire read a north-shore sea as well as any man alive on it. It was on one of the crossings of her middle years, out on the skerries themselves with the seal-taking done and the crew waiting on the tide before the run home, that she climbed the highest of the bare rocks to look for the change in the weather her father had taught her to watch for, and saw, lying along the whole northern edge of the sea where sky and water ought to have met in a plain line, a grey that did not lift.

It was not fog as she knew fog, which came and sat on the land in the small hours and burned off with the sun. This lay always in the same place, along the same stretch of horizon to the north and, she came to notice on crossings after, along much of the eastern water as well, never closer and never further, a wall of grey that the brightest day never burned through and the hardest gale never blew away. She asked the older hunters of her own crew whether they had marked it before, and found that they had, in a loose way, the way a man marks a hill he has looked at all his life without ever once asking its name; no one on that coast had

gone out far enough, or often enough, or with reason enough to look hard at it, to have made more of it than a grey bank that sat, as it had always sat so far as any of them could tell her, on the sea to the north and east and nowhere else.

Scaire looked at it a long while that day, from the highest of the skerries with the wind coming cold off it and the seal-blood still on her hands, and she did not go toward it, for there was nothing in the going that any purpose of hers required, and the boats she and her people built were built for the work they had, not for a water no one had yet had reason to cross. She told of it at her own hearth that winter and it went from there, as such things went on that coast, hearth to hearth along the shore until most who worked the northern water had heard some form of the telling: that there was a grey on the sea to the north that never lifted, that it stood always where it stood and moved for no wind, and that no boat of that coast, so far as anyone yet knew, had gone into it and come back to say what lay beyond.

She herself went out to the skerries most autumns of the rest of her life, gale years and calm years both, and grew old on that hard water the way Oisean had grown old on the gentle water of the south, dying at last at her own hearth in her sixty-third year, remembered by her own kin less for the grey bank, which by then every household of that coast had heard of and settled into simply knowing, than for the thirty-eight boats she had brought home whole across a working life on a sea that forgave very little.

IV

Of the Weirs on the Abhainn ìseal

While the two shores learned the water each in its own way, a quieter change was working itself out along the banks of the longest river on the island, where it ran wide and slow through the low ground before losing itself in the sea.

The Abhainn ìseal had never, within any telling that reached that far back, run in quite the same bed for two generations together, spreading itself across the flat ground in wet years and drawing into a narrower, deeper channel in dry ones, until sometime in the years after Gràinne's death it settled, as rivers will when the ground beneath them has finally been worked to its own true shape, into the wide bed that the households along it came to know as simply the river, without fur-

ther telling being needed to say which one was meant. It was in the side channels of that newly settled bed, the shallower cuts where the current ran gentler and the fish gathered thickest at certain seasons, that the first weirs of hazel stakes were driven.

No single teller is remembered as the one who thought of it, and no single household claimed the making the way Neachdan's household claimed *Teine a' Chlachair*¹; it was a thing that seems to have occurred to more than one household along that stretch of river at much the same time, once the bed had settled enough that a stake driven one autumn could be trusted still to stand there the next. The stakes were driven close together across the mouth of a side channel at the season when the fish ran thickest, angled to hold against the current, with gaps left for a man to reach in and take what the current had crowded against the barrier; and when the season's run was done the stakes were left standing rather than pulled, for a household that had once found the right place for a weir saw no reason to find it again from nothing the following year.

They were renewed rather than rebuilt, generation on generation, the households of that stretch of river driving fresh stakes into the same holes the old ones had rotted out of, so that a weir kept by a household thirty years on from its first driving stood, to any eye that measured it against the riverbank, on almost exactly the ground it had first stood on, though not one stake of the original driving remained in it. It became, without anyone remarking on it as a change worth remarking, the way that stretch of the Abhainn ìseal was fished, and children of those households grew up wading the shallows at weir-mending time the way children elsewhere grew up herding, knowing which hole took a stake easily and which fought it, long before they knew why the holes were where they were.

The salmon came up that river in their great runs each year at much the same season the seals hauled out on Scàire's northern skerries, and it was some twenty-eight fathers after the mason, the weirs by then old and well proven, that the households along the river first kept what came to be remembered as a feast of it rather than simply a harvest: households from up and down that stretch gathering at the largest of the weirs when the run was at its thickest, sharing out what the barriers had caught between more hands than any one household's own, and eating, by every account that survived of it, better in that one week than most of them ate in the whole of any other season. No single voice planned it, the tellers

1. the mason's fire, the first fire

say; it grew the way the weirs themselves had grown, out of neighbours finding it easier to work a good run together than to guard it apart.

By then the neck where Gràinne had watched the tide lay drowned at every water, and the seal-bothies of Eilean mhin stood thatched each summer as a matter of course, and boats of one build or another put out from half the coasts of the island in weather that would once have kept every hearth ashore. A traveller of that year, walking the bank of the Abhainn ìseal at the height of the salmon feast, might have seen at the largest of the weirs a boy no older than six or seven wading out with his father's hand steadying him, driving a fresh stake into a hole worn smooth by stakes his father and his father's father had driven there before him, into water that ran, as it had run for longer than either of them could reckon, exactly where the river had chosen, at last, to run.

CHAPTER SIX

Of the Shell Mound and the Three Strokes

VE 751 – 820

I

Of the Heap at Dunn

On the eastern coast, where the land breaks into low cliffs and the tide goes out a long way over flat rock, there was a heap of shell already old before any of this is told. No one living could have said how it began, and no teller of the hills, then or after, ever went near enough to ask, for the hill-folk and the people of that heap did not go about among one another, and what passed between them, if anything passed, is not told here.

A woman came down to the shore each morning while the tide was out, and worked the rock pools and the wet sand with a stick of bone worn smooth at the grip, and filled a woven bag with limpets prised loose one at a time, each with its own small crack and give, and with the flatter shells that lay half buried at the tideline, and with whatever crab or urchin the falling water had left behind in a hollow. She had done this since she was old enough to carry a bag of her own, following her mother down the same path over the same rock, and her mother had done it before her, and no one troubled to ask further back than that.

What she gathered she carried up a short rise above the shore to where the heap stood, and there she opened the bag and let the shell fall where the heap wanted it, working it in with her foot so that it lay level and did not slide, the way she had been shown. Bones went into it too, seal bones mostly, cracked for the marrow and picked clean and then given to the heap along with everything else,

and weed burned black on a fire kept at the heap's foot went into it in its ashes, so that the whole mass of the thing was shell and bone and burnt weed together, layer under layer, each layer settled by the weight of the one above it.

The woman's mother had told her, as her own mother had told her before that, where each kind of shell was to be set and where the bone, and why the burnt weed went in thin and not thick, and why the whole was worked with the foot and never simply thrown; and the woman kept it as she had been given it, without asking herself why it should be kept in that order rather than some other, for it had always been kept so, and a thing kept so long needs no further reason than that.

The work took most of a morning and something of the afternoon too, in every season but the deepest of winter, when the household drew in closer to the fire and lived a while off what the summer and the autumn had put by. In spring the pools ran thick with young limpets easily taken, and the gulls came down onto the rocks in numbers to work the same ground a little behind the gatherers, so that a woman crouched at her work through half a morning might straighten to find the whole shore behind her white with birds, waiting on whatever she left uncovered. In the drier months of summer the low cliffs above the shore carried nests of their own, and eggs went into the bag along with the shell when a ledge could be reached, though never so many from one ledge that the birds did not come back to it the next year; that much, at least, every gatherer on that coast seemed to know without having been told it in words, the way a hand knows not to close entirely round a coal.

The fire at the heap's foot never went fully out. Who had first set it there, or how, no one now living could say, any more than they could say who had first carried a shell up from the shore and let it fall in that one place rather than any other; it was simply a thing the heap had, the way the shore had tide and the sky had weather, and it was kept the way anything is kept that a household cannot do without, fed through the wet months with driftwood carried up from the strand-line and through the dry months with whatever scrub grew close enough to spare. In the worst of the winter gales, when the wind came in off the water hard enough to lay a grown man flat, two or three would crouch about it through the black hours with their backs to the weather, feeding it a stick at a time, and in the morning it would still be there, low and red under its own ash, however far the gale had driven the rest of them to shelter.

One such gale, in the woman's own girlhood, tore the roof from the low shelter her household kept behind the heap and drove the sea itself up over the rocks where the gathering was done, so that for three days no one went down to the pools at all, and the household sat close about the fire at the heap's foot with what little was left from before the storm, listening to the wind take whatever it could still find to take. When the gale broke and the water drew back off the rocks it left the shore scoured clean and strange, familiar pools filled with sand and new pools opened where none had been, and the gathering had to be learned freshly over that stretch of coast as though the sea had asked a question and expected the answer found again from the beginning. The fire, banked low and fed through all three days by whoever could be spared to crouch over it, had not gone out; and though nothing was said of that in any words the telling has kept, it was noticed, and it was remembered, the way a thing is remembered that a household has come near to losing.

By the time the woman had a daughter old enough to carry her own bag down to the shore, the heap already stood higher than the woman's own waist along its seaward face, and higher again where the older shell had settled hardest, grey with age and crusted with a growth the newer shell did not yet have. It smelled, on a still day, of the sea gone stale, of weed and old bone and smoke, a smell that clung to the hands and the hair of anyone who worked at it and that none of them, having grown up inside it, ever noticed until they had been away from the shore a day or two and come back to it.

II

Of the Height of a Man

The years went by the way years go by for people who keep no count of them: by the return of the birds that nested on the low cliffs each spring and left again each autumn, by the runs of fish that came in close to shore at one season and out again at another, by the slow climb and fall of the tide against marks on the rock that every child of that shore learned before any other lesson. The woman's mother grew old working the pools in the cold months long after her hands had stiffened past any real use for the work, unwilling to sit by the fire while there was shell still to be carried, until one winter she did not come up

from the shore at the day's end, and was found sitting against a rock with the tide already turning round her feet, gone as quietly as she had lived.

They buried nothing of her at the heap. What was done with her the telling does not follow, for it went on below the rise, among the household's own places, out of sight of anything that would carry the doing of it further than it was meant to go; only that after that day the woman worked the pools alone for a season, and then with her own daughter beside her, and the heap went on growing the way it had grown before, a little higher each year, as though it had not noticed, and in a sense it had not.

For that one season the woman went down to the shore before first light and came up from it after dark, working alone the ground she had always worked beside another, and those who watched her said afterward that she never once let the fire at the heap's foot go lower than she had kept it when there were two pairs of hands to feed it. She did not speak of her mother at the work, then or later; grief in that household, whatever shape it took, took it below the rise and out of sight, and what showed at the heap was only the steadiness of a woman going on with a thing that wanted doing whether she grieved or not.

The daughter, grown near a woman's height herself by then, found once, digging her stick down into an old shoulder of the heap to loosen a stubborn crust of shell, a tool of her grandmother's time worked into the mass below: a scraper of flint, broad and short and struck from the stone in a way that showed, to anyone who set it beside a tool freshly made at the heap's fire that same season, that the hand which had made it had held the stone differently, and struck it at a different angle, and finished its edge by a different kind of working altogether. It was not a strange thing to find an old tool in the heap, for tools went in with everything else once they were worn past use, but this one the daughter kept out a while before she let it go back into the shell, turning it in her fingers and running her thumb along its edge, which was blunted now but had once, by the set of it, been sharp along a line no one now living struck a stone to match. She said nothing of it to her mother that she is remembered to have said, and put it back where she had found it before the light went, and the heap took it in again the way it took in everything given to it.

The heap stood, by the year that the woman herself began to feel her own hands stiffen in the cold months as her mother's had, taller than any of them, higher at its crown than a grown man could reach with his arm stretched over his head, a long low mass along the rise above the shore that could be seen, on a clear

day, from boats working the water some way off, a pale ridge against the darker ground behind it. No one had set out to build it to any height. It had simply grown, morning by morning, bag by bag, foot-fall by foot-fall, for as long as anyone could remember and a good while longer than that, until it had become, without any one person meaning it, the tallest thing that shore had.

The day it was first remarked on for its height, rather than simply worked at as it had always been worked at, was an ordinary one: a boy of the household, sent up from the shallows to fetch fire down for a smoking of fish, stood at the heap's foot and looked up its face the way he had never troubled to before, and said, to no one in particular, that a man standing at the top of it could see further out over the water than a man standing anywhere else on that stretch of coast. It was true, and no one had thought to say it before him, and after that it was said again from time to time, when a boat was overdue or a weather sign wanted watching for, that the top of the heap was the place to stand for it; and so the heap that had grown for no purpose beyond having somewhere for the shell to go came, without anyone setting out to make it so, to be used as a place from which to watch the sea.

On other shores of that same coast, in those same years, other households kept other heaps in the same slow way. None of them is this telling's business, save to say that the heap at the eastern shore was neither the largest of its kind on that coast nor the smallest, and that whatever moved the hands that heaped the others moved the hands at this one too, without any of them, so far as anyone can now say, ever comparing their work with any other household's along the whole long line of that shore.

III

Of the Net-Maker of Cwen

Some way along the coast, where the land turned in on itself and made a wide bay sheltered from the worst of the open sea, another household kept a different trade, and a woman of it who is remembered only as the net-maker worked stone weights for her lines the way her own mother had worked them before her.

She took beach stones for it, rounded ones about the size of a fist, and pecked a groove about the middle of each with a harder stone struck again and again in

the same place until the groove was deep enough to hold a cord without slipping, a slow careful work that ruined more stones than it finished, for a stone that split wrong at the wrong moment was no use to her and went back onto the beach with the others. When a weight was finished and true, she did one thing more to it before she judged it done: she cut three short strokes into the stone's face, close together, always in the same place and always in the same order, the first stroke a little longer than the two beside it, the whole no bigger than the width of two fingers laid flat.

No one asked her why she did it, and the telling carries no answer, for there is none to carry. Every stone she finished carried the same three strokes, no more and no fewer, whatever its size or its place on the line, always the same close order whether it was the first weight cut that season or the fiftieth. It was simply a thing she did to a stone once the stone was ready to be a weight and not before, the way a woman elsewhere might finish a pot with a rim pressed by her own thumb, or a scraper with one last stroke along its edge past the point where the edge itself needed it. Whether it was hers alone, or a mark that had come to her from someone before her the way the notching of the groove itself had come to her, no one now can say; only that every weight found afterward along that stretch of shore, however old, carried the same three strokes cut the same way, so that a stone worked a lifetime before her own could be told from a stone worked by any other hand only by the eye that had learned the small differences a lifetime leaves in even the same three strokes cut again and again.

The net itself was her mother's work as much as the weights, plant fibre twisted and knotted by hand into a mesh wide enough to let the smallest fish through and hold the rest, a labour of whole winters spent close by the fire with the cord running through fingers grown hard and quick at it, knot after knot after knot until the mesh lay in coils as tall as a child. For years the nets that household set were short ones, reaching only a little way out from the shallows on either side of the bay's mouth, enough to take a fair catch on a good tide but leaving the deeper water of the channel between them open, and through that gap, on the years the run was heaviest, more fish went than ever came against the line.

In the year the net-maker judged her mesh long enough at last to close the whole distance, she set it across the bay from shallow to shallow in one unbroken run for the first time in that household's memory, staking it through a low tide with every hand that could be spared, the net-maker herself wading the deepest stretch of the channel with the heaviest weights slung at her waist to sink the

centre of the line true. The tide came in behind them as they worked, and they finished the last stake with the water already at their thighs, and stood back on the shingle in the dusk to see the whole long line of floats and weights holding steady from one side of the bay's mouth to the other, a barrier where there had never before been more than two arms reaching toward each other and failing to meet.

What came against that net in the days that followed was more fish than the household's smoking-racks could hold, and word of the catch went along the shore the way such word went, so that households some way off came to see the thing for themselves and went home again to lengthen their own nets by whatever means each knew, though none of them, so far as anyone remembers, ever matched the closed line at the net-maker's own bay in that same year. She set her nets across the mouth of the bay in every season after that the fish ran thick, staking the ends where the water shallowed and letting the weighted line hang between, low enough to sit just under the surface where the fish did not see it until they were already against it, work that wanted more than one pair of hands and drew the whole household down to the shallows at both ends of the day, wading out to their knees in cold water to set stakes and gather in whatever the night had brought against the line.

IV

Of the Three Strokes

The net-maker had a daughter who came to the work early, as children of that shore came early to any work that wanted small quick hands, and who sat beside her mother through whole afternoons watching the groove deepen in stone after stone, the same patient strokes falling in the same place until the stone gave way and took the shape wanted of it. She learned to judge, before she was trusted to peck a groove herself, which stones would split true under the working and which would shatter wrong however carefully they were struck, a judgement her mother never troubled to put into words and that the girl came to only by watching enough stones ruined and enough stones finished to feel the difference in her own hands before she could have said what the difference was.

It was longer still before her mother let her cut the three strokes, for a weight badly grooved could be reworked or set aside with little lost, but the strokes were cut only once, on a weight already finished, and a bad cut there spoiled a stone

that had cost a morning's careful work to bring that far. The girl watched her mother's hand do it a great many times before she was given a stone of her own and the smaller flint used for the cutting, and was shown, without being told in any words the telling has kept, where the first stroke began and how long it ran and at what small angle the two beside it were meant to fall, close enough together that a glance took in all three at once and none as its own mark apart from the others.

Her first attempts went wrong the way a child's first attempts at any close work go wrong, the strokes too long or too short or crossing where they should have stood apart, and each spoiled stone went back to the pile of stones not yet fit to be weights, without anger and without much comment, for every hand at that work had spoiled stones before it made good ones and the girl's mother had spoiled her own share in her time. The girl kept at it through a good part of a year, cutting the three strokes on stone after stone in whatever quiet hour her mother judged she could be spared from the heavier work of the nets, and each time she looked harder than the time before at the depth and the angle and the closeness of the cuts, holding the flint the way she had watched it held rather than the way that first came easiest to her own hand.

On a morning in the calm weather that closed one summer of that stretch of years, she cut three strokes into a finished weight and held it up to the light the way she had seen her mother hold a hundred stones up before her, turning it so the low sun caught the grooves and threw a small shadow along each one, and found nothing in it that her eye, trained now to the fault, could fault. Her mother took it from her without a word and turned it the same way in the same light, and gave it back, and said nothing more than what her hand did next, which was to take up another stone from the unworked pile and set it down before the girl for the next one.

From that stone onward she kept a way of turning a finished weight over in her hand before she set it down that her mother had never quite had, holding it a breath longer in the light than the work itself required, as though the three strokes, once she had learned to cut them true, had become a thing worth looking at for its own sake and not only for the weight's sake.

Her mother grew old at the work in the years after, her eyes going first, so that she gave over the finer judging of a stone's fitness to the daughter's sharper sight some while before her hands themselves failed her, and the daughter took up the whole of the weight-cutting in her own right well before she had any daughter of

her own to sit beside her and watch the groove deepen in stone after stone. She kept the strokes as she had been given them, the first a little longer than the two beside it, the same close order every time, on every stone she ever finished from that year to the end of her own working life; and when in time she came to teach the cutting to a child of her own, she taught it exactly as it had been taught to her, without adding to it and without troubling to explain what, if anything, it stood for, for there was nothing more to give than the shape itself and the knowing of it complete.

The weight the girl had cut went onto the net with all the others that season, indistinguishable among them to any eye but her own and her mother's, one more small stone among a great many doing the same plain work at the edge of a bay that had held a household at that work for longer than either of them could reckon; and if it were possible to lay every weight ever cut on that shore out in a single row, the three strokes on each would run the same close order down the whole long line of them, stone after stone, hand after hand, the one mark on all that coast that any of them ever troubled to make the same way twice, for no other reason than the telling keeps than that it had always been made so, and that having a shape to give a finished thing was itself, it seems, a kind of answer to something none of them ever asked aloud.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Of the Boy Who Asked

VE 821 – 889

Tha spiorad fa leth san speur, san talamh agus sa mhuir. Meascaich na spioradan agus bidh iad uile-chumbhachdach. The sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit. Merge the spirits, and they become almighty.

— Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich, as Clann a' Chlachair keeps it
The Second Part: Of the Question in the Grove, and the Gold on the Sea

I

Of the Pot and the Bag

At Tobar dhìreach the hearth had not gone dark since Oidhche an Deal-anaich¹, and after some thirty fathers no one troubled to say so any more, the way no one troubled to say that the sun rose. The household had grown the way a good field grows, year on year, until it was less one house than a scatter of houses about the old ring of stones where Teine a' Chlachair² had been set down, and the line that kept the ring had a name in every mouth from the high valleys to the eastern hearths, though the name meant no more to most of those mouths than "the people who keep the fire and ask the question nobody can answer."

The fire itself was ordinary enough to look at: peat and birch and whatever else the year gave, banked low at night and built up at morning, the same as any

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

2. the mason's fire, the first fire

hearth from the coast to the moor. What set it apart from every other hearth on the island, the household said, and had said for so many generations that the saying had worn as smooth as a much-handled stone, was that it had never once been struck new. It had come down, coal to coal, unbroken, from the storm that had put it into Neachdan's well; and to keep that unbroken thread alive, one woman of the line at a time kept a clay pot near the ring, banked with ash of its own, in which a single ember of the old fire was never let go out, so that even if the whole wide hearth should somehow die in the night — which it never had, but the women who kept the pot did not build a custom on what had never happened, they built it on what must never happen — there would still be, in the little pot, enough of the mason's own fire to light the hearth again from that one ember, and owe nothing to any neighbour's fire for it.

The pot had a name in the household, though not, in those years, one the wider hills had troubled to learn: they called it simply Poit an Teine³, and the woman who kept it, the keeper of the pot, and both titles had passed, mother to daughter or aunt to niece as the fires of a household usually pass, through more hands than the household could easily number by then. In the year this telling opens, the keeper of the pot was an old woman known to her own kin only as the old woman of the pot, for she had outlived every teller who might have troubled to fix a better name to her; and it was into her charge, and after her into the charge of a woman named Fionnghuala, that the pot came down.

There was a second thing kept at Tobar dhìreach that the wider hills knew a little better, because children carried word of it home from visiting cousins the way children carry word of anything strange and bright. This was a leather bag, worn soft at the seams, that held seven pieces of stone unlike any stone dug from any other ground on the island. Black, one of them was, and took a polish like still water at night. A second had a sheen of gold on it, so that it seemed, held to the light, to hold a small still sea inside it. A third was flecked all through with points of white, like a hard black sky full of small stars. A fourth had a gleam of silver under its black; a fifth was the deep red-brown of an old oak's heart; a sixth held the colour of flame itself, red and gold together, moving in it as flame moves when it is turned; and the last was a colour no one at Tobar dhìreach had ever agreed how to name, for it changed as it was turned, gold to green to a blue no sky ever wore, and back again, never twice the same, the way oil sits on the top of still water and

3. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

shows every colour there is without keeping any of them. This last piece the household called, when it called it anything, the rainbow piece.

The pieces had come home in Neachdan's own tunic on Oidhche an Deal-anaich, part of the same breaking of stone that had let the fire into the world; and being pretty and being useless — they had been tried in the fire, long before, and had burned low and dark and given up their colour to the flame like any other coal, and no one troubled the trying twice — they had passed, in time, out of the keeping of the elders and into the hands of the children, the way a household's outworn treasures generally do. Every child born at Tobar dhìreach for as long as the pieces had been kept there had, at some point in a short and undistinguished life of being minded by an older cousin while the grown households worked, tipped the bag out on the hearthstone and set the pieces in a row, and turned them to the fire to watch the colours move, and lost interest in them by the time the next meal was called, the way children lose interest in anything that does not need feeding or chasing.

That was the whole history of the coloured pieces, so far as the household of Fionnghuala's girlhood understood it: a wonder found with the fire, tried once as fuel and found no better than any other coal, kept afterward because throwing away a thing that had come with the lightning felt, to every keeper who had ever considered it, an unlucky sort of economy. No one at Tobar dhìreach, in all the generations between the mason and the boy this telling is about, is remembered to have asked why the pieces were coloured at all, when the coal of the common hills was not; or if any had asked it, the asking had died with them and left no mark on the telling, the way most questions do.

II

Of the Question

iarmad was born at Tobar dhìreach some thirty-four fathers after Conall, the third child and second son of Fionnghuala, who was by then some four-and-twenty and not yet keeper of the pot, that office still resting with her own mother's sister, the old woman the household called, without much ceremony, the aunt. He was a quiet child by the account of those who remembered him quiet, and by all other accounts a child who asked more than his fair share of questions even for a child, which is a kind of creature that asks a great

many; but the household had raised enough children by then to have a settled patience for it, and most of what he asked — why the geese went, why the salmon came, why the frost took some plants and spared others — got him a plain answer or an honest "no one knows that," and the matter closed there the way such matters generally close.

He was seven years old, in the summer of his seventh year, when he tipped the bag out on the hearthstone one wet afternoon with two cousins for company, and set the seven pieces in their row as every child before him had set them, and turned them, one after another, to the low grey light coming in at the door. It was a game he had played a dozen times before without it meaning anything more than an idle afternoon. This time, holding the black piece up and turning it so its polish caught what light there was, he asked the aunt, who was working wool by the same hearth and paying the children the same half-attention she paid the weather, why it was that this stone had colour in it and the coal from the cutting on the hillside, which she burned every day of her life, did not.

The aunt did not know, and said so without much thought, the way she would have said she did not know why the frost took some plants and spared others; and that, on any other afternoon with any other child, would have been the end of it. But Diarmad set the black piece down and picked up the gold-sheened one and asked the same question of that, and then of the silver one, and then, turning the rainbow piece so the colour ran gold to green and back, asked it of that piece hardest of all, for it seemed to him, he said afterward more times than the telling can count, the strangest of the seven and therefore the one most owed an answer. By then the aunt had given over three or four answers of the "no one knows that" kind and found the child unsatisfied with every one of them, and she said at last, not unkindly, only with the weariness of a grown woman whose wool has stopped taking her attention, that the stones were coloured because the sky had made them so on the night it sent the fire, and a boy who wanted a better answer than that could go and ask the sky.

It was meant, by every account the household later gave of it, as the kind of thing said to close a matter, not open one. Diarmad took it, by every account he himself is remembered to have given, as an answer worth pursuing.

III

Of the Years of Asking

he did not go and ask the sky, being seven, and having some idea, even at seven, of where a question could sensibly be carried and where it could not. He went instead, over the years that followed, to everyone at Tobar dhireach and beyond it who might plausibly know a thing that his own household did not, and asked each of them, in his own words and in his own time, why the coloured pieces held colour when no other stone on the island did.

The oldest of the line, a bent man who had buried more of his own kin than he had living, told him only that the fire had come from the sky and the pieces with it, and a thing that comes from the sky need not answer to a boy why it looks as it looks. The fire-bearers, the men and women whose office it still was, in those years, to carry a coal in a clay pot to any household that asked one, and who therefore travelled further and saw more of the island than most, gave him one true morsel among the rest: a woman among them had heard, from a household three valleys over, that colour in a stone was only the same colour the eye puts into a rainbow, no more real than a rainbow is, and vanishes the same way when you go close enough to look. This pleased Diarmad not at all, for he had gone close enough to look at the pieces a hundred times and their colour had never once thinned for the looking. Travellers passing through on their way to somewhere else, strangers with no stake in the household's pride and therefore, he reasoned, no reason to fob him off with an answer meant only to be rid of him, gave him, from most of them, either a shrug or a longer answer that amounted, when turned over, to the same shrug dressed in more words.

He took to carrying the rainbow piece with him, in a small bag of its own hung at his belt, from about his tenth year onward, and the household grew used to seeing him turn it in whatever light was going: the low red light of the hearth of an evening, the white light of noon on a clear day, the flat grey light of the rain, which he seemed, if anything, to prefer, for he was known more than once to sit out under the eaves in a shower with the piece held bare to the wet, turning it slowly, watching to see whether the rain drew the colour out of it or only lay on top of it the way rain lies on any other stone. It lay on top of it. He noted this, in the way a child notes a thing he means to come back to, and went on asking.

By his thirteenth year the asking had become, without his quite meaning it to, a settled feature of the household's talk, the kind of thing a family jokes about the way it jokes about an old dog's habits or an uncle's temper. "Diarmad's question," the valley began to call it, and the phrase travelled further and faster than any answer ever had; a fire-bearer from Tobar dhireach arriving at a strange hearth with a

coal in her pot might be met, before the coal was even set down, with someone asking, half in earnest and half to raise a laugh from the rest of the house, whether she had brought word yet of why the pieces were coloured, for the boy at Tobar dhìreach was still asking, was he not, and had anyone yet given him an answer that stuck. It was said, for the most part, the way a valley says most things about its own, with more affection in it than the words alone would suggest to a stranger. But it was said often, and a joke said often enough wears a groove, and by the time Diarmad was old enough to notice the groove for what it was, he had been the valley's fondest jest for longer than he could clearly remember not being it.

His mother did not always find it so fond. Fionnghuala had taken the office of keeper of the pot in her two-and-fortieth year, the aunt having died the winter before at a good age and by a quiet death, and she kept it, by every account, with the same close attention she had always given her son's asking, neither of which she was minded to have laughed at in her hearing. There is a telling kept at Tobar dhìreach still, worn thin with retelling, of an evening when a cousin by marriage, newly come into the household and not yet schooled in its ways, made the joke of the coloured pieces once too carelessly at the hearth, in front of a full house and in front of Diarmad himself, who by then was near enough grown to feel a joke land where a child does not; and of Fionnghuala setting down her work, and saying, in a voice the telling swears carried to every corner of the house though she never once raised it, that a question asked twenty years running by the same boy was not the same thing as a boy who could not let a matter drop, and that she would thank the house to remember the difference, for she had raised the one and would not sit easy hearing him called the other. The cousin, the telling says, made no more such jokes in that house again; the rest of the valley, having no such mother to answer to, went on making them a good while longer, though a little more quietly when word of that evening reached them.

Diarmad, for his own part, seems from every account to have taken the joke and the mother's defence of him both with much the same even temper, neither much stung by the one nor much comforted by the other, as a man goes on with a long walk regardless of whether the weather along it is fair or foul. He kept asking. He kept turning the rainbow piece to whatever light the day offered. And by the time he had passed twenty years, with the household's fire and the pieces' silence both unchanged since the day he first set them in a row on the hearthstone, he had begun, without much announcing it, to ask a narrower question than the one he had started with: not why the pieces held colour, which no one on the is-

land seemed able to tell him, but whether there was anyone, or anything, on the island at all that might know.

IV

Of the Herder of the North Moor

It was a fire-bearer, in the end, who gave him the first thread worth following, though she herself did not know she was giving it, and would have been surprised, the telling says, to learn what came of it.

In the summer of Diarmad's four-and-twentieth year she had gone on the longest circuit the household's fire-bearers still walked in those days, up past the last of the herding grounds and onto the high moor that lay north and a little west of the valley, where the households thinned to a scatter and a fire, once given, might not be asked for again for a generation. She came home some weeks later with little enough to report of the households she had found, for there had been few, and those few had wanted only the fire and no talk with it; but she mentioned, more in passing than as a matter she thought worth much, that one old herder on the moor, a solitary sort who kept more to his sheep than to any hearth, had told her, when she asked the way onward, to keep well clear of a grove of oaks a further two or three days north, for the wind in it, he said, did not blow the way wind blows anywhere else, and a man who camped near it on a bad night might hear it say things a wind has no business saying.

The fire-bearer told it as she had heard it, as an old herder's fancy, the kind of tale every solitary keeper of a lonely ground tells to anyone who will listen, more to hear his own voice than to be believed; and most of the household who heard it that evening took it exactly so, and forgot it by the next day's work. Diarmad did not forget it. More than once over the following weeks he asked her to say again exactly what the herder had said, and exactly how he had said it, until she grew tired of the asking and told him plainly that she had already told him everything there was in it, three times over, and that he would do better to go and hear it from the herder's own mouth if he wanted more than that.

He took the suggestion more seriously than she had meant it. Over the two years that followed he sought out every traveller who passed through Tobar dhìreach from the north and west and asked each of them the same thing: had they heard, in their own travels, of a grove where the wind spoke, or of the old

herder who kept sheep near it, or of anything at all that a teller might set beside such a tale. Most had heard nothing. A few had heard something, thinner scraps mostly, an old woman's warning to keep no fire lit within sight of a certain stand of trees, a half-remembered saying that the birds would not roost in it though the ground round it was as good as any for nesting; and one traveller, an old man himself, said he had passed near enough to see the tops of the oaks from a distance once in his youth, standing taller and greener than any wood he knew elsewhere on the moor, and had felt no wish at all to go nearer, though he could not, when Diarmad pressed him, say what exactly it was he had felt or feared.

None of it, set together, amounted to much that a careful man would have called evidence of anything beyond a lonely moor's fondness for its own stories. Diarmad set it together anyway, the way a man who has been asking one question for twenty years learns to set together whatever scraps come his way, for he has long since given up waiting for a whole answer to arrive complete. What struck him, he is remembered to have said at the hearth more than once in those years, was not that the wind in a grove might speak, for winds say a great many things to a lonely ear and he did not think himself fool enough to build much on that alone. It was that of all the tellings he had chased in near twenty years of chasing them, this was the first that had not simply shrugged the coloured pieces off as a matter closed, the sky's business and no one else's. A grove where something spoke, whatever it was, was at least a place where a question might be put and an answer, of some kind, might come back.

V

Of the Walk

he was seven-and-twenty in the late winter he finally went, old enough by the reckoning of that country to have long since taken a wife and a household of his own, which he had not, being by then a man the valley had grown used to thinking of chiefly as the boy who still asked the question, and finding, most of them, little enough reason to change the habit of thought even though the boy had grown, in every other respect, into something closer to a settled man. His mother was the first of the household he told what he meant to do, for he judged, rightly, that she alone among them would neither laugh at it nor try seriously to talk him out of it; and she gave him, in place of either, the

rainbow piece to carry loose in his hand rather than shut in its bag, saying that if he meant to ask his question of a wind in a grove, he had best have the thing itself before him while he asked it, and not only the memory of its colours.

Diarmad set out on a clear morning in the month of the lambs' first coming, walking light, with a small clay pot banked round a coal from the hearth, a small store of food, a cloak against the weather, and the rainbow piece carried, as his mother had told him, loose against his palm inside the fold of his cloak, where his thumb found it without his troubling to look. The way north and a little west from Tobar dhireach ran first through country he knew, herding ground and the thinning edge of it, and then, by the second day, through country he did not, where the households grew as few and as far between as the fire-bearer had found them, and the moor opened wider on every side than any ground he had walked before.

The weather held fair through the first day and turned, on the second, the way weather turns on a high moor without much warning given for it: a wind coming up out of the west in the early afternoon, cold and steady, and clouds massing behind it faster than a walking man cares to watch. He camped that night in the lee of a fold of ground with what shelter he could find, and woke before light to a wind grown harder still, and pushed on regardless, for he had counted the days of his walking against the little food he carried and knew he had no days to spare for waiting out weather on open moor.

By the third afternoon he could see, some way ahead across the last stretch of open ground, a dark line along a low rise that was neither heather nor bare rock but stood taller than either, and greener even at that distance and in that light than anything else the moor showed him; and he knew, before any traveller's telling could have told him so for certain, that this was the grove he had walked three days to find.

The gale was on him in full by the time he came under the first of the trees, a wind such as he had not felt even on the open moor, for the moor at least let a wind run clear and did not throw one gust back against another the way the oaks now did, roaring in their high branches and flinging down showers of last year's leaves and small broken twigs in the gusts between. He put his back to the nearest broad trunk he could find, a great old oak fallen half over and caught against its neighbours, and crouched in what lee it gave him, and got, after long blowing at the coal from his pot with his hands shaking from the cold and the wet, a small

fire of gathered twigs going in the shelter of the fallen wood, low and guttering and streaming sideways in every gust that found its way through to him.

He sat with his back to the trunk and the rainbow piece turned to the small unsteady light of his own fire, watching the colour run in it the way he had watched it run a thousand times before at the hearth of Tobar dhìreach, while the gale went on through the branches overhead with a sound that was, he thought, turning it over afterward as he turned over every part of that night for the rest of his life, less like any wind he had ever camped under and more like a great many voices speaking all at once and none of them quite loud enough, or quite close enough, to be made out.

Whether that was the truth of the place or only the tiredness of three days' walking working on a mind that had waited twenty years to come this far, he did not yet know. He meant to sit up and listen, all the same, for as long as the fire held and his strength with it, and see what the grove, if it had anything to say, would say to a man who had come this far to ask it.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Of the Keeper in the Grove

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I

Of the Fire Under the Oaks

Three days he had walked, north and west, out of the high valleys where every hearth knew his face and his question both, and into a country that grew stranger the further he went from Tobar dhìreach: the heath thinning, the birch giving way first to hazel and then, on the last day, to oak, standing thick and old in a hollow where the wind funnelled down off the moor above it and never seemed to rest. He had gual bogha-froise¹ loose in his palm inside the fold of his cloak, as his mother had bidden him, though for most of his life he had carried it in a small bag at his belt, and his food was three days gone and his feet were three days blistered, and he came down into the grove at Doire ghlas in the last light with the gale already roaring in the crowns of the oaks over his head.

He had meant, that first evening, only to find shelter and go on looking in the morning, though he could not have said what he thought there was to find. A herder of the northern moor had told him once, in the way men tell a thing they do not quite believe themselves, that there was a grove far to the north-west where the wind talked if a man sat still enough to hear it, and Diarmad had carried that the way he carried every scrap anyone would give him, turned it over on the long road the way he turned the coal over in his hand, and come, in the end, because it was the last thing left that no one had yet laughed him out of trying.

1. the rainbow coal, of spirit

He had been asking since he was seven years old, and he was seven-and-twenty now, and in that whole span he had learned exactly one thing worth the learning: that a question asked often enough stops sounding like a question to the people who hear it and starts sounding like a habit, the way a limp stops sounding like pain to those who have watched a man walk with it for twenty years. The fire-bearers who carried the flame from Tobar dhireach out to the last farm before the moor only shrugged when he asked them, and said the fire was the fire, colour or none, and warmed a hand the same either way. Travellers who came up from the eastern farms with salt and hides to trade looked at him the way a man looks at a child who asks why the sky is up. The old women at his own hearth, who kept every other telling of the valley word for word back past memory, had patted his head when he was small and, later, when he was not small any longer and went on asking, stopped patting it and started laughing instead, not unkindly, the way a house laughs at the one habit of its own that it has stopped expecting to outgrow. Only his mother had never laughed. She had never had an answer for him either, but she had never once told him to stop asking, and it was the memory of her face, more than any hope of an answer, that had kept the question alive in him after every other mouth in the valley had worn it smooth with repeating.

The trunk of a fallen oak lay along the hollow's lowest ground, its roots torn up in some older storm into a wall of black earth and white wood taller than a man, and in its lee the wind dropped enough that a small fire might live if it was fed with care. He gathered what dry twigs the ground gave him, oak mostly, snapped short, and built them up the way his mother had taught him when he was small enough to sit at her knee and watch her hands do it before his own were old enough to be trusted with the work, a little tent of the driest first and the damper laid to catch after. No new fire was struck. He had carried an ember the whole way, in a clay pot packed with moss, the way the fire-bearers carried it to every hearth from the northern moor to the eastern farms, and he tipped it out now into the twigs and blew until they caught, and sat back on his heels with his hands out to the small heat of it while the gale went on tearing through the oaks above him as if the grove were a thing to be pulled apart.

He took gual bogha-froise out of its hide and held it up before the little flame, the way he had held it up before every fire he had ever sat beside since he was seven years old, turning it slowly so that the colours ran across it and would not settle into any one of them, gold sliding into red and red into a blue he had no better word for, and none of it staying long enough to be named. It burned black-

flamed like any other coal when it was thrown into a fire whole, the way the whole seven had burned black the first night the mason ever fed his own fire from the vein; every hearth in the high valleys knew that story, and every hearth had heard, sooner or later, that Diarmad of Tobar dhireach still asked why the colour went out of it. He thought of none of it now, sitting there warm at last after three cold days on the road, his mind gone as empty as a man's mind goes when the walking is done and the fire is caught; and it was in that thoughtless moment, with the coal turning in his fingers and the small fire streaming sideways in the wind that came down through the roots, that he looked up and found someone standing across the fire from him.

It was the height of a tall man, and it was made of grey smoke, such as a peat fire gives when it is banked low and burns slow through a wet night, and it stood in the middle of the gale and did not stir. Diarmad's own little fire streamed flat along the ground under the wind's hand, the flame laid nearly sideways, the smoke of it torn away as fast as it rose; and the figure across from him stood in that same wind as still as a standing stone, its grey unmoving, no fold of it lifting, no edge of it fraying into the air the way smoke frays into air everywhere else in the world. The oaks roared. The dead leaves went past between them in streams, low along the ground, and not one passed through where the figure stood; they went round it, the way water goes round a rock in a stream, and came together again on the far side.

He did not run. The tellers make much of that afterward, when the tale is given at the hearth in the dark of the year: that a man alone at night, far from any house he knew, with a shape out of nowhere standing in his own fire's light in a wind that should have scattered it to nothing, did not run. He had asked his question too long and been laughed at too often to let a wonder pass him by unquestioned, whatever it cost him to stay and ask it; or perhaps, and this is also told, he was too weary from the road to find the strength for fear. He sat where he was, with the coal still warm in his closed hand, and looked at it a long while before he found his voice, and when he found it, it did not shake as much as he had thought it would.

"What are you?" he said.

"I am Coimhdeach na Fine²," it said. Its voice was quiet and very clear, and the wind did not carry it away, though it carried away everything else in that grove

2. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

that had a voice to carry, the crack of the fire, the roar of the oaks, his own breath when he let it out. "The keeper of the kin. I watch over the people of this island for the one who made them."

"Are you a god?"

"No."

"A ghost, then."

"Neither. I was made out of the smoke of the first coal he woke. I have watched your line since the mason." It was still a moment, the grey of it neither settling nor stirring, and then it said, "You have a question. Ask it."

Diarmad held up the coal in his hand, so that what little light his fire still threw caught the edge of it and the colours moved across Coimhdeach na Fine's stillness the way they moved across everything else he had ever held it up to. "Why are there colours in it?" he said. His voice had steadied now, and there was something in it that had not been there when he asked the boatmen and the fire-bearers and the old women at every hearth from his own valley to the last farm before the moor, something that had learned, over twenty years of being laughed at, not to hope for an answer and to ask anyway. "What are they for?"

II

Of the Telling

Then Coimhdeach na Fine¹ told him.

It did not tell it the way a teller tells a tale at a hearth, with the shape of a beginning and an end laid out for the listener to walk between. It came to him instead the way a fire comes up in a room full of smoke, all at once and everywhere, so that afterward he could never say in what order he had learned it, only that by the time the grove went quiet around him again he knew it whole, the way a man knows his own name.

He saw sparks flying wide from a coal broken open in a god's hand, and the sparks did not fall. A cold came over him in that seeing, though his own small fire still burned at his knee, the cold of the dark before there was any world to be warm in, and he watched the sparks hang and catch and become, one by one, the very stars that hung now over the roaring oaks above his head, so that when he

1. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

looked up in the middle of the telling he found himself looking at the same fire twice, once remembered and once real. The weight of hills pressed up out of a black coal by two thumbs was in his own hands as he felt it, though his hands held nothing but gual bogha-froise², no bigger than an egg. A grey sea opened before him with no land in it anywhere, and a last coal held up over the water and let burn, and drops of fire falling from it one at a time into the grey, each drop hissing and hardening where it struck, until a rock stood in the sea, and then a hill, and then mountains he knew the shape of from every ridge he had ever walked, though he had never once thought before to ask how they had come to stand there.

He knew, without being told it in any order he could afterward have set down, that there was more folded into the coal in his own closed hand than the black weight of the ground alone: a colour for the sea and a colour for the air, a colour for the running water and a colour for the blood in a living thing, and last of all the one he held, that took every colour and kept none, holding whatever the other six were only once they were together. He did not see each in its turn the way a teller lays out a telling for a child, one thing and then the next; he felt them the way a man feels the separate aches of a body he has driven too hard on a long road, all at once, none of them waiting politely for the others to be named first. The names came to him afterward, in the days and years he had left to turn them over; that night in the grove he had only the feeling of a great deal folded very small, the way a whole winter's warmth is folded small into one banked coal under its blanket of ash.

He saw people come up out of the heather like grass after rain, blade after blade, too many to count and each its own, blinking in a light they had never yet opened their eyes to, the soil still on their bare feet. He had heard old women call the folk of the island the green grass of the island all his life and thought it only a manner of speaking, the kind of thing said at a hearth because it had always been said; now he saw it, or something that was not seeing and was not less than seeing, and understood for the first time that it had once been meant whole: that the people of Dia-thìr had grown up out of the island itself as grass grows, root and blade together, and that this was the oldest ground of the saying every hearth on the island knew without asking where it came from: *we did not come; we were here*.

And then, somewhere in the telling, though he could not have said where the joy of it turned, he felt something close and hot behind his own eyes that was not

the fire's heat, and knew it for shame before he understood what he was ashamed of. He was seeing a hillside torn open by a flood, long before the mason, long before any fire burned on the island at all, and a child of the old godfolk standing in the raw bank with her cloak filled with stones that shone where no stone should shine, gold and silver and white-flecked and red-brown and the black that took a polish like still water at night; and he watched, helpless in the seeing the way a man is helpless in a bad dream, while that whole valley turned the stones over in the sun and struck them together and broke a tooth on one and cut a shape into another and threw it down in disgust, and called them, in the end, the droppings of the mountain, fit for children to play with and no one else, and let the heather grow back over them until there was no one left alive on the island who remembered they had ever been found. It was his own blood in that valley, though bloodlines meant little enough in days before any line was counted; it was his people, whatever people meant so long before there were hearths to keep the count of a people at all, and they had held the whole of what he had spent his own life since he was seven years old asking after, held it in their two hands in the sun, and let it fall back into the ground unasked.

"Was he angry?" Diarmad said, when he could make himself say anything at all. His voice came out smaller than he meant it to, a boy's question more than a man's. "The one who made it. Was he angry, that they let it lie?"

The grey shape across the fire did not answer at once, and when it did there was something in the stillness of its voice that might, in a living face, have been the ghost of a smile. "He was not," it said. "He watched it from his father's hall, and he laughed, as a father laughs who sees his child set aside the finest gift of the feast to play with the wrapping instead. A gift that is not opened is still given. He could wait. The coal was in no hurry, and neither was he."

All that Coimhdeach na Fine told him that night Clann a' Chlachair³ kept after, word for word, and carried it in time to every hearth in the hill country that would listen, so that within a few lifetimes there was hardly a fire lit from the northern moor to the eastern farms where a child could not say some part of it back before he was old enough to understand what he was saying. It is not told twice here. What is told is only this: that it was long past the middle of the night before the telling was done, and that Diarmad sat afterward without speaking for longer than he had sat in silence in the whole of his walk north, while his fire

2. the rainbow coal, of spirit

3. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

burned down to a red eye in grey ash and the gale went on unwearied above him, and that when at last he did speak, it was the one question that had followed him three days north and would follow him three days home again.

III

Of the Riddle

"**h**e hid it," Diarmad said at last. "Why would he hide a gift?"
 "So that it would be found," said Coimhdeach na Fine¹. "He said to me once: a gift that is not opened is still given."

"Then how is it opened? The mason burned the coals and they burned like any coal. We have burned them since, at every hearth in the valleys, and the colours go out of them every time, and nothing is left but heat like any other fire's heat." He held up *gual bogha-froise*² again, though there was little enough light left in his own fire to show its colours by now, only the last red glow under the ash. "How is it opened?"

"Because you burn them all in the one fire," said Coimhdeach na Fine, "and none of them in its own."

Diarmad waited, but nothing followed that could be called an answer to it, not at once; Coimhdeach na Fine only stood as it had stood the whole of that long night, grey and upright and unmoved by the wind that moved everything else in that grove, and after a moment it spoke again, and this time it spoke slowly, the way a man speaks a thing he means another man to carry away whole and unbroken, first in words Diarmad did not know and then again in the tongue of his own hearth, so that he might keep both:

Tha spiorad fa leth san speur, san talamh agus sa mhuir. Meascaich na spioradan agus bidh iad uile-chumbachdach. The sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit. Merge the spirits, and they become almighty.

He said the words over once in his own mouth, haltingly, the strange ones first and then the plain ones, to be sure he had them, and Coimhdeach na Fine did not correct him, which he took, rightly or not, for a sign that he had them right. Then

1. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

2. the rainbow coal, of spirit

he sat with them a while longer, turning them the way he had turned the coal all his life, looking for the seam in them that would open, and found none.

"That is no answer," he said.

"It is the one I was given to give," said Coimhdeach na Fine.

And the wind, which had gone round it all that long night without once so much as stirring the grey of it, went through the place where it stood as though there had never been anything there to go round, and there was nothing there.

Diarmad sat alone by the last red eye of his fire with the two coals of the night in his two hands, the rainbow one that would not light and the three words that would not open, and above him the oaks went on roaring at a wind that had, for the whole of that long telling, seemed to be listening as hard as he was, and now seemed only a wind again.

IV

Of the Two Days Alone

he did not leave the grove in the morning. When the grey light came up cold and wet through the black branches and found him still sitting where Coimhdeach na Fine¹ had left him, he told himself he would go on looking in the morning; and when the morning had come and gone he told himself the same of the next, because he could not make himself walk away from the one place on the whole island where the answer had stood across a fire from him and spoken, even though it had told him plainly that it had no more to give.

He tried Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich² against everything the grove offered him, the way a man tries a key in every lock he can find rather than admit the one door it was cut for is shut to him. Up through a gap in the oaks where the gale had torn the crown from one of them he held gual bogha-froise³ to the sky, turning it so that whatever light came down through the grey cloud might find it, the way a man holds a thing up to catch the sun; nothing in it changed. Into the black wet earth at the fallen trunk's root he knelt and pressed it, deep as his hand would go, and left it there through the better part of a day, and dug it out again in the failing light no different than he had buried it, cold, dark, and itself. Into his little

1. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

2. the Keeper's riddle

3. the rainbow coal, of spirit

fire it went, alone this time, none of the other six with it, and it caught black-flamed and low as any other coal, the colours going out of it exactly as they went out at every hearth; he raked it out again with a stick before the flame had eaten more than its edge, and it lay scorched and dark on the leaves, and the colours came back into it only slowly as it cooled. Sky, and earth, and fire; he had none of the sea to try, so far from any shore, and no way, alone in an empty grove with one small coal in his hand, to know what it would mean to try the three at once even if he had had them all.

On the second morning he tried it once more, a way that had not occurred to him the first day: he set the coal down bare on the black wet bark of the fallen trunk and knelt over it and spoke the words aloud into it, both the strange ones and the plain ones, close enough that his breath stirred the ash of his dying fire beside it, as though a thing that had answered to sea-water and open sky and buried earth in the telling he had heard might answer also to a voice alone, if the voice said the right words over it in the right place. The coal lay where he had set it and did not so much as warm. A wren came down out of the fallen trunk's roots while he knelt there, hopped along the bark to within a hand's breadth of the coal, looked at it and at him with its head cocked first one way and then the other, and went off again about its own business in the undergrowth, entirely unconcerned with a god's hidden fire or a man's twenty years of asking after it; and something in the plainness of the bird, going about a wren's morning in a grove where he had spent a night talking with the smoke of the first coal ever woken, struck Diarmad harder than any of his failed trials had, and he sat back on his heels and did not try again that day.

By the second evening he understood, in the flat tired way a man understands a thing his heart has known since the wind first went through the place where Coimhdeach na Fine had stood, that nothing he did alone in that grove was going to open Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich for him. The story was his now, whole and unbroken, more of it than any living soul on the island had ever been given in one night, and the three lines of Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich had been turned over so many times in two days that he could no longer tell whether he was still hearing Coimhdeach na Fine's voice in them or only his own. An answer was not among what he had, and Coimhdeach na Fine had told him, as plainly as it had told him anything, that it had none left to give him.

So he banked what was left of his little fire under turf, the way a man banks a fire he means to leave and come back to, though he did not think, walking away

from it, that he would ever stand in that hollow again. Then he took up his coal, wrapped it back into its fold of hide against his chest where it had ridden the whole way north, turned south with the wind now at his back instead of in his face, and began the three days home.

The words came out of him the whole of that first day, aloud where the road let him and under his breath where it did not, the strange ones and then the plain ones, over and over, the way a man says a name again and again on a road so as not to lose it before he reaches the house he means to carry it into: *tha spiorad fa leth san speur, san talamh agus sa mhuir; meascaich na spioradan agus bidh iad uile-chumbachdach*; the sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit; merge the spirits, and they become almighty. By the second day the words had worn a way into him the way a path wears itself into a hillside, so that he no longer had to reach for them; they were simply there, turning under his walking the way the coal turned under his fingers, and he found himself, without quite meaning to, already shaping in his mind how he would say them at his own hearth, and to whom, and what face his mother would make when he told her he had not found an answer after all, only a longer question than the one he had carried north.

The weather turned kinder on the way south than it had been on the way north, as though the grove had kept the worst of the gale for itself and let him go with only ordinary wind and ordinary rain, and he was glad of it in a way he could not quite have explained, glad of the plainness of it, the mud that was only mud and the wet that was only wet, after a night in which nothing had been only itself. He slept the first night on the road under a fold of rock, as he had slept coming up, but he did not sleep well; he woke twice with the sense of a grey shape standing just outside the reach of the small fire he had built, and both times there was nothing there but hazel scrub and the ordinary dark, and both times he lay a long while afterward with the coal held tight in his closed fist before he could make himself sleep again. He thought, walking the second day through country he had barely marked on the way up, so intent had he been then on reaching the grove, how strange it was that a man could carry the whole shape of the world's making folded into him and still feel his feet ache and his belly want feeding exactly as they had before he carried it, as though the story and the body it lived in had agreed to go on about their separate business without troubling each other overmuch.

More than once on that second day his mind went back to the six coals he had not brought north at all, the rainbow alone having gone with him: the black one

and the fire-red one and the white-flecked and the silver and the red-brown, all of them kept at the hearth in the leather bag the children still played with when they were small enough not to know better, and it came to him, somewhere on that road, that whatever 'Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich meant, it was not a thing one man could finish alone with one coal in an empty grove, however many days he gave to trying. It would want the whole bag, and the whole line, and more roads walked than the one under his own two feet; and though the thought should perhaps have weighed on him as one more failure laid on top of the first, it did not weigh that way. It sat in him instead the way the fire itself had sat in the mason's well before anyone thought to carry it home, a thing not yet begun rather than a thing already finished and found wanting, and for the first time since the wind had gone through the place where Coimhdeach na Fine stood he found himself walking a little faster on the road south.

He came down at last into the high valleys on the evening of the third day, footsore and hollow with hunger, with hazel giving way to birch and birch to the bare heath he had grown up on, and somewhere on that last stretch of road, with the smoke of known hearths rising thin and grey against a sky he had walked three days under without once seeing it clear, he stopped saying the words aloud and let them go quiet in him, the way a coal goes quiet under ash and is not gone. He had gone north with one question and come home with a story no one else on the island had ever heard and a riddle he could not open, and he did not yet know, walking down into the valley in the last light with Tobar dhìreach's own smoke rising ahead of him among all the rest, which of the two the hearths would find harder to believe.

CHAPTER NINE

OF the COUNTING OF the FATHERS

VE 890 – 950

I

Of the Telling at the Hearth

he came down into Tobar dhìreach on the evening of the third day with mud to the knee and his feet gone past aching into a kind of numbness he no longer noticed, and the household that had watched him walk north with a stone in his shoe of a question came out to watch him walk south with something in his face none of them had a name for. His mother reached him first, and old as her eyes had gone she saw before she asked that he had not found what he went for, and something else besides, and she put both hands to his face the way she had done when he was small and fevered, to feel whether the heat in him was sickness or only walking.

"What did you find," Fionnghuala said, the words shaped less to draw an answer out of him than to steady the hand that held his face.

"I found what there was to find," Diarmad said, and said no more of it that night, even to her. He sat by the fire eating what was put in front of him without tasting it, gual bogha-froise¹ still wrapped against his chest under his cloak where it had ridden the whole way, until the household had gone one by one to their own sleep and only his mother sat up with him in the low light, waiting the way she had always waited, without pressing.

It was two nights more before he told it, and when he told it he told it standing, the way a man stands to say a thing he means the house to keep. He had

thought, on the road home, that he would tell it the way it had been told to him, but he found before he was three sentences in that no mouth could carry the whole of what had come into him that night in the grove, the sparks that did not fall and the sea with no land in it and the grass-people blinking up out of the heather, not in an evening, not in a hundred evenings; so he told instead the bones of it, the making of the island out of drops of fire let fall from a broken coal held over grey water, the forgotten gift buried in the ground and dug up and thrown away by a valley of grass-people who did not know what they held, and the smoke shape that had stood across a small fire from him in a grove three days north and told him all of it in a single long night without once sitting down. He told them *Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich*² last, because it was the only part of it he had by heart word for word, having said it over to himself the whole road south until the strange tongue and the plain tongue had worn a single path through him: the sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit; merge the spirits, and they become almighty.

There was a silence after it of the kind a house keeps after a death, and then someone at the back, one of the young men of *Tadhg's* line by marriage who had never once in his life let a chance for laughter go by unused, said that *Diarmad* had walked three days into an empty grove and talked to the wind, and the wind, being an accommodating sort of listener, had told him whatever he most wanted to hear; and the laughter that followed was not unkind, exactly, it was the same laughter the valley had always kept ready for *Diarmad's* question, worn smooth from years of use, the laughter of people glad to have their world handed back to them the shape it had always been. *Diarmad* did not argue it. He had expected the laughter, had walked three days home turning over how he would meet it, and he only said that he had told them what he had been given to tell, and that they might keep it or let it go as they pleased, and sat down again by the fire, and let the talk move on to other things the way talk always does when it has worn out the one thing it came for.

It was his wife who would not let it go, though not, at first, in his favour. *Niamh* had married him four years before, a strong-handed woman of a hearth two valleys east who had heard of *Diarmad's* question long before she ever met the man who carried it, and had thought, in the way of a young woman weighing a match, that a man known the length of the high valleys for a single stubborn

1. the rainbow coal, of spirit

2. the Keeper's riddle

foolishness might at least be a man of some substance under the foolishness, which had proved true enough in the small ways a marriage tests it, in patience and in temper and in the work of two hands against a hard year. But she had not married a man who talked with the smoke of the dead, and when he told her, alone, what he had not told the whole hearth, the telling in full this time, sparks and grass-people and the shame he had felt for a valley of grass-people he had never met, she heard him out to the end and then said, plainly, that three days alone on an empty moor with too little food and too much cold in his blood could put a great many things into a man's head that had no business being in it, and that she loved him, and that she did not believe a word of it.

He did not press her either. He had learned, in twenty years of asking one question to a valley that had no answer for it, that pressing only wore a thing smoother without changing its shape underneath, and he let her keep her unbelief the way he let the young men of Tadhg's line keep their laughter, and went on saying Aithris a' Chruthachaidh³ at the hearth, a little more of it each time as he found the words for pieces of it he had not had words for the first night, until there were nights when even Niamh sat and listened without leaving the fire, arms folded, her face giving nothing away, and other nights when she did not.

II

Of the Fathers' Names

What changed the house was a second thing Diarmad set himself to beside Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹, in the second year after his return, a thing that asked for no belief at all, only memory. He began going hearth to hearth among the kin, the near kin and every household further out besides, from the high valleys to the northern moor, any that could claim so much as a grandmother married into the line, and at each one he asked the same plain question he had once asked about the coal, save that this one had an answer if only enough mouths could be found to hold it between them: who was your father, and who was his, and how far back could the house say the names before the names ran out into "an old man" and "before my grandmother's time" and silence.

3. the Telling of the Making

1. the Telling of the Making

It was slow work and unglamorous, nothing like a night in a gale with a god's smoke across the fire from him, and for that very reason it won him a hearing Aithris a' Chruthachaidh itself had not. A man who talks to spirits in a grove is easy enough to laugh at over a fire in company; a man who sits at your own hearth of an evening and asks patiently after your grandfather's grandfather, and writes nothing down because there is no writing to be had, only carries the names away whole in his own head the way a fire-bearer carries an ember in a pot of moss, is doing a kind of work every house in the valleys understood and most of them, once they thought about it, wanted done. Old women who had never once troubled themselves over Diarmad's question about the coal turned out to have kept, unasked, four and five names of fathers back, the way a house keeps a worn tool it has stopped using but cannot bring itself to throw out, and were glad enough of someone willing to take the names off their hands and carry the weight of remembering them onward.

He worked at it three years, off and on, between the ordinary work of a household that still had to be fed and warmed whatever a man's head was full of, and at the end of it he could stand at his own hearth and say, without a pause anywhere in it, the whole of the line back to Neachdan who broke the vein and Conall who carried it burning to the first hearth beyond his own, father and father and father, thirty-six names in all, and the few deeds that were remembered with them, Conall's watch over the burning vein and Leac na Fèithe² laid over it in the days of his sons' sons, on down to his own father's father's name and his own; and where a house's memory ran out before it reached him, he said so plainly, rather than filling the gap with a name invented to make the line look longer than it was, which his mother told him, when he asked her once whether he should, was the one thing that would make the whole of it worth nothing at all.

He fixed the saying of it, in the end, as a thing said once a year, standing, on the darkest night, rather than told loosely by the fire on whatever evening someone thought to ask for it, the night every household in the high valleys already kept in its own smaller way as the night Teine a' Chlachair³ first came into the world; and it was on that night, in the year that made five years since his walk to the grove, that he stood at his own hearth with the whole household gathered and every kin-house that could reach them in one evening's walk besides, and said the fathers' names from Neachdan to himself without a stumble, and after him,

2. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhireach

3. the mason's fire, the first fire

because he asked it of her before he began and she had not said no, Niamh stood and said Aithris a' Chruthachaidh after him. She had not come to believe it; she said afterward only that a house ought to hear the whole of what its head carried, belief or none, and that a wife who would not say a hard thing for her husband when he asked it of her once in a marriage was no wife worth the name. The recital had no name that night beyond "the fathers' names" or "the Line," said plainly, and the name it bears, Sloinneadh a' Chlachair⁴, came to it only slowly, as names come; but the shape of it was set that night and never afterward broken: the fathers named standing, on Oidhche an Dealanaich⁵, in the order they had lived, with no name added that a house could not answer for.

III

Of the Trials That Failed

Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich did not sit idle in him all those years, though it did no better for the waiting. He had come home from the grove with six coals still dark in the leather bag at his hearth, the black and the fire-red and the snowflake white and the silver and the red-brown, none of them tried even once against their own element the way the rainbow had been tried against sky and earth and buried ground alone in the grove, and it seemed to him, turning the words over through those same years he spent gathering names, that a riddle which spoke of three spirits and their merging could hardly be answered by one man trying one coal alone, and that the line owed it more than his own two hands could give while those two hands were also busy carrying names from hearth to hearth.

So when the kin gathered for the standing of the Line, in the years after that first telling of it, they tried the coals as well, together, the whole bag of seven emptied out onto the flat stone before the fire while half the valley watched. They put four of the dark ones into a driving rain one autumn, laid out bare on the hillside through a night of it, on the thought that rain was as much the sky's water as the sea's, and found them in the morning only wet and cold and themselves, no different for the soaking than any stone left out in weather. They carried the bag up

4. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

5. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

onto the ridge above Tobar dhìreach on a night the wind came hard and steady off the moor, thinking that if earth and sea each had a spirit to answer to, the sky's own spirit might answer to nothing gentler than its own true weather, and held the coals up bare-handed into the gale until their arms ached with the cold of it, and the wind went through their fingers and around the coals and past them into the dark, indifferent as wind always is to what it passes over. All seven went into the one fire together another year, on the reasoning that if merging was the word of Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹, perhaps it meant only that the coals themselves must be merged, thrown into one flame rather than kept apart in the bag or tried alone one at a time; they burned down black and ordinary together exactly as each had burned alone at every hearth since the mason first fed his own fire from the vein, no brighter for the company. And because word of Oisean's boat and Scàire's skerries and the salt taste of the wider sea had reached even so far inland as Tobar dhìreach by then, Diarmad sent to the south shore for a skin of true sea-water, carried the long way home on a man's back and poured over the coals in a stone basin at the hearth itself, the nearest any of them could come, that far from any coast, to trying the sea without walking to it; and the sea-water did to the coals exactly what the rain had done, wetted them and left them cold, and was tipped out afterward onto the ground the way any spent water is tipped, and soaked away into the same earth that had already refused the black coal its own trial twice over.

None of it worked, and none of it surprised him, by the third or fourth failure, though he did not stop trying for that. He came, in those years, to a kind of patience with Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich that was not quite belief that the answer was near and not quite despair that it would never come, a patience his mother, before she died in the second year after the first standing of the Line, told him was the only sensible way to hold a question too large for one lifetime to finish: to carry it the way a man carries a full pot on a long road, minding it without staring at it every step, and letting it crush none of the ordinary days under it. Fionnghuala died in her own bed with Poit an Teine² within reach of her hand, as she had asked, and was buried the way the valley buried its own, and Diarmad took up the keeping of the pot himself, that year, alongside the keeping of the names and the keeping of Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich, three weights on the

1. the Keeper's riddle

2. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

one back, and carried all three without once, in any hearth's telling of him afterward, being heard to complain of the load.

IV

Of the Telling's Going Out

Aithris a' Chruthachaidh itself, meanwhile, had begun to do what no argument of Diarmad's could do for it: it travelled. A fire-bearer who had heard it three times at Tobar dhìreach on his rounds carried it, unasked, to a hearth on the northern moor where he stopped each winter to trade, and told it there in his own halting way, missing pieces and mixing others, so that the version that reached the moor had the sparks becoming stars but lost the grass-people entirely and gained, from somewhere in the fire-bearer's own head, a line about the god's laughter that Diarmad, hearing it come back to him years later from a traveller who had it from the moor in turn, did not recognise as his own telling at all until the laughter itself gave it away. He did not correct it. He had learned by then that a telling, once it left his own mouth, belonged as much to the mouth that carried it onward as to the one that first shaped it, the way a coal passed hand to hand at a fire-begging keeps the shape of the pot that last held it more than the shape of the hearth it came from, and that a thing told at every hearth from the high valleys to the northern moor could not, and perhaps should not, come back sounding exactly as it went out.

It went east as well, slower, because the eastern farms traded less with Tobar dhìreach than the moor did and had their own tellings already, of deer and dogs and the salmon runs, that made room grudgingly for a new one. But it went, carried by traders who came up for salt and hides and went home with more than they had bargained for, and by the thirtieth year after Diarmad's walk to the grove there was hardly an eastern hearth that had not heard some shape of it, sparks or grass-people or 'Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich' itself said wrong in a dozen small ways and right in the one way that mattered, that the coal held a gift no one had yet found how to open. Diarmad heard, once, from a trader newly down from the east, a version of his own riddle so garbled that the sea and the sky had traded places in it and the earth had dropped out entirely, replaced by a line about fire

1. the Keeper's riddle

answering to fire that made no sense at all set against what he himself had heard in the grove; and he sat a long while after the trader left, turning that over, not troubled by the wrongness of it so much as struck by how far a true thing could travel and still be carried, however badly, by people who had never doubted for a moment that it was worth the carrying.

He grew old carrying all of it, the names and the pot and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich and the slow spread of Aithris a' Chruthachaidh² east and west of him, and the household watched him go from the man who had walked north at seven-and-twenty with one question and come home with a longer one, to a man they no longer laughed at even the young men of Tadhg's line, though few enough of them, in the end, said outright that they believed him. Niamh believed him at last in the tenth year after his return, though she never told him so directly; she told their daughter instead, one evening when she thought Diarmad out of hearing, that a woman could live a long while beside a strange thing without believing it and then find, on some ordinary evening with no sign to mark it, that she had come to believe it without ever once deciding to, the way a path comes to lie worn into a hillside without any single footstep being the one that made it a path; and Diarmad, who had in fact been within hearing the whole time, said nothing of it to her that night or ever after, and kept what he had overheard the way he kept the coals, quietly, and did not try to open it further.

V

Of Diarmad's Death and the Daughter Who Kept It

he died in his seventieth year, an old man by the reckoning of the high valleys though no age at all beside Coimhdeach na Fine¹'s long night, sitting up in his own bed with Poit an Teine² near enough to touch and the leather bag of six dark coals and one that would not stay any colour long enough to be named laid on the floor beside him, and the last thing the household heard him say, to Niamh, who sat with him through that last night as she had sat up with him through so many nights of trying and failing before it, was that he was sure now the answer was near, nearer than it had ever been in all the years of the

2. the Telling of the Making

1. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

2. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

trying, though he could not, when she asked him plainly what he meant by it, say what had brought the nearness home to him beyond a feeling he had no better word for than the feeling a man gets on a long road when the smoke of a known hearth first shows over a rise he has not yet crested. He was not able to say whether he meant *Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich*³ would be answered in his son's time or his son's son's, or only that a question carried long enough and honestly enough could not, by its own weight and the weight of everyone who had come to carry it alongside him, go forever unanswered; and Niamh, who had spent forty years learning not to press him for more than he had to give, did not press him for that either, and let him die with the nearness unexplained, the way she had once let the whole of *Aithris a' Chruthachaidh*⁴ itself sit unbelieved in her for ten years before it settled.

It fell, in the end, to his daughter to keep *Aithris a' Chruthachaidh* whole, where his sons had not. *Deirbhile* was thirty-seven when her father died, old enough by then to have heard *Aithris a' Chruthachaidh* said at the hearth every darkest night of her own remembered life and young enough still to have the whole of it by heart in a way her older brothers, busy with the herding and the ordinary work of the household, had never troubled to make theirs; and where her father had told it a little differently each time, finding new words for pieces that had never quite settled into words the first time, *Deirbhile* set herself, almost from the week of his burial, to saying it the same way every time, word for word, the sparks and the grass-people and *Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich* in the exact order and the exact phrases her father had used in the last years of his telling it, on the reasoning she gave her own children when they asked her why she was so strict about it: that a telling which changed with every mouth that carried it would, given enough mouths and enough years, end up saying nothing at all that the first mouth had meant, the way a coal passed round a whole valley of hearths comes home, if it comes home at all, cold and unrecognisable; and that if her father's question was ever to be answered by anyone, that someone would need the words as he had first been given them, not as forty years of retelling had worn them.

She taught it the same exacting way she kept it, sitting each of her own children down in turn once they were old enough to hold a long telling in their heads without losing the thread of it, and making them say it back to her a section at a time until they had it as clean as she did, and she taught it, besides her own chil-

3. the Keeper's riddle

4. the Telling of the Making

dren, to any of the wider kin who would sit still for the whole of it and promise to keep it as strictly as she asked; and by the sixtieth year after Diarmad's walk to the grove, there was no longer any single mouth in the high valleys that alone held Aithris a' Chruthachaidh, but a scattering of them, cousins and cousins of cousins, each one able to say it clean from the first spark to the last plain line of Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich, so that the thing Diarmad had carried home alone on his own two feet from an empty grove now walked the valleys on a dozen pairs of legs at once and could not, any longer, be lost by the death of any single one of them.

VI

Of the Telling at an Eastern Hearth

It was said, that year, at a hearth three days' walk east of Tobar dhìreach, by a woman who had never met Deirbhile and had it instead from her own mother, who had it from an aunt who had sat once, as a girl, at Deirbhile's own knee and taken the whole of it down clean; three mouths removed from the keeper who had fixed it, and further still from the mouth of Diarmad himself, and further again from the grey shape that had first given it, word for word, across a small fire in a grove no one at that eastern hearth had ever seen or would ever see. The woman said it standing, on the darkest night of that year, to a household that kept no fire-pot and no bag of coloured coals and no claim at all on Sloinneadh a' Chlachair¹ beyond the bare fact of being kin to kin to kin who had once married into it three generations back, and she said it the way Deirbhile had taught her mother to say it, the sparks that did not fall, the grass-people blinking up out of the heather, the sky and the earth and the sea each carrying their own spirit, and the words she gave last, because they were the words she herself had been given last and had never once heard explained: merge the spirits, and they become almighty.

A child at that hearth, hearing it for what he could not have known was the first time in his own short life though it would not be the last, asked the plain question every child who ever heard it seemed, sooner or later, bound to ask, the same question that had once sent a boy of seven at Tobar dhìreach out to badger

1. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

every fire-bearer and elder and traveller within a day's walk of his own hearth: what did it mean, to merge a spirit. The woman who had told it did not know, no more than her mother had known, no more than the aunt three mouths back had known, no more, in the honest end of it, than Diarmad himself had known on the last night of his life with the nearness of the answer sitting unexplained in him like a smoke he could smell but not yet see the fire of; and she told the child, as her own mother had told her when she asked the same thing at the same age, that it was a question for An Clachair's own line to answer, if any line on the whole island ever answered it, and that a household three days east of Tobar dhìreach had only to keep the words themselves whole and hand them on, the way a fire is handed on in a pot of moss from a hearth that lit it to a hearth that did not, asking of the coal only that it stay lit long enough to be carried, and trusting that whoever received it at the far end would know, better than the bearer ever could, what to do with the fire once it arrived.

2. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

CHAPTER TEN

Of the Mole and the Steps

VE 951 – 1,169

I

Of the Mole at Skell

On the first day of the warm month the old man walked the bank of the river at Skell¹ from first light, looking at nothing anyone else would have troubled to look at, and by mid-morning he had chosen his stone.

He had judged stones on that bank for longer than anyone at Skell could remember him not judging them, walking the shingle at every fall of the water with his hands loose at his sides, turning one boulder with his foot and letting the next lie, so that the younger men who worked at his word had long since stopped asking what marked the ones he chose from the ones he left. It was not size alone, for he passed by boulders bigger than the one he took that morning, and it was not shape alone, for the one he took was no rounder or flatter than a dozen others within reach of it; it lay, when he had finished with it, in the current's edge with its broadest face turned upstream and its weight sitting low and sure against the drag of the water, and that was the whole of what could be said of his judging by anyone who watched him do it and never learned to do it himself.

They rolled it down to the water's edge on green logs cut for the purpose, six men to a stone that size, with the old man walking beside it the whole way and saying nothing until it came to rest where he wanted it, at which point he would put out one hand, flat, and the log-bearers would know to stop, and the stone

1. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

would go into the current from there, walked the last length on its own logs until it dropped with a sound that carried up the bank and settled into the silt the river had already given it. Then the old man would stand in the shallows with the water at his shins, turning his head one way and then the other at the stone half-sunk before him, and either nod, once, and send for the next, or shake his head and set them to shifting the one already placed a hand's width this way or that, which was harder work by far than the placing of it, for a stone once let go by the current did not want to be moved again.

It went on so through the whole of that warm season and into the wet one after it, boulder after boulder rolled and set and sometimes shifted, walked out from the bank a little further with every stone that held, so that by the time the leaves turned there was a low ridge of rock standing above the water even at the flood, running out from the bank at a slant the old man had set on the first day and never once changed, though he changed everything else about the work as it went. Boats that had beached on open shingle, dragged up clear of the water by main strength at every landing and dragged down again at every setting-out, began instead to come in under the lee of the stone and lie there quiet while the current went past outside it, and by the second winter there were boats enough sheltering there of an evening, a dozen at a time on a bad night, that the households along that stretch of bank had stopped thinking of the beach below their houses as open water at all.

The wet season after the first stones were set brought a flood the like of which the old man said he had not seen at Skell in all his years on that bank, the river coming up brown and fast and carrying whole trees down from higher ground, and the boats that had not been hauled well clear of it went where the water took them, out into the main current and away downstream past where any of them could follow on foot before dark. One boat went that flood, a small one, with nothing worse lost than the boat itself and the fishing gear in it, for the man who owned it had had the sense to leave it rather than go after it into that water; but the mole itself, the low ridge of stone the old man had been building through two seasons, took the flood's whole weight against its upstream face and held, and when the water fell back within its banks the ridge stood there still, scoured cleaner than before and not a stone of it shifted from where he had set it.

After that flood the old man was not troubled for stones. Households that had watched the work from a distance, minding their own boats and their own beaches, came now and asked to have their landings brought under the same lee,

and he took them at their word and set them to the rolling and the placing exactly as he had taught the first of them, walking beside every stone still, right hand out flat when it had come far enough, until the ridge that had begun as one man's slow work along a hundred paces of bank had become, by the years his own grandsons were grown men rolling stones themselves, a long low wall of unmortared boulders reaching further out into the river than any one household could have built in a lifetime working alone.

He did not live to see it reach as far as it would go. What he did live to see, in the last summers when his legs no longer let him walk the bank at first light but only sit above it and watch others do the walking, was a whole season's boats come in of an evening one after another under the lee of the stone he had first set with his own hands, riding easy in water that would have driven every one of them onto open shingle in his own father's time, and it is told that he sat above the river on those evenings and counted the boats coming in the way another man might count anything else worth the counting, though what he made of the count, or whether he made anything of it at all beyond the pleasure of watching it grow, the telling does not carry, for it went with him below the rise where the households of that shore keep what is theirs alone.

There was a boy among the old man's grandsons who took to the water in those years the way some children take to it and others never do, and who is remembered, by whoever it was that first told this of him, for standing chest-deep at the mole's outer edge on the calmest days of high summer with his feet braced against the last stone set, letting the current push at him and push at him without once giving ground, as though the stone under his feet had lent him some part of its own stubbornness against the river. His grandfather, watching from the bank with the patience of a man who had spent a lifetime watching water move against stone, said nothing to him about it either way, neither calling him in nor praising him for staying out, and the boy grew to be one of those who rolled the furthest stones in the old man's last working years, walking beside them exactly as he had watched his grandfather walk, right hand ready to go up flat the moment a stone had come far enough.

The foot of the mole he set that first warm month lies under the water still at the lowest fall of the river, and every landing built out from that bank in all the years since has stood, in the end, on stone he chose and placed with his own hand and eye, though none now living could point to which stones were his and which were set by the hands that came after him, for a wall of unmortared boulders

holding back a river gives up that kind of memory the moment the current has run over it a single winter.

II

Of the Steps at Bral

On the far side of the island, where the land fell to the sea in a cliff of raw rock rather than a shore of shingle, a household that kept its beasts on the grazing above the water had for longer than anyone could reckon gone down to the shingle by whatever crack and ledge a man's feet could be trusted on, a scramble that wanted both hands free and was not to be tried at all after rain, when the rock ran wet and the safest holds turned treacherous under a boot.

It was a woman of that household, in a year no one troubled to fix, who first set her shoulder to a slab loosened already by frost and worked it, over the better part of a season, into a step at the foot of the worst of the scramble, wedging it level with smaller stones packed in beneath it until it took her whole weight without rocking. She had no thought, that first year, of doing more than the one step, for the one step alone saved the worst stretch of the climb, the stretch where a slip meant the shingle thirty feet below rather than a bruised hip on the rock; but a step once cut asks, in its own way, for the step above it, and by the time her own daughter was old enough to carry a bag of shellfish up from the shore unaided, there were a dozen slabs set one above another where before there had been only the crack and the ledge.

The work went on as such work goes on among people who keep no count of years, in the odd hour between the beasts and the shore, in the slack season when the grazing wanted less watching, a slab worked loose and dressed rough with a harder stone and set and packed and tried under a full load before the next was begun. Some years saw three steps cut, some years none at all, for the stone did not always give a slab where a slab was wanted, and a household with sickness in it or a hard winter behind it had neither the hands nor the heart to spare for cutting stone that would still be there, unset, the following year. No one who worked at it ever spoke, so far as the telling carries, of finishing the climb entire; each worked the stretch in front of them, the stretch that made the going hardest that season, and left the stretch above or below to whoever came to it next with strength and time enough.

By the time the third generation of that household was grown, the steps ran unbroken from the shingle at the cliff's foot to a shelf perhaps a third of the way up, wide enough there that two could pass without either turning sideways, and the scramble that had once wanted both hands free and a clear head began, above that shelf, all over again. A boy of that generation, sent down for shellfish on a morning when the tide was right and the household short-handed, is remembered to have run the whole finished stretch without once setting a hand to the rock, down and up again both, laughing at the top of it in a way that made the older women watching from above laugh with him, for none of them, not the woman who had cut the first slab nor any who came after her, had ever gone down that stretch without at least one hand out for balance until that morning.

The steps above the shelf took longer than the steps below it, for the rock there ran harder and gave up fewer slabs willing to be freed by frost or fire-cracking, and more than one worker of that household spent a whole season on a single stretch of a dozen feet that yielded, in the end, three steps and no more. It is told that when the full climb was at last finished, two hundred and twelve steps from the shingle to the grazing above, cut by hands that had never once all worked together in the same season, the household that had begun it was three generations removed from the woman who set the first slab, and not one of the three generations between had known her, though every one of them had grown up going down to the shore and up again by steps she had begun and none of them had finished.

The treads of the lower steps, the ones cut soonest and used longest, wore hollow in their middles long before the upper steps had worn at all, a shallow dish worn by bare feet and sandalled feet alike, by the young going down light and the old coming up slow with a full bag, by beasts driven down once in a while to graze the weed left uncovered at a low spring tide and driven up again bawling at every unfamiliar step under their hooves. No one now living could say how many feet, over how many years, it had taken to wear stone that hard into a hollow a thumb's width deep, and none of that shore, so far as the telling carries, ever tried to reckon it; the steps were there, and were climbed, and wore as anything wears that is used every day by every hand and hoof a household has, and that was the whole of what needed saying about them.

An old woman of that household, late in the years the steps took to finish, is remembered to have sat some evenings on the shelf a third of the way up, where two could pass without turning, and to have run her hand along the edge of the

topmost step then cut, the one nearest the unfinished stretch above it, the way another woman might run a hand along the rim of a pot she had shaped herself. She had not cut that step, nor any near it, her own working years being long behind her by the time the climb reached that height, but she had carried stone up to whoever did cut it, in her turn, as her own mother had carried stone before her, and she is remembered to have said, of the unfinished rock above, only that it would come when it came, in the tone of a woman who had learned, over a long life on that cliff, not to trouble herself over work that was not hers to finish.

III

Of the Recital Kept Idle

At the hearth of Clann a' Chlachair¹ the fire that had once broken living out of the rock burned now, as it had burned since before any of the fathers now spoken could remember otherwise, in a pit dug and stone-ringed and fed with heather and split wood the way any hearth on the high valleys was fed, no different to look at than the hearth of any household a day's walk off, save for the clay pot set always at its western edge and the leather bag kept always within reach of whoever tended it.

The recital that Diarmad had fixed, standing on Oidhche an Dealanaich² with the fathers' names running back through him to Neachdan who had broken the vein, was said now by hands that had never known Diarmad living, taught mouth to mouth from a woman of his line to a granddaughter of hers, and from that granddaughter on again, each keeper holding the words as she had been given them and giving them on unaltered, for a word changed in the telling, however small, was held to be a word lost, and no keeper of that hearth wished to be remembered as the one under whose watch a word was lost. It was said standing, every year, on the dark-of-the-year night, to whatever household had gathered for it that season, and it was said also, more quietly, to a child of the line old enough to hold still through the whole of it, the first of many such tellings before that child grew old enough to say it back whole and unbroken.

Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich³ that had come with Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁴, the sky and the earth and the sea and the three spirits that must somehow be

1. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

brought together, was said too, every year, in its place after the recital of the fathers, but it was said now the way a thing is said that has been tried and has failed and is not, for the present, being tried again. In Diarmad's own day, and after him in his daughter's, the coals had been carried to a rain that would not stop falling, sunk in sea-water fetched home in skins from a shore three days off, set together seven at once in the hottest fire the line's hands could build, and had come out of every trial the same dull stones they had gone in, no brighter and no darker, giving up nothing of what Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich asked of them. After the third such failure, or the fourth, the telling does not keep the count exact, the trying was let rest, the way any hard work is let rest when the hands that might do it have other work in front of them that wants doing first, a hearth to keep fed and children to raise and beasts to see through a winter; and by the years the mole was rising at Skell⁵ and the steps were being cut at Bral⁶, the leather bag of coloured coal hung at the hearth of Clann a' Chlachair much as it had hung for two generations already, opened sometimes for a child to turn the pieces over in wonder at their colours and closed again after, tried against nothing.

It was not that the line had given up Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich, for no keeper of that hearth, asked outright, would have said so; it was only that Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich had become, in those years, a thing that was kept rather than a thing that was worked at, said each year in its proper place the way the fathers' names were said in theirs, waiting on whichever of the line's children might yet take it up again with a strength or a notion the ones before had lacked. More than one traveller passing through the high valleys in those years heard the recital said at that hearth and asked, afterward, whether anyone had tried this or that against the coals, some new way that had occurred to the traveller on the spot, a fresh idea offered in good faith by someone with no stake in the failures already behind it; and the keeper of the hearth, whoever she was in that year, would hear the traveller out and thank him for it and set the bag away again unopened, for a household that has tried the sea and the rain and the fire together and failed at all three has little patience left, most years, for a stranger's fresh idea got in an afternoon.

4. the Telling of the Making

2. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

3. the Keeper's riddle

5. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

6. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

So the recital was kept whole, word for word, said standing every dark-of-the-year night whether the household that heard it that year troubled to ask for it or not, for by then the saying of it had become, in its own right, a thing the line did because it had always been done, in much the way a mole of stone is added to because a mole of stone has always been added to, and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich rode along inside it unanswered, carried forward from keeper to keeper the way the recital's own words were carried, waiting on a hand that had not yet been born.

In the year the crossing to Bral's higher shelf was first made without a hand out for balance, though the hearth of Clann a' Chlachair knew nothing of that crossing and never would, the recital was said, as it was said every year, to a gathering that had come that season without being sent for, walking up from the lower valleys of their own will on the strength of a saying passed hearth to hearth that the night was near; and the keeper of that year, a granddaughter's granddaughter of the woman who had first fixed the words in her own memory, stood and said the fathers' names from Neachdan down to her own father without once being asked to begin, for by then no asking was wanted, the gathering's own silence being asking enough. She said Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich after, as she said it every year, and closed the bag again after, as it was closed every year, and if she felt any want in herself to be the one who opened it in earnest rather than merely kept it, the telling that survives her does not carry so much as a hint of it.

IV

Of the Dead of Vell

On the low headland in the island's south-east, where the shore ran flat enough for a boat to be launched at any state of the tide, a household kept its own dead the way it kept everything else it valued: apart, and facing the water.

When one of that household died, whether old at the work or young to a fever that came up sudden from the marsh air, the body was washed and wrapped in the household's own way, which the telling does not follow past the wrapping, and carried down to the shore on a litter of poles, and set into the broadest of the hide boats with two rowers to take it out. The crossing to the low island off that coast took less than an hour's pull in calm water, and it was never made light of

even so; the rowers went out at first light, before the day's other work began, and came back before the sun was high, and no household of that shore, so far as anyone now can say, ever sent its dead across in bad weather, waiting instead however many days the sea gave them no choice but to wait, the body kept meanwhile in a place apart from the household's own hearth-fire.

On the island the graves were boxes of set stone, four slabs and a lid, raised a little above the ground and packed round with rubble so that the whole would stand against weather and time both, each one built by the household of whoever it was to hold before that person died, if there was time for it, or built in haste after if there was not, by whichever hands could be spared from the rowing. Every box, without exception, so far as the telling carries, was set to face the same way: not toward the open sea beyond the island, where a dead man's household might have thought to send him on to wherever the drowned or the departed were held to go, but back across the strait toward the mainland shore, toward the low headland and the shore and, beyond it, whatever fires still burned in the households that had rowed the boxes' occupants out.

Why the dead of that shore were made to look back rather than out, no teller of that coast, in all the years the telling ran, is remembered to have said, and none of the mainland's own tellers, who came no nearer that shore than any hill-folk came to any of Seann-Dhaoine¹ places, ever learned enough of the matter to guess at it either. It was simply the way it was done: a box was built, and a box was set, and the lid that closed it faced always toward the mainland and never toward the open water, whatever the last months of the person inside it had been spent looking at while they lived.

The rowing itself fell, in most households of that shore, to whichever two were fittest for it in a given season, and it was not held to be grim work, or at least not spoken of as grim work by anyone the telling remembers, though a woman who had rowed her own mother out one autumn and her own daughter out the spring after is said to have gone to the boat, after that second crossing, with a face that told those who watched her go that this was not, for her, a labour like any other, whatever it might have been for a rower sent out with someone else's dead. She rowed it all the same, for the household wanted two hands at the oars and hers were among the fittest still, and came back before noon as every crossing came back before noon, and took up the day's other work as though the morn-

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

ing's had been no different from any other morning's, which the telling holds to have been, for her, the greater part of what there was to admire in her.

The stone for each box came from the island where the ground gave it up, or was carried across in the same boats that carried the dead when the island's own rock ran short, a labour spread across whatever days the household could spare from its other work, so that a box begun the week of a death was not always finished the week after, and more than one family of that shore is remembered to have gone back and forth across the strait a dozen times over a season, ferrying slabs one or two at a time, before the four walls and the lid stood true over the one they were meant to close in. The lid itself was always the last stone set, and always the heaviest, wanting every hand the crossing boat could carry along with it, and it is told that no household of that shore ever let a grave stand open through a night, whatever the state of the work, choosing rather to lay a covering of brush and stone across an unfinished box until the true lid could be brought than to leave the dead exposed to weather even for the span of a single dark.

The island filled slowly, box by box, over more lifetimes than any one household on that shore could reckon by its own memory alone, each new box set a little further along the low ground than the one before it, following the same face-the-mainland rule without deviation, so that a person walking the length of the island, had any hill-folk ever gone there to walk it, which none ever did, would have found row on row of stone boxes all looking the same way, at the same low headland, out of which every one of their occupants had once been rowed. The households of that shore, so far as anyone now can say, kept some rough sense among themselves of how many boxes stood there, though the telling that survives them does not say by what means they kept it, whether by a mark cut somewhere or simply by the kind of memory a small close-knit shore keeps of its own dead without needing to write any of it down; and it is told, of the year the crossing that closed out these years came, that the box set that season was counted, by whatever reckoning the household used, the fortieth to stand on that low ground, its lid laid and its face turned, like every lid before it, back toward the water it had been rowed across and the shore its household had never once let it out of sight of.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Of the Road on the Marsh and the Signs on the Cliff

VE 1,170 – 1,330

I

Of the Gate in the Rock

At Toll¹, where a shelf of grey rock ran down into the Abhainn uaine and broke the river's push into two channels before it could reach the sea, a household kept a gate cut into the rock's own body rather than standing open on it, a channel worked into the stone with a wattle gate set only into the channel's narrowest place.

The cutting had been begun long before any of them now living could remember its beginning, a groove picked out stroke by stroke with a harder stone against the softer, following a crack that already ran most of the way where the channel was wanted, so that the work was less a making from nothing than a widening of what the rock half offered on its own. It ran from the still water above the shelf down to a pool below it that filled and drained with the river's own rise and fall, a channel a man's stride across and knee-deep at its shallowest, worn smooth along its floor by the water that had gone through it every year since before the cutting was finished, so that no one could any longer say which of the smoothness was the river's work and which the first workers' own.

At the channel's narrowest place, where the rock pinched in on either side close enough that a man could touch both walls with his arms half spread, a slot

had been cut into the stone on each side, deep and true, running from above the water's highest mark down below its lowest. Into the slots, when the river ran low and the pool below wanted emptying, a woven gate of wattle was let down and driven home with a mallet of oak until its foot sat hard against the channel's floor and no fish of any size could pass either way through the gap it closed.

The dropping of the gate was a household's whole work for the better part of a day, from the first light in which the water could be judged low enough to try, through the fetching of the gate from where it hung, dried and mended, under the eaves of the shelter above the shelf, to the driving of it home stroke by stroke with the mallet, one man in the channel to guide its foot true and two above with their weight on the mallet's haft, until the gate stood square in the slots and the water above it began, almost at once, to climb a hand's width against its face where before it had run through unchecked.

Behind the gate, in the pool the channel fed, the fish that had come up with the last high water and not gone back down again with the ebb were left penned in a stretch of water no deeper, at its lowest, than a woman's knee, and it was there, once the gate stood driven and the pool's level had settled, that the real work of the day began: wading in with woven baskets and bare hands both, working the pool's whole width from the gate down to its lower lip, taking what the day's need called for and leaving the rest to swim on when the gate was drawn again with the next rise. It was slower work than a net across open water and it took more hands, but it took fish from a stretch of river where no net could be strung, in a channel the household had made for no purpose but this, and it took them dry-shod but for the one man in the water, which on a cold morning of the wet season counted for something the tellers of that shore never troubled to say aloud, for it did not need saying.

A child born to that household in the years the channel was already old learned to walk its length before she learned to walk the shore proper, led by the hand along the smoothed floor at low water while the elders worked, and learned before she was fit to lift the mallet herself which stretch of the channel's floor stood firm underfoot and which gave a little where the current had worked beneath it, a knowledge no one troubled to teach her in words because there were no words in that household's use fit to carry it, only the leading of a small hand

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

along the same stretch of rock, season after season, until the feet themselves knew what they stood on without asking the eyes.

The slot into which the gate was driven wore, over the years the channel was worked, a groove of its own inside the groove first cut for it, the wood's own foot working the stone a little smoother, a little truer, with every dropping and every drawing, until an old man of that household could set the gate's foot to the slot in the near dark and feel, through the haft of the mallet, whether it sat true before it was more than halfway home. What the river gave in one wet season and withheld in the next, the channel and the gate together took in whatever measure the season allowed, penning a little where a little was there to be penned, and standing open and unremarked the rest of the year while the current ran through the gap the gate had left, carrying down to the sea whatever the rock had not been cut to catch.

There were years the river did not fall low enough, or not for long enough, to make the dropping of the gate worth the day's work, and those years the household lived on what the sea gave a little further down, and on what small game the woods above the shelf held, and did not trouble the gate at all from one wet season to the next; and there were years it fell so low and stayed so low that the gate was dropped twice or three times before the autumn rains filled the channel again, each dropping taking the same day's labour as the last, so that a household's whole late summer might be measured out, in the telling that has come down of it, by the number of times the gate had been driven home and drawn again since the water first began to fail, a count kept in place of any count of days. It was not the same gate from one generation to the next. Wattle rotted where it stood driven into wet slots, and a gate that failed at its foot in the pull of a high river was mended where it could be mended and remade whole where it could not, so that the shape of the gate outlasted any one weaving of it, each in turn gone back into the reed bed it was cut from, the way the channel persisted though no two floods left its floor carrying quite the same silt.

A boy who lost two fingers of his left hand to the mallet's swing, misjudging the moment his own weight ought to come off the haft and leaving it a breath too late, went on working the gate in the seasons after with the hand that remained him and the stumps of the other tucked close against his palm out of the mallet's way, and was neither pitied for it nor spared the work on its account, for a household that lived by the channel wanted every hand it had, whole or not, and the

boy himself, so the telling carries, came in time to set a gate's foot into its slot as true by feel as any man of that shore with both hands unhurt.

II

Of the Road Across the Reeds

Some way to the west, where a wide loch lay cupped among low hills and its western shore ran out into a reed marsh a full mile across before the ground rose firm again, another household turned, generation on generation, to a slow work of shell laid upon reed and mud, a little each season, until what had been water underfoot for half the year became, at last, ground a person could walk dry across without once feeling the marsh reach for the foot.

It began, as such things begin on that shore, without any one person setting out to make a road. A family whose gathering-ground lay on the firm rise beyond the marsh had worn a path through the reeds by the plain repetition of walking it, a soft track that held for a season and sank again with the winter's water, so that every spring the same feet found the same reeds standing where the path had been the autumn before, as though the marsh forgot each year what had been asked of it. What changed it was the shell.

The household that worked the loch's edge gathered a great deal of shell from the shallows there, freshwater mussel mostly, and had always let the broken and the empty shell fall back near the water where it was worked, the way any household lets its waste fall near its work. Someone among them, one wet season when the reed track had sunk further and sooner than most years, began instead to carry the broken shell out along the worst of the sunken stretch and let it fall there, underfoot, rather than by the water where it did no one any good; and where the shell fell and was trodden in, the reeds beneath it held firmer through the following winter than the reeds a stride to either side.

It is not told which season this began in, nor whose hands first carried a basket of shell out onto the reeds rather than leaving it by the shallows, for the telling that has come down of it keeps no name and asks for none. What is told is that it was done again the next season, a little further along the same stretch, and again the season after that, until the carrying of shell out onto the worst ground had become, without anyone deciding it should, a thing the household did each year as

part of its ordinary work at the loch's edge, the way the net-menders of other shores mended nets each spring because the nets wanted mending.

The shell was crushed before it was carried, broken small underfoot on a flat stone kept by the water for the purpose, for whole shells worked loose and slid where crushed shell packed and held; and it was carried in the same woven baskets that carried the day's gathering home, so that a basket that went out full of mussel in the morning might come back in the evening full of its own broken shell, emptied onto the reeds on the way out and refilled with the day's take on the way back, two errands made of one walk. Over years enough that no one household's own memory held the whole of it, the crushed shell built up along the worst of the marsh a hand's depth at a time, packed down by every foot that crossed it and topped again the next season where the winter water had worked it thin, until the track that had once sunk under every autumn's rain stood instead a good forearm above the reeds on either side, pale with shell against the dark water, a raised way running the better part of a mile from the firm rise to the loch's own shallows.

A girl of that household, grown just old enough to be trusted with an errand of her own, was sent one autumn to carry word to the loch's edge that the boats were wanted in before the light failed, and went the whole way out along the shell road at a run without once setting a foot into the reeds on either side, the first, so far as the telling remembers, to cross the whole finished length of it without the older habit of testing the ground first with a toe before trusting it with a step. She came back the same way, still at a run, and it was some while before anyone thought to remark that the road, worked at by so many hands over so many years that none of them had set out to build a road at all, had that day carried a child at a run from one end to the other and not once given way beneath her.

The marsh on either side of the shell road kept its own way through all the years the road was built, standing wet and reed-thick and treacherous to any foot that stepped off the packed shell, so that the road did not drain the marsh or change it, only crossed it, a single dry thread laid over ground that remained, on both sides of that thread, exactly what it had always been. Boats still went out from the shallows at the loch's edge to work the deeper water, and the reed-cutting for thatch and for matting still went on along the wet margins either side of the road, and the road carried nothing more than feet and baskets and, on the days the catch was heavy, fish strung on cords over a shoulder; it asked for nothing and gave nothing but the one dry way across, and the household that had built it without meaning to keep it, once built, the way any household keeps a well or a

hearth, mending the low places each spring with a fresh basket of crushed shell before the winter's washing had quite worn them through.

It was not the only crossing of that marsh, for the household beyond the firm rise had, in the years before the shell was ever carried out, waded the reeds at need the way any household wades a marsh it must cross, wet to the thigh and watching for the softer ground that would take a leg to the knee if a foot found it unlucky; and even once the road stood finished, a hand at least a forearm above the water on either side, those who worked the reed-cutting close along its edges went on wading as they always had, for the road served the crossing and not the cutting, and no one thought to lay shell out over ground that only wanted standing in a while and not walking across. The two ways of using the marsh went on side by side the whole time the road was building, the wet way and the dry, neither troubling the other, and a child of that household might grow to a grown height knowing both, the firm shell under the sole for an errand to the far rise and the cold reed-water at the shin for the cutting, without ever once thinking the one had made the other less needful.

In the autumn a family from further round the loch's northern shore, whose own crossing lay a longer way about over higher ground, came down one year to see the road for themselves, having heard of it from a household that fished the loch's open water and had watched the shell-carrying from their boats for seasons without once setting foot on the finished road themselves. They walked its length from the firm rise to the water's edge and back again, the whole family together, saying little that the telling has kept, and went home the long way about all the same, for the road belonged, in whatever unspoken reckoning that shore kept of such things, to the household that had built it, and a stranger's foot on another household's shell was not a thing lightly done, however plainly the shell lay open to any foot that wanted to try it.

III

Of the Signs on the Cliff

Far along the same coast, where the land rose in a line of pale cliffs above a shore too broken with rock for any mole or any road, a household of a different trade turned, in the years the gate was worked at Toll¹ and the road

was laid at the loch, to a labour that left behind it neither a channel to catch fish nor a way to walk dry-shod, but rows of small cut marks on the standing rock, and nothing else that the telling has ever been able to say the marks were for.

A man of that household is remembered, though not by any name, for the care of his hand at the cutting, a care that others of the same trade along that cliff did not always trouble to match. He worked with a chisel of flaked flint, held close to the eye and struck with a small stone hammer no bigger than could be closed in one fist, and he cut each sign the same careful way: a line begun at one point and carried through without lifting the chisel until the whole shape of it stood cut, then a second line crossing or joining the first as the shape called for, each stroke of the hammer light enough that the chisel bit only a little at a time, so that a single sign that a careless hand might have cut in a dozen blows took him, by the count of a boy who once sat a whole afternoon watching him at it, the better part of two hundred.

The signs he cut, and the signs others of his trade cut beside his along the same stretch of cliff face, ran in rows, one row above another where the rock stood high enough to carry more than one, each row running some way along the face before it stopped, sometimes at the rock's own edge and sometimes, it seemed, at no edge at all, simply where the cutter had judged the row done. No two rows ran the same length. No two signs within a row, to an eye set beside them and asked to judge it, looked quite the same as any other, though each carried some kinship with its neighbours that the eye caught without being able to say in what the kinship lay, the way a hand knows one household's pot-rim from another's without being able to say which curve of the thumb made the difference.

The careful man was watched, more than once, by others of his own household standing a little off while he worked, and none of them, so far as the telling carries, ever asked him what the rows said, for there was no word in any of their use for what a row of cut signs on a cliff face might be asked to say, any more than there was a word for what the three strokes on a net-weight far along the coast might be asked to say. He worked at his rows in whatever hours the tide and the weather left him free of the trade that fed his household, some days cutting three signs and some days none, and when a row was as long as he judged it wanted to be he began another above it or beside it, without troubling, so far as anyone

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

watching him could tell, to look back at what he had already cut before he began the next.

Not every row on that cliff stood as its first cutter had left it. Here and there along the face a run of signs had been gone over a second time, the first shallow cutting deepened and widened by a later hand until the old shape beneath it was lost under the new, or cut across at an angle that broke the row's own line into two halves that no longer read, if they had ever read, as one thing. The tool that did this second cutting was of the same kind as the first, a flint chisel struck with a small hammer, and the care taken with it was, where it could still be judged, of the same order as the care taken with the first cutting it undid; whoever went back over an old row worked it with the same patient stroke-by-stroke care that had made the row in the first place, neither careless nor hurried nor angry at the stone. Why the second hand undid what the first had made, the telling does not carry, and no one now living, on that shore or any other, has ever claimed to know.

The rain that fell on that coast in every wet season found the new-cut rows before it found anything else on the whole exposed face, running down into the fresh grooves and darkening them a shade the older, weathered signs around them had long since lost, so that for a little while after every cutting a row stood plain against the paler rock about it, sharp-edged and dark-lined, before the weather over the following seasons drew it down toward the same pale, softened grey as everything cut before it. The careful man cut on through his own years at the trade regardless, adding row to row along a stretch of cliff that already, by the time a boy watched him at it for an afternoon, carried more rows than any one person standing at its foot could take in with a single turn of the head; and when in time his own hand grew too unsteady for the fine work of it, it is not told that anyone else of his household took it up in the same close way, or that the rows he had already cut were ever added to again by any hand as careful as his own.

The boy who watched him that one afternoon came back more than once as he grew, drawn to the foot of the cliff on days his own work left him free, and stood looking up at the rows the way he had once sat and watched them made, though he himself never lifted a chisel to the rock in all the years the telling follows him. He came to know, by looking alone and by no other means, which rows the careful man had cut and which belonged to other hands of the same trade working the same stretch of cliff in the same years, for the careful man's own signs kept, to an eye grown patient enough to find it, a straightness in the line and an evenness in the spacing that the others' did not quite match, however close they

came to it; and this knowing he kept to himself, for there was, in that household's whole use of words, none fit to carry it further than the looking had already carried it.

Below the rows, where the cliff's foot ran down into a shingle no different from any other shingle on that coast, the same household that fished and gathered the tideline there went on with its ordinary work the whole time the signs were being cut above them, hauling boats up past the high-water mark and mending nets and splitting driftwood for the fire, most of them never once climbing the short scramble up to where the rows stood, for the cutting was the careful man's trade and not theirs, the way the gate was the Toll household's trade and the shell road the loch household's, each a labour one people took up for reasons the telling has never been asked to give, and each left, by every other people near it, entirely to the hands that had begun it.

IV

Of the Rain on the New Signs

It fell to a woman of the household at Toll¹, in the years the gate had been worked at longest and the slot wore its own groove within the first, to walk the coast one summer on an errand that is not told, and to come, in the course of it, along the cliff where the signs stood cut in their rows, and to stand a while at their foot looking up at them the way the boy had once sat and watched the careful man cut them, though her own eyes found only what was already finished and could say nothing of how it had been made.

She had never seen the like before, for no household of the river-gate or the marsh-road cut anything into stone beyond what bare use demanded, a groove for a gate's foot, a notch for a cord; and she stood at the cliff's foot a while in a rain that had begun while she walked and had not yet decided whether to lift, watching the water run down into the freshest of the rows and darken it against the older signs around it, and then she went on the way her errand called her, and the telling, which follows her only that far, does not say that she ever spoke of it at either of the two households she came from or came to.

The rows stood after her as they had stood before her, taking the rain the same way they had always taken it, darkening under it and paling again as it dried,

without asking of any hand that passed beneath them, hers or another's, more than the looking she had given them; and along the whole of that coast, where the gate was dropped and the road was mended and the rows were cut a little longer every season they were worked at, no telling passed from the gate's household to the marsh's, or from the marsh's to the cliff's, so that what was made at each stood, so far as the tellers of that shore have ever carried it forward, entirely on its own, known to no household but the one whose hands had made it.

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

CHAPTER TWELVE

Of Aodh and the Northern Sea

VE 1,331 – 1,442

I

Of the Boy Who Had Not Seen the Sea

Aodh was born at Tobar dhìreach a good many fathers after Diarmad had first brought Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹ down out of the grove, into a hearth that had by then told the same three lines so many times over that the youngest child at it could say them before it could walk a field alone: the sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit; merge the spirits, and they become almighty. He learned the words the way every child of that line learned them, from his mother's mouth before he had teeth enough to say them back whole, and he grew up knowing the sky for the wind that came down off the moor and the earth for the black ground his own feet stood on and the wool his own hands helped card, and knowing the sea, when he thought of it at all, for a word.

He was nine years old before it troubled him that a word was all it was. A traveller up from the eastern farms, resting a night at the hearth on his way to trade salt for hides, said something in passing of a grey water without a far shore to it, and Aodh, sitting close by the fire with the leather bag of the seven pieces in his lap as every child of the line was let hold it once the elders judged the small hands careful enough, asked the man plainly whether he had seen it himself. The traveller laughed and said he had, more times than he could count, from a headland a

1. the Telling of the Making

day's walk past his own farm, and that it went on flat and grey to the very edge of the sky and gave nothing back to a man's eye but more grey water. Aodh turned that over the whole of the next day, and the day after asked his mother how far off the sea might be found, and she told him a day's walk north, more or less, past the last hearth any of their kin kept, and that she had never gone to see it, having had no cause.

He had cause enough of his own by then, though he could not yet have said what it was. Every recital of Aithris a' Chruthachaidh that he had sat through since he was old enough to sit still for one ended the same way it had ended since Diarmad first brought it down out of the grove: that gual òir² held the sea, and had never yet been carried to the sea itself, only wetted in Diarmad's day with sea-water fetched home in skins, because no one of the line, in all the generations since, had carried it the day's walk north to try. The old women who kept the recital word for word said this the way they said every other part of it, as a fact long settled and long past troubling anyone new, the way a household says a well has always run dry in a hard summer and always filled again after; and it was some while before Aodh understood that what the old women called long settled, no one living had actually gone and done.

He asked why, the way Diarmad had once asked why the stones had colours, and got much the answer that first Diarmad had got: that the sea was a day's walk and more for a household with beasts to tend and a hearth to keep, and that a coal thrown once and sunk was a coal thrown, and there were six pieces left in the bag that answered to nothing anyone had found yet, and the line had waited five hundred years already and could wait a season or two longer. It did not strike him, at nine, as a good answer, though he had not yet the years to say so to anyone who would listen; and the thought sat in him after that the way the grove had once sat in Diarmad, waiting on nothing but a body old enough and free enough to go and do it.

II

Of the Growing of the Question

2. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

The recital raised him the way a trade raises another boy, said standing at every gathering of the fathers' names, at Oidhche an Dealanaich¹ when the whole kin turned out under the dark of the year to say the Line from Neachdan down, and at the lesser tellings besides, when a traveller asked to hear it or a child was born and the elders judged the new soul owed the whole of the story before it was a season old. Water was carried and peat was cut and the shape of every field his household worked came to him the way it comes to any child of a hearth, the black soil that gave the barley and the wet ground that did not; and under all of it he carried, the older he grew the more rather than the less, the one plain fact that troubled him: that he had heard the sea named at every recital of his whole life and had still, at fifteen, at twenty, never once stood before it.

His own mother had little patience left for the trouble by the time he was grown, having heard it out of him since he was nine and judged it, by twenty, a habit more than a hope; but his mother's aunt Muirgheal, who kept Poit an Teine² at the hearth and had Aithris a' Chruthachaidh³ word for word as Deirbhile's teaching had fixed it, had a longer patience for it than anyone else at Tobar dhìreach, a woman of few words who could say Cunntas nan Athraichean⁴ back further than most cared to follow; and it was Muirgheal who did not laugh when Aodh at five-and-twenty said aloud, at last, what he had carried quiet since he was nine, that he meant to walk north and try gual òir⁵ against the sea himself before another generation let it lie.

"Your grandfather's grandfather said the same," Muirgheal told him, "and never went. It is easier to mean it than to walk it."

"Then I will walk it," Aodh said, "and find out which I am."

She did not answer that at once, and when she did it was not to forbid him, only to say that a thing waited five hundred years bore waiting a little longer yet, until the barley was in and the beasts settled for the dark months, so that a household could spare the hands his going would cost it; and Aodh, who had waited sixteen years already since the trouble first took him, found he could wait one more season for the sake of an old woman's asking. He worked the harvest that year with more will in him than any harvest before it, the way a man works faster

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

2. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

3. the Telling of the Making

4. the count of the fathers; the only long measure of time in the age, a father to about twenty-five years

5. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

at a thing he means to leave behind him clean, and when the last of the barley was under thatch and the beasts driven in from the high pasture, he told Muirgheal he would go with the first clear spell of weather, and she nodded and said nothing more against it.

III

Of the Walk North

he went in the season the leaves were down off what few birches grew that high, when the moor above the valley stood the colour of a bruise under a sky the colour of ash, and he carried the leather bag with all seven pieces in it against his chest under his cloak, in the same fold of hide Diarmad had once carried an *gual dathach*¹ alone. The night before he left he had asked Muirgheal whether he ought to carry the gold piece alone and leave the other six safe at the hearth, and she had told him no, that Aithris a' Chruthachaidh² said the seven were cast at the mason's own fire together and ought, in her own reckoning if in no other's, to go together wherever one of them went, so that whatever answered would answer among its own. He did not ask her how she came by that reckoning, and she did not offer to say more of it, only wrapped the bag in a second fold of hide against the weather and pressed it into his hands the way a mother presses bread on a son going to a fair, as though the wrapping were half the gift.

The moor rose steadily under him the whole first hour, heather giving way in patches to bare black peat where the wind had scoured it, and he walked it alone, for no one else of the hearth had cause to go and he had not asked anyone to come; this was a thing he meant to do with his own two feet and no other's, the way Diarmad had gone alone into the grove eighteen fathers before him. The wind came harder as the ground climbed, the last cold breath of the season before the true dark months shut the moor entirely, and twice he stopped in the lee of a rock to eat a little of the bread he carried and to feel, through the two folds of hide, that the bag still sat close and whole against him.

He crossed no hearth he knew the whole first day, for the last of his own kin's fields lay behind him before noon, and the ground past them belonged to no

1. the coloured coal

2. the Telling of the Making

household he had ever heard named, bare moor cut here and there by a burn running fast and brown off the high ground, cold enough at the fording that his feet ached the length of the far bank before feeling came back into them. Once, on the highest stretch, he startled a flock of small dun birds up out of the heather at his very feet, so sudden and so many together that his heart went hard in his chest before he understood what had frightened him; and once he passed the bleached ribs of some beast long dead, sheep or deer he could not tell by then, picked clean and half sunk into the peat, and gave it no more than a glance, being in no mind that day to read a sign into every bone the moor happened to show him.

It was past noon of that first day, with the moor's highest ground behind him and the land beginning at last to fall away north, that he smelled it before he saw it: a coldness in the air different from the moor's own cold, carrying something in it he had no word ready for, salt and weed and a wideness that seemed, even before his eyes found anything to confirm it, to have already got into his breathing. He came over the last rise with that smell thick in his throat and stood a long moment looking down at grey water running flat to the edge of the world, exactly as the trader long ago had said it would, and found that sixteen years of imagining it had prepared him for nothing at all. It moved. That was the thing no telling at any hearth had ever thought to say plainly, that the sea did not lie still the way a loch lay still on a calm day. It heaved from edge to edge, slow and grey and endless, a live thing breathing under a skin too wide for any eye to take in whole.

He stood there long enough that the cold began to work into his feet before he remembered to go on, and came down the last slope to a shingle shore where the land gave out at last into the water proper, waves running up the stones in long grey folds and drawing back with a sound like a held breath let go, over and over, without ever once resting between one and the next.

IV

Of the Casting

he did not throw the coals that first evening, though the light still held enough for it. A day and more of walking lay behind him now, and something in him, once he stood at last on the stones with the bag warm against his chest, wanted the doing of it done properly and not rushed at the tail of a long walk with his legs still shaking under him from the climb; so he found a

hollow above the tideline out of the worst of the wind, ate what bread was left him, and lay through a cold night listening to the sea work at the shingle below him, a sound he had never once heard in his life until that day and thought, lying awake under it, that he might never afterward be able to sleep easily without.

In the morning, with the light come up grey and even over water that ran the same colour as the sky above it, he went down to the water's edge and opened the bag.

The seven pieces lay in his palm the way they had always lain in the leather bag at the hearth, small and dull and unremarkable to any eye that did not know what they were, none of them showing, in the flat morning light, more than the plain black of any coal broken from any vein. He held each in turn a moment before he threw it, the way a man says a word over a thing before he lets it go, though he had no fixed form of words for the doing and made none up on the spot, only stood at the water's edge with the cold coming up through his boots and let each piece go into the swell as it rose to meet his hand.

The first sank without a mark of any kind, gone under the grey water as plainly as a common stone would have gone, and the second went the same way, and the third and fourth after it, each swallowed into the sea's own colour before the ripple of its falling had even smoothed away. He had known, standing there, that six of the seven were not the sea's to answer and had told himself as much on the whole walk north, so that he felt less each time than he had feared he might, only a small settling disappointment, familiar by the fourth piece, that this one too had been only a coal. The fifth went the same way. The sixth.

The seventh he held longest of all, though he had meant to hold none of them longer than another, for his hand seemed, of its own accord, unwilling to let it go; and when at last he did throw it, no differently than he had thrown the six before it, out into a swell rising grey and slow toward the shingle, it did not sink.

It took fire on the water, a small bright gold flame standing up out of the swell where the coal had struck, no bigger than a hand's span and burning steady in a wind that would have snuffed any ordinary flame in a breath; and it rode the rise and fall of that one swell the whole way in toward the shore, burning gold on grey water under a grey sky, until a breaker further out gathered itself and rolled over where the small flame stood and put it under in a single fold of white water, and it did not come up again.

Aodh stood at the water's edge with the empty bag hanging loose in his hand and watched the place where the flame had been, though there was nothing left to

watch, the sea already smoothing back into the same grey heave it had shown him the evening before, giving no more sign that a coal had burned gold on its face than it gave of the six that had simply gone under. He stood there long enough that the cold reached past his boots into his legs before he remembered himself, and when at last he turned from the water he found he was weeping, though he could not afterward have said, when the old women at the hearth asked him, whether it was for the five hundred years the answer had waited or for the small span of a morning that a fire had burned and then had not.

V

Of the Telling at the Hearth

He walked home slower than he had walked out, for the weather had turned against him and the ground was heavier with rain underfoot, so that a day and more going became the better part of two days coming back; and he came into the valley at last gaunt and salt-stained and empty-handed but for the leather bag, which he had folded and carried home though there was nothing left in it that answered to anything.

Muirgheal was the first to hear it from him, sitting by the fire she had kept since before he was born, and she made him say it twice over, once plain and once again slower, before she would let herself believe the whole of it: that six had sunk as any coal sinks, and the seventh, the gold, had taken fire on the swell and burned there, riding the water, until the sea had put it under. When he had said it the second time she sat a long while without speaking, her hands still in her lap, and when at last she did speak it was to the fire rather than to him, in the voice of a woman working out a sum she had carried unfinished a very long time.

"Nearly five hundred years," she said, "since the grove." And then, to Aodh, "Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹ is true, then. Each answers to its own."

Word of it went out from Tobar dhìreach faster than Aodh himself had walked home, carried by whoever first heard it told and could not sit still on the hearing, so that by the second evening households a half-day's walk off in every direction had sent someone to ask whether it was true, and by the third Poit an Teine²'s own door stood open near the whole of the daylight to let in one more

1. the Keeper's riddle

household wanting to hear it from Aodh's own mouth rather than a neighbour's telling of it. He said it over so many times in those first days that the words wore into the same shape each time, the six that sank and the one that burned, until he no longer needed to search for how to say it and it came out of him as easily as the fathers' names came out of the old women at a recital; and he noticed, saying it the tenth time and the twentieth, that no one who heard it laughed, not once, not even the youngest children who had laughed at every other wonder a grown man ever told them.

She wept that night at the hearth before the whole gathered kin, an old woman who had buried a husband and two children of her own without more than a dry eye shown for either, weeping now over a fire lit gold on a grey sea a day's walk from where she sat; and when she was asked why, by those too young to have carried the weight of it themselves, she said only that she had said Aithris a' Chruthachaidh³ word for word since she was a girl, and had never once let herself believe, in all her years of saying it back word for word, that she would live to hear it proved even once. The recital that night ran longer than any within living memory, for the fathers' names were said as always down from Neachdan, and then, for the first time since the mason's own well, a new line was added after them, plain and short: that in that year *gual òir*⁴ was thrown into the northern sea by Aodh of the line, and took fire there, and burned gold until the water put it under. It is from that night that the piece was first called, at every hearth Aithris a' Chruthachaidh reached after, *gual òir*, *gual òir*, a name it has kept at every recital since.

VI

Of the Six That Would Not Answer

Aodh did not let the matter rest with the one answer given him. He went back to the northern shore twice more in the years after, though the bag now held only six pieces and no eighth chance for the gold, and threw each of the six in turn from a different height and a different ground each time he went, from the hilltop above the shingle where the wind stood hardest, from the

2. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

3. the Telling of the Making

4. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

black peat of the high moor dug open to the bare ground beneath, from a shallow pool of standing rainwater he found once in a hollow and thought, for want of any better guess, might stand close enough to the sea's own element to serve. Nothing answered him. The coals lay in whatever ground or water he set them in the same dull black they had always shown, and he came home from each of those later walks with nothing to tell the hearth but that the six were still six, and the gold still one, and the answer, whatever shape it would take for the rest, was not going to be hurried by a man's own wanting it hurried.

He did not stop trying for that. In the years he had left he carried the six pieces to every high ground and every water within a hard day's walk of Tobar dhíreach that he could reach and return from before the season turned against him, and tried each against ground and water and once, in a hard frost, against the bare air, held up on an open palm the way Diarmad was said to have held an *gual dathach*¹ up to the sky in the grove; and each time he came home to say, to whoever still troubled to ask him, that the ground had not answered and the water had not answered and the air had not answered, only the sea, only once, and that he did not yet know what any of the rest were waiting on. Muirgheal did not live to hear the last of these failed tryings. She died an old woman by then even by the reckoning of a household that buried most of its own well short of her years, and the recital that told her death added, after the fathers' names, only that she had lived to hear the sea answer and had wept for it, and that she was carried out and laid as her own mother had been laid before her, with the fire kept burning at the hearth the whole night through as it had never once been let go out since the mason first carried it home.

Aodh himself did not live to see any of the six answer either. He kept the trying up until his own strength for the walking gave out under him, and died in his own bed at Tobar dhíreach at eight-and-sixty years, a long life by the reckoning of that hearth though not the longest the line had known, with the leather bag of six unanswered pieces still under his own hand where he had kept it close through all his last years the way another man might keep a tool he had not yet finished the work he meant it for. The recital that told his death said what it had said of every keeper of the line before him, the fathers' names down from Neachdan and then his own name added after them; and it said, besides, what no recital before his had ever had cause to say of any man of that line, that in his one lifetime the sea had

1. the coloured coal

been answered where it had waited five hundred years unanswered, and that six waited yet, and that whoever came after him would have to carry them further than he had, or find some ground he had not thought to try.

VII

Of the New Pieces from the Stream-Bank

It fell, in the years just after Aodh was laid in the ground, to a boy of his own house too young to remember him clearly, out following a strayed goat along the bank of the stream below Tobar dhireach where the water had cut a fresh notch into the earth after a hard season of rain, to find the black vein showing bare in the cut bank exactly as the mason's own crack had once shown bare in the rock of the well, a seam no wider than two fingers laid together, dark and dull in the wet earth. He did not know, at first look, what he had found, only that it was not the ordinary black of the peat around it, and he carried a broken piece of it home in his fist the way any child carries home a thing that has caught its eye, meaning to ask someone older what it was.

The elders of the hearth knew it at once for what it was, and more than one of them wept a second time that autumn, more than forty years after Muirgheal had wept at the gold, to see a bare showing of the vein found again after so many generations of the line had known it only as seven old pieces kept close in a leather bag and never renewed. They went out themselves to the stream-bank in the following days and cut what fresh pieces the notch would give them, careful of the bank's own crumbling the way the mason had once been careful of his well, and brought the new coal home to lie beside the old seven in the bag the children still played with, so that for the first time since Neachdan's own day the line held more pieces of the vein than the seven it had counted and recounted for five hundred years, with no more certainty than the mason himself had ever had of what any of the new ones might answer to, or when, or in whose lifetime the answer would come.

They said the recital that year with the new pieces passed hand to hand around the gathered kin before the fire was banked, an old custom half remembered and half made new on the spot, so that every soul at the hearth might hold, once at least, a piece of the vein not yet tried against anything at all; and it is told that the youngest child there, no older than Aodh himself had been the year the trader

first spoke to him of the sea, held one of the fresh pieces up before the fire the way every child of that line had done since Diarmad first turned an gual dathach¹ in his own small hand, and asked, in a voice too young yet to know how old the question was, what it was for.

1. the coloured coal

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

OF the Kilns

the Ramps and the Houses on the Water

VE 1,443 – 1,669

Dhìrich Fearghas gu mullach an eilein, agus ghabh an gual sneachda teine san adhar. Fearghas climbed to the top of the island, and gual sneachda took fire in the air. — from *Sloinneadh a' Chlachair*
The Third Part: Of the White Coal on the Height, and the Walls of Seann-Dhaoine

I

Of the Kilns at Morn

At Morn¹ the beach ran shingle to a bay of grey water, and above the shingle, where the ground rose enough to stand dry of the highest tide, a household of the Seann-Dhaoine² had for longer than any of its own living members could number dug pits into the turf and lined them with flat stones set on edge, so that each pit stood like a shallow box sunk into the ground with its rim just proud of the grass. Seven such pits stood there by the year the kilns are first told of, though the household said, when asked, that there had once been fewer, the way any household says of a thing it keeps adding to as the years and the catch allow.

Each pit had, cut into the turf at its lower side where the ground fell a little toward the shingle, a short channel no wider than a forearm and no deeper, through

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

which a fire lit at the channel's mouth drew its smoke the length of the pit and out through gaps left along the stone lining, so that the whole pit filled with a slow smoke thick enough to hang a hand's blackness on a strung fish inside a morning and a night. It was not, the household would have said had there been anyone of another trade to ask it, a fire built to warm a body or cook a meal; it was built low and kept low and fed sparingly, on purpose, for its work was smoke and not flame, and a pit that flared was a pit whose keeper had misjudged the peat.

The keeping of the fires fell, in the years this telling holds, to a woman of that household who is remembered by no name but by the plain fact of her trade, the keeper of the kilns; and hers was a day unlike any other day kept on that shore. She rose before the light to walk the seven pits in turn, laying a palm flat an inch above each smoking bed to feel whether the night's fire had held or guttered, and where it had guttered she fed it a little dry peat from a store kept dry under an overhang of turf for that single purpose, never green peat and never wet, for green peat flared where dry peat only smoked, and a flare in a kiln full of the day's catch could undo in a morning what a season's fishing had built. Where the fire had held steady through the night she did nothing at all, for a kiln left alone in good order was a kiln doing its work, and it was, she had been taught and taught in her turn, no part of the trade to trouble a fire that troubled no one.

The catch itself came down to her from the boats each evening, strung on cords through the gills the way every household of that coast strung a catch, and she laid the strings across green withies set from rim to rim of each pit, low enough that the smoke closed over them but high enough that no fish hung near the fire's own heat, for a kiln was reckoned well kept when a hand laid flat on the fish by evening found it no warmer than the smoke around it. A fish taken out too soon spoiled within days despite the smoking; a fish left too long in a pit whose fire had crept too high dried hard and lost its worth at the trading; and between the two lay a length of days that the keeper of the kilns judged, so far as the telling can say, by no measure but the one in her own hand and eye, laid on the fish itself each morning and each evening, cord by cord.

It is told that in the years the seventh pit was dug, the smoke of Morn's kilns stood some mornings thick enough over the bay to be seen from the high ground a half day's walk inland, a grey column standing where no cooking-fire's smoke had ever stood long enough to be marked, and that herders of the inland hearths who saw it took it, for a while, as weather of some kind particular to that stretch of coast, a mist that rose from the sea on certain still mornings and no other. It

was some years before the herders understood, by what road the telling does not say, that the column was smoke and the smoke was a fire kept on purpose, low and smouldering, day upon day, for no warmth and no cooking and no light against the dark, but only to dry a fish that would keep through a season no boat could fish in.

No hearth of the hills built the like of it in all the years this telling has followed either shore, for the hearths of the hills had no catch to keep in such a quantity that a single winter's eating could not see it through, and a fire built and fed and never let flare, day upon day, for the sake of what it did to meat rather than what it gave to the people standing near it, was a use of fire the hill-folk had not yet had reason to think of. It is the first building raised on Dia-thìr, so far as the telling has ever traced, for a trade and not for a hearth to sleep by or a hearth to lay a body near in death; and the keeper of the kilns, whoever she had been in the years before this telling opens, or her mother before her, or whoever it was first thought to dig a pit and line it and lead a channel of air into it rather than simply hang a string of fish over an ordinary fire and hope the smoke found it, left no name behind for the thinking of it, only the seven pits themselves, and the eighth begun before the telling loses sight of that shore, and the ninth begun after.

It is told of one summer, a good way into the years this telling has followed the kilns, that a night's rain drove in sideways off the bay and put out the fire in the fourth pit before the keeper had made her last round of the evening, so that she came to it at first light and found the withies bare, no smoke standing over them at all, the fish upon them cold and wet and already turned in their smell. She did not relight that pit that day, for a fire started fresh under a full load of soaked fish would have flared before it settled, and a flare would have cost her the load twice over rather than once; she carried the spoiled strings down to the tideline instead, where the gulls of that shore had long since learned to wait on such mornings, and let the pit stand cold and empty until the stones inside it had dried enough, by her own judging hand, to take a new fire without weeping steam back into the smoke. It is the only loss of a whole pit's load that this telling has kept a memory of from all the years the kilns are told of, and it is kept, so far as can be judged, only because the keeper herself is said to have spoken of it once, in her age, to a niece she was teaching the trade to, as the one morning she had ever stood at a kiln and found it had nothing at all to give her.

The niece kept the telling of it, and kept also, from the same teaching, the rule the keeper drew from that one wet morning: that a kiln in a gathering rain wanted

watching past the hour a keeper would otherwise have gone to her own bed, for a fire low enough to smoke and not flare was, by that same lowness, a fire near enough to going out that a hard rain could take it before a keeper's next round found it gone. Whether every keeper of Morn's kilns who came after held to that watching in every wet night of her own years, the telling does not say; but the ninth pit, dug in the last years this telling follows that shore, stood a little higher on its rise than the first seven, its channel a little longer and angled a little more against the wind that drove rain in off the bay, as though whoever dug it had learned something from a pit dug lower and had no wish to learn it twice.

II

Of the Ramps at Brenn

On the north coast, where the land ran down in long shelves of flat pale stone toward water deep enough close in that a boat could float within an oar's length of dry ground, another household of the same people had for its own long span of years built and launched and mended the skin boats common to every shore of the island, each hide stretched on a light frame of bent wood no bigger than two or three grown people could carry between them down to the water and back. In the years this telling now turns to, that household began a work no other shore had yet attempted: they laid, down the same shelving stone their boats had always launched from, long ramps built up of flat slabs set edge to edge and levelled with smaller stone packed beneath the low places, running from well above the highest tide down into water deep enough to float more than a skin boat's draught.

The first of the ramps was the work of more seasons than the telling can count with any confidence, for the slabs were heavy beyond what two or three hands could set true, and each one had to be walked and levered into its place a hand's breadth at a time, tried with a loaded sledge dragged its length, and lifted and reset where the sledge caught or rocked. It is told that the ramp stood finished, its whole length from the turf above to the water below laid true enough that a sledge run down it met no check from the first stone to the last, some years before anyone of that household had cause to build, upon it, anything heavier than the boats they had always built.

What was built there afterward, and drawn down that ramp and launched from its foot into the deep water, was a hull of a different make than any hide boat: a frame of timber built up plank upon plank rather than skin stretched over bent wood, shaped and pegged and caulked with whatever that household used for the purpose, and raised the whole length of the ramp on rollers cut from young trunks, a crew of them at the ropes and more at the rollers, walking it down by inches while the tide stood at the height the ramp was built for. A boy of the household, sent down at first light to see that no roller had shifted in the night, is the only person the telling names as standing close by it in its last hour ashore; the rest of the household came down as the light rose, and stood along the ramp's edge, and did not go into the water themselves.

The hull went down slower than any load the ramp had carried before it, checked twice on rollers that bit unevenly and freed each time with the same patient shifting of weight that had built the ramp in the first place, and took the water at last with no more sound, so far as anyone standing on the shore could afterward agree in the telling, than the ordinary slap of a wave against stone. It floated low and steady, riding in water deep enough that no one standing on the ramp's foot could any longer see its keel, and hands already aboard it, for someone had gone aboard before it left the rollers, though the telling has never agreed how many nor which of the household, took up oars of a length no skin boat's crew had ever needed and worked it out past the last shelf of stone into open water.

No season that the household could later fix a year to brought it back to that shore, so far as this telling has followed the household afterward; and of where it went, or what it was built to reach, or whether it reached it, nothing is told. The household went on building at the ramp after it, wider each time and longer, and launched hulls from it in the years that followed the way any trade repeats what it has learned once it has learned it; but the first hull, and the water it went out into, and the coast it may or may not have raised on some horizon no one of Brenn¹ ever stood close enough to see confirmed, belong, in every telling that has come down of it, to the sea alone.

Of the first ramp's own building, before ever a plank was laid to make a hull for it to carry, more is told than of the hull that came after, for the ramp stood a long while as a thing seen and stepped over by the whole household before it became a thing that launched anything at all. Twice, in the years the telling follows

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

its laying, a slab set well enough by daylight was found in the morning to have settled crooked in the night, the packed stone beneath it having given under its own weight where the ground below ran soft, and both times Leac na Fèithe² was levered up again with poles of green oak braced against driven stakes, the low place packed afresh with smaller stone rammed hard by hand and by heel, and Leac na Fèithe let down a second time onto ground that had, by then, been tried and found wanting once already. The household that did this work is not told to have cursed the crooked stone or hurried its second setting; the telling that has come down of it says only that it was done again, the same careful way, as many times as the ground asked for it.

A dog of that household is remembered, though not by name any more than the boy who watched the last rollers or the hands that first went aboard, for lying across the finished ramp on warm days in the last summer before the first hull was framed above it, so that more than one of the household is said to have stepped over or around it on the way down to the water rather than move it, the ramp by then being as ordinary a part of that shore's ground as the shingle either side of it. Whether the dog lay there on the morning the hull was finally walked down to the water, and was moved for that one day only, or was kept well clear of the work for longer than a single morning, the telling has not troubled to say; it is remembered only for the many ordinary days before, lying full length on stone that had cost the household more labour than anything else that shore had ever raised, exactly as it might have lain on any bare patch of turf.

III

Of the Houses on the Water

I nland from either shore, where the land folded down into a loch called Loch chrom, ringed close about with reed and alder, a scatter of low platforms stood out over the water on legs of oak driven down through the shallows into the firmer ground beneath, each platform joined to the shore, and each to its nearest neighbour, by a walk of split planks laid end to end and lashed to cross-beams below. Whether the platforms were the work of the Seann-Dhaoine¹,

2. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhreach

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

whose kilns smoked on one coast and whose ramps grew on another in those same years, or of some other people who left no other mark the telling has since been able to point to and say *these were theirs and no one else's*, is not a thing this telling, or any telling that has come to it, has ever been able to settle; the oak legs, driven and trimmed and lashed at their tops to bear a floor of split timber, say only that hands did it, and are silent on whose.

The platforms stood a little apart from one another across the loch's shallower reach, each with its own low house of wattle and turf raised on the floor above the water, and the walks between them ran narrow enough that a laden basket carried along one had to be carried square to the body or knocked against the low rail lashed along either side. Beneath the floors, in the water and the mud between the piles, eels gathered in numbers no open bank of that same loch ever drew them to in such close reach of a hand or a woven trap, for the shade of the platforms and the stillness the piles made in the current suited them better than open water did, and the households above learned, within what the telling reckons a very few years of the first platform standing, to lower baited traps through gaps left on purpose in the plank floor rather than working the open shallows from a boat as they had before.

A child of one of those households, too young by the household's own reckoning to be trusted alone on the open walks, was set nonetheless, on a morning this telling has kept though it has kept no name to go with it, to carry a basket of the day's eels the length of the longest walk, from the furthest platform to the shore, while the grown hands of the household were occupied at the traps. The child went the whole distance at a careful walking pace with both hands full and the basket's strap looped twice about a wrist against the chance of a slip, watching the planks underfoot rather than the water on either side, and set the basket down on dry ground at the walk's landward end without once losing footing on planks that another child, a season or two younger, would not yet have been trusted upon at all.

It is told, though not by any teller close enough to the loch to have seen it done, that the child was watched the whole way by an elder of the household standing at the shore end of the walk, arms folded, saying nothing, neither calling encouragement nor warning of a loose plank, for the crossing was by then, in that household's own reckoning of such things, an ordinary errand and not a trial; and that when the child set the basket down at last, the elder only turned back to the day's work at the traps without remark, the way a household turns back to its

work once an ordinary thing has been ordinarily done. What the telling has kept of that morning, it has kept for the crossing alone, and not for anything the child or the elder is remembered to have said of it.

The platforms stood on their piles through wet years and dry, mended plank by plank as planks split or piles settled, longer than any one household's memory held whole; and the eels taken from beneath them, smoked or eaten fresh or carried inland on the same slow roads that carried word of the smoke at Morn², fed households that never set a plank of their own over that water nor asked whose hands had first driven a pile into its mud.

The driving of a new pile, when one was wanted, in place of an old one worked loose by years of current and weight, was reckoned the heaviest labour any of the loch's households undertook, heavier by their own account than the raising of a wattle wall or the cutting of a season's reed, for it asked four or five hands working together where most of that shore's other work asked one or two. A trimmed trunk of oak, its foot cut to a rough point and charred a little in a low fire to harden it against the wet ground it would stand in, was walked out along the nearest finished platform on rollers of its own, upended over the gap where the old pile had failed, and driven down by a weighted beam of the same oak, swung and dropped from a frame lashed above the gap, blow upon blow, until a hand laid flat against the standing trunk could no longer feel it give at the strike. It is told that the driving of a single pile in firm ground took the better part of a day, and in soft ground, where the trunk wanted driving deeper before it held, the better part of two; and that the households of the loch counted a new pile driven and holding as an occasion worth a shared meal on the nearest platform once the frame was struck down and the mud had settled around the new wood, though the telling has kept no word of what was eaten or said at such a meal, only that it was held.

The walks between platforms, no less than the platforms themselves, wanted mending against the same wet years that worked the piles loose, for a plank laid flat across open water and walked upon by every foot and every laden basket of a household's daily round wore thin at its centre long before its lashed ends gave way, and a worn plank was watched for and replaced before it broke rather than after, by households that had, by the years this telling holds, come to know the sound a sound plank made underfoot and the slightly different sound a thinning

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

one made, a knowledge kept in the foot and the ear rather than in any word for it. A child too small yet to be trusted with a basket, but old enough to be sent along a walk on no errand heavier than its own feet, is remembered to have been set, more than once, to walk the length of every plank each morning before the grown hands went out to the traps, listening for the sound of a plank gone thin beneath its own light weight before a grown foot, heavier and less patient in its listening, might find the same plank the hard way.

IV

Of the Shore Grown Bold

Three shores, in the years this telling has followed them, each took up a work heavier and stranger than any before it: pits dug and lined and fired for smoke alone; stone laid the length of a shelf to carry a hull the sea itself would swallow the memory of; timber driven down through water to raise a floor where no floor had stood. None of the three households that raised them knew, so far as any telling carries, what the others were about on their own stretch of coast in those same years, for word between shore and shore travelled slower in those days than smoke rose from a kiln or a plank was laid across a pile, and each work stood, while it was building, as its own household's own matter and no one else's.

Yet a single thing had changed along every coast the telling has followed in this age, and the telling, looking back from beyond it, can call the thing by its right name though none of the three households then building could have called it by any name at all: the sea, which had for so long been taken as it was found, waded and fished and rowed across in a skin no bigger than a boat's own crew, had begun in these same years to be worked. Ground was dug for it that had never been dug before. Stone was laid for it that would outlast the hands that laid it. Water was driven timber into, and floored over, and made to carry a household's own floor above its own depth. The shore that had once only received what the sea gave it had begun, in three places at least, and likely in others the telling has not followed, to shape the meeting place between land and water to its own purpose rather than take that meeting place exactly as the tide had always left it.

Inland at Tobar dhìreach, where the fire that had come down out of the storm still burned as it had burned since before any of these three shores had cut a kiln-

pit or laid a ramp-slab or driven an oak pile, the line of the mason kept its seven pieces in the leather bag and told, at every recital, of a gold coal that had taken fire on the sea and six that had not; and no word had yet come to that hearth, in the years this telling holds, of kilns or ramps or platforms on any coast, for the hills and the shore-trades of the Seann-Dhaoine¹ kept, in this age as in every age before it, each to its own doings and its own silence toward the other. What passed between the fire-keeping line of the hills and the smoke-keeping, water-working households of the coasts was carried, when it was carried at all, no faster than a traveller's own two feet, and a traveller with reason to cross from one to the other was not yet, in these years, a common thing on any of the island's roads.

The last that is told of the hull launched from Brenn² is the small dark shape of a sail it is said to have carried, seen once, by no name the telling has kept, from high ground some distance along that same coast, standing out against the grey of the water and growing smaller with every count of the watcher's own breath until it could no longer be told from the water it stood on. Whether that sail belonged to the hull raised at Brenn, or to some other hull of some other shore's building that this telling has not followed, is not settled and was not settled then; but the watcher who saw it, whoever that watcher was, is remembered for one thing only, which is that they stood and watched until there was nothing left to watch, and then turned and went back down to whatever work the day still asked of them, the way every shore of that age turned, in the end, back to its own work once the sea had taken what it was going to take and shown what it was going to show.

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thírich

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Of the Whale

the Round Houses and the Tower

VE 1,670 – 1,950

I

Of the Whale-Ribs at Dunn

Below the southern Dunn¹, where the land broke down from turf to shingle in a single short fall a man could jump without troubling to look for a path, a whale came ashore in an autumn gale out of the west, driven in on a sea already grey and heavy long before the wind that carried it had properly begun, so that the household nearest the shingle heard the surf change its voice before first light and were down on the stones, half dressed, before the sky had greyed enough to show them what the noise had brought.

It lay the length of six grown men end to end, and longer, stranded above the ordinary reach of the tide and beyond any hope the next high water might carry it off again, and it lived through that first day and into the next, its one visible eye following the household as they stood off from it at a careful distance, not yet knowing what a thing of that size, breathing still, might do if it heaved. By the third morning it had stopped its breathing, and by then word had gone along the shore both ways, on the two feet of whoever could be spared to carry it, and other households besides the one that had heard the surf change came down to Dunn to see what the sea had put ashore.

The cutting of it was work for every hand the shore could gather, and took the better part of a half-month, the meat carried off in loads no single household

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

could have eaten before it turned, salted where salt could be got and smoked over slow fires where it could not, shared out by a reckoning none of the tellings that have come down of it have troubled to set out in full, save that no household that had come down to help went home again with an empty basket. The blubber was rendered in clay-lined pits dug back from the shingle, the oil skimmed and kept in bladders and in the same clay pots the shore already used for water, and burned afterward in stone lamps through two winters at least by more hearths than the one household that had first heard the whale come in.

What was left, once the meat and the blubber and the skin had all been taken and the gulls and the foxes had begun on what remained, was the frame of it: ribs longer than a man is tall, curved the whole of that length, white already before the flesh had wholly gone from them, and too heavy for fewer than four hands to lift any one of them clear of the shingle. It is told that no one set out, in the first days after the whale came ashore, to do anything with the bones beyond let the sea and the gulls have them back in their own time, the way any household let a carcase go back to the shore once it had given what it could give; and it is told, just as plainly, that before that first winter had closed, the ribs stood upright in the turf a little back from the high-water mark, driven in at their thicker ends and lashed together in threes and fours at the crown, so that three round houses stood where, a season before, there had been only shingle and the smell of rendering.

The turf that roofed them was cut in long strips from the ground a little above the shingle and laid across the curve of the ribs the way turf was laid across any lighter frame of bent wood or driven stake, but the ribs held a wider span and a taller crown than any house the shore had raised before, so that a grown man could stand upright in the middle of one of the three without his head troubling the roof, a thing not every household's own house allowed him. The households that took up the three whale-rib houses that first winter are not named in any telling that has reached this one, save that they were of the shore nearest the shingle and had first cause, by the plain fact of having heard the surf and come down to look, to whatever the sea had left behind once every other hand had taken its share.

The bone did not last as the driven stake and the bent branch of an ordinary frame lasted. Salt and rain and the slow work of years told on it faster than they told on green wood, and a rib that had stood four winters was found, on the fifth, cracked through where the weight of the turf bore hardest, and had to be shored with a driven stake lashed alongside it or taken down before it brought the roof

with it. The three houses stood, in the shape the whale had first given them, the better part of ten years before the last of the original ribs failed past shoring; and when they were rebuilt, it was on whale-bone again, for by then a second stranding, smaller than the first but of the same kind, had come ashore some way along the same stretch in the years between, and the household had learned, from the first building, how a rib wanted setting and lashing and how deep its foot wanted driving to stand the winters it could be made to stand.

It is told that the frames were raised a third time in the years this telling now follows, on bone from neither of the first two strandings but carried, this third time, some distance along the shore from a whale that had come ashore further west and been cut there by a household with no thought yet of building anything from what it left behind; word of usable ribs travelled, by then, faster along that coast than word of the strandings themselves had once travelled, for the shore had come to know what a length of whale-bone was worth to a household that wanted a house taller and wider than turf laid over branch could give it, and did not wait, the third time, for the bone to come ashore of its own accord below their own stretch of shingle.

Between one raising and the next, the rotted ribs that were taken down rather than shored were left where they had stood, unburned and uncarried, half sunk already into the turf that had grown up thick around their feet, so that a child of the third household to build there, digging one spring for no purpose sharper than a child's own digging, turned up a length of bone gone soft and dark with the years it had lain buried, and could not at first say what kind of thing it was, until an elder, called over, named it for what it had been: the foot of a rib from the first house, sunk and near forgotten under turf that had by then grown as thick over it as over any ground the whale had never touched at all.

The shingle below the three houses kept, through all the years of the first and the second and the third raising, a scatter of smaller bone the cutting had left behind and no one had ever troubled to clear, vertebrae the size of a grinding-stone and finger-bones no bigger than a child's own thumb, worked by the tide and the years into the ordinary stones of that shore until a stranger walking the shingle for the first time might have crossed the whole stretch below the houses without once marking that half of what lay underfoot had come from the sea's own flesh and not from the island's own rock. A household living there long enough came to know one from the other without looking, by the heft of a stone in the hand and the give of it underfoot, the bone always a little lighter for its size than the true

stone lying beside it, though none of that household is remembered ever to have found a word to say why.

Of the second stranding, smaller than the first and further along the same stretch, less is told than of the first, save that it came ashore in calm weather with no gale to announce it, found by a household out at low tide for shellfish rather than woken to it by any change in the sea's own voice, and that the cutting of it, being a smaller thing altogether, was the work of the finding household alone, with no call sent along the shore for other hands to come and share the reckoning. What that household kept from it, beyond the meat and the oil every stranding gave, was the whole set of ribs entire, and it is these, more than the first whale's bones already once rebuilt and once failed, that a household of the third raising is remembered to have chosen, judging bone that had not yet stood a single winter driven upright in wet ground to be worth more than bone twice already shored and twice already failed.

II

Of the Round Houses of the Eastern Vell

A different shore, a good way to the east and south of Dunn¹, held nothing so strange as a whale's own bones for a roof, but raised, in these same years, a cluster of houses in stone the whale-rib builders never troubled to lay: fourteen round houses of dry-built stone, walls two courses thick and near shoulder height before the roof began, set close enough together on the ground the eastern Vell² held that a household leaving one door could all but touch the wall of its neighbour's without crossing open ground at all.

The stone there was got from a scatter of loose slabs and boulders lying thick enough on the ground above the shore that no one household needed to quarry fresh rock to raise a wall; the labour lay instead in the choosing and the fitting, a wall built without mortar of any kind, each stone set and reset until it sat true against its neighbours on every side, the courses above holding the courses below without any binding but their own good fit. A wall raised this way asked more patience than speed of the hands that raised it, for a stone set badly low down was

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

not found out until the courses above it had grown too heavy to lift off again without bringing half the wall down with it, and the households of the eastern Vell are remembered, in what has come down of their own telling, for unbuilding a wall's top courses more than once rather than build on over a stone they had begun, too late, to mistrust.

Each house was raised round rather than square, the walls curving in a little as they climbed until the last courses could be closed over with flat slabs laid corbel-fashion, one edging in past the one below it, until an opening no wider than a man's two hands together remained at the crown, closed at last with turf and a single flat stone laid over the whole. Inside, the floor was sunk a little below the ground outside the door, and at its centre a hearth-pit cut deeper again than the floor around it and lined with smaller stone set on edge, so that the fire burned below the level a draught from the door could easily trouble, and the smoke found its own way up past the corbelled roof and out through whatever gaps the fitting of the last stones had left open at the crown, for no house of that cluster is remembered to have cut a hole on purpose for it.

What the eastern Vell's builders are remembered for beyond the walls and the sunk hearths was a channel cut under the wall at its lowest point, lined the same way the hearth-pit was lined, running out from beneath the floor to open ground some way beyond the house, so that water that gathered on the sunk floor in a wet season, whether rain found its way in past an ill-fitted door or the ground simply rose wetter than usual under the winter's rain, had somewhere to go that was not simply where it happened to lie until it was trodden into mud by every foot that crossed the floor. It is told that not every one of the fourteen houses was given such a drain from its first raising, and that the households without one, watching their neighbours' floors stand drier through a wet winter than their own, took their own floors up in the following dry season and cut the channel in afterward, working it in under a wall already standing rather than build it in from the first course, a harder labour by every account that has come down of it than laying the channel before the wall went up, but done all the same, house by house, until by the years this telling now closes on, every one of the fourteen had its own dry outfall and its own drier floor to show for the labour.

The fourteen houses stood close enough, and were raised near enough in the same years, that no single telling has kept which household raised which first, or in what order the cluster grew from one house to fourteen; what has come down instead is the cluster whole, as a thing already finished and already lived in, doors

facing every way the ground allowed rather than all one way, so that a child born into that press of near neighbours grew up knowing, before it knew much else, which door led to which household's hearth and which threshold belonged to kin close enough to walk in on without first calling from outside. A woman of the cluster is remembered, though not by name, for having been born in one of the fourteen houses, married into another three doors along without ever leaving the same cleared ground the fourteen stood on, and buried at last, by her own household's telling, within sight of both thresholds, the one she was born to and the one she kept; and it is said of her, in the one line the telling has kept whole, that she never in all her years needed to ask a stranger's door twice which household's hearth lay behind it.

The ground between the fourteen doors was worn, within a few years of the last house standing finished, into a hard-packed yard no grass ever troubled again, criss-crossed with the paths every household's own errands wore into it, to the well the cluster shared at its centre, to the midden each kept a little apart from its neighbour's, to whichever threshold a child had been sent to borrow fire from on a morning its own hearth had gone out overnight. A dog loose in that yard on an ordinary day might be fed from three or four hearths before the day was done, none of the fourteen households troubling to ask whose dog it was so long as it answered to being driven off a threshold it had no business lying across; and a stranger come to the eastern Vell for the first time is remembered to have stood some while at the yard's edge before venturing in, unable at first glance to tell, among so many low doors set so close, which belonged to the household with the elder he had been sent to find, until a child playing in the packed yard was asked and pointed the way without stopping its own game.

III

Of the Tower at the North-Western Skell

Further north again, on the coast the north-western Skell¹ held at its farthest and least sheltered reach, a household raised a single tower the like of which no other shore of the island had yet built: round like the fourteen houses of the eastern Vell², but built with a wall thick enough to be hollow through its

1. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

whole height, an inner face and an outer face of dry-laid stone with a stair let into the gap between them, climbing the wall's own thickness in a tight turn from the door at the foot to an open crown at the top, so that a person could go up inside the standing wall without once crossing open floor.

Why that household chose to build hollow rather than raise a plain thick wall as the eastern Vell had done, the telling that has come to this one does not say, save that the ground the north-western Skell held there ran out to open water on three sides at once, and a household settled at such a place had cause, more than most, to want a height from which the sea in every direction could be watched without a climb up onto an exposed roof that the wind off that water might not have let a person keep their footing on for long. The tower's crown, once the stair had climbed the whole height of the wall to reach it, stood open to the sky, ringed by a low parapet no higher than a standing man's waist, and from it the water to the west lay open to the edge of sight on a clear day, with nothing between the tower's foot and the horizon but the sea.

The building of it, by what the telling has kept of the labour, went slower than the raising of any single house of the eastern cluster, for two faces of wall had to be carried up together, course matched to course on either side of the stair's gap, with cross-stones laid at intervals through the gap to bind the inner face to the outer and keep the whole from leaning apart as it climbed; and it is told that the household lost the top of one half-finished stair to a winter storm before the tower stood a third of its final height, the outer face alone thrown down while the inner held, and had to clear the fallen stone from the gap and set the cross-stones closer together through the whole climb of what remained before they trusted the wall to carry a stair any higher.

The first night any of that household spent at the tower's crown, once the stair stood whole and the parapet was laid, fell in a season of clear cold weather with little wind, and is remembered, in the one line of it the telling carries whole, for the plain fact that whoever climbed up that night saw more of the sea at once, by starlight alone, than any of that household had ever seen from any roof or headland they had stood on before, the water running unbroken from directly below the tower's foot out to where the dark of the sea and the dark of the sky no longer could be told apart. What was said on the crown that first night, if anything was said at all beyond what the climb and the sea's own width might draw from a per-

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

son standing where no one of that shore had stood before, the telling does not carry; it keeps only that the climb was made, and that it was made again, by other hands of the same household, on other clear nights in the years that followed, until the crown of the tower had become, for that household, as ordinary a place to stand of an evening as any threshold or any strand.

The tower asked more of its household than the fourteen houses of the eastern Vell had asked of theirs, and the keeping of it once raised was the harder half of that asking, for a stone worked loose high in either face wanted setting again before the next storm found the gap it had opened, and the climb to reach a loose stone near the crown was neither short nor easy; and it is told that the household kept, from the first years the tower stood finished, a habit of walking the whole stair from foot to crown after every storm hard enough to have been worth remarking at all, feeling with a hand along both faces as they climbed for any stone gone slack in its bed, a labour that fell, in the years this telling has followed that household, to whichever of them had the surest foot and the least fear of the narrow dark of the stair, rather than to any one person by right of age or of standing.

The stair was dark through nearly its whole climb, lit only where a gap left on purpose in the outer face let in a narrow blade of daylight at two or three turns of its rise, so that a person climbing learned it as much by the hand trailing the inner wall and the foot's own count of the turns already taken as by anything the eye could make out in the gloom between one blade of light and the next; and a child of that household, sent up for the first time without a grown hand ahead of it to follow, is remembered to have stood some while at the foot of the stair before starting up, and to have counted the turns aloud the whole way, a habit that stayed with the child into a grown age, muttering the count of the stair under its breath even on climbs it no longer had any real need to count.

The household kept, besides the walking of the stair after storms, a second use for the tower beyond the evening climbs to its open crown: when a wind rose out of the west hard enough to make the open water dangerous to any boat still out on it, whoever of the household could be spared went up to the crown and stood watching the water below for as long as the light held, not for any one boat known to be out, for the household's own boats stayed ashore on such days, but on the chance that some other shore's craft, caught further out than its own crew had judged wise, might be seen making for whatever shelter the coast below the tower could offer it; and it is told, though the telling names no year for it, that a boat not of that household's own shore was once seen from the crown standing in

toward the rocks below in weather that would have driven it onto them blind, and that a fire was lit on the parapet in time for its crew to see the coast they were running for and bear off from the worst of the rocks before the light failed altogether; where the boat and its crew went once they had borne off, the telling does not carry.

IV

Of the Huts at Toll and the Sand

Far to the north, on the other coast of the island, where the land ran low into dune country and the wind off the sea had built the sand, over years longer than any telling could set a number to, into ridges taller than a standing man, a household of Toll¹ built a scatter of stone huts in the lee of one such ridge, low-walled and turf-roofed, set close against the dune's own slope so that the ridge's own bulk broke the worst of the wind before it ever reached a wall.

The huts stood some years in the shelter the dune gave them, the dune troubling them no further, the sand that blew loose off its crown in an ordinary autumn gale settling no deeper against the walls than a household's own broom could clear from the threshold each morning, a small and steady labour so ordinary to that shore that no telling has troubled to remark it as labour at all, any more than a shore further south remarked the daily emptying of a fish-trap. Children of that household are remembered for having been set, almost as soon as they could be trusted to swing a broom, to clear the night's blown sand from the door each morning before the grown hands of the household turned to any other work, a task light enough for small hands and steady enough that a child too young yet for heavier work could be given the whole of it and trusted to see it done.

In the year this telling now comes to, a wind rose off the sea that did not settle in a night as the ordinary gales of that coast had always settled, but held through a full day and into a second, driving sand off the dune's whole exposed face in a haze thick enough that a person standing at one hut's door could not, by what the telling has kept of it, make out the next hut along with any certainty, the air gone the colour and near the heft of the ground it carried. The household worked at

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

first as it had always worked, clearing what blew against the walls as fast as the wind piled it there, but the sand came faster than any number of hands could clear it, mounting against the windward wall of the first hut in the row until, by what the telling has kept of the second day's reckoning, it stood higher than the wall itself and had begun to press in over the turf of the roof.

It is told that the household left the huts before the second night of that wind closed on them, carrying what could be carried in the arms and on the back in the little time the sand's own rising gave them warning to judge by, and went inland to higher ground the ridge itself had always sheltered them from having to think about before, waiting out the rest of the storm under whatever cover the higher ground could give a household that had brought no shelter of its own with it. No one of that household is remembered, in any telling that has reached this one, to have been lost in the leaving of the huts, nor hurt beyond what a hard walk through blown sand in the last light of a bad day might be expected to cost any household that made it; the huts themselves are the only thing the telling says the sand kept.

When the wind fell, on the third day, and the household came back down from the higher ground to see what the storm had left them, the row of huts they had built in the dune's lee was not there to be seen at all: the dune had moved forward the whole width of the huts and some way beyond them, and stood, where the huts' doors and thresholds had opened onto level ground the morning before, as an unbroken slope of new sand, paler and looser underfoot than the ridge's older face, with nothing above it to show that a household had ever raised a wall or laid a roof on the ground it now covered. The household dug, in the days that followed, at the edge of the new sand where they judged the nearest hut's door might lie, and found, by what the telling has kept of the digging, enough of a wall and enough of a roof-turf still in place beneath the fresh sand to know that the huts stood yet, whole, under the weight that had come over them, before the digging itself was given up as asking more than it could return, and the household turned instead to raising new walls a little further inland, on ground the dune had not yet claimed and might, by their own reckoning of how the wind and the sand had always worked on that coast before, be trusted not to claim again for longer than any of them now living could expect to see.

Four shores, in the years this telling has followed them, each found its own shelter against what the sky or the sea or the ground itself might otherwise have taken from a household unhoused against it: bone raised against the open air at

Dunn², stone and a hidden channel against the wet ground at the eastern Vell³, a hollow wall and a climbing stair against the wind and the watching sea at the north-western Skell⁴, and, at Toll, walls that in the end kept out neither wind nor sand, but were themselves kept, whole and unbroken, under the one thing they had never been raised to hold back. The household that built there last turned its face inland and did not trouble the buried row again; and the dune that had taken it stood afterward as it stood on the day the digging was given up, its new paler face already beginning, before that year was out, to darken and settle into the same weathered grey as the ridge behind it, with the roofs of Toll's first row lying still and undisturbed beneath it.

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

3. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

4. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Of the Lean Years of the Line

VE 1,951 – 2,097

I

Of the Kilns in the East

At the eastern landing the fires were never all lit at once and never all dark at once, for a household that dried its whole catch on the same night had nothing to eat the night the wind failed and the boats came in empty. So it had been kept since before anyone tending the pits that year had first crawled to them on hands and knees to feel the heat off the stones, and so it was kept still: three kilns fed while three stood cold and swept, the ash from the cold ones carried down to the shingle and given to the tide, the short flues drawing peat-smoke up through racks of split fish laid belly-down until the flesh went the colour of old rope and would keep a season without turning.

The one who minded the middle kiln that year had minded it, in one turn or another, for longer than the youngest of the household could remember any other hand at it, and had in that time worn a path in the turf between the drying racks and the door of her own house that no grass had troubled to grow back over. She judged the smoke by its smell more than by its colour, holding her face low over the flue's mouth at first light and again at dusk, and she judged the fish by the give of the flesh under one finger, and neither judgement had she ever put into words that anyone remembered, teaching it instead the way it had been taught her, by standing a child at her elbow through enough dryings that the child's own hand learned what her mother's had learned before it.

A day's rowing up the coast, along a shore that showed nothing but grey water and grey sky to anyone who did not already know the set of it, another household kept the same three kilns and three, the same racks and the same flues, built by whoever had first carried the way of it between the two landings, in a trade or a gift or a theft the telling of neither shore has ever kept. The two places knew of each other the way a household knows of a cousin's household two valleys off: seldom seen, never in doubt. A boat went between them now and again with dried fish traded for something the one place had and the other lacked, a bundle of sinew, a stone good for scraping hide, and came back before the light failed, for neither crew cared to be caught between the landings after dark on a coast where the current ran stronger than it looked.

The woman who minded the middle kiln had a granddaughter old enough that year to be trusted with the racks alone through a whole low tide, and it was this granddaughter, and no one older, who first noticed that the smoke off the middle kiln ran a shade paler than the smoke off the two beside it, some seasons, without the fire beneath it being fed any different. She said so to her grandmother, expecting to be told what it meant. Her grandmother looked at the flue a long while, and then at the girl, and said only that the smoke told her what the smoke told her, and set the girl to turning the racks, which was answer enough for a child who had asked the question mostly to be spoken to.

That same winter a boat came up from the south with word, passed on the way word travelled between the two landings, that a beast had come ashore dead below the southern kilns and been cut up for its oil, and the eastern household sent back, by the same boat when it turned, a share of dried fish it could ill spare that season, for the giving and the taking between the two places ran both ways over the years and no one there kept any closer account of it than that. The woman who minded the middle kiln put the fish into the returning boat with her own hands, and stood on the shingle watching it go until it was a shape and then nothing against the water, and went back to her racks without a word to anyone about how long she had stood there watching an empty stretch of sea.

II

Of Gormal and the Kin That Went Down

Six hundred years, near enough as the reciters kept it, had gone by since Aodh stood to his knees in the northern sea and watched gual òir¹ ride the swell before a breaker took it under, and in all that span only the sea had answered. The gold burned in the tellers' mouths at every recital, bright as the night it was seen; the other six lay in the leather bag at Tobar dhireach dark as any stone off any hillside, tried against the rain and the wind and the fire together and giving up nothing for the trying.

Gormal had grown up on the trying. She had heard Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich² said standing before she could say the fathers' names back whole herself, had turned the six dark coals over in her own hands as a child the way every child of the line had turned them, and had watched, as she grew, more of the kin lose patience with a question that answered no one in a life or in three lives together. By the time she was keeper of Poit an Teine³ in her own right, past thirty and past the birth of the one daughter who lived, she had buried a father, an aunt and two of her own age who had gone to their graves saying the sky-coal would never light and the line was fools to keep hoping otherwise.

She had been a plain child, by her own later telling of herself, neither the quickest of the kin's daughters nor the slowest, and had come to Poit an Teine only because the aunt who kept it before her had no daughter of her own living and had taken a liking to the girl who sat nearest the hearth without fidgeting through a whole recital. What Gormal had, that the aunt saw in her before anyone else troubled to look, was a memory that did not let a word go once it had taken it in, and a temper that would not let a thing drop merely because it had gone unanswered a long while. She learned the fathers' names from Neachdan down at nine years old, standing them over to the aunt every evening for a whole winter until not a name came out of its place, and she learned Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich the same way, and asked, the first time she heard it whole, why no one had simply tried the thing from higher ground; and the aunt, who had heard every manner of fresh notion offered by children and travellers alike over a long keeping, only smiled at her and said that the hills of the high valleys had all been climbed already by hands with the same notion, and that Gormal would learn, given time, how much a hill could be climbed and still leave the question standing.

1. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

2. the Keeper's riddle

3. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

She would not let the recital go slack for that. It was Gormal's rule, said first to a gathering that had come more out of habit than hope, that the fathers' names and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich after them be said standing every dark-of-the-year night whether any soul under that roof cared to hear it or not, for a thing kept only while it was believed was not a thing kept at all, and a hearth-keeper who let the saying lapse one year would find it harder, not easier, to raise it again the year after. Some of the kin thought her stubborn for it. She let them think so.

Her own daughter, Sìomha, grown to a woman with children of her own by the time the branch made ready to leave, had more than once told her mother to her face that the young of the kin no longer sat still for Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich the way they had once been made to, and that a keeper who wanted the words carried on after her would do better to soften them, to let a child leave the fire once the fathers' names were done rather than hold him through Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich after, when half of them were asleep on their feet before the last line was out. Gormal heard her through and answered that a child who slept through Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich at nine would wake to it at nineteen or at forty, the words being in him whether he had listened with his eyes open or shut, and that she herself had slept through the greater part of a good many recitals as a girl and could say every word of them back all the same. Sìomha did not trouble to argue the point a second time, though she went on saying it, in her own house, to her own children, in gentler words than her mother's.

It was in those same years, while the argument between mother and daughter went on being had and never quite settled, that word came up from the eastern slopes of a good harvest two years running, and then a third, and the branch that had been drifting down in ones and twos for two generations began drifting faster.

That branch was cousins three and four times removed from Gormal's own line, kin all the same by the reckoning that mattered at a hearth, and it had for two generations been walking down to the lower ground where the farms of the eastern slopes gave a man back more than the high valleys ever had for the same digging, the high valleys being stone under thin soil at the best of times and a wind off the moor for most months of the year. Twenty years into Gormal's keeping, the last households of that branch still on the high ground made ready to follow the rest down for good, and when they went they went with a coal from no one's hearth but their own daily fire, carrying not one splinter of the mason's vein with them.

Gormal walked out to meet them the morning they loaded the last of their gear onto two ox-sledges, and stood in the yard while the sledges were lashed, and said what she had come to say plainly, without asking them to stay, for she had asked that of others before and had learned it did no good.

"You go with no coal of the vein in your hand," she said. "In all the years the line has kept the bag, no household has gone from it empty before."

The man who answered her, a grandson of her own grandfather's brother, did not stop lashing the sledge while he spoke. "We have carried the dark coals up every hill within a day's walk of here, grandmother's kin, and thrown them off every one, and they have come back dark every time. What is there left in a stone that will not answer for six hundred years?"

"You have thrown them from every hill you could reach in a day," Gormal said. "You have not thrown them from the highest ground this island owns, and no two of you agree, even now, which ground that is."

That checked him, though only for a breath. "Then let whoever agrees on it climb it," he said. "We have farms waiting that do not care what the sky thinks of us." And he went back to the lashing, and within the hour the sledges were moving down the track east with the whole branch walking behind them, children and dogs and all, and none looked back at the high valleys they left, so far as anyone watching from Tobar dhìreach that morning could see.

Gormal did not let the matter drop merely because the branch had. She raised it at more than one recital after, standing at the fire with the leather bag in her lap and the coals laid out on a cloth before her, sky and earth and sea, and put to whoever would hear her the same thing she had put to the man at the sledges: that the sea had been thrown into by a man who had never before seen it, and had answered at once, on the very shore where he first laid eyes on it; that the sky, by the same reasoning that had served the sea, ought to be tried from the ground that stood nearest it, and that no ground on the whole island stood nearer the sky than the highest of it, wherever that proved to be. She named three hills she herself judged for the honour, one south of the black well, one west toward Achadh dhìreach, and the third, the one she came back to oftenest in her last years, a bare shoulder of moor she had walked to once as a young woman and never forgotten the wind of. The old men of the kin argued each for a different one of the three, and some for a fourth she had not named, and none of the arguing settled anything in her lifetime, for no one among them had climbed all of the candidates

and come down able to say with a clear conscience which had stood highest under his own feet.

She kept Poit an Teine and the bag until the year she died, in her seventy-fifth year, and on the last recital she stood for, her voice gone thin but the words unfaltering, she said Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich as she had said it every year of her keeping and then added, which was not in the fixed words and was never repeated by the reciters after her exactly as she said it, that the line had thrown the coals from every hill it could be troubled to climb and had still not thrown from the one that mattered, and that whoever first agreed with his own eyes which hill that was would do the line more good in an afternoon than the branch that had gone down to the farms would do it in ten generations of easier digging. She died that winter in the house she had kept Poit an Teine in her whole life, with Sìomha at one side of the bed and a granddaughter at the other, the fire fed and the leather bag within her reach though she no longer had the strength to lift it on her own. Near the end she asked to have the six dark coals laid out on the blanket where she could see them, and lay looking at them a long while without speaking. When Sìomha asked if she wanted Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich said once more, she shook her head; she had said it enough times in her own life, she told her daughter, that saying it again over a dying woman's bed would only ease the living, not answer the sky. It needed saying to someone who still had years enough left to climb a hill in. The bag and the question passed, as the recital passed, to hands that had heard her say both enough times to say them back the same way, and the three hills she had named were argued over at more than one hearth for years after, without the argument once coming nearer an end than it had stood the day she named them.

III

Of the Oyster Beds in the South

On the southern coast, where a long low headland ran out into water shallow enough that a child could wade past a man's height of it before the bottom dropped away, one shore had built its whole living on a shellfish so plentiful there that no other trade had ever taken firm root beside it. The oysters lay thick along the headland's whole seaward face, packed close enough in places that a rake drawn once through the shallows at low water came up heavier

than two hands could easily carry, and generation on generation of the same households had done little else with their days than rake them, open them, eat what could be eaten fresh and dry what could be dried, and pile the empty shells where the tide would not soon take them back.

The pile they made of it, by the time anyone now living there could remember, ran the whole length of the headland and stood, at its oldest and thickest end, higher than a tall man could reach with his arm above his head, whiter at its crown where gulls had picked it clean and greyer with age the deeper a hand dug into it. Children of that shore were set, almost as soon as they could be trusted not to cut themselves on a broken edge, to carrying the day's empty shells up to whichever part of the mound was that season's dumping-place, and grew up thinking of the heap the way a hill-country child thought of the hill behind its own house, a thing that had simply always stood there and would go on standing after they themselves were gone from the shore.

The lowest layers of that mound, where the oldest shells lay, held oysters bigger by half than any taken from the same water in the memory of the raking households still living, broad as a spread hand and thick-shelled enough that opening one wanted a harder blow than a fresh catch ever needed. No one on that shore troubled over why the old shells ran larger than the new; the water gave what the water gave, in whatever size it chose to give it in a given generation, and a household that had raked the same beds for as long as any of them could reckon had learned not to ask questions of a tide that answered none of them. There was little else to that shore beyond the raking and the eating and the piling: no ramps for hulls, no kilns for drying fish, no mole against a current, for the water there ran shallow and gentle the whole year and gave up its harvest to a rake and a strong back with nothing else asked of anyone. A household that wanted a hull for deeper water went without rather than build one, for there was little enough deep water within reach of that shore to make the building worth the trouble, and a family that wanted dried fish traded a basket of oysters for it at whichever landing further along the coast had fish to spare, walking the trade there on its own feet rather than by any boat of its own.

The rake itself was the one tool that shore troubled to make with any care, a length of bent wood with a row of teeth lashed along its lower edge, each tooth shaped and fitted by whichever household's hands were freest that season, and a rake once well made was kept and mended rather than replaced, passed on at a death to whoever in the house had the surest arm for using it. A woman known

along that shore for the truest rake anyone there could remember had made it as a girl under an aunt's eye and used no other through a life long enough to see her own granddaughters raking beside her with rakes of their own making, and when she died the rake went to the granddaughter judged strongest in the arm, who used it in her turn until it wanted mending past any mending and was laid, by a custom none of that shore explained to anyone who was not of it, on the mound rather than burned or thrown back to the sea.

An old woman of that shore, whose own hands had raked oysters from the same stretch of headland for longer than she herself cared to count, was known to sit some evenings on the crown of the oldest part of the mound with a broad shell from its lowest layer turned over in her lap, running a thumb along its ridged outer face the way another woman might run a thumb along the rim of a well-used bowl, and to say nothing at all about it to whichever grandchild had come to sit with her, for there was nothing in it that wanted saying beyond what the shell already said by its own size and weight, and a shore that had lived on the same harvest for longer than its own oldest teller could reckon had long since stopped feeling any need to say more about it than that.

IV

Of the Second Landing

Far to the north-east, along a stretch of coast none of the shore's own tellers ever set beside the first without a pause, a household laid slabs of flat stone edge to edge down the shelving shore into deep water, wide enough for hulls greater than any hide boat, and walked hulls down them exactly as another household had done, generations before, on the northern coast far to the west, at a landing that bore, by whatever chance carried a name across so much land and water, the very same name as this one.

Whether the two households had ever been one people, split by some journey or some quarrel too old for either shore to keep in its own telling, or whether only the name had travelled between them, carried by a trader or a wanderer who had seen the first ramps and given the second place its word without ever giving it the people who built the first, no teller of either coast, then or after, was ever known to say, and none of the hill-folk who might otherwise have puzzled over it ever came near enough that shore to ask.

The work went as such work always went: a slab judged and levered and set, a length of green log laid and greased with fish-oil and left to season under a spread of brush until it would bear a hull's whole weight without splitting, a first small boat walked down the finished ramp on a still morning with half the household standing along the bank to watch it take the water clean, no different in the taking than the first hull had taken the water at the western landing so long before that not one soul now living at either place had any memory, or any telling handed down of a memory, of which ramp had gone into the water first.

The old man who judged the stones for this second set of ramps had learned the judging, as every hand at that work learned it, from another who had learned it before him, back through a line of judging hands that ran further than the household's own memory could reach, so that no one now at the second landing could have said whether the way of laying a ramp down into deep water had been carried whole from the first landing in one crossing, brought by some ancestor who had rowed or walked between the two in a single lifetime, or had grown up new at the second place out of the same sea and the same need working on hands that had never once seen the first ramps with their own eyes. He himself favoured neither telling over the other when a grandchild pressed him for one, saying only that a ramp that carried a hull was a ramp that carried one, wherever the knowing of it had first come from, and that a boy more interested in where a thing came from than in whether it worked would make a poor judge of stones.

By the second summer there were two ramps standing side by side where there had been one, and a household grown confident enough in the work to let its youngest hands set the smaller stones under the old ones' eyes rather than under their hands, and by the third there was a third ramp begun a little apart from the first two, for a household with hulls enough now to want more room than two ramps gave it. A boy of that household, sent one autumn morning to carry word along the bank that the tide had turned, is remembered by whoever first told this of him to have stood a long while at the water's edge before he ran his errand, looking at the two, and then the three, long pale ramps running down into the same grey water that had carried away, out of any memory the shore now kept, whatever hands had first thought to lay stone into the sea in that particular way; and he ran his errand at last, as he had been sent to, and said nothing to anyone of what he had stood looking at, for it was, to him as to every other soul on that coast, no more than the ramps his own household used every day of the boating season, twin to another set of ramps on a shore he had never seen and never

would, and no cause, so far as that shore's own telling ever carried it, for a boy already late on his errand to stand and wonder over it any longer than he did.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

OF FEARGHAS ON THE HEIGHT

VE 2,098 – 2,240

I

Of the Two Brothers and the Three Hills

Gormal had been five generations in the ground before anyone climbed for her. The bag with its six dark coals hung where it had always hung, in a niche cut in the wall above Poit an Teine¹ at Tobar dhìreach, and Tòimh-seachan a' Choimhdich² was said standing at every dark-of-the-year recital exactly as she had left it, sky and earth and sea, and no one born since her death had thrown a coal from anywhere higher than the shoulder of moor she herself had once favoured and never climbed. The three hills she had named went on being argued at hearths that had never known her, the argument outliving the woman who had started it, the way a fire outlives the hand that first struck it.

Fearghas grew up on that argument the way every child of the high valleys grew up on it, hearing it before he could walk to the door on his own legs and forgetting to be surprised by it long before he was grown. He had it from his mother, as the recital had kept it since Gormal's day, and he heard it said the same way every year at the recital: the sea answered when a man who had never seen it stood on its shore and put a coal into it; the sky, by the same reckoning, wanted the ground nearest it, and no ground on the whole island stood nearer the sky than the highest, wherever that proved to be. He turned the six dark coals over in his

1. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

2. the Keeper's riddle

own hands more than once as a boy, the way every child of the line turned them, weighing nothing in his palm but stone, and put them back in the bag without either of the wonder or the doubt that older mouths brought to the same handling.

His brother Mathan was three years the elder and had none of Fearghas's patience for sitting still through the whole of a recital, but he had a longer stride and a surer foot on wet rock than any of the kin his own age, and it was Mathan, not Fearghas, who first said aloud what the two of them had each been turning over apart for a year or more: that a question asked since the grove was not going to answer itself while the line sat arguing at its own hearth which hill among three it had never troubled to climb was the one that mattered. Fearghas was nine and twenty that summer, Mathan two and thirty, and neither of them had climbed higher than the ridge behind Tobar dhìreach where the sheep went in the hard months.

"Gormal named three," Fearghas said, "and none of the three agreed with the other two."

"Gormal never climbed further than her own doorstep to name them," said Mathan, who had never had much reverence for a woman five generations dead. "She named what she could see from where she stood. We have legs."

They went first to the hill south of the black well, the nearest of Gormal's three, on a morning fine enough that half the kin thought it no more than an outing, and stood on its crown by midday with the wind pulling at their cloaks and the whole run of the high valleys laid out below them, brown and green and grey, and Mathan looked west and said that the shoulder of moor Gormal had favoured stood plainly higher than the ground they were standing on, and Fearghas, looking the same way, was not sure he agreed, for a hill seen across a valley cheats the eye as often as it tells true, and a man standing on one height has no sure way of judging another he has not stood on himself. They argued it there on the crown until the light began to go, and came down no wiser than they had gone up, save that they had learned between them that Gormal's three hills could not be judged one against another from any one of the three, and that the only honest way to settle it was to walk to each in its turn and stand on it, and then walk on to whatever ground beyond it still looked higher, and keep walking until no ground anywhere in sight looked higher than the ground they stood on.

It took the better part of two years, the walking. They went out in the fair months and came back before the hard ones, for neither of them was fool enough

to be caught on open ground in a Dia-thìr winter with no more shelter than a cloak, and each season's walking carried them a little further south than the season before, past hills that had looked from a distance like the last word on the matter and proved, once climbed, to have a taller neighbour standing behind them all along, hidden by the very ridge that had seemed, from below, to be the whole of the sky's edge. More than once they stood on a crown certain they had found it at last, only to see, once the low haze burned off toward noon, a paler shoulder of rock further off still, standing clear over everything nearer, and to know without needing to say it to each other that the walking was not done.

They quarrelled the whole way, as brothers will who are agreed on the errand and disagreed on every step of it. Mathan wanted to trust his eye and be done; Fearghas wanted to trust nothing he had not stood on with his own two feet, and would not let a hill go unclimbed merely because it looked the lesser of two from where they already stood, for he had seen enough by then to know how often the eye lied on ground it had not walked. More than once Mathan called him stubborn to his face, and Fearghas answered, more than once, that a stubborn man who climbed every hill in his path would find the true one eventually, and a quick one who trusted his eye might die old on the wrong summit and never know it.

In the second summer they fell in with a herder driving a small flock along a saddle of moor neither of them had crossed before, an old man with a dog and a stick and a face burned dark by more winds than either brother had yet walked into, and when they told him what they were about, in the plain words the whole high country used for it by then, he stood a while chewing on nothing and looking south past their shoulders before he answered. He had grazed that ground man and boy, he said, and every ground a day's walk from it besides, and there was a shoulder further on, past a burn he named and a stand of stunted thorn he named after it, that his own father had sworn stood higher than anything nearer the valleys, though the old man himself had never gone to prove it, having sheep enough to mind without chasing his father's notions over open moor. He gave them the way of it as well as he could, pointing with the stick, and went on after his flock without asking why two young men of Clann a' Chlachair³ wanted such ground, for the line's long business with the coals was known well enough by then that a herder needed no telling of it twice.

They found the burn and the thorn on the fourth day after, and beyond them the shoulder the old man's father had sworn by, and stood on it in a driving rain

that let them see nothing at all of what lay further south, and came down soaked through and short-tempered with each other over whether the climb had been worth the wetting. It was three days more, the rain cleared and the ground drying under them, before they climbed it again in better weather and saw, from its crown, the same bare grey summit with the cloud on it, which by the third summer they had proved beyond doubting to be the one true height; but that first sight of it, small and far off and half hidden in its own weather, taught Fearghas, he said afterward, more of patience than the whole two years before had taught him, for a man who had climbed a hill in the wet only to find a truer one waiting beyond it, still half a season's walking off, learned either to give the search up for good or to trust that the walking itself would end somewhere, in its own time, whether he could yet see the end of it or not.

It was in the third summer, walking a ridge neither of them had gone near before, bare rock breaking through thin turf and the wind already colder than it had any right to be so early in the season, that they came out from behind a shoulder of stone and saw, standing clear above every other height in every direction the eye could reach, a bare grey summit with cloud dragging along its top like smoke off a hearth that would not settle. Neither of them said anything for a while. Then Mathan said, low, that they had found it, and Fearghas, who had learned by then not to trust a first look, said only that they would know when they had stood on it and looked from there, and not before.

II

Of the Climb

They went up for it at the turn of the summer in the third year of their walking. He was thirty-two that year, Mathan five and thirty, and both of them had grown lean and hard-legged on three summers of walking ridges, so that the climb, when they came to it at last, felt to Fearghas less like a beginning than like the last stride of a road they had already been three years on.

They carried the six dark coals in the leather bag, wrapped in a fold of hide against the wet, and Fearghas carried it himself the whole way, slung from his shoulder under his cloak the way Neachdan was said to have carried Teine a'

3. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

Chlachair¹ home under his, though no one at Tobar dhìreach had made that likeness aloud before Fearghas set out, and he did not make it aloud either, only felt the weight of the bag against his hip on every stride and thought of it once or twice without meaning to.

They set out from the camp they had made at the foot of the climb on the first evening of an t-Sultain, meaning to sleep an hour or two and go up with first light, but the wind came on hard after dark and neither of them slept much, lying in the lee of a boulder with their cloaks pulled tight and the coals in their wrapping between them, and so it was still black night, the second of an t-Sultain not yet an hour old, when Mathan sat up and said there was no more sleep to be had lying still and freezing for it, and they might as well be climbing.

The lower slopes went easily enough, turf and loose scree and here and there a burn to cross by stepping-stone, and they climbed in the last of the dark and the first grey of the morning without much need of speech between them, each finding his own footing by feel where the light was not yet enough to see it. Higher up the turf gave out and the rock came through bare, and the wind, which had been at their backs on the lower ground, found them from every side at once as the ridge narrowed, so that Fearghas felt it less as a wind from any one quarter than as a thing that had been waiting for them on the height and now had them where it wanted them.

The cold on the summit, when they came out onto it at last with the sun not yet clear of the eastern sea, was a cold that got into the back of the jaw and made the teeth ache, a cold neither of them had felt on any of the lower hills they had climbed the two summers before, though the season below was still warm enough for haymaking. Fearghas stood a while with his hand over his mouth before he trusted himself to speak, and when he took the hand away his breath went out of him in a plume that the wind tore apart before it had gone the length of his arm.

There was no growing thing on that top, not so much as the toughest moor-grass, only bare stone scoured pale by weather that never let up on it, and a scatter of loose rock at the summit's crown where frost had been working at it longer than any teller could reckon. The two of them stood at the highest point of it, where the ground fell away on every side, and turned slowly on their heels, and saw the sea.

It stood at every edge of the island at once, shining where the early sun caught it, grey-gold to the east and a deeper grey to the north and west where the light

had not yet reached, and between the sea and the two of them lay the whole of Dia-thìr laid out below in one sweep neither of them had ever seen it in before, valleys and ridges and the pale threads of rivers, and away to the north, small and grey and impossibly distant, a shoulder of higher moor that Fearghas knew, without needing to be told, for the ground where the mason had struck his wedge into the rock two thousand years before. He had never in his life thought of Tobar dhìreach as a small place. From where he stood it looked no bigger than a thumbnail held at arm's length.

Mathan spoke first, and his voice came out thinner than Fearghas had ever heard it, the wind taking half the words before they had gone a yard. "There is nothing higher than this on the whole island. Nothing anywhere in sight stands over it."

"No," Fearghas said, and found his own voice no steadier. "There is nothing."

He unwrapped the coals with hands that had gone stiff and clumsy in the cold, kneeling at the steep southern edge of the summit where the rock fell away in a long broken slope toward the lower ridges, the wind trying the whole time to take the hide wrapping out of his fingers and carry it off over the drop. Mathan crouched beside him and said nothing more, and for a while there was only the wind and the small sounds of Fearghas working the knots loose, and somewhere below them, very far off, a bird crying over open ground.

Fearghas took the first coal out, the one with the gleam of silver under its black, and held it a moment in his open palm, feeling nothing from it but its own cold weight, and then let it fall from the height of his own arm, out over the drop, the way a man drops a stone into a well to hear how deep it goes.

It struck the slope some way below and lay still. He let the second fall, and the third, watching each all the way down to be sure, and each struck and lay as dark and cold as it had left his hand. The fourth went the same way. Mathan had stopped speaking altogether by then, watching the drop with his jaw set, and Fearghas found that his own hands had begun to shake, not wholly from the cold.

He took out the fifth, the one flecked all over with small white marks like stars caught in dark water, and held it a moment longer than the others, turning it once so the flecks caught what light there was, and then opened his hand and let it go.

It did not fall far.

1. the mason's fire, the first fire

Fearghas watched it turn once in the air, no more than the height of two men below the edge, and then it was burning. There was no smoke first, no slow catching such as a hearth-fire takes from tinder; one moment it was a falling stone and the next it was a small fierce whiteness in the grey morning air, white as nothing Fearghas had ever seen a flame be, sharp-edged against the dull rock behind it like a star fallen out of its place and still burning where it had no business to burn, with no fuel under it and nothing around it but empty air and the fall. It struck the slope below still alight and did not go out on the striking, and lay there among the cold grey stones burning white and steady in the wind that could not put it out any more than the rain, so long before, had put out the vein in Neachdan's well.

Neither of them moved for a long moment. Then Mathan let out a sound that was half a laugh and half something with no name to it, and gripped Fearghas by the shoulder hard enough to hurt, and Fearghas found that he was on his knees at the very edge of the drop with the cold stone biting through his knees and had no memory of kneeling there, only of watching the small white fire below him and feeling, for the first time in his life, that the thing the whole line had been asking after for twelve hundred years was a true thing that answered, when a man found the right way to ask it, and no mere story told at a hearth.

"It is the sky's," Fearghas said, when he had breath enough to say anything. "Gormal was right. It only wanted the right ground under it."

They climbed down to where the coal lay, a slower going than the climb up, for the cold had stiffened their hands and the drop was steep and loose underfoot, and stood over it a long while before either of them would touch it. It burned on, small and white and even, giving off no smoke that either of them could see and no more heat than a man might feel from a hearth-coal held at arm's length, and it did not sink into ash the way a burning thing should, only went on burning, as steady on the third hour as it had been on the first.

They left it there. Neither of them said so to the other in so many words, but each knew without asking that the coal had found its own place and its own element and had no more business being carried home in a pot than gual òir², so long before, had had any business being fished back out of the northern sea. Fearghas gathered the four cold coals from the slope, and let the sixth fall after them for the sake of the telling, and it struck and lay as cold as the rest; and he wrapped

2. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

all five again in the hide, and the two of them climbed back to the summit and stood there a last while with the sun well up now and the whole island bright below them, and Mathan, who had never in his life been given to solemn gestures, stooped and set one loose stone from the summit's crown atop another, a small cairn no higher than a man's hand, and said nothing over it, and Fearghas understood the doing of it without needing the saying.

III

Of the Naming and the Cairn on the Height

They came down off the height in two days, going carefully on legs that had gone stiff with the cold and the standing, and reached Tobar dhìreach on the evening of the second day with the five cold coals in the bag and nothing else to show for a climb of three summers' finding and two days' doing, and yet the whole household knew before either of them had said a word that something had answered, for Fearghas came through the door with a look on him that no one at that hearth had worn coming back from any hill before.

He told it standing, as the telling of such things was always told at that hearth, with the bag open on the floor before him and the five dark coals laid out on a cloth for anyone to see and turn over who wanted to, and the household sat late into the night hearing it twice through, once from Fearghas and once, because Mathan would not be left out of the telling of a thing he had climbed for as long and as hard as his brother, from Mathan, whose telling ran shorter and rougher but agreed with Fearghas's in every particular that mattered. The old women who kept Gormal's saying at the recital wept at the hearing of it, the same weeping the old women were said to have wept the night Aodh came home from the northern sea, eight hundred years before, and by morning the telling had gone out from that hearth to every household within a day's walk, carried by whoever had heard it first and could not keep from carrying it further.

The summit took the kindred's name before that first winter was out, called Binnean a' Chlachair¹ from the first telling of it and by no other name after, Binnean a' Chlachair, though no one household could afterward say for certain who had first called it so; it was as if the name had been waiting on the height the

1. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

whole two thousand years since the mason struck his wedge into the rock, needing only a household willing to climb high enough to claim it. Herders of the high valleys who drove their flocks anywhere within sight of that grey summit began, within a few years of the telling, to leave a single stone on its crown whenever their own way brought them near enough to climb it, a small stone laid without much ceremony on the little cairn Mathan had begun, so that within a lifetime the crown that had been bare rock scoured clean by weather carried a heap of stone a man could see from some way off, each stone laid by a different hand and none of the hands ever troubling to say why, beyond that it seemed a poor thing to stand on such ground and leave nothing of oneself there.

Fearghas went back to the height himself twice more in his life, once with his own son grown old enough to make the climb, to show the boy the white fire still burning steady among the cold stones of the slope below the summit, unchanged in every particular from the morning he had first seen it catch, and once alone, in his last years, when his legs were no longer what they had been at two and thirty and the climb took him the better part of three days each way instead of two. He found the coal burning that third time exactly as he had left it every time before, and stood over it a long while in the cold, an old man now, remembering a morning when his own hands had shaken with more than cold, and left a stone of his own on the crown before he climbed down for the last time.

IV

Of the Years After

Mathan did not live to see his brother's second climb. He died in his fifty-sixth year, of a fever that came on him in a wet spring and would not break, and was buried at Tobar dhìreach with the small cairn stone he had kept from the summit's crown, the very first one he had ever set there, closed in one hand at his own asking, for he had told his wife, in the last days when he could still speak clearly, that he wanted something of the height with him in the ground, having given the height, as he put it, three summers of his legs and the best notion he had ever had in his life. Fearghas stood over the grave and said nothing that the household later remembered as fit for the recital, only that his brother had trusted his eye from the first day on the ridge and had been right from the first day, whatever the walking after had cost either of them to prove it.

Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹ went on being asked at every recital after, for five of na Seachd Guail² still lay dark, the earth and the blood and the river and the fire, and the rainbow last of all, still to be found by hands not yet born, and the line did not grow easy merely because the sky had answered where the sea had answered before it; if anything, Fearghas himself was heard to say more than once, an old man by then, that a question answered twice in twelve hundred years was no cause for slackness, only for the patience to keep asking it a third time and a fourth. But something had changed at that hearth all the same, in a way none of the kin could easily have put into words. A household that has thrown one coal into the sea and had it answer, and thrown a second from the height of the whole island and had it answer too, keeps the other five with a different weight in its hands than a household that has only ever heard the throwing told as another household's story.

Fearghas himself lived into his sixty-second year, an old man by the standards of the high valleys though not the eldest anyone at that hearth had known, and he kept his own hand steady enough to turn the five remaining dark coals over by his own fire almost to the last, saying to whoever sat with him in those final months that he had climbed the highest ground the island owned and stood there with his own two feet under him, and a man who had done that once in his life had no great cause to fear a bed.

He was buried within sight of Leac na Fèithe³ that covered the mason's own vein, as every keeper and every finder of the line had been buried before him, and at the recital said over his grave that winter, standing as every recital of the fathers was said standing, the reciter gave the fathers' names down from Neachdan and Conall and Diarmad and Aodh, thirty-one fathers whose names the line no longer gave to strangers, down to the last of them, who was the father of Fearghas; and after his father's name the reciter said Fearghas's own, and told, in the fixed words that would be said the same way at every recital after, how he had climbed to the top of the island with his brother beside him and let the six coals fall, and how the snowflake had taken fire in the empty air and struck the stones below still burning, and how the summit bore the kindred's name from that day for as long as anyone should climb it. The old among the household, who had heard Gormal's own three hills argued over at that same hearth every winter of their

1. the Keeper's riddle

2. the Seven Coals

3. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhireach

childhood, stood through the whole of it with their heads bent, and when the reciter came to the naming of the height, more than one of them was heard to say the name back under their breath before the reciter had finished saying it aloud, as though the word had been waiting in them the whole long while since Gormal first named her hills, needing only someone to climb high enough to give it a place to stand.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Of the Cliff-house and the Curved Mole

VE 2,241 – 2,523

I

Of the Long House at Tarr

At Tarr¹, in the north-east, where the cliff broke back on itself into a cleft wide enough for a household to stand upright in and deep enough that the wind off the water lost most of its strength before it reached the innermost wall, a household built a single long house against the living rock rather than free of it, so that the cleft's own back became the house's back, and no wall needed raising where the cliff already stood higher than any wall a household could have built for itself. The floor they levelled with beach shingle carried up in baskets a load at a time, and the walls that closed the cleft's mouth were laid dry, stone on stone, no higher than was needed to keep out what the cliff itself did not already keep out, so that from the sea the house showed as little more than a darker line across the cleft's opening, easy to pass without marking at all unless a boat came close enough in to see the smoke.

The hearth they set against the rock face itself, a little back from the door, where the draught that found its way past the stones outside would not trouble a low flame, and it burned there through every season the household kept the house, fed on driftwood gathered along the shingle below and on whatever the sea gave up after a hard blow, so that in time the rock above the hearth blackened with soot to the height of a tall man standing, a stain no scrubbing ever lightened

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

and none of the household ever tried to lighten, for a blackened stone over a hearth was no more remarkable to them than a blackened pot, and told only that the fire had been kept a long while in the one place. A child of that household, grown old enough to be sent for wood on her own, is remembered to have measured her own growing by that stain, standing back to it each year at midwinter to see how much further up the rock her own crown now reached, until the year she stood as tall as the soot itself and was told, by whoever stood the measuring with her, that she had grown past what the fire alone could tell her.

The winter that gave the household its hardest year came some years into their keeping of the cleft, when the wind held out of the north for the better part of two months without once swinging round to give the coast a day's rest from it, and the sea below the cliff ran white from the rocks out to as far as the cleft's mouth let anyone see, so that no boat put out from Tarr that whole stretch and the household lived on what it had already dried and salted and on shellfish gathered at low water between one gale and the next, work that fell hardest on whoever's hands were quickest and least troubled by the cold, for a slow hand on the rocks in that weather came back with less than the tide alone would have given it and sometimes did not come back with fingers it could feel at all. The driftwood ran thin before the wind did, and toward the worst of it the household burned what it could spare of a broken boat-frame kept those several years against just such a want, stripping it plank by plank rather than let the hearth go cold, and is remembered to have argued, in whatever words that argument took, over how much of the frame could be burned before there was not boat enough left in it to mend once the weather turned.

It turned at last a little before the shortest day, the wind dropping out of the north in the space of a single night and swinging round to a quarter that let the sea inside the cleft's mouth lie flat enough by morning for a hand to be put over the side without the cold of it stopping the breath outright, and the household is remembered to have gone down to the shingle that morning before the light was properly up, wanting nothing from the calm so soon beyond the standing in it, a place out of the wind at last where they could feel, for the first time in two months, a stillness that did not mean the storm was only drawing breath before it came again. What they found on the tide that morning, driven in against the rocks below the cleft, was a run of small fish thick enough to be taken by hand from the shallows, more than the household could eat fresh or dry before it turned, and it is told, in the one line of that winter's telling that has come down

whole, that no year after was reckoned as hard as that one by anyone of Tarr who had lived through it, however hard a later winter might in its own turn have seemed while it was being lived.

The house stood the better part of that household's years in the cleft, mended where the sea reached it and left alone where the cliff already stood firm enough to need no mending, and a household coming after them kept the same hearth against the same blackened rock rather than clear the stain and begin again, holding, by whatever reasoning shaped it, that a fire already so long fed in one place burned the readier for being lit again where it had always been lit, and that a hearth moved even the width of the house lost something of what the years already spent there had given it.

Outside the one door the cleft allowed, a shelf of rock ran a little above the tide's ordinary reach, wide enough for a man to stand and cast from without wetting his feet, and the household kept its lines there through every season the fish ran close enough in to be worth the casting, coiling the wet cord each evening on a peg driven into a crack in the cliff face rather than carry it inside where the damp of it would trouble the floor. A boy of the household, sent out one still morning to draw water from a pool the tide filled and left standing among the rocks below the shelf, is remembered to have called the whole household out at a run for what he took at first sight to be a seal hauled up close under the cliff, and to have been laughed at gently, once the thing was seen plainly for a length of drifted timber turned dark and round-backed by the sea's own working of it, though the timber itself was kept afterward and split for firewood rather than thrown back, the fright it had given him judged no reason to waste good wood.

Winters lighter than the hardest one still asked their own toll of the household, for the cleft that broke the worst of the wind also kept the sun from the door through the shortest months, the cliff standing high enough on either side that the shingle floor saw direct light for no more than an hour at midday even on a clear one, and a household living so many years in that half-dark is remembered to have kept, without any of its own tellings troubling to say who began the custom, a second small fire lit just inside the door on the darkest days, fed lighter than the great hearth against the rock and let burn low, more for the little more light it gave the doorway than for any warmth the great hearth further back did not already give the whole house.

II

Of the Vell on the Abhainn Bheag

A day's walk and more to the west of Tarr¹, where the Abhainn bheag ran down to the sea through banks steep enough on either side that a household building close to the water needed to cut its own level ground into the slope before it could raise a wall at all, a small Vell² grew up a short way above the river's mouth: four houses set close along the cut ground, and beside them, nearer the water than any of the four, a boat-shed roofed the same way as the houses but longer and lower, built to keep a hull dry and out of the weather between one season's use and the next rather than to shelter anyone sleeping in it. No dwelling of the Seann-Dhaoine³ on the whole of that coast stood further to the north-east than the four houses at this Vell, a fact none of the four households troubled to remark on in any telling that has come down of them, for a household living at the world's furthest edge in its own day rarely knows itself to be living there, and knows only that its own water runs cold and its own reach up the coast finds nothing further before the shore itself gives out.

The river gave the Vell what the open sea further along the coast could not always be trusted to give: eels taken in wicker traps set where the current ran slow enough near the bank for a trap to hold its place, and salmon in their season, run thick enough some years that a household needed only to wade into the shallows with a spear and strike without much troubling to aim, the fish crowding past in such numbers that a poor cast found another target within the same breath as a good one missed its first. The boat-shed held one hull built for the river's own quieter water rather than for the open sea beyond its mouth, flat enough in the bottom to be poled up past the first rapids in a dry season when the current ran low, and the household that built it is remembered to have gone further up the Abhainn bheag in that boat than any of the four households had gone on foot, coming back with word of ground upriver that none of them, in the years that followed, ever troubled to walk out and see for themselves, holding the word of the boat's own crew good enough without the seeing.

A child of the Vell, born into the youngest of the four households in the years the boat-shed still smelled of its own new-cut timber, grew up knowing the river

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

before she knew the sea it ran to, and is remembered, once grown, for having gone down to the river's mouth on a still evening and stood a long while looking out past it at the open water beyond, water wider and greyer than anything the river itself had ever shown her, before turning back up the bank to the four houses without going any further down the shore to see what lay beyond the mouth in either direction. It is told that she never went that further way in all her years at the Vell, holding, when asked, that a mouth was as far as a river's own child had any business going before the river's own water gave out under her, and that what a boat might carry a person to beyond that mouth was the boat's own business and not hers.

The four houses stood close enough to the water that a hard spring flood, coming once in a run of years when snow high on the central massif melted faster than the ground could carry it away, rose far enough up the bank to reach the boat-shed's lower course and stood there the better part of a day before falling back, leaving the shed's floor silted with river mud that took a household the best part of a week to clear, working the mud out in baskets the same way the shingle at Tarr had once been carried up in baskets, though no one at the Vell on the Abhainn bheag ever knew, or had any way to know, that a household so far along the coast from them was that same year carrying the same kind of load for much the same reason. After that flood the boat-shed was raised a course higher on its uphill side, and no later flood, however high the snow-melt ran, troubled the hull kept inside it again in the years this telling follows.

The four households ate well enough in most years to spare a share of their eel-catch and their salmon both, dried and smoked over slow fires built for no other purpose, for kin further down the coast who kept no river of their own and were glad of a fish that did not taste of salt water in every bite; and word of what the Vell on the Abhainn bheag could spare travelled, by whatever slow paths word travelled along that shore, far enough that a household from two days' walk to the south is remembered to have come up once in a lean year with nothing to trade but a good store of dried seaweed and a promise of help at the next boat-launching, and to have gone home again with more dried fish than the promise alone seemed to the Vell's own households worth, given all the same because a household that asked plainly for help in a lean year was not, by the Vell's own reckoning, a household to be sent away counting.

The eel-traps wanted mending every season the willow they were woven from dried and split in the sun between one setting and the next, and the weaving of a

new trap fell, in the years this telling follows, mostly to an old woman of the youngest household who had learned the pattern as a girl from hands older still than her own, and who is remembered to have taught it in turn to two of the Vell's children, a boy and a girl both, holding that a pattern known only in one pair of hands was a pattern one bad season from being lost to the whole Vell, whatever a river running full of eels every year of a person's own life might tempt that person to believe.

III

Of the Second Mole at Skell

On the northern coast, far from the river mole the Seann-Dhaoine¹ had laid out into the Abhainn naomh at the great Skell² many generations before, a household of a second Skell took up the same work for its own stretch of water, laying stone on stone out from a low headland; but where the river mole ran straight against a current, this one was given a curve against the open swell, so that a boat standing off in rough weather with that headland in sight could find, by the shape of the stone alone, water calmer than the sea running past it on either side.

The work went slower than the first mole's own telling remembers its own laying to have gone, for the household at this second Skell had fewer hands to spare from the ordinary work of the shore than the builders of the first mole are remembered to have had, and carried the stone for their own curve down from a scree a little back from the water rather than quarry fresh rock, choosing each piece for its fit against the pieces already laid rather than for the ease of carrying it, so that some years the curve grew by no more than a boat's length of new stone and other years, when the scree gave up pieces that fitted well one against another, by a good deal more. A household further along the shore, watching the curve grow from one season's visit to the next, is remembered to have said of it only that stone laid slow stood no less firm for the slowness, a saying that outlasted, in the tellings that have come down, the names of whoever first said it.

The curve was carried far enough out, by the year this telling now reaches, to break the swell for the length of shore behind it that the household judged worth

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

the sheltering, and no further, for a longer mole asked more stone than the scree behind the shore was ever likely to give up and more years than any one household expected to have hands enough to spend on it. A boat brought in behind the finished curve on a day the open sea beyond it still ran hard rode easier at its mooring than any boat of that shore had ridden before the mole stood finished, and a household that had lost gear more than once to a swell running in past an unsheltered mooring is remembered to have moved its own hull inside the new curve within the same season the last stone was laid, without waiting to see a full year's weather prove the shelter good.

The two moles, the river mole far to the south-west and this curved one on the northern coast, were never joined in any telling that has come down, each household knowing its own stone and its own stretch of sheltered water and little enough, beyond the bare fact that another such mole stood somewhere along the same coast, of the other's. It is told that a boy of the second Skell, grown to a man and travelling some way south-west over the land on an errand this telling does not trouble to name, came once within sight of the first mole and stood some while looking at it before going on, saying to whoever asked him of his travelling, on his return, only that the stone there was laid the same way as the stone he had grown up watching laid at home, stone for stone, though built, so far as either shore ever came to know, without one household ever having set eyes on the other's work before it was finished.

The choosing of the stone asked more of the households than the carrying did, for a piece taken from the scree without care for its shape as often sat loose against its neighbours as true, and a wall of loose-fitting stone standing against an open swell failed sooner than the swell itself troubled to test it fully, so the household that kept the work longest is remembered for a habit of laying each new piece dry against the course already set before committing it, working it back and forth by hand until it sat without rocking, and setting it only then, a slower way of building than simply piling what came to hand but one that let the second Skell's own curve stand, by the time this telling reaches it, through more winters of hard weather than the household that began it had thought, at the outset, the work would ever need to answer for.

One autumn a swell rose out of the north-west harder and longer than any the second Skell had yet tried its unfinished curve against, breaking clean over the

2. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

stone at its furthest point and running white the whole visible length of it for the better part of two days, and the household that had laid the most recent courses went down each morning of that swell expecting to find its own work of the past several seasons scattered back along the shore the sea had taken it from; it found instead, when the swell dropped at last, every stone still where it had been set, moved perhaps a hand's width here and there but nowhere thrown clear, and took the finding as proof enough of the slow way of laying it had kept to that no household of that shore, in any telling that has come down, is remembered to have argued for a quicker one after.

IV

Of the Pits in the Western Dune

On the western shore, where the Seann-Dhaoine¹ had long kept a Vell² among the dunes a little back from the open beach, a household began, in these same years, to dig a line of pits into the dune's own slope rather than raise anything above it, each pit cut down past the loose upper sand to ground firm enough to hold its shape, lined round with clay carried up from the river mouth a short walk to the south and beaten smooth against the sand walls before it dried, and closed at last with a slab of flat stone heavy enough that no fox working at it in the night could shift it clear.

What went into the pits was whatever the shore gave more of than a household could eat in the season it was taken: fish salted and dried past the point a gull or a fox would trouble to dig for it, shellfish packed in their own liquor and sealed while it still ran fresh, and in a lean season the last of a stranded catch too much for any one household's ordinary stores to hold. A pit once filled and lidded was left alone through the season it was meant for, opened only when the shore's own ordinary catch had run thin enough that a household judged the stored season's food worth more, taken now, than left sealed against a leaner year still to come, a reckoning each household made for itself and is not remembered to have agreed on with its neighbours, so that one pit might stand opened in a season another, dug the same year and filled the same way, was left sealed through.

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

A woman of the western Vell, whose own hands had dug the first of the line and lined it before any other household of that shore had troubled to dig one of its own, is remembered to have argued, in the years the line of pits grew from one to a scatter of a dozen and more, that a pit dug too near another drew damp from its neighbour through ground neither clay lining alone could wholly stop, and to have set her own later pits a full body's length apart from the first for that reason, a spacing the households that came after her on that stretch of dune are remembered to have kept without troubling to test, for themselves, whether her reasoning held.

Some of the pits, opened after longer than a season had passed over them, gave back less than had gone in: fish bones picked clean of anything a household might still have wanted from them, the flesh gone and the bones themselves gone soft with damp that had found its way past even the best-laid clay in the end, and a household opening such a pit learned, from the finding, to trust the clay less far into a second year than into its first, and to empty a store before the season turned rather than let it stand sealed on the chance a leaner year might still make use of it.

The clay itself was not always got without argument among the households that shared the walk down to the river mouth for it, for a bank cut too often in the same place slumped in the next high water and gave up no good clay at all until a season's rain had settled it back into a workable bed, and the woman who had dug the first pit is remembered to have kept, in her own head if nowhere any telling has set down, a kind of turn among the households as to which bank each might cut in a given season, a turn she never once wrote or marked in any way this telling can point to, holding it only in memory and in the asking, each spring, of whoever meant to dig that year where the last digging had been. A younger household new to the dune, not yet knowing the turn she kept, once cut a bank two others had already agreed between themselves to leave a season fallow, and gave over, when the disagreement that followed reached her, one full pit's worth of its own dried catch to the household whose turn it had truly been, a settling neither side is remembered to have thought unfair once it was made.

The lids themselves were not all of one stone. Some were slabs carried whole from a low reef bared at the lowest tides a little south along the beach, flat enough on both faces to need no working before they were set; others, where no slab of the right size could be got whole, were built up of two or three smaller stones fitted edge to edge and packed round with clay the same way the pit's own walls were packed, a harder seal to keep sound than a single slab but one that let a

household close a pit dug in a season the reef gave up nothing of the size it wanted. A pit closed with the pieced lid asked checking, once or twice through a long winter, that the clay between the stones had not dried and cracked enough to let a fox's nose in at it, a small chore that fell, in most households, to whichever child was old enough to walk the dune alone and young enough still to be given so plain a task without complaint.

In these same years a quiet came over that shore that none of its households ever put a plain reason to in any telling that has come down whole: doors that had for generations faced the open water without a second thought began, in one household after another, to be set a little more toward the dune at their backs than toward the sea in front, and a family that had always kept its hearth nearest the door that looked seaward moved it, without remark, nearer the wall that looked inland instead. No teller of that shore ever said what the eyes had begun to look for in that direction, or whether they found it, and none of the households that turned their doors is remembered to have said so themselves; only that where a threshold had once opened straight onto the beach, it came, in those years, to open a little sideways from it, toward the rising ground behind. The last pit of that season was dug, lined and lidded before the first hard frost, *Leac na Fèithe*³ set and the sand banked back over its edges the way every pit before it had been closed, and the shore settled, as it had every year before, into the waiting that a sealed store and a closed season together asked of it, though what else it had begun, in those same years, to wait for, none of its own tellings ever say.

3. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhireach

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Of the Outpost and the Three Rings

VE 2,524 – 2,678

I

Of the Wall on the Spur

For as long as any hearth of the Seann-Dhaoine¹ could tell of itself, its people had kept to the shore. They dressed stone at Morn², dried fish over peat smoke in the seven pits of the kilns, launched hulls down the ramps at Brenn³, raised round houses over a stranded whale's ribs, and buried pits of clay-lined store against the lean months, but whatever they raised, they raised within a morning's walk of salt water, and no telling of that shore said why, only that it had always been so. In the year the spur was first climbed, that had already stopped being true a season or two, though none of the diggers who broke ground on it that spring could have said when the stopping began.

The spur stood a day's walk inland from the nearest kiln, a shoulder of higher ground thrown out from the southern lowland where the grass thinned to gorse and the wind lost the salt smell it carried everywhere nearer the water. A household that had fished three generations out of the same cove sent its two eldest sons up first, to look before anyone thought to build, and what they came back saying was that a man standing on the spur's crown could see the whole lowland laid out below him the way a gull sees it, and see, too, any thing that moved across that lowland long before it reached the cove. Whether that was reason enough to raise

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

3. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

a wall so far from the water, no one now living could tell straight, but a wall went up all the same, through two summers of carrying stone on sledges dragged by hand up a slope steep enough that more than one load went over sideways and had to be gathered again from where it had rolled.

The mason who set the first course, a woman past the middle of her years and known on that shore for the evenness of her fitting rather than for her name, chose to dress the stones only on the face that would show outward, leaving the inner face rough as it came from the ground. Asked why, by a younger man who thought it a waste of good stone to leave any of it unworked, she said only that a wall need be smooth where an enemy's eye would run along it looking for a hold to climb by, and rough where a friend's hand would rest on it going up the inside steps, and that a stone dressed on both faces for no reason but tidiness was a stone whose labour had gone begging. The younger man had no answer to that beyond a shrug, and the wall rose the rest of its course the same way, smooth without, raw within, and stood so through every season it was kept.

The gate they set to face inland, away from the sea the whole people had always kept its face toward, and this choice more than any other is remembered to have been argued over at length before the first lintel stone was lifted into place. One old man, who had fished the same cove as the mason's own kin and had never in his life built anything higher than a smokehouse, said plainly that a gate looking away from the water was a gate built by people who had forgotten what the water had always been to them, and that no good would come of turning a whole household's door from the one direction the sea had never yet failed to feed it from. The mason answered him, not unkindly, that the sea had never yet come up the spur to trouble anyone standing on it, and that whatever a gate here needed watching against would not come rowing. The old man went home unconvinced and is not remembered to have climbed the spur again in the years he had left, though he sent his own grandsons up to help finish the carrying whenever the work asked for more hands than the spur's own people could spare.

Through that first winter Làrach an Dùin-fhaire⁴ held no more than a handful of families, enough to keep the wall's steps swept of snow and a watch kept from first light to last, and it is told that the watch in those early months was kept less for any thing seen approaching than for the keeping's own sake, as though the people who had built so far from the water needed some task to fill the silence a

4. the watch-fort ruin

coastal hearth never knew, the silence of ground that gave back no tide sound and no gull cry, only wind moving through gorse and, some nights, nothing at all. A woman who kept that first winter's watch longer than anyone else of her household, because sleep came harder to her than to the rest, used to say afterward that the quiet up there had a weight to it unlike any quiet the shore ever gave, and that she had grown, before the winter was out, almost to prefer it to the sea's own noise, a preference she never fully explained even to those who asked her outright what she meant by it.

By the second summer the gate itself was hung, a heavy door of oak planks pegged edge to edge and swung on a socketed post that two strong men together could just move on its hinge, and the day it first swung shut on its own weight without needing a shoulder to help it home is remembered as a small feast day among the households that had given hands to the work, though no telling now living can say which household first thought to mark it so, or what exactly was eaten or said. What is remembered plainly is that the old fisherman who had argued against the inland gate came up that day unbidden, stood at the threshold a long while without going either in or out, and at last put his own hand flat against the swung door and said nothing at all, a silence the young folk who saw it took, rightly or wrongly, for a kind of blessing withheld and given both at once.

Cattle were driven up the spur that same summer for the first time, a slow business of coaxing beasts used to level grazing up a slope steeper than any they had climbed before, and more than one animal balked outright at the gate itself, planting its feet and lowing until a rope round its horns and three men's shoulders together got it through. Once inside, though, the beasts settled to the thin grass within the wall readily enough, and a boy set to herd them there through that first season used to say the cattle seemed, within a few days, no longer to miss the sea grass they had grazed all their lives, a settling he thought stranger, in his own way, than anything the people themselves had done in coming up.

The steps that ran up the wall's inner face on both sides of the gate were cut narrow and set close, each no deeper than half a foot, so that a watcher could go up or down them at a run in the dark without needing to look at his own feet to find the next one, and it was the boy who herded the cattle, more often than any grown watcher, who was sent up and down them fastest, carrying word between the gate and whoever stood the height at any hour, since a boy's legs tired less of the running than a grown man's did and a boy could be spared from other work

more readily than a man who was needed, besides, at the wall itself or out among the beasts. He came, before that first year was out, to know every uneven tread in both flights of steps by the feel of it under a bare foot, and is remembered to have said once, when an older cousin asked him how he never once stumbled going up in full dark, that his feet had simply learned the wall the way a hand learns a rope it has hauled on every day for a year, without his ever once sitting down to learn it on purpose.

It was that same boy, in the second autumn of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire's keeping, who first raised the cry that brought every watcher on the wall to the gate side at a run, for what he saw, coming across the lowland from the west in the last low light of an evening, was a line of shapes he took at first for a herd of deer moving faster and more evenly together than any deer he had ever watched cross open ground. The watch was called and held through that whole night, torches kept burning along the inner steps though no one on the wall could say for certain, once full dark had come down, whether the shapes were still out there or had never been more than deer after all, moving as deer sometimes did in a hard year when a whole herd shifted ground together ahead of an early frost. By first light nothing showed on the lowland at all, no track a careful eye could find once a party went down to look, and the matter was let go without ever being settled either way, though the boy himself held to his first telling of it all his life, and Làrach an Dùin-fhaire's watch, from that autumn on, was never again let lapse to a single pair of eyes the way it had sometimes been let lapse before.

II

Of the Cistern and the Three Rings

Some distance off, on a height nearer the south-eastern coast, a greater work was rising in those same years, and the two crews that raised it never once, in any telling that has come down whole, met at either site or knew in full what the other built, so that each held for a long while to its own account of what was going up on the far height, some saying it no more than a second watch-wall like their own, others saying it something larger they could not picture without having seen it. It was, in the end, larger by a wide measure: three walls, ringed one within the other round a hilltop broad enough, once the innermost ring was

closed, to hold four hundred people at once with their beasts and their stores besides, a scale no single household on that coast had ever raised to before.

The crew that raised it worked under a woman the tellings give no name to beyond what her own people called her, the one who reads the ground, for it was said of her that she could stand on a rise and see, before a single stone was laid, where a wall would hold and where the same wall built a spear's length to either side would slide with the first hard winter's frost, a reading she never once explained beyond saying that the ground told her plainly enough if a body only stood still long enough to be told. Under her eye the outer ring went up first, broad and low, more a barrier to slow an approach than to stop one outright, and behind it the middle ring rose higher and thinner, and behind that again the innermost ring stood tallest of the three, tall enough that a man standing at its base and looking up could not see over it without stepping well back.

The cistern was cut into the bedrock at the hill's own crown before either ring was finished, a basin hollowed by hand and fire together, heated stone after heated stone cracked loose from the rock with water thrown on while it still glowed, a labour that is remembered to have taken the better part of two whole seasons and to have blistered more hands than the rest of the building together. The woman who read the ground stood over that digging as closely as she stood over the walls, and is remembered to have said, when a digger asked how deep the basin need go, that it should go deep enough to hold water through a summer no rain fell in, though none then living had seen such a summer, and that a cistern cut shallow to save a season's labour was a cistern that would fail exactly the year it was most needed.

It filled for the first time the spring the innermost ring was closed, a slow filling from a spring found seeping through a crack near the basin's foot that no one had marked until the digging opened it wider, and the day the water stood a hand's depth over the basin's floor a child of one of the building households was let climb down on a rope to fetch up the first drawn measure in a skin, more for the wonder of the thing than for any thirst the height's own people yet had. The woman who read the ground tasted that first measure herself before anyone else touched it, held it in her mouth a long moment, and said only that it tasted of stone, which everyone standing by took as high praise from her, whatever it might have meant from anyone else.

Cattle were driven inside the rings that same year, a longer and steeper climb than the spur had asked of its own beasts, and more animals were lost on the way

up, over loose scree that gave without warning under a hoof, than the spur's herders had ever lost driving theirs. A woman who lost two of her own household's beasts that climb is remembered to have said afterward that whatever the three rings kept out, they charged dear enough for what they let in, a saying repeated on that height for years after by anyone minded to grumble at the work the rings' upkeep still asked of them.

The inner buildings went up more slowly than the walls, round houses set close along the innermost ring's inner face, roofed in turf cut from the hill's own flank so that from a distance, before smoke rose from any of them, the whole crown of the hill showed as one unbroken slope of green, the houses hidden in the ground's own shape the way a bird's nest is hidden in a hedge. A household that moved up from the shore to take one of the first of these houses is remembered to have found, its first winter within the rings, that the wind that reached them there, filtered three times over by wall after wall, was gentler by far than any wind the same household had known at the water's edge, a mercy none of them had thought to look for in coming so far from the sea, though it was thought a poor trade by more than one older voice among them, weighed against all that the sea itself was no longer at hand to give.

The woman who read the ground grew old within the rings she had raised, and in her last years she took to walking the innermost ring alone each morning before the rest of the height was awake, a slow circuit with a stick to lean on that had once needed no stick at all, and more than one of the younger builders who saw her at it took to walking a length of the wall with her, for she said little on those mornings, but to be shown, by nothing more than where she chose to stop and rest a hand flat on the stone, which stretches of the three rings she still judged sound and which she had begun, in her own private reckoning, to distrust. She never said outright that any stretch of wall she had herself set was failing, only that a wall, like a person, aged unevenly, some lengths of it good for a hundred winters and others, laid the very same season by the very same hands, good for a good deal less, and that a height meant to hold four hundred people needed someone always walking it who could tell the difference before the ground told it plainer, in a wet spring, by giving way.

She died within the innermost ring in a season the tellings give no exact count of years for beyond saying she was old, and her own people buried her, at her own asking made long before, not outside the rings among the dead of the households that had come up from the shore, but within the second ring's shelter, close under

a stretch of wall she had named to more than one listener, in her last winter, as the soundest work of her whole life. A cairn was raised over her there small enough not to trouble the ground the cattle grazed, and it is told that for as long as the height was kept, no herder let a beast graze close against that particular cairn, though none of them could have said, pressed for a reason, what harm they thought a hoof might do to stones that had already stood so many winters undisturbed.

III

Of the Kerbed Way

Between the spur and the height a stretch of lower ground ran, marsh in its wettest reaches and stony moor in its driest, ground that had never before carried more traffic than a herder's own two feet, and it was across this ground, in the years Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹'s wall stood finished and the rings' innermost course still rose course by course on the height beyond, that a track was laid the like of which the Seann-Dhaoine² had never built away from the shore in all the generations the tellings hold.

It began, by most accounts, as no more than a line of trodden ground worn by the few who had reason to go between the two rising works, a path that grew muddier each season as more feet used it, until a household living along its worst stretch, tired of hauling loads through ankle-deep mire every time the rain held more than a day, laid a scatter of flat stones across the softest ground simply to keep its own feet dry, with no thought, at the laying, of any greater work to follow. Others saw the dry going those few stones gave and laid more beside them, each household adding what it could spare of its own labour to the stretch nearest its own door, so that the track grew the way a shoreline midden grows, one household's contribution at a time, with no single hand ever holding the whole plan of it from one end to the other.

It was only some years into this scattered laying that anyone thought to kerb the edges, setting upright stones along both sides of the trodden way to hold the paving in place against the ground's own slow spreading, and the first stretch so

1. the watch-fort ruin

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

kerbed held so much better through a wet winter than the unkerbed stretches on either side of it that the practice spread along the whole track within a few more seasons, each household that had laid its own piece coming back to add the kerb its neighbours had shown the worth of. A cart, once the kerbing held firm enough over a long enough stretch, could be dragged its width without a wheel sinking to the axle, and it is told that the first load ever so dragged, of stone meant for the height's own innermost ring, went across in a single day where the same load, hauled the old way over open moor, had once taken the better part of three.

The paving itself was never of one stone throughout, for each household cut what its own nearest quarrying gave, so that a traveller walking the whole way in one going would have passed, in a single day's walk, over pale stone and dark, over slabs broad as a door and stretches of smaller stones fitted edge to edge like the pieced lids of a storage pit, the whole track a record, to anyone minded to read it so, of every household that had ever laid a hand to it, though none of those households, laying its own short stretch, is remembered to have thought of the work as anything grander than keeping its own feet dry between one season and the next.

A cart was driven the whole length of the track for the first time in the year the last of its middle stretches was kerbed, laden with dressed stone meant for the height's outer ring and drawn by two yoked oxen a household near the spur had raised from calves for no other purpose, and the driver of that first cart, a young man who had never before taken a load further than the short haul from his own quarrying to his own household's wall, is remembered to have walked the whole way at the oxen's heads rather than ride, watching the wheels for any give in the paving that might tip the load, and to have found, at the far end, that not one stone of it had shifted the whole way, a steadiness he called out to the height's own people before he had so much as unyoked the beasts, as proud of the road's holding as he might have been of a wall he had raised himself.

The last stretch to be laid ran up the final rise toward the height itself, steeper than any ground the track had yet crossed, and the crew that closed it set its final slab, by every account that has come down whole, tilted a little rather than level as the rest of the track had been laid, so that the paving's whole run, seen from below, seemed to lift the eye up the slope and on past the height itself toward the high country further inland, the central mountains standing pale and distant beyond the nearer ground the way they stood on every clear day from anywhere on that coast, though no teller of that laying ever said the tilt was meant to point there, only that the stone was set so and has lain so ever since, unmoved by any

season that has passed over it, and that whoever set it last, whether by design or by nothing more than the ground's own lie under that final slab, is not remembered by any name the tellings have kept.

IV

Of the Turning

What passed between the households of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹ and the households of the three rings in the years both works stood finished, no telling that has come down whole says plainly, for the two never worked one crew and kept, even after the track joined them, more to their own hill each than to any single people shared between the two heights. But it was of both together, and of no other work the Seann-Dhaoine² had raised before them, that the shore hearths first began to say the thing that afterward became a saying repeated the length of that coast: that a people who had always kept their faces to the sea had, in those years, without any single voice among them ever quite deciding it aloud, turned their faces from it instead, toward the ground behind them and the high country beyond that ground, a turning no shore mother ever fully explained to a child who asked why the family's own door, that had opened on the water three generations running, now opened instead on the path inland.

It was not that the sea was given up. The kilns at Morn³ still smoked through every drying season, the ramps at Brenn⁴ still launched their hulls, and the households of the two new heights sent down, every year, kin enough to keep a hand in the old work and bring back dried fish and traded shell for a hearth too far from the water to gather its own. But the gate that had once seemed, to the old fisherman who mistrusted it, a strange thing to build facing away from the only direction that had ever fed his people, no longer seemed strange to anyone climbing the spur by the year the last slab of the track was laid, and a child born within either ring of the height, or within the spur's own wall, grew to walking age never once having slept in a house that heard the tide.

The last stone was set into the kerbed way's final stretch on a still morning with no wind off the sea to carry any salt smell up that high, and the small crew

1. the watch-fort ruin

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

3. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

that set it, having no more stone of its own to add and no further stretch left unpaved between the two heights, stood a while looking back the way the track had come, down across the lower moor toward the shore neither height could any longer see from where they stood, and then turned, without any word the tellings have kept, to look instead the other way, up the track's own tilted last slab and past it, toward the high pale country that had stood at the edge of every clear day's sight for as long as any of them had lived, and had never before that morning seemed a thing worth walking toward.

4. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

CHAPTER NINETEEN

OF the ALTAR and the SHAFTS

VE 2,679 – 2,800

Na las teine far am faic e thu. Light no fire where it can see you.
*The Fourth Part: Of the Black Coal in the Ground, Uilebheist na
Mara and Marbh-bheò*

I

Of the Platform in the Eastern Hills

The last slab of the kerbed track had lain a bare season before the households of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹ and Làrach an Dùin² began, without any telling saying which of them first raised a hand to it, a work higher into the hills than either wall or ring: a platform of fitted stone built up in steps on a shoulder of ground in the eastern hills, each step no higher than a man's knee and wide enough along its whole run for two people to walk abreast, so that a climb up its face went easier than a climb up any hillside near it, though no telling says why so gentle a climb was ever wanted there in the first place. On the topmost step, set back from its outer edge by rather more than a stride, a single great block of stone was laid and dressed flat on its upper face, and it is this block, more than the steps that carried a person up to it, that the tellings of the hills came in time to mean when they spoke of Làrach an Teampaill³.

The stone for the platform was quarried some way off and dragged up on rollers of trimmed timber, the same labour that had raised Làrach an Dùin-

1. the watch-fort ruin

fhaire's wall and Làrach an Dùin's three rings, and a household that had helped haul stone for either of those earlier works would have known this hauling for the same kind of work, only carried higher and further than either. What set the altar block apart from every other stone Seann-Dhaoine² had ever cut and laid, in the eastern hills or on any shore before them, was not its size, for stones as large had gone into Làrach an Dùin's walls, but the line its face was cut to lie along, for while every mole, every ramp, every kiln and every round house Seann-Dhaoine had ever raised faced the water that fed it, salt or fresh, near or by sight, the top of this one stone was squared instead to the great mountains standing in the middle of the island, a good many miles off and out of sight of any sea at all from where the block was set.

Who first laid a level along that line, and by what means, no telling that has come down says, and none of the households that climbed the platform's steps in the years that followed ever troubled, in any word remembered of them, to ask. A woman old enough to have climbed those steps as a girl and again as a grandmother said only, of the one time she was asked by a stranger why the great stone at the top looked where it looked and not where the sea lay, that the stone had always looked that way and that a thing so set before her own grandmother's grandmother was no more hers to question than the shape of her own hand.

In the first years of the platform's standing, before habit had worn a clear path up its steps, a household of the southern lowland is remembered to have gone up at first light on the shortest morning of the year, carrying nothing between them that any telling names, and to have stood some while about the great stone as the sun came up over the sea behind them and its first light ran along the top of the block and out toward the mountains it was squared to, touching, for the little while the sun stood low enough to throw a light so far, the same line the stone held. What was said at that standing, if anything was said, has not come down; what has come down is only that the household went up again the next year at the same season, and the year after that, and that others of the lowland, seeing them go, began in time to go up too, until the shortest morning of the year found more households climbing the steps together than any single household could have climbed alone.

A boy of one such household, sent up for the first time old enough to be trusted on the steps without a hand held out for him, is remembered to have asked,

2. the fortress ruin

3. the temple ruin

on the climb, what it was they were going up to see, and to have been told by whoever climbed beside him only that they were going up to see the light meet the stone, an answer that satisfied him well enough at the time and that he is remembered, grown old in his turn, to have given in the same words to a child of his own asking the same question on the same climb. No one of the eastern hills, in any telling that has come down whole, ever said more than that of what the standing was for, or what, if anything, the mountains the stone looked toward were held to hold. A crowd need not know why it gathers each year at the same season to watch a light meet a stone; the tellings remember the gathering, kept and passed on, far more surely than they remember why it began.

The rite, once it had settled into a yearly thing, kept always to the one morning and never to any other, whatever the weather made of that morning, so that a year came, within living memory of those who told of it after, when cloud lay thick over the eastern hills from the day before the shortest morning until well past it, and no light reached the stone at all that year for any household to see meet it; and it is remembered that the households climbed the steps all the same, in the dark and the cold, and stood about the great stone through the whole of the morning it would have taken the light to cross it, and went down again when the hour had passed without a word of complaint at what the cloud had cost them, holding, so far as the telling says anything of their holding, that the standing was owed whether the light came to be seen or not.

None of the households that kept the rite, in all the years this telling follows, ever cut so much as a single mark into the great stone, though marks were being cut in those same years on the cliffs of the eastern coast by hands of their own people, and the stone stood at the century's end exactly as it had been dressed at the century's start, bare of any sign but the flatness of its own face and the squareness of its own cut. A woman who kept, among her own household's things, a small carved bird of the kind the Seann-Dhaoine of the shore sometimes carved and buried with their dead, is remembered to have carried it up once and set it at the stone's foot rather than take it home again, and to have gone down without it; whether this was the rite's own custom or a thing she alone did, no telling that has come down can now say, for no second such bird, and no third, was ever found at the stone's foot by anyone who came after her.

The steps themselves asked more years to finish than the great stone atop them asked to raise, for a household laying flat stone into a slope worked slower than a

household piling wall on open ground, each slab bedded and levelled before the next was set above it, and the work was carried on, by the tellings that name it at all, mostly in the months between one planting and the next, when the hands that dug and hauled were not also wanted for the ground below. A man who gave the better part of his own years to the laying of the upper steps, where the slope stood steepest and the stone wanted the most patient setting, is remembered to have refused more than once to let a slab go into place before he had knelt on it himself and rocked his own weight across it, holding that a step a person's foot could feel give, even by a hand's width, was a step that would, given the years, throw someone from it, and that the platform's whole worth lay in a climb no one troubled to watch their own feet upon. The last step, laid some years after the great stone had already stood on its own step above the unfinished work below it, closed the run at the bottom flush with the moor's own ground, so that a person coming to it from level walking felt no more than the least catch underfoot before the climb began, and it is this last, easiest step, rather than any higher and harder-won one, that the tellings of the households nearest the platform remember best, for it was the one every child among them first learned to find with a bare foot in the dark, going up before dawn on the one morning of the year the climb was made.

A stranger to the eastern hills, come up from the southern lowland on some errand the telling does not trouble to name, is remembered to have stood at the platform's foot one year on an ordinary day, neither the shortest morning nor any day near it, and to have asked of a woman drawing water nearby what the great stone at the top was raised for; and she is remembered to have answered him, in words a granddaughter of hers repeated to others, that a stone which had stood before her grandmother's grandmother needed no raising explained to a stranger who had not troubled to be born to it, and to have gone on with her drawing without looking up again at either the stranger or the stone. He is not remembered to have climbed the steps himself, that day or any other, nor to have come back a second time; and no telling of the eastern hills, from that year to the end of this one, names him again.

4. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

II

Of the Shaft at the Eastern Toll-dubh

Some years into the platform's keeping, and some way off from it, at a place in the south-east the hills already called Toll-dubh before any hand had touched it, a household began a work of a wholly different kind: not up, as the platform went, and not out along a shore, as every mole and every ramp before it had gone, but straight down into the ground, on level moor where no well and no quarry had ever yet been cut.

The first cut was no deeper than a well's own depth, and for the better part of a year it might have passed, to anyone who came upon it without knowing better, for a well begun and left, the kind of half-finished digging a household abandons when the water it hoped for does not come. But the digging went on past the depth any well on that moor had ever needed to reach, and it went on straight, cut round and true as a well is cut, but with its walls worked smooth by hand long after the digging alone would have left them rough, an old man of the household standing at the lip each evening with a lamp let down on a cord to judge, by the reach of its light along the walls, how far the smoothing had been carried and how much of the day's work still wanted doing before the light gave out on him.

The baskets that came up out of the shaft, full of the broken rock the digging threw off, were carried away each evening over the rise at the moor's edge by whoever's turn it was to carry them, and were not, by any telling that has come down of that household, brought back empty the way a basket carried only a little way is brought back; and no heap of the rock so carried was ever afterward found anywhere near the shaft's mouth, nor anywhere on the moor about it that anyone troubled to walk out and look. Where rock enough to fill so many baskets went, over years enough to sink a shaft so deep, no telling that has come down so much as guesses at; the telling gives only the carrying, evening on evening, and the going, and lets the rest lie where the household itself let it lie.

A woman of that household, grown old in the years the digging went on, is remembered to have said to a granddaughter asking after the rock's going, only that some work is carried and some work is asked after, and that a household did well to know which was which before it went asking the wrong question of the wrong work. The granddaughter, so the telling says, never asked again, though whether from being satisfied by the answer or from knowing, by the way it was given, that no better answer would follow it, the telling does not say either.

The lamp was let down further with each year the shaft went deeper, on a longer length of the same plaited cord each time, and it is remembered that a length was added to the cord on three separate occasions before the digging stopped, each addition marked, in the one telling that names it at all, only by the household gathering at the lip on the evening a new length was first paid out, to watch the lamp go down further than it had ever gone before and come up again still burning. On the last such evening the telling names, the lamp went down so far that its light, by the time it reached the bottom, showed no more of the walls around it than a small round patch no wider than a man's two hands held apart, the rest of the shaft's depth standing dark above and below that patch alike, and it was on this same evening, or very near it, that the digging is remembered to have stopped, though no telling says in so many words that the two things were one and the same, or that the small patch of light was the reason the digging went no further.

A stone let fall from the lip on an evening after the digging had stopped, by a hand the telling does not name, gave back no sound of striking anything below, though the household that let it fall stood listening a good while after it left the hand, in a silence that the telling remembers as longer than the silence any of them had kept for anything else in all the years of that digging, well or ill.

The work was not without its cost to the hands that did it, for a shaft cut so narrow and so straight gave a person let down into it no room to fall wrong without striking the wall on the way, and a young man of the household, sent down one autumn on the cord to free a basket that had caught against a shoulder of unworked rock some way below the lip, is remembered to have come up again with a gash along one forearm that kept him from the heaviest carrying the better part of a season, and to have gone down again the following spring all the same, the cord tied about him the same way it had always been tied, as if a single wound was owed no more weight in the reckoning than a blister from the oar or the mattock. The cord was renewed twice in the years the digging went on, the old length kept afterward rather than thrown aside, coiled and hung inside the household's own door, so that a visitor coming to that threshold afterward might see, without being told what it had once measured, two lengths of worn hide cord hanging where another household might have hung a net or a snare.

Winter closed the shaft each year before the ground froze hard enough to trouble the digging, for the lamp burned poorly in the damp that gathered in the depth once the air above turned cold, and guttered more than once, in tellings

that name the guttering at all, before it could be drawn up again; and it became the household's own custom, kept without any single year's telling saying when it began, to lay a flat stone loosely over the shaft's mouth each year at the first hard frost and lift it again only when the days had lengthened past the shortest, a covering meant, so far as the telling says anything of its meaning, to keep a wandering beast or a careless foot from the lip through the months no one went down to work it, rather than to shut anything already below away from anything still above.

III

Of the Shaft at the Western Toll-dubh

Far across the island, on ground the western households likewise called Toll-dubh before the digging began, a second shaft was cut in these same years, by a household that had no more knowledge of the eastern one, by any telling that has come down of either, than the eastern household had of it. The two shafts were never, in the whole of this telling, said to have been begun at the bidding of one crew working both, or of any word carried between the two households that cut them; each is remembered only for its own digging, by its own people, on its own ground, and it is left to whoever hears both tellings together, side by side, to wonder at how closely the one work answers the other.

The western shaft went down the same way the eastern one had gone, straight and round and smoothed by hand past the depth the digging alone would have left rough, and its baskets were carried off in the same manner, evening on evening, by whoever's turn the carrying fell to, and were never brought back to be tipped where any later hand could find what they had carried. A man of the western household, past the age when the heaviest carrying still fell to him, took instead to keeping the lamp trimmed each evening for whoever went down to judge the smoothing, a smaller work than the digging but one the telling remembers him for all the same, as though the wick kept even and the oil kept full mattered to that household as much as the depth the digging reached that day.

A girl of the same household, young enough still to be sent for water rather than set to carrying, is remembered to have asked her mother, on an evening the lamp came up burning low from further down than it had gone the evening before, whether the shaft would be dug all the way down to wherever the moun-

tains kept their roots; and her mother is remembered to have answered only that the ground kept its own matters, and that a household did well not to ask them aloud, an answer that told the girl nothing of what the shaft was truly for, and that the telling gives, in the end, as the nearest any teller of the western shore ever came to saying why the digging was begun at all.

The western shaft, like its twin in the east, was carried down until the lamp at its bottom showed no more than a small patch of smoothed wall with darkness standing above and below it, and it too, so far as any telling says, stopped there and went no further, though which of the two shafts reached that depth first, or whether they reached it in the same year or years apart, no telling that has come down troubles to say, holding them, in the manner of the tellers of that coast, as two halves of one thing rather than as a first and a second.

It fell to a boy of the western household, the youngest old enough to be trusted with the lamp's own cord, to let the last stone go on the evening the digging there, too, was given over, and he is remembered to have counted, under his breath, the whole time it took the stone to leave his hand until he judged, by his own counting, that it must by then have struck bottom somewhere below him; and when no sound came up to him at the number he had reached, nor at any number after it that the household, standing about him in the last light, troubled to go on counting to, he is said to have looked up at the faces around him rather than down the shaft, as if the listening, and not the stone, was the thing that mattered to be seen doing.

The western household kept, through the years of its own digging, a habit the eastern telling does not name for its own shaft: each evening the lamp came up, whoever had carried it down that day set it, still burning, on a flat stone laid for the purpose a little back from the lip, and let it burn there untended until it went out on its own, rather than snuff it the moment the day's work was done, a small wastefulness of oil that the household never once, in any telling that names it, troubled to give a reason for keeping. A grandmother of that household, asked once by a grandchild why the lamp was left to burn out above ground when it had already done its work below, answered only that a light let go out on its own was no more trouble to anyone than a light snuffed by a hand, and that some things, once begun, were better let run their own course than stopped short by whoever happened to be standing nearest when the stopping crossed their mind; whether she meant the lamp alone by this, or the digging with it, the telling does not say, and the grandchild is not remembered to have asked her to say more.

The two shafts stood after that, east and west, neither filled nor covered, each with its own household keeping, in its own way, a distance from the mouth that the digging had never kept, so that a person of either coast coming near either shaft afterward is remembered to walk wide of the lip rather than close to it, and to let a dropped stone, if a stone was ever again dropped there by anyone, go down into a silence that by then no household troubled any longer to break by listening after it. The platform in the eastern hills went on being climbed each year at the one morning it had always been climbed; the two shafts went on standing where they had been sunk, unfilled and unexplained, the rock that came out of them gone wherever it had gone, and no household of that age, on either coast, is remembered to have asked, aloud and before others, where either people had learned to dig so straight, or so deep, or why, having dug so far down into ground that had never before answered any question anyone had put to it, they let the digging stop at all.

Of the three works this telling has followed, one reaching up toward the mountains and two reaching down past every depth a well or a grave had ever asked of that ground, no single teller of the shore or the hills ever set them side by side in one telling while any of the three still stood unfinished; each was kept, in its own years, as its own household's own matter, told by its own people in its own words, the platform's climbers knowing nothing, so far as any telling says, of the shafts' diggers, and the diggers of the one shaft knowing as little of the other. It is only from the far side of those years, gathering what three separate hearths each kept whole in their own way, that a listener comes to see the one thing plainly enough to be surprised by it: that in these same generations, on three pieces of ground far enough apart that no single pair of feet is remembered to have walked between all three, Seann-Dhaoine¹ stopped building only along the water that had fed every other work of theirs before, and turned instead toward the high ground and the low, the mountains that no boat had ever needed and the dark that no net had ever asked for, as if the shore, for those years, had come to hold less than it once had for the reaching.

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

CHAPTER TWENTY

Of the Steersman

VE 2,801 – 2,860

I

Of the Word of the West

On the north-west shore, where the household hearths sat back from the water among stunted thorn and the wind never quite stopped, they kept Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹ the same as the high valleys kept it, but they kept it differently too. The recital of the Line went out to them father by father, the way it went out to every hearth on the island, and they knew it as well as anyone who had never seen Tobar dhìreach: the sky and the earth and the sea, each with its own spirit, and the coal that would answer only its own element. A shore household hears a telling with the sea at its back, though, and what it takes from the telling first is neither the sky's part nor the earth's. Sky was the sea's business one day in a hundred, when the weather turned; earth was under the feet and gave the peat and little else in that stony ground. The sea was at the door every day of a life, grey most mornings, green when it wanted to be kind, white when it did not, and the shore hearths listened hardest to the part of Aithris a' Chruthachaidh that spoke of what lay past it.

That part did not come from Coimhdeach na Fine²'s own mouth, or none said so. It came, the old women said, from further back than the mason, from an Dia-shluagh³'s own children before there was fire at all, and it had ridden into Aithris a' Chruthachaidh the way a stray dog rides in among a flock and is let stay

1. the Telling of the Making

2. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

3. the godfolk; lit. 'the god-host'

because no one has the heart to drive it out. It said that west over the open sea, past the edge of sight and further than any hide boat had gone, there lay a green land that had no equal on Dia-thìr: Tìr nan Òg⁴, and Magh Meall⁵ beside it, Magh Meall, where nothing grew old and nothing grew sick and the fruit hung ready in every season at once. And further off again, to the south-west, on a rock the sea went round and round without ever quite reaching, stood Taigh Dhuinn⁶, the house of the lord of the dead, where those who did die on Dia-thìr went over water at the last, whether they had ever set foot in a boat in their lives or not.

Bran was born into that hearth in a year the household counted, later, as a year of good fishing, though he did not remember it, only that his grandmother spat into the fire for luck whenever the year was named. He grew up with the sea a stone's throw from the door and was in a coracle before he could say his own name straight, sitting in his father's lap with both small hands round the withy frame, howling with delight at every dip of it. His father, Fearadhach, was himself a fisher of the middling sort, careful rather than bold, and it was a puzzle to him all his life where the boy's restlessness came from, since nothing in his own blood or his wife's had ever looked past the next day's catch.

By the time Bran was a man grown he was the best boatman on that whole stretch of coast, and everyone on it, kin and stranger alike, said so without being asked. He could read a swell before it broke and tell, by the particular grey of the sky to the west at evening, whether the next day would let a boat out or keep it ashore, and he was right about it far oftener than he was wrong. He took seal and fish for his own hearth and for three others besides, and he mended the hide of every boat on that shore that needed mending, because his stitches held where other men's let the sea in. Neighbours brought him boats from half a day's walk along the coast rather than trust their own kin's needle, and he never once asked payment beyond a share of what the mended boat brought home after. Of an evening, when the tide had turned and there was nothing left to do at the water, he would sit with the other boatmen of that shore mending net or line by the last light, and the talk there was of seal grounds and the run of the mackerel and which headland kept a boat dry in a north wind and which did not, talk that filled a whole life for most of the men who traded it. Bran traded it as freely as any of

4. the land of the young

5. the plain of delight

6. the house of Donn, where the dead go

them. It was only afterward, alone or with his mother, that the other listening began.

Such a man did not sit easily at the fire once the meat was eaten, the way some boatmen were content to, glad of the work and glad to let the rest of the world alone. Bran listened instead. He listened to Aithris a' Chruthachaidh every time it was said, the same words he had heard a hundred times, the way another man might listen for the note in a bowstring that told him it would break before it broke. What he wanted he could not himself have said clearly, only that when the recital came round to the part about the land past the sea's edge he sat forward with his hands gone still in his lap, and his mother used to say, once the matter had stopped being a thing said lightly, that even as a small boy he had looked west at the closing light with an attention no other child on that shore gave to it.

Once, when he was near ten, she found him standing at the tideline in the last grey of an evening, long after he should have been called in, and asked him what he thought he was looking at out there with nothing to see. "The place where it stops being water and starts being something else," he told her, and would not say more, and she did not press him, taking it for a child's fancy that would wear off with the years the way most fancies did. It did not wear off. "It is only a telling," his father told him once, when Bran was near a man and had asked, for the third or fourth time, whether anyone now living had ever gone out past the point where the swell ran long and slow and the gulls thinned to nothing. "The sea is the sea out there the same as it is here, only colder and longer, and a man who goes into it far enough does not come back to say what he found. The telling means no more than that. It is a way of saying: don't."

Bran said nothing to that. He did not forget it either, though, and it never once did the work his father had meant it to do.

II

Of the Boat He Stitched

he was six-and-twenty, unmarried still though not for want of asking, when he began to gather hides that were not for mending. At first he told no one what they were for, and his kin took it, for a season, as a boatman's habit: a man who works hides gathers hides, and no one thinks to ask why a net-mender keeps cord by him. Only the toughest bull-hides would do, cured

longer than any hide he had cured before, worked soft with fat and smoke until they would bend without cracking and hold water without weeping. He cut ribs of bent hazel and ash, more of them and set closer than any boat on that shore carried, and lashed each joint with sinew twisted so tight it sang when he plucked it, the way a good bowstring sings.

He worked through two winters at it in the lee of the house, out of the worst of the wind, most evenings after the day's fishing was done and most of the dark months when the sea kept him ashore anyway. Neighbours came by at first out of no more than a boatman's interest in another boatman's frame, and stayed longer than they meant to, turning the ribs over with their hands and asking, at first idly and then less idly, what water he meant such a hull for. He gave no straight answer for a long while, only that a bigger boat could carry a bigger catch, which was true enough as far as it went and satisfied most of them. By the second winter it satisfied fewer, for no man building only for a bigger catch builds a bow so high, or decks half the length of his hull with skins stretched and sealed against green water, or sets his ribs closer than three fingers' width apart when a hand's width has always served.

By the second spring the thing standing on its trestles in the yard was no coracle and no boat any of his kin had a name for: broad in the beam, high enough at the bow to climb a real sea rather than ride over a river chop, built, though none but Bran yet said so aloud, for water that meant to fight back. His mother asked him straight out, at last, what he meant to do with a boat built for more sea than any man on that coast had ever needed to cross, and he told her straight back.

"I mean to go and see if Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹ is true."

She did not weep, or not where he could see it. She had half known, she said afterward, since he was the boy who stood too long at the tideline in the failing light. What she said to him that evening, standing at the door of the boat-yard with her arms folded against the wind, was only this: that Aithris a' Chruthachaidh never once said a living man had gone and come back to say what he found, and that a telling with no one to bring it home was not a telling to build a boat on.

"Then I will bring it home," he said, "and it will be a telling with someone to bring it, after."

He found his crew easier than he had looked to, which surprised even him. Four men came, none of them fools, all of them known on that coast for steady

hands: two who had fished with him from boyhood and trusted his eye on a swell over their own judgement of it; one older man, a net-mender of that shore, who had buried a wife the year before and said, when asked why he would go, only that there was less now to keep him ashore than there once had been; and last a boy not yet a man, not seventeen, whose name the tellers who kept the hushed part of this telling never gave, saying only that he was Bran's sister's son and had begged so long and so hard to come that his mother let him go at last rather than have him hate her for keeping him. Bláthnaid was that sister, three years the younger, and she alone of the whole kin neither wept over the boat nor argued against it. She asked her brother only one thing, the night before he put out: to tell her the truth of what he found, whatever it proved to be, if ever the chance came to tell her anything at all. He promised her that. It was the promise she held to for the rest of her long life, though there was soon no one left to ask it of.

They put out on a morning in high summer when the sea lay flat and green almost to the edge of sight and the wind, such as there was, sat steady out of the north-east, which Bran judged would carry them long and even without driving them off whatever line he meant to hold. Out past the last skerries to the north the sky carried the grey bank that never lifted off that stretch of sea in any season, the same grey that every boatman on the coast knew to leave well alone; Bran held his bow south of it from the first hour, west and a little south, away from the grey and into open blue water where no boat of that coast had held a course before. He stood the whole of that first morning at the steering-oar himself and let no other hand take it, watching the grey bank fall away astern on the right hand until it was only a smudge and then nothing at all, and the household came down to the shingle to see the five of them off. No one sang, for there was no telling yet of what a voyage like this one ought to be sung with, and the tellers say the silence of that leaving was remembered longer on that shore than any of the words that were said in it.

III

Of the Boy Who Came Back

What passed on the water in the days that followed, no one on Dia-thìr can tell with a whole mouth, for only one of the five that went out ever stood on the shingle of that coast again, and he was past whole telling by the time he stood there.

He was found near the end of the same summer, a season and a little more after the boat put out, lying below the tide line on a stretch of coast two days' walk south of where he had left, as though the sea itself had carried him round and set him down gently at a place he had never asked to be brought. A woman gathering shellfish found him and thought him drowned until she saw his chest move. He was burned dark by a sun harder than any that fell on that coast, thin as a stripped willow-wand, and his mouth was too cracked to make more than a whisper for the better part of a day after they carried him in and gave him water a little at a time, as a man returning from a long fast must be given it, for fear the giving itself would kill him.

When the whisper came, it came in pieces, and the pieces did not always agree with one another, which the tellers say is only what is to be looked for of a boy half out of his wits with thirst and grief both. He said they had sailed many days, more than he had kept count of, west and a little south as Bran held the course, with nothing before them but water going out flat to a rim that never came any nearer for all they sailed toward it. He said the food ran thinner than they had reckoned and the water thinner still, and that there were whole days none of them spoke, because a man's mouth was too dry to waste on anything but the oar. Then, he said, his voice dropping so low that those who sat by him had to lean in close to catch it, as though he were telling something he half believed himself and half thought he must have dreamed in his thirst, they came on a land.

It rose green out of the water on a morning when none of them had strength left to hope for it, he said. It was a green such as none of them had ever seen on any hill of Dia-thìr, a green that seemed to hold its own light apart from the sun rather than only catching what the sun gave it. There was fruit on the trees down almost to the tideline, and a spring of sweet water broke out of the rock not a stone's throw from where they beached the boat, and they drank until their bellies ached and slept where they fell and woke with strength in them they had not carried since they left home. He said the people of that land came down to them without fear, neither young nor old to look at, none of them marked by time the way every face on Dia-thìr was marked by it, and that they were made welcome as though welcome cost that land nothing at all, because there was more of

everything there than anyone could use in a life, and more life, it seemed, than any of them had ever thought to ask for.

He said his uncle would not leave.

That one thing at least, the tellers say, had stayed whole in the boy's mind through everything else the sea had done to it, and he told it plainly where the rest of his telling wandered. Bran had stood on that shore, he said, and looked back once at the boat drawn up on the sand, and told the boy he was free to go home if home was what he wanted, and that no one would think the less of him for wanting it. He himself had followed a question the whole length of his life to get to that shore, Bran told him, and he would not turn from it now that his feet were standing on the answer.

Of the other three men nothing certain is told. Some say they stayed beside Bran of their own will; some that the sea took them on the way home and only the boy, youngest and lightest of the five, lived to be carried the whole way back on whatever swell or storm set him down again on his own coast. The boy himself could not say which was true, and would not guess at it even when pressed. What he did say, more than once and always the same way, was that his uncle had held him by both shoulders on that green beach and told him: go home, and tell them the truth of it, and no more than the truth, and let them believe what they will of it after. Bran had put him back in a small boat alone, with water and dried fish enough for the crossing, though how a small boat crossed what the great one had barely crossed, and how a boy alone found his own coast again when five men together had needed the better part of a summer and Bran's own eye on the swell to find that other shore, none of the tellers who kept this after him have ever been able to say, and none of them pretend to.

The household that carried him home did what could be done for a body so far gone in thirst and sun, and for the first two or three days thought they might yet keep him. They laid him nearest the fire and gave him broth before water, a little at a time through the night, and one or another of the kin sat by him at every hour so that he never once woke to an empty room. Word of him went along the coast faster than any of them could stop it, and by the fourth day there were strangers at the door asking to see the boy who had crossed the western sea, and had to be turned away for his own quiet.

He lived eleven days after they carried him in from the shingle, long enough to say what he said to his mother, and to Blàthnaid, and to two or three others who sat with him by turns, and no longer. He grew quieter each of those days rather

than stronger, and on the last of them asked that the door be left open so he could see the water from where he lay. The failing light of that evening was the last he saw, and the last thing he was heard to say, more than once in those eleven days, was that it had not been an unkind land, and that his uncle had not looked afraid.

IV

Of Blàthnaid's Hushing

What the boy said did not stay in one mouth. It could not; too many had sat by him in his dying to keep it to themselves, and a telling of that kind does not wait to be asked for before it goes from hearth to hearth. Within a year it had gone the length of that coast and some way inland besides, gathering, as every telling gathers in the going, a little more certainty than the boy himself had ever claimed for it. Men who had never been within sight of the boat spoke of the land in the west as though they had walked on it themselves. Boys not yet grown talked, the way boys do, of building craft of their own and finding it for themselves, and one household lost a fifteen-year-old for the better part of a night before he was found sitting on the shingle in the dark with a coracle he had no business taking out, only looking west, and was brought home and beaten and wept over in the same evening.

It was after that night that the elders of the shore, kin of Bran's household and of two others besides, sat together at a fire none of the young were let near and agreed, without much argument, that the telling had done all the good it was going to do and would now only do harm. They did not forbid the speaking of it outright; a thing forbidden is a thing every young man on a coast wants to hear twice over. They let it fall instead the way a fire is let fall when no one feeds it. No one told it new to a child who had not already heard it. No one who came asking after strangers' talk of it got a straight answer. Within a generation there were households on that same shore whose children had never heard Bran's name at all, and grew up knowing only that some kin of theirs, long ago, had once built an over-large boat for reasons nobody now troubled to remember, and had lost it, and that was thought reason enough to build no other like it. A boy of that later generation who asked his grandfather why no one on that shore built boats bigger than the seal grounds needed was told only that a big boat once went out and did not come back, and that the sea did not reward greed in a hull any more than it re-

warded greed in a net, and the boy took the answer for the whole of the matter and never asked again.

Blàthnaid alone did not let it fall all the way. She kept the promise she had asked of her brother the night before he sailed, though he was never there again to be asked anything further of, and she kept it, in the years after, the only way left to her: by holding the whole of it in her own mouth and giving it out, once, to one person only, long after the shore's common fire for the telling had been let die. She was an old woman by then, and the daughter she told it to was near grown herself, and the two of them sat alone at a hearth Blàthnaid had banked and covered rather than let its light show through the door, the way that shore had by then come to keep its fires of an evening when a telling not meant for every ear was going to be said over them. The whole of it she told her daughter as the boy had told it to her: the green land, the spring, the welcome that cost nothing, the uncle who would not turn from a question he had followed his whole life to answer. She did not tell it as a warning, the way the elders' hushing had meant it, in the end, to be kept. She told it, her daughter said afterward, the way a woman tells a thing she has been keeping warm a long time against the day someone would finally ask to hear it.

"And his name," she said, when the telling was done and the fire had sunk to nothing under its covering stone, "was Bran."

She died some twenty years after, an old woman by any count that shore kept, and what she had told her daughter that one evening went on after her from mother to daughter in the same low voice at the same covered fire: further, with each telling, from the shore's common talk, and closer, in its way, to what a thing becomes when only one mouth at a time is trusted to carry it. It was kept dim on that coast rather than forgotten outright, and it was never again said where the young could hear it start.

OF BRIAN and the Buried Five

VE 2,861 – 2,936

I

Of the Man Who Dug the Graves

Seven hundred years had gone by since Fearghas let the white-flecked coal fall from the height of his arm and saw it catch fire halfway down the rock and lie burning on the stones like a star come down before its time. Since then the summit had taken the kindred's name and kept it, and herders left a stone on the top when they passed, and at Tobar dhìreach the recital was said every year on Oidhche an Dealanaich¹ with two colours answered and five still dark in the bag: the black, the red-brown, the silver, the one that woke at a snap of the fingers, and the rainbow that held them all and answered to none. Children of the line grew old hearing it and died leaving it no further on than they had found it. It had come to be said, among households that were not of the line and had no cause to be kind about it, that An Clachair²'s people would go on asking the same question until the island wore down to the sea.

Brian was born into that waiting and paid it little mind. A plain man, thought plain by those who knew him, he wore the word without complaint. He dug the graves of the valley. It was not an office anyone had given him; his father had done it before him, a little, alongside his proper work of herding, and Brian had found in himself a steadiness for it that others lacked, and by the time he was two-and-

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

2. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

twenty it was understood that when a death came to any of the hearths above Tobar dhìreach, someone went for Brian.

He was a big-shouldered man, slow to speak and slower to laugh, with hands scarred across the backs from stone he had turned in a hundred diggings. He kept his own counsel about the dead, the way another man kept his counsel about a debt. When a child of the black-well household died of a fever in his twentieth year he dug through frozen ground for the better part of two days without once cursing it, and when he had finished he sat by the raw earth a while before he would take the food that was brought to him, though no one asked him to and he never said why. Those who worked beside him said only that he was good at it, and better than good, and let it go at that, for it is not an easy thing to praise a man for burying your dead well, and the valley had not found the words.

He married Caoimhe in his one-and-twentieth year, before the whole valley had settled on calling him for its dead. She was of a herding household two valleys east, a quick, sharp-tongued woman who could set a whole hearth laughing with a single word and who had, more than one of her kin said, married beneath her wit if not beneath her worth. She used to say of Brian, to those who would listen, that he had courted her the way he dug a grave: without hurry, without noise, and with his eyes down at the ground the whole time, so that it was three seasons before she was sure he had meant it. It was fondly said, and truly.

They had no children who lived past their first winter, three of them, one after another, and this the valley also understood without being told, in the way a valley understands most things about its own people, and let alone. Caoimhe kept a hearth that was warm to visitors and cold to pity. Brian dug on.

It was work that gave a man time to think, more than most, for the labour of it did not fill the mind the way herding or splitting stone filled it, being slow and repeated and requiring no more of him than his back and his hands, hour on hour, in earth that did not care how carefully he opened it. He had grown up, like every child of the high valleys, on the telling of the mason and the lightning and Coimhdeach na Fine³ in the grove, said at his own hearth and at every hearth he visited, for it belonged to no one household by then; it was the valley's own tale, told to strangers before the strangers had finished sitting down. He had heard Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁴ a thousand times before he understood it was a riddle and not merely a saying:

3. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

4. the Keeper's riddle

Tha spiorad fa leth san speur, san talamb agus sa mhuir. Meascaich na spioradan agus bidh iad uile-chumbachdach. The sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit. Merge the spirits, and they become almighty.

Two of the seven had answered already, long before any grandfather now living could remember, and further back than that: the sea had taken gual òir⁵ on the swell of the northern shore, and the sky had taken the white-flecked coal in the empty air above the height that bore the kindred's name now. Of the sea and the sky Brian knew only what every hill-child knew, which was little, for he had never gone so far as either; he had walked as far as the market at Àth gharbh once in his life and no further. What he knew, and knew better than most men in the valley knew anything, was the earth. He had put his hands into it more times than he could count, and taken more out of it than he had put in, if a body counted for anything; the tellers said it did not, and Brian left such reckoning to them.

II

Of What a Plain Man Thought

The line still kept the five dark coals in the leather bag that had held all seven once, and still tried them, though less often than it had, for the trying had worn down a great many hopes across the generations and left less each time to spend. They had been thrown into rain and left in it a season; they had been carried down into the wet air above the black well and the young well and held there through a whole spring; they had been laid in one fire all together, on the reasoning that if each answered its own element perhaps all together they might answer each other, and burned dark as any stone burns, giving off nothing but the ordinary red glow of heat and none of the promised fire. Diarmad's own grandchildren had tried carrying them in skins of sea-water home from the northern shore and pouring the water over them at the hearth, which struck most of the valley, when it heard of it, as a fair example of how far a household could go on an idea that had already failed once.

Brian had never gone near the bag. It belonged to the eldest women of the line, kept as it had been kept since Fionnghuala's day, and a man who dug graves for his bread had no more claim on it than the herder two valleys off. He heard

5. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

the trying discussed, as everyone in the valley heard it discussed, at every gathering and every recital, the older folk arguing over which shore, which height, which season, as though the failure of seven hundred years could be mended by trying the seventh height instead of the sixth. He listened the way he listened to most talk, without much to say, turning it over slowly the way he turned a spade in unfamiliar ground, feeling for where it gave.

What struck him, when it struck him, was not clever. He said so himself, afterward, more than once, to those who wanted to make more of it than there was. He had been standing at the edge of a fresh-dug grave, waiting on the kin to bring the body down from the hearth, on a grey morning in his seven-and-twentieth year, and he had looked down into the black earth he had opened and thought, the way a man thinks of an ordinary thing without meaning to think of anything at all: *this is where the dead go, and the dead lie still, and the earth takes them and does not give them back.* And on the heel of that thought, without his calling for it, came another: *the sea took its coal by being waded into. The sky took its coal by the coal being thrown into the sky's own air, from as high as a man could climb. If the earth is to take a coal, the coal must go where the earth is deepest, and be left to it, the way a body is left to it.*

He was a slow man with an idea, the way he was slow with everything. He finished the grave he was digging, and saw the dead put into it, and stood at the edge with the rest of the valley while the words were said over it, the same words said over every grave in the high valleys, asking the ground to hold what was given it gently. Three days went by before he said anything to Caoimhe, and a fortnight more before he said anything to the eldest of the women who kept the bag, an old widow named Sireadh who had held it longer than Brian had been alive.

"You want to bury them," she said, when he had got it out, plainly and without much art, the way he said everything.

"I want to try it," Brian said.

"It has been tried," said Sireadh. "In the rain. In the wet air by the wells."

"Not this," Brian said. "Deep, and left there. The whole night through."

The old woman looked at him a long while, the way she might have looked at a piece of ground she was deciding whether to trust, and at last she said what many of the line had said before her, across the generations, to one idea or another: that it could do no harm, since the coals were dark already and had been dark as long as anyone living had known them, and a man who spent his days putting things into the ground might, for once, know something the rest of them did not.

III

Of the Grave Beside the Slab

She would not let him take the whole bag, nor all seven, for the two that had answered were not hers to risk on a guess, however good the guesser; but she gave him the five that were left, wrapped in a fold of undyed wool, and told him to bring them back whole, whatever came of it.

He chose the ground beside Leac na Fèithe¹. It was the plainest choice in the world to him and he never understood, afterward, why anyone should think it strange; Leac na Fèithe at Tobar dhìreach was the one place on the island where the earth was known, past doubting, to have held fire once, for the vein still lay under it, covered these seven hundred years and more, and if the earth had a spirit at all it seemed to Brian no more than sense that the spirit should be nearest where the earth had already shown it could hold such a thing. No one drew water beside Leac na Fèithe, and no house was built near it, and the ground there was given over to grass and to the recital that was said standing on it once a year; it was as close to consecrated as any ground in the valley came, though that word belonged to no one yet.

He dug on an evening in the middle of an t-Sultain, when the barley was in and the light was going early and there was a smell of turned earth and woods-moke over the whole valley. He dug it the depth of a grave, no more and no less, for it was the only depth he trusted himself to judge by feel, and he lined it, as he lined the graves he was known for, so that the sides would not fall in on what was laid there before morning. Caoimhe came out to watch him at it, wrapped against the evening cold. Neither of them held digging to be woman's work, and she offered him no hand with it, but she stayed the whole while, sitting on an old quern-stone near Leac na Fèithe with her knees drawn up, watching her husband dig what half the valley by then, having heard the word of it, was calling the sixth grave he had dug for the line, though nothing of the line's was dead.

"They will say you have buried it," she told him, once, into the quiet. "The hope of it. However this comes out."

"Let them," Brian said, and went on digging.

Others came, in ones and twos, as the light failed, drawn by the word the way word always drew a valley to anything out of the ordinary: an old man of the

1. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

north hearths who had tried the coals in his own youth and failed with them and had opinions still; two of Sireadh's grandchildren, sent to watch and report back what was done, since the old woman's knees no longer let her stand at a graveside past dusk; a boy who had no business there at all and was sent home twice and came back a third time and was let stay, since by then Brian had stopped noticing who watched him and who did not. The talk among them was low, and one voice did not agree with the next. Some held that burying the coals was no different, in its bones, from throwing them in the sea or the rain, one more trying among many, no likelier to answer than the rest. One or two, more sourly, said that a grave-digger ought to know better than most what the earth did with things put into it, which was nothing, which was keep them, unchanged, or eat them slowly down to nothing at all, and that neither keeping nor eating was the same as answering.

Brian heard all of it and answered none of it. When the hole was as deep as he wanted, he climbed down into it himself, though it came near to his shoulders, and Caoimhe passed the five coals down to him one at a time, unwrapped now from the wool, dark and ordinary-looking in the last of the light, five pieces of blackish stone that might have been swept up off any hearth in the valley. He laid them at the bottom close together, the way a mason sets stones that must bear together, and stood over them a moment with his hands still dusty from the digging.

"I don't know the words for this," he said, half to Caoimhe, half to no one. "There are no words for burying a stone."

"Say what you say over the dead," said the old man of the north hearths, not unkindly. "It cost nothing to try."

So Brian said, standing in the grave he had dug for five coals as he had stood at the edge of a hundred graves he had dug for the valley's dead, the same words, asking the ground to hold gently what was given it; and no one there thought it strange, though the tellers, shaping the night into a telling of its own, would make much of how well the words fit.

He climbed out and filled the grave himself, working by the last light and then by starlight, tamping the earth down the way he tamped it over the dead, firm but not hard, so that the ground would settle true and not sink hollow later. Caoimhe brought him a brand from the hearth to see the last of it by. When it was done there was nothing to mark the place but turned earth, no different to look at from

any grave in the valley, lying in the grass a stone's throw from the flat slab that covered the vein.

The watchers went home in twos and threes, most of them saying, in one way or another, that they would come back in the morning to see. Sireadh's grandchildren ran the word back to her before they were properly indoors. Brian and Caoimhe stayed longest, sitting by the fresh earth as the night came down cold and clear, the kind of clear that comes after a warm harvest day, with more stars out than either of them troubled to count, until Caoimhe said at last that there was nothing more to be done by sitting, and they went in.

Neither of them slept well. Brian never said, after, what he had thought through that night, lying awake beside his wife with the ordinary sounds of the valley outside the door, a dog somewhere, the wind working at the thatch; but Caoimhe, old now and telling her own small part of a larger telling, said more than once that she had asked him that night in the dark whether he believed it would work, and that he had been quiet so long she thought him asleep, and then he had said: "I believe the earth keeps what's given it. I don't know if that's the same as answering." And she said that was the truest thing anyone in the whole long history of the question had said about it, though she never said it to his face, not wanting to spoil him with praise he had no use for.

IV

Of the Black Coal Warm in the Ground

he went out at first light, before Caoimhe was properly up, and by the time she came out to him he had already opened the grave down to where the earth was undisturbed by frost, working carefully now, with his hands more than his spade, the way he worked when he came near a coffin he did not want to mark. Word had gone round the valley faster than either of them, and by the time the five coals were bare in the bottom of the hole there were a dozen people standing at a respectful distance, among them Sireadh, who had got herself out that far on a grandchild's arm and would not be talked out of it.

Brian knelt and lifted them out one at a time, the way he had laid them, and laid each on the flat of his palm before he set it down on the grass beside him.

Four were cold. Cold the way any stone out of cold ground is cold, cold with the whole night's chill still in them, no different to the hand than they had been the evening before, dark, ordinary, dead.

The fifth was the black one, *gual dubb*¹, black as a wet crow's back, the same black the mason himself had first seen in the broken vein seven hundred years and more before that morning. Brian's hand closed round it out of habit, the same motion he used lifting any stone from a grave, and he had it half out of the earth before he understood what his hand was telling him, which was that it was warm.

He said, afterward, that he thought at first it was only the ground's own warmth, held over from some trick of the night, and it was Sireadh, watching from her grandchild's arm, who called out to him to hold it up so she could see, for she had kept coal and fire-pot both across sixty years and knew better than any living soul what a thing ought to look like when the earth had merely warmed it and what it ought to look like when it had not.

He held it up. In the grey of the morning, with the sun not yet over the eastern shoulder of the valley, a line of red crept across the black surface of the coal where the air first touched it, slow, the way the last coal of a banked fire creeps back to life when the ash is stirred from it, and then widened into a glow, deep in the black, red going toward gold at its heart, and a thread of smoke came up off it into the cold air, and it smouldered in his open hand the way a coal smoulders that has been fed all night and is only waiting to be blown on.

It did not burn him. He said that too, afterward, more than once, for it was the thing people asked him first: did it burn you. It did not. It lay in his palm warm as another man's hand is warm, no hotter, though it went on glowing and smoking gently the whole while he knelt there with it, and the four cold coals lying forgotten in the grass beside him, and the dozen people at the graveside gone entirely silent, so that the only sound in the whole waking valley, for what Caoimhe swore afterward was the length of a held breath and longer, was the small tick and whisper of a coal breathing.

"The earth took it," Sireadh said at last, into the silence, in a voice that had gone thin with more than age. "The answering came at the rising out of the ground, not the lying in it."

It was the truest word said that morning, and it held. The line had tried the coals in rain, and the rain had done nothing, for rain was the sea's business, not

1. the black coal, of earth

the earth's; they had held them in wet air, and the wet air had done nothing either, being neither one element nor another; but the earth, given the whole slow dark of a night to work in, undisturbed, had done what the earth does with anything laid deep in it and left, which was change it, patiently, from beneath, the way a seed is changed, or a body, though a body's changing goes the other way. The black coal had waited seven hundred years for someone to think of asking the earth for that much time, and Brian, who had spent his life giving the earth exactly that much time with everything he laid in it, had been the one man in all the valleys who thought to ask.

He did not go home first. He went, still kneeling, still cradling the warm coal in one hand and the four cold ones gathered up in the crook of the other arm, to Tobar dhìreach itself, to the hearth where Poit an Teine² was kept, and there before the eldest of the line and half the valley that had come running at the word, he set the black coal down among the embers of the mason's own fire, the fire that Clann a' Chlachair³ held to have burned, hearth to hearth, unbroken, since Oidhche an Dealanaich⁴; and it caught there the way any coal catches, low and steady, and burned on, red-hearted, the whole of that day and into the night, and did not go dark again.

V

Of the Long Keeping

Afterward he kept it in a plain clay pot of his own making, fired for the purpose, with a lid of turf he cut fresh each season to fit it; the pot of the line was another woman's charge, its own long watch, and no part of his to hold. He fed the coal wood and heather as any hearth is fed, and carried it with him, in the pot, banked and covered, wherever the year's work took him, so that for the better part of forty years there was not a night in the high valleys that Brian's black coal was not burning somewhere within a day's walk of Leac na Fèithe¹.

More times than he ever troubled to count, he was asked whether he thought he had answered Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich², whether the black coal's burning

2. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

3. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

4. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

1. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

meant the earth's spirit was in it now and no further finding needed. He always said the same thing, in one form or another, and Caoimhe used to say it word for word behind his back to make the children of the valley laugh, though there was no unkindness in it: that he had only asked the ground a question it was willing to answer, and that whether the answer was the whole of what Coimhdeach na Fine³ meant, or only a part of it, was a matter for cleverer heads than his, and he had graves to dig.

He went on digging them. The valley did not let a man of sixty stand at every graveside as it had let a man of thirty, and in his last years the heavier digging fell to younger hands he had himself taught the trade to, watching over how deep they went and how they lined the sides, for he held, and said often, that a grave badly dug was a poor last gift to give anyone; but he kept the black coal himself, banked in its pot by his own hearth, until the year he died.

He was three-and-sixty that year, worn more by the work than by any illness the valley could name, and Caoimhe, who outlived him by nine years and never remarried, said that he went the way he had put every one of the valley's dead into the ground before him: without complaint, and with his eyes on the work in front of him almost to the last, which in his case was nothing more than sitting by his own hearth watching the black coal glow.

They buried him beside Leac na Fèithe, near the ground he had first opened for the five coals, for it seemed to the valley, and to Caoimhe, that there was nowhere else so fitting; and the pot with the black coal in it was set beside the grave through the length of the burial, still burning, banked low, so that the last thing said over Brian, grave-digger of the high valleys, was said by a fire that owed its life to him and to no one else in the whole history of the question. When the words were finished and the earth given, Caoimhe herself lifted the pot and carried it home, and kept the coal burning at her own hearth the rest of her days, and after her it passed, as such things do, into other hands, banked and fed and carried on, one more small fire added to the fires the mason's line had already kept unbroken for the better part of three thousand years.

At the recital that was said on the next night of the lightning, the reciter of the line, coming to the old count of the coals, said it new for the first time in living memory: the sea had taken the gold, the sky had taken the white-flecked coal, and now the earth had taken the black, *gual dubh*², slowly, in the dark, the way the

2. the Keeper's riddle

3. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

earth takes everything it is given time enough with. Four remained unanswered: the red-brown, the silver, the one that would wake, if it woke at all, to no more than the snap of a hand, and the rainbow that held every colour and answered to none of them yet. It was, by every count the line still kept, some seven hundred and fifty years since the sky, and more than fifteen hundred since the sea, and no one standing at that recital thought the finding of the fourth would come soon; but it was said at that recital, and at every one since, that the earth's answer had come the way Brian himself had lived, without hurry and without noise, out of a man who asked it no more than the plain question a plain man asks, and waited, the one night through, for the ground to tell him what it knew.

Of the Stakes in the Mud and the Watcher in the Sea

VE 2,937 – 3,146

I

Of the Stakes in the Mud

The north-western point ran out low and black into the sea, a spine of rock worn smooth by a tide that came and went twice in a day and left, at its lowest ebb, a wide shelf of mud the colour of a bruise. The households that fished that stretch of coast knew the shelf the way a man knows the floor of his own house in the dark, by feel and by long habit rather than by looking, for it was seldom worth looking at: grey mud, grey stone, grey water going out to a grey sky, and nothing in any of it to hold the eye. They went out on it at the low tides to gather cockle and razor-shell, and to see to their own stakes, the short hazel posts driven into the firmer ground above the mud-line where the coracles were tied of an evening against a rising tide that would otherwise have carried them off to wherever the sea carried things it was given.

It was a boy minding his family's stakes, in the year the households later reckoned as some four generations back from Criomthann's own time, who found the others.

They lay further out than any household drove its own, in a line so straight that no eye could mistake it for anything the tide had arranged by accident: a row of posts, most of them broken off at the mud's surface and a few standing a hand's height proud of it, and caught about the base of one, worked down into

the silt until only a corner of it showed, a scrap of hide gone black and stiff as old leather left in a byre. The boy dug it free with his fingers and brought it home, and his father turned it over by the fire that evening and could make nothing of it beyond what his own eyes told him: that it had been stitched once, along one edge, with a neat close seam no different in kind from the seams every boatman on that coast sewed into his own hide boats, though finer than any hand on that shore now living could match.

Whose posts they had been, and what boat or boats they had once held against what tide, no one on that coast could say, then or after. They were not new work when the boy found them; the wood was grey through and through, and the hide had the look of a thing the sea had been working at for longer than any single life could account for. Some of the elders said the posts were old kin's work, driven by grandfathers of grandfathers no one living had known to speak to. Others said, in the low voice a man uses for a thing he does not care to say loudly, that the stakes were not kin's work at all, that no household on that coast had ever driven a mooring so far out into water no coracle of theirs had cause to sit in, and that whoever had rowed there had rowed from somewhere else and gone back to it, or not gone back at all. The mud gave up nothing further to settle it either way. It kept the stakes, half of them still standing after all those generations, and it kept its silence about the rest, and the households of that shore learned, the way they learned most things the mud and the sea would not answer, to let the not-knowing stand rather than fill it with a telling that pretended to more than it had.

They called it only the stakes, after that, when they had cause to speak of it at all, which was seldom; a landmark for the low tide, no more remarked than the black spine of rock itself. Children were shown it once, usually by an older cousin rather than a parent, with a shrug rather than a story, and grew up knowing it the way they knew the shape of the point, without ever quite wondering at it the way a stranger might have wondered. It sat in the mud below the north-western point for as long as anyone's telling ran back, half swallowed, patient, asking nothing and answering nothing, until the year *Uilebheist na Mara*¹ was first seen from that same stretch of water.

1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

II

Of the Watcher

The crew that saw it were four men out after mackerel in the grey hour before a summer dawn, working a net between two coracles lashed gunwale to gunwale the way that shore fished a big shoal, with the net paid out between them and the fish already knocking against the hide in numbers enough to make the morning's work a good one. The sea that morning lay flatter than any of the four had known it lie in a lifetime of going out on it, flat and pewter-coloured under a sky not yet decided whether it meant to clear, and it was into that flatness, off to the north where the water ran deep and no boat of that coast had reason to go, that the eldest of the four, a man near fifty who had fished that water since before any of the others were born, happened to look up from the net.

What he saw, he said afterward, more times than he ever wanted to say it again, was a back. Not a wave, not a rock, for there was no rock on any chart the coast kept in its head for that stretch of open water, and not a whale either, though it was the shape his mind reached for first and fastest, because a man's mind reaches always for the shape it already knows. It was too long for a whale and it broke the water wrong, rising without the roll a whale's back gives as it comes up to breathe, rising instead the way a low island might rise if an island could rise, smooth and dark and glistening where the light caught it, and it held above the surface for longer than any breathing thing he had ever watched hold, long enough that he had time to call out to the others and have all three turn and see it too before it went down again, without spray, without sound, the water closing over it as quietly as it had opened.

None of the four could afterward agree on how long it had shown itself, whether the span of ten breaths or the span of a hundred, which the tellers of that coast came in time to take as its own kind of proof, on the reasoning that a true wonder unmakes a man's count of things the way an ordinary sight never does. What they agreed on, all four, without needing to put their heads together over it first, was the size of the thing: bigger, by every man's reckoning, than the biggest whale any of them had brought a story home of, bigger than anything that had business being in water that shallow so close to shore, though none of them could afterward say with any confidence how far out it had lain, for distance on a flat morning sea is a hard thing for even a practised eye to judge.

They rowed home without finishing the net, which no man on that coast did for any lesser cause, and they told what they had seen before the fish they did bring in were so much as gutted, and within the day it had gone from that one household to every hearth within a morning's walk, growing, as such things grow, a little surer and a little larger in every mouth that carried it onward. By the second telling the thing had a name it kept from then on, though none of the four who saw it first ever claimed to have coined it: *Uilebheist na Mara*¹, *Uilebheist na Mara*, as though the old women who first fixed the name to it had reasoned, in the space of a single evening's talk, that a thing so patient in its rising and its going under again could only be watching, and had been watching, likely, for longer than any of them had been alive to know it.

Not every hearth believed the four had seen what they said they had seen. There were fishermen on that coast, in that first year and in every year that followed it, who held the whole telling to be nothing more than four tired men and a trick of flat light on deep water, and said so, sometimes to the four men's faces, in the blunt way one fisherman tells another he thinks him a fool without quite using the word. But the four did not change their account under any pressing, not that year and not in all the years after, and one of them, the youngest, carried the telling of it word for word into his own old age and told it to his grandchildren exactly as he had first told it to his own father, without adding to it or taking from it, which the coast came in time to count for more than any argument the doubters brought against it. Believed or doubted alike, the water off the north-western point went, from that year forward, by a name it had never needed before: *Uilebheist na Mara's* water.

III

Of the Beacon

Criomthann was born on that shore some five-and-twenty years after the four men saw what they saw, into a household of net-menders and boatmen no different in its trade from any other on that stretch of coast, though different in one particular that shaped him before he had any way of knowing it had: his mother's mother had been kin, at some remove no one

1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

troubled any longer to trace exactly, to the household that had once sent a great hull and five men west over the open sea and got back only a dying boy and a telling that was, by the time Criomthann was old enough to hear any of it, kept low and close and spoken of, when it was spoken of at all, at a covered fire rather than an open one. He grew up knowing the shape of that older grief without ever being told the whole of it plainly, the way a child on that coast came to know most things that mattered, by the silences round a subject rather than by anyone sitting him down to explain it, and it left him, from very young, with a caution about open water that some of his cousins mistook for want of nerve and none of them, in the end, ever managed to shame out of him.

He was not, by his own account and by every account his neighbours gave of him afterward, a bold man in any way that coast measured boldness. Never once, in all his years on that shore, did he build boats bigger than the water called for, or express the smallest wish to see what lay past the edge of sight to the west. What he had instead, and had in a measure none of his kin quite matched, was a steadiness that showed itself first in small things: a net mended so that it held a season longer than any other man's, a boy pulled from a rip current by Criomthann's own hand while three grown men still stood arguing on the shingle about the best way to go after him, a hearth kept banked through a winter storm that put out every other fire in the household's row of huts. By the time he was a young man grown, the shore had come to trust him with the kind of trust that is given seldom and taken back almost never, the trust given to a man who does the plain necessary thing before anyone has finished discussing whether it needs doing.

He was a score of years old, married a year and with his first child not yet walking, when the second of the great losses came to that shore, though it did not yet come from the water Uilebheist na Mara¹ had been seen in. A boat working close in below the point, in weather no worse than any boat on that coast went out in twice a week, went over in a swell that rose from nowhere any of the watchers on shore could afterward account for, and two men drowned within sight of their own hearth smoke, in water shallow enough that a third man, hauled out half-drowned himself, stood afterward and could point to the very patch of sea where his companions had gone under. It was not laid to Uilebheist na Mara, not by anyone, for the water was the wrong water and the drowning had the ordinary shape of any drowning that coast had known before the four men's telling ever

1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

began; but it happened in a year when Uilebheist na Mara's telling was still young enough on that shore to colour everything, and Criomthann, standing on the shingle with the rest of the household watching the third man dragged in, found himself thinking, not for the first time and not for the last, that the sea gave a man very little warning of the exact moment it meant to take something from him, and that a warning given late was no better than no warning at all.

He said as much to his wife that night, by their own hearth, with the child asleep between them, and she asked him what warning a man could give the sea that the sea would trouble itself to answer to. He had no answer for her then. It was another seven years before he had one, and when it came it came, by his own telling of it afterward, less as a thought arrived at than as a thing he found himself already doing, the way a man sometimes finds his hands at work on a task before his mind has finished deciding to begin it.

What he began, on the last headland of that coast, the one that stood highest and looked furthest out over the water where the four men had seen the back rise, was a fire.

It was not, at first, meant as anything more than what any fire on any headland might have been meant as: a mark for boats working late to steer home by, no different in kind from a dozen such fires kept on a dozen headlands the length of the island, wherever a household wanted its boats to find the shore in failing light. Criomthann fed it himself, most evenings, climbing the last steep pitch of the headland with an armful of driftwood and gorse after his own day's work was done, and for the first season or two no one on that coast thought it any more remarkable than a careful man's habit. It was only in the second year, when he began to keep it burning through the daylight hours as well, in fair weather when no boat needed a mark to find its way home by, that his own kin began asking him plainly what the fire was for.

He told them, when he told them at all, in few words, and the words changed from telling to telling while the sense of them held steady: that a man who watched water long enough came to feel, in his own body before his mind had properly reasoned it out, where the water changed its temper, and that the stretch off that headland, ever since the four men's telling, had felt to him like water that wanted watching rather than water that wanted trusting. He never once claimed to have seen Uilebheist na Mara himself, in all the years the fire burned, and when pressed on it he always said the same thing: that he had not needed to see it to believe four men who had no reason between them to agree on a lie, and that a fire

cost him little enough to keep, set against what it might, one day, be found to have saved.

The word he settled on to go with the fire, the word he began calling down to any boat that worked too far out into that stretch of water, came to him worn smooth over several seasons, the way a saying is worn smooth by repeated use, until only the truest, shortest form of it was left standing. By the time he had said it enough evenings running that his own children could say it back to him in their sleep, it had settled into the few short words every household on that coast came in time to know as well as they knew Aithris a' Chruthachaidh² itself:

Tionndaidh air ais. Chan ann dhutsa an t-uisce seo. Turn back. This water is not for you.

He called it down from the headland to any boat he judged had strayed too far into Uilebheist na Mara's water, in a voice pitched to carry over wind and surf both, a voice his own sons said they could still hear plainly enough asleep in their own beds a full night's memory away. Most boats that heard it turned without argument, for a warning shouted from a headland by a man known the length of that coast for steadiness rather than fancy was not a warning easily laughed off, whatever a man might privately think of Sea-Watchers and old women's tellings. A few did not turn, in those first years, and came to no harm for the not turning, which some on that coast took as proof the whole fear was overblown and others took as no proof of anything at all, since a warning given need not be answered by disaster every time it goes unheeded in order to be a true warning.

The fire burned on. Criomthann tended it himself for close on forty years, through every season and every weather that coast gave him, adding wood and gorse and, in the leanest winters, peat cut specially for the purpose from a bank his own household kept aside and touched for nothing else, so that the fire on the last headland was never once let go dark in the whole span of his tending it. He was three-and-sixty, and had been a widower nine years by then, his own wife carried off by a fever that took half the young children of that shore with her in the one bad season, when his own strength began, at last, to fail the climb; and it was his eldest son, and after him his son's son, who kept the fire fed from the year Criomthann's legs would no longer carry the wood up the last steep pitch, so that the

2. the Telling of the Making

flame he had first lit for no reason he could fully put into words burned on above the water long past the reach of his own life.

He died at four-and-sixty, in his own bed, with three generations of his own kin about him, having outlived, by then, every one of the four men whose telling had first sent him up that headland with an armful of driftwood in his arms. His own asking was to be buried on the lower slope of the headland itself, apart from the household's other dead, within sound, his sons said afterward, of the fire he had kept; and the fire went on being kept above him, generation folding into generation the way fire on that coast was always kept, fed by hands that had never seen Uilebheist na Mara and never once doubted that there was good cause to feed it.

IV

Of the Widows of Ros ruadh

It was Criomthann's grandson who was tending the fire, some years into his own turn at the keeping of it, when the season came that the whole of that coast afterward reckoned the worst it had known.

It began, as the worst seasons on that coast most often began, in weather that gave no warning at all of what it meant to take. A calm settled over the water in early summer of the kind fishermen prayed for and seldom got in full measure, day after day of flat grey-green sea and a wind too light to trouble a coracle's balance, the sort of run of weather that filled a household's stores for a whole winter if a crew worked it hard enough while it lasted. The boats of Ros ruadh, a fishing settlement some way down the coast from the headland where the fire burned, close enough that its own boats had heard Criomthann's call turned back more than once in his lifetime and his grandson's after him, went out harder that season than any season in living memory, for a calm like that one was not a thing a fishing household let go to waste.

The first boat did not come back from an evening's work that any of the watchers on shore could afterward point to as different, in any particular they could name, from a hundred evenings before it. It had gone out with three men aboard, working water well inside what any household on that coast called safe, in sight of the shore for most of the day, and it simply did not come home with the tide, and no wreckage of it, then or ever after, washed up on any shingle the

length of that coast for anyone to find. A second boat went the same way eleven days later, from a different household and a different stretch of that same calm water, with two men aboard this time, and again no wreckage, again no storm any watcher on shore had marked, again only the tide coming in as it always came in and the boat that should have ridden it home simply not among the boats it brought.

By the time the seventh boat failed to return, in a season that had by then gone on calm for longer than any fisherman on that coast could remember calm holding, there was no household left at Ros ruadh untouched by it, for seven boats lost from one settlement in one season, out of the handful that settlement kept afloat at any time, meant there was scarcely a hearth in the place that had not lost a father, a son, a brother, or all three together, to water that showed no storm, gave up no bodies, and left no boat's timber behind to say what had taken it.

The widows of that season were the ones who first said, plainly and at every hearth that would let them say it, what half the coast had until then only thought and not spoken: that Uilebheist na Mara¹ had taken them. It was not the four men's telling, grown old and half-doubted by then in some mouths, that gave the widows their certainty; it was the plain fact, turned over at every hearth in Ros ruadh through that whole terrible summer, that seven boats crewed by careful men working water they knew like their own hands had gone under, one after another, in a season with no storm in it to blame, in water that lay within a morning's row of the stretch a headland fire had been kept burning against for two generations by then. What else, the widows asked, and asked in a way that was less a question than a naming, could take seven boats from calm water and leave nothing behind to say how, if not the very thing the fire on the headland had been lit to warn against in the first place.

It was the first time on that whole coast that a loss had been laid at Uilebheist na Mara's door by name rather than only feared in its shadow, and once said it was not unsaid again. The tellers who carried the telling onward in the years after gave the widows themselves the naming of it, and said, more than one of them, that a fear kept general and nameless for two generations had needed only one bad season, and the plain grief of women who had buried nothing because there was nothing left to bury, to become a fear with a name fixed to it for good.

The fire on the headland burned harder that year than in any year since Crimthann first lit it, fed, the tellers say, not only by his grandson's hands but by kin

from three households besides, men and women who climbed the headland of an evening with what wood they could spare, as though a fire fed by more hands might somehow answer for what seven boats' worth of careful seamanship had not been able to answer for. It went on being fed, year on year after that season, long past any living memory of the seven who had been lost in it, banked by night and built up by day, tended by hands that had themselves been born after the worst of that summer and grown up knowing the fire only as a thing that had always burned there and always would, until its ash, heaped and shifted and heaped again on the same patch of ground for lifetime after lifetime, stood a man's own height deep on the headland where it was kept, deep enough that a boy sent up to feed it could stand in the hollow of it and be seen from below only from the shoulders up.

Of the seven boats themselves nothing further was ever told. No wreck came ashore in any season after to close the account, no drowned man's body was ever found on any shingle to be carried home and buried where the rest of Ros ruadh's dead were buried, and the coast, having no better answer to give and having by then a name it trusted to stand for whatever the true answer was, let the not-knowing settle the way it had let the stakes in the mud settle two generations before, without pretending afterward to know more of it than it did. What Ros ruadh kept, in place of graves it had no bodies to fill, was the empty places on its own shingle where seven boats had once been drawn up of an evening among all the rest, spaces the households marked for years after by habit rather than by any need, walking round them at the tide's edge the way a man walks round a grave he does not mean to stand on, until the shingle itself, shifted by enough winters' tides, no longer held even the memory of where the seven boats had lain, and only the fire on the headland, and the telling the widows had first given a name to, remained to say that they had ever gone out from that shore at all.

1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

OF the Lee of the Headlands and the WRITING in the Hills

VE 3,147 – 3,303

I

Of the Boats That Kept the Land Close

For two generations after Criomthann's fire the boats of the north-west still went out by the old marks, keeping the headland on the left hand and the open water on the right, the way their fathers had gone before Uilebheist na Mara¹ had a name to be feared by. It was not fear alone that turned them in the end, or none of the tellers of that coast ever said so outright; it was the slow arithmetic of empty boat-places on the shingle, which any fisherman can do without being taught it, and which comes, in time, to the same answer as fear does.

The change was not a single season's work. A crew that had always worked the open water off the northern point began, without much said about it, to work the water in the lee of the headland instead, where the swell broke early and a boat could see the whole of its ground at once; and the next season two more crews did the same, and by the time a boy born the year the fire was first lit had grown old enough to take an oar himself, there was hardly a hide boat left on that coast that put out past the last headland while the light held. The change carried its own cost, which the shore hearths counted as carefully as they counted the empty places: seal thinned where the old grounds had always given seal, at Ros ruadh

1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

and along the outer skerries, and the middens that had grown for generations at those grounds grew slower, and in some years did not grow at all. But in the sheltered water south of the headlands, and along the strait where the tide ran quiet between the mainland and the near skerries, the middens of Bothan a' Chaolais² rose faster than they had ever risen, shell on shell and bone on bone, until the oldest of the bothy folk said that a man might build a wall as long as a house out of what a single winter left there.

It was the strait folk themselves who first said it plainly, at a gathering that had no more purpose than the mending of nets and the telling over of who had lost whom that year. An old steersman of Bothan a' Chaolais, whose father had fished the outer grounds all his life and never once seen what his son now feared without having seen it either, put it the way it was afterward remembered: that the sea had not grown smaller, only that the island's hand had drawn back from the part of it a man could no longer trust, the way a hand draws back from a fire that has burned it once, without waiting to be burned a second time to learn the lesson again. No one at that gathering disputed him, and no one thanked him for saying it either, for there is little thanks going in a fishing camp for a man who says aloud what everyone has already done without discussing it.

The strait was not without its own dangers, for no water on Dia-thìr was without danger, but its dangers were the old, known kind: a squall coming down off the mainland heights faster than a boat could run from it, a rip where two tides met at the narrows, a rock that showed at low water and did not show at high. Against these a fisherman could set his knowledge and his oar and win more often than he lost. Against the other danger, the one that lay off the open coast and showed itself perhaps once in a generation and was never once proved false by any wreck brought home to argue with, there was nothing to set but distance, and distance the strait gave freely. So the boats came in from the open water, and the seal bones thinned at the old grounds and thickened at the new, and a whole coast learned, within the span of two lifetimes, to call a stretch of open sea its neighbour's water and not its own, though no one on it had ever seen the neighbour, and no one who had seen it had lived long enough to be believed twice.

2. the bothies of the strait; the north-shore seal camp on the strait (place 1010, site of burg 95)

II

Of Eimhir and the High Pastures

South of that coast, and a long day's walk inland from it, the land climbed into a country of thin soil and thinner grazing that the hill folk called, among themselves, the green grove country, for the oaks that had once stood there thick enough to darken a hillside, though by the time this telling opens the old grove itself had gone back to scrub and bracken and only the name remembered what it had been. It was harder country than the shore, and harder again than the broad valley where Clann a' Chlachair¹ kept its fire and its recital twelve miles to the north, and the households that worked it were fewer and kept closer to their beasts than to each other, each family holding its own stretch of high pasture through the summer months and coming down only for the worst of the winter.

Into one such household, some three hundred years after the black coal was warmed in the ground at Tobar dhìreach, though the hill folk reckoned their years less carefully than the valley did and would have said only that it was long since, a girl was born who was given the name Eimhir, and who grew, as most children of that country grew, first at her mother's hearth and then, as soon as her legs were long enough to keep pace with a flock on a slope, out on the high ground with the sheep and the cold and the wide grey sky. She was not a remarkable child by any account that survives her, quick enough with a crook and a whistle, slow to anger and slower to forget a slight, more comfortable, by most tellings, in the company of beasts than of people, which is no rare thing among those raised to that work. She knew the recital, as every hill child knew it, in the broken, half-understood way it reached households that stood twelve miles from the hearth where it was said whole, and she could recite the count of the coals — gold, white, black, and the four still unanswered — without being entirely certain, if pressed, which coal was which, or why the count mattered so much to the valley folk who came up now and then to trade wool for salt and talk of nothing else.

What she knew better than the recital was the ground itself: every fold of it, every seep and outcrop and stand of gorse for three valleys in either direction, learned the way any herder learns a country, through the soles of the feet more than through the eyes, over years of walking it in every weather the sky could

1. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

send. By the time she had seen twenty summers she could have walked the whole of her family's grazing blind, and often did, in the grey light before dawn when the flock needed moving before the day's heat brought the flies up from the bog.

It was in the course of that walking, and no more than that, that she came, on a morning in the season when the bracken was just turning, upon the face of rock that would give this telling of the hills its name.

III

Of the Cutting on the Stone

A ewe had strayed in the night, as a ewe will, up a narrow defile where the family did not usually take the flock, being poor grazing and awkward footing both; and Eimhir went after it before the light was properly up, more from habit than from any great worry for one animal among many, following the beast's own track through wet bracken into a fold of the hill she did not remember walking before, though she had thought she knew every fold within a day's reach.

The ewe she found easily enough, caught by a bramble and glad enough to be caught by a person instead. It was on her way back down, with the animal on a rope and the light coming up grey and slow behind the eastern ridge, that she stopped, for no better reason at first than that something in the corner of her sight did not sit the way stone usually sits.

The rock face rose sheer on her left hand, a grey scarp perhaps twice her own height, weathered the way every outcrop in that country was weathered, lichened in patches of orange and pale green. But across the lichen, where the surface had been struck away to bare stone beneath, ran lines: not the crack and tumble of frost-split rock, which she had seen a thousand times and would have known blind, but lines cut with intent, straight and angled and joined to one another in shapes that repeated, here and there, close enough to be the same shape said twice, the way a word is the same word said twice in a telling. They ran the height of the rock and along it for longer than her own arm span, more of them the further along the face she walked, the ewe forgotten on its rope behind her.

She had seen carved stone before. Every household in that country marked its boundary posts, and Clann a' Chlachair¹ itself, she had been told, kept the count

of the coals by mouth at Tobar dhìreach and said it standing, though she had never gone to hear it. But those marks she knew, plain notches and simple figures a person could learn in an afternoon. What ran across this rock face was neither plain nor simple, line after line of it, in a hand — if a hand it was, and not some older weather she did not have the word for — that she did not know at all, and had never heard any teller in her own hearth's memory claim to know either.

She stood a long while before she touched it. When she did, running two fingers along one cut line from where it began to where it stopped, she found the stone at the bottom of the groove smoother than the weathered face around it, as though wind and rain had not yet had the years to roughen what the tool had first laid bare; and yet the lichen at the edges of some of the cuts was old lichen, thick and long-established, telling her without words that whatever hand had made these marks had not made them yesterday, nor in her grandmother's day either.

And there was this, which she noticed last and remembered longest: in three places along the face, a passage of the cutting had itself been cut across, the clean lines broken by a second working, rougher than the first, done — she would have sworn it, standing there, though she could not have said how she knew — with the very same kind of tool, as if whatever hand had written the lines, or another hand that knew the same trade, had come back afterward, deliberately, to strike part of the writing out.

She left the ewe to find its own way home, which it did, being a sensible enough animal on level ground, and went down off that hill faster than she had come up it.

IV

Of the Word Going Down

She told her mother first, at the family's own hearth, in the plain, halting way a person tells a thing they themselves do not yet believe, and her mother, who had lived sixty years in that country and buried a husband and three of six children in it, did not laugh at her, which Eimhir noted and was grateful for long after she had forgotten most of what was actually said that morning. Instead her mother sent word, by the boy who carried salt between the hill house-

1. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

holds and the valley, to the two or three elders of that country whose opinion still carried weight beyond their own hearths, and within the week a small company of them had climbed the defile behind Eimhir to see the thing for themselves.

They were longer at it than she had been, and quieter. One of them, a bent man named for a grandfather three generations dead whose own name this telling does not keep, put his palm flat against the stone the way a person tests a beast for fever, and held it there a good while before he took it away again and said nothing at all, which unsettled the company more than any word he might have offered. Another, a woman who had outlived two husbands and kept, besides her flock, a longer memory of the hill country's own small tellings than anyone else living in it, walked the length of the writing twice, once each direction, and then said, in the flat voice of someone stating a fact rather than offering an opinion, that she did not know the hand, and did not know anyone, living or lately dead, who had ever claimed to know it, and that in her long experience a thing no one in a small country claimed to know was, more often than not, a thing that country would come, in its own time and by its own means, to know anyway.

She was right, though not one of the company standing at the rock face that morning could have said how she knew to say it, or how the knowing would come. It did not come as a telling handed down from someone who had read the marks, for no one on that hill, then or after, ever claimed to read them; the lines stayed as unreadable to the last hill-born child of that generation as they had been to Eimhir on the morning she first laid two fingers against them. It came the way certain things come to a small country that lives close together and talks at its hearths through the long winter evenings with little else to talk of: slowly, by no one path that could afterward be traced, gathering itself out of dreams two or three people swore, independently and without having spoken to one another first, that they had dreamed in nearly the same shape; out of a half-remembered scrap some old woman recalled her own grandmother saying, without recalling where her grandmother had had it from; out of the plain, wordless dread that settled, before any of it could be put into a sentence, over anyone who stood alone at that rock face after dark. By the time two winters had passed, there was not a hearth in that country that could not have told a stranger, if a stranger had ever come asking, what the cutting on the stone was held to say: that something had once walked those hills that did not breathe as a living thing breathes, and that it fell upon whoever lit a fire where it could see the light of it burning.

No one could say why breath and fire, of all things, should be bound together in the telling, and the hill folk, being practical people more given to watching their flocks than to turning over the whys of their own fears, mostly left the asking alone. It was enough, for most of that country, that the fear had come, and had come to more than one hearth at once, and agreed with itself too closely, dreamer to dreamer, to be set aside as one old woman's fancy.

V

Of the Cutting-Over

What none of the company at the rock face could account for at all, that first morning or in the years after, was the second working: the passages of writing struck across and spoiled by a hand using, as near as anyone with an eye for stonework could judge, the very tool that had cut the writing in the first place. Two thoughts went about the hearths concerning it, and neither ever won out fully over the other.

The first was that whoever had written the warning had come back to unwrite parts of it, out of some purpose no hill teller could guess at: to hide a name, perhaps, or a place, or some part of the telling too dangerous even for a warning to carry whole. The second, favoured by the woman who had walked the stone twice that first morning and by most who thought as she did, was harder and colder, and it was this: that the very thing the warning spoke of had done the defacing itself, offended, in whatever way such a thing could be offended, at having been written down and named where the light could fall on it. A hand that could scar stone the way another hand had first cut it was not a hand a sensible person went looking for after dark.

Eimhir herself, in the many years she lived after that morning, was asked more than once which of the two she held to, and by every account that survives her she never answered plainly either way, saying only, when pressed, that she had touched the smoothed groove of the first cutting and the rougher groove of the second with the same two fingers on the same morning, and that her fingers had told her nothing at all about which hand she should fear, only that both hands had been in earnest.

VI

Of the Years Between

The finding of the writing did not empty the hills, nor did it stop the flocks going up to the summer grazing, for a country that lived by its beasts could not afford a fear that kept it from its work, and the hill folk, whatever else is told of them, were not a people who let fear idle their hands for long. What it did, slowly, over the better part of two decades, was change the shape of the days: fewer households sent a child alone to the far pastures after the finding than had sent one before it, and fewer still let a fire burn low and unwatched through the small hours on a night when the wind came off the high ground with nothing in it a person could put a name to. The defile where Eimhir had found the ewe was given a wide berth by common unspoken consent, though sheep still strayed into it now and again, and were fetched, though never after dark and never by a child sent alone.

Eimhir herself went up past that rock face more times than she ever troubled to count, for a herder's country does not rearrange itself around one bad morning, and in time the going grew almost ordinary to her, the way any fear grows ordinary that a person must live alongside rather than flee. She married into a neighbouring household two valleys over. Of her husband this telling keeps only that he was a quiet man, steadier with beasts than with words, and that he outlived her by eleven years. She raised children on the same slopes she had herself been raised on, and taught them, as she had been taught, to read the weather and the ground and the temper of a flock before they were old enough to read anything else. What she taught them of the writing on the stone she kept plain and short, by every account: that it was there, that no one read it, that the hills had their own sense of what it meant, and that a fire built where the ridge could see it was a fire built carelessly, whatever else a person believed or did not believe about why.

Twice in those years word came up from that country of a thing seen on a ridge at dusk by travellers with beasts to drive home and the light failing on them before they were ready for it: an upright figure, unhurried, walking the crest against the last grey of the sky, with no breath standing in cloud above it though the night was cold enough to hang breath from every mouth and muzzle below. Both times the ones who saw it lived to tell it, and both times the telling agreed on the one particular that the hill folk came to hold above all others: that neither

party had had a fire lit or a light shown on the path, and that this, and nothing else they could name, was why they had come home to tell it at all.

VII

Of the First Covered Hearth

It was in the sixtieth year of Eimhir's own life, by the hill country's rough count, that a household two ridges to the east of her own — new to that ground, having come up from a lowland valley to take a grazing left empty by a family that had died out — dug its cooking fire down into a pit for the first time and roofed it over with a flat slab lifted on two low stones, so that no flame showed above the ground at all, only a slot of red light and a thread of smoke escaping sideways into the dark. They had heard the telling of the writing from their new neighbours within a season of arriving, as any newcomer to that country heard it soon or late, and had chosen, being cautious people in a country new to them, to give the fear more credit than a life's habit, and dig accordingly.

They were mocked for it a little, in the way any first departure from custom draws a little mockery before it is judged either foolish or wise, and one or two of the older households said openly that a family which had not lived in that country long enough to lose anyone to it had no business teaching the country its own fears back to it. But no one stopped them digging, and within the year two more households on the eastern side had done the same, more from watching the first family's fire burn on, unremarked and untroubled, through a whole hard winter, than from any argument put to them in words.

Eimhir watched the pit dug from a little way off, on the day the eastern family first cut it, and said nothing to anyone about it that this telling keeps, though her daughter, many years after, remembered her mother standing longer at the sight than the digging alone seemed to call for.

VIII

Of Eimhir's Own Hearth

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he did not dig her own fire down, that year or in any year that followed it, though she lived to see a fourth household and then a fifth take up the covered hearth after the first three, each a little more readily than the one before, the way any new custom gathers speed once enough hands have tried it and not been burned for the trying. Her own hearth stayed as her mother's had been and her mother's mother's before that, a ring of stones on the open floor of the house, the fire built up each evening and banked each night under its own ash, giving its light up through the smoke-hole in the roof for any ridge in that country to see, had anything been walking the ridges to see it.

Her daughter, grown and married with children of her own, asked her once, late in her life, why she had never dug the fire in, when half the hearths of that country had done it by then and the other half were talking of doing it before the next hard winter. Eimhir was an old woman by that time, by the standard the hill country kept for old, her hands slower on a crook than they had once been and her eyes gone milky at the edges, but her mind, by every account, no less her own than it had been on the morning she followed a strayed ewe up a defile she did not remember walking before.

She gave no answer at once, but sat, when the question was put to her, on the low stool she had used at her own hearth for the better part of forty years, with the fire built up before her the way she had always built it, open to the room and open, through the smoke-hole above, to whatever sky lay over the roof that night; and she looked at it a long while, the way a person looks at a thing they have looked at every evening of their life without, perhaps, ever once looking at it quite so closely, before she said what she said, which her daughter kept, and which is the last of Eimhir's own words this telling has to give: that she had touched the writing on the stone with her own two fingers before any hearth in that country had thought to cover itself against it, and that whatever the writing meant, and whatever walked the ridges when it chose to walk them, she was not going to spend the years she had left hiding her fire from the sky that had watched every fire her family had ever kept, on the chance that the sky had turned against her only now, in her own old age, after keeping faith with her the whole of her life before it.

She said no more than that, her daughter's telling has it, and went on looking at the fire, and the fire went on burning the way it always had, open to the room and to the roof and to whatever, if anything, watched from beyond it.

IX

Of the Years After

She died two years on from that evening, some sixty years after the finding of the writing, of no illness or misfortune the country could put a name to beyond the plain wearing-out of a long life honestly spent; and she was buried, as the hill folk buried their own, on a slope above her family's grazing, with no marker but a stone set on end and no telling but the one her children and her children's children carried on afterward at their own hearths.

Her own fire went out with her, banked for the last time by her daughter's hand and never built again in that house on the open floor; for her daughter, though she had defended her mother's choice to every questioner who asked it of her in Eimhir's own lifetime, dug the family's hearth into the ground within the year of the burial, and said, when asked why she had not done it while her mother lived, only that a daughter does not take a fire from a living mother's floor, whatever she herself might choose to do with her own.

By the time forty years more had passed over that country, the covered hearth had spread from household to household and ridge to ridge until an open fire, built up on the bare floor the way Eimhir had kept hers to the last, was a rare enough sight in the Doire uaine hills that a child born into a household that still kept one was asked about it by every other child at every gathering, the way a child is asked about any household custom that has become, elsewhere, a thing of the grandparents' time. It had not yet become the whole country's law, nor would it, this telling must own, for some years longer than either Eimhir or her daughter lived to see; there were households still, scattered along the country's quieter edges, that kept the old open floor through habit or stubbornness or a plain want of belief in a fear no living soul could any longer claim to have seen with their own eyes. But the hills had begun, by the century's turning, to keep their light low and covered more often than they kept it open, and to watch their ridgelines at dusk the way they had once watched only the weather; and what had begun on one morning with a strayed ewe and two fingers laid against a cut stone had become, by slow and uneven degrees, the shape of how a whole country lived after dark.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Of the Covered Hearths and the Nine

VE 3,304 – 3,407

I

Of Laoghaire and the Hearth Under the Slab

Forty-two years had gone by since the herder-girl who found the defaced lines on the rock faces of the Doire uaine hills had died an old woman with her own hearth still open to the sky, unwilling in the end to live any other way, though she had lived the last of her years knowing what the hills now knew and could not unknow: that the lines running for yards across the stone, cut over and cut over again by the same hand or the same kind of tool, told of something that walked without breathing and fell upon whoever lit a fire where it could see. On the eastern side of that country the first household to dig its own fire into the ground and roof it with a slab had by then been dead two generations, and most of the hearths that side of the hills had long since followed it below the turf. But the custom had come slower, and less certainly, to the quieter western valleys, where the ground ran higher and stonier and a household's neighbours were a morning's walk apart rather than a shout across a field; and it was there, in a valley that still kept as many open hearths as covered ones, that the argument the eastern side had already half settled went on being argued still. Two of the earliest pits dug on that side had shown, on windless nights, a thread of glow at the smoke-vent that had frightened the households that dug them nearly as badly as an open fire would have, and it had left a fair part of that country unsure whether the

ground itself had made them any safer or only given them a new way to be careless.

Whether a fire kept low was fire enough hidden, whether the walker minded smoke or only flame, whether a people that had carried its light from hearth to hearth since before any of them could count backward should now go creeping about in the dark of its own valleys like thieves in another man's house: all of it was argued over again, that western valley's own way, at every gathering.

Laoghaire was no thinker on the matter, by his own telling of himself and by everyone else's telling of him after. He was a digger of ditches for the water off the high pastures, a big slow-spoken man with a spade-shaped scar across one forearm from a fall on wet rock as a boy, and what he brought to the question that had worn a generation thin with talking was a habit of hands rather than any answer. He had spent half his life putting things into the ground where the weather could not get at them: seed corn against the wet, the hides of slaughtered beasts against the crows, the small store of hazelnuts his household kept for the lean months, sunk in a clay-lined pit and lidded with a slab no fox or badger had ever worked loose. It was his wife, by the account the hills kept longest of the two of them, who said it to him first, more in weariness than in hope, on an evening when the argument had gone round the fire circle for the hundredth time and got nowhere: that the eastern hearths had already shown a fire could be put into the ground, and that if theirs still glowed at the vent on a still night, then the fault lay in the digging and not in the notion, and a man who could sink a pit for hazelnuts that no fox nor badger had ever worked open ought to be able to sink one for a fire that no eye on a ridge could ever find.

He did not answer her that night. He sat a long while with the fire between them going down to embers, turning the notion over the way he turned a stone over before he set a spade to it, looking for the grain of it. "A pit for hazelnuts keeps out crows," he said at last. "It does not keep out cold, or breathe, or want a way down a man can walk without breaking his neck." His wife said only that she had not told him it would be easy, and went to bed, and left him sitting by the fire a good while longer, watching the low light of it climb the smoke-blackened roof-poles and thinking, by his own account to his sons, that a fire seen from above at that hour would carry a very long way over open ground.

He went out at first light instead, alone, to a shoulder of ground below his own house where the soil ran deep enough for a man to dig his own height without striking rock, and he began.

It was harder work than any pit he had cut for corn or hide, for a fire could not simply be dropped in and lidded; it wanted air to breathe by, and a way down to it that would not throw light where light could be seen. He dug a hole a man's height in depth and near two men's lengths across at its widest, and cut into one wall of it a slanting shaft no wider than his own shoulders, angled so that a man going down it went down blind, with the last stretch bent enough that no glow from below could climb it straight to the surface. At the bottom he laid a floor of flat stones and built his hearth upon them as any hearth was built, wood and peat and a coal carried down in a clay pot from the household fire above, and over the whole pit, resting on a low kerb of stone he had set into the sides for the purpose, he laid a great flat slab dragged down from the scree on a hide sledge by himself and his two elder sons, with a gap left at one corner no wider than a man's forearm, for the smoke to find its own slow way up through a crack in the turf a good ten paces off, where it thinned in the heather and told nothing to anyone looking down from above.

The digging took him the better part of three days, working alone through the first and calling his sons to the slab-dragging on the third, and there was a moment on the second evening, kneeling at the bottom of his own half-finished pit with the light gone from the sky above him and nothing but a hand's width of grey dusk showing at the top of the shaft, when he owned afterward to a fright that had nothing to do with any beast that walked the ridges: the plain, ordinary fright of a man who has dug himself into the ground and cannot, for the length of a held breath, remember which way the shaft bends. He came up that evening faster than he had meant to, and said nothing of it to his wife, and went down again the next morning as though the moment had not happened, for a man who dug ditches for a living did not let one bad breath in a hole turn him from a job half done.

He slept beside it the first night it was whole, in the pit, on the excuse of tending it, though everyone who knew him understood well enough that he wanted to be the one below if the thing he had built proved no better than the two glowing pits on the eastern side that had failed to settle anyone's mind before him. On his back on the packed earth with the fire's small light moving on the underside of *Leac na Fèithe*¹ above him, close enough to touch if he reached, and listened, he said, for a long time to nothing at all: no wind, for the pit took the wind clean

1. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

away, no voice, no step on the turf overhead that the earth might have carried down to him, only his own fire's small talk and his own blood in his ears. Nothing came. He came up at first light with soot on his hands and grass seed in his hair from the crawl up the blind shaft, and told his wife only that it had held its heat through the dark better than any open hearth he had ever slept beside, which was true and was also, everyone agreed afterward, not the whole of what he had gone down to learn.

It was the whole of what he could tell them, and it proved, in the end, to be enough. Word of the blind bend and the offset vent went from his own hearth to the next and from that to the next again, the way any useful thing went in those hills, carried by whoever had seen it and told plainly, without ornament, to whoever asked; and within the season the two families whose own pits had glowed at the vent came and stood at the lip of his, and went home, and dug theirs afresh on his pattern. Within two years there was a scoffer's name for anyone west of the ridge still keeping an open fire on the old pattern, and within five it was the open hearth that wanted explaining and the covered one that needed none. Laoghaire himself dug three more in the years that followed, one for a widowed sister and two for households that begged the digging of him outright rather than trust their own hands to the angle of the shaft, for he alone among them seemed to hold in his head, without ever setting it down as a rule anyone could repeat back, exactly how far the blind bend had to run before no glow climbed it, and how wide the vent had to be to draw the smoke away thin and slow rather than in a column any eye above could follow to its root.

He was six-and-sixty, and had outlived two of his own children and buried them under no marker louder than a plain heaped stone, when he died in his own house on a night no different from any other, his wife said afterward, save that he had gone to check the pit himself before bed as he had gone every night of his life since the first, out of a habit by then worn as smooth and as unremarked as breathing. He was buried, at his own long-standing wish, not beside the pit he had dug first, which his sons kept in use for another three generations after him, but on the shoulder of ground just above it, where he had stood the morning he began to dig and looked down, his wife said he had told her once, at nothing more than a patch of bare soil that had not yet become anything.

II

Of the Hearth That Would Not Be Covered

At Tobar dhìreach, a long day's walk to the north, the fire that had come down from the mason's own well had never once, in all the generations since Diarmad first carried Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹ home from the grove, been put under a slab or a skin or anything else that stood between it and the open sky. It burned where it had always burned, in the low stone ring at the centre of the line's own house, with the clay pot that held what the line called the mason's first fire set always within an arm's reach of it, and the leather bag of the six dark coals and the one that would not darken hung on its peg above, and no household of Clann a' Chlachair², in all the years the covered hearth spread through the hills to the south, so much as dug the first spadeful of earth to make one of its own.

It was not that the word had failed to reach them. Travellers carried it, as travellers carried everything, and kin by marriage from the Doire uaine households brought it plainer still, standing in the doorway at Tobar dhìreach with soot still under their nails from a pit dug that same season and asking, some of them gently and some of them not, why a people who kept the mason's own fire, of all the fires on the island, should be the one household too proud or too stubborn to learn from its neighbours.

The man who kept the pot in those years — his name is not given here, for it is a rule older than any single teller that the fathers of the line between Brian and the one the hills came in time to call Cormac of the Misstrike are kept by the recital and given to no stranger who asks, and a telling carried beyond the hearth is a stranger before it is anything else — heard the question put to him more than once at his own hearth, and gave, by every account that has come down of it, the same answer each time, in words that varied a little from telling to telling but held to the one shape.

The fire in this house, he said, was not kept for warmth alone, nor even chiefly for warmth, though it warmed them as any fire warmed any house. It was kept because the mason's own hands had carried the first of it out of the ground on a flat stone under his cloak, and because every fire on the island, the pit-fires of the Doire uaine hills not excepted, traced back through some chain of borrowed em-

1. the Telling of the Making

2. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

bers to this one ring of stones and no other. A fire that had never once, in all those generations, been let go dark could not now be hidden without becoming, in the hiding, a fire like any other fire that a household banked low against its own fears; and the line held, rightly or not, that Teine a' Chlachair³ was owed better than to be treated as though it were no different from a peat-stack fire on a hillside that had reason to be afraid.

There were those at Tobar dhìreach, in those same years, who thought this reasoning proud rather than wise, and said so, and one branch of the kin did in the end dig a covered hearth of its own, apart from the line's own house, keeping the open fire only for the recital nights and banking the household's daily fire below ground the rest of the year, a compromise that satisfied neither the boldest nor the most fearful among them and was, by most tellings, quietly let drop again within two generations. But the line's own hearth, the one ring of stones the pot and the bag were kept beside, stayed open through every year of the trouble that follows in this telling, and stays open, so far as any teller of the hills can say, to this day.

III

Of the Nine

There was a hill camp in those years in the south of the massif, a scatter of huts where three or four households wintered their beasts close together against the worst of the weather, no larger and no smaller than a dozen such camps the hills kept, and no more remarked. It kept its fires the old open way still, being far enough from Laoghaire's own valley and young enough in the custom that the pit under Leac na Fèithe¹ had not yet been dug there, and no ill had come of it in all the winters the camp had stood, so that its households had come, as households will, to hold their own distance from the trouble a lucky thing rather than a borrowed grace.

The shepherd who found it, from a neighbouring valley and kin by marriage to one of the camp's three households, had gone up on an errand no more solemn than the borrowing of a ram, and noticed the lack of smoke only as a man notices

3. the mason's fire, the first fire

1. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

any small wrongness, a thing his eye caught before his mind had troubled to ask why. He stood a while at the foot of the last rise looking up at a sky with nothing rising into it from any of the huts, on a morning cold enough that his own breath hung white before his face, and told himself, walking up, three or four reasons a camp might let its fires go low on a still night that had nothing to do with anything worse. None of the reasons held by the time he reached the gate. He found it standing open to a silence he said afterward he had felt on his skin before his eyes had told him anything was wrong.

Nine people lay inside it, about a hearth burned down to fresh grey ash and no further, none of them fallen as a man falls in a struggle, none marked by wound or blood or any hurt a living eye could find on skin or bone, lying instead as though the sleep that had taken them at the fire's side had simply not let them up again. The shepherd did not go in past the doorway. He went for the nearest kin the camp had, and they did not go in either, not that day nor any day after, and the hut was left standing with its dead inside it and its door swinging, until in time the wattle rotted and the roof went down over them and the grass came up through the collapsed thatch and no one from that day to this has ever gone in to bury what the roof by then had already covered.

What had been burning in that hearth, on the night whatever came for the nine had come, no one who found them could afterward say with certainty, though the ash was fresh enough, the shepherd swore, that the fire could not have been out above a day when he climbed to the camp and found the smoke gone. Whether it had been a fire kept open on the old pattern by householders too newly come to that ground to have learned the custom of their neighbours, or a covered hearth whose smoke-vent had for some reason shown more than it should have on a still night, the hills never settled, and the tellers who carried the account onward after gave it, in the end, no answer at all, only the one plain fact that stood at the centre of every version: nine people, a fire gone cold in an ordinary way, and not a mark on any of them to say what had stopped their breath.

The camp was never resettled. Other households, in the years that followed, drove their beasts wide of that shoulder of hill at the season the trouble had come, and in time the ground took on the kind of name that needed no telling to explain it, spoken of by herders passing near it, when it was spoken of at all, in the same low voice a man on the north-western shore might once have used for a stretch of water he had cause to keep clear of, though on the hills that voice had

learned to speak of ground rather than water, for it was ground, and not the sea, that the hills of Doire uaine had come to fear.

IV

Of the Hut That Burned Empty

Some thirty years after the camp was left, a family new to that country came up from the eastern farms to take grazing on a slope the hills had by then gone a long generation without settling, drawn by grass that had grown thick and unclaimed in the years since the neighbouring ground was given up. They were kin of a line that had never lived among the Doire uaine hills and had heard the custom of the covered hearth only as a thing travellers spoke of, half believed and half thought a hill people's fancy, the way any custom sounds when it is heard secondhand from a people one does not yet know well enough to trust.

They built their first house that summer on the old pattern, with the hearth open to the roof-hole as every hearth of their own kin had always been built, and it drew comment from the nearest neighbours before the roof-thatch was even finished, comment given, by every account, kindly enough and more than once, in the plain hope of sparing strangers a grief the hills themselves had already paid for. One old woman of the next valley over, who had herself dug her own pit-hearth as a young wife in the years the custom first spread, walked up twice that summer to say her piece plainly at their door: that she had lost no kin herself to the walker, and knew no one now living who had seen it, and would not for that reason claim to know its mind; only that a people did not go on digging into their own ground for a hundred years over nothing, and that a stranger new to a country did well to take an old fear from its own people at their word before learning, the hard way, what the word had been worth. The family thanked her for it, both times, and kept their fire open through that first autumn all the same, being, as newcomers to any custom often are, readier to hear a warning than to act on one they had not yet felt the weight of themselves.

It was in the dark of that same winter, on a night none of the near households could afterward fix more exactly than "hard frost, and still," that a boy sent at dawn to borrow fire, his own household's having gone out overnight in weather too cold for even banked coals to hold, came down again from the new family's

door faster than he had gone up it and could not, for some while, get out more than that the door stood open and no one had answered his call.

Those who went up with him found the hut as he had found it: the door open to a morning white with frost, the beds slept in and thrown back as a bed is thrown back by someone rising in haste or in sleep, and every soul of that household gone from the place without a trace of where or how, no blood, no sign of a struggle, no track in a fresh fall of snow that had come in the night to say which way, if any way, they had gone. And on the hearth, banked the night before by a hand that plainly meant it to hold till morning, the fire burned on into the empty house exactly as it had been left, low and steady and untended, warming a room that held, by the time the neighbours reached it, no one left alive to feel it.

V

Of the Walker on the Ridge

Twenty years more went by, the ash on the abandoned camp's cold hearth long since blown into the heather and the empty house on the eastern slope fallen in the way any house falls in once no one is left to mend its roof, before two herders of that country, a man and his sister-in-law out after strayed ewes on the ridge above the old camp in the last light of an autumn day, saw what Eimhir's own generation had once seen and lived to tell, and what few enough had seen since to keep the telling fresh: a shape moving along the skyline, at a distance neither of them could afterward agree on more closely than "far enough that we should have felt safe, and did not," that walked as a man walks and was not a man.

It went, they both said, at an even pace neither hurried nor slow, following the line of the ridge the way a shepherd follows a track he knows without needing to look down at his own feet, and it gave off, in the failing light, no breath they could see rise from it into the cold air, though the evening was cold enough by then that every sheep on that hillside stood wreathed in its own small cloud of it. Neither of them called out. Neither of them, by their own account given many times after to kin who asked and to kin who did not, so much as spoke to the other until the shape had passed beyond the shoulder of the ridge and out of sight, and it was only then, with it gone, that the man found he had been holding his sister-in-law's

arm the whole time without either of them noticing when his hand had closed on it.

They had, that evening and every evening before it on that slope, no fire lit anywhere near them, their own hearth banked and covered a good half-hour's walk below, and it was this, more than anything either of them could put into clearer words, that both came to believe afterward had let them come home at all: that whatever walked the ridge that evening had passed by two people with no flame anywhere about them for it to find, the way it had passed, in every telling the hills by then kept of it, by every hearth that gave it nothing to see.

It was the last such sighting the hills kept any close account of, though not, in the tellers' own admission, because the walker was never seen again, only because by then there was little left for a sighting to prove that the hills had not already settled among themselves beyond arguing. The pit with the blind bend and the offset vent, the pattern Laoghaire had worked out on the shoulder of his own ground close on a hundred years before, was by the year the two herders came down off that ridge with their flock and their unspoken fright no longer spoken of household by household as it spread, east side or west, nor a scoffer's mark against whoever still kept the old pattern, but simply the way a hearth was built in that country, so plainly and so completely that a child born in those hills in that year would grow to be an old woman herself without ever once, in the whole span of her life, seeing an open fire lit under any roof but the one at Tobar dhìreach, where the mason's own flame went on burning, as it always had, in the one house the hills had long since stopped expecting to change.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Of the Uncut Woods

VE 3,408 – 3,639

Tha blas eile air an uisce seo seach uisce na mara. This water tastes
different from the sea water.

*The Fifth Part: Of the Coal of Life, the Silver in the River, and the
Shore*

I

Of the Wood That Knew Itself First

In the east of that country, a long way past the last of the covered hearths and the last of the arguing that had gone with them, there stood a wood that no household living could say who had first set apart. It was not a young wood. The oaks in it had the girth of three men's arms linked, and the ground beneath them lay dim even at noon of midsummer, the light coming down in coins rather than sheets, and every family whose fields ran up to its edge told the same telling of it, passed down as plainly as the shape of the hills: the trees knew it first, and the people after.

No one could say what that meant, put to the question straight, and no one who lived by that wood ever put it to the question straight, for it was not the kind of telling that wanted testing. It meant, near enough, that the wood had been holy before anyone had thought to hold it so, the way a well is cold before anyone thinks to call it cold; that a household new to the country, walking its dogs along the treeline for the first time and feeling the hair rise on its own arms without cause, was feeling a thing the wood had always done and not a thing the older families had taught it to feel. Sadhbh's grandmother had told it to Sadhbh's moth-

er in those words, sitting at the hearth with the shutters closed against an autumn gale, and Sadhbh's mother told it to Sadhbh in turn on a morning much like any other, when the girl was six years old and had asked, the way children ask, why the wood-carriers went the long way round instead of through.

The long way round was no small thing to choose, in that country. The nearest true fuel-wood outside the holy trees lay the better part of half a day's walk beyond them, over a shoulder of open ground that gave no shelter from weather and less from the walking, so that a household cutting its winter store made two journeys where one would have served it, had it been willing to put an axe to anything standing within the wood's own bounds. No one was. Sadhbh grew up watching her father and her uncles set out before light with the cart and the two dogs, swinging wide of the treeline by a field's width even where the ground made the wide way harder, and she grew up too watching the charcoal that came into the household's own hearth arrive black and ordinary from a dozen kinds of tree and never once, in all the years she kept count without meaning to, from that one.

There was talk, now and again, among the younger of the households, of what a wood that size might spare a family in a hard winter if only one tree of it, one, were felled and split and burned like any other. It came up most often at the end of a bad season, when the wood-carriers had made their third or fourth double journey of the month and a man's back had good cause to grumble at the extra mile. Sadhbh heard her own uncle say it once, half in jest and half not, leaning on the cart in the last light of a short winter afternoon with the load still short of what the household wanted: that a tree was a tree, whatever ground it stood in, and a fire did not ask where its wood had grown before it burned warm. No one answered him that evening, not with argument and not with agreement, and by the next wood-carrying he was walking the long way round with the rest of them as though he had never said it, for it was the kind of talk that a household let pass without rebuke and without repeating, the grumble of a tired man rather than a settled wish, and no one in Sadhbh's lifetime, whatever was said at the end of a hard month, ever put an axe within the wood's own bounds to test what the trees or anything behind them might have to say to it.

It was not forbidden in the way a thing is forbidden when someone has said the word aloud and set a penalty behind it. No elder stood at the treeline turning axes back. It wanted no guard, her father told her once, hefting the cart's shaft onto his shoulder on a cold morning with his breath standing white before him,

because a thing that wanted guarding was a thing a person might still be persuaded to try, and no one in that country, so far as living memory or the memory before it could reach, had ever tried. He said it without heat, the way a man says a thing he has never once had cause to doubt, and Sadhbh, walking at his side with a hand on the cart's rail to keep her feet in the frozen ruts, understood before she had words fit to hold the understanding that this was the whole of the custom. No law kept it. It was a thing simply not done, the way a person does not eat the fire that warms them.

She asked once, being a child and not yet grown past asking the plain question aloud, what would come of a man who cut there all the same. Her father was quiet long enough that she thought he had not heard her over the cart's creaking, and then he said only that no one had ever found out, and that he for his part had no wish to be the first, and turned the talk to the state of the ground ahead, which was as much of an answer as she got from him that day or any other. It was, she came to see as she grew, the whole hills' answer to the same question, offered in one shape or another by every elder ever asked it. None of them could point to a harm done. What held them back was a caution kept so long and so evenly across so many households that it had worn a path into the ground the way any path wears, needing no one's word to keep it and no one's memory of why it was first walked.

II

Of the Stag at the Wood's Edge

S adhbh was past twenty and already a hunter in her own right, known across the eastern households for a steadier hand at the gully-drives than most of the men who worked beside her, when the wood gave the country the telling that outlasted every other telling that came out of it.

It happened at the gully the hunters called Gleann nan Damh¹, a deer-drive run down along the wood's own southern shoulder where the ground narrowed between a fall of scree on one side and the first outlying trees on the other, close enough to the holy ground that a beast driven hard down it sometimes broke for the treeline rather than the open flats below, and no hunter had ever yet followed

1. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

one in. Sadhbh had worked that drive a dozen years by then, knew the wind of it and the footing of it as well as she knew her own threshold, and had never in all those years so much as raised her bow within a spear's throw of the trees, out of the same unspoken caution every hunter in that country carried with them the way they carried their knives.

She was posted that morning at the narrowest turn of the gully, waiting on the drive that two of her cousins were bringing down from higher ground, when a stag broke from the treeline rather than from the open hill, which was a thing she had not seen in all her years at that post and did not, for the length of a held breath, know how to read. It was white: white the way new snow is white before any foot has crossed it, from the muzzle back along the whole run of its flank to a tail that flicked once, catching what little light came down through the trees at its back, its antlers standing up out of that white like something carved rather than grown.

It stood at the treeline a long moment, close enough that Sadhbh could see the working of its ribs with each breath and the dark, unhurried eye it turned on her, not the wild white-rimmed eye of a beast that has just broken from a drive in fright, but a look she found no better word for after, in all the tellings she gave of it in her own long life, than steady. Her bow was in her hand and half drawn before she had thought to draw it, the plain reflex of a hunter's body outrunning her own mind, and it was her mind that stopped her hand where it was, though she could not afterward say what thought had done the stopping, only that the drawing felt, of a sudden, like a thing her body had begun on its own account and her whole self refused to finish.

Two others saw it with her that same morning, her cousin Ruadhan coming down late off the high ground and a boy new to the drive whose name the hills did not trouble to keep, and neither of them drew either, though both had clean sight of it and time enough, by their own later telling, to have loosed and struck. The boy said afterward that his hands had simply gone slow on him, the way hands go slow in a dream where a person means to run and cannot make the legs answer; Ruadhan, older and less given to saying more than he meant, said only that he had looked at it and known, without working out how he knew it, that it was not a thing his arrow had any business touching. The stag held its ground a breath or two longer, long enough that all three of them stood frozen in the same unspoken accord, and then turned, unhurried as it had come, and went back into the trees, and none of them heard so much as a snapped twig to mark its going.

They told it that evening at the nearest hearth, plainly and without much dressing, the way any hunting tale was told in that country, and it went from that hearth to the next the way every tale went, gathering a little colour at each telling but losing nothing of its bones: a white stag at the wood's edge, and three hunters who could not, between them, say why none of the three had drawn. Some of the older women, hearing it, said it was no beast at all, something the wood had put out to be seen, and let the matter rest there; others said only that a beast so marked belonged to no drive that had ever been run in that country and ought, on that ground alone, to be let go by whoever met it. No one that first year put a name to it, god or spirit or anything between. Sadhbh, asked more than once as the years went on whose creature she took it to have been, always gave the same answer: that she had looked it in the eye and known only that it was not hers to kill, and had never wanted to know more than that.

In the years between the first seeing and the second, the tale did its own quiet work on the country's custom without any elder ever setting it down as a rule. Hunters who ran the gully after that first year went to the post at its narrowest turn already carrying the tale with them, so that a drive that broke for the treeline, whatever beast led it, was let go with less argument than it might once have needed, on the plain chance that among the ordinary deer some one unlucky shot might catch the wrong beast in a bad light and bring down on the whole country a grief no one could afterward undo. It cost the households something real, in meat foregone at the wood's edge over years enough to count, and none of them, asked whether the cost was worth the caution, answered the question as though it were a hard one.

It came back. Twenty-two years on, when Sadhbh was past forty and had given the gully post to younger hands, word came down from a fresh pair of hunters, neither of whom had been born the first time it was seen, that a white stag had stood at the same treeline and let itself be looked at a long while before it turned back into the trees, drawing no arrow and taking no harm from any that were there. It was, by every account the hills kept afterward, the same beast, or one enough like it that no one troubled to argue the difference, and from that second seeing on it left off being one hunter's tale carried at one hearth and became a thing the whole country held between them, spoken of at the gully-drives before any beast was run, so that a hunter posted where Sadhbh had once been posted went to that ground already knowing what she might meet and what she was, by the country's own unspoken law, to do about it, which was nothing at all.

III

Of the Second Wood

Many days' walk to the west, past the southern hills and out into the middle country, there stood a second wood that few of the eastern households had ever seen, though the hearths about it knew it as well as the east knew its own, though every one of them could point the way to it without hesitating.

It was older in its bearing than Coille Naomh Muileann chiar¹ of the stag, or seemed so to every eye that fell on it, though no one living could have said by what mark they judged the age of a tree they had never gone close enough to touch. The ground about it rose in low, broken folds, and out of those folds the trees stood taller and closer-set than any wood a household had ever felled and let regrow, with a floor beneath them that no foot, so far as any telling reached, had ever walked from one side to the other. Three paths ran toward it, worn by generations of feet that had gone that way for water, for grazing, for the plain human want of walking to the edge of a thing and looking at it, and all three paths, without a single household ever having met to agree on it, stopped short of the trees at the same low line of set stones.

The stones themselves were nothing grand to look at, no taller at their highest than a man's knee, running in a broken course that dipped and rose with the ground rather than holding to any straight rule a mason might have set, so that a stranger coming on them without knowing their name might have taken them for no more than the kind of stone a field turns up on its own and a farmer piles at its margin out of the way of the plough. But no field lay behind them. Beyond the line the ground was not worn at all, not by foot nor by hoof nor by anything a person could point to and say a beast had passed this way, and every one of the three paths, worn smooth and hard-packed right up to the stones, went no further than the stones themselves, as though the feet that had made them, generation on generation, had walked to that exact mark and turned back without a word ever needing to pass between them as to why.

The hearths called that country the sìth's, though none of them, pressed on it, could say when the naming had begun or who had first said it aloud. It was the same shape of telling as the first wood's, near enough: no fear anyone could point

1. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

a finger at and give a cause to, only a thing worn so evenly into the custom of the country that asking after its beginning got a shrug more often than an answer. The sith, the hearths said, were the people of the hills and the mounds, who had held that ground before ever a household of the mason's own kind set a fence-post in that country, and who kept, by every account, to the far side of any line their own custom or their own leaving had drawn, so long as no one was foolish enough to draw it back the other way.

Children were told it early and told it plainly, the way children in that country were told which mushrooms killed and which fed, with no more ceremony than the telling wanted: go as far as the stones and no further, and if a ball or a stray lamb or a wandering hound crossed the line ahead of you, let it go, for whatever was lost that way stayed lost, and no household in living memory had gone in after anything and come out again the better for it. It was not, most families found, a hard rule to keep. A line of low stones asked little of a child beyond the asking, and the wood beyond it offered nothing a child's eye found it hard to leave alone: no berries grew close along that edge that did not grow just as freely on the near side, no game ran thick enough there to tempt a hunter's arm past caution, and the trees themselves, seen from the stones, gave back only the same dim, unbroken green that every other stand of old timber in that country gave back, holding out no promise a person might be fool enough to chase.

IV

Of Muireall

Muireall was nine years old in the year the hills lost her, the youngest of four and the only girl among them, a quick, sharp-eyed child who had been told the rule of the stones as plainly and as often as every other child of that country and had, so far as anyone could afterward swear to, kept it as well as any of them until the one afternoon that undid the keeping.

It was late in the summer, the households out at the hay in the low fields a good way off from the second wood, and the children of three families left, as children of that country were often left on a fine working day, to their own charge on the near ground with an older cousin's half an eye on them. Muireall had gone with the others to the line of stones to watch for the deer that sometimes crossed the open ground beyond it in the evening light, a game the children of that coun-

try played often enough and thought little of, for the deer kept well clear of the trees themselves and a child standing at the stones to watch them was no closer to any harm than a child standing at its own threshold.

What drew her past the line, none of the other children who stood with her that afternoon could afterward say with any certainty, though every one of them was asked the question more times than any of them, by their own account, cared to be asked again. The eldest among them, a boy of twelve who carried the guilt of that afternoon a long way into his own grown life, said only that he had turned to call the younger ones back from the drop of a gully nearer the stones, and turned again a breath or two later to find Muireall gone from where she had stood, with no cry, no rustle in the bracken, nothing at all to mark which way she had gone save a small, easy gap in the undergrowth at the near edge of the trees, no wider than a child makes passing through without troubling to hold the branches back.

They called for her first among themselves, the way children call for a playmate they think has only wandered off to tease them, and it was some while, by the boy's own shamed account, before the calling turned to fright and the fright sent the eldest running for the hay-field at a pace that left him unable, when he reached it, to get out more than her name and the word gone before her mother was already past him and running the other way.

The search that followed held nothing back that the country had to give it. Every household within a half-day's walk came, men and women both, with torches cut and lit before the light was fully gone, for none of them, whatever they told each other of the sith's own custom, could bring themselves that first evening to leave a nine-year-old child to a dark wood without at least the trying. They went up the three paths together, all of them, calling her name in a chorus that carried, by every account, a long way over the still evening air, and they reached the line of stones with the last of the daylight still holding in the west and stood there, the whole company of them, in a silence that none who were present that night ever fully found words to fill afterward.

No one crossed the line. It was not spoken of aloud, that first evening, as a thing decided; no elder stood forward to forbid it, and no household voice was raised in argument for going further. It happened the way the custom had always happened, without a word needing to pass between them: torch after torch came up to the stones and stopped there, the light of each one falling a little way into the trees beyond and showing nothing but more trees, and no foot, of all the dozens gathered on that ground that night, went past the line the child had

crossed a few hours before. Muireall's mother stood at the stones longer than any of them, past the point where her own kin had begun, gently, to draw her back by the arm, and it was said afterward, by more than one who stood near her, that she asked the wood, once, in a voice pitched low enough that only those closest to her caught the words, to give the child back, and that no sound came from the trees in answer beyond the ordinary small movement of leaves that any wood gives back to any question put to it.

They searched again the next day, and the day after that, working the ground on the near side of the stones as thoroughly as any ground in that country had ever been worked, turning every fold and hollow within a stone's throw of the line on both flanks of the wood, in case the child had strayed along the edge of it rather than in, and found nothing: no print in ground soft enough to hold one, no scrap of the plain wool she had worn, no sound of her voice carried back on any wind that blew those two days from any quarter. On the third day the search narrowed to the stones, and stopped there. No household had tired of looking. There was, by then, nowhere left to look that did not mean crossing a line that no one in living memory, not even for a lost child of nine, had ever yet crossed and come back whole to speak of.

The hearths said afterward that the sith had taken her, in the same plain, worn way the hearths said everything of that country's own custom, offering it neither as comfort nor as blame, only as the one telling that fit what the ground had shown them: a line long kept, a child who crossed it, and nothing on the near side of the stones, search it as thoroughly as they had, to say she had ever come back across. Muireall's father dug no grave, for there was no body to lay in one, and the household kept instead, in the years that followed, a small stone of their own setting near their own threshold, not at the wood, bare of any mark, so that whoever asked after it, whenever they asked it, would be told, in as many or as few words as the asking seemed to want, of a child who had gone as far as a line of set stones on a fine summer evening and had not, for all the searching the whole country gave her, ever been found on the near side of it again.

The rule of the stones, which had asked little of any child before that year and had been kept, in the main, without any household troubling to test how hard a rule it truly was, was kept a good deal more plainly after. No elder needed, in the years that followed, to remind a child twice of where the near ground ended, and no household ever again let its children stand watching for deer at that particular stretch of the line without a grown hand somewhere near enough to close on a

small arm before it could slip free. The torches that had halted at the stones on the night Muireall was lost halted there still, in every telling the hills gave of that summer afterward, a whole country's worth of light standing at the edge of a wood it had searched to the very limit it would allow itself, and going no further.

Sadhbh lived to hear the telling of it many times over before her own death, an old woman by then and long past any drive of her own, sitting at hearths that were not her own household's and were asked, more often than she cared to count, to set the white stag she had once met at the gully's turn beside the child the second wood had taken, as though the two tellings answered each other. She never granted the two woods a common cause, not once in all the years she was asked it. The stag's wood had given nothing but a look and a going, she said, and had taken from the country only the meat it might otherwise have lost at a hunter's hand; the wood of the stones had taken a child outright and given nothing back at all, not so much as a mark in the ground to say which way she had gone. They were two uncut woods holding to two different silences, she told whoever asked her plainly enough that few asked her twice, and a country that meant to go on living beside either of them would do well to leave the working-out of why to those with more patience for it than a hunter had ever needed.

By the year the households about that wood counted, later, as the year the search finally stopped being spoken of at every gathering and became instead a thing simply known, the way the covered hearths of the southern hills had become a thing simply built, the line of stones had stood a full generation as the one mark on that country's ground that no household crossed and no household argued the crossing of. Children born in the years after Muireall's going grew up knowing the rule before they knew the reason for it, in the same worn, unquestioned way their grandparents had grown up knowing to carry their fuel the long way round Coille Naomh Muileann chial¹ far to the east, two customs kept by two countries far apart for two griefs that had never, in all the years since, given either of them cause to test what lay beyond either line.

1. the holy wood of Muileann chial, Flidais's wood

OF CORMAC OF THE MISSTRIKE

VE 3,640 – 3,719

I

Of Cormac and the Four Dark Coals

It was going on eight hundred years since Brian had dug his hole beside Leac na Fèithe¹ and found the black coal warm in the morning, and in all that time the line had answered nothing further. Four coals still lay dark in the leather bag: the red-brown, the silver, the one that would wake, if it woke at all, to no more than the snap of a hand, and the rainbow that held every colour and answered to none of them yet. Three had spoken, out of the sea and the height and the ground, each in its own slow year, and the households of the high valleys had grown so used to waiting on the fourth that they had stopped remarking on it, the way a family stops remarking on a debt so old it has become a kind of furniture.

Cormac was born into that waiting at Tobar dhìreach, the eleventh child and the fourth son of a household that had held the bag and Poit an Teine² and the recital, father to father, since Neachdan's own well. He was not the eldest, and by the custom of the valley that ought to have kept him at the plough and the herding and let an older brother stand for the line at the hearth on Oidhche an Deal-anaich³; but his two elder brothers died within a season of each other in his fifteenth year, one of a fever that took half the valley's children that winter and one

1. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

2. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

3. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

of a fall on the scree above the black well, and so it came to Cormac, whether he wanted it or not, to learn the recital word for word from his father and to be the one who, when his father died, took the leather bag down from its shelf and untied the thong and counted the four dark coals into his own palm, one by one, the way every keeper before him had counted them.

He was a big man, wide through the shoulders, with a temper that came on him early and that his mother had spent his childhood trying, without much success, to teach him to keep behind his teeth. He never raised his hand to man or beast, and no one in the valley ever called him unkind. But he was quick to anger at a thing that would not go the way he meant it to go, a gate that would not latch, a rope that slipped, a lamb that would not be caught, and he had been known, more than once, to put his fist through a hurdle he had spent the morning building rather than mend the one weak lashing that had let it sag. His wife, Aoibheann, of a household two valleys west, used to say that Cormac could split more stone in an afternoon of temper than another man could split in a week of patience, and that the trick of living with him was never to be standing near the stone.

He grew up on the recital the way every child of the line did, said standing at the hearth on Oidhche an Dealanaich, the fathers named back to Neachdan and Conall, the tale of the boy who walked to the grove and came back with a riddle and no answer, the sea that had taken the gold, the height that had taken the white-flecked coal, the grave beside Leac na Fèithe that had taken the black one slowly, in the dark, overnight. He had heard it so many times before he was grown that he could have said it in his sleep, and did, once, to Aoibheann's laughing report, waking the whole house with the line about Fearghas and the height. It was a story he loved the way a man loves a thing he has never once had to work at loving. What he did not love, what caught at him worse each year he held the bag, was the four dark coals themselves, lying cool and ordinary in his palm at every year's telling, giving nothing back.

He tried, as every keeper before him had tried, the things that were known to have failed: rain, wind, the sea a second time in case the sea had merely been careless the first, the coals together in one fire in case the spirits, once woken, might wake each other. Nothing answered. He tried things no one had thought to try before him, because he was not a patient man and patience was what the line had mostly brought to it until then: he buried the red-brown one a second time, deeper than Brian had buried the black, thinking perhaps the earth wanted more of it;

he carried the silver one to three different rivers in one summer, thinking perhaps the Abhainn ghorm alone had been asked and had said no for reasons of its own. He came back from each of these journeys with the coal as dark as he had carried it out, and each time the temper in him grew a little worse before it settled, and Aoibheann learned to have the supper ready and to say nothing until he had eaten.

It was in his thirtieth year, some three years into his keeping, that he came to the idea of the grove. He had heard, the way every child of the line heard it, that Diarmad had gone north to a place where the wind talked and come back with the whole Telling and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁴ both; that Coimhdeach na Fine⁵ had stood there once, in the smoke of an oak-twigg fire, and had not been seen since by any teller the line kept. It seemed to Cormac, turning it over through a wet spring while the lambs were born, that a place with that much of Coimhdeach na Fine's business behind it might hold some leaving of whatever the smoke-figure had been, in the ground there, that would answer a coal the way the earth at Tobar dhìreach had answered Brian's. He said so to Aoibheann one evening, expecting her to laugh at him, as she laughed at most of his notions before he had finished having them.

She did not laugh. She looked at him a long while across the fire, the way she looked at a beast she was deciding whether to trust with a lamb, and said only that if he meant to go he had better go once the hay was in, and that she would keep Poit an Teine fed and the bag's thong tied while he was gone, and that he was to come back whether the coal answered him or not, for she had buried two brothers-in-law already and had no wish to add a husband to the count on the strength of a story.

II

Of the Month Under the Oaks

he set out on a grey morning at the turn of autumn, with the four dark coals wrapped each in its own scrap of hide inside the leather bag, and a second bag of oatcake and dried mutton over his other shoulder, and no

⁴ the Keeper's riddle

⁵ the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

company but his own, for he had asked no one to come and no one had offered, the valley holding by then that a man's business with the coal was his own to carry. It was three days' walk to the grove, north and a little west, over ground that grew wilder the further he went from the last hearths he knew: up out of the high valleys onto open moor, down again through birch scrub into a country of standing water and rushes where he lost the best part of a morning finding a way round a bog that had not been there, or that he had not heard tell of, the last time anyone from Tobar dhìreach had gone that way. He slept the first night under an overhang of rock with a small fire of heather roots, the second in the lee of a fallen birch with no fire at all, for the wood was too wet to catch and his temper was too short by then to spend an hour coaxing it. He came to the oaks on the evening of the third day, footsore and hungry and in a worse humour than he had left home in, and stood at the edge of them a while before he went in, the way every teller said Diarmad had stood, though he did not think of that until afterward.

The grove was as the tellers described it and larger than he had pictured it: old oaks, wide-spaced, their crowns meeting high overhead so that the light under them came green and broken, and a stillness in the air that owed nothing to the wind, which he could hear moving in the crowns without ever feeling it move at ground level. He found the fallen trunk the tellers spoke of, or one he took for it, grey and half sunk into the leaf-mould, and made his camp in its lee, and built a small fire there of oak-twigs as Diarmad was said to have built his, more out of habit than hope, for he did not truly expect Coimhdeach na Fine¹ to come for the asking.

It did not come. He sat by the little fire the first evening with the four coals laid out on a flat stone in front of him, watching them, as if watching hard enough were a kind of work, and nothing answered him but the small sounds of the wood settling into night, an owl somewhere off to the west, the creak of a branch finding its own weight. He told himself, that first night, that a place needed time to notice a man in it, the way a dog needed time to notice a stranger was not going to hurt it, and that he would give it a week.

A week became a fortnight, and a fortnight a month. He kept the little fire burning most nights, fed on fallen wood, for the grove gave him that much without complaint, and he ate through his mutton and then through what he could find, the last of the hazelnuts, rowan berries, once a wood pigeon he

1. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

brought down with a stone after two days of trying. He walked the whole grove end to end more times than he could afterward have counted, laying each of the four coals in turn at the foot of every oak he thought looked older or stranger than the rest, leaving them a night, coming back for them in the morning as dark as he had left them. Thinking the ground here, so near whatever Coimhdeach na Fine had been, might succeed where the ground at Tobar dhíreach had not, he tried burying them again as he had at home; it did not answer him any better. He tried speaking to the grove outright, once, standing in its centre in the grey hour before dawn, asking it plainly what it wanted of him, and felt so foolish afterward, alone under the oaks with his own voice still hanging in the air, that he did not try it again.

The temper that Aoibheann knew so well, and that three years of failed rivers and a second grave had already worn thin, did not improve on a diet of hazelnuts and disappointment. By the third week he had stopped laying the coals out gently at the feet of trees and begun setting them down hard, as a man sets down a thing he is angry at, and by the fourth he had begun to talk to himself in the grove the way another man might talk to a stubborn beast, short words, no patience in them. He knew, some clearer part of him knew, that the coals could not hear him and would not answer him faster for being cursed at, and he went on doing it anyway, because there was no one else in the grove to curse at and a man alone for a month with a failure grows less careful of himself than he would be watched.

It was near the end of the fourth week, with the hay long in at home for all he knew and Aoibheann's patience, he suspected, wearing thinner than his own, that he came to the end of whatever restraint the month had left him.

III

Of the Misstrike

he had carried, among the little he brought from home, the same maul and stone wedge his father had used for splitting stone, more from habit of a travelling man than from any plan to use them, for there was no well to sink in the grove and no wall to raise. On that last morning, waking stiff and cold and hungry to a fire gone to ash overnight, he took the red-brown coal from its scrap of hide and looked at it a long while, turning it over in his fingers in the grey

light, a plain dull stone the colour of old blood dried on wood, giving no more sign of a spirit in it than the pebbles under his boots.

It came to him, in the flat, stubborn way an idea comes to a tired and angry man, that he had never once tried to break the coal open. Every trial the line had made, his own and his father's and his father's father's back to Aodh, had been a trial of where the coal was put, the sea, the height, the ground, the hearth. No one, so far as the recital told it, had ever asked what might be found inside one, whether the spirit, if it was there at all, lay hidden under the surface the way the colour had lain hidden in the vein before the mason's wedge went in and struck it open. It was not a clever thought, and some later part of him, telling it afterward at the recital, allowed as much; it was the thought of a man who had run out of patience and still had a hammer in his hand.

He set the red-brown coal on a flat stone at the foot of the fallen trunk, the same stone he had watched it on every night of the month, took up the maul in his right hand, and struck.

The coal was harder than any stone he had split in his life, harder than the granite of the well his own grandfather's grandfather had sunk, and the maul came down on its curved, unyielding face and turned in his grip, glancing sideways off the surface instead of biting into it, the way an axe turns on a knot no one saw in the wood. He had swung with the whole of a month's temper behind it, not thinking to guard against a miss because he had not truly believed, in the part of him that still believed anything, that the coal could turn a blow struck that hard. The head of the maul came round and down across the back of his left hand, which had been steadying the coal on the stone, and laid it open from the base of the thumb to the first knuckle, deep, to the white of the bone.

He did not cry out. He said afterward that the pain came a breath behind the blow, the way it always does with a true wound, and that in the space of that breath, before the pain had caught him up, he watched his own blood run off his fingers and fall, three drops, four, onto the red-brown coal still sitting where he had set it.

Where the blood touched, the coal caught.

It came up slow at first, a thread of colour spreading out from where the first drop had fallen, the way a stain spreads in cloth, and then all at once, a flame standing up out of the stone, the exact colour of the coal, red-brown, deep, low, not bright the way the gold had burned on the sea or fierce the way the white-flecked coal had burned in the fall through open air, but warm, close, the colour

of firelight seen through the grain of oak, or of blood held up to a lamp. No sound came with it, and no spark. It stood there on the flat stone, burning quietly in the green morning light of the grove, while Cormac knelt with his ruined hand still open and dripping in his lap and stared at it.

He said, afterward, that he had no thought in his head for a long while but the plain fact of it burning, and that the pain of his hand, which by every reckoning should have driven every other thought out of him, did not reach him at all in that first stretch of time; he knelt there in the leaf-mould with the blood running unheeded down his wrist and into his sleeve, watching the small red-brown flame stand up out of a coal that had lain dark in a bag on his shoulder, and in his father's before him, and in every father's before that, back thirty generations to Brian, and he did not move, and did not bind the hand, and did not think to.

The other three coals lay forgotten on the ground beside him. He did not touch them again that morning.

IV

Of the Bound Hand

how long he knelt there he could not afterward say with any certainty, though he guessed, from the light, that it was the better part of the morning. The flame burned steadily the whole while, fed by nothing he could see, taking neither larger nor smaller as the hours went, and it was only when it began at last to sink, guttering low the way any fire sinks when it has burned through what feeds it, that Cormac came back to himself enough to notice his own hand, stiff and swollen and crusted black with dried blood to the elbow, and to understand, with something between shame and wonder, that he had knelt beside a fire lit from his own body for the better part of a day and never once thought to stop the bleeding.

He bound it then, tearing a strip from his shirt and winding it tight over the wound, wincing for the first time since the blow had fallen, as though the pain had been waiting politely for his attention and came on all at once the moment he gave it. By the time he had the binding knotted the flame on the stone had gone out entirely, leaving the coal lying dark again where it had lain, save that its surface, when he picked it up at last with his good hand, felt warm still, faintly, the way a hearthstone stays warm long after the fire on it has died.

He gathered the other three coals, and the red-brown one now gone quiet, back into the bag, and broke his camp that same afternoon, though the grove had given him nothing but the one answer and he might, by the letter of what he had set out to prove, have stayed and tried the rest of the summer against the oaks as he had tried the first month. He did not. Telling it after, he said that something in him understood, kneeling there with his hand torn open and the small flame standing over his own blood, that the grove had answered nothing; that whatever had spoken had spoken out of him, out of the wound and not the wood, and that there was no more sense in staying under the oaks to ask the same question of his other hand than there would have been in staying under the roof of any house merely because a good thing had once happened inside it.

The walk home took him four days instead of three, for the hand slowed him and would not let him use it, and twice he had to stop and rebind it when the old binding worked loose and the wound, still raw, began again to weep. He came down into the high valleys on a cold evening with the bag over his shoulder and his left arm held stiff against his chest, and Aoibheann, who had been watching the northern track for the better part of a week without telling anyone she was watching it, saw him coming from a long way off by his walk before she could see his face, and went out to meet him at a run.

He was thirty that year. Standing in the yard before he would go in to the fire, he told her the whole of it: the month, the hazelnuts, the last morning, the blow, the blood, the flame that had burned quietly over his own hand for the better part of a day while he knelt and watched it and forgot, in his wonder, to save the hand at all; and she looked at the binding, already soaked through again, and said nothing about the coal at all, only that he was a great fool and that she would look at that hand properly before he said one more word to anyone.

The scar it left him ran the width of his hand, thick and pale, the bone beneath it never quite straight again, so that from that day he could never again close that fist all the way and had, more than once, to ask another man to draw a stubborn peg for him. He wore it, once the shame of the misstrike had worn off him, the way another man wears a mark he is secretly proud of, and let it be seen, and the valley, which had laughed at Diarmad's question near three thousand years before and long since stopped laughing at anything the line brought home from the grove, did not laugh at Cormac either. What they called him, from that year to the end of his life, was Cormac of the Misstrike, and he answered to it without complaint, saying once, when a nephew asked whether the name shamed

him, that a man ought to be glad of any name he is given for having done a thing no one else in the world had ever done, whatever the manner of the doing.

At the recital that was said the next night of the lightning, he stood at the hearth at Tobar dhìreach with the bag counted out before him as every keeper counted it, three cold, one gone quiet after its burning, and held up the scarred hand for the whole gathered valley to see before he spoke the new line into the telling: that the sea had taken the gold, the sky had taken the white-flecked coal, the earth had taken the black slowly in the dark, and now a fourth had answered, quick, out of a man's own blood, the colour of firelight seen through oak. The kindred took to calling it *gual donn-ruadh*¹, and, more often, simply the coal of life, for it seemed to them, turning the word over at hearth after hearth that winter, the rightest name a coal could have that had wanted nothing of sea or sky or ground, and had wanted only a living man, and the hurt of him.

Cormac kept his keeping some forty years more, the temper in him gentling, Aoibheann said, a little each year, though never so far gentled that she stopped keeping the supper back until he had eaten it in peace. He tried the silver in three more rivers before he gave it over to a younger cousin to try in his stead, and lived to see that trial fail as his own had failed, and to laugh about it, which the valley took as proof enough that the misstrike had done him some good beyond the scarring of one hand. He died in his two-and-seventieth year, at his own hearth, with Poit an Teine² burning near him as it had burned near every keeper of the line before him, and Aoibheann, who outlived him by six years, told it afterward that his last clear word, before the fever took his sense from him, was a complaint that his hand ached in the damp, the old scar aching the way old scars do, long after the wound is a story told and not a wound felt.

They buried him near Leac na Fèithe³, as Brian had been buried, and the leather bag with its three remaining coals, silver and the one that had never yet been tried by fire and the rainbow that answered to none, passed to a younger kinsman of the line, whose name the recital keeps but does not give to strangers, as it does not give any name between one finder and the next. For some years after, at the hearths above Tobar dhìreach, children of the valley were shown the trick of it, an old scar on an old man's hand held up in the firelight and the story told again, of the coal that would not break and the blood that lit it anyway, until it had passed,

1. the mahogany coal, of life

2. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

3. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

the way every wonder passes in a valley that has already had three thousand years of them, into a thing everyone knew and no one any longer marvelled at, save on the one night of the year when the recital brought it round again, and the reciter's hand, whoever then held the office, was raised at the telling of it, empty of any scar, in memory of the one that had once been shown there.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

OF the DOGS

the Geese and the Farthest Reach

VE 3,720 – 3,921

I

Of the Glen of the Stags

Dubhghall was twenty-five the autumn he first stood at the gully's throat, and he had been driving it in someone else's shadow since he was old enough to hold a stake upright. Gleann nan Damh¹ lay east of the households, a fold of ground the red deer had used, by every telling the old people gave, since before any teller now living had a grandmother. Dubhghall's own father had walked it, and his father's father, laying the same lines of stakes and cut brush in the same low places each autumn to turn the herd's running into one running, funnelled down through birch and bramble to the narrow throat of the gully where men waited with spears braced against their own weight and the weight of what was coming.

It was plain work, and no one who did it thought otherwise. It wanted patience in the setting and nerve in the standing, and both of those Dubhghall had in the ordinary measure his people had, no more. He set his stakes where his father had set stakes, cut brush from the same low thickets so that the thickets kept their shape year on year and the deer, coming down off the high ground in the first cold, ran the path their mothers had run without knowing there was any other path to run. A drive was a slow thing to build and a fast thing to spend: half a day of quiet labour with mallet and knife, and then, some grey morning when the

1. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

wind sat right, a noise raised from three sides at once, and the whole autumn's work gone by in the length of time it took a frightened animal to cross a gully.

He stood that first year at the narrow end with his uncle at his shoulder, close enough that Dubhghall could smell the wet wool of the older man's shoulder over the deer-smell coming down the wind ahead of the herd itself. Frost had whitened the bramble in the night and gone soft and dark by the time they took their places, so that the ground underfoot was greasy where the sun had not reached it and hard as bone where it had. The noise began somewhere up the glen, thin at first, then thickening as it was taken up along the line: sticks beaten on sticks, a dog's short bark cut off, a man's voice pitched high and wordless. Dubhghall's hands were cold on the spear-shaft and his knees, he would say afterward, had no more strength in them than a boy's, and then the first of the herd was on him, a hind with two calves close behind her flank, and past before he had thought to move at all.

The stags came after, and it was for the stags the whole day's labour had been spent. His uncle took the first, a big beast with a head like a low branch of oak, catching it low and letting it run itself onto the spear rather than driving the spear at it, which was, his uncle told him after, sitting on a wet stone with the blood still steaming off his hands in the cold air, the whole of the craft and the only part of it that could not be taught by watching. "You can be shown the stand," the old man said, working the feeling back into his fingers, "and you can be shown the throw. What you can't be shown is the moment you let the beast do the work for you instead of doing it yourself. That comes or it doesn't." Dubhghall's own throw went wide and struck a young stag in the shoulder rather than the throat, and the beast went down thrashing not twenty paces past him, bawling in a way that put the hair up on his arms worse than the cold had, and it took his uncle and two others to finish what his bad aim had begun. He was ashamed of it for a season, turning the throw over in his mind on nights when sleep was slow to come, and practising alone through the winter against a bundle of brush hung from a birch, until by the spring his arm knew the throw the way it knew the shape of his own name. No one else thought the wide throw worth remembering past the day it happened. That was the mercy of a household that lived close to its own failures: it forgot them quickly, having too many of its own to keep count of another's.

The antlers of the greatest stags were carried apart from the rest of the cutting and set up together at the mouth of the gully, a stand of them leaning one against another so that from a little way off they looked, in half-light, almost like a thing

standing on its own account, a beast made of the parts of other beasts. No one had ever said why this was done, and Dubhghall did not ask his uncle, who would not have known either. It was the shape a good drive took at its end, the meat carried home and the horn left standing where it had fallen, a mark of what the glen had given that year set apart from what had been taken away and eaten. In a hard autumn the stand was thin. In a good one it grew tall enough that a boy could stand in its shadow at noon and cast no shadow of his own that reached past it.

Dubhghall drove that gully for thirty years, first at his uncle's shoulder and then, when his uncle's knees would no longer hold a standing man through a whole autumn morning, at the head of the line himself, setting the stakes where the stakes had always been set and teaching younger men the throw that let a beast run onto the spear rather than the other way about. He was not a hard teacher, by the accounts that outlived him, though he was exacting in the one thing that mattered: he would let a young man's aim go wide a dozen times before he said a word of blame, but he would not let a young man stand carelessly, feet planted wrong or weight back on his heels, because a badly planted man was a man the glen might yet take instead of giving to. He buried his uncle at the last of those thirty autumns, an old man by then, worn thin by winters, in ground close enough to the gully's mouth that the old man's grandchildren could point to the low rise from the stand of horn and say, without needing to walk the distance, that he lay just there. Dubhghall stood afterward at the mouth of the glen with the season's antlers stacked fresh beside the grey weathered horn of years before, and thought, as much as he thought anything so plainly, that the glen would go on taking its deer and giving its meat when every man now living at its mouth had gone the same way as the horn: standing a while, whitening a while, and then down among the rest, indistinguishable from what had come before it.

II

Of the Dog at Cnoc fhionn

It was Dubhghall's own grandson, a boy called after no one living, who first buried a dog the way a person is buried, and it was done at Cnoc fhionn, the hill households east of the glen where Dubhghall's daughter had married into a family with fields of their own. The dog had been the boy's from a pup, one of a litter got off a bitch that ran the drives at the glen, and it had grown into the kind

of dog that is loved past all reckoning of its use, little good for herding or hunting either one: it herded nothing well, killed nothing bigger than a rat, barked at strangers and at its own shadow with equal conviction, and slept across the boy's feet every night of its life from the week it was weaned, so that the boy learned early to sleep with his knees drawn up rather than disturb it.

It died old, as dogs that are loved past their usefulness are sometimes let to do, lying down one evening by the hearth after a day no different from any other and not rising the next morning. The boy, who was near a man himself by then, found it stiff and cold in the grey light before the household was properly awake, and sat with his hand on its flank a long while before he told anyone, as though the telling would make the thing truer than it already was. When he did tell it, his mother said only that it had been a good dog and a long-lived one, and went back to the morning's work, for a dog's death, however loved the dog, was not a thing a household could stop its day for. The boy dug it a grave the length of a dog and not the length of anything smaller, on the low rise above the house where the ground was dry and did not flood in a wet spring, working through the morning with a mattock too big for the job and getting blisters for his trouble that he did not complain of. He laid the dog in on its side, the way a sleeping dog lies, its legs drawn up as they had been drawn up every night of its life across his own feet, and before he closed the earth over it he set a shell at its head, a sea-shell some trader or fire-bearer had carried up from the coast years before and given to the boy as a boy's trinket, kept on a shelf by the hearth and turned over in idle hands on winter evenings but never used for anything until that morning.

No one told him to do it. That was the thing the household spoke of after, when the story of it had gone round the near hearths and come back changed a little in the telling, as such things do: that the boy had not asked anyone, not his mother, not old Dubhghall, whether a dog might be given a shell and a grave the way a person was given a shell and a grave, but had simply done it, on his own reckoning that the dog he loved deserved no less a leaving than the grandmother he had loved before it, who lay not far off on the same rise. Some of the older women thought it strange, even a little wrong, to put a beast's death alongside a person's in the same ground and by the same rite, and said so plainly enough at the next gathering of the near hearths, one of them going so far as to ask the boy, not unkindly, whether he meant to put a shell at the head of every lamb the household lost too. The boy had no ready answer for her, being young and not much given to argument, and only said that the dog had slept at his feet for nine years

and a lamb had not, which the old woman allowed, after a pause, was answer enough. Others, and among them Dubhghall himself, thought it strange only that no one had done it sooner, dogs having slept at hearths and died at hearths since long before any teller now living had a telling of Teine a' Chlachair¹ itself. "A thing that shares your fire that long," the old man said to his daughter, turning the matter over as he was given to turning things over in his last years, "and never once asks for more than it's given, earns more than being left for the crows."

Whatever was thought of it, it was done, and it was done again. Within a few years two more households near Cnoc fhionn had buried dogs the same way, a shell at the head and the grave dug proper, one of them a hunting dog that had put up game for its household for a dozen seasons and the other a pup that had lived scarcely a year before a fever took it, and the custom travelled on quietly, hearth to hearth, the way any custom does that answers something people already feel and only wanted shown how to say. No beast had been given a grave on the island before that boy dug the first one; afterward it was not thought remarkable at all, only ordinary, the way the covered hearth had gone in one lifetime from a strange new digging to a thing no household in those hills would think of doing without.

Dubhghall did not live to see the custom old. He died at Cnoc fhionn in his sixty-fifth year, among his daughter's family and near the hill where the dog and, before long, his own grandson's grandmother lay, an old man by the reckoning of that country though not, by the reckoning of the line at Tobar dhìreach, any great age at all; his people did not live long lives, and did not look for them, and thought a man who had kept his knees and his eyesight into his sixties had been given a fair measure and no cause for complaint. It was said of him at his own leaving, by the same grandson who had dug the dog's grave, that he had never in thirty autumns of driving the glen lost a man to a stag's horn or a fall on wet ground, a modest enough praise as such things go, and in that country no small thing to be able to say, and the grandson set a shell at his grandfather's head too, the last of a small store he had kept since the dog's burying, saying that a man who had taught him the throw that let a beast do the work deserved no less a shell than a dog that had only ever slept across his feet.

1. the mason's fire, the first fire

III

Of the Geese of Eilean ghorm

West of the last of the households, off the coast no hearth-kindred had ever settled, there lay an island the tellers called Eilean ghorm, and to it, every year with the first hard storm of autumn, came the grey geese. No one now living could say when the geese had first been noticed rather than merely seen, the way no one could say when the wood in the east had first been held sacred rather than merely walked around; but by Dubhghall's day, and long before it, it was a thing every hearth from the glen to the northern moor could tell a stranger without needing to be asked twice: that the geese came to Eilean ghorm with the first storm and left it with the last, and that in all *Cunntas nan Ath-raichean*¹ no one had ever gone out to that island to take them.

It was not, by any telling that survived, forbidden in the way the second wood was forbidden, with its line of set stones and its children taught early to stop at it. No household kept a law against the taking of the geese, because no household had ever needed one; it had simply never been done, the way a well is not fouled and a hearth-fire is not fed with green wood, a thing so plainly against the grain of how things were kept that the not-doing of it wanted no telling to hold it up. A boat could be built to reach the island easily enough, and boats far harder to build had crossed to islands far further out for seals and for less. But the geese came in on the storm-wind with a noise that carried for miles on a still evening, ragged lines resolving into order as they came down out of a sky already darkening toward the season's first real weather, and went out again months later the same way, their going almost always a day or two ahead of whatever storm would be the year's last, so that a household that watched them close enough could read the turn of the whole winter in it. Between the coming and the going the island was theirs and no one's else, and that was held to be simply how the geese and the island stood to one another, needing no more reason than the tide needs a reason to come in.

A young man of the northern moor, some years before Dubhghall's own time, was said to have gone out to Eilean ghorm all the same, in a season of want when the store of dried meat had run low before spring and a household counted every goose it saw fly over as meat it did not have. He built himself a small hide boat

1. the count of the fathers; the only long measure of time in the age, a father to about twenty-five years

over a hard winter, telling no one what it was for, and put out from the shore alone one grey morning with the geese still on the island in their thousands. What happened to him the tellers did not agree on even then, and agreed on less as the years carried the story further from anyone who might have set it straight: some said he found the crossing harder than he had judged and never reached the island at all, his boat found stove in on the rocks below the point a week after; others said he reached it and came back with nothing to show for the going, the geese having risen off the water before his boat was within a bowshot and not settled again while he stayed; a few, and these were the tellers most given to saying more than they knew, held that he had reached the island, and that something on it had turned him back before ever he raised a hand toward a goose, though what, they could not say, having no more of the tale than the bare bones any teller starts from. Whichever of it was true, and none now living could sort the true from the added, the young man was not spoken of afterward as one who had found a rich hunting-ground and kept it to himself. He was spoken of as a warning, the kind of warning a country keeps by instinct, from one hard example, with no need to understand the danger it points at.

Dubhghall himself, in his last years, used to stand on the rise above Cnoc fhionn of a still autumn evening and watch, when the wind was right, for the first grey lines of geese going over high toward the west, and count it, in the way a man counts a thing he cannot number, as the true turning of the year quite as much as any telling of the cats' crossing or the salmon's run. When his grandson asked him once, as a boy asks, why no one hunted them there when the meat on so many birds together would have fed a household through half a winter, Dubhghall thought a while before he answered, watching the last light go off the water, and gave the boy no better answer than any other man of his country would have given, but gave it plainly: that some things were left because a people had always left them, and a people that stopped leaving what it had always left was not, any longer, quite the people it had been. The boy did not press him further, being at an age when a grandfather's plain answers were still answer enough, and the two of them stood together until the light was gone and the geese, if they had come that evening, had come and settled and could no longer be told from the darkening water.

IV

Of Skell at Its Height

Far to the west, on a coast none of Dubhghall's kin had walked and none of their tellings named, the people of the landings had by those same years come to hold every shore of the island there was to hold. From the northern moor's edge to the southern lowland, from the eastern cliffs round to the far side of the western capes, there was no stretch of coast left where they had not, at one time or another in the long count of their own years, set a landing, laid a mole, driven a mooring-stake into the mud, or dug a kiln to dry the catch over peat-smoke; and the islands off those coasts were theirs as well, the near ones worked for seal and bird and the far ones rowed to for the dead.

Of all their landings the greatest stood where the Abhainn naomh ran down toward the western sea, at Skell¹. The mole that the old stone-judge had begun there in the time of the first boats of that river had by then stood some nine hundred years, mended and added to season on season until it ran further out into the current than any one lifetime could have carried it, and behind it, in the still water it made, lay more hulls at once than any person of that landing could have numbered without losing the count and beginning again.

A woman of Skell, who had the keeping of the mole's stones in those years as her mother had kept them before her, walked its length one autumn evening at the turn of the tide, as she walked it every evening, looking for any stone the day's current had worked loose. The river was full of boats. They lay three and four deep along the mole's sheltered face, skin boats and plank hulls together, some come in that day from the coast north and south with dried fish and seal-oil and cut shell, some waiting on the morning's tide to go out again; and on the shingle above them the smoke of more hearths than she could set a number to went up into a still sky, so thick and so many that the air over the river's mouth hung grey the whole evening long, like a low cloud that never moved and never rained. Children ran the mole's top the way children run along any wall built for other purposes, and were shouted off it, and ran along it again the moment the shouting turned away.

She found no loose stone that evening. She stood a while at the mole's far end instead, where the river's push met the stone and turned aside, and looked back

1. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

along the whole of it: the moored hulls, the landing, the smoke, the people moving among the boats too many to be watched one by one; and then she turned and walked home along it in the last of the light, for the mole was sound and the tide was making and there was nothing more that evening that the stone asked of her.

The hills kept their own count of things, the drive at the glen and the shell at the dog's grave and the grey geese coming in on the storm, and the landings kept a count of their own that no hearth of the hills ever heard. At Skell that autumn every mooring was taken, and the smoke stood over the river from dawn to dark, and the mole held the current off the boats as it had held it for longer than any keeper of it could reckon.

OF the Warm Springs and the Walled Gate

VE 3,922 – 4,123

I

Of the Springs Under the Mountain

On the southern flank of the central mountains, where the ground drops in broken steps toward the lowland and the rock runs red when the evening light is on it, there is a place where the water comes up warm. It rises out of three low mouths in the hillside, one above another, at a heat a hand can bear for no longer than a slow count of ten, and runs down in a steaming thread over rock stained orange and green by its passing, and in the cold months the steam of it stands over the hillside like the smoke of a hearth that is never let go out. Fuar-ain Theth Muileann ruadh¹, are called so still.

The people of the landings came to it in the years when their reach inland was widest, when their walls stood on the spur above the southern lowland and their three rings on the height near the south-eastern coast, and the kerbed way ran between the two; and what they built there was the plainest of all their works away from the sea. Below the lowest of the three mouths they cut the rock back to make a shelf, and on the shelf they set stone basins, slab fitted to slab and the joints packed with clay, three of them in a row, so that the water fell from the hill into the first and ran over its lip into the second and from the second into the third, cooling a little in each. In the first a hand could not be held. In the third a body could lie to the chin.

1. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

The woman who kept the basins in the years the telling first follows them had come up from the coast as a girl with a brother whose foot had been crushed under a hull at the launching, and had stayed, because the foot had mended and she had watched it mend. She was not young now. Her hands had gone red and soft at the fingertips from a lifetime in warm water, and she could tell by the colour of a wound, and by its smell when the dressing came off, whether it wanted the second basin or the third or neither, and she did not explain the telling of it to anyone, for she had no words for it that were not the thing itself.

They brought the sick to her from every coast. A man came in on a litter of poles and hide with his leg broken below the knee, the bone through the skin in two places, carried four days by six of his kin in turns, and the kin set him down at the lip of the shelf and stood back, the way people stand back from a thing they have carried a long way and no longer know what to do with. The keeper of the basins looked at the leg a long time. Then she had him lifted into the third basin on a frame of woven withies that held him off the stone floor, and she set the bone herself with her own two hands under the warm water, pulling and turning until the ends met as they had met before the fall, and bound it with wet bark and cord, tighter than any healer of the coast would have dared bind a broken leg for fear of choking the foot; and she turned him twice a day for a whole season, morning and evening, and changed the binding, and fed him broth from a horn spoon, and did not once let the wound-mouths go dry or foul.

He walked out on a stick before the winter turned. He walked without it inside two years, and lived to be old, and when he died he was brought back and buried on the slope below the basins at his own asking, with the other dead of the springs, where the ground was warm under the turf all winter long. The bone of that leg, if any hand had ever turned it up again, would have shown the old break as a thickened ring round the shaft and nothing more, knitted clean and straight. So would the bones of a good many of those who lay on that slope in the years that followed: arms and legs and ribs and, once, the bones of a child's skull, all broken, all mended, lying quiet in warm ground with the steam of the springs going up above them.

It was the first place on the island where the sick were brought to be made well. Before it every people had nursed its own hurts at its own hearths, with what skill each hearth had and no more. After it, among the people of the landings, a broken body had somewhere to be carried.

The keeper of the basins grew old at the work. In her last years she sat on the shelf beside the first basin, where the heat was fiercest and her old bones liked it best, and watched a younger woman do the turning and the setting and the binding, and said nothing unless something was being done wrong, which was seldom. When she died they buried her on the slope with the others, nearest the water, and the young woman went on with the turning the next morning, because there was a man in the third basin with a crushed hand who could not be left.

II

Of the Young Keeper and the Child's Skull

The young woman who took up the turning after the old keeper died had come to the springs as a girl of twelve with a father whose ribs a falling spar had stove in, and had stayed on after he walked away mended, because the old keeper had seen her watching and set her to the carrying of the clean bark before she could decide whether she wanted to be set to anything. She had carried bark for nine years, and cord, and broth, and had turned the sick in the third basin when the old keeper's back would not let her, and she had never once set a bone with her own hands while the old woman lived. On the morning after the burying she set three.

It was not the setting that frightened her. She had watched it done so often that her hands knew the pull and the turn before she had ever made them, and the first bone, a boy's forearm snapped clean across in a fall from a boat's gunwale, went back into its place under the warm water with a small grinding she felt in her own teeth, and lay true when she bound it. What frightened her was the choosing. The old keeper had known, by a look and a smell, which hurt wanted the second basin and which the third, which wound would take the heat and knit and which would take the heat and rot; and the young woman, standing over the fourth that morning, a man whose leg had gone black below a crushing, did not know, and knew that she did not.

She put him in the second basin, where the water was hotter, and watched him through two days and two nights without sleeping more than an hour at a time on the shelf beside him, and on the third morning the black had not spread, and on the fifth it had drawn back a finger's width from where it had been, and by the time the moon came round again the man could bear his weight on the leg

with a stick. She never knew whether she had chosen right or only been lucky, and she said so, when she was old, to the girl who by then carried bark for her; and she said that the not knowing had made her careful for the rest of her life in a way that knowing might not have, and that she did not wish it on the girl, and did not wish her spared it either.

The child came to her in her fifth year at the basins. It had fallen from the top of a kiln wall onto the stones below and struck its head, and it was carried in senseless by its mother, who had walked two days with it in her arms and would not give it to anyone else to carry. The bone above its ear gave under the young keeper's fingers like the shell of an egg that has been dropped and not quite broken. She had never seen such a hurt mended. The old keeper had spoken once of a man who lived for a season with a broken skull and died when the season turned, and of another who lived and never spoke again, and of none who had lived and been whole.

She did not put the child in the water. She laid it on the shelf beside the first basin, where the steam rose thickest and the stone was warm to the touch all night, and she cut the hair away from the broken place and washed it with water carried from the lowest mouth of the spring, which was the cleanest, and bound a pad of moss over it and did not bind it tight. Then she and the mother sat by it. They sat by it for three days, turning it as the sick in the basins were turned, twice a day, gently, and dripping broth between its lips from a twist of cloth; and on the fourth morning it opened its eyes and looked at its mother and asked, in a small cracked voice, for something to eat.

It grew up. The bone above its ear knitted with a ridge in it that could be felt under the hair all its life, and it was slow in the tongue for a year or two and then was not, and it lived to be a grandmother at a landing on the south coast, and when she died her own people carried her back to the springs to be buried on the slope, because she had asked it, and because it was known at that landing that she had been given back once and it seemed right that the place which gave her back should have her at the last.

The young keeper, who was not young by then, buried her herself, nearest the water, and said nothing over the grave that anyone remembered, and went back to the shelf where a man with a broken collarbone was waiting to be turned.

The keepers of the basins did not all come from the same landing, nor from the same kin, as the keepers of a hearth come; each was a girl or a boy who had come up with someone hurt and had stayed, because the keeper of that year had

seen them watching. It was the one office among the people of the landings that passed by watching and not by blood, and it passed that way for as long as the basins were kept. In the dry summers the water ran lower from the three mouths and the basins cooled, and the keepers learned to lay flat stones heated in a fire into the third basin to bring it back to the warmth the sick needed; in the wet winters the water ran so hot and so full that it steamed over the shelf like a fog and the keepers worked in it half blind, feeling for the frames of withies under the water with their feet. In every season the sick came, fewer in the years when the heights were full and the landings far, and more again as the landings filled and the roads to the springs were walked by more feet; and in every season the slope below the basins took its share of those who did not mend, and those who mended and came back at the last, until the turf there lay over more dead than any other ground the people of the landings had given to the dead, save only the island off the south-eastern coast where the stone boxes stood in their rows.

III

Of the Youth Sent Down

In the south-east, some days' walk from the springs, the eastern shaft at Toll-dubh had stood open since before any grandmother of that coast could remember its making: a hole sunk straight down through the living rock, its walls tooled smooth as far as any lamp had ever shown them, with no spoil heap beside it and no telling of where the stone had gone. Children dropped pebbles into it and listened, and heard nothing, and ran off laughing to hide how the nothing had frightened them. The grown people of that shore walked wide of its lip and did not drop anything into it at all.

The year the youth went down, it was the people of the south-east who plaited the rope. They made it of hide, cut in long strips from the skins of three oxen and plaited four-strand the way a mooring line is plaited, and it took two women the better part of a month, and when it was done it lay coiled on the turf by the shaft's mouth higher than a sitting child. Who first said that someone should go down, and why it should be that year and not some other, the telling does not say. It says only that the youth asked to be the one, and that no one argued with him long.

He was not yet grown to his full height. He sat on the lip of the shaft on a grey morning with the rope knotted under his arms and across his chest, and a lamp of fat in a hollowed stone in his lap, and the wind came up out of the hole, cool and smelling of wet stone, and lifted the hair off his forehead. The men who were to pay out the rope stood behind him with their heels dug into the turf. The women who had plaited it stood a little apart. No one spoke to him. He looked down into the dark a long while, and then he looked round once at the faces behind him, and then he slid off the lip and hung, turning slowly, and they began to let him down.

The lamp went down with him. That is the part of the telling that has been kept most carefully, and it is kept in the same words every time: the lamp went small. It burned as steadily as any lamp burns, and it did not go out, and it only grew smaller and smaller as the rope paid out hand over hand through the men's fists, a yellow point on the smooth wall, and then a smaller point, and then the dark closed over it and there was only the rope going down, creaking through the hands, and the wind coming up out of the hole past the watchers' faces.

The rope ran out to its last knot. They held it there. It hung straight and heavy from the lip and gave no sign, no jerk, no slackening, and the men holding it stood with their arms trembling from the weight and did not let go, and the women stood behind them, and no one said anything at all for so long that a woman at the back began, very quietly, to weep, and was not hushed.

Then the rope jerked twice, and they hauled.

They brought him up slowly, as he had been let down, hand over hand, because a thing that has hung a long while on a rope in the dark is not to be jerked back into the light as if it were a bucket, and because no one wanted to be the one who hurried whatever was on the end of it. It took longer to bring him up than it had taken to let him down. When his head came over the lip, the lamp in its stone was still in his hand, and it was out, and his face was the colour of ash.

He did not speak. They lifted him onto the turf and untied the rope from him and he sat where they set him, and his mother put her hands on his face, and he let her, and looked past her at nothing. They asked him what he had seen. He shook his head. They asked him again, gently, that evening, and the next day, and in the days after, and he shook his head each time, and in the end they stopped asking.

He never said what was at the bottom, not then and not in all the years he lived. He took a wife from a landing two days south, and had children, and

worked a boat, and was known on that coast for nothing strange except that he would not let a lamp burn low in any room where he was; he would rise in the night to trim it or put it out altogether, and never said why a failing light troubled him. After him no one went down again. The rope was cut up for mooring lines, and the shaft stood open as it had always stood, and the grown people of that shore walked wider of its lip than before.

IV

Of the Last Stone Set

On the spur above the southern lowland, where Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹ had stood with its one gate facing inland for longer than any watcher on its wall could count back, a season came when the gate was closed.

It was closed from within. The telling of it follows one man inside, and follows him only so far, and it is given here as far as it goes.

He carried rubble to the gate through the last of a short day. There had been others with him at the start, carrying and fitting, and one by one as the light went they had gone to some other part of the work within the walls, and he was left alone at the gate with a heap of broken stone and a lamp. He set each stone into the gap that was left with the same care a mason gives a wall that is meant to stand, turning it in his hands to find its best face, trying it, taking it out and turning it again, and packing the smaller stuff in behind it with the heel of his hand. The gap narrowed. Outside it, through the last of the opening, he could see the kerbed way running down off the spur toward the lowland in the dusk, pale and empty, and beyond it the dark line of the hills. He did not stop to look at it.

The lamp burned low beside him on the packed stone. It had been filled that morning and he had not filled it again, and he did not hurry because of it; he worked by its thinning light as he had worked by the full light of noon, and when the gap had shrunk to the width of his two hands he fitted the last stones by feel as much as by sight. The flame had sunk to a blue bead in the fat. He took up the last stone, a flat piece the size of a loaf, and turned it, and tried it in the gap, and it would not go; and he turned it the other way and tried it again, and it went, and

1. the watch-fort ruin

he pressed it home with the flat of his hand and held it there a moment as if it might fall out again when he let it go.

It did not fall. The lamp beside him went on burning, very low.

There the telling stops. It does not say where he went after, or whether there was anywhere to go.

V

Of the Empty Places

Làrach an Dùin-fhaire stood empty after that. No smoke rose from within the wall on the mornings when smoke had always risen, and no watcher stood on the steps inside the gate, and the kerbed way that ran down off the spur went unwalked, so that within a few years the grass had crept in over the slabs from the edges and the kerbs showed through it like the bones of a thing half buried. The gate stayed as it had been left, choked from within with rubble packed so tight that a hand could not have worked a single stone of it loose. By then there was no one to try.

Whoever had closed it had gone out of it some other way, or had not gone out. The wall ran unbroken round the whole of the spur, and no ladder had been left leaning against it, and no rope hung over it; and inside, among the footings of the houses where the roofs had fallen in, the grass grew as tall and as undisturbed as grass grows anywhere no foot troubles it.

On the height near the south-eastern coast the three rings still stood, and people still lived within them, and drove their cattle in at the gate of the outer ring at dusk and out again in the morning, and drew their water from the great cistern cut in the rock at the crown of the hill. It had served four hundred people and their beasts through summers when no rain fell, as the one who read the ground had meant it should when she stood over its digging. It served them still.

The woman who went to draw from it one morning, in a year a long while after Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹ fell silent, went early, before the rest of the household was up, because the water was sweetest at first light and her father was ill and wanted it. She carried two skins and a rope. She came to the lip of the cistern in the grey half-light and let the first skin down, and it did not go down. It struck

1. the watch-fort ruin

something a little below the lip, something that gave under it and did not splash, and she drew it up again and looked, and in the grey light she saw what it had struck.

The cistern was full of cattle. They had been thrown in whole, unbutchered, beasts with their hides on and their horns on, heaped in the water on top of one another so that their backs and their bent legs broke the surface, and the water between them had already gone dark. There were more of them than the household she belonged to had ever owned, and more than the household beside it. She did not count them. She stood at the lip with the empty skin hanging from her hand and the smell coming up at her, and then she let the skin drop on the stone and went back to her father's house, walking, not running, and woke her brother, and told him what she had seen, and he went and saw it too.

No one of the three rings could say who had done it. No one had heard the beasts driven to the crown of the hill in the night, or heard them bellow, or heard the fall of so much weight into so much water; the watch on the outer ring had seen nothing come in at the gate. The cattle were beasts of the rings, and some of those who looked into the cistern that morning knew their own among them by the set of a horn or a mark on a flank, and said nothing of it, and went away.

They did not draw from the cistern again. No one would, not that year and not in any year after, though a people living on a dry height has no easy water but what it cuts into the rock for itself, and the carrying of water up from the springs of the valley below was a whole morning's labour for every household every day. They carried it. The cistern they left as it was, full of bone under water gone black, and they laid no cover over it, and walked round it as they walked round a grave.

What had gone wrong in the high places, in the years when Làrach an Dùin-fhaire's gate was closed and the cistern of the three rings was fouled, the people of the landings never said, not to one another in any telling that has been kept and not to anyone else. On the coasts their kilns still smoked and their boats still went out, and Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh² under the mountain still ran, and the sick were still carried up to the basins on litters of poles and hide and turned twice a day in the third basin by a woman whose hands had gone soft at the fingertips. But on the heights the people who had turned their faces from the sea found that

2. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

the ground they had turned toward had begun, one silence at a time, to give them nothing back but the rain.

OF THE EMPTY RINGS AND THE STRIPPED ALTAR

VE 4,124 – 4,195

I

Of the Last Fire in the Rings

The three rings of wall on the height near the south-eastern coast had held fire along their circuit for longer than any hand still living within them could say it had first seen one lit. In the last winter that fire burned there it burned no differently than it had ever burned: a chain of small fires set along the inner face of the middle wall, each tended by whoever was nearest when it wanted feeding, so that a watcher standing at the gate could look along the curve of the rampart on a clear night and see a string of low lights going away from him in both directions until the wall's own bend hid the rest.

That winter there were fewer hands than fires. Since the cistern was found full of bone, every household had carried its water up from the valley springs on its own back, a whole morning's labour every morning, and some had grown tired of the carrying before they grew tired of the height, and gone down. Those who were left let the farthest fires go dark first and fed what peat they had toward the fires nearest the gate, so that the string of lights grew shorter at both ends and thicker in the middle, like a rope fraying from its outer strands inward toward the one core that still held.

A woman who had tended the second fire from the gate for as many winters as she could count on both hands was the last of them awake on the last night. She had buried, in the two years before, more of her own kin than she had watched

grow old: a husband who went from a cough to a grave inside one wet spring, a sister's whole household taken by the same spring or by the thin harvest after it, no one troubling any longer to say which. The rest of her blood had gone down the track from the gate one by one, some saying they went only for the winter and meaning it, and none of them had come back.

She had gone as far as the gate herself, more than once, on mornings when the track looked less like a way down than like the only sensible answer to a question the height had stopped troubling to ask. Each time she had turned back to her fire. A wall built to hold four hundred ought not to be left holding none, she had told herself, and her staying was a kind of tending too, no different from the peat she fed the flame each evening, only harder to see burn.

She fed it that night from the last of the store beside her, peat cut two summers before by hands that were no longer there to cut more, and sat with her back to the wall and watched it take. The wind came up off the valleys below as it always came after dark, carrying turf-smoke from some hearth low down that was still lit, and wet stone, and the cold clean breath of ground that never quite dried between one shower and the next. She sat in it a long while doing nothing more than any woman does at her own hearth on an ordinary night, and fed the fire again when it wanted it, and sat on.

In the morning she went the length of the middle wall to see what other fires wanted tending, as she had gone every morning of those two years, and found every one of them dark. Some had been banked to nothing by careful hands. Some were simply out, the peat beside them untouched, as though whoever had tended them last had walked away in the middle of the tending. She walked the whole circuit before she let herself believe it, out past the far bend where the ground fell away and the wind came harder, and found the same cold stone and the same untouched peat everywhere, and stood there a while looking out over the valley rather than back at the wall.

She did not light the far fires. She went back to her own, which still held a little heat under yesterday's peat, and sat by it that day and the day after; and on the third day, finding no one left to share the tending and no reason she could give herself to go on keeping a fire in a ring of wall that no one else needed, she spread the last of the embers thin across the stone, the way a fire is spread when a household means it to die and not to smoulder on unwatched, and walked out through the gate and down the track her kin had gone down before her, carrying nothing but what she had carried in.

The fires along the middle wall were not lit again. The gate she walked out through was never afterward closed by any hand, and stood open through every season that followed, and within a few winters grass had found a footing in its threshold, where the feet of four hundred had once kept the stone worn bare.

II

Of the Ones Who Went Down

They went down in ones and in small kin-groups, over years and not in any one season, and none of the landings that took them in ever spoke of a single day when the high places emptied, only of finding, season on season, more faces at the shore fires than the shore had raised, and fewer questions asked of where a face had come from than might have been asked in an easier time.

A boy of one of the western landings, too young to remember the height his grandfather had come down from, grew up knowing only that the old man did not speak of the hills the way the landing's other old men spoke of the sea, with a store of small sure facts about a place they had spent their whole lives in. Asked what the height had been like, his grandfather would say only that it was cold there in a way the shore never was, a wind that found a man through wool doubled over wool, and that a fire there wanted feeding oftener than a fire anywhere he had lived since. He would not say why he had left, or when, or whether he had meant at the leaving to go back; and once, when the boy pressed harder than he usually dared, the old man said that a place could go on being a man's own long after it had stopped wanting him in it, and that this was not a thing a boy who had never lived on a height would understand, nor one he wished his grandson ever to have cause to.

It was the same at landing after landing along every coast: old men and old women who had come down from one height or another in their youth, settled among kin who had never gone up at all, and keeping whatever they kept of the high years to themselves. Some brought down small things the height had let them carry, a worked stone, a tool no one on the shore had a use for and no one asked the use of, kept on a shelf afterward or laid in the stone box with its owner when the time came. Some brought down nothing but what they stood in, having judged that a height given up was a height to be left whole and not picked over on the way out. The middens at the southern landings grew faster in those

years than in any years before them, and a landing that had once counted its households by the dozen came, within two lifetimes of the last fire in the rings, to count them by the score.

None of the shore's own people ever gave a reason for the coming down, beyond the plain fact of it. What was said, by more than one old mouth at more than one fire, was only this: that a thing begun wants explaining and a thing given up does not; that a people troubles itself over why it went somewhere, and lets the coming back stand.

III

Of a Household Come Down to the Kilns

One household that came down from the rings in those years came down to Morn¹, where the seven kilns and the eighth and the ninth still stood above the shingle as they had stood for longer than anyone at that landing could say, and it is told of that household more than of most, because it came down with nothing and had to learn the shore again from the beginning.

There were five of them: a man and his wife, both past the middle of their lives, and their son, and the son's wife, and a girl of eight who had been born inside the innermost ring and had never in her life seen the sea. They came down the old track from the height with what they could carry on their backs and one ox, and the ox died of a fall on the scree below the outer ring on the first morning, so that they came the rest of the way with only their backs. It took them nine days. The girl asked, on every one of the nine, how much further the sea was, and on the ninth her grandfather lifted her onto a rock at the top of the last rise above Morn and turned her to face it, and she looked at it a long while and said nothing at all, and then asked whether it ever stopped moving.

The landing took them in. There was no telling afterward of any argument over it; a household come down with nothing was a thing every landing on that coast had seen by then, some years more than one, and the ground above the shingle had room in it for another roof. What the landing did not do was feed them for nothing, for no landing on that coast had ever fed a strong back for nothing, and within the month the man and his son were out in the boats with

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

the landing's own crews, sick over the side for the first week and then not, and the two women were set to the kilns under the eye of the woman who kept the middle kiln that year.

It was here that the household's learning went hardest. On the height a fire was a thing a person fed to keep warm and to cook by, and fed well, and was glad of when it blazed; and the keeper of the middle kiln, watching the son's wife build up a kiln-fire on her first morning until it roared under the racks, took her by the wrist without a word and led her to the next kiln, where the peat lay smouldering so low that the smoke came up thick and white and no flame showed at all, and held her hand flat over the rack there a long while, until the young woman understood by the heat on her palm what she had been told three times in words and had not understood. The fish on the racks above her own roaring fire had begun to cook where they should have been smoking, and were fit that evening for eating and for nothing else; and that was the whole of the lesson, and it was not given twice.

The older woman learned it faster, having less pride to lose in the learning, and it was she, in the end, who kept the eighth kiln for the rest of her life, and was known on that shingle as a keeper as good as any born there, save that she would never feed the fire from the landward side of the kiln but always from the seaward, and would not say why, and the landing let her have her way in it because the fish she smoked kept as well as any fish on that coast. Her husband never grew easy in a boat. He took to mending nets instead, and sat through the long evenings on the shingle below the kilns with the cord running through his fingers, looking up now and again at the dark line of the hills inland where the height stood that he had come down from, and he did not speak of it, and no one of the landing asked him to.

The girl who had never seen the sea grew up on that shingle as though she had been born to it. She learned to gut and to rack and to feel the heat of a kiln with the flat of her hand before she was twelve, and to handle a small boat before she was fifteen, and when she was grown she married a man of the landing whose people had kept the fourth kiln since before anyone could remember, and bore him children who were never told, by anyone, that their mother had been born inside three rings of wall on a hill above the southern lowland, because by then no one at Morn thought it a thing worth the telling. She told them herself once, when she was old, on an evening when the wind came off the land and not off the sea and carried a smell of heather down onto the shingle; and they listened po-

lately, as children listen to an old woman's tale, and asked her whether the sea could be seen from there, and she said that it could not, and that she had not known, until she came down, that it was a thing a person could be without.

IV

Of the Prising of the Altar

The temple on its stepped platform in the eastern hills was tended some years after the rings had gone dark and Làrach an Dùin-fhaire's gate had been closed, by fewer people each year, and by the end by no more than one kin of the valley below it, who went up on the shortest morning as their grandparents had gone up, and stood about the great stone while the light came over the sea behind them and ran along its top toward the mountains, and went down again.

Three of them climbed the steps with prising-bars on their backs on a grey morning at the fall of the year, with a thin rain in it, and the bars were long lengths of seasoned oak, shod at their ends with bone, the kind a household uses to lever a boulder out of a field. One of the three was the eldest of that kin, a man past sixty who had climbed the steps on the shortest morning every year of his life that he could remember, and he went up slower than the other two and did not ask them to wait for him.

They worked at the altar's top stone for the better part of the morning. The block had been set into the step below it in two sockets cut deep into the rock, and bedded there with clay and small stone so long ago that the clay had gone as hard as the rock around it, and the two younger men had to break it out a finger's width at a time with the points of the bars before they could get any purchase at all. The old man did not work the bars. He stood at the stone's far edge with both hands flat on its top, where the light used to run on the shortest morning, as if he were holding it steady against a shifting it had not yet begun to make.

It came free a while past noon. It canted first to one side, groaning in its sockets, and then with a shift of the bars it lifted clear of them and was lowered, not dropped, onto the step, and lay there whole. The three of them stood over it

1. the watch-fort ruin

without speaking, as men stand over a thing whose weight has only just left their hands and whose next weight, the carrying of it on, they have not yet taken up.

They carried it down. They slung it between them on the bars in a net of hide rope and took it down the steps one step at a time, resting at every third, and out across the hillside below toward the west, where the ground fell away into the valley; and a little before dark they went over the shoulder of the hill with it, all three together, walking slowly under the weight, and the platform behind them stood with its top step empty.

The telling goes no further with them, and the stone was never found. On the top step the two sockets were left standing open, sharp-edged where the bars had broken out the old clay, and they did not soften with the years as a path softens or a doorsill, for a socket cut to hold a great weight keeps its edges as long as the rock around it keeps its shape. What had been cut on the top of the stone, if anything had been cut there, went with it.

V

Of the Cairn on the Steps

After the stone was gone no one of that kin climbed the steps on the shortest morning again. The grass came in between the fitted slabs where it had never been let grow, and the last step, the easy one that every child of the valley had learned to find with a bare foot in the dark, was lost under turf within a few years, so that the climb began now with a stumble where it had once begun with no more than the least catch underfoot.

Some years after the prising, the old man who had stood with his hands on the stone while the others worked the bars went up alone. He was very old by then and went up slowly, a step and a rest and a step, with a stick; and at the top, below the empty sockets, where a person climbing would set his last foot before the platform, he built a small cairn. He built it out of the loose stones the prising had broken from the edges of the sockets, and out of others he gathered from the scree below, fitting each one to the one beneath it and tapering the whole of it toward a flat cap-stone set square on top, as square as the altar had been set. It took him most of a day. Then he went down again, and did not go up after.

He did not say what the cairn was for, to his kin or to anyone, and no one asked him, for it was plain enough to those who watched him come down with

his hands scraped raw that he did not mean to be asked. It stood below the empty sockets after he was dead, kept by no one and added to by no one, weathering as unmortared stone weathers, a little of its shape lost to every hard frost, until in the end it stood no higher than a man's shin, and to an eye that did not know to look for it might have passed for a fall of loose stone off the step above.

VI

Of the Rain in the Sockets

So the temple stood stripped, though it was not yet wholly forsaken; now and then someone of the valley still climbed its steps, and stood a while by the empty sockets, and came down again. The platform stood as the old man had left it: grass thickening between its stones, the small cairn below the top step, and the two sockets holding, in place of the stone that had been set square to the central mountains, whatever the sky over the eastern hills chose to put in them.

It was rain, oftener than anything. That country's weather was mild and wet and seldom dry for long between one shower and the next, and on any day after rain the two sockets held a little standing water apiece, dark with whatever had blown into them, and if the light fell right and the water lay still, the sky lay open in each of them, cut to the square shape the stone had once filled. From a little way off they looked less like two holes than like two small mirrors set into the hill, giving back whatever passed over them and keeping nothing of what had stood there.

In the south-east the shaft at Toll-dubh stood open as it had always stood. Under the mountain Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹ ran on, and the sick were still carried up to the basins, though by fewer hands each year, for the landings they came from were further off now than they had been when the heights were full, and the way up was long. Làrach an Dùin-fhaire² and the rings stood empty, and the temple stripped, within a few days' walk of one another, each left to the weather in its own year and its own way; and on every coast the landings filled, and the smoke of more hearths went up over the shingle than the shore had ever

1. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

2. the watch-fort ruin

carried, and a people who had gone up into the hills came down to the sea again and did not say why.

CHAPTER THIRTY

OF Eòghann at the River

VE 4.196 – 4.274

I

Of Eòghann's Keeping

Five hundred and fifty years had gone by since Cormac stood at the hearth of Tobar dhìreach with his ruined hand raised for the valley to see, and in all that span the bag had grown no lighter. Three coals lay in it still, cold and ordinary as the day the mason first tipped them out of his tunic: the silver-sheen, the one that would wake, if it woke at all, to no more than the snap of a hand, and the rainbow, which held every colour the eye could give a name to and answered to none of them. Keeper had followed keeper in that time, more of them than the recital troubled any longer to number separately, each carrying the three dark coals down to whichever water or fire or ground seemed to that keeper's own eye most likely, and each handing them on unlit to the next. The valley had long ago stopped remarking on the waiting the way it had stopped remarking, generations before that, on the waiting for the black coal and the red-brown. A thing five centuries unanswered ceases to feel like a question at all, and becomes instead a kind of furniture the household keeps because it has always been there, dusted at intervals and otherwise let stand.

Eòghann was born into that furniture at Tobar dhìreach, the second child of the household that held it, some five hundred and twenty-five years after Cormac's misstrike. He was not raised to think the keeping strange, any more than a child raised beside a hearth thinks the hearth strange; the bag hung on its peg

above Poit an Teine¹ from his earliest memory, and he had counted the three coals into his own small palm long before anyone asked it of him in earnest, turning them over the way another child turns over river stones, for the plain unremarkable pleasure of a smooth thing in the hand. His elder sister was the one looked to carry the keeping forward, by every custom the valley held to, and Eòghann grew up free of it in a way few before him had been free, watching the bag rather than answering for it, until his sister died of a fever in her nineteenth year and the keeping came to him instead, whether he had been raised to it or not.

He was twenty that year, and he took the bag down from its peg and untied the thong with his own hands for the first time on the same evening his father was carried out to be buried beside Leac na Fèithe², and he said afterward, when he was old enough to be asked such things and patient enough to answer them, that the two griefs had come so close together in his mind that for a long while he could not think of the coals at all without also thinking of his father's hands, which had counted them out the same way for thirty years before his own.

He was not a man of Cormac's temper. Where Cormac had struck at a thing that would not go his way, Eòghann turned from it and walked, and the valley came in time to know him by his walking the way it had known Cormac by his scar: a keeper who thought best with his feet moving, who would set out at first light with the bag over one shoulder and be gone three days, four, a week, and come back saying little of where he had gone or what he had tried there, only that it had not answered. His mother, who lived to see him grown into that habit and shook her head over it more than once, used to say that her son had been given a question too large for any one valley to hold him while he carried it, and that a body restless in that way was better let walk than penned to a hearth to grow sour on its own waiting, as she had watched other keepers before him grow sour, in households not her own, on years of counting the same dark coals into the same idle palm.

He married, in his twenty-fourth year, a woman of the lake-shore line named Dearbhail, who kept his fire-pot fed and his supper warm through absences that grew, as the years went on, neither shorter nor less frequent, and who used to say of him, laughing to her own kin about it, that she had married a man who would sooner walk to the edge of the island and back than sit still with a question he could not answer. She did not come to Tobar dhìreach ignorant of what she was

1. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

2. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

marrying into; her own grandmother had kept a fire-pot for a lesser household two valleys off, and Dearbhail had grown up knowing, in the plain way a hill child knows which crops fail on which ground, that a keeper's household ran on a different clock than other households did, its comings and goings set less by season and herd than by whatever the bag's silence had lately driven its keeper to attempt. She never once, in all the years the valley afterward remembered of her, asked Eòghann to give the keeping over to some other line, though it was hers by no blood of her own and she might, by the custom of in-marrying wives elsewhere in the hill country, have been forgiven for wishing a quieter husband; she said only, when she was asked, that a man who walked was easier kept than a man who sat and brooded, and that she would rather feed a keeper his supper cold three nights in ten than feed a bitter one his supper hot every night of the year.

He tried, in his first years of keeping, most of what the recital told him earlier keepers had tried, and a good many things it did not trouble to tell, for every keeper before him had added some private trial of his own to the bag's long history and not all of them had thought their failures worth passing on. He carried gual airgid³ to the Abhainn ghorm below Tobar dhìreach, where his own great-grandfather's generation was said to have first carried it, in case the water nearest the hearth had simply never been given its fair turn against the water of strangers' valleys. Two other rivers he tried besides, north and east, in the same summer, and a mountain tarn that was no river at all but held, by the telling, water enough to be worth the asking. None of it answered him. Over those years he grew into the particular patience of a man who does not expect an answer and goes on asking anyway, less from hope than from the plain fact that the bag was his to carry and a thing carried wants somewhere to be carried to.

It was old custom in the valley, older than Eòghann's grandfather could say with any certainty, to carry the dark coals down to the northern shore from time to time and throw them into the sea, in memory of the gold that had answered there and out of the stubborn belief, held longer in some households than in others, that water was water and the sea might yet be asked again what the small rivers had refused. Eòghann did not put much store in it himself; he had heard his father call it an old man's habit kept past its use, water thrown after water, and had heard his father do it all the same, twice in Eòghann's own boyhood, because a thing done by every keeper before him was not a thing a keeper lightly let drop,

3. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

whatever he privately thought of it. Eòghann kept the custom too, in his turn, the way a man keeps a saying he no longer quite believes because his father said it and his father's father before him, and in his twenty-ninth year, with nothing else newly occurring to him and the bag's three coals lying as dark against his palm as they had lain the day they came to him, he took them down to the shore once more.

II

Of the Northern Shore

It was two days' walk north from Tobar dhìreach to the coast, over the shoulder of the massif and down through birch and open moor into country that grew rockier and windier the nearer it came to salt water, and Eòghann went it alone, as he went most of his errands with the bag, telling Dearbhail only that he would be back inside the week and that she was not to trouble Poit an Teine¹ on his account, for it burned as well without him standing over it as with. He slept the first night in the lee of a boulder with a small fire of heather roots, as every keeper before him had slept on that same road, and came down to the shore on the evening of the second day with the wind already rising and a grey swell running in long unbroken lines from somewhere far out past the edge of what any teller on the island had ever claimed to have seen.

He knew the place. It was the same stretch of shingle his father had brought him to as a boy, a low curve of grey stone below a line of dunes, with nothing on it but the wrack the tide had left and a scatter of driftwood too salt-soaked to burn well, and a scatter, further up the beach, of the low stone hearths the seal-hunters of the near bothies built and abandoned season by season, cold now and half filled with blown sand. He had stood on that same shingle as a boy of nine or ten, holding his father's hand while the older man went through the same plain motions Eòghann went through now, and he remembered, standing there again with his own bag open, that he had thought nothing of it then beyond the ordinary wonder a child brings to any errand of his father's, salt spray and grey water and the strangeness of a coast after a childhood spent inland among hills. It did not feel strange to him now. It felt, if anything, like a duty discharged rather than

1. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

a wonder attempted, the way a man goes through the motions of a rite whose meaning has worn thin with the keeping of it and finds that the going-through has become a kind of comfort in its own right, whatever it does or does not accomplish.

He stood there in the last of the light with the bag open on his palm, gual air-gid² and the untried one and the rainbow lying together the way they had lain together on every such evening for five hundred years, and threw them, one after the other, out past the breaking water into the grey swell beyond it.

He did not know, standing there, quite what he expected to see. No keeper's telling that had come down to him described the sea giving back anything more than the plain fact of its own indifference, a coal sinking, or washing back in on the next wave to be found again among the wrack, cold and wet and no different for the wetting; and that was what he found now, wading out to his knees in the falling light to gather them back before the tide could carry them beyond finding, three coals as dark in his palm as they had been dark in the bag, the salt water running off them the same as it ran off any stone on that shore. He stood a while longer than he needed to, watching the swell come in, less because he thought a longer watching would change anything than because a man who has walked two days to be disappointed is in no great hurry to turn round and walk two days back to say so.

The wind had backed round to the north-east by the time he set out for home the next morning, carrying rain in from somewhere further out than the eye could follow, and he walked the first day of the return in a steady wet that soaked through his cloak by noon and left him, by the time he found shelter for the night under an overhang he remembered from his boyhood travels with his father, colder and wearier than the walking alone accounted for. He did not think, that first night, in any words he could afterward have set down, about the coals at all; he thought, as a tired man thinks, of the fire he did not have and the dry clothes he did not have and the distance still between him and his own hearth, and slept badly, and woke stiff, and went on.

The second day the rain eased into the kind of fine wetting mist the hill country called no more than a greening day, not worth a cloak's trouble, and Eòghann walked through it with the bag closed again over his shoulder and his mind, so far as he afterward could say, on nothing more than the ground in front of his own

2. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

feet, one stride and then the next, the way a man's mind goes when a body has been walking longer than it wants to and has stopped troubling itself with anything beyond the next mile. He came down off the moor by the middle of the afternoon into country he knew well, the birch scrub thinning into the upper reaches of the high valleys, the shoulder of the massif rising grey and wet-shouldered ahead of him, and somewhere in the last hour of that day's walking, with the light already going and his own thirst grown sharper than he had troubled to notice until then, he heard, before he saw it, the particular voice of moving water that meant the Abhainn ghorm, running full and brown-clear with the two days' rain, in the cut below the last rise before Tobar dhìreach.

III

Of the Abhainn Ghorm

He came down the bank at the place where the path always crossed it, a shallow reach where the water ran clear and quick over grey stone and a man could kneel at the edge without wetting more than his boots, and he knelt there now without much thought behind the kneeling, the way a thirsty man kneels at the nearest water without weighing whether it is the water he means to make a study of, and cupped both hands and drank.

It was cold, colder than he had thought it would be so far downhill from the height, and it ran clean and sharp against a throat gone dry with two days of salt wind and rain, and he drank a second time before he sat back on his heels with the water still on his chin, and it was only then, sitting back with his hands still wet and the last of the day's light lying flat and grey along the surface of the river, that some part of him not given to remarking on such things noticed, the way a man notices a change in weather before he has troubled to look at the sky, that the water sat differently in his mouth than the water he had waded through two nights before, and he said it aloud, to no one, the way a tired man will say a thought aloud simply because there is no one nearer than the water to hear it and correct him.

"Tha blas eile air an uisce seo seach uisce na mara," he said. This water tastes different from the sea water.

It was not, when he turned it over afterward at the recital and in all the years after that, a thought he could claim any cleverness for. He had not walked two

days home turning the silver's long failure over in his mind and arrived, footsore, at some conclusion worth the saying; he had knelt, and drunk, and been thirsty, and the words had come out of him the plain unplanned way a true thing comes out of a tired man, before he had troubled to think whether it was worth saying or to whom. But he sat back on his heels a while after he had said it, with the bag still over his shoulder and the coals inside it as cold and unregarded as they had been all the way down from the shore, and something in the saying stayed with him longer than the words had taken to say, the way a thing said aloud sometimes settles in a man's mind more firmly for having been given a voice than it would have settled left silent.

He did not reason his way to what he did next, not by any account he ever afterward gave of it. He untied the bag's thong there on the bank, with the light nearly gone and the water running loud over the stones in front of him, and took out the three coals, and without weighing the sea's long failure against this one river's long failure, without any thought that this crossing had been tried before by his own great-grandfather's generation and had answered no better than the rest, he threw them, one after another, into the current in front of him, the way he had thrown them into the sea two evenings before, save that this time he did not wade in after them, being too tired, or too little minded to trouble, to go looking for what the river might do with them before it had done it.

Gual airgid took the current a hand's breadth below the surface and did not sink further, held for a moment turning in the flow the way a leaf turns caught on a stone, and then it caught.

It came up from beneath the water rather than from its own surface, a thread of pale fire spreading out along the coal's underside first, silver-white, the colour of moonlight on moving water, and then whole, a flame standing in the current and burning there, under the surface, fed by nothing the eye could account for and quenched by nothing the river could bring against it, the water running over it and through it without troubling it any more than the wind troubles a hearth-fire built in a sheltered lee. It lit the riverbed beneath it, the grey stones there showing pale and trembling through the moving water, and it lit, faintly, the underside of the current's own surface, so that a man kneeling on the bank, as Eòghann now knelt, saw not only the flame but its light thrown up and scattered across the whole width of the river in front of him, broken and re-made a thousand times over by every ripple that passed above it.

He knelt there a long while, by his own telling of it after, watching a fire burn under water that had never in all the tellings he knew burned under anything but open air, and did not at first think to look for the other two coals at all, the untried one and the rainbow, which the current had rolled on past him into the dark; he found them at first light the next morning, wading the shallows below the crossing, lodged cold and dark against a bar of gravel a stone's throw downstream, and carried them home in the bag as dark as they had gone into the water. The silver burned on where it had caught, through that whole night and, so far as anyone at Tobar dhìreach was ever after able to say, through every night since, a low pale light under the current at the shallow crossing below the height, that any traveller might kneel at the bank and see for himself on a dark evening when the water ran clear.

I V

Of the Recital

he came into Tobar dhìreach some while after full dark, wet through, empty-handed but for the bag which now held only what the river had left him, and found Dearbhail still awake by Poit an Teine¹, who took one look at him standing in the doorway, soaked and hollow-eyed and saying nothing, and thought at first that some harm had come to him on the road before she thought to ask about the coals at all. He told her the whole of it standing there in his wet clothes before he would sit to the fire, the two days at the shore and the nothing they had brought him, the walk home in the rain, the kneeling at the crossing, the taste of the water and the words that had come out of him unbidden, and the fire that had stood up under the current and gone on standing there while he knelt on the bank and watched it, and Dearbhail, who had heard him come home disappointed from that same errand more times than either of them troubled any longer to count, said nothing at all for a long moment, and then only that he had better sit down before he told the rest of it, for he was shaking, though whether from the cold of the road or from what he had seen at the crossing he could not himself have said with any certainty.

At the next telling of the Line, on Oidhche an Dealanaich², Eòghann stood at the hearth of Tobar dhìreach with the bag counted out before him as every keeper

before him had counted it, one coal gone from three to two, and spoke the new line into the recital before the gathered valley: that the sea had taken gual òir³, and the height the white-flecked, and the earth the black slowly in the dark, and a man's own blood the red-brown, and now the river had taken the fifth, not thrown to it in trial as every coal before it had first been thrown, but given to it, he said, by a man who had done no more than kneel at its edge, thirsty, and tell it the truth of what he tasted. The valley took to calling it *gual airgid*², gual airgid, and some among them, turning the telling over at hearth after hearth that winter the way every new wonder was turned over before it settled into a thing everyone knew, said that of the five coals now answered, this was the only one that had asked nothing of the man who woke it beyond the plain truth he would have told anyway, to no one, at the edge of a river he had crossed a hundred times before without once expecting it to answer him.

There were those at the recital that first winter who pressed him afterward, at his own hearth and at others, to say again exactly what he had tasted in the water that made it different, hoping perhaps to learn some sign by which another man might know a river worth kneeling at before he troubled to throw a coal into it, and Eòghann, patient with them as he was patient with most things, told it the same way each time he was asked and owned, each time, that he could not have set the taste into words that meant anything beyond the plain fact of its being different, no more than a man could say in words what told him one face from another he had known all his life. It was not a taste he had gone looking for, he said, and he did not believe, however often he was pressed on it, that a man could go looking for it and find it any sooner than he himself had, kneeling tired and thirsty at a crossing he had waded through a hundred times without once thinking to drink from it slowly. Some among the valley's older hearths took that for a kind of answer on its own, that the coals had never once been woken by a man who set out meaning to wake them, and said so at their own firesides that winter, though none of them said it at Eòghann's hearth, judging it unkind to tell a keeper, however gently, that his own long walking might have counted for less in the matter than his own thirst.

Travellers came to the crossing below Tobar dhìreach in the years that followed, more than had ever troubled to pass that way before, kneeling at the bank

2. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

1. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

3. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

in the last light of an evening to see for themselves the pale fire standing under the current, and some of them, the recital afterward kept, knelt and drank from the same water Eòghann had drunk from, though none of them, so far as any teller ever carried word of it back to the hearth, found the water tasting to them any different from water anywhere else on the island. Gual teine and the rainbow lay in the bag as dark as they had lain in it for five hundred years and more, the one that would wake, if it woke at all, to no more than the snap of a hand, and the one that held every colour and answered to none; and Eòghann kept the bag some thirty years further, walking still, though less far and less often as the years wore on him, and in that long stretch of his own keeping tried gual teine⁵ against flint more than once, without ever striking from it more than the ordinary spark any stone gives a blade, and let it be, at the last, telling Dearbhail that some things wanted a hand he did not have and would come, if they came at all, to a keeper not yet born.

He died in his six-and-sixtieth year at his own hearth, with Poit an Teine burning near him as it had burned near Cormac and near every keeper of the line before either of them, and Dearbhail, who outlived him by some years at Tobar dhìreach, told it afterward that his last words, before the fever took his sense from him, were of the crossing, not the coals, asking whether the water still ran clear there and whether the light could still be seen under it on a dark evening, as though the one answer his long keeping had ever been given mattered to him, at the end, less as a wonder accomplished than as a place he wished, one last time, to be told was still there. The bag passed from his grave to a younger kinsman of the line, as it had passed from Cormac's, carrying two coals still dark and a keeping not yet finished; and the crossing below Tobar dhìreach kept its pale fire under the current through every season that followed, so that a traveller coming down off the height on a clear night might see it a long way off, a low still light lying under moving water, and take it, before ever he was told otherwise, for no more than the moon caught and held a moment on the stones.

4. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

5. the fire coal, of fire

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

Of the Shore

the Sea-Way and the Godkin

VE 4,275 – 4,474

I

Of the Empty Sockets

The last of the people of the landings who climbed to Làrach an Teampaill¹ in that age was a woman whose name did not come down with her, and what she went up to do there, in the last year anyone is known to have gone up at all, no telling carries either. She climbed the steps of the platform alone in the early light, past the small cairn below the top step that the old man had built, with nothing in her hands, and she came down the same steps at evening with nothing in her hands, walking no differently than she had climbed. Whatever had drawn her up there that day she carried away from the hill entire, and she did not come back to it, and no one after her came in her place.

The platform had stood stripped for the better part of a hundred years by then, ever since three men of the valley below had gone up with prising-bars and come down with the altar's top stone slung between them and carried it over the shoulder of the hill to the west. The temple had not been given up all at once on that day. It had gone on being climbed to, now and again, by ones and twos who still held some errand there, as a household goes on setting a place at table for a while after the one who sat in it has stopped coming, before it stops setting the place at all. The stripping of the stone was the wound. The woman with empty hands was only the last visit the wound was paid.

1. the temple ruin

What had lain on the altar's top before the stone was prised away, if anything had, her people did not say. The two sockets on the top step had nothing more to tell for being looked into: two square hollows cut clean into the rock, deep enough to have held the stone fast against any weather the height could throw at it, and holding now only what the sky put into them, rain in the wet months and a skin of ice in the cold ones and, in a dry summer, a little blown grit that the next rain washed out again.

After her no one climbed. The grass that the occasional foot had kept short between the fitted stones grew up thick, the sockets filled and emptied with the seasons, and the height became, for the landings below it, a place spoken of the way any finished thing is spoken of, without the reaching forward that a live question gets.

II

Of the Middens at Cwen and the Landing-Stones

Whatever had turned the coast-people back from the high places in those years, Làrach an Dùin¹ abandoned to its choked cistern and Làrach an Dùin-fhaire²'s one gate blocked from within by hands no telling ever named, the turning held. No new work of theirs went up again anywhere out of sight of salt water, not in the years the temple stood emptying nor in the long stretch after it, and the shore took back, little by little and without any single year marking the change, all the labour that the high ground had for a while drawn away from it. A people that had once spent its strongest hands cutting steps and shafts and standing walls into rock spent them now on nets and hulls and the long patient business of a midden, which is only a household's leavings kept in one place across more years than any single household lives to see the whole of, and which grows, for that reason, at exactly the pace a people's numbers grow, no faster and no slower.

At the southern landing of Cwen³ the midden that had stood modest and slow-growing for as long as the oldest tellers' grandmothers could account for it began, in the years after the temple's last climbing, to thicken season on season in

1. the fortress ruin

2. the watch-fort ruin

3. the Old Ones' root (burgs 36, 14, 139)

a way that outpaced every midden near it, Dunn⁴'s included, which had for a lifetime and more held the name of the largest heap of shell and bone and burnt weed the coast could show. It grew the plain way any midden grows, one household's supper at a time, limpet and whelk and the split bones of whatever the nets and the low-tide gathering brought in, laid down and covered and laid down again across more years than any one pair of hands could claim credit for; and it grew faster at Cwen than anywhere else along that shore for the plain reason that more of the coast-people had come to live and eat and leave their leavings there than had ever gathered in one landing before, drawn down out of the abandoned heights by ones and families and, in the last years of the drawing-down, by whole kin-groups at once, until a landing once counted by the dozen came, within the span the tellers reckoned by, to be counted by the score, and the midden below it rose to match.

It was at that same landing, or near enough to it that the coast-people who kept the one kept the other without troubling to draw a line between them, that the lane of stones was worked hardest and kept plainest: a string of flat landing-slabs laid along the shallow water of the south-east coast a day's rowing apart, grooved deep in places by the passage of keels hauled up across them season after season, running from the river mouth below Dunn round the long cape and on to the sheltered bay that lay beyond it. No single hand had set the whole of it down; each slab, by the plainest reading anyone gave it, had been laid by whichever household found that stretch of shore convenient to its own comings and goings, and the lane had grown, stone by separate stone, into a single continuous way only because each household's convenience happened, by the shape of the coast, to fall a day's rowing from the next household's. It asked no one's leave to be called a road, and no one's labour to keep it one beyond the ordinary wear of use; a keel dragged often enough across the same stretch of stone wears its own groove into it, the way a path wears into a hillside underfoot, and the lane along that coast wore in the same way, by nothing more than the daily habit of people going where they had always gone.

A rower working that lane in the years the middens at Cwen were thickest could put a name to every landing-stone on it without troubling to count the miles between them, the way a man who has walked one road his whole working life comes to know it by its ruts and its particular trees rather than by any measure

4. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

of distance a stranger might ask him for. He knew which stones took the tide well and which wanted a careful eye at the ebb, which stretch of open water between two landings ran calm on an ordinary morning and which turned ugly if the wind came round from the north before a boat was clear of it, and he knew, without needing telling, that the lane he worked had a beginning at the river mouth below Dunn and an ending at the sheltered bay beyond the cape, and nothing at either end that any teller of his acquaintance had ever claimed lay further. He rowed it, in the season the tellers afterward remembered best of him, with a boy of his own household in the bow to watch the water ahead and call the stones as they came, and he taught the boy the lane the only way it had ever been taught, by rowing it with him stone by stone until the boy's own eye could find the next landing before his father's voice named it, the same teaching a father gives a son the whole run of that coast, before and after, whatever the boat or the cargo or the year.

The lane was not without its own dangers, and every rower who worked it carried a private list of them the way a shepherd carries a list of the ground where a beast might founder. A stretch below the cape ran shallow over a bed of weed that could foul an oar in calm weather and turn a boat broadside in anything rougher, and every rower of that coast learned to feel for the change in the water's colour before his own eye had properly picked it out, the way a foot learns a familiar floor in the dark. Further north, where the lane left the shelter of the cape and ran a while in open water before it found the next landing-stone, a wind out of the north could come up faster than a laden boat could answer to it, and the tellers of that coast kept, among their older sayings, a plain word of caution for any rower new to the stretch: watch the gulls before you watch the sky, for the birds leave that water a good while before a man standing in it feels the first of what is coming. A boat caught there in a quick blow had no landing nearer than the stone it had last left or the one it was making for, and more than one crew, in the tellers' keeping, had spent a hard night pulling for whichever of the two seemed the less far, with nothing to show afterward for the night's work but a boat brought in whole and a story told quietly at the next gathering of boats.

He was rowing that lane, in the last summer the tellers gave him a season at all, when a boat coming the other way hailed him at a landing neither of them had reason to linger at, and the two crews sat their boats together a while in the calm water off the stone, trading nothing more than the news each carried, which was, that season, mostly news of the shore filling: more households at Cwen than either boat's crew could remember from a single year before, and a landing fur-

ther north near empty of the families that had worked it a generation back, gone down, by every account either crew had heard, to the same swelling numbers at the southern shore. Neither rower troubled to wonder aloud why the pull toward that one landing had grown so much stronger than toward any other; it was enough, for the telling either of them carried home, that the shore was filling where it was filling, the way a valley's herds drift of their own accord toward the better grass without any single beast leading the rest to it, and the two boats parted at the landing-stone with nothing settled between them but the plain fact traded and carried on, each in its own direction, along the lane that neither of them had ever thought to give a name beyond the shore's own word for it: the old way of the sea, worked as long as either crew's memory reached, and older, by every account handed down to them, than that.

III

Of the Dead Laid in the Ground

In the high valleys about the crack, in those same years, the households laid their dead in the ground as they had always laid them, and it is worth telling how, since it was by this more than by any other thing that the valleys afterward knew themselves.

When one of a hearth died, the women of that hearth washed the body with water drawn that morning and wrapped it in a cloak of its own, or in a hide if there was no cloak to spare, and laid it on its side with the knees drawn up, as a sleeper lies on a cold night. The men dug. They dug on ground near the hearth, or on a rise the household had always used, never on the green mounds of the valleys, which were the sith's roofs and not to be broken, and never near Leac na Fèithe! at Tobar dhireach, where no one drew water and no one dug save the line itself. The grave went down to the depth of a man's waist, or deeper if the ground was soft, and the body went into it with its face toward the central mountains, and with whatever the household judged it would want: a knife, a comb, a string of shells, oftener nothing. Then the earth went back over it, and the turf over the earth, and a stone was set on end at its head, a plain stone, uncut, and that was all.

No mark was put on the stone. The valleys cut no signs, and did not wish to. A household knew its own dead by where they lay, and by the shape of the rise,

and by the stone at the head, which was a stone and not a word; and when there was no longer anyone living who knew whose grave it was, the grave was left alone all the same, because it was a grave. A child of the valleys learned this as it learned which way the burn ran, before it could have said why: that the ground was full of the dead of the valleys, laid in it since before any father's name could be counted back, and that the living walked over them every day and did not break them.

It was this that Rathnait's people meant, afterward, when they said they had not come. The dead of the valleys lay in the valleys, under the turf, facing the mountains, as far back as anyone could dig; and there was no telling at any hearth of any other place they had ever lain, or any water they had crossed, or any shore they had come from. They were in the ground because they had grown out of it. Aithris a' Chruthachaidh² said so, and the ground agreed.

IV

Of the Name Said Aloud

Rathnait was not of An Clachair's¹ own line, nor of any house that kept a fire-pot or a bag of dark coals against its own hearth, but she was of the valleys about the crack all the same, born the third child of a household two ridges east of Tobar dhìreach, and she grew up hearing Aithris a' Chruthachaidh² the way every child of those valleys heard it, a little at a time, from whichever hearth she happened to be sitting at when some elder took it into their head to say a piece of it. She was not, by her own account given later in her life, a woman much given to wondering over the coals themselves, dark as they had lain in their bag for longer than any living teller could put a plain number to; what she wondered over, from a fairly young age and without ever quite settling the wondering, was the plainer question of what a household was, set beside all the other households of the valleys, and what a person owed to the ones near her blood as against the ones merely near her hearth.

It was a question that came to a head, for Rathnait as for a good many of her generation, on the night the valleys kept as the darkest of the year, the night the

1. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

2. the Telling of the Making

1. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

2. the Telling of the Making

recital called Oidhche an Dealanaich³, when every household that could reach another in a single evening's walk gathered at whichever hearth was that year's turn to hold the gathering and heard the fathers' names said standing, from the first spark to the mason's own line down to the living, and heard after it the older riddle of the sky and the earth and the sea that no one any longer troubled to try against the coals in earnest. Rathnait had sat through that gathering every year of her life she could remember, first on her mother's knee and then on her own two feet among the other children let stay up past their ordinary bedtime for it, and she had never, in all those years, heard the gathered households called by any single word that named the whole of them at once; each hearth was known by its own place and its own kin, this house of the eastern ridge or that house of the ford, and Aithris a' Chruthachaidh, when it named the people it spoke of, named them only as the mason's kin or the valleys' own, never by any word that drew a line around the whole gathering and set it apart from whatever lay beyond the line.

In her five-and-twentieth year the gathering fell to a household on the western side of the crack, larger than most and closer by half a day's walk to two other valleys besides its own, so that the crowd that came in for Oidhche an Dealanaich was thicker that year than Rathnait had seen it in any year before, hearths she barely knew sitting shoulder to shoulder with hearths she had known her whole life, all of them come for the one telling and the one riddle and the one night's watch against a dark that every valley of that country kept in exactly the same way. She sat that year not among the children, being grown enough by then to be counted among the women who kept the fire fed through the long recital, and she watched the crowd rather than the speaker for a good part of the evening, the way a person newly grown into a gathering often watches the gathering before she troubles to listen closely to what it has come together to hear.

It was in the stir after the fathers' names were said and before Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁴ was taken up, the crowd loosening for a while into its own smaller talk the way any long-held silence loosens once the thing it was held for has been said, that Rathnait heard a man of the western household, older than her own father and known to her only by sight, answer a stranger's question about who these people gathered here were, all told, with a word she had never heard given to the whole of them before. Clann nan Dè⁵, he said, Clann nan Dè, and said it

3. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

4. the Keeper's riddle

plainly, the way a man says a thing he has turned over long enough in his own mind that it no longer feels new to him in the saying, though it plainly felt new enough to the stranger who had asked, and new enough, too, to more than one of the near hearths who caught the word and turned to hear it repeated. He gave no long account of where the word had come from, only that it seemed to him, and to others he had spoken with, a truer word for the gathered valleys than any word tied to a single ridge or a single ford, since what held the valleys together on a night like this one was neither ridge nor ford but the fathers' names and Teine a' Chlachair⁶ and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich that had come down with them, a thing shared by blood or by hearth or by both at once, in a way no single valley's own name had ever quite managed to say.

Rathnait asked him, when the talk had opened enough for a young woman to put a question to an elder of another household without seeming forward in it, where the households said they had come from before Teine a' Chlachair was given them, whether from some shore beyond the water, and the old man answered her without hesitation that they said no such thing of themselves; the households of the valleys held no telling of any coming at all, only of having been there, in the ground they buried their own dead in and cut no mark upon, for as far back as any father's name could carry a listener. The valleys' dead went into the ground itself, he said, under the same earth the living walked over, and the households that buried them that way had never, in any telling Rathnait's own elders could carry back to her, claimed to have arrived from anywhere at all; and the households called themselves, when they troubled to call themselves anything beyond their own ridge or ford, the children of the gods Aithris a' Chruthachaidh spoke of, and let whoever asked further make of that claim what they would.

The word went round the gathering that night the way any new word goes round a crowd already loosened by a long recital and a full fire, tried out first in ones and twos at the edge of the firelight and then, as the night wore toward its coldest hour and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich was taken up in its turn, said more freely by more mouths, until Rathnait heard it a dozen times before the gathering broke for the households to find their own places to sleep out the rest of the dark. She said it herself before the night was done, trying the shape of it in her own mouth the way a person tries a new word to see whether it sits well or ill on the tongue, and found, without quite deciding to find it, that it sat well enough;

5. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

6. the mason's fire, the first fire

she was of no house that kept a fire-pot, and no line that counted fathers back to the mason himself by name, but she was of the valleys about the crack, buried her own kin in the same ground as every other hearth of that country, and had never in her life claimed to have come from anywhere but the place she stood in. Not every hearth at that gathering took to the word so readily. An old woman of the ford, sitting nearer the fire than her years strictly wanted on so cold a night, was heard to say to her own daughter that a name was easily enough taken up in one warm evening's talk and just as easily let drop again once the frost of the walk home had cleared a person's head of it, and that she herself had heard other words tried at other gatherings in her own long life, words that had seemed, for an evening, to fit the valleys as well as any word could, and had none of them lasted so much as a season past the fire that first warmed them into being said. She was not unkind about it, and she did not trouble to argue the man of the western household out of his word; she said only, when her daughter pressed her on why she would not use it herself, that she had buried too many hearths' worth of new names already in her own lifetime to grow fond of one before it had proved itself against more than a single cold night, and that she would wait, as she had waited before, to see whether the word was still being said the next time the valleys gathered, and the time after that, before she troubled to let it sit easy in her own mouth.

Rathnait did not have an answer ready for the old woman that night, being young enough still to feel the weight of an elder's doubt without having any settled reply to set against it, but she carried the doubt home with her all the same, turning it over on the walk back to her own household's hearth the way she turned over most things that unsettled her without quite convincing her. It seemed to her, turning it, that the old woman was right about one thing and wrong about another: right that a word tried once at one fire was no sure thing, and wrong, or so it came to seem to Rathnait across the seasons that followed, in judging this one word by the run of words that had gone before it, for she found herself using it still at the next night of the lightning, and heard others near her using it too, hearths that had not been at the western gathering at all and could only have had the word carried to them by some mouth that had, the way a coal is carried from one hearth to a cold one three valleys off. By the time Rathnait was old enough to sit among the elders at her own hearth's turn to hold the gathering, the word she had first heard tried out at the edge of a stranger's firelight had settled into ordinary use across the valleys about the crack, said as plainly and as

unremarked as any of the older words for a single ridge or a single ford, and she herself, asked once by a child of her own household where the households of that country had first got the name they called themselves, could only say what the old man of the western hearth had once said to her: that it seemed to her, and to others she had spoken with, the truer word for what held the valleys together, and let the child make of that what she would.

Clann nan Dè, she said it to herself once more, low, with the fire between her and the western hearth's crowd still finding new mouths to carry the word further, and it was still in her own mouth, unremarked and untroubled, when the gathering at last went down to sleep and left the name standing, for the first time that any teller after ever cared to mark, said aloud.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

OF the Sliver at Àth gharbh and the Name of the Line

VE 4,475 – 4,671

*Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann. We did not come; we were here.
The Sixth Part: Of Clann na Ceiste, and the Seventh Coal*

I

Of the Sliver at Àth gharbh

Barabal was five and thirty years old the spring she burned the sliver, and she had carried it in a fold of her own girdle, on and off, since she was a girl young enough to be given a bright stone for a plaything and old enough to remember, all her life after, exactly where she had been given it.

It had come to her the way small things come to children who are not watched every hour: a boy of the households nearest the crack, one of the many who ran errands between the high valleys and were fed at whatever hearth they stopped at, had shown it to her at a ford four miles from her own door, turning it in the light to make her see the colours run, and had then, tiring of her wonder or wanting to be free of his hands for the game they were playing, pressed it into hers and told her to keep it, as boys will give away in an idle hour what they would fight to keep the next. Where he had it from he did not say and she did not ask, being at that age more taken with the having of a bright thing than with the history of it, and by the time she was old enough to wonder where a stone with a rainbow shut inside it might have come from, the boy himself was long gone back to his own val-

ley and grown, for all she knew, into a man who no longer remembered giving it. She kept it the way a woman keeps the small relics of her own childhood, in a fold of cloth at the bottom of a box, taken out now and again to be looked at and put away again, and told no one at Àth gharbh what it was, chiefly because she did not herself know.

She knew only Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹, which every hearth of the valleys knew by then, of the mason and the fire out of the sky and the coloured stones that had gone into it and burned dark like any other stone; and she knew, because every child of that country was told it before it was told anything else worth telling, that Clann a' Chlachair² kept a whole bag of such pieces yet, unburned, and turned them over every so often at the hearth on Oidhche an Dealanaich³, trying this shore and that height against a riddle none of them could answer. It had never once occurred to Barabal, in all the years she kept her own small piece folded away, that what she held was of a kind with what the line kept; it was to her a pretty stone a boy had given her at a ford, no more sacred than a good flint or a well-turned spindle-whorl, and if she thought of Aithris a' Chruthachaidh at all when she took it out to look at it, it was only the way a person thinks of any old story while handling any old thing, without troubling to draw the two together.

What put the drawing-together into her head, in the end, was nothing more than an idle evening and a low fire. She was five and thirty, married eleven years, mother by then of three living children and one buried, and it was the wet edge of a spring that had been hard on the peat-stacks; she had gone out in worse weather than she liked to cut what she could from a bank already half drowned, and had come in cold to the bone with her hands raw from the wet turf, and sat that evening turning the little bright stone in her fingers by the low fire the way she always did when her hands were tired and wanted something small to do. She had wondered, not for the first time, whether it would burn like any other stone if she put it in, and had never once tried it, out of some half-formed care for the pretty thing that she could not have named a reason for. That evening, with the peat smoking low and green from the wet bank and giving off more smoke than heat, she thought: it is only a stone, and stones do not care what is done to them, and set it, before she could talk herself out of it, on the coals at the fire's edge.

It did not vanish, and it did not shine. It caught the way any coal catches, slow at first and then all at once, a small black-flamed fire no bigger than a thumbnail,

1. the Telling of the Making

2. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

burning low and steady exactly as the peat around it burned, giving off the same dark smoke and the same middling heat, so that a person coming in from the yard and finding it burning there would have seen nothing in the fire worth a second look. Barabal watched it the whole while it burned, waiting for some other thing to happen, some flare of colour or some voice out of it such as Aithris a' Chruthachaidh gave to the mason's own finding, and none came; it burned down to a black cinder exactly as a lump of ordinary coal burns down, and went out, and by morning was cold ash mixed in with the rest of the hearth's ash, indistinguishable from it.

The hearthstone under where it had lain, though, had taken a stain through its whole thickness, a colour gone down into the grain of it the way water goes into a dry cloth, no soot-mark for a hand to rub away, faint gold at the stone's heart and paling to nothing at its edges. No scrubbing Barabal gave it in the weeks after ever brought the stone back to plain grey. She showed her husband, and her husband, who had no more patience for wonders than any man with peat to cut and cattle to see to, said only that it was a strange stone and she had best not go setting any more strange stones on his hearth without asking him first, and left it there. It was her husband's mother, an old woman who had outlived two households and remembered a good deal of the valleys' talk from further back than most, who said, turning the stained stone over in her own hands by the daylight of the door, that she had heard tell, once, long ago, from a teller who had it from a teller before her, that Clann a' Chlachair kept coloured stones just such as this, and that no one outside that line had ever, in any telling the old woman knew, been fool enough or curious enough to try one on an ordinary hearth.

Barabal did not think herself either a fool or unusually curious, only a tired woman with cold hands on a wet evening who had wanted to see what a pretty stone would do, and she said as much when word of the stained hearthstone began, as such things do in a country where every hearth knows every other hearth's business within a season, to travel beyond her own door. It travelled slowly at first, carried by whoever happened to stop at Àth gharbh and see the stone for themselves, and it travelled, in the main, as a curiosity rather than a wonder, a strange small thing that had happened to one household and might never happen to another, since no one else at Àth gharbh or the households near it had a piece of an gual dathach⁴ to try, nor any notion of where one might be got. It

3. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

4. the coloured coal

did not reach the line's own ears, so far as anyone ever afterward could say, for some years, and when at last a fire-bearer of the old carrying custom, passing through Àth gharbh on his way to a hearth further north, heard the tale told over a cup and carried it home with him among the ordinary gossip of the road, the line's own hearth at Tobar dhìreach took it, by every telling that survives of that day, with less astonishment than Barabal herself had felt at the first burning. The old woman who then kept the bag and the pot, whose name the recital does not give to strangers, is said only to have listened to the fire-bearer's telling of the stained stone through to its end, and to have said, when he had done, that a piece thin enough to fit in a boy's palm was thin enough to lose, and that she was neither surprised nor sorry that one had gone astray somewhere in the many years since the mason first filled his tunic with more than he could ever afterward account for.

Barabal lived seven and thirty years more after the burning, long enough to become, in her own valley, less the woman who had done a strange thing once than simply an old woman among her grandchildren, as every woman who lives long enough becomes; she died in her two-and-seventieth year, at her own hearth, with nothing more said over her going than is said over any grandmother's, and the stained stone, by then split at last by some later hand trying to see whether the colour ran all the way through, was kept afterward at Àth gharbh as a plain curiosity, shown to travellers who asked after it and to children who did not, for longer than any single teller's memory could afterward account for.

II

Of the Stained Wool of Achadh dhìreach

Giorsal was born at Achadh dhìreach fifteen years after Barabal set her stone on the coals, in a household ten miles west of the crack that kept no fire-pot and counted no fathers back to any mason, and grew up, as every child of those hearths grew up, on Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹ and on the plainer, harder business of getting a living out of ground that gave up its crops grudgingly and its dead, in the way of all ground, without asking leave of anyone.

It was the dead that Giorsal came, in time, to know better than most women of her valley knew them, for she was the one her household turned to when a

burial had to be seen to properly, the washing and the wrapping and the choosing of what went into the ground with a body and what stayed behind for the living to use, work that fell more often to the women whose own hands had steadied enough of their kin's dying to have lost their fear of the office. She had buried, by the time she was five and thirty, more of her own blood than she cared to count aloud, and a good many besides who were no blood of hers at all but had no one left of their own to see to them properly, and she had come, across all that burying, to a private habit that she never troubled to explain to anyone who did not ask, and that not many did.

She rubbed a little broken coal into the wool a body was wrapped in before the ground took it.

It was not a custom she had invented outright; there was, at Achadh dhìreach as at a scatter of other hearths along that stretch of the valleys, a scrap of broken coloured stone kept in a box much as Barabal's had been kept, come to that household by some road no living teller could any longer trace, whether traded for a good hide or given by a passing kinsman or simply picked up, once, by some forgotten hand, from a place it had no business lying. Giorsal's own grandmother had shown it to her as a girl, calling it only the bright stone and saying nothing of what it was, and Giorsal had grown up handling it the unremarkable way a child handles any small treasure kept in a household box, until the year she first stood over a grave with the wrapping in her hands and found herself thinking, without quite meaning to think it, that the dead ought to carry something of worth into the ground with them, and that a stone worth keeping in a box for three generations was as fit a thing as any to give.

She broke off no more than a sliver's dust each time, rubbed between finger and thumb into the coarse wool at the breast of the wrapping, where a mourner's own hand might rest a moment before the ground closed over it, and she did it seldom, by her own later account, from no rule she had ever set herself, only from the plainer fact that the stone was small and the dead of Achadh dhìreach were, in an ordinary year, more than it could ever have served had she rubbed it into every wrapping that passed through her hands. She judged, in some manner she never put fully into words even to the daughter she taught the office to after her, which graves wanted it and which did not, choosing perhaps one burial in thirty across the whole span of her working years, so that most households of that valley, asked

afterward whether their own dead had gone into the ground with any of the coloured stone about them, could say only that they did not know, or that they supposed not, the office being Giorsal's to judge and not theirs to ask after.

The wool took the colour the way Barabal's hearthstone had taken it, a stain gone down through the fibre, no smear for time or damp to wear away, streaks of a hue that no plant Giorsal or anyone else of that valley had ever set to dyeing wool could match, gold in some threads and a deeper red-gold in others depending, it seemed to her, on nothing she could ever predict from one grave to the next. She never dug a wrapping up again to look at it, that being no fit thing to do to the dead for the sake of a woman's curiosity, and so she never knew, nor did any who came after her, whether the stain held in the ground the way it held in the moment of the rubbing, or faded, or spread, or did anything at all once the earth had closed over it; she knew only what her own eyes saw in the last moment before the closing, and she kept that knowledge to herself and to the daughter she taught, telling her only that the stone was a good thing to give the dead and that she would understand, in time, which graves asked for it, the same understanding having been given to her without much explaining by the grandmother before.

Word of Giorsal's habit travelled less far than word of Barabal's burning, partly because a wrapped body going into the ground offers less of a spectacle than a stained hearthstone shown at every passing traveller's asking, and partly because Giorsal herself, being a private woman about the office in every other particular, saw no reason to make more of this one particular than of the rest. It reached the ears of the line, when it reached them at all, by much the same slow road the tale of Barabal's stone had travelled, carried by a fire-bearer or a trader who happened to hear it told at some hearth along his way and thought it worth the telling further, and the line, by the time it heard, had already had some fifteen years to grow used to the plainer fact that its own long-kept treasure was not, after all, the only coloured stone the valleys held between them. Giorsal died in her seventieth year, at Achadh dhíreach, of a wasting that took the better part of a winter to finish its work, and was buried, her own daughter saw to it, with a sliver of the stone rubbed into her own wrapping in her turn, the office passing that once, as it must, from the hand that had always given it to the hand that had only ever received it before.

III

Of the Bright Thing on the Midden at Bral

Far to the west, on the shore the coast-people called Bral¹, a woman going over the midden below her own household's huts in the low light of an autumn morning found, among the ordinary wrack of shell and burnt weed and the split bones of whatever the tide and the nets had lately given up, a small hard thing that was neither shell nor bone nor any stone she had ever turned up out of that heap before.

It caught the early sun the way wet slate never caught it, a gleam with more than one colour folded into it, and she turned it over in her fingers a good while, the way a person turns over any small unaccountable thing found where it has no business being, before she did with it what she did with most such finds: she carried it up to the huts and showed it to the others of her own household, who turned it over in their turn and were, by every account the shore afterward kept of that morning, no wiser for the turning than she had been. No one of that household could say how long it had lain among the midden's ordinary leavings before her own eye found it, whether it had come down with that season's shell and bone or lain buried some years already under layer on layer of the heap's slow growing, and no one troubled the question long, a midden being, by its nature, a place where things arrive by more roads than any one household can keep account of: by its own hands, by trade struck at some other landing and carried home, by a stranger's leavings washed up with the tide and taken for the household's own, or by some smaller, quieter road that no one at Bral that morning cared, or was able, to put a name to.

It was not burned. No one at Bral that season, or any season the shore's own tellers afterward reached back to, is known to have set it to any fire, cooking or otherwise; it was handled the way the coast-people handled any bright find that served no plain use, admired for a morning or two and then set aside among the household's other small keepings, a shell too fine to throw back, a bone worked smooth by the sea, a stone that caught the light. Whether it lay afterward in some box or niche of that household's own keeping, or was lost again in its turn to some later midden or some child's careless hand, no telling of the shore or the hill country either one ever afterward claimed to know; it passed, as most small bright

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

things pass, out of the particular notice that had first found it remarkable and into the general keeping of a household that had a great many other things to attend to besides one stone among its trinkets.

The hill country never heard of it. Whatever the bright thing at Bral was, and however it had come there, by gift or by trade or by theft, it remained a thing the shore alone half-wondered at for a season and then let go, the way the shore let go of a great many small unaccountable things the sea and the land between them brought to its notice and never troubled to explain.

IV

Of the Name Taken at the Gathering

By the year Colla came to the keeping of the bag, it was known across the whole breadth of the valleys about the crack, settled by then into the ordinary stock of things everyone knew rather than kept as any marvel, that an gual dathach¹ did not belong to Clann a' Chlachair² alone; that a stone had been burned once at a hearth of Àth gharbh and had stained the very rock it burned on; that a woman of Achadh dhìreach had, for a working lifetime, given slivers of it to the dead; and that here and there, at this hearth or that, some household could show a scrap of its own, come by gift or trade or simple finding, and could tell a version of the tale, more or less true to the first telling, of how it had come to them. None of it troubled the line's own long keeping in the smallest degree, the bag at Tobar dhìreach holding still, that year, the two coals that had never yet answered any trial given them, gual teine³ and the last, the coal of every colour together that the reciters had taken, since Diarmad's own day, to calling the rainbow; but it had changed, all the same, something in the way the valleys spoke of the line, for a people who had once been the sole and singular keepers of an unaccountable wonder were by then one household among several that held a piece of the same wonder, distinguished from the rest chiefly by how much of it they held and how long they had gone on asking what it was for.

It was this, more than Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁴ itself, that a wit of Àth gharbh named Oscar took up, half in jest, at the gathering that fell that year to a

1. the coloured coal

2. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

3. the fire coal, of fire

hearth two ridges from his own, on the night the valleys kept as the darkest, when every household that could reach another in an evening's walk came together to hear the fathers' names said standing and the old riddle taken up again and laid down again unanswered. Oscar was five and forty that winter, a man well known in his own valley and a good many neighbouring ones for a tongue that found the loose thread in any solemn thing and pulled it, gently enough that most who felt the pull laughed along rather than took offence, and he had, by his own later telling, no plan at all when he opened his mouth that night beyond the plain wish to say something that would make the hearth laugh before the cold walk home.

The recital had been said, the fathers named back through Eòghann and the fifteen whose names the line kept from strangers to the one then living at Tobar dhìreach, a man named Colla, five and thirty years old that winter and new enough to the keeping of the bag that more than one elder present remembered his father's own turn at the reciting better than they yet knew his. Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich had been taken up after, as it always was, and laid down again, as it always was, for no one that night had brought forward any new trial to try against it, the sea and the sky and the earth and the blood and the river all having long since answered, and the two dark coals lying, as they had lain for longer than anyone at that gathering had been alive to remember otherwise, exactly as dark as the day the mason first burned their fellows.

It was in the loosening after, the crowd breaking into its own smaller talk the way any long-held silence loosens once the thing it was held for has been said, that Oscar, standing near enough the fire to be heard by a good part of the gathering without troubling to raise his voice, remarked to whoever was near him that the line ought by rights to be given a better name than the mason's children, seeing as how the mason's own trade of splitting stone had gone clean out of the family more generations back than anyone could count and been replaced by nothing so much as the steady, unhurried business of asking the same question of the same two coals and getting, every time, the same silence back. He called them, that night, for the first time that any teller after ever troubled to fix a year to, Luchd-ceasnachaidh a' Ghuail Dhiomhair⁵, the long questioners of the secret coal, saying it slow and a little grand, the way a man says a thing he means partly to be funny and partly, though he might not have owned to it that night, to be true.

The hearth laughed, as Oscar had meant it to, and a good part of the gathering with it, the name being long enough and grand enough set against so plain and

patient a business to strike most ears there as exactly the joke Oscar intended; but it did not die with the laughing, the way most jests of a cold night die by morning, for a name that fits a thing, however it is first meant, has a way of being said again by mouths that never heard the first saying of it, carried the same slow road any word travels in a country of scattered hearths, from this fire to that one, until it no longer belongs to the man who first shaped it. Colla himself, asked some months after by a traveller passing through Tobar dhìreach what his people called themselves, is said to have given the long name back without any of the laughter that had first carried it, adding only that the short form most mouths found easier was Clann na Ceiste⁶, the children of the question, and that either would serve, his own line having asked one question, in one form or another, for longer than it had done any other single thing worth the naming.

He was five and sixty when he died, having kept the bag some thirty years by then and handed the keeping on before the end to a son whose name, like every father's before and after him along that stretch of the line, the reciters kept from strangers; and it was under his name, said standing at the recital the winter after his death, that the older name of the line, the mason's children, was heard for what the tellers afterward reckoned the last time spoken as the line's own name rather than as an old thing remembered. The households of the valleys had, by then, taken to calling the line simply Clann na Ceiste in their ordinary talk, the way a name settles into use long before anyone troubles to mark the day it settled, and the reciters, who kept the older forms alongside the new the way they kept every name the line had ever answered to, said both that winter at the gathering, the mason's children and the children of the question together, before letting the newer name stand alone in every recital after.

Rathnait's own word for the whole of the valleys, spoken first at a gathering not so many years before Oscar's jest and settled by then into as ordinary a use as any name the hearths had ever taken up, was said that same night alongside the line's new name, Clann nan Dè⁷ and the children of the question both, two names taken up within one generation of each other, the one by the valleys and the other by the line, which shared, that winter, the one gathering and the one fire and, though neither troubled to remark on it, the one long habit of the valleys:

4. the Keeper's riddle

5. the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal

6. the Children of the Question

7. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

that a name tried once at a cold hearth, if it fitted the thing it was given to, outlived the fire that first warmed it into being said, and was carried on, from mouth to mouth and gathering to gathering, long after the man or woman who first shaped it had gone, in their own turn, into the ground.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

Of Fire in the Stone

VE 4,672 – 4,850

I

Of the Stone New in the Grass

Lughaidh was two and twenty the year he first drove his flock up the western slopes past the ford where the two burns met, following the ewes further than his father had ever troubled to follow them, on the reasoning, which was his own and which he never explained to anyone who did not first ask, that grass eaten short by one summer's flock was grass a man wanted to leave a season or two before he brought his beasts back to it. He was a patient shepherd rather than a clever one, the kind neighbours spoke of as steady before they spoke of him as anything else, and it was this steadiness, more than any restlessness of his own, that carried him that year to a fold of the western grass no one of his own hearth had grazed in living memory.

He came on the stone in the last of the day, when the light lay long and gold across the tussocks and every small rise threw a long shadow ahead of it. It stood alone on a low shoulder of ground where nothing else stood, no cairn near it, no path worn to it that he could see, a single upright slab taller than a man with his arm raised, grey where the lichen had not yet taken it and green-grey where it had, leaning not at all, so square to the ground that Lughaidh's first thought, looking at it across the darkening grass with his dog gone quiet at his heel, was that no weather he knew of stood a stone up that straight on its own.

He did not go to it that evening. He counted his ewes instead, the way a shepherd counts before anything else, and made his fire a good bowshot off, on ground he knew, and ate what he had carried and lay down with the dog against

his side and did not sleep well, waking twice to look toward the shoulder of ground where the stone stood black now against a paler dark, telling himself both times that a stone was a stone and had never yet troubled a sheep or a man, and neither time quite believing himself enough to sleep sound on it.

In the morning, with the light coming up grey and then gold behind him and the stone standing plain and ordinary in it, he walked over.

It was new. That was the thing he could not afterward make anyone who had not seen it for themselves believe: new in the way of a thing lately made, the cut faces of it sharp-edged still, unrounded by rain, the grass at its foot not yet grown back over whatever digging had set it, a bare collar of turned earth no wider than a hand's span all round the base, greening at the crumbled edges and black and raw at the centre where no green had reached at all. Lughaidh had seen old stones before, the low grey teeth of them scattered here and there about the high ground the way old stones are scattered on any hill a people has walked long enough, softened at every corner, sunk a little into their own hollows, grown into the land until a man half forgot they had ever been raised. This one had begun no such forgetting. It stood the way a new-cut post stands in a fence line before its first winter, still telling, to anyone who looked close, exactly how lately a hand had set it there.

He put his own hand flat against the face of it, for no reason he could have given beyond the reason any man puts a hand to a strange thing, and found it warm from the morning sun and rough under his palm in a way that was not all weather; and looking closer, with his eyes now used to the light, he saw that the roughness ran in lines, a shape laid on the stone by some other hand than weather's, a single running line of signs cut into the upper face from one edge near to the other, in a script he did not know and had never seen, and that no one of his people cut or read. It ran level, and it stopped clean at both ends, as though whoever had cut it had known exactly how much they meant to say and said no more and no less.

He did not touch that line again once he had seen it plainly. But lower down the face, where the stone narrowed toward its foot and the full morning light now fell square upon it, he found a second cutting, shorter, four small clusters of signs set close together, cut narrower and shallower than the line above by what he judged, turning his head to catch the shadow in the grooves, a finer tool and another hand. He could no more read them than the line above. He stood a good while with his hand near the stone and not on it, looking from the narrow lower

cutting to the broad line above and back, turning over in his own slow way the plain fact that here were two hands where he had at first looked for one, and that neither hand had left any other mark on the hillside, no footprint the grass had not already swallowed, no ash of a fire, no litter of chips such as a mason leaves at his work. The stone stood finished. Whoever had raised it had raised it and gone.

He brought his flock down off that ground within the week, going a longer way round than the ground asked, and keeping the stone in sight over his shoulder the better part of the descent, as a man keeps a strange dog in sight rather than turn his back on it first. That night, at his own hearth, with the fire built up higher than a shepherd's supper called for, he told what he had found to his father's household, and was made to tell over again the shape and the place of the lower cutting, how many clusters, how close, how deep; and his father, an old man by then and slower to wonder than his son, asked only whether the boy had left anything of his own behind him up there, a mark, a stone moved, anything the ground might afterward be made to answer for, and Lughaidh, a little stung that this should be the first question asked of him, said he had moved nothing at all, which was true, and remained true the whole length of his life after.

The tale went from that hearth to the next inside the week and further before the season turned, gathering as it went, the way any tale gathers: that the stone stood taller than a man with his arm raised became, by the third or fourth telling, taller than two men stood one on the other's shoulders; that Lughaidh had found it in the last light of evening became, in some mouths, that he had found it by a light of its own, which Lughaidh denied plainly and without heat whenever the telling reached back to him. And by the next winter every hearth that told of the stone told also what its four low words said, *Bha teine sa chloich*, there was fire in the stone, though no one of the valleys could read a sign, and no one could say whose mouth had first given the words to the marks. How that came to be known is a riddle, as the knowing of the lines in the Doire uaine hills had been; known it was, and said the same way in every mouth, as though a saying that fitted so well the felt shape of an old wonder needed no hearth's embroidering to carry.

What the line made of it, Lughaidh himself never troubled to learn in any close way, being a shepherd and not a keeper, and the keeping of stones not being work he had ever been asked to take up; but it came back to him, in the way things came back along that same slow road, that the fire the second saying spoke of was held by Clann na Ceiste¹ to be their own fire, Teine a' Chlachair², though

who had cut the words, and when, and by what right a hand not of the line's own reckoning had come to speak the line's own matter in stone, none of them could say any better than Lughaidh could say who had left the older, wider line above it. The line took the lower words for their own. The upper line they left as Lughaidh had left it, unread, and it stayed unread by every eye that came after his, the whole length of Lughaidh's own life and long past it, a single running mark on a stone none could account for standing above four words that everyone, in the end, agreed to.

Lughaidh kept his flock on those slopes and the others near them for the better part of fifty years after, growing old the way a steady man grows old, and he is remembered, where he is remembered at all beyond his own hearth, as the shepherd who found the stone new. He died in his seventieth year, at his own hearth, the same year, as it happened, that a young man of the line standing at that season's gathering said the four words aloud for the first time to a crowd that had come to hear the fathers named; and whether Lughaidh, failing by then in his last illness, ever heard that they had gone so far, no one troubled to say.

II

Of the Two Hands on the One Face

The line did not leave the stone in the west alone once it had taken the four low words for its own. A woman of Clann na Ceiste¹ who had the recital better than any of her generation, and who was troubled, as the line had always been troubled, by any question left standing, walked west to it in the second summer after Lughaidh's finding with two of her sons to carry the food, and sat before it three days.

What troubled her was the order of the two hands. The broad line of unread signs across the upper face and the four narrow words below it had not been cut at one time, nor by one tool; any eye could see that much, and hers was a sharp eye. But which had come first she could not tell, and it seemed to her, sitting in the grass with her back to the wind and the stone standing over her, that it mattered a great deal which. If the broad line had been cut first, then some hand

1. the Children of the Question

2. the mason's fire, the first fire

1. the Children of the Question

of the line's own people, or of a people who spoke as they spoke, had come afterward to a stone already cut by another and set its own saying beneath the older one, as a man might set his own mark beneath a stranger's on a gatepost to say that he had passed that way too. If the four words had come first, then some other hand had come afterward and cut its own saying above them, in signs no one of the valleys could read, over the head of a saying they could.

She looked for the answer in the grooves. She ran her fingers along the upper line and along the lower words, morning and evening, when the light came across the stone low enough to throw a shadow into every cut, and she felt the edges and the floors of the grooves and the lichen at their rims, and she could not tell. The upper cuts were broader and the lower narrower, and the lower were cut with a finer tool; but the lichen had not yet taken either, the stone being so new, and the weather had worked no more on the one than on the other. She said, when she came home, that she had sat three days with the two hands and they had both kept their counsel, and that she would not guess which had come first, since a guess said at the recital would be a guess remembered as a thing known.

The line kept to that. At every recital after, when the stone in the west was spoken of, it was said that the four low words were the line's own saying and the fire in them 'Teine a' Chlachair², and that the broad line above them was unread; and it was said, too, that when the second hand came to the stone is not known. The woman's sons, who had carried the food and sat the three days with her and grown very tired of the grass, said privately to their own children that their mother had known perfectly well which hand came first and had simply refused to say, because she did not like to be wrong in front of the recital; but their mother, asked it straight out on her own deathbed by a grandson who had heard the story, said she had not known then and did not know now, and that he might ask the stone himself if he doubted her, since it had answered her exactly as plainly as it would answer him.

It was the first of the island's stones to carry the marks of two hands on one face. The line said, and it is told still, that this was fitting, for 'Teine a' Chlachair had come to the island by two hands also, the sky's and the mason's own, and neither of them had asked the other's leave.

2. the mason's fire, the first fire

III

Of the Second Stone

The second stone stood a good day's walk from the first, further into the hills where the ground rose broken and stony and the grass thinned to tussock and bare rock between, on ground no shepherd of Lughaidh's own valley grazed at all, being poor feed and further than any flock needed driving for it. It was found later than the first, by how much later no telling ever fixed with any certainty, though the line came to reckon it a matter of some years rather than many, and it was found, as such things are found on ground that few walk, by a traveller rather than a shepherd, a man of no particular note who left no name behind him in any telling and who is remembered only as having said, when he brought the word down to the nearer hearths, that he had near enough walked into the thing before he saw it, so little did it stand apart from the broken grey rock all about it.

This stone was shorter than the first and plainer, no line of unread script upon it at all, only the one cutting, three words only, in the same narrow, sure hand that had cut the four words low on the other stone, or in a hand so like it that no one who compared the two, then or after, could swear to any difference between them:

Cuimhnich an teine.

Remember the fire.

Who was bidden to remember, and what exactly they were bidden to remember beyond the plain word, no telling that came down from that hillside ever said, and the line at Tobar dhireach, asked by more than one traveller over the years whether the second stone spoke to them any plainer than the first, gave the same answer each time: that the fire was theirs to remember whether the stone bade them or no, and that a command cut in rock to no one in particular was, for all that, a command they were glad enough to take as meant for them, there being no other hand on the island that kept a fire so old or minded so hard to be told to keep minding it.

It was some years after the second stone's finding that the four low words of the first stone were said, for what the tellers held to be the first time, standing, before a whole gathering rather than at a single hearth. The young man who said them was of the line, new enough to speaking before a crowd that his voice caught once in the saying and had to be steadied, and he said them as a thing

come down to him, by the same slow road as everyone else, from a traveller who had had it from a traveller before him, back, though no one at that gathering could have traced the whole chain of it, to the first hearths that told of the stone, fifty years gone. The gathering took the words up the way the valleys took up any saying that fitted a felt thing, repeating it after him at the fire until it had passed into the ordinary stock of what was said at every gathering after, alongside the recital of the fathers and the old unanswered riddle of the coals.

IV

Of the Ring at the Second Stone

Mòrnait was born at Tobar dhìreach into Clann na Ceiste¹, though not into the narrow line of fathers that kept the bag from father to son, her own household being one of the many that had gathered, over the generations since Oscar's jest first took, about the line's own hearth without ever holding the coals themselves. She grew up on Aithris a' Chruthachaidh² as every child of the valleys grew up on it, and on the newer sayings besides, the four words and the three, said so often at so many gatherings by then that a child of her own age could not have told anyone which she had learned first or from which mouth, the sayings having become, by the time she was old enough to say them back, simply part of what was known, the way the shapes of the hills were known, without a first telling anyone troubled to remember.

She was a woman of no particular office among the line, keeping no bag and reciting no fathers, but she had, from a girl, the kind of restlessness that finds its own work where none is asked of it, and what she found, some years into her own married life, was the stone of the three words, Colbh Cnoc chiar³, and the poor, broken ground about it, which she took to visiting at first out of no more than the wish to see for herself a thing so much spoken of and so seldom looked at, the valley's own folk being no readier to walk a hard day into stony hills than the shepherds before them had been.

The walk was no small undertaking for a woman with a household of her own to keep, a full day out over broken ground that gave a walker nothing easy under-

1. the Children of the Question

2. the Telling of the Making

3. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

foot the whole way, rising steadily from the last of the good grass into country where the path, such path as there was, picked between slabs of bare grey rock split by frost into edges sharp enough to cut a soft boot-sole, and where the wind, coming off the high ground with nothing to break it, found a traveller from every side at once rather than the one side a valley wind came from. She went in fair weather when she could choose her day and in weather no fairer than most when she could not, carrying the coal wrapped in its damp moss inside a second wrapping of oiled hide against the wet, and food enough for the two days the walk there and back and the sitting between them asked of her, and she came home each time, her own husband said afterward, looking as though the ground itself had had something to say to her on the way that she had not yet finished turning over.

Asked once, by a niece of her own household who thought the whole business a strange use of a grown woman's days, what she meant to prove by it, Mòrnait is remembered to have said that she meant to prove nothing, proving being the line's own long business at Tobar dhìreach and none of hers; and asked a second time, more gently, by an old woman of a neighbouring hearth who had herself walked the long road once and found nothing at the far end of it but a stone and cold rock, what she hoped to find there that the older woman had not, Mòrnait said only that she went to leave something rather than to find anything, a fire, where a stone had asked for one to be remembered, and that whether the stone or anyone behind it ever marked her leaving it was not, in the end, greatly her business either. What she did, once she had made the walk a second time and a third, she never afterward explained in any way that satisfied everyone who later asked her why, saying only, when pressed, that a fire kept meant more than a fire spoken of, and that a stone bidding her remember seemed to her, however the stone had meant it, ill remembered by words alone. She carried fire up from the pot at Tobar dhìreach, the coal wrapped close in damp moss the whole hard day of the walking so that it lived to the far end of it, and she built, on the bare stony ground about the foot of the second stone, a ring of fire-cracked stones gathered from the broken rock all round, and in the ring she laid and lit a fire the size of any ordinary hearth-fire, no bigger, and sat by it until it had burned down to nothing, and then she went home.

She did this again the next year, and the year after, at first alone and then, as word of it went about the valleys the way word of anything went about them, with others who came to sit by the fire with her a night or a day before going their

own ways home, so that by the tenth year of her keeping it the ring at the stone had grown a worn path to it where before there had been none, and the ground within the ring had taken the hard-trodden, ash-blackened look of ground that has held fire and feet upon it many times over, no different in the end from the ground about any hearth kept a working lifetime, save that no house stood by it and no one lived there and the fire, once built and burned down, was left to go out on its own rather than banked to keep till morning.

Nothing came of it beyond the keeping, no wonder shown, no answer given, the fire she built behaving exactly as any fire behaves that is fed dry wood and left to burn, no coal of the vein ever brought to that hillside to be tried against the stone's own bidding, for Mòrnait held, and said so to anyone who asked whether she meant the fire as some trial of Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁴, that the stone had asked only to be remembered and not to be questioned, there being questioning enough already given to the two dark coals by better keepers than herself over more years than she had been alive to count. She built her fires instead the way a woman keeps any old duty that has come to feel, over years of keeping it, less like a duty than like her own: because the ground asked for it, and because a stone that had stood so long bidding anyone at all to remember deserved, she thought, at the least, to see that someone had.

The ring was kept the whole of her own life after, walked to every year she was able, her steps growing stiffer with the walking as the years told on her the way years tell on any woman, until in her own sixty-fifth year she made the walk for what turned out to be the last time, her own household by then grown used to letting her go alone and expecting her back within the fortnight as she had always come back before. The fire she lit as she had always lit it, and sat by it as she had always sat by it, and it is told, by the few who came that year to sit an evening with her before going on their own ways, that she said, watching the flame go down toward the last of its light, that she did not know what the stone remembered, only that she had kept it as well as she knew how, and that whoever came after her would have to find their own way of keeping it if they meant to keep it at all.

She died that same year, at her own hearth at Tobar dhìreach, some weeks after her return from the last walk, of no illness anyone could name beyond the plain wearing-out of a long life, and her own daughter, and after her the daughter's own children, took up the walk to the stone in her stead, less often than Mòrnait

4. the Keeper's riddle

herself had kept it, yet often enough that the ring did not go cold in any one man's lifetime after hers, the ash of each new fire laid down over the ash of the last until the ground within the stones held, in its blackened depth, more years of keeping than any single teller could any longer count from the top of it.

Of an evening, in the years after Mòrnait, a traveller crossing that stony ground toward dusk might still come on the ring at the second stone with a fire newly lit and low in it, and a face or two beside it he did not know, keeping, without much to say for themselves beyond the plain fact of the keeping, a fire that answered no riddle and proved no coal and asked, of anyone who sat by it, nothing at all but to remember; and the stone stood over them as it had stood over Mòrnait and over the traveller who first found it before her, plain and grey and three words deep, giving no more account of itself in the last light of any one of those evenings than it had given in the first.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

OF the Column

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I

Of the Third Stone

Ciannait was one and thirty the summer the third stone was found standing where no stone had stood the year before, on a low rise of open ground two days' walk south-west of the crack, where the hill households of that country brought their beasts down each autumn to graze the stubble before the frosts came. She had made that same drive every year of her grown life, her own hearth lying a half-day short of the rise, and she had crossed that same ground a hundred times without there being anything on it to cross toward beyond the one thorn tree the drovers used as a mark; so that when her brother's boy came running back along the track that year shouting that there was a great stone standing on the rise where the thorn tree stood alone, she took it at first for a boy's way of making an ordinary walk into something worth the telling, and only went to look because the beasts were slow that morning and there was time enough to spare for looking.

It stood taller than the thorn tree beside it, a single squared pillar of the pale blue-grey stone the hill country called only the blue rock, for want of any better word, set so true to the level ground that a plumb line hung from its top would, by the account of the first men to lay hands on it, have kissed the earth at its foot without a hair's width to spare either way. No cairn stood by it. No path led to it, not yet, though within the year there would be one worn plain enough by the feet of those who came to see it that even a stranger new to that country could have found the rise by the track alone, without ever being told which way to look.

She came up to it with her brother's boy at her heel and the rest of the drove already scattering out over the stubble behind her, and she did what everyone who came to it that first summer is remembered to have done: she put her hand flat to the stone's face, low down where a hand reaches without stretching, and found it warm from the morning sun and rough under her palm with the lines of a cutting she had heard tell of but never yet seen with her own eyes.

The words ran the whole breadth of the lower face, more words than either of the two stones further north had carried, cut in the same narrow, sure hand, or a hand so like it that no one who set the three sayings side by side, then or after, could ever swear to any difference between them:

Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann.

We did not come; we were here.

Above the saying, where the stone narrowed toward its shoulder, ran a second line in the older, wider script that no one on the island had ever read and no one on the island ever would, the same running, level mark that had stood over the first stone's four words and, fainter and shorter, over the second stone's three; and it was this, more than the new saying below it, that told the hill folk who came to look that whatever hand had cut the older line meant the three stones to be read, if they were to be read at all, as one long saying rather than three short ones, though what that whole saying was, taken together, no one at Achadh a' Chalbh¹ that summer, or in any summer after, ever agreed on closely enough to fix it in words of their own.

Ciannait could no more read the cutting than anyone of her people could read a sign; yet before that first summer was out every drover who stood at the pillar said what its lower words were, as the words of the other two stones had come to be known, by no mouth anyone could name. She said them herself that autumn at the stone's foot, and heard her own voice go out over the stubble and come back thin off the one bare rise, and stood a while with her hand still on the stone after the saying was done, turning over in her own slow way what it meant to be told, by a hand no living person had seen at its work, that her own people had not come from anywhere at all.

Her brother's boy asked her, when she came away from it at last to see to the beasts, who had cut it; and she told him, because it was the only true answer she had to give him, that she did not know, and that no one living knew, and that it

1. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

did not seem, from the plain freshness of the cutting and the bare turned earth still black at the stone's foot, that whoever had cut it had troubled to wait about afterward to be asked.

He asked her a second question that she liked no better for having no better answer to give it, which was whether the stone would still be standing come morning, boys of his age having heard enough, by then, of the walker on the ridge and the covered hearths of the hill country to wonder whether anything found new on open ground was safe to be left overnight; and she told him only that a stone was not a fire, and had never yet been known to go out, and that they would see for themselves soon enough, the drove being due back over that same ground within the fortnight whether the stone had a mind to bide there or not. It was there when they came back, exactly as they had left it, the bare turned earth at its foot a little more weathered and no wider, and it was there again the fortnight after that, and every fortnight and every season after, so that within that one year's turning the households of the drove had stopped asking, among themselves, whether it would stand, and begun asking only what, besides its own two sayings, it might yet be found to mean.

II

Of the Field of the Column

Word of the third stone went out from that rise the same slow road the first two sayings had gone, hearth to hearth and gathering to gathering, but it went further and it went faster, for by the year it was found the four words of the first stone and the three of the second had already had the better part of a lifetime to settle into the ordinary stock of what every hearth in the hill country knew, so that a saying come new from a third stone, and a longer one besides, found ears already listening for it in a way the first two sayings had never found when they were new. Within two summers the rise had a name of its own among the households that gathered there, Achadh a' Chalbh¹, and within five it had a worn ring of bare earth about the stone's foot where feet had stood so often and so long that no grass had troubled to come back into it, much as the ring at

1. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

the second stone had worn bare under Mòrnait's own feet a day's walk to the north.

It was at Achadh a' Chalbh, in the third summer after the stone's finding, that Ciannait heard the whole saying said standing, before a gathering of some thirty households come together at the dark of that year to keep Oidhche an Deal-anaich² together on ground none of them had kept it on before, the recital of the fathers being said, as it was said at every such gathering, by whoever among them had it best by heart; and it was an old woman of a hearth two valleys east of Ciannait's own, a woman near her eightieth year whose name went into no telling that outlasted her own grandchildren, who rose when the fathers had been named and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich³ laid down again unanswered, and said the three sayings of the three stones together for the first time that Ciannait, or anyone else at that gathering, had ever heard them said as one.

She said the four words of the first stone, and the three of the second, and then, turning to face the pillar where it stood pale in the firelight with its own shadow thrown long across the trampled ground, she said the words of the third: *Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann*. And she said after it, in words that were her own rather than any stone's, that Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁴ every hearth in the hill country already kept, of the young god who had made the island of his last coal and the first people who grew up out of its ground like grass, meant a plainer thing than most tellers troubled to draw out of it: that a people grown from the ground they stood on had no other ground to have come from, and no other root than the one under their own two feet, and that the stone said only, in fewer words than Aithris a' Chruthachaidh used, what Aithris a' Chruthachaidh had always said.

Ciannait was four and thirty that night, old enough by then to have children of her own standing at her side and young enough still to remember, plainly, what it had been to put her own hand to the stone the summer it stood new; and she said afterward, to those of her own hearth who asked her what she made of the old woman's words, that she did not know if the god had meant the saying or only the shape of the telling had come to fit it, but that she had stood a long while that night looking at the pillar with the fire between herself and it, and had felt,

2. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

3. the Keeper's riddle

4. the Telling of the Making

for the length of that looking, that the ground under her own feet had a name it had not had before the saying was said over it.

The gathering at Achadh a' Chalbh was kept again the next dark of the year, by more households than the first, and again the year after that, until within Ciannait's own lifetime it had become, for the hearths of that whole stretch of country, the one gathering-ground of the year that every household within two days' walk turned toward as the days shortened, in much the way that other households further north turned each year toward Tobar dhìreach to hear the fathers named at the line's own hearth. No house was built there in Ciannait's time, nor for long after it, the ground about the pillar being kept, by a custom no one troubled to set down as a rule because no one thought it needed one, for the fires and the standing and the going home again rather than for living; but it had, by the time Ciannait's own hair had gone from dark to grey, what neither of the two older stones had ever had on their own bare hillsides, which was a name that every child of that country learned before it learned to walk the day's ground to earn it, and a fire built there, at the very least, once in every year that the dark of the year came round.

The crowds that gathered twice a year, once at the dark of the year and once at the height of summer when the drove-roads were driest and easiest walked, brought with them, as any crowd of that size brings, more business than the saying alone; and it was out of the standing and the going home again, rather than out of any plan laid by any one household, that a market grew up on the stubble about the pillar's foot in the years of Ciannait's own middle life, hides traded for salt and salt for wool and wool for whatever a household further off had to spare, the traders setting out their goods on hide cloths spread over the same trampled ground the fires were built on, and taking them up again within the day, for no one yet thought to leave anything standing there overnight beyond the stone. Ciannait traded there herself more than once, wool off her own beasts for salt she could not get nearer than three days' walk any other way, and she said of it, once her hair had gone grey, that she had gone the first few times for the salt and kept going, in the end, as much for the crowd and the fire and the saying said over it as for anything a trader could set out on a cloth.

III

Of the Fire Coal in a Child's Hand

While the saying at Achadh a' Chalb¹ was still new enough that most who heard it had heard it first from someone who had themselves heard it only at second or third remove, a child was born at Tobar dhìreach into the narrow keeping of the bag, the son of the tenth father after Colla, whose name the reciters have never given to any stranger who asked it of them; and that child, a boy named Seathan, had gual teine² in his own hands, by every account that came down from that hearth, before he was old enough to be trusted with anything else his household kept.

He was not yet six the first summer a fire-bearer passing through the valley on his way north carried with him, along with the ordinary coal for the hearths that had let their own go out, the word of the third stone and its saying, new enough then that even at Tobar dhìreach it was still told as news rather than as a thing everyone already knew; and the boy sat that evening at the edge of the household's fire with gual teine turned in his fingers, as he turned it most evenings for no reason beyond the plain unremarkable comfort of a smooth stone in a small hand, listening to the fire-bearer tell of the pillar and its shadow and the old woman's words without troubling, at that age, to understand more of it than that somewhere two long days south a stone stood that people walked a long way to look at, much as his own hearth was a place people sometimes walked a long way to hear the fathers named.

He asked his mother, when the fire-bearer had gone on his way, whether the coal in his own hand had come from the same place as the stone's saying, and she told him, in the plain way the women of that hearth answered such questions of their children, that the coal had come from the mason's own vein under Leac na Fèithe³, and the stone's saying from no one anyone living could name, and that the two were not, so far as she or anyone else of that house had ever heard, the same matter at all, though both were things the valleys had come, in their own way, to keep.

His father, whose own name the reciters have kept from strangers as they had kept the nine fathers' before his, said less of it than his mother had, being a man of few words even at his own hearth, but he took the boy's chin in his hand that same evening and turned his son's face up to his own and told him only that the bag on the peg had waited longer than any stone in the south had waited, and that

1. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

2. the fire coal, of fire

3. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

a thing worth keeping was worth keeping without asking each year whether the keeping had yet come to anything. The boy took it gently, said gently as it was, and kept it in mind ever after, by his own account given late in his own life, better than he remembered most of what either of his parents said to him in those years, for it was the first time anyone had told him plainly that the waiting, and not only the answer waited for, was a part of what the bag asked of whoever held it.

The coal did nothing that evening it had not done every other evening of the boy's short life: it lay black and cool in his palm while the hearth-fire threw its light across the backs of his hands, unburning and unchanged, the way it had lain in every hand of that household since the mason's day, while its fellows one by one answered to the sea and the height and the earth and the blood and the river, and this one and the rainbow were left over, unanswered, in the bag on its peg. The boy set it back in its place when his mother called him to his supper, and thought no more of the stone at Achadh a' Chalbh, by his own much later account, than a child thinks of any far country he has been told of once and has no cause to think of again; and it would be the better part of forty years, and the household grown old and passed to his own keeping, before that same coal gave him any cause to think of it a second time.

IV

Of the Word Carried North, and Ciannait's Children

The saying of the third stone went further north than either of the two before it, carried, some twenty years after the stone was found, by a woman of the northern shore who had come south to trade hides for salt at one of the market days the valleys about Achadh a' Chalbh¹ had lately begun to keep on the strength of the crowds the gathering-ground drew twice a year; she heard the saying said at the stone, standing among strangers with her own bundle of hides still on her back, and carried it home with her the whole long walk north the way she carried the salt, meaning at first, by her own later telling, only to have something worth the telling to set against the hides she had got for her trouble.

She had walked the better part of ten days to come so far south, by the drove-roads and the fords where the hill households kept the stepping-stones renewed,

1. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

carrying her bundle of hides the whole way down and her sack of salt the whole way back, and she said afterward, to whoever at her own hearth asked her whether the walking had been worth the trading, that the salt alone would not have answered for it. Never in her own life had she stood among so many strangers at one fire as she stood among at Achadh a' Chalbh, nor heard so many households at once say the same four words together as though they had rehearsed them, which, in a manner of speaking not one of them would have owned to, they had, each in their own valley, for a lifetime before that night.

She said it first at her own hearth on the northern shore, to a household that kept no stone of its own and no gathering-ground within any number of days' walking, and it went from that hearth to the next the way any saying went among people with little enough new to tell one another, until within a handful of years a shepherd of the far north-western moor, asked by a trader what his own people held of where they had come from, could answer him with four words he had never once walked south to hear at any stone, and answer him as though the words had always been his to answer with.

Ciannait lived to see that much of it, though she never herself walked further north than the drove-roads her own beasts had always used, and she said, in the last years of her own life, to the children she had raised at her hearth two days short of the pillar, much what the old woman of that first gathering had said to her when she herself was four and thirty: that Aithris a' Chruthachaidh² every child of the valleys already knew, of the god who had made the island last of all his makings and the people who grew out of its ground like grass, said the same thing the stone said, in older and longer words, and that a saying found new on a hill-side was no less true for having waited so long to be said, any more than a well was less good water for having been dug only last spring rather than in the mason's own day.

She said it to them by her own hearth-fire on more evenings than any of them troubled to count while she was living to say it, and she said it to them once more, plainly and without much dressing beyond the words themselves, in the last winter of her own life, sitting close by the fire with a granddaughter's hand in her own because the cold had by then got into her joints past any warming; and it is this last saying of it, rather than any of the summers she had walked to Achadh a' Chalbh in her own strength, that her own children kept longest and passed on

2. the Telling of the Making

furthest, so that the words came down, in that one household at least, less as a stone's saying than as an old woman's, said at her own fire in her own last winter to the children who would carry it after her.

She told the granddaughter whose hand she held that winter, when the girl asked her why the words mattered so much to an old woman who could no longer make the walk to hear them said at the stone, that a saying did not need a body able to walk to it in order to go on being true, any more than 'Teine a' Chlachair³ had needed the mason himself still living to go on burning from hearth to hearth long after his own death; and she said that the girl might live to see the stone herself, or might not, and that it would be true either way, standing there with its two sayings and the one above them no one could read, whether any of Ciannait's own blood ever stood at its foot again or never did.

Ciannait died that same year, at her own hearth, in her one and seventieth year, and was buried on the ground her own people had always buried their dead on, without any coal of the vein given her in the ground, that custom never having reached so far south-west in her own lifetime; and her children kept the walk to Achadh a' Chalbh after her, some years and not others, much as Mòrnait's own daughter had kept the walk to the second stone, so that the fire at the pillar's foot did not go long unlit in any one generation's span, and the saying she had given them at her own hearth went on being said, at that fire and at others, by mouths that had never once stood at the stone themselves and never once doubted, for all that, that the words were theirs to say.

In the years after her death the pillar at Achadh a' Chalbh stood as it had stood the summer Ciannait first put her hand to it, its lower face no less plain for all the years of firelight that had played across it, its upper line no better read; and the boy who had once turned gual teine⁴ in his fingers by a fire far to the north, hearing a fire-bearer's first telling of a stone he had never seen, was by then a grown man keeping that same coal in a bag on a peg above his own hearth, walking nowhere with it, waiting, without much hope left in the waiting, for a day he did not yet know was close upon him.

3. the mason's fire, the first fire

4. the fire coal, of fire

Of Seathan's Snap

VE 4,905 – 4,950

I

Of the Fire Coal in Seathan's Keeping

By the time the saying at the column had gone the length of the hills and back, so that a shepherd of the Doire uaine could say *Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann* to a stranger from Àth gharbh and be understood without a word of telling first, the bag at Tobar dhìreach still held two coals unanswered, and had held them so long that the households nearest the hearth had stopped troubling to ask after them at all. Five of the seven had been given up by then to the sea, the height, the earth, a man's own blood and the river below the house, each in its turn and each after its own long waiting, and the recital that named them had grown so familiar at the fire on Oidhche an Dealanaich¹ that children said the fathers' names along with the reciter before they were old enough to know what a father was. What was left in the bag was *gual teine*², *gual teine*, and the coal that held every colour and answered to none, *gual bogha-froise*³, the rainbow; and of the two *gual teine* was reckoned, by most who troubled to reckon it at all, the likelier of the pair, since fire was a thing the line already kept and fed and carried from hearth to hearth every day of its life, and it seemed a smaller step from keeping a fire to waking one than from nothing at all.

Seathan was born into the keeping of it, at Tobar dhìreach, the only son of a father whose name the reciters do not give to strangers, being one of the ten they

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

2. the fire coal, of fire

3. the rainbow coal, of spirit

keep back between Colla and himself; and he had gual teine in his own two hands, by his own account, before he could well remember not having it, turning it over as every child of that hearth turned it over, black and ordinary to the eye but for the faint sheen that ran through it when the light caught it a certain way, like the last colour left in an ember that has gone from red to grey. His father kept the bag until Seathan was twenty, walking with it as every keeper before him had walked, to the sea twice in Seathan's own boyhood and to the high moor once, and coming home each time with nothing to show for the walking but the same two dark coals and the same tired shrug he gave the household at the door, so that Seathan grew up, as Eòghann had grown up seven hundred years before him and Cormac five hundred years before that, watching a grown man's failure become, by long repetition, no more remarkable than the weather.

He took the bag over on his father's death, in his own twentieth year, and did not, in the years that followed, walk with it the way his father had walked. He had watched enough walking from the doorway of that same house to have formed, without ever quite saying so to anyone, a private opinion that the walking answered nothing, that a coal carried a hundred miles and thrown into water was no likelier to catch than a coal held quiet in a man's own palm by his own hearth, and that the recital's telling of five lightings — the sea taken by a man who had never before seen it, the height by a man who reasoned his way up to it, the earth by a man who buried it like the dead, the blood by a man's own hurt, the river by a man too tired to reason at all — argued, if it argued anything, that no manner of asking had yet been tried twice with the same result, and that a man might as well ask in the way that came naturally to him as go hunting after some other man's manner that had happened, once, to answer. So Seathan kept gual teine near him rather than carrying it abroad, put it into the household's own fire on the night he took the keeping and on every night since when the old fire was rekindled from the pot after some absence, watched it lie in the flame with the wood and the peat about it, unburning and unchanged while everything around it blackened and fell to ash, and took it out again each time no worse for the fire than it had gone in, and set it back in the bag, and waited.

He had put it, by his own count, into the pot once, into the fire the line held to be the mason's own, carried unbroken from hearth to hearth since Oidhche an Dealanaich; and it had lain in that fire as it lay in every other, dark and cool to the eye though the flame stood all around it, and Seathan had watched it a long while that night with the household asleep behind him, and gone to his own bed no

wiser than he had sat down. He did not, after that, expect very much of any fire he put it into, though he went on putting it into fires all the same, the way a man goes on doing a small habitual thing less from any hope in it than from the discomfort of leaving off something that has become, over enough years, a part of how an evening is spent.

Seathan married, in his six-and-twentieth year, a woman named Caitir, of a household two valleys to the east that kept no coal and no telling beyond the ordinary one every hearth in the hill country now knew by heart, and she came to Tobar dhìreach knowing, as every woman who married into that house came knowing, that she was marrying a keeper and not only a husband, and that the bag on its peg above Poit an Teine⁴ was a third presence in the household that no wife before her had ever managed to be rid of, however she might in time come to be fond of it. Caitir was neither so patient with the waiting as Dearbhail had been at Eòghann's hearth seven hundred years before, nor so impatient with it as some wives of other keepers were remembered to have been; she said of Seathan, to her own kin when she visited them, that she had married a man who thought a great deal and walked very little, and that she would sooner have him sitting where she could see him of an evening, turning a black stone over in his fingers and saying nothing, than have him gone a week at a time over hill and shore the way his father had gone, and if the coal never woke at all she judged that no great loss set against a husband who came home to his own supper every night of the year.

They had children, three of whom lived past their weaning, and Seathan told Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁵ to each in turn as it had been told to him, Coimhdeach na Fine⁶ in the grove and the smoke that stood still in a gale and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁷ of the three spirits, and watched each of his children, in the way of every child of that house before them, take up gual teine from its bag on some idle evening and turn it in the firelight, half in earnest and half in play, the way a child handles any wonder it has grown too used to to be properly afraid of. The years went by him in that house in much this manner, gual teine in its bag or in his hand or in some fire that could not touch it, the recital said each year on Oidhche an Dealanaich with his own name given now among the fathers who came after Colla, and no more happening in all that span, by his own reckoning of it, than

4. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

5. the Telling of the Making

6. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

7. the Keeper's riddle

happens to any man who keeps a hearth and raises children and grows, without quite meaning to, into the settled middle of his own life.

II

Of the Warm Evening

It was the sixteenth day of an t-Ògmhios, and the evening had come on warm and still after a day of full sun, the kind of evening the high valleys got perhaps a dozen times in a good summer, when the heat stood in the ground and the midges hung thick over the burn and no one troubled to build up the hearth-fire before dark because the warmth of the day had not yet gone out of the walls. Seathan sat in the doorway of his own house with the last of the light on his hands. He had no particular business there; the doorway caught what air moved on such an evening, and the inside of the house did not. Gual teine was out of its bag, as it often was on a quiet evening, and he turned it in his fingers less to test it than for the plain unremarkable comfort of a smooth stone in the hand, the way another man might turn a whetstone or a knife-hilt while his mind ran on something else entirely.

He was not, that evening, thinking of gual teine¹ at all, whatever the recital afterward made of the moment. He was thinking, so far as he could ever afterward say what he had been thinking, of the mason, and of the well the mason had been sinking on a morning nearly five thousand years further back than any living man could properly picture, and of the lightning that had come down into that well out of a storm and set a vein of black stone burning that had lain unburning under the hill since before there were hearths on the island to burn anything at all. It was an old thought, one he had turned over at that same doorway more evenings than he could count, and it came to him now, as it had come to him before, that Teine a' Chlachair² had needed nothing carried to it and nothing thrown into any sea; it had simply come, in a single crack of light, out of nothing that any man beforehand could have named as its cause, the way a dry year ends in one afternoon's storm and no man can say, watching the sky the morning before, that this was the day the rain would come.

1. the fire coal, of fire

2. the mason's fire, the first fire

His fingers turned the coal as he thought it, working at it the way a man works absently at a thing his hands have long since learned to handle without his mind's leave, pressing and turning until the coal's outer face, dried by thirty years of handling and by that day's own sun on the doorstone, began to crumble under his thumb into a fine black dust that caught in the lines of his palm.

He did not decide to snap his fingers, and said so every time afterward that he was asked, and he was asked a great many times in the years that were left to him: his hand had done it the way a hand does a thing it has done ten thousand times before, without asking the rest of the man whether this time was different from the last, a boy's trick, a man's idle habit, the small dry crack a finger and thumb make when they are pressed and loosed the right way, and he had done it perhaps a hundred times that same summer alone, at that same doorstone, with dust of one kind or another on his fingers and his mind on something else.

He snapped his fingers.

The dust on them took fire.

It went up off the back of his hand in a small quick rush, no larger than the flare a dry twig gives when it first catches, and it was the colour of gual teine itself, a clear red-gold, brighter by a good measure than any hearth-flame he had sat beside in all his years of keeping it, and it lit the doorway around him for the length of a breath the way a struck spark lights a dark room, so that Caitir, coming to the door from within at the sound he made, saw his whole face for a moment lit from below as if he held a small sun cupped in his hand.

He shouted, more from the shock of the light than from any hurt, and beat his hand hard against the front of his coat the way a man beats out a spark that has caught in dry cloth, and the flame went out under the blow as quick as it had come, and he stood a moment with his hand still pressed to his chest before he brought it away and looked at it in the last of the daylight.

There was not a mark on it. The skin lay whole and unreddened across the back of his hand and along each finger, no different than it had lain that morning, and the black dust that had covered his fingers a moment before was gone entirely, burned away to nothing that even a careful eye could find on him.

He stood looking at his own open hand for what Caitir afterward said was a good deal longer than the thing had taken to happen, turning it front and back in what light was left, and then he sat down heavily on the doorstone where he had been sitting before, and began to laugh.

He laughed, by Caitir's telling of it, in a way she had not heard from him in all the years of their marriage: a long helpless laughing, far past the short dry laugh he gave at some jest of an evening, that bent him forward over his own knees and would not let him straighten to answer her when she asked, twice and then a third time, standing over him in the doorway with her hands still floury from the evening's baking, what in the world had come over him. Between one fit of it and the next he got out that the fire had been in his hand the whole time, that he had carried it thirty years in a bag on a peg and walked nowhere with it and asked nothing of sea or height or earth, and it had been sitting the whole while in the one place he had never once thought to ask, which was his own two hands doing what his own two hands had always done. Caitir understood perhaps a third of what he was telling her and none of why it should be so funny; she sat down on the stone beside him at last and took his hand in both of hers and turned it over herself, front and back, to see with her own eyes that there was truly no mark on it.

III

Of the Telling at the Hearth

Word of it went from that doorway to every hearth within a day's walk before the week was out, carried first by the children, who had seen their father laughing on the doorstone in a way none of them could account for and had run to tell their mother's kin of it before they had rightly understood what there was to tell, and then by Caitir herself, who found, once she had turned the thing over in her own mind a night and a day, that she believed it a good deal more than her first hearing of it had let her believe, and said so plainly to whoever asked. Seathan told it himself at the recital that same year, on Oidhche an Dealanaich¹, standing at the hearth of Tobar dhìreach with the bag counted out before him as every keeper before him had counted it, one coal now gone from two to one; and he told it, by every account that came down from that telling, in much the plainer words he had used to Caitir on the doorstone, without dressing the thing up in any manner beyond the bare truth of it, that the fire had been in his own hand the whole time he carried it, in the hand and in the snap of it, the way the lightning had been in the sky the whole time before the

1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

mason ever set his wedge in the seam that woke it, and that a man could go looking a long way off for a thing he had carried on him from birth without once thinking to look there.

The old women of the line who remembered the silver's lighting in their own girlhood, and had heard from their own mothers of the black and the red-brown before that, wept a little at the telling, the recital says: no grief in it, only the plain accumulated weight of four thousand years since the grove, now come round again to a sixth answer; and there were those among the younger households, who had grown up thinking the two remaining coals no more likely ever to wake than Leac na Fèithe² was likely to lift on its own, who came away from that telling with a new respect for the bag on its peg that their own fathers had not troubled to give it. The valley began, that same winter, to call the coal *gual teine*³, gual teine, in the telling that had before called it only the sixth or the last-but-one, and some among the households furthest from Tobar dhìreach, hearing the tale at one remove and then at two, told it back with small changes of their own, so that within a very few years there were tellers who had Seathan snapping his fingers a-purpose, meaning to try gual teine that way as a fisherman tries a new knot, and had to be corrected by those nearer the hearth who had heard it plain from Caitir's own mouth, that there had been no purpose in it at all, only a man thinking of the mason with dust on his fingers.

There remained, after that telling, only the rainbow, *gual bogha-froise*⁴, the coal that held every colour the eye could give a name to and had answered, in all the four thousand years since the grove, to none of them; and it was this coal, and not gual teine's own waking, that the household at Tobar dhìreach turned its mind to in the years that followed, for a man does not sit easy with one question answered while a second sits unanswered in the same bag on the same peg. Seathan, for his own part, said more than once at his own hearth that he had come to doubt any single manner of asking would serve the rainbow as it had served none of the rest by the same means twice; the sea had taken the gold, the height the snowflake, the earth the black, a man's blood the red-brown, the river the silver, and his own idle hand the sixth, and no two of those six had come by the same road, so that a man hoping to wake the seventh by copying any one of them was, to his mind, hoping against the very pattern the other six had already shown him.

2. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

3. the fire coal, of fire

4. the rainbow coal, of spirit

He carried it to the northern shore himself, in the second year after his own coal's waking, more out of the old custom that every keeper before him had kept than from any real expectation in it, and threw it into the same grey swell his forebears had thrown coals into for generation on generation, and waded in after it in the falling light to find it exactly as dark and salt-wet as it had gone in. He carried it, the following year, down to the crossing below the house where the silver still burned under the current as it had burned since Eòghann's day, a pale fire any traveller might kneel at the bank to see, and held the rainbow a long while over the water without throwing it at all, reasoning that if the river had already taken one coal it might, given the chance, take a second without the trial of a throw; and when nothing in the water's own light or sound gave him any sign that it meant to answer, he threw it in as he had thrown gual teine's dust into nothing, and fished it out again some way downstream the next morning, cold and ordinary among the wet stones. Caitir went with him on both of those journeys, the recital says, the only keeper's wife of the line remembered to have gone rather than stayed by Poit an Teine⁵ at home, and it was she, by her own later telling to her daughters, who first said aloud what afterward became a saying among Clann na Ceiste⁶, that the rainbow held every spirit and so belonged wholly to none of them, and might in the end be a coal no single element would ever claim for its own, whatever the line went on doing with it.

I V

Of Seathan's Death and What Was Left

Seathan kept the bag some fifty years in all, from his father's death to his own, and in that whole span only gual teine¹ answered him, and it answered him, as he never tired of telling it, on an evening when he had gone looking for nothing at all. He grew old at Tobar dhìreach in much the way his own father had grown old before him, the household about him thickening with grandchildren as his own children married into neighbouring hearths and brought husbands and wives back to sit at his fire, and he told Aithris a' Chruthachaidh² to each new face that came into that circle as he had told it to his

5. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

6. the Children of the Question

1. the fire coal, of fire

own children, word for word as his father had given it to him, the smoke that stood still in the gale and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich³ of the three spirits and the six lightings that had gone before his own; and he told, along with it now, the seventh telling that was his to give and no other man's, of the dust on his fingers and the snap and the light that had shown his own wife his face from below in a doorway at dusk.

He died in his three-and-seventieth year, at his own hearth, with Poit an Teine⁴ burning near him as it had burned near every keeper of the line before him back to Conall who first kept the vein alight; and Caitir, who was with him at the end, said afterward that his last clear words left the rainbow alone, though it had beaten him as it had beaten every keeper before him, and asked instead for gual teine, that she bring it to him from its place in the bag so that he might hold it once more in his own hand while there was still warmth in that hand to hold it with. She brought it to him, and he held it a while, saying nothing further that she could afterward make out, and was found at first light with it still closed in his fingers, cold as it had always been cold, though the hand that held it had by then gone cold as well.

The bag passed from his grave to his eldest son, a quiet man who had never expected, by his own account, to be given so great a charge while his father's hand was still warm; and Caitir stayed on at Tobar dhìreach some six years further, keeping Poit an Teine fed as she had kept it fed through the whole of her marriage, and telling, to whoever asked her at her own hearth, the same plain telling of the doorstone that Seathan had told at the recital, growing no fonder of the dressed-up versions that had gone about the valley than she had been the first year she heard them. She tried the rainbow herself once more in that time, at the river below the house, more for the comfort of doing something with it than from any hope she troubled to name, and it lay in her palm afterward as dark and unmoved as it had lain in Seathan's, and she put it back in the bag without any great disappointment in her face, by the account of those who were there, for she had long since ceased, she said, to expect that coal to answer to a woman who only wished it well and asked for nothing in return.

She died in her three-and-seventieth year also, the same age her husband had reached before her, and was buried beside him near Leac na Fèithe⁵, and the bag

2. the Telling of the Making

3. the Keeper's riddle

4. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

by then held only the rainbow, one coal against the six that had gone before it, in a leather grown soft and dark with the handling of more generations than anyone could count since the mason first filled his tunic with it in the rain. The keeping passed on from her son's hearth in its turn, as it had passed from every keeper's hearth before, carrying the one coal still unanswered into years that Seathan and Caitir did not live to see; and the households of the high valleys, telling it over at their own fires in the winters that followed, said of gual teine what they had not troubled to say of any of the five before it, that it alone among the six already answered had asked of its keeper no long journey and no hard trial, only a tired man's idle hand on a warm evening, doing a small thing it had done ten thousand times without ever once, until that evening, being asked to answer for it.

5. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhireach

OF THE GATHERINGS AND THE ROWS OF THE DEAD

VE 4,951 – 5,169

I

Of the Crowd at the Column

The saying at Calbh Cnoc ghorm¹ had been a thing spoken to whoever stood near enough to hear it said, in the years after the column was first raised: a shepherd passing, a household come to leave an offering at the older stones nearby, a handful of children sent to fetch water from the spring below the hill who lingered to hear an old man say the words over because the words pleased them, whether or not the sense of them had yet come home. By the time Seathan's snap had been told a few winters over, that had stopped being true. Word of gual teine²'s waking in Seathan's hand had gone out from Tobar dhìreach faster and further than any telling before it, carried by kin visiting kin and by traders who had no kin in the matter at all but liked a good tale on the road, and it reached Achadh a' Chalbh³ already grown in the telling, so that some who heard it there believed the fire had come down a second time out of a clear sky rather than out of a tired man's own hand on his own doorstone. Whichever way they had heard it, they came to the column to hear the saying said properly, by someone who could be trusted to have it right, and they did not come one or two at a time any longer.

They came in tens, and then, on the nights the reciters chose for the telling, in what the households of Achadh a' Chalbh afterward judged to be some hun-

1. the column at Cnoc ghorm

dreds, walking in from every quarter of the hill country and camping about the stone for a night or two before they walked home again. No one had built anything at Calbh Cnoc ghorm before that; the column had stood alone on its rise with the grass growing up to its foot and nothing near it but the older markers that no one now living could say the meaning of. The first shelters went up in the year the crowd first overran the grass around the stone and trampled it to mud in a wet spring, low walls of turf and stone roofed with branches and hide, built by whoever had walked furthest and meant to stay the longest, and taken down again when the telling was over because no one yet thought of the column as a place a person lived. They were built again the next year the crowd came, on the same ground, because it was easier to raise a wall where a wall had stood before than to choose new ground and clear it; and within a lifetime there were shelters enough about the rise, rebuilt so many times over on the footings of the ones before them that a household coming for the first time could see, in the worn hollows and the packed earth between the walls, that other households had stood there before it and would stand there after.

The telling changed with the crowd, though no one who told it would have said they had changed anything. Where a single household's fire had once heard the recital from whichever elder of the line was nearest, the crowd at Achadh a' Chalbh wanted a voice that could be heard past the first ring of listeners, and got, in time, a manner of telling suited to it: slower, with a pause held after each father's name long enough for those at the back to catch it passed forward from mouth to mouth, and a way of standing on the rise above the column, with the crowd below it, that no single hearth had ever needed. Clann na Ceiste⁴ sent one of its own to Achadh a' Chalbh for the great tellings now, in the years after Seathan, a duty that fell in turn to whichever of the line could be spared from Tobar dhìreach and had the voice and the patience for it; the recital says only that it fell first to a nephew of Seathan's, a man the reciters keep among the names they do not give to strangers, and that he stood on the rise at the telling that named gual teine among the six already lit and told it, as Seathan had told it at his own hearth, without dressing the matter up beyond the bare truth of a man breaking coal-dust with his fingers on a warm evening.

He was a young man for the charge, by his own later account, and had stood the whole day before the telling watching the shelters fill and the cook-fires start

2. the fire coal, of fire

3. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

up across the trampled ground, sick with a fear that had nothing to do with the words themselves, which he had known since boyhood, and everything to do with the number of faces he would have to say them to. An old woman of Achadh a' Chalbh, who had walked to every telling at the column since she was a girl and meant, she said, to walk to this one though her knees no longer thanked her for it, found him sitting apart from the fires with his hands pressed together between his knees, and asked him plainly whether he meant to lose his supper before he had given the hill country its telling. He told her he had never spoken the recital to more than a household's worth of listeners in his life, and that Seathan's telling belonged, by rights, to Seathan's own kin at Seathan's own hearth, not to a hillside of strangers who would carry it home and change it in the carrying. She said, and the recital keeps her words as it keeps few from outside the line, that a story kept in one hearth was safe from changing and safe from nothing else, and that a story given to a hillside might come back altered in a hundred mouths but would not, this way, die in the one mouth that first held it. He stood on the rise the next evening and gave the telling, and did not lose his supper, and the crowd, by every account that came down from it, wept a little at that telling as the old women of the line had wept at Tobar dhìreach, and went home in the days after and told it themselves at their own hearths with such changes, large and small, as every telling gathers in the mouths of those who were not there to hear it first.

By the middle years of that century the gathering at Achadh a' Chalbh had become, without anyone deciding that it should, a thing the hill country reckoned its year by nearly as much as it reckoned by the seasons: a night when households that never otherwise met walked toward the same rise from every quarter of the country, slept a night or two in walls that had stood, in one shape or another, longer than any one of them could remember building them, and heard a name spoken that every hearth in the hill country now knew before it left home. Some among the older households said the column had grown too crowded for its own good, and that a saying was worn thin by so much handling; more said nothing against it at all, and came again the next time it was told, and brought their children so that the children too could say they had stood under the stone and heard it.

II

Of the Rainbow Passed Hand to Hand

In one of those years, at the great telling at the column, the keeper of the bag who had come down from Tobar dhìreach to say the Line did a thing no keeper had done before him at any gathering: when the fathers had been named and the six lightings told, and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹ said, he untied the thong of the bag and took out gual bogha-froise² and gave it into the hand of the woman standing nearest him in the front of the crowd, and told her to look at it and pass it on.

He had not told anyone at Tobar dhìreach that he meant to. He said afterward that he had not known he meant to until the coal was in his hand, and that it had come to him, standing on the rise over so many faces, that the coal had been kept in a bag on a peg in one house for longer than anyone could count, and tried by the hands of that house and no other, and that there were hundreds of hands on that hillside that had never touched it, and that it did not seem to him a thing any keeper could be sure of, that the coal would not answer some hand that had never been let hold it.

So it went round. It went from the woman in the front to her husband and from him to a boy beside him, and on through the crowd in the dark by the light of the fires, hand to hand, each person holding it a little while and turning it so that the firelight ran the colours across its face, gold and green and a blue that no sky wore, and passing it on. Some held it a long while and some hardly a breath. Some said something over it, low, and some said nothing. An old man who had walked four days to be there held it against his forehead with his eyes shut, and would not say afterward what he had asked of it. A girl of five, lifted up by her father to take it, put it in her mouth before anyone could stop her, and took it out again, and said it tasted of nothing, and was laughed at, not unkindly, by everyone near enough to hear.

It took the better part of the night to go round the whole crowd. The keeper stood on the rise the whole while and did not sit down, watching for it in the dark, following it from fire to fire by the stir it made where it passed; and near dawn it came back to him, carried up the rise by the same woman who had first taken it, who had gone round the crowd behind it to see that it was not lost. He

1. the Keeper's riddle

2. the rainbow coal, of spirit

took it from her and looked at it. It was as dark as it had been when he untied the thong, and as cold.

He put it back in the bag. He said, when he stood to speak again in the grey light, that the coal had been held that night by more hands than had held it in all the years since the mason, and had answered none of them, and that he did not know whether to be sorry for it or glad; for it seemed to him that a coal which would not answer to a whole hillside of hands asking it together, each in its own way, was not a coal that wanted asking at all, in the way the line had always asked, but something else, which he could not name. The crowd went home in the morning and told it at their own hearths, how they had held the seventh coal in their own hands and it had done nothing; and it was told for a long while after, by those who had been there, as the one night of their lives on which they had held the mason's vein, and it did not seem to any of them, telling it, that the coal's silence made the holding any less.

III

Of the Burial Ground No One Had Made

Two days' walk and more to the south-east of the column, near the southern shore, on rising ground above a burial hill the hill country called Tuam Cnoc dhìreach¹, the dead of that country had for longer than any telling could account for been laid in the ground without ceremony that any teller thought worth keeping. No one living could say who had first chosen that hill over any other for the purpose, or why; the graves nearest the crown of it were older than the oldest names that could still be read there, and no name at all could be read there, for no hand on the island yet cut a name into stone for the dead any more than it cut one for the living. The thorn grew thick over the older mounds, and the households nearest the hill let it grow, holding that ground once given to the dead was not ground to be cleared again for any other use, though none of them could have said which ancestor had first laid down that rule, or whether it had ever been laid down in words at all rather than simply done, once, by someone whose reasons died with him, and kept ever after because no one saw cause to do otherwise.

1. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

The dead of the hill country went into that ground in the plainest way the households knew: wrapped in a cloak or a hide, laid on their side with the knees drawn up as though asleep, and covered over without marker or word beyond whatever was said at the graveside by whoever had loved them, which the reciters at Achadh a' Chalbh² never kept and never claimed to keep, holding that a hearth's own grief belonged to the hearth and not to the column's telling. A few of the dead went into the ground with something of their own beside them, a knife worn smooth with handling, a comb, a string of shells from the western shore that had come to the hill country by trade a generation back and further; most went with nothing at all but the cloak they were wrapped in, for the hill country did not hold, as a rule, that the dead had need of what the living still had use for.

It was into this ground, some six score years after Seathan's snap, that a household from a hearth two valleys from Tuam Cnoc dhìreach carried a child too small to have been given more than a season's worth of a name among its own kin, and laid it in a grave dug at the western edge of the ground where the older mounds gave out into open turf.

IV

Of Aoife's Child

Aoife had been married four years to a man of that hearth when the child was born, her first living child after two that had not lived past their first winter, and she had carried this one, by her own later telling of it, with a fear she had not let herself speak aloud to her husband or to her own mother, having buried enough already that she had stopped trusting a full nine months to mean what it seemed to mean. The child lived through its birth and through the first hard days after it, and lived through its first winter besides, thin and quiet but breathing steadily enough that Aoife's mother, who had raised six of her own and buried three, said at the turn of the year that this one, at least, she judged would live to walk. Aoife let herself believe it that winter, for the first time since the first of the two she had already lost, and she sewed, in the last of the cold months, a small coat cut to the child's own growing rather than handed down

2. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

from an older cousin as its clothes had been until then, a thing she had not let herself do for either of the children before it.

It did not live to walk. The child sickened in the spring, in the way small children of that country sickened and sometimes did not recover from, without anyone being able to say afterward what the sickness had been or why it had taken this child and spared another, two houses along the same valley, that had shown the same fever in the same week; and it died in Aoife's own arms on a morning near the end of that spring, quietly, without the crying-out that had marked the deaths of the two before it, so that she said afterward she had known, before she was willing to know it, that this death was not going to be like the others.

She kept, from the leather pouch her own grandmother had left her, a sliver of an *gual dathach*¹ no larger than a fingernail, black-veined and streaked through with the same gold and white and red-brown a hundred hearths in the hill country kept a piece of by then, broken long ago from some larger fragment traded down from household to household until no one troubled any longer to ask which of the seven colours it belonged to or whether it belonged to any. She had kept it as a child keeps a bright stone, without much thought of what it was, turning it over on quiet evenings the way every household with such a piece turned its own over; and on the morning the child died she took it from the pouch, without asking her husband and without, by her own account, quite deciding to do it in any way she could afterward explain, and closed it into the small cold hand before the wrapping was done, so that it went into the ground with the child rather than staying in her own keeping.

Her husband's mother said, when she heard of it, that a hearth ought not to give away a piece of an *gual dathach* to the dead when the living still had use for it, and there were words between the two households over the matter that neither side afterward cared to keep in the telling. Aoife did not take the sliver back, and would not be moved to, saying only, when she was pressed on it, that the child had held nothing else of its own in the whole short span of its life, no toy worn to its shape by its own hand, no coat cut to its own growing but the one small coat she had sewn it that last winter and that had gone into the ground with it besides, and that she would not begrudge it the one small dark thing that had been, for the little while it lived, given wholly to it and taken back from no one. The household buried the child at the western edge of *Tuam Cnoc dhìreach*² with the sliver

1. the coloured coal

2. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

closed in its hand as she had closed it, and those who lowered it into the ground saw, before the last of the cloth was drawn over, a dark stain already spreading through the wrapping the shape and size of a small closed fist, though what had stained it, the coal or the child's own body or the two together, none of those standing at the grave could rightly say.

No other grave in all that ground, before that spring or after it through the whole span the recital covers, is remembered to have held any piece of the vein. Aoife's own mother said, in the years that followed, that she doubted any other household in that country could have done what Aoife did even if it had wished to, for want of a piece to give rather than want of the grief to give it with; An gual dathach had by then gone thin in its scattering, worn down and lost and handed on so many times over since the mason first filled his tunic with it that whole valleys held none of it at all, and a household that had kept even a sliver this long, and had not already burned it or lost it or traded it away, was rarer by that century than it had been in Colla's day. Aoife kept nothing else of the coal after that morning. She had given the one piece her house still held, and did not, so far as the telling knows, ever trouble to ask after another.

She went back, in the years after, to the western edge of Tuam Cnoc dhíreach more often than her husband's kin thought a woman ought to trouble herself with a grave already closed and grieved, walking the day's distance alone when she could spare it and sitting a while by the small mound with nothing in her hands, and she said, to the one or two who ever asked her outright what she went there to do, that she went to see whether the turf had settled evenly and to pull the thorn back before it could reach the child, which was, by that country's own reckoning, no more than any mother owed a grave, however far the walking. It was on one of these walks, in a year the recital does not trouble to fix, that she first noticed the new graves beginning to keep to a line along the western edge where before they had been scattered as the ground allowed, and remarked on it to no one, having by then grown used to watching that particular stretch of turf more closely than most.

V

Of the Rows That Bent

The graves at Tuam Cnoc dhíreach¹ had for longer than living memory been laid without much order beyond the plain custom of the ground: a family buried its dead near its own earlier dead where it could, and elsewhere where it could not, and no one had troubled to lay one grave square with another by any rule a stranger walking the hill could have named. That began, in the years after Aoife's child was buried at the western edge, to change in a way no single household could claim to have started and every household, once it was pointed out to them, admitted they had somehow fallen into. The newer graves, dug further out from the old crowded crown of the hill where the thorn grew thickest, began to be set in something like a line, each new grave a body's length from the last and facing the same way, heads toward the great mountains that stood blue and unreachable on the northern skyline from every part of that ground; and the line, once two or three graves had been laid to it, drew the next grave to itself the way a worn path draws the next foot that crosses that ground, until a household bringing its dead to Tuam Cnoc dhíreach a score of years after looked for the row before it looked for empty turf, and laid its own dead into the row's own line without being told to.

The rows held straight where the ground let them. Where an older grave stood in a row's path, a low unmarked swelling in the turf that no one now could put a name to but that every household knew, by long custom, not to open or to build across, the new row bent around it rather than through it, and straightened again on the far side, so that a stranger walking the ground while the thorn still allowed the rows to be seen whole could read in the bending of them the shape of every old grave that the newer dead had been laid to honour without a name to honour it by. The bending was not planned by anyone; the recital is plain on that, and every household questioned afterward agreed on it. A grave was dug in the row where the row ran, and if an old swelling stood in the row's way the diggers went round it because no one among them, not the most impious of the young men who sometimes grumbled at the extra work of the going-round, would put a spade to ground that had held a body long enough for its memory to have gone out of the world entirely. One young man of a hearth near the hill, digging his own grandfather's grave in those years and finding an old swelling square in the line he had meant to keep, said aloud to the two kinsmen working beside him that they might as well level the thing and be done with the awkward turning it cost

1. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhíreach

them; and his uncle, who had dug more graves at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach than any other man then living, put down his own spade and told him plainly that a man who could not say whose grave he opened had no business opening it, grandfather's grave or no, and that the going-round cost an afternoon's awkward digging and no more, against a debt to some stranger's bones that no living man could reckon in years and had therefore no business trying to pay off with a spade. The young man dug the grave round the swelling, as every grave before his had gone round it, and did not raise the question again.

The rows grew, year on year through that century, out from the crowded crown of the hill toward the open turf at the edges where Aoife's child lay, each new row a little further out and a little more given to bending than the one before it, until the whole western face of Tuam Cnoc dhìreach showed, to anyone who stood back far enough to see the whole of it, no longer straight lines but a slow curved weaving, row folding round row folding round the swellings that no living hand had made and no living memory could explain.

Clann na Ceiste², through those same years, did not let the rainbow rest. The bag that had passed from Seathan's grave to his son passed down the line of fathers, and one of them, whose name the recital keeps from strangers, carried the one coal left in it, gual bogha-froise³, north to Doire ghlas, meaning to try it in the grove where Coimhdeach na Fine⁴ had first given Diarmad Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁵ and where no keeper of the line, so far as the recital knew, had thought before to bring it. He walked the whole way north on his own feet, a journey of three days from Tobar dhìreach by the tracks that then ran, telling those who asked him along the road only that he went to the grove because every other ground the line had tried had failed the coal and the grove alone, of all the places the recital named, had once answered a question with more than silence. He found the oaks much as the tellings described them, tall and old with the wind loud in their crowns, and he built a small fire in the lee of a fallen trunk much as Diarmad was said to have done, and sat with gual bogha-froise turning in his hand through the evening and on into the dark, watching the firelight run the colours across its face and waiting, by his own later account, for anything at all: a smoke that stood still, a voice, even a wind that blew wrong. Nothing came. He

2. the Children of the Question

3. the rainbow coal, of spirit

4. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

5. the Keeper's riddle

held the coal to the coals of his own small fire until the fire burned down around it, and it lay black and cold among the ash in the grey of the morning, no likelier to catch than it had been the evening before, and the grove gave him, in a whole night's waiting, nothing that any teller afterward thought worth calling an answer.

He carried it home again, and told, at the next great telling at Achadh a' Chalbh⁶, that the grove itself had answered him nothing, so that the crowd who had begun to hope, on hearing where he had gone, that Coimhdeach na Fine might speak again as it had spoken to Diarmad, went home disappointed of that hope along with every other. The line tried the coal again after him, at the sea and at the river and once, by one keeper's own idea, buried a night in the earth as the black coal had once been buried; and it answered none of them, through all the years the recital covers in this telling, any more than it had answered Seathan or Caitir before them.

Aoife lived on at her own hearth some forty years past her child's burial, raising two children born after it who lived to grow, and telling, to those of her own kin who asked her, the plain account of the sliver and the small stained cloth, growing no fonder with age of the versions that went about the valley with more grief dressed into them than her own telling ever gave it. She died in her seventieth year, and was carried to Tuam Cnoc dhìreach and laid in the row nearest the western edge where her child already lay, the row bending a little as it reached her grave to keep clear of the old swelling that had stood there, unnamed and unopened, since before either of them was born.

6. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

Of the Panther Roads

VE 5,170 – 5,299

I

Of the Cats That Kept Their Own Time

Beithir had herded on the high shoulders of the central mountains since he was a boy too small to carry a full crook, and he had never in all those years thought the great cats of the passes kept anything that could be called a custom, any more than the weather kept one, or the frost. They were there in the high country the way stone was there, a thing a herder learned to walk around rather than a thing that came and went by any order he could set his own days by. His own father had lost a ewe and a half-grown lamb to something on the high ground in a single bad summer of Beithir's childhood, and had said afterward only that the high pasture took its toll the way any pasture with a drop and a river and a hungry winter took its toll, naming no one thing above the rest as the cause of it. It was in the twenty-second year of a life spent among those shoulders, in a winter cold enough that the sheep's breath hung about them like a second, whiter fleece, that he first let himself believe otherwise.

He had gone up past the last shieling with two dogs and no company to look for three ewes that had wandered from the flock in the days before, and he found, in a saddle of ground between two peaks where the snow lay unbroken from one week's end to the next, a line of prints going through it that were not sheep and not deer and not his own dogs: broad, round-toed, sunk deep, spaced in the long easy stride of something that had not been hurrying and had not needed to. He had seen such prints before, singly, here and there over the years, and thought no more of them than a man thinks of a single crow. What stopped him now was

that the line ran straight, from the saddle's western lip to its eastern one, as though the ground between held nothing to turn a beast aside for, and that when he cast about he found the same line, worn a little into the frozen turf as though feet before these had gone the same way, running on both sides of the saddle as far as the fall of the ground let him see it.

He did not find his ewes that day, and did not go looking for them the day after either, for the same track, followed a short way east with the dogs close at his heel and their hackles up the whole time, brought him within scent, though not within sight, of what had made it: a smell low and rank on the wind that put both dogs flat to the ground with their ears back before he had done more than take three steps past the last drift. A long while he crouched at that distance with his hand on the older dog's neck, more to still his own breathing than the animal's, and saw nothing move against the white of the slope above him, though the smell came and thinned and came again on the wind as if whatever carried it were pacing rather than standing still. Turning home without argument, he told what he had seen and smelled to the oldest man of his own hearth, who heard him out over the evening fire without any great surprise in his face, and said only that his own father had told him the same of that same saddle, in a different year, and that his father's father was said to have told it before him: that the great cats of the mountains did not wander the high ground at every season as a man might wander it, but crossed it, at some times of year and not at others, along lines they seemed to hold in the same regard a shepherd held a path.

No one in that country could have said, that year or for long after it, what set the times the cats kept, only that they were kept; that the same saddle, and others like it further along the spine of the mountains, lay empty of that smell and that track through most of the year and thick with both at two turns of it, once when the year climbed toward its warmest and once when it fell back toward its coldest, and that a household with beasts on the high pasture in those weeks did well to bring them down before the smell came, and ill to leave them up after it had. Beithir lived to be an old man himself, and told the saddle's prints to his own sons and their sons after him, and by the time he died the households of that country had begun to reckon those two turns of the year as surely as they reckoned the salmon run below or the geese going over, without any one of them being able to say, any more than his own father's father had been able to say, why the cats kept the roads they kept, or what walked them, or where.

II

Of the Signs on the Gateposts, and the Thirty Head

The custom that grew up around the cats' crossing was not decided in any one place or by any one household, any of those who kept it agreed, when they were asked; it grew the way the rows at a burial ground grow, each household falling into the shape the households before it had already worn into the ground. Within a lifetime it had a shape plain enough that a stranger walking from one valley to the next in the crossing weeks could read it on every gatepost he passed without being told what it meant: a mark cut fresh into the wood at the turn when the smell and the track first came back to the high saddles, and scraped away again, flat and pale against the weathered grain around it, at the turn when both were gone.

It was not, so far as any teller of that country ever claimed, a mark that spoke to the cats themselves, or asked anything of them, or warded anything off; it spoke to the household's own kin and to whatever traveller might pass the gate in those weeks, saying plainly that the high ground behind this post was closed for the season, in the same way a low branch bent across a path said that the ground beyond it belonged, for the time being, to something better left alone. A woman new-married into a hearth on the eastern side of the mountains, coming from a valley too far south to lie under the cats' road at all, asked her husband's mother, the first crossing season she kept there, why the mark was cut so deep it scarred the post rather than simply chalked or tied on with a strip of hide as she had seen other warnings given in her own country; and the old woman told her that a mark meant to be scraped off again wanted cutting deep enough to still be read in the scraping, so that a household coming late to a gate already marked and already half cleared would know, from the pale scar under the fresh growth of weather, that the season had been kept there before and would be kept there again, whether or not the wood itself still carried the cut.

The camps in the high passes emptied with the same regularity the gateposts marked. Shielings that stood full through the warmer half of every year, herders and their dogs and their fires among them from the last frost to the first, stood bare through the two turns the cats kept, walls standing, hearths cold, the paths worn to them by summer's traffic left to close over with grass the herders themselves had trampled flat only weeks before. A boy sent up in error one crossing season, his own father having lost the count of days in a wet spell that blurred one

week into the next, found the shieling he was to have wintered sheep at already stripped and shuttered by households further along who had read the signs aright, and came down again the same evening with nothing worse to show for the mistake than a scolding and a night's walk wasted, which the country afterward told as the mildest lesson the crossing season ever gave anyone, set against what it gave others.

Not every household held by the custom with the same care, and the country did not let the ones who broke it forget what it had cost them. Some years after, a man of the lower slopes, whose grazing ran further up into the passes than most and whose herd had grown large enough that the high pasture's extra weeks of grass had come to matter more to him than it had to smaller households, judged that the crossing that year had come early enough in its own turning that he could risk another ten days on the height before he brought his cattle down, the gateposts of his neighbours already scraped and closed while his own stood freshly cut and, in his own reckoning, cut too soon. His wife had asked him, the evening before, why he trusted his own count of the year over the marks his neighbours had already made of theirs, and he had told her that a man who grazed that ground summer on summer knew its temper better than any post cut by a household two valleys off, and that ten days of good grass was ten days he did not mean to give away for nothing.

He was not a fool by any account the country kept of him afterward, only a man who trusted his own eye over the mark on another man's post, and who had grazed that same high ground long enough without incident that the custom had come, in his own mind, to look more like caution than like law. He brought the cattle down himself on the tenth night, later than any neighbour would have risked it, driving them by torchlight down a track he could have walked with his eyes shut, and found in the morning that thirty head of the herd he had driven up whole had not come down with the rest, scattered wide of the track in the dark and never called back to it, though the drovers with him swore they had heard nothing in the night beyond the ordinary complaint of beasts unsettled by a strange path in the dark. What they found, searching the ground above the track by daylight two days after, when the smell that had kept them from searching sooner had at last thinned enough to risk it, the recital does not dwell on past the bare count: thirty head, and not one whole carcass among them worth the skinning, the ground about them torn in a way no wolf of that country tore ground.

He kept cattle after that, and grazed the lower slopes as every prudent household of that country grazed them, but he never again cut a gatepost sign later than his neighbours, and the tale of his thirty head was told at hearths a long way from his own for longer than his own name was, so that by the time Cairbre was a grown man on the southern shore, a full week's walk and more from the slopes where it had happened, the count of thirty head lost in a single crossing season was a thing every household along that coast could recite though few of them could have said whose herd it had first been lost from, or in which of the mountains' many high passes it had happened.

III

Of the Cats That Turned Back

It was given, among the tellings the country kept of the crossing season, that the cats themselves might be read for a sign, though no one professed to know what mind, if any, lay behind what they were seen to do. In a later year, in a crossing that had begun ordinarily enough, with the smell coming up to the high saddles at the turn it always came and every gatepost along that stretch of the mountains cut fresh in its own week, a family watching from a rise above the track by daylight, at a safe remove and for no better reason than that the rise gave the clearest view of weather coming in from the west, saw the line of beasts that had begun crossing toward the eastern passes turn, without any cause the watchers could see, and go back the way they had come, down off the road and away toward the foothills on the western side, where by every account that country kept, the cats did not commonly linger once the crossing season had called them onto the high ground at all.

The family that saw it told it plainly, without dressing the matter in more meaning than the bare sight gave it: that the beasts had turned, that they had gone down rather than on, and that no one among the watchers could say why, since nothing in the weather or the ground that day looked to a human eye any different from a hundred crossings before it that had gone through to their own end without a turning. It was the households further along that stretch of country, hearing the telling in the weeks after, who first said aloud what the family who had seen it had been careful not to say themselves: that a sign so plain, and so far outside anything the crossing season had shown before, ought to be answered

rather than merely watched, and that a hard winter was coming on the strength of it whether or not the turning cats had meant to say so.

They stored double that autumn against a want that had not yet shown itself in any other sign, peat cut and stacked higher than any household along that stretch had troubled to stack it in living memory, grain and dried meat laid by past what the ordinary count of mouths at each hearth called for. Households further off, who had the turning only at second hand and no rise of their own to have watched it from, stored single as they always had, and some among them said afterward, when word of the hard winter reached them too, that they envied their neighbours nothing so much as a rise with a clear view west and a family willing to trust their own eyes over an unbroken habit. The winter that came on after that autumn proved, by the time it broke, hard enough that snow lay to a grown man's waist in drifts along the lower valleys for the better part of two months, and every household that had stored against it said afterward it had been worth the extra cutting and the extra carrying, and not one of them claimed to know any better than before why the cats had turned, only that they had turned, and that the winter had come as if in answer.

IV

Of Cairbre and the Eleven

Cairbre was thirty-two years old, and had led men of his own hearth on lesser errands into the foothills often enough that no one on the southern shore thought twice about it when he said, one autumn, that he meant to take ten with him up past the last of the low pastures to bring back a household of kin that had settled two valleys further in than any of the shore's own people commonly went, and whose harvest that year, word had come down, had failed badly enough that they would not see the winter through unhelped. His wife stood at the edge of Teallaichean a' Chladaich¹ the morning the eleven set out, with their own two children at her skirts, and asked him only how many days he judged it, so that she would know when to begin watching the track for them; he told her twelve at the most, ten men's worth of harvest to carry down and no cause in the world to linger once it was loaded, and kissed her once before he took

1. the hearths of the shore; the southern-shore households from which the eleven went up (place 1006)

the path inland with the others behind him in single file, each carrying less on the way up than he meant to carry on the way down.

It was not, by his own reckoning and by the reckoning of every man who went with him, a crossing-season errand. The geese of the coast below Teallaichean a' Chladaich had not yet gone over in their numbers that autumn, and the shore held, as it had always held, that the geese going over marked the turn of the year toward the cold reliably enough to set a household's own calendar by; and the geese, that particular autumn, held later on the southern water than any of the eleven men setting out could remember them holding in their own lifetimes. Cairbre had said as much himself, the evening before, to an old man of the shore who asked him only in passing whether he had thought to reckon the mountain's own time against the coast's, and not against the season the geese were keeping that year down on the water; Cairbre answered, not unkindly, that the geese were the surest clock the shore had ever kept faith with, and that he saw no cause to trust a stranger's gatepost over a sign his own household had watched every year of his life.

They went up in good order, by the account the search that followed them later pieced together from what could be read of their camp-sites and their fire-scars along the way, keeping to the lower ground as long as the lower ground offered a path and climbing only where the valley they followed narrowed and left them no choice but the higher slopes. Cairbre had grazed no cattle in the high passes himself and knew the gatepost signs of that country only as a traveller knows another country's customs, by report rather than by his own hand on the wood; he read, at the last hearth before the true height, a post scraped bare of any mark at all, which he took, as any stranger reading it without a local tongue to ask, for a plain word that the season the mark was cut against had already come and gone. What the bare post did not tell him, because no post along that whole stretch of mountain was cut to tell it, was that the scraping that year had come early, the household who kept that gate having read the geese's own lateness as the country's other households read it, and judged, wrongly as it turned out, that a season slow to come would also be slow to hold, and cleared their post a full ten days before the smell that should have kept it standing came back up to the saddle above them.

Cairbre and the ten who went with him climbed into ground that the crossing had, in fact, already claimed for that turning of the year, reading the empty shielings and the bare posts around them as leave to go on rather than as the same

closed season written in a hand they had not learned to read. They did not come down again. No household of that country, questioned afterward by the searchers who came up from the shore once the errand's length began to trouble those left behind, could say they had seen the eleven pass, or heard anything in the high ground in the nights the errand must have crossed it beyond what every household in the crossing season heard and had long since stopped remarking on. The kin two valleys in, whom Cairbre had set out to help, waited through that autumn and into the winter for a party that never reached them, and came themselves in the spring down to the shore to ask after men they had begun, by then, to fear they would never see arrive.

Cairbre's wife kept the twelfth day and the thirteenth and the fourteenth without word, and told herself, as any wife of that shore would have told herself, that a household two valleys in might have kept the eleven a few extra days over some kindness owed for the carrying, or that the track down was slower loaded than the track up had been empty. She watched the path from the same rise she had stood on to see them go, morning and evening, through a fifteenth day and a twentieth, and by the thirtieth day had stopped telling herself anything at all, and only watched. No household along that shore sent word up into the hills after them that autumn, for none of them knew, any more than Cairbre himself had known, which valley among several the eleven had meant to reach, or by which of several tracks; and winter closed the higher ground before any search could have been made of it in any case, so that the shore was left, through that whole first winter, with nothing to do but wait for a spring thaw that might, at least, let a search be tried.

The same year, at Tobar dhíreach, a son was born to the household that kept Poit an Teine² and the bag of coals, a big child from his first week who closed his hand round a finger held out to him and would not readily let it go, so that they said of him, as they would go on saying of him, that he had been born holding on. He was given the name Suibhne, and grew, in the years the shore still watched for word of Cairbre and found none, into a boy old enough to be sent with the herds and old enough, when Poit an Teine's keeping fell to him in his own turn, to hear the whole of the Line said over him standing, as every keeper before him had heard it. A search was tried in the spring after the eleven went missing, and again the spring after that, men of the shore and of the two valleys both walking the

2. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

ground the errand should have crossed as far as the season allowed them, and both times came down again with nothing to show for the walking but blistered feet and a country too wide, and too indifferent to a searcher's want of answers, to give up eleven men for the asking.

V

Of the Bones Along the Road

It was eighteen years before anyone found what had become of Cairbre and the ten who had gone with him, and it was chance, by every account, and not any renewed search, that found it at last: a household driving cattle down off the high pasture at the proper close of the crossing season some eighteen years after, keeping well within the marked track as every household of that country had always kept it, came on a scatter of bone some way off the track itself, where the ground fell steeply enough on one side that a man losing his footing in the dark might easily have gone down it without meaning to. The drover who found the first of it took it at a glance for a deer's remains, weathered white and half sunk into the turf, and might have driven on and thought no more of it had one of his own dogs not worried a length of it out of the ground with a fixed intent no deer-bone had ever raised in the animal before, and set it down at his feet whole and unmistakable for what it was.

They found more, over the days that followed, spread wider than any one fall could account for, some of it gathered close in twos and threes as though the men it had belonged to had stood together at the end and some of it strung out along a line that ran, when the whole of it was at last laid out and looked at together, roughly the same course the cats themselves were known to keep between one saddle and the next. Nothing that had been carried with the eleven, no strap or blade or scrap of the harvest they had gone to fetch, was found among the bones or anywhere near them, so that the searchers who gathered them could not even say for certain, past the count of the bones themselves, that this had been the whole of the party and not some lesser part of it.

Nothing about the bones themselves said plainly what had killed the men they had been, and no one who found them claimed afterward to know for certain; the households of that country, hearing the tale carried down from the shore where word of it travelled fastest, said only what they had always said of that ground in

that season, that eleven men had gone up into it at the one time of year no one went up into it by choice, and that the road itself, whatever walked it, had not troubled to leave more of an answer than the bones gave. A young man from Tobar dhìreach, eighteen years old that year and newly given the keeping of his own household's fire though not yet the full charge of the Line, walked with the search that carried word of the find back down from the passes, and came home from it saying little, by the account of those who knew him, beyond the plain fact of what had been found and where.

The southern shore buried what could be gathered of the eleven where they were found, high on the mountain's own ground rather than carried the long way home, for no household among them could say with any certainty which bones had belonged to which man, and it seemed to the country a lesser wrong to lay eleven men together where the road had taken them than to guess wrongly at dividing them among eleven separate graves. Cairbre's own name outlasted the rest in the telling, as a leader's name will outlast the men who followed him, but the shore kept, alongside it, the plainer fact the whole country had already made of the matter before his bones were ever found: that the cats' road asked to be read by its own signs and no other's, that a gatepost cut for one household's season could not be trusted by a stranger's eye, and that the crossing months, whatever walked them and for whatever reason, kept a count of their own that no household's calendar, however carefully watched, had yet learned to keep exactly with it.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

OF AILEAN SON OF SUIBHNE

VE 5,300 – 5,324

I

Of a Child Born Slow to Speak

Suibhne was a boy of eighteen, born the same year Cairbre and the ten who had gone with him into the hills in the crossing season failed to come home, when he walked with the search that at last found their bones strung out along the cats' road at wide distances, as if the men had scattered from one another at the end rather than kept together. He carried nothing of the vein with him on that walk; there was no custom of it, and none of the households along the road had ever heard that fire of any kind would serve against what kept that road at that season. He came home from it saying little, by the account of those who knew him, and it was some years after, in his own house at Tobar dhìreach with a wife new to the keeping, that his son was born.

Ailean was a big child from the first week, heavier in the arm and the leg than any infant the women who helped at his birth could readily match against their own memory, and slow to close his hand round a finger held out to him and slower again to let it go once he had closed it, so that his mother said of him, half in complaint and half in something nearer pride, that he had been born holding on. He was slow with words as he grew, keeping to single ones while children a season younger than him at the neighbouring hearths were already stringing sentences, and there were those among his own kin who wondered aloud, in the way kin will wonder aloud over a child too young to answer for himself, whether the

line had at last thrown up a son too plain to be trusted with the keeping; his mother put a stop to that talk wherever she heard it, saying that a slow tongue was no mark against a steady hand, and pointing to his hands themselves, broad already at six years old and thickening year on year after, as proof enough of what sort of man he would be.

He had, from as early as anyone could afterward call to mind, an interest in *Poit an Teine*¹ that went beyond a child's ordinary fascination with flame. Other children of that hearth had been drawn to the coloured pieces in the leather bag as toys, turning them over for their colours and their smoothness and losing interest once the colours proved to give nothing back to the hand; *Ailean*, from the age he could sit upright unsupported, would be found by the pot for whole mornings together, not reaching for it or troubling it, only sitting near enough to feel what heat came off it, watching the low steady flame the line had kept without a break since the mason first carried it home under his cloak. His father found him there so often that he came in time to leave the boy be, saying to his own wife that a child could do worse than keep company with the one thing in the house that had outlasted every one of their forefathers, and that if the boy meant to sit and stare at it until the staring had taught him some sense, there was no harm and might be some good in letting him.

He grew into a young man built along the same broad lines as the child had promised, tall by the reckoning of the high valleys and heavier through the shoulder than his father, with hands that the old women of the household said, more than once and not always meaning it kindly, were the mason's own hands come round again after five thousand years, hands shaped for a wedge and a maul rather than for the small close work the keeping of the coals more often asked. His speech never fully caught the pace of other men's; he answered slowly, and thought visibly before he did it, so that strangers meeting him at the recital sometimes took his slowness for dullness and were corrected only once they had put a question to him worth a real answer, for what he gave back, when he gave it, was seldom the thing a quicker man would have said first. Among his own kin this was known well enough not to need remark, and the reciters who taught him *Sloinneadh a' Chlachair*² found him no slower a pupil for it than any other, only one who wanted the words said over more times before he would trust himself to say them back whole.

1. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

2. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

II

Of the Rainbow That Would Not Light

Suibhne kept the bag of two coals from his own father's death, a fire coal grown ordinary through generations of handling since Seathan's day and a rainbow no keeper between Seathan's household and his own had ever once coaxed into flame; and he kept, as every keeper before him had kept, the custom of trying it, some years with more hope in the trying than others. He was not, by nature, a man given to running after a thing that had already refused him a dozen times, and there were long stretches in his own keeping, a decade together on occasion, when the rainbow sat untouched in the bag while he gave his mind to the herds and the hearth and the long slow business of a household growing round him; but the recital came once a year, and every year at the recital the reciters gave the tellings of the six lightings in their order, and every year, hearing his own forefathers named one after another, Suibhne felt the old itch return to try the seventh again himself before the next telling came round.

The height he tried first, in the second year of his keeping, climbing to Binnéan a' Chlachair¹ in a morning wind that near took him off the summit and dropping the rainbow from the height of his own arm over the same steep side Fearghas had dropped the snowflake from, watching it fall the whole way to the stones below without so much as a flicker in it. The river he tried the year after, kneeling at the same crossing Eòghann had knelt at, and threw it into the current where the silver still burned beneath the water in its low steady flame, so that for a breath the rainbow lay beside a coal that was already alight, dark against bright, before the current carried it on downstream to be fished out cold some way below the house. The sea he tried once, on a hard grey autumn when the household could spare him a week for the walk, wading to his knees in water cold enough to numb the foot and throwing it out past where the gold was said to have taken fire on the swell in Aodh's day, and watched it sink without a mark on it the same as every coal before it that had not been the gold.

He tried the earth twice in different years, once digging a hole no deeper than a man's knee and once, in the year he judged himself old enough to know better and dug it anyway, a hole as deep as the grave Brian had dug for the black coal near two and a half thousand years before, laying the rainbow in it and covering it

1. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

over and going back for it the following dawn to find it cold as the clay around it had been cold. By blood he would not try it; that trial he left alone all his life, saying to his own wife once, in a rare unguarded moment by the fire, that a man ought not go looking to open his own hand for a coal that had already shown him six times over that it wanted no single element and no single hurt, and that he had no wish to carry a scar for nothing the way Cormac had carried his for good cause. The small idle way that had served *gual teine*² he never once thought to try, for that way, by its nature, could not be gone looking for; a man does not set out with a purpose to stumble on a thing by accident, and *Suibhne*, trying the rainbow at all, was always trying it with a purpose, which was, though he never said so in these words, half the reason it never answered him.

He was four-and-forty years old, going grey at the temple and thicker through the middle than the man who had climbed *Binnean a' Chlachair* in his youth, when he took the rainbow north to *Doire ghlas* for the first and only time in his life, walking the three days alone with the coal wrapped in a fold of cloth inside his shirt against his chest, reasoning, as his son would reason after him though by a longer road, that the place where *Coimhdeach na Fine*³ had first spoken might hold some virtue the shore and the height and the river did not. No fire did he build in the grove, having nothing to ask that a fire would serve to ask it with; he only sat under the oaks a night and a day with the coal held loose in his open palm, watching it for any change of colour or warmth that his own eyes might have missed a hundred times before in duller light, and saw none, and walked home again three days further with it cold in the same fold of cloth it had travelled north in.

He told the household, on his return, that he did not think the rainbow meant to answer to him, and that he did not know, past a certain point, whether a man ought to go on asking a question that had by then been asked in every way a man's own life could think to ask it. He said this at his own hearth and not at the recital, for he had never been a man to trouble a crowd with his own private failures, and it was among the last things of any length that *Ailean*, then sixteen years old and sitting near *Poit an Teine*⁴ as he had sat by it since infancy, ever heard his father say on the matter. *Suibhne* died two years after, in his forty-sixth year, of a fever that came on him hard in a wet spring and took him inside a fortnight,

2. the fire coal, of fire

3. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

4. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

quick enough that there was no long dying to make a telling of; Ailean, eighteen years old and already the broadest man at that hearth though not yet its keeper by any word said over him, sat with his father through the worst of the last nights and heard nothing from him about the rainbow at all, only the ordinary things a dying man says to a son he trusts to carry on the herd and the house without him.

III

Of Lìobhan and the Thought That Came

A ilean had married the year before his father died, taking Lìobhan of a household two valleys west that kept no coal of its own and had never, by her own telling, expected to marry into a keeping at all; she had known him three summers at the recital before either of them said anything of marriage, drawn, as she told her own daughter, less by his slow careful speech than by the way he sat with animals and small children alike, as a man sits who has never once in his life needed to raise his voice to be minded. She came to Tobar dhìreach a bride of fifteen, young even by the valley's own reckoning, and found herself within the year keeping house at the hearth of Poit an Teine¹, learning from Suibhne's own widow, in the short time that remained to teach her, how the pot was fed and how the bag was kept and what was and was not said of its contents to a stranger at the door.

Their daughter was born the same year Suibhne died, in a wet autumn that the household afterward remembered chiefly for having buried one keeper and welcomed one child within the turn of a single season; they named her Gormshuil, for the colour of her eyes at birth, which Lìobhan's own mother swore had never once in all her years attending births looked so blue so soon. Ailean was eighteen that year, a father and, by his father's death, the keeper of the bag as well, though he did not think of himself in those words for some time after, going on much as he had gone on before, minding the herd and sitting his evenings by the pot with his daughter more often than not asleep against his shoulder.

He tried the rainbow himself, in the first years of his keeping, much as his father had tried it before him, though with less patience for the long solitary journeys his father had made of it; he threw it in the river once and dropped it from

1. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

the height once and dug it into the earth once, in each case finding it as cold afterward as his father had always found it, and came away from each trial a little more short with himself for having expected, however faintly, some different end to it than the end six generations of keepers before him had already reached. It was Liobhan, by her own account given years later to her own grandchildren, who first said aloud to him what he had by then half thought and not yet let himself say: that a coal made, by Coimhdeach na Fine²'s own telling, of every colour together might not be a coal that any single element, taken alone, would ever own as its own, any more than a man born of two households could be said to belong wholly to either one.

Ailean turned that thought over through the better part of a winter, by the fire and at the herding and on the long walks a shepherd takes alone with sheep for the only company, and it grew in him slowly, the way his own words had always grown in him slowly, until it had settled into something nearer a certainty than a guess: that the six coals had each answered a single spirit because each of them, sea and sky and earth and blood and river and the small fire in a man's own hand, was a thing wholly on its own; the seventh held all six spirits at once, and so could not be woken, he came to believe, by offering it to any one of them alone, any more than a man could satisfy six hungry guests by setting a single dish before whichever one happened to be nearest the door. If the rainbow held every spirit, he reasoned, then it wanted every spirit answered at once, brought together in the one place and the one hour, so that whatever bound the coal shut might hear all six speak to it together rather than one after another across a hundred separate years.

He said as much to Liobhan on an evening in his three-and-twentieth year, turning the rainbow over in his own broad hand by the fire while Gormshuil, five years old by then, slept curled against her mother on the far side of the hearth, and Liobhan, hearing him say it slowly and carefully as he said everything, told him only that it sounded to her like a thing worth the trying, since nothing else in six generations had been. He did not go to the recital that year with any announcement of what he meant to do; he told the reciters only, when his turn came to stand and give his portion of the Line, that he meant in the year ahead to light the six again himself, one by one, by each one's own old way, and carry them living to wherever the seventh might at last be answered, and the reciters, who had

2. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

heard bolder claims than this from keepers before him come to nothing, said only that they would wait to hear how it went before they put any new line into the telling.

IV

Of the Six Kindled Again

A ilean began with the gold, in the last warmth of that same year, walking the day's road north to the shore with a fresh piece of the vein's colour carried loose in his palm the whole way, as Aodh had carried the seven before him, and a clay pot slung at his hip with a lid of green turf cut that same morning to fit its mouth. The northern sea in that season ran grey and short-tempered, breaking hard on the shingle under a sky the colour of wet slate, and he stood a long while at the water's edge before he waded in; it was the plain cold of it that held him back, and no fear of what would happen, for no telling of Aodh's day had ever troubled to mention the cold. Then he threw the coal out past the breaking water with an underhand cast that sent it further than a smaller man could have managed, and watched it strike the swell and take, exactly as the telling gave it, a flame the colour of its own sheen that rode the heave of the sea bright gold until a wave rolled over it; only this time, where Aodh had let it burn out on the water and gone home with an empty hand, Ailean waded in after it to the waist, careless of the cold, and caught it up still burning between his cupped hands the way a man catches a moth without crushing it, and carried it, dripping and alight, back up the shingle to the waiting pot, where it went on burning under its lid of turf all the long walk home, fed each evening with driftwood he gathered as he went.

Before the winter closed the height he climbed to Binnean a' Chlachair¹, carrying the second pot on his back beside the first, and stood in a wind cold enough to make his own teeth ache exactly as it had made Fearghas's teeth ache, and let gual sneachda² fall from the height of his own arm as his forefather had let it fall, and watched it catch fire halfway down the steep side and burn white against the grey rock in the failing light. Going down after it took him longer than the wad-

1. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

2. the snowflake coal, of air

ing had taken, the ground there being steeper and the light worse; he found it still burning where it had fetched up against a shelf of stone, and lifted it with a flat piece of slate into the second pot, and carried both fires down off the height together in the last of that day's light, the gold and the white swaying against each other in their pots on his shoulders with every step.

The black he woke at home, needing no journey for it, digging a hole beside the old slab as deep as a grave in the last week before the ground froze hard, and laying the third coal in it and covering it over as Brian had covered his five, and going back to it at first light the next morning to find it warm in his hand and glowing at its heart the dark red Brian's own telling had given it, so that he had three fires burning in three pots under his own roof before the shortest days of that year were out, and Lìobhan said afterward that the house that winter never once in her memory stood so bright of an evening, with three low flames instead of one keeping the dark back from the walls.

He woke the red-brown in the early spring, alone in the yard behind the house on a morning grey with the last of the frost, setting the fourth coal on a flat stone as Cormac had set his and striking it with a hammer meant for splitting kindling, and the hammer turned on the coal's hard face as it had turned on Cormac's and came down across the back of his own left hand, laying it open near to the bone; he stood a long moment watching his own blood run down over the coal on the stone before the pain of it reached him at all, and where the blood touched the coal a flame came up the colour of the coal, deep and warm as firelight seen through oak leaves, and Ailean lifted it into its pot with his good hand while the other bled freely down his sleeve, and only then went in to have Lìobhan bind the wound, by which time the bleeding had slowed of its own accord and the scar it left, when it healed, sat white and puckered across the back of his hand much as the old tellings said Cormac's own scar had sat across his.

He woke the silver at the river below the house on an evening in early summer, kneeling at the same crossing Eòghann had knelt at and drinking from his cupped hands before he threw the fifth coal into the current, less from any need to test the water's taste, which every child of that hearth had known from infancy, than from a wish to do the thing whole, in the manner the telling gave it, rather than skip to the part that mattered; the coal took fire as it went under exactly as Eòghann's had taken fire, burning silver on the riverbed while the current ran over it and could not put it out, and Ailean lifted it out with a shallow wicker

scoop he had made for the purpose and set it, wet and still alight, into the fifth pot.

The sixth he woke without meaning to, on a warm evening near midsummer, sitting on his own doorstep with the last fragment of the old fire coal crumbling to dust between his fingers as he turned over in his mind the whole year's work and what remained of it, thinking, as it happened, of nothing at all to do with fire; his fingers closed the way a hand closes on its own account when a man's mind has gone elsewhere, and snapped without his asking them to, and the dust on them caught and flared red-gold for the length of a breath before he beat it out against his coat from old habit though it left, as it had left Seathan, not a mark on him. He sat looking at his own open hand a good while by the last light, and then went in and told Lìobhan only that the sixth was done, and did not trouble to say how, for it seemed to him, once it was over, too small and too accidental a thing to make a telling of, though Lìobhan drew the whole of it out of him before the night was over all the same.

V

Of the Road North

Six fires stood that summer under one roof for the first time since the making of the world, each in its own clay pot with its own lid of turf, fed morning and evening by a man who had by then, without quite noticing the change come over him, stopped sleeping a full night through, waking instead at odd hours from long habit to see that none of the six had failed. He kept them through the last weeks of that summer at Tobar dhìreach, going about the ordinary business of the herd and the house by day and tending the pots by evening, while Lìobhan watched him grow thinner and quieter across those weeks and said nothing against it, having by then no more doubt than he had that the year's work was not yet finished. Gormshuil, six years old that summer, was kept from the pots by her mother's word, though she was found more than once crouched at a safe distance watching the lids lifted and the low strange colours beneath them, gold and white and the black coal's low red glow, silver, and the deep red-brown of the fifth, with the plain wide-eyed attention of a child who knows well enough that no other house in her own memory has ever kept the like.

In the last week of an t-Iuchar he set out for the grove, carrying the six pots slung in pairs from a pole across his shoulders, three to a side, with the seventh coal, the rainbow, wrapped in its old fold of cloth inside his shirt against his chest where his father had once carried it the same way. Lìobhan walked with him as far as the last hearth before the moor, carrying Gormshuil on her hip, and said little at the parting beyond that he should mind his feet on the northern slopes, which were wet that year even in high summer, and that she would keep the house fire as she had always kept it until he came home to it. Three days he walked alone, the pole's weight settling into a rhythm across his shoulders that he found, by the second day, he no longer noticed except when he set it down, and slept each night in the lee of whatever rock or bank offered itself, tending the six fires by starlight before he lay down and again before first light, so that he came into each new day already a little short of sleep and grew no less short of it as the days went on.

He came down into Doire ghlas on the twenty-first day of an t-Iuchar, with the light already going long and gold through the oaks and no wind at all in the crowns of the trees, a stillness he had not looked for after everything the tellings said of the gale that had met Diarmad in that same grove four thousand years before. There he set the six pots down in a ring among the roots of the oldest oak he could find, and lifted their lids one after another, and stood back to watch six fires stand up together out of the leaf-litter in their six colours, gold and white and the black coal's deep red and the red-brown of his own blood and the river's silver and the clear fire-colour that had once been dust on his own hand, closer together than any six of them had stood since the day each was first found. Never in his life had he seen more than three of them burning under one roof at once, and he stood a long while looking at the ring of them before he set the rainbow down in the bare ground at its centre and sat down himself beside it to wait, for every telling that had come down to him said that this was the place Coimhdeach na Fine¹ came, if it came at all.

It was there before the light had wholly gone, standing among the oaks the height of a tall man and made, as the old telling had it, of smoke that did not move with the smoke of his own six fires though that smoke blew past it steadily on whatever small air still stirred in the grove. Ailean looked at it a long moment, and it was Coimhdeach na Fine that spoke first.

"You have brought them all," it said.

1. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

"All I could," said Ailean. "The last will not light."

It said nothing to that for a moment, and the six fires around him burned on without a sound in the stillness of the grove, gold and white and black-red and the river's silver and the dark warm red-brown and the last clear flame that had been dust on his own fingers. Then it came forward into the ring, stooping low over the bare coal at its centre where Ailean had set it, and where it stooped the rainbow took fire.

Ailean said afterward, to the few he ever spoke of it to at all, that he could not have named the colour of that flame to save his life, for it would not hold still long enough to be named, running through every colour the six fires around it held and others besides that he had no word for; and the six fires themselves, gold and white and black and red-brown and silver and the clear fire-red, leaned in toward it all together where they stood in their ring, the way grass in six different places leans the same way in one wind, and for the first time since the making of the world all seven coals of the island burned together, each out of its own spirit and all of them now out of one flame besides.

"Stay with them," Coimhdeach na Fine said, "until they are cold."

PART TWO

The Annals of the Age

THE YEARS VE 1 – 500

20 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 1 — *The mason's fire.* Neachdan, a mason splitting rock for a well, breaks into a vein of hard coal that shows every colour in the break. That night a storm comes over the hills, and lightning strikes the broken vein, and it takes fire. He carries a burning coal home and lays the first hearth: it is the first fire of the Dia-thirich. On it he tries the other coals he broke out, and all burn alike, with a low black flame; he is glad of the fire all the same.

10 AN GEARRAN, VE 1 — *The spring under the shoulder of the hill fails.* The spring that fed Neachdan's valley thins through a wet season and fails by the dark of the year, leaving four households to carry water a mile and a half by skin. The valley meets and chooses to sink a well of its own.¹

11 AN GEARRAN, VE 1 — *Neachdan chosen to sink the well.* The households of the failed spring choose Neachdan, the best splitter of stone among them, to dig a new well. He has already gone to mark the shaft while the others are still weighing whether the old spring might return.²

17 AM MÀRT, VE 1 — *Neachdan's hands split at the knuckle.* Through the dead of the year Neachdan digs the new well with wedge and oak maul in sleet and frost. His hands split at the knuckle and never close between one day's work and the next, and Sorcha rubs sheep-fat into the cracks each night.³

18 AM MÀRT, VE 1 — *Neachdan fills his tunic with the coloured stone.* Breaking into the black seam, Neachdan finds pieces streaked gold, white, red-brown and silver, and one that holds every colour at once. Knowing no name or use for them, he judges them too beautiful to leave in the flooding shaft and carries them home against his chest.⁴

27 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1 — *Neachdan shelters as the storm breaks.* A storm comes up the valley at dusk with a green-black sky. Neachdan caps the shaft and takes shelter under a crag above it rather than go back down into a flooding hole, and watches the light change to a thick yellow-brown before the sky breaks.⁵

28 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1 — *Neachdan finds the vein still burning under the rain.* After the lightning strikes his capped shaft, Neachdan uncovers it to find the black seam awake along its whole face, breathing heat and a dark red flame that the driving rain cannot drown, only turn to a thin white smoke off its surface.⁶

1. → Leads to *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1.

2. → Leads to *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *The spring under the shoulder of the hill fails*, 10 an Gearran, VE 1.

3. → Leads to *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Neachdan chosen to sink the well*, 11 an Gearran, VE 1.

4. ○ Same place *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Neachdan's hands split at the knuckle*, 17 am Màrt, VE 1.

5. → Leads to *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Neachdan fills his tunic with the coloured stone*, 18 am Màrt, VE 1.

- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1** — *Neachdan weeps at the well's mouth.* Kneeling at the shaft with his hands held over the burning vein, Neachdan feels warmth reach his split and aching knuckles for the first time since the winter began, and weeps at the well's edge in the storm.⁷
- 12 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 1** — *The household gathers at the first hearth.* Neachdan sets the carried coal on a swept ring of earth in his house. Sorcha, the boy Conall, and three younger children watch the first flame any household on Dia-thir has ever kept, unsure at first whether it is dangerous.⁸
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 1** — *The household learns the fire can be fed, and can die.* As the first coal burns down to ash-grey crust, Neachdan breaks it open and finds it still glowing beneath. Sorcha feeds it dry heather from the bedding stack, and the household understands, in one night, that the fire must be fed or it will go out.⁹
- 16 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 1** — *Sorcha burned by the fire.* Feeding the fire a second time, Sorcha brushes her palm against the ash-grey crust of the coal, mistaking it for cold stone, and is burned across the base of her fingers. It is the first hurt any hearth on the island gives.¹⁰
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 1** — *The household sets the rule of the stick.* After Sorcha's burn, the household sets a rule kept ever after: the fire is fed with a stick's length between hand and flame, never with a bare palm. Sorcha teaches it to the younger children before dawn, showing them her reddened hand.¹¹
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 1** — *Neachdan says the fire must not go out.* At dawn, with the storm spent and his household warm for the first time any of them can remember, Neachdan kneels by the fire with his hand on the cold earth and says it must not go out. Sorcha pledges to feed it as long as she has hands.¹²
- I AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 1** — *The well begun below the flat stone.* Neachdan sets the first wedge on a rise a little east of the dead spring, where the older men of the valley say the rock runs true, and works through the dead of the year a hand's depth at a time.¹³

6. ○ Same place *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Neachdan shelters as the storm breaks*, 27 an Giblean, VE 1.

7. ○ Same place *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Neachdan finds the vein still burning under the rain*, 28 an Giblean, VE 1.

8. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Neachdan weeps at the well's mouth*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1.

9. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *The household gathers at the first hearth*, 12 an t-Iuchar, VE 1.

10. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *The household learns the fire can be fed, and can die*, 13 an t-Iuchar, VE 1.

11. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Sorcha burned by the fire*, 16 an Lùnastal, VE 1.

12. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *The household learns the fire can be fed, and can die*, 13 an t-Iuchar, VE 1.

13. → Leads to *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Neachdan says the fire must not go out*, 27 an t-Sultain, VE 1.

- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 1** — *The rock runs dark under the wedge.* By the fifteenth day of the digging the shaft is over Neachdan's head and the rock has begun to run from grey to black, ringing under the maul instead of cracking clean.¹⁴
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 1** — *Heather first fed to the fire.* Sorcha lays a handful of dry bedding-heather against the failing coal on the first night, and the fire takes it faster and brighter than it took the stone; the household learns that the thing can be fed.¹⁵
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 1** — *The first dawn by a fire.* The household sits awake round the fire through the whole first night, and at grey dawn the children wake reddened by its glow instead of blued by the cold, for the first time in their lives.¹⁶
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, VE 2** — *Meat first set to the fire* (Tobar dhìreach). A haunch of mutton hung too low over the hearth browns in the night, and the household wakes to a smell none of them has ever smelled; within a season meat is laid on stones heated at the fire's edge.¹⁷
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3** — *Ailbhe born by the hearth* (Tobar dhìreach). A daughter is born to Neachdan and Sorcha so close to the fire that the women turn her aside for fear of a spark. She is the first child of the hill country to open her eyes by firelight rather than daylight alone. They name her Ailbhe.¹⁸
- 28 AN GEARRAN, VE 3** — *The stone kept at the hearth's edge for meat* (Tobar dhìreach). A flat stone is kept at the edge of the mason's hearth for the cooking of meat and nothing else, and the knowing of it goes out with every coal the household gives.¹⁹
- 29 AM MÀRT, VE 4** — *Teine a' Chlachair*²⁰ *begged and given* (Tobar dhìreach). A neighbouring household, its own hearth cold, comes asking for a coal of Teine a' Chlachair. Neachdan gives it freely and will not hear of any debt for it, telling his children that a fire withheld from a cold house is worse than a fire given away unthanked.²¹
- 28 AN GEARRAN, VE 5** — *Fire first carried in a pot* (Tobar dhìreach). The household hearth drowns in a night of driving rain. The boy Conall runs alone in the dark to the burning vein, scrapes a live coal into a clay water-pot banked round with cold ash, and carries it home to relight the fire. It is learned that fire need not stay where it is born.²²

14. → Leads to *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *The well begun below the flat stone*, 1 an t-Samhain, VE 1.

15. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Neachdan says the fire must not go out*, 27 an t-Sultain, VE 1.

16. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *The rock runs dark under the wedge*, 7 an t-Samhain, VE 1.

17. ◇ Same person *The first dawn by a fire*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, VE 1.

18. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Meat first set to the fire*, 27 an Giblean, VE 2.

19. ◇ Same person *Ailbhe born by the hearth*, 30 am Faoilleach, VE 3.

20. the mason's fire, the first fire

21. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Ailbhe born by the hearth*, 30 am Faoilleach, VE 3.

22. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *The first dawn by a fire*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, VE 1.

- I AM FAOILLEACH, VE 6** — *The hearth dies in the wet spring* (Tobar dhìreach). Three days of driven rain come through the thatch in the fifth spring after the lightning and put out the hearth in the black hour before dawn, with Neachdan from home.²³
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 6** — *Conall relights the hearth from the vein* (Tobar dhìreach). Conall, eleven years old, runs barefoot through the rain to the burning vein with his mother's water-pot, scrapes a live piece into it, and brings the fire home to the dead hearth before his mother wakes.²⁴
- 24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 12** — *The hut on the heather burns*. A near household's fire, laid on packed heather, catches unseen from beneath and breaks into open flame under a heather roof. The family escapes with nothing saved. It is the first house lost to fire since the mason carried his home.²⁵
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 12** — *Conall's word: fire keeps to stone*. Watching the burned household in its ruined yard, the young Conall says plainly what he has half understood since he was eleven: that a fire kept on stone can be trusted, and a fire laid on heather waits only for a moment's neglect to remember what it is.²⁶
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, VE 15** — *Households begin laying stone under their fires*. After the hut on the heather burns, the near hearths begin laying flat stones from the burn-bed beneath their fires, and the household that lost its roof rebuilds with a stone floor under its hearth.²⁷
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, VE 20** — *Ailbhe first sent out with Poit an Teine*²⁸ (Tobar dhìreach). Ailbhe, still a girl, is sent alone two valleys off with a coal banked in ash in a clay pot, because her hands are steadier with a live coal than her brothers'.²⁹
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 25** — *Fire reaches the northern moor* (Tobar dhìreach). Ailbhe, grown sure of the ground, carries a banked coal a full day's walk north to the edge of the moor at the limit of any household's grazing. Teine a' Chlachair³⁰, walked outward hearth by hearth, now burns in dozens of houses that were once each other's strangers.³¹
- II AN T-IUCHAR, VE 29** — *Sorcha dies* (Tobar dhìreach). Sorcha, who bore Ailbhe by the hearth and was herself the first to be burned by the fire her husband brought home, dies at Tobar dhìreach. The household keeps its fire fed through the mourning without letting it fall.³²

23. ◇ Same person *Fire first carried in a pot*, 28 an Gearran, VE 5.

24. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *The hearth dies in the wet spring*, 1 am Faoilleach, VE 6.

25. ◇ Same person *Conall relights the hearth from the vein*, 30 am Faoilleach, VE 6.

26. ◇ Same person *The hut on the heather burns*, 24 an t-Ògmhios, VE 12.

27. ◇ Same person *Conall's word: fire keeps to stone*, 23 an t-Iuchar, VE 12.

28. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

29. ◇ Same person *Ailbhe born by the hearth*, 30 am Faoilleach, VE 3.

30. the mason's fire, the first fire

31. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Ailbhe first sent out with Poit an Teine*, 27 an Giblean, VE 20.

32. ◇ Same person *The stone kept at the hearth's edge for meat*, 28 an Gearran, VE 3.

- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 38** — *Neachdan dies* (Tobar dhìreach). Neachdan, An Clachair³³, dies old by the hearth he lit from the burning vein, having asked once more to be carried to see the well-cut still burning. The household keeps the fire through the mourning as it has kept it every night since the lightning.³⁴
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 40** — *Conall's rule of the stone*. At a gathering of the near hearths in the dark half of the year, Conall sets down standing what he has held since the burned hut: that fire kept from the mason's line should be laid on stone and never on packed heather. The near households take it as their own law.³⁵
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 55** — *Conall keeps the winter watch at the vein* (Tobar dhìreach). Conall sits the dark half of every year on the two flat stones above the burning vein, and the valley's children learn not to go near them without an elder by.³⁶
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 71** — *Conall dies* (Tobar dhìreach). Conall, who first carried Teine na Fèithe³⁷ home in a water-pot as a boy, dies by the hearth in old age, with the vein in the well-cut still burning as it has burned since Oidhche an Dealanaich³⁸, unchanged through two of the mason's line.³⁹
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 71** — *The watch passed to Conall's son* (Tobar dhìreach). Without ceremony, Conall's son takes up the watch of the burning vein his father and grandfather kept before him, sitting the dark half of the year on the two flat stones above the cut, understanding it is not his to let go out.⁴⁰
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, VE 76** — *Three wells claim the crack* (Tobar dhìreach). Tobar dhìreach, Tobar dhubh and Tobar òg each tell that the mason's well was theirs, and that the lightning fell there. Tobar dhìreach can show a capped shaft with a scorched stain on its lip; the other two have only the telling. Between the three no chronicler has ever judged.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, VE 80** — *Tadhg's scorched stone*. At the black well two valleys east, Tadhg holds up a dark-faced stone before a gathering and swears the lightning struck his own family's well, not the mason's. The mason's household hears of it and answers nothing, keeping the fire rather than the argument.⁴¹

33. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

34. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Teine a' Chlachair begged and given*, 29 am Màrt, VE 4.

35. ◇ Same person *Households begin laying stone under their fires*, 26 an Cèitean, VE 15.

36. ◇ Same person *Conall's rule of the stone*, 4 an t-Samhain, VE 40.

37. the fire of the vein; the burning of the broken vein in the mason's well, VE 1 – 151

38. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

39. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Conall keeps the winter watch at the vein*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, VE 55.

40. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Conall dies*, 1 am Faoilleach, VE 71.

41. ← Follows from *Three wells claim the crack*, 17 an Giblean, VE 76.

- 29 AM MÀRT, VE 82** — *Ailbhe dies* (Tobar dhìreach). Ailbhe, the fire-bearer, dies in her old age at the hearth she was born beside, having walked Teine a' Chlachair⁴² to more hearths than anyone had counted.⁴³
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, VE 95** — *The young well's telling*. An old woman of the young well to the south begins to tell, softly and without a stone to prove it, that her own mother saw the lightning fall into their well and not the mason's. The telling travels further than Tadhg's louder claim and outlasts it.⁴⁴
- 16 AN GEARRAN, VE 96** — *Three tellings held at once* (Tobar dhìreach). The high valleys settle, without any household deciding it outright, into three tellings of where the lightning fell, held side by side and never set against each other. Only the scorched lip of the mason's own shaft still shows the truth of it, plainly, to anyone who walks to see.⁴⁵
- 17 AM MÀRT, VE 100** — *Conall's son keeps the watch grown grey* (Tobar dhìreach). Conall's son, grown grey at the watch his father left him, will not have the claims of the black well and the young well argued: the fire was walked to a hundred houses that do not care which valley the lightning chose.⁴⁶
- 18 AM MÀRT, VE 112** — *Muirne born* (Tobar dhìreach). A daughter is born at Tobar dhìreach, a great-granddaughter of Conall's line, and is given young to the household's hearth-keeper to be raised among the fire before she is raised among words. She is named Muirne.
- 17 AN GEARRAN, VE 128** — *Muirne takes up the watch of the well-cut* (Tobar dhìreach). Not yet grown, Muirne begins to keep the winter watch over the burning vein as the keeper before her tires of the work, sitting the dark half of the year on the two flat stones as every keeper has sat since Conall.⁴⁷
- 15 AN CÈITEAN, VE 130** — *Teine na Fèithe⁴⁸ burns low* (Tobar dhìreach). Through the years of Muirne's watch the glow in the broken vein fades winter on winter, unmarked by most of the valley, whose hundred hearths no longer need it, and marked only by the one keeper who sits with it in the cold.⁴⁹
- 16 AN GIBLEAN, VE 135** — *Muirne marks Teine na Fèithe⁵⁰ sinking* (Tobar dhìreach). Keeping a private reckoning against her own memory, Muirne comes to see what no keeper before her has said aloud: that the glow in the well-cut grows a little lower with every winter, the vein burning down like any fire that is fed by nothing but itself.⁵¹

42. the mason's fire, the first fire

43. ◇ Same person *Fire reaches the northern moor*, 9 an Lùnastal, VE 25.

44. ← Follows from *Three wells claim the crack*, 17 an Giblean, VE 76.

45. ← Follows from *Three wells claim the crack*, 17 an Giblean, VE 76.

46. ⇐ Answers *Three wells claim the crack*, 17 an Giblean, VE 76.

47. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Muirne born*, 18 am Màrt, VE 112.

48. the fire of the vein; the burning of the broken vein in the mason's well, VE 1 – 151

49. ◇ Same person *Muirne takes up the watch of the well-cut*, 17 an Gearran, VE 128.

50. the fire of the vein; the burning of the broken vein in the mason's well, VE 1 – 151

22 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 140 — *Teine na Fèithe*⁵² *marked lower each winter* (Tobar dhìreach).

Muirne, sitting the dark half of the year on the flat stones, begins to keep a private reckoning of the glow in the well-cut against her memory of five winters before.⁵³

19 AM MÀRT, VE 151 — *The slab over the burnt vein* (Tobar dhìreach). When the fire in the vein has burned itself out, the mason's people dig no further. They lay a flat stone over the broken vein, draw no water beside it, and cut their well again a stone's throw off. In this all the tellings agree.

4 AN GIBLEAN, VE 151 — *The last ember* (Tobar dhìreach). In a wet spring of failed crops and standing water, Muirne sits out the last night of *Teine na Fèithe*⁵⁴ in the rain and watches its pale glow go out, quietly, with no one else there to see *Teine a' Chlachair*⁵⁵ die in the ground where it was struck.⁵⁶

29 AN CÈITEAN, VE 151 — *Muirne refuses the digging* (Tobar dhìreach). When talk turns to deepening the well-cut in hope of striking fire again, Muirne stands at the mouth of it and forbids the digging, saying the fire came out of the sky on one night only and is not a thing to be dug after in the ground.⁵⁷

27 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 151 — *The seed rots in the wet spring*. The spring that finishes *Teine na Fèithe*⁵⁸ is remembered also for rain that stands a hand deep in the low fields and rots the seed in the ground, so that hunger is abroad in the valleys.

30 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 152 — *Leac na Fèithe*⁵⁹ *laid over the vein* (Tobar dhìreach). The household levers a broad flat stone across the mouth of the mason's well-cut and packs its edge with turf, sealing the burnt vein from the weather and forbidding any water to be drawn near it again.⁶⁰

29 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 152 — *The new well cut* (Tobar dhìreach). A stone's throw from the covered vein, the household cuts a fresh well that gives clean water from its first day, and it is this well, not the mason's old cut, that the household draws from from that day on.⁶¹

51. ← Follows from *The mason's fire*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1; ◇ Same person *Teine na Fèithe burns low*, 15 an Cèitean, VE 130.

52. the fire of the vein; the burning of the broken vein in the mason's well, VE 1 – 151

53. ◇ Same person *Muirne marks Teine na Fèithe sinking*, 16 an Giblean, VE 135.

54. the fire of the vein; the burning of the broken vein in the mason's well, VE 1 – 151

55. the mason's fire, the first fire

56. ← Follows from *The slab over the burnt vein*, 19 am Màrt, VE 151; ◇ Same person *Teine na Fèithe marked lower each winter*, 22 an t-Samhain, VE 140.

57. ← Follows from *The slab over the burnt vein*, 19 am Màrt, VE 151; ◇ Same person *The last ember*, 4 an Giblean, VE 151.

58. the fire of the vein; the burning of the broken vein in the mason's well, VE 1 – 151

59. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

60. ← Follows from *The slab over the burnt vein*, 19 am Màrt, VE 151; ◇ Same person *Muirne refuses the digging*, 29 an Cèitean, VE 151.

61. ← Follows from *The slab over the burnt vein*, 19 am Màrt, VE 151.

- 25 AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 165** — *Muirne tells the covering standing* (Tobar dhíreach). Muirne tells the finding and the covering of the vein the same way every year, standing, until her telling is the one the household keeps unaltered: a wonder found, a wonder covered, and a well that gave water all the same.⁶²
- 23 AN LÚNASTAL, VE 175** — *Grandchildren sent out to Leac na Féithe⁶³ in Muirne's stead* (Tobar dhíreach). Grown too slow for the winter walk, Muirne sends her grandchildren out to Leac na Féithe to see that the turf at its edge still holds the rain out and that no bucket stands near it.⁶⁴
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, VE 181** — *Muirne dies* (Tobar dhíreach). Muirne dies at Tobar dhíreach in old age and is buried in the ground near the house with no coal or fire laid beside her, having already given the vein's fire, whole, back to the stone. The telling of Leac na Féithe⁶⁵ passes to her grandchildren.⁶⁶
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 185** — *A palm laid on the cold slab* (Tobar dhíreach). The youngest of Muirne's grandchildren walks out to the covered stone in the dark half of the year and lays a bare palm on it, as she was taught, for what the stone once held.⁶⁷
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 205** — *Conn born to the upper valley*. Conn is born to a herding household high up the Abhainn uaine, further inland and higher than any household of that kin cares to winter, the country from which the summer grazing is followed up onto the shrinking snowfields.
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 224** — *Conn trusted to choose the high ground*. Grown to a young man, Conn reads the colour of the light on the high tops before dawn to judge whether the beasts want driving down, and is seldom wrong; the older herders of his kin begin letting him choose the summer ground himself.⁶⁸
- 14 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 227** — *The high snowfields shrink* (Abhainn uaine). Meltwater off the central mountains cuts the bed that Abhainn uaine follows still. On the gravel terraces of its lower reach lie hearth-stones at three heights, each left as the water rose to it.⁶⁹
- 23 AM MÁRT, VE 230** — *Conn's fire-ring on the gravel terrace*. Conn lays hearth-stones on the gravel terrace above the summer bend of the Abhainn uaine, on ground his father and grandfather used before him, a coal carried up from the household's own fire in a clay pot banked in ash.⁷⁰

62. ← Follows from *The slab over the burnt vein*, 19 am Màrt, VE 151; ◇ Same person *Leac na Féithe laid over the vein*, 30 an t-Ògmhios, VE 152.

63. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhíreach

64. ◇ Same person *Muirne tells the covering standing*, 25 an t-Iuchar, VE 165.

65. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhíreach

66. ◇ Same person *Grandchildren sent out to Leac na Féithe in Muirne's stead*, 23 an Lùnastal, VE 175.

67. ¶ Legacy *The slab over the burnt vein*, 19 am Màrt, VE 151.

68. ◇ Same person *Conn born to the upper valley*, 18 an t-Samhain, VE 205.

69. → Caused by *Conn born to the upper valley*, 18 an t-Samhain, VE 205; → Caused by *Conn trusted to choose the high ground*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, VE 224.

70. ← Follows from *The high snowfields shrink*, 14 an t-Ògmhios, VE 227; ◇ Same person *Conn trusted to choose the high ground*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, VE 224.

- 21 AN GIBLEAN, VE 240** — *The flood takes Conn's lower ring.* A week of unlifting cloud on the high ground sends the Abhainn uaine over Conn's fire-ring at flood height; he saves the coal and drives the beasts to the shelf above, and the water carries off all but the flat stone at the ring's back.⁷¹
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, VE 250** — *The white draws back up the mountain* (Abhainn uaine). Year on year of Conn's manhood the old snow draws back further up the shoulder of the central mountains, and more water comes down the Abhainn uaine than the grass alone can explain.⁷²
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 260** — *Conn shows his sons the three rings* (Abhainn uaine). Conn walks the terrace above the river with his sons and shows them three rings of fire-stones on three shelves, each set higher than the last by a man who judged the water would not come so far.⁷³
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 266** — *Conn dies among three rings.* Conn dies at his household's hearth in the low valley in his sixty-second year, having shown his sons the three fire-rings on three shelves of the one terrace, each built a little higher than the last by a man reading how far the river could be trusted.⁷⁴
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 281** — *Eachna born south of Tobar dhìreach.* Eachna is born to a household some way south of Tobar dhìreach that keeps a fire carried, hearth by hearth, from the mason's own since Ailbhe first walked it outward; she grows up wanting open ground of her own rather than a corner of her father's.
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 300** — *Eachna walks the straight field* (Achadh dhìreach). Eachna walks the level ground west of Tobar dhìreach more than once as a young woman, looking at it the way a woman looks at a thing she means to have.⁷⁵
- 16 AN CÈITEAN, VE 303** — *The first hearths of the high valleys* (Achadh dhìreach). Hearths are made at Achadh dhìreach, of pine and heather charcoal, with scrapers of grey flint and the split bones of red deer about them. There is no coloured coal in them: those who sat there had none of it, or would not burn it.⁷⁶
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 306** — *Eachna carries fire to the straight field* (Achadh dhìreach). Eachna walks a day's distance from Tobar dhìreach with a coal from the line's own hearth to settle the level, well-watered ground west of the high valleys that households call, for its lie, the straight field; the line asks nothing for the giving.⁷⁷

71. ← Follows from *The high snowfields shrink*, 14 an t-Ògmhios, VE 227; ◇ Same person *Conn's fire-ring on the gravel terrace*, 23 am Màrt, VE 230.

72. ← Follows from *The high snowfields shrink*, 14 an t-Ògmhios, VE 227; ◇ Same person *The flood takes Conn's lower ring*, 21 an Giblean, VE 240.

73. ◇ Same person *The white draws back up the mountain*, 20 an Cèitean, VE 250.

74. ← Follows from *The high snowfields shrink*, 14 an t-Ògmhios, VE 227; ◇ Same person *Conn shows his sons the three rings*, 29 an Dàmhair, VE 260.

75. ◇ Same person *Eachna born south of Tobar dhìreach*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, VE 281.

- 3 **AN LÙNASTAL, VE 306** — *The first hearth of Achadh dhìreach laid on stone* (Achadh dhìreach). Eachna lays her first fire on a bed of pine and dried heather banked over flat stone, the lesson of stone under every fire carried out from the mason's own household as freely as the fire itself; grey flint and red deer bone gather round it in the seasons after.⁷⁸
- 7 **AN GEARRAN, VE 320** — *Deer hunted by torch at Achadh dhìreach* (Achadh dhìreach). With calves lost to deer grown bold on ground still thin of houses, Eachna's sons take to hunting the moor's deer by torchlight after dark, a burning brand carried low and a spearman behind, working the herds back from the standing crop.⁷⁹
- 9 **AM FAOILLEACH, VE 330** — *The straight field named* (Achadh dhìreach). The level ground between the burn and the rise where Eachna settled is called the straight field by those who first work it, and keeps the name after the households round it grow too many to count.⁸⁰
- 11 **AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 335** — *Achadh dhìreach grows to five hearths* (Achadh dhìreach). Eachna's household becomes three hearths and then five as sons and daughters marry out and stay near rather than moving off, each new fire lit in an unbroken line from the coal Eachna herself carried from Tobar dhìreach.⁸¹
- 12 **AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 349** — *Eachna dies at her own hearth* (Achadh dhìreach). Eachna dies at Achadh dhìreach in her sixty-eighth year among her own grown children; the fire she carried from Tobar dhìreach burns on after her, tended by hands that have never seen the mason's well and owe it only the memory of it.⁸²
- 11 **AN LÙNASTAL, VE 378** — *The oak comes to the lowlands* (Doire ghlas). The birch and pine of the cold years give way to oak and hazel, as the pollen in the bog under Doire ghlas shows. The grove that names the place stands on ground that was open heath when the vein was first broken.
- 14 **AN DÀMHAIR, VE 390** — *The first autumn store of roasted hazel-nuts* (Achadh dhìreach). At Achadh dhìreach, under the oak and hazel now grown thick where birch once stood, Eachna's descendants roast whole nuts in the embers and lay by the first store of them against the dark months, rather than gathering only as the season allows.⁸³

77. ← Follows from *The first hearths of the high valleys*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 303; ◇ Same person *Eachna walks the straight field*, 24 am Faoilleach, VE 300.

76. → Caused by *Eachna born south of Tobar dhìreach*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, VE 281.

78. ← Follows from *The first hearths of the high valleys*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 303; ◇ Same person *Eachna carries fire to the straight field*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 306.

79. ← Follows from *The first hearths of the high valleys*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 303; ◇ Same person *The first hearth of Achadh dhìreach laid on stone*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 306.

80. ← Follows from *The first hearths of the high valleys*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 303.

81. ← Follows from *The first hearths of the high valleys*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 303; ◇ Same person *Deer hunted by torch at Achadh dhìreach*, 7 an Gearran, VE 320.

82. ← Follows from *The first hearths of the high valleys*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 303; ◇ Same person *Achadh dhìreach grows to five hearths*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, VE 335.

15 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 400 — *Oak fuel holds a fire through the night* (Doire ghlas). The grandmothers of the northern heath tell that oak has come in where their own grandmothers knew only birch, and that a household with oak in reach keeps a warmer hearth for less carrying.⁸⁴

17 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 425 — *Luag born to the northern heath*. Luag is born to a herding household of the northern heath, near enough the changing country of birch and oak that he grows up on the grandmothers' telling of it, and restless in a way his own kin cannot account for.

19 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 440 — *Luag herds further out each year*. Luag of the northern heath follows the grazing past where his kin are used to follow it, until by his twenty-fifth year he has walked ground no one of his household has walked.⁸⁵

16 AN CÈITEAN, VE 451 — *Luag sets out for the north-western horn*. Alone, with a coal carried in a clay pot and dried meat under a hide, Luag walks four days past the last households his own kin know of, out past the last stands of oak and hazel, meaning to see how far the land runs before it meets the sea.⁸⁶

22 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 451 — *The bare north-west*. The oak never reaches the north-western horn of the island. The gales off the north-western sea keep it bare, low heather and blanket bog behind the shore without a tree, as it is still. No hearth of that age has been found there.

⁸⁷

18 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 451 — *Luag's fire will not live in the wind*. On the bare shore of the north-western horn Luag's banked fire is taken sideways along the ground faster than he can feed it, and he lets it go out rather than waste his last tinder; he finds no hearth-stone or charcoal anywhere he walks that coast.⁸⁸

22 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 452 — *Luag's return and telling*. Luag walks the four days home, re-lighting his fire at the first hearth he reaches, and tells at his own hearth and at the dark-of-the-year gathering that the land runs out at last in the north-west, bare to a wind no fire can stand against.⁸⁹

21 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 453 — *The island is told to have an edge*. Luag's telling goes from hearth to hearth until most of the northern heath has heard that the land runs out in the north-west, bare to a wind no fire can stand against.⁹⁰

83. ← Follows from *The oak comes to the lowlands*, 11 an Lùnastal, VE 378.

84. ← Follows from *The oak comes to the lowlands*, 11 an Lùnastal, VE 378.

85. ◇ Same person *Luag born to the northern heath*, 17 an Lùnastal, VE 425.

86. ◇ Same person *Luag herds further out each year*, 19 an t-Iuchar, VE 440.

87. → Caused by *Luag born to the northern heath*, 17 an Lùnastal, VE 425; → Caused by *Luag sets out for the north-western horn*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 451.

88. ← Follows from *The bare north-west*, 22 an Lùnastal, VE 451; ◇ Same person *Luag sets out for the north-western horn*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 451.

89. ← Follows from *The bare north-west*, 22 an Lùnastal, VE 451; ◇ Same person *Luag's fire will not live in the wind*, 18 an Dàmhair, VE 451.

90. ← Follows from *The bare north-west*, 22 an Lùnastal, VE 451; ◇ Same person *Luag's return and telling*, 22 an t-Sultain, VE 452.

- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 455** — *Gràinne born on the drowned neck*. Gràinne is born to a household that has kept a hearth on the low neck to Eilean dhubh since before her grandmother's grandmother, on a shelf of dry ground between two arms of shingle where the crossing to the island is narrowest and firmest underfoot.
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 475** — *Gràinne learns to watch the tide*. Taught by her mother to set a stone at the mark each spring tide leaves on the shingle and measure it against the last, Gràinne takes up a watch on the sea's creep against the neck that she keeps, by her own habit, for the rest of her life.⁹¹
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, VE 480** — *Gràinne sets stones at the high-water mark* (Eilean dhubh). Gràinne's mother teaches her to walk the shingle at every high water and set a stone at the sea's mark, so that each tide can be measured against the last.⁹²
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 495** — *The crossing to Eilean dhubh dries only at the lowest ebbs* (Eilean dhubh). By the time Gràinne is grown the neck to Eilean dhubh can be crossed only within two hours either side of the lowest ebbs, and only by those who know which channels run firm.⁹³
- 13 AM MÀRT, VE 497** — *Luag dies among his own children*. Luag dies at his own household's hearth in his seventy-second year, remembered kindly as the man who walked to the edge of the world and came back with nothing to show for it but a burnt cloak and a telling that outlived him.⁹⁴

91. ◇ Same person *Gràinne born on the drowned neck*, 26 an t-Iuchar, VE 455.

92. ◇ Same person *Gràinne learns to watch the tide*, 24 an Lùnastal, VE 475.

93. ◇ Same person *Gràinne sets stones at the high-water mark*, 10 an Cèitean, VE 480.

94. ← Follows from *The bare north-west*, 22 an Lùnastal, VE 451; ◇ Same person *The island is told to have an edge*, 21 an Dàmhair, VE 453.

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- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 506** — *Eilean dhubh cut off* (Eilean dhubh). The rising sea floods the low neck of land that joined Eilean dhubh to the main island. The hearths of the neck lie drowned under the sand of the sound, and the deer of the island, cut off, grow smaller in the lifetimes after.¹
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 506** — *Gràinne leaves the drowned neck*. The sea reaches the hearthstones of Gràinne's house in a spring of hard westerlies; she rakes the fire into her mother's clay pot and carries it, the same day, to new hearth-ground behind the shelf that no tide of her lifetime reaches again.²
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 507** — *The new hearth behind the drowned shelf* (Eilean dhubh). Gràinne carries the coal herself from the flooded house to a new hearth on the dry ground behind the old shelf, and lights it there before dark on the day the sea comes in.³
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 528** — *Oisean born to the seal-hunters of the south shore*. Oisean is born to a household that works the rocks and skerries of the south coast for grey seals, and grows up watching the greater number that haul out on Eilean mhin, further out than any boat of that coast has yet been trusted to carry a man and bring him back.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 531** — *Gràinne dies at the second hearth*. Gràinne dies by her own fire on the higher ground she moved to twenty-five years before, and is buried there rather than on the shelf that had been her people's ground for longer than any teller could reckon, and that by then the sea covers at every tide.⁴
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 540** — *The Abbainn ìseal settles into its wide bed*. After generations of shifting across the flat ground below the high valleys, the longest river of the island settles into the wide bed the households along it come to know simply as the river, the shallower side channels running gentler and thick with fish at certain seasons.
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 545** — *The first hazel weirs driven in the side channels*. Households along the newly settled river drive the first weirs of hazel stakes across the mouths of the side channels, angled against the current with gaps left for a hand to reach through, and leave the stakes standing once the season's run is done.

1. → Caused by *Gràinne born on the drowned neck*, 26 an t-Iuchar, VE 455; → Caused by *Gràinne learns to watch the tide*, 24 an Lùnastal, VE 475; → Caused by *The crossing to Eilean dhubh dries only at the lowest ebbs*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, VE 495.

2. ← Follows from *Eilean dhubh cut off*, 13 an t-Iuchar, VE 506; ◇ Same person *The crossing to Eilean dhubh dries only at the lowest ebbs*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, VE 495.

3. ← Follows from *Eilean dhubh cut off*, 13 an t-Iuchar, VE 506; ◇ Same person *Gràinne leaves the drowned neck*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 506.

4. ← Follows from *Eilean dhubh cut off*, 13 an t-Iuchar, VE 506; ◇ Same person *The new hearth behind the drowned shelf*, 3 an t-Sultain, VE 507.

- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 546** — *Oisean stitches the first hide boat.* Working alone over the better part of a season, Oisean stretches and stitches greased sealskin over a frame of bent hazel shaped to his own body, and floats it first in a calm inlet, where it holds him and does not sink.⁵
- 13 AM MÀRT, VE 547** — *Oisean crosses to Eilean mhin and comes home.* Alone and with only a paddle and a coil of plaited hide, Oisean crosses the open water to Eilean mhin in an early summer calm and returns before dark with three seals lashed to the frame behind him, the first crossing on the island made of set purpose to a place seen but not walked to.⁶
- I AN T-IUCHAR, VE 551** — *Hunters on Eilean mhin* (Eilean mhin). Seal-hunters pitch camps on Eilean mhin, coming there by boat: the first sure sign that anyone on Dia-thìr crossed open water of set purpose. The camps are kept a season at a time and left.⁷
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 552** — *The seal-bothies of Eilean mhin first thatched.* Oisean builds a larger boat and begins camping among the seal rocks of Eilean mhin for a stretch of good weather at a time rather than returning each day, raising a shelter of driftwood and hide that comes to be kept and re-thatched, season after season, by those who cross after him.⁸
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, VE 553** — *Others follow Oisean across* (Eilean mhin). Oisean's brothers and then young men of the neighbouring households build boats on his pattern and follow him to Eilean mhin, until the crossing in the calm months is a thing the shore simply does.⁹
- 11 AN GIBLEAN, VE 560** — *The deer of Eilean dhubh grow smaller.* Hunters who cross to Eilean dhubh by boat, the neck no longer drying at all but the lowest ebbs, bring home carcasses lighter than their grandfathers' tellings led them to expect, the island's deer penned by the water onto ground too small to feed a herd that once ranged the length of two islands as one.¹⁰
- 24 AN GEARRAN, VE 590** — *Scàire born to the north shore.* Scàire is born into a household of the north shore that has already taken up the hide boat after the manner spreading up the coast from the south, though built heavier and lower for water that seldom runs calm even at midsummer.
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 596** — *Oisean dies among boats of his grandsons' making.* Oisean dies at his own hearth on the mainland shore in his old age, by then one boat-builder among many of that coast, his grandsons shaping hulls beside his own with a sureness he never had, having had nothing of his own to look at when he began.¹¹

5. ◇ Same person *Oisean born to the seal-hunters of the south shore*, 2 an Dàmhair, VE 528.

6. ◇ Same person *Oisean stitches the first hide boat*, 5 an Lùnastal, VE 546.

7. → Caused by *Oisean born to the seal-hunters of the south shore*, 2 an Dàmhair, VE 528; → Caused by *Oisean stitches the first hide boat*, 5 an Lùnastal, VE 546; ← Leads to *Oisean crosses to Eilean mhin and comes home*, 13 am Màrt, VE 547.

8. ← Follows from *Hunters on Eilean mhin*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 551; ◇ Same person *Oisean crosses to Eilean mhin and comes home*, 13 am Màrt, VE 547.

9. ← Follows from *Hunters on Eilean mhin*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 551; ◇ Same person *The seal-bothies of Eilean mhin first thatched*, 21 an Dàmhair, VE 552.

10. ← Follows from *Eilean dhubh cut off*, 13 an t-Iuchar, VE 506.

- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 600** — *The weir-stakes renewed in the same holes.* A generation on from the first driving, households of the Abhainn iséal renew their weirs by driving fresh stakes into the holes the old ones rotted out of, so that a weir kept thirty years stands on almost the same ground it first stood on, though none of its first stakes remain.
- 1 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 606** — *Scàire first goes out to the skerries* (Eilean fhada). Scàire goes out with her father's crew to the seal skerries off Eilean fhada from her sixteenth year, bailing in boats that ship water with every third swell.¹²
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 611** — *Seals on the skerries* (Eilean fhada). Hunters of the north shore go out in skin boats in the autumn gales to the skerries off Eilean fhada, where the grey seals haul out to pup, and take them there. The seal bones in the middens of the north coast bear the same cut-marks as those of Eilean mhin. On Eilean fhada a hard year is counted by the boats the gales kept ashore.¹³
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 620** — *Scàire sees the grey bank from the skerries.* Master of her own boat and crew, Scàire climbs the highest of the seal skerries off Eilean fhada to judge the weather and sees, lying always along the same stretch of the northern and eastern sea, a grey that no sun burns off and no gale blows away.¹⁴
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 628** — *The hard year of the kept boats.* In Scàire's thirty-eighth year the autumn gales hold five boats out of every six ashore the whole season through, the seal harvest thin enough that more than one household of the north shore goes into the winter short of oil for its lamps.¹⁵
- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 640** — *Scàire master of her own boat* (Eilean fhada). After her father's death Scàire is master of his boat and crew without much argument from anyone, no one on that coast doubting that she reads a north-shore sea as well as any man alive on it.¹⁶
- 25 AN GEARRAN, VE 652** — *Scàire dies having brought her crews home whole.* Scàire dies at her own hearth in old age, remembered by her kin less for the grey bank on the northern sea, by then known to every household of that coast, than for a working life spent bringing crews home whole across water that forgave very little.¹⁷

11. ← Follows from *Hunters on Eilean mhin*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 551; ◇ Same person *Others follow Oisean across*, 10 an Cèitean, VE 553.

12. ◇ Same person *Scàire born to the north shore*, 24 an Gearran, VE 590.

13. → Caused by *Scàire born to the north shore*, 24 an Gearran, VE 590; ← Leads to *Scàire first goes out to the skerries*, 1 an t-Samhain, VE 606.

14. ← Follows from *Seals on the skerries*, 30 an t-Sultain, VE 611; ◇ Same person *Scàire first goes out to the skerries*, 1 an t-Samhain, VE 606.

15. ← Follows from *Seals on the skerries*, 30 an t-Sultain, VE 611; ◇ Same person *Scàire sees the grey bank from the skerries*, 30 an t-Samhain, VE 620.

16. ◇ Same person *The hard year of the kept boats*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, VE 628.

17. ← Follows from *Seals on the skerries*, 30 an t-Sultain, VE 611; ◇ Same person *Scàire master of her own boat*, 27 am Faoilleach, VE 640.

- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 681** — *The flood-plain of Abhainn íseal* (Abhainn íseal). Abhainn íseal, the longest river of the island, settles into the wide bed it keeps now. Fish-weirs of hazel stakes are set across its side channels, and the stakes are renewed in the same holes for generations.¹⁸
- 18 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 690** — *Children wade the shallows at weir-mending* (Abhainn íseal). Children of the households along the Abhainn íseal grow up wading the shallows at weir-mending time, knowing which hole takes a stake easily and which fights it long before they know why the holes are where they are.¹⁹
- 16 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 700** — *The salmon run first feasted at the weirs*. Households up and down the Abhainn íseal gather for the first time at the largest of the weirs when the salmon run stands at its thickest, sharing out the catch between more hands than any one household's own rather than guarding it apart.²⁰
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 751** — *The middens of Seann Dunn*²¹ (Seann Dunn). The Seann-Dhaoine²² begin the great mound at Seann Dunn: limpet shell, seal bone and burnt weed, laid down over many lifetimes until it stands taller than a man. It is the first sure trace of them. No tool in it is shaped as any later Dia-thìreach shaped tools.
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 758** — *The heap's fire kept through the three-day gale* (Seann Dunn²³). A winter gale tears the roof from the shelter behind the shell heap at Dunn and drives the sea over the gathering-rocks for three days; the fire kept at the heap's foot is banked low and fed through the storm by whoever can be spared, and does not go out.²⁴
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 760** — *The heap worked with the foot* (Seann Dunn²⁵). A woman of Dunn keeps the heap as her mother taught her, letting each bag of shell fall where the heap wants it and working it level with her foot, with the burnt weed laid in thin.²⁶
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 765** — *The gatherer's mother dies at the tide* (Seann Dunn²⁷). An old woman of the Dunn heap, who has worked the shore pools long past when her hands were fit for it, is found sitting against a rock with the tide turning round her feet, dead as quietly as she lived; what is done with her is not carried past the household's own places.²⁸

18. → Caused by *The Abhainn íseal settles into its wide bed*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, VE 540; ← Leads to *The first hazel weirs driven in the side channels*, 3 an t-Sultain, VE 545; ← Leads to *The weir-stakes renewed in the same holes*, 3 an Dàmhair, VE 600.

19. ← Follows from *The flood-plain of Abhainn íseal*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 681.

20. ← Follows from *The flood-plain of Abhainn íseal*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 681.

21. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

22. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

23. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

24. → Leads to *The middens of Seann Dunn*, 28 an Lùnastal, VE 751.

25. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

26. ← Follows from *The middens of Seann Dunn*, 28 an Lùnastal, VE 751.

27. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

28. → Leads to *The middens of Seann Dunn*, 28 an Lùnastal, VE 751.

- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 766** — *A season worked alone at the heap* (Seann Dunn²⁹). Through the season after her mother's death the gatherer works the shore pools alone, going down before light and coming up after dark, and keeps the heap's fire no lower than it was kept with two pairs of hands, before her own daughter is old enough to work beside her.³⁰
- 22 AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 770** — *Eggs taken from the low cliffs at Dunn*³¹ (Seann Dunn). The gatherers of Dunn take eggs from the ledges of the low cliffs in the dry months, never so many from one ledge that the birds do not come back to it the next year.
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 778** — *An old scraper turned up in the heap* (Seann Dunn³²). Loosening an old shoulder of the Dunn heap, a girl finds a flint scraper struck and finished unlike any tool freshly made at the heap's fire that same season; she turns it over a while and lets it fall back into the shell with everything else the heap has taken in.³³
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 785** — *The heap first used to watch the sea* (Seann Dunn³⁴). A boy sent to fetch fire down for the smoking of fish remarks, standing at the heap's foot, that its top gives the farthest view of the water on that stretch of coast; after that day the heap is climbed from time to time to watch for boats or weather.³⁵
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 790** — *The Dunn*³⁶ *heap stands a man's height* (Seann Dunn). The shell heap above the shore at Dunn, built shell by shell and bag by bag over more lifetimes than any one gatherer can reckon, now stands higher at its crown than a grown man can reach with his arm raised, the tallest thing on that shore.
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 798** — *The net-maker of Cwen*³⁷ *begins the long mesh* (Seann Chwen). At Cwen, on the sheltered bay to the south, a net-maker who has always set short nets from each shallow toward an open channel begins, over a winter's close work by the fire, twisting a mesh long enough to close the whole width of the bay's mouth.
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 805** — *The Cwen*³⁸ *nets first set across the bay* (Seann Chwen). The net-maker's household stakes a single unbroken net from shallow to shallow across the mouth of the bay at Cwen for the first time, the net-maker herself wading the deepest channel to sink the centre true; more fish come against it than the smoking-racks can hold.
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, VE 806** — *Households come to see the closed net* (Seann Chwen). Word of the catch taken at the closed net travels the shore, and households from some way off come to see the long line of stakes and weights for themselves, going home to lengthen their own nets by whatever means each knows.

29. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

30. → Leads to *The middens of Seann Dunn*, 28 an Lùnastal, VE 751.

31. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

32. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

33. → Leads to *The middens of Seann Dunn*, 28 an Lùnastal, VE 751.

34. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

35. → Leads to *The middens of Seann Dunn*, 28 an Lùnastal, VE 751.

36. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

37. the Old Ones' root (burgs 36, 14, 139)

38. the Old Ones' root (burgs 36, 14, 139)

- 9 AN GIBLEAN, VE 810** — *The net-maker's daughter learns the groove* (Seann Chwen). The net-maker's daughter, grown old enough for close work, begins sitting beside her mother through whole afternoons at the stone weights, learning by eye alone which beach stones will split true under the pecking and which will shatter wrong.
- 11 AM MÀRT, VE 812** — *The daughter's first spoiled stones* (Seann Chwen). Given a stone and the small flint used for the cutting, the net-maker's daughter is set to notching the three strokes; her first attempts run too long, too short or crossing, and each spoiled stone goes back to the unworked pile without comment.
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, VE 815** — *The net-maker's eyes fail first* (Seann Chwen). The net-maker of Cwen³⁹ gives the finer judging of the stones over to her daughter's sharper sight some while before her own hands fail her.
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 818** — *The three strokes held a breath longer in the light* (Seann Chwen). The net-maker's daughter takes up a way of holding each finished weight a breath longer in the light than the work requires, as though the three strokes were worth looking at for their own sake.
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 820** — *The notched net-weights of Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). At Seann Chwen the Seann-Dhaoine⁴⁰ sink their nets with beach stones, and every stone is notched with the same three strokes. It is the eldest mark on Dia-thìr made again and again of purpose.⁴¹
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 820** — *The daughter cuts the three strokes true* (Seann Chwen). On a calm morning the net-maker's daughter cuts three strokes into a finished weight and finds nothing in it her trained eye can fault; her mother takes it up, turns it in the same light, and sets down the next stone before her without a word.
- 18 AM MÀRT, VE 862** — *Diarmad is born at Tobar dhìreach*. Diarmad is born the third child and second son of Fionnghuala, into a household that keeps the mason's own unbroken fire and a leather bag of seven coloured pieces the children play with at the hearth.
- 16 AN GIBLEAN, VE 868** — *The aunt keeps Poit an Teine*⁴² (Tobar dhìreach). Poit an Teine at Tobar dhìreach is kept in Diarmad's childhood by his mother's aunt, called by the household only the aunt, who works wool by the hearth while the children play with the coloured pieces.

39. the Old Ones' root (burgs 36, 14, 139)

40. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

41. → Caused by *The net-maker of Cwen begins the long mesh*, 15 an t-Samhain, VE 798; → Caused by *House-holds come to see the dosed net*, 8 an Cèitean, VE 806; → Caused by *The net-maker's daughter learns the groove*, 9 an Giblean, VE 810; → Caused by *The daughter's first spoiled stones*, 11 am Màrt, VE 812; → Caused by *The three strokes held a breath longer in the light*, 12 am Faoilleach, VE 818.

42. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

- 15 AN CÈITEAN, VE 869** — *Diarmad first asks why the pieces are coloured.* Playing with the leather bag of coloured pieces at the hearth, Diarmad, seven years old, asks the aunt who keeps Poit an Teine⁴³ why the mason's pieces hold colour and the coal of the hillside does not, and is told only that a boy who wants a better answer may go and ask the sky.⁴⁴
- 13 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 870** — *The aunt tells Diarmad to go and ask the sky* (Tobar dhireach). Wearied by a seven-year-old's questions, the aunt tells Diarmad that the stones are coloured because the sky made them so on the night of the fire, and that a boy who wants a better answer can go and ask the sky.⁴⁵
- 12 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 871** — *Diarmad asks the elders and the fire-bearers.* Diarmad puts his question to the oldest of the line and to the fire-bearers who carry coal to the hearths of the hills, and gathers only shrugs and a fire-bearer's tale that the colour is no more real than a rainbow's, which the pieces' own unfading colour does not bear out.⁴⁶
- 10 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 872** — *Diarmad carries the rainbow piece.* From about his tenth year Diarmad keeps the piece that holds every colour and none carried loose at his belt, and takes to turning it in every light the day offers, once holding it bare in a shower of rain to see whether the wet would draw its colour out; it does not.⁴⁷
- 8 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 873** — *Diarmad asks it of travellers.* He begins putting his question to travellers passing through Tobar dhireach with no stake in the household's pride, reasoning that a stranger has no cause to fob him off, and gets from most of them a shrug dressed in more words.⁴⁸
- 7 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 874** — *The rainbow piece held out in the rain* (Tobar dhireach). Diarmad is seen more than once sitting under the eaves in a shower with the rainbow piece held bare to the wet, watching to see whether the rain draws the colour out of it; it lies on top.⁴⁹
- 12 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 875** — *The valley names it Diarmad's question.* The asking becomes a settled joke of the high valleys, carried from hearth to hearth by the fire-bearers, half in earnest and half for a laugh, until every household near Tobar dhireach knows Diarmad's question and no household yet has an answer for it.⁵⁰
- 13 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 880** — *Fionnghuala takes Poit an Teine*⁵¹. On the death of the aunt who had kept it, Fionnghuala becomes keeper of the pot that holds the mason's own ember, the office passing to her at two-and-forty as it had passed through the women of the line before her.⁵²

43. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

44. ◇ Same person *Diarmad is born at Tobar dhireach*, 18 am Màrt, VE 862.

45. ◇ Same person *Diarmad first asks why the pieces are coloured*, 15 an Cèitean, VE 869.

46. ◇ Same person *The aunt tells Diarmad to go and ask the sky*, 13 an t-Ògmhios, VE 870.

47. ◇ Same person *Diarmad asks the elders and the fire-bearers*, 12 an t-Iuchar, VE 871.

48. ◇ Same person *Diarmad carries the rainbow piece*, 10 an Lùnastal, VE 872.

49. ◇ Same person *Diarmad asks it of travellers*, 8 an t-Sultain, VE 873.

50. ◇ Same person *The rainbow piece held out in the rain*, 7 an Dàmhair, VE 874.

51. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

52. ◇ Same person *Diarmad is born at Tobar dhireach*, 18 am Màrt, VE 862.

- 15 AN CÈITEAN, VE 881** — *Fionnghuala silences the joke at her own hearth.* When a cousin by marriage mocks Diarmad's question in front of a full house, Fionnghuala answers that twenty years of one question asked is not the same as a mind that cannot let a matter drop, and the joke is not made again in her hearing.⁵³
- 16 AN GIBLEAN, VE 882** — *A fire-bearer brings a false answer* (Tobar dhìreach). A fire-bearer tells Diarmad that colour in a stone is no more real than colour in a rainbow and thins when looked at close; he has looked close a hundred times and the colour has never thinned.⁵⁴
- 5 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 884** — *Diarmad narrows his question* (Tobar dhìreach). Past twenty, Diarmad begins to ask a narrower question than the one he started with: not why the pieces hold colour, but whether there is anyone or anything on the island that might know.⁵⁵
- 8 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 886** — *A fire-bearer brings word of a grove where the wind speaks.* Returning from the longest circuit the household's fire-bearers still walk, a woman of Tobar dhìreach reports, more in passing than in earnest, an old herder's warning of an oak grove on the far northern moor where the wind does not blow as it blows anywhere else.⁵⁶
- 7 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 886** — *Diarmad presses the fire-bearer for the herder's words.* Diarmad asks the fire-bearer more than once to repeat exactly what the northern herder had said of the grove, until, tired of the asking, she tells him to go and hear it from the herder's own mouth.⁵⁷
- 10 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 888** — *Diarmad gathers every scrap told of the grove.* Over two years he seeks out travellers from the north and west and sets together their thin, half-agreeing tellings of a grove no bird will nest in and no fire is lit within sight of, the first tale in twenty years of asking that does not simply shrug his question off.⁵⁸
- 31 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 889** — *Fionnghuala gives Diarmad the rainbow piece for the road.* Told her son means to walk north to put his question to the grove itself, Fionnghuala gives him the piece that holds every colour to carry loose in his hand rather than shut in its bag, so that he may have the thing itself before him when he asks.⁵⁹
- 1 AM MÀRT, VE 889** — *Diarmad walks north from Tobar dhìreach.* At seven-and-twenty, Diarmad sets out alone from Tobar dhìreach with a coal banked in a clay pot, a little food and the rainbow piece against his palm, walking three days north and a little west into country his own household has never settled.⁶⁰

53. ◇ Same person *Fionnghuala takes Poit an Teine*, 13 an t-Ògmhios, VE 880.

54. ◇ Same person *Fionnghuala silences the joke at her own hearth*, 15 an Cèitean, VE 881.

55. ◇ Same person *A fire-bearer brings a false answer*, 16 an Giblean, VE 882.

56. ◇ Same person *Diarmad narrows his question*, 5 an t-Samhain, VE 884.

57. ◇ Same person *A fire-bearer brings word of a grove where the wind speaks*, 8 an t-Sultain, VE 886.

58. ◇ Same person *Diarmad presses the fire-bearer for the herder's words*, 7 an Dàmhair, VE 886.

59. ◇ Same person *Fionnghuala silences the joke at her own hearth*, 15 an Cèitean, VE 881.

60. ◇ Same person *Fionnghuala gives Diarmad the rainbow piece for the road*, 31 am Faoilleach, VE 889.

- 5 AM MÀRT, VE 889** — *A gale overtakes Diarmad on the open moor.* On the second day of his walk a hard west wind rises over the high moor and does not slacken, and Diarmad pushes on through it regardless, his food too scant to spare for waiting out weather.⁶¹
- 3 AN GIBLEAN, VE 889** — *Diarmad reaches the grove's edge in the gale.* On the third afternoon Diarmad comes under the first oaks of the grove he has walked three days to find, and shelters at a fallen trunk with a small fire, listening to a gale in the branches that sounds, to his tired ear, less like wind than like many voices speaking at once.⁶²
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 890** — *Diarmad reaches Doire ghlais after three days on the road* (Doire ghlais). After three days walking north-west from Tobar dhìreach, footsore and short of food, Diarmad comes down into the oak grove at Doire ghlais in the last light with a gale already roaring in the crowns of the trees.⁶³
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 890** — *Diarmad builds his fire in the lee of a fallen oak* (Doire ghlais). In the shelter of a fallen trunk's torn roots, the one spot in the gale-driven grove where a small fire might live, Diarmad builds a fire of oak twigs from an ember he has carried the whole way from Tobar dhìreach in a moss-packed pot.⁶⁴
- 17 AN GEARRAN, VE 890** — *The Keeper in the grove* (Doire ghlais). In the oak grove at Doire ghlais a figure of grey smoke comes to Diarmad of the Mason's line, who has asked why the coal of the vein has colours. It names itself Coimhdeach na Fine⁶⁵, the kin's keeper, and tells him of the making of the world by Caoran, the Young God, and of the gift hidden in the coal. Asked how the colours may be opened, it gives a riddle: the sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit; merge the spirits, and they become almighty. From Diarmad's line the telling of the making goes to every hearth.⁶⁶
- 19 AN GEARRAN, VE 890** — *A grey figure stands still in the gale* (Doire ghlais). Across Diarmad's fire a figure of grey smoke, the height of a tall man, stands unmoving in a wind that flattens the flame and tears every leaf and branch in the grove; Diarmad does not run, and asks it what it is.⁶⁷

61. ◇ Same person *Diarmad walks north from Tobar dhìreach*, 1 am Màrt, VE 889.

62. ◇ Same person *A gale overtakes Diarmad on the open moor*, 5 am Màrt, VE 889.

63. ◇ Same person *Diarmad reaches the grove's edge in the gale*, 3 an Giblean, VE 889.

64. ◇ Same person *Diarmad reaches Doire ghlais after three days on the road*, 12 am Faoilleach, VE 890.

65. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

66. → Caused by *Diarmad first asks why the pieces are coloured*, 15 an Cèitean, VE 869; → Caused by *A fire-bearer brings word of a grove where the wind speaks*, 8 an t-Sultain, VE 886; → Caused by *Fionnghuala gives Diarmad the rainbow piece for the road*, 31 am Faoilleach, VE 889; → Caused by *Diarmad walks north from Tobar dhìreach*, 1 am Màrt, VE 889; → Caused by *Diarmad reaches the grove's edge in the gale*, 3 an Giblean, VE 889; → Caused by *Diarmad reaches Doire ghlais after three days on the road*, 12 am Faoilleach, VE 890; → Caused by *Diarmad builds his fire in the lee of a fallen oak*, 30 am Faoilleach, VE 890.

67. ← Follows from *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *Diarmad builds his fire in the lee of a fallen oak*, 30 am Faoilleach, VE 890.

- 11 AM MÀRT, VE 890** — *Coimhdeach na Fine*⁶⁸ names itself to Diarmad (Doire ghlas). The figure names itself Coimhdeach na Fine, the keeper of the kin, made from the smoke of the first coal an Dia Òg⁶⁹ woke, watching the island's people for the one who made them; it tells Diarmad it has watched his line since the mason and bids him ask his question.⁷⁰
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, VE 890** — *Diarmad bears Aithris a' Chruthachaidh*⁷¹ (Doire ghlas). Coimhdeach na Fine⁷² tells Diarmad the whole Aithris a' Chruthachaidh, from Caoran's choosing of coal to the shaping of the world and the island's own birth of fire, and of the seven spirits hidden colour by colour in the vein under the mountains.⁷³
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, VE 890** — *Diarmad asks whether an Dia Òg*⁷⁴ was angry (Doire ghlas). Shamed by the telling of how an Dia-shluagh⁷⁵ once found the coloured stones and let them fall back into the heather unknown, Diarmad asks Coimhdeach na Fine⁷⁶ whether an Dia Òg was angry at the forgetting; Coimhdeach na Fine answers that he only laughed, for a gift not opened is still given.⁷⁷
- 16 AN CÈITEAN, VE 890** — *Coimhdeach na Fine*⁷⁸ gives Diarmad *Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich*⁷⁹ (Doire ghlas). Asked why Teine a' Chlachair⁸⁰ burned the colour out of every coal alike, Coimhdeach na Fine answers that they are burned all in one fire and none in its own, and gives Diarmad *Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich* of the sky, the earth and the sea, first in the old words and then in his own tongue.⁸¹
- 27 AN CÈITEAN, VE 890** — *Coimhdeach na Fine*⁸² leaves Diarmad by his dying fire (Doire ghlas). When Diarmad calls *Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich*⁸³ no answer, Coimhdeach na Fine tells him it is the one it was given to give, and the wind that had gone round it all night long passes through the place where it stood and finds nothing there.⁸⁴

68. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

69. the Young God, Caoran

70. ← Follows from *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *A grey figure stands still in the gale*, 19 an Gearran, VE 890.

71. the Telling of the Making

72. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

73. ← Follows from *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *Coimhdeach na Fine names itself to Diarmad*, 11 am Màrt, VE 890.

74. the Young God, Caoran

75. the godfolk; lit. 'the god-host'

76. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

77. ← Follows from *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *Diarmad bears Aithris a' Chruthachaidh*, 30 an Giblean, VE 890.

78. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

79. the Keeper's riddle

80. the mason's fire, the first fire

81. ← Follows from *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *Diarmad asks whether an Dia Òg was angry*, 7 an Cèitean, VE 890.

82. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

83. the Keeper's riddle

84. ← Follows from *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *Coimhdeach na Fine gives Diarmad Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 890.

- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 890** — *Diarmad tries Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich*⁸⁵ *alone against sky, earth and fire* (Doire ghlais). Unwilling to leave the grove, Diarmad spends two days trying gual bogha-froise⁸⁶ by himself: held up to a gap of open sky, buried in the wet earth by the fallen trunk, and set back into his own small fire alone, with no sea near enough to try and none of the other six coals in hand.⁸⁷
- 23 AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 890** — *Diarmad speaks Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich*⁸⁸ *over the bare coal* (Doire ghlais). On the second morning Diarmad kneels and speaks Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich's words aloud over the coal laid bare on the fallen trunk's bark; nothing in it changes, and he gives up trying it alone after that.⁸⁹
- 1 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 890** — *Diarmad turns south for Tobar dbireach* (Doire ghlais). After two days failing to open Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁹⁰ alone, Diarmad banks his fire under turf, wraps gual bogha-froise⁹¹ back against his chest, and sets out on the three-day road home, saying the words over to himself so as not to lose them.⁹²
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 890** — *Diarmad returns to Tobar dbireach*. Diarmad comes down into the high valleys on the evening of the third day with Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁹³ whole in him and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁹⁴ unopened, not yet sure which of the two the hearths of his own kin will find harder to believe.⁹⁵
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 890** — *The dead leaves go round Coimhdeach na Fine*⁹⁶ (Doire ghlais). In the gale at Doire ghlais the dead leaves streaming past Diarmad's fire go round the place where the smoke-figure stands, as water goes round a rock, and meet again beyond it.⁹⁷
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 890** — *Diarmad sees the forgotten coal* (Doire ghlais). In Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁹⁸ Diarmad sees a child of an Dia-shluagh⁹⁹ carry coloured stones home in her cloak and a whole valley throw them away as the mountain's droppings, and is ashamed for them.¹⁰⁰

85. the Keeper's riddle

86. the rainbow coal, of spirit

87. ← Follows from *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *Coimhdeach na Fine leaves Diarmad by his dying fire*, 27 an Cèitean, VE 890.

88. the Keeper's riddle

89. ← Follows from *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *Diarmad tries Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich alone against sky, earth and fire*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, VE 890.

90. the Keeper's riddle

91. the rainbow coal, of spirit

92. ← Follows from *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *Diarmad speaks Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich over the bare coal*, 23 an t-Iuchar, VE 890.

93. the Telling of the Making

94. the Keeper's riddle

95. ← Follows from *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *Diarmad turns south for Tobar dbireach*, 1 an Lùnastal, VE 890.

96. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

97. ⇌ At the same time *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *Diarmad returns to Tobar dbireach*, 19 an Lùnastal, VE 890.

98. the Telling of the Making

99. the godfolk; lit. 'the god-host'

- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 890** — *A wren comes to the coal* (Doire ghlas). On his second morning alone in the grove a wren hops along the fallen trunk to within a hand of gual bogha-froise¹⁰¹, looks at it and at Diarmad, and goes about its business; Diarmad does not try Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹⁰² again that day.¹⁰³
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 890** — *Diarmad says Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹⁰⁴ over on the road*. All the first day of the walk home Diarmad says Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich aloud, the strange words and the plain, over and over, the way a man says a name so as not to lose it before he reaches the house.¹⁰⁵
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 890** — *Diarmad tells Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹⁰⁶ at his own hearth*. Home from Doire ghlas, Diarmad stands at the hearth of Tobar dhreach and tells the household the bones of what Coimhdeach na Fine¹⁰⁷ gave him: the making of the island from drops of fire, the gift buried and thrown away, and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹⁰⁸ of the sky, the earth and the sea.¹⁰⁹
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 890** — *The hearth's laughter*. A kinsman of Tadhg's line by marriage laughs Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹¹⁰ off as three days' talk with an empty grove, and the household laughs with him, gently, glad to have its world handed back the shape it always was.¹¹¹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 890** — *Niamh will not believe it*. Told Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹¹² in full, alone, Diarmad's wife Niamh hears him out and says plainly that hunger and cold on an empty moor can put much into a man's head that has no business there, and that she does not believe a word of it.¹¹³
- 17 AM MÀRT, VE 892** — *Diarmad begins gathering the fathers' names*. Diarmad takes up a second labour beside Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹¹⁴, walking hearth to hearth among the wider kin of the high valleys and the northern moor to ask each house how far back it can say its fathers' names, keeping no name a house cannot answer for.¹¹⁵

100. ⇔ At the same time *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *The dead leaves go round Coimhdeach na Fine*, 21 an Lùnastal, VE 890.

101. the rainbow coal, of spirit

102. the Keeper's riddle

103. ◇ Same person *Diarmad sees the forgotten coal*, 8 an Dàmhair, VE 890.

104. the Keeper's riddle

105. ◇ Same person *A wren comes to the coal*, 17 an Dàmhair, VE 890.

106. the Telling of the Making

107. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

108. the Keeper's riddle

109. ← Follows from *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *Diarmad says Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich over on the road*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 890.

110. the Telling of the Making

111. ◇ Same person *Diarmad tells Aithris a' Chruthachaidh at his own hearth*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, VE 890.

112. the Telling of the Making

113. ◇ Same person *The hearth's laughter*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, VE 890.

114. the Telling of the Making

115. ◇ Same person *Niamh will not believe it*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, VE 890.

- 15 AN GIBLEAN, VE 893** — *Old women give up the fathers' names.* Old women who never troubled themselves over Diarmad's question turn out to have kept four and five fathers' names back, and are glad to give them to someone willing to carry the weight of remembering them.¹¹⁶
- 14 AN CÈITEAN, VE 895** — *The first recital of the Line.* On Oidhche an Dealanaich¹¹⁷ Diarmad stands at his own hearth and says the fathers' names from Neachdan to himself without a stumble, and Niamh, unbelieving still, stands after him and says Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹¹⁸ in full because a house should hear whole what its head carries.¹¹⁹
- 23 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 895** — *Niamh says Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹²⁰ after the Line* (Tobar dhreach). At the first standing of the Line Niamh stands after her husband and says Aithris a' Chruthachaidh, though she does not yet believe it, holding that a house ought to hear the whole of what its head carries.¹²¹
- 21 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 897** — *Diarmad takes up Poit an Teine¹²²* (Tobar dhreach). On his mother's death Diarmad takes the keeping of Poit an Teine alongside the keeping of the names and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹²³, three weights on one back.¹²⁴
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 900** — *Niamh comes to believe.* In the tenth year after Diarmad's return, Niamh tells their daughter that she has come to believe Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹²⁵ without ever deciding to, the way a path comes to lie worn into a hillside with no single footstep marked as the one that made it.¹²⁶
- 18 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 902** — *Fionnghuala dies keeping Poit an Teine¹²⁷.* Diarmad's mother Fionnghuala dies in her own bed with Poit an Teine within reach of her hand, as she had asked, and Diarmad takes up the keeping of the pot himself alongside the names and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich^{128, 129}.
- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 903** — *The dark coals tried in driving rain.* At a standing of the Line the kin lay four dark coals bare on the hillside through a night of hard rain, on the thought that rain is the sky's own water as much as the sea's, and find them in the morning only wet, cold and themselves.¹³⁰

116. ◇ Same person *Diarmad begins gathering the fathers' names*, 17 am Màrt, VE 892.

117. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

118. the Telling of the Making

119. ◇ Same person *Old women give up the fathers' names*, 15 an Giblean, VE 893.

120. the Telling of the Making

121. ◇ Same person *The first recital of the Line*, 14 an Cèitean, VE 895.

122. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

123. the Keeper's riddle

124. ◇ Same person *Niamh says Aithris a' Chruthachaidh after the Line*, 23 an Dàmhair, VE 895.

125. the Telling of the Making

126. ◇ Same person *Niamh says Aithris a' Chruthachaidh after the Line*, 23 an Dàmhair, VE 895.

127. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

128. the Keeper's riddle

129. ◇ Same person *Diarmad takes up Poit an Teine*, 21 an t-Samhain, VE 897.

130. ◇ Same person *Fionnghuala dies keeping Poit an Teine*, 18 am Faoilleach, VE 902.

- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 904** — *The coals held up into the gale.* The kin carry the leather bag onto the ridge above Tobar dhìreach on a night of hard wind and hold the coals up bare-handed into it, on the thought that the sky's spirit might answer to its own true weather; the wind passes them by unchanged.¹³¹
- 11 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 905** — *All seven burned together in one fire.* Reasoning that Tòimh-seachan a' Choimhdich¹³²'s merging might mean the coals themselves rather than their elements, the kin burn all seven together in the hearth-fire and watch them go down black and ordinary together, no brighter for the company.¹³³
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 905** — *Sea-water carried inland for the trial.* A skin of true sea-water is carried the long way from the south shore to Tobar dhìreach and poured over the dark coals in a stone basin, the nearest the inland line can come to the sea itself; it wets them and leaves them cold, as the rain had.¹³⁴
- 12 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 910** — *Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹³⁵ carried to the northern moor.* A fire-bearer who has heard Aithris a' Chruthachaidh three times at Tobar dhìreach carries it unasked to a hearth on the northern moor, and tells it there in his own words, some pieces lost and others changed in the carrying.
- 14 AN CÈITEAN, VE 920** — *Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹³⁶ reaches the eastern hearths.* By the thirtieth year after Diarmad's walk to the grove, traders carry some shape of Aithris a' Chruthachaidh to nearly every hearth of the eastern farms, garbled in a dozen small ways but keeping, in each, the one true thing: that the coal holds a gift no one has yet opened.
- 15 AN GIBLEAN, VE 925** — *A garbled riddle comes back from the east.* A trader newly down from the east gives Diarmad a telling of his own riddle in which the sea and the sky have changed places and the earth has dropped out; Diarmad sits a long while after, struck by how far a true thing can travel.¹³⁷
- 17 AM MÀRT, VE 931** — *Diarmad dies sure the answer is near.* Diarmad dies at his hearth with Poit an Teine¹³⁸ near him and the six dark coals and the rainbow at his side, telling Niamh he is sure the answer is nearer than it has ever been, though he cannot say what has brought the nearness home to him.¹³⁹

131. ◇ Same person *The dark coals tried in driving rain*, 29 an t-Ògmhios, VE 903.

132. the Keeper's riddle

133. ◇ Same person *The coals held up into the gale*, 28 an t-Iuchar, VE 904.

134. ◇ Same person *All seven burned together in one fire*, 11 an t-Iuchar, VE 905.

135. the Telling of the Making

136. the Telling of the Making

137. ◇ Same person *Sea-water carried inland for the trial*, 9 an Lùnastal, VE 905.

138. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

139. ◇ Same person *A garbled riddle comes back from the east*, 15 an Giblean, VE 925.

- 16 AN GEARRAN, VE 940** — *Deirbhile fixes Aithris a' Chruthachaidh*¹⁴⁰ *word for word*. Diarmad's daughter Deirbhile, keeping Aithris a' Chruthachaidh more exactly than her father ever told it, teaches it word for word to her own children and to any of the wider kin who will learn it as strictly as she asks.
- 18 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 945** — *Deirbhile teaches Aithris a' Chruthachaidh*¹⁴¹ *a section at a time* (Tobar dhireach). Deirbhile sits each of her children down in turn and makes them say Aithris a' Chruthachaidh back to her a section at a time until they have it as clean as she does, and teaches it so to any of the kin who will sit still for the whole.¹⁴²
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 950** — *Aithris a' Chruthachaidh*¹⁴³ *said at an eastern hearth*. Three mouths removed from Deirbhile, a woman of an eastern household with no claim on the Line beyond distant kinship says Aithris a' Chruthachaidh standing on the darkest night, and tells a child who asks what Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹⁴⁴ means that it is a question for An Clachair¹⁴⁵'s own line to answer.¹⁴⁶
- I AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 951** — *The mole at Seann Skell*¹⁴⁷ (Seann Skell). A mole of unmortared boulders is laid out into the Abhainn naomh from the bank at Seann Skell, long enough to shelter a dozen boats from the current. Its foot lies under water still at the lowest tides, and every quay wall built there since stands on it.
- 31 AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 951** — *The old man begins choosing stones at Skell*¹⁴⁸ (Seann Skell). On the first day of the warm month an old man of the river bank at Skell walks the shingle at first light and chooses, by a judgement none of the younger men beside him can name, the boulder that will be rolled and set as the first stone of a mole into the current.
- 21 AN GEARRAN, VE 955** — *The trying of Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich*¹⁴⁹ *is let rest at the mason's hearth*. After coals have been carried to unceasing rain, sunk in sea-water fetched home in skins, and set together seven at once in the hottest fire the line's hands can build, and have come out of every trial the same dull stones, Clann a' Chlachair¹⁵⁰ lets the trying rest, the leather bag closed and kept rather than opened again.¹⁵¹

140. the Telling of the Making

141. the Telling of the Making

142. ◇ Same person *Deirbhile fixes Aithris a' Chruthachaidh word for word*, 16 an Gearran, VE 940.

143. the Telling of the Making

144. the Keeper's riddle

145. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

146. ◇ Same person *Deirbhile teaches Aithris a' Chruthachaidh a section at a time*, 18 am Faoilleach, VE 945.

147. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

148. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

149. the Keeper's riddle

150. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

151. → Leads to *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890.

- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 958** — *A grandson stands against the current* (Seann Skell¹⁵²). A boy of the old man's own kin takes to standing chest-deep at the mole's outer edge on calm summer days, bracing his feet on the last stone set and letting the river push at him without giving ground, watched from the bank by a grandfather who says nothing of it either way.¹⁵³
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 960** — *The mole's first winter* (Seann Skell¹⁵⁴). By the turn of the second year the low ridge of unmortared boulders reaches far enough from the bank at Skell that boats which once beached in the open now lie sheltered in its lee, a dozen at a time on a hard night, and the households along that stretch stop thinking of their landing as open water.¹⁵⁵
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 962** — *The first slab set on the worst scramble at Bral*¹⁵⁶ (Seann Bhral). A woman of the grazing household above the western cliffs at Bral works a frost-loosened slab, over most of a season, into a single set step at the foot of the worst stretch of the scramble down to the shingle, wedging it level with smaller stones packed beneath.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 964** — *The first stone box raised for the dead of Vell*¹⁵⁷ (Eilean dhearg). A household of the low south-eastern headland rows one of its own dead out to the near island for the first time in a boat built broad enough for the crossing, and raises a box of four slabs and a lid over the body, its face set toward the mainland shore rather than the open sea beyond.
- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 966** — *The flood the mole holds against* (Seann Skell¹⁵⁸). A flood the old man says he has not seen the like of in all his years on the bank takes one small boat downstream and out of reach, but drives its whole weight against the mole's upstream face without shifting a single stone the old man has set, and the ridge stands scoured clean when the water falls.¹⁵⁹
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, VE 968** — *Other households ask for the same lee* (Seann Skell¹⁶⁰). After the flood, households that had watched the mole rise from a distance come to the old man and ask to have their own landings brought under its shelter, and he sets them to the rolling and placing exactly as he learned it, so the work outgrows any one household's hands.¹⁶¹
- 8 AN GIBLEAN, VE 975** — *The old stone-judge counts the boats coming in* (Seann Skell¹⁶²). In his last summers, too stiff to walk the bank at first light, the old man who began the mole at Skell sits above the river of an evening and counts the boats coming in under its lee.¹⁶³

152. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

153. → Leads to *The mole at Seann Skell*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 951.

154. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

155. → Leads to *The mole at Seann Skell*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 951.

156. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

157. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

158. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

159. → Leads to *The mole at Seann Skell*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 951.

160. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

161. → Leads to *The mole at Seann Skell*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 951.

162. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

163. ← Follows from *The mole at Seann Skell*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 951.

THE YEARS VE 1,001 – 1,500

- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 1,005** — *The steps reach the first shelf at Bral¹* (Seann Bhral). Cut a slab at a time in whatever season allows it, the steps from the shingle at Bral now run unbroken to a shelf a third of the way up the cliff, wide enough for two to pass, while above it the bare scramble still wants both hands free.
- 7 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,012** — *A boy runs the finished stretch without a hand to the rock* (Seann Bhral). Sent down for shellfish on a morning the household is short-handed, a boy runs the whole finished stretch of the Bral² steps down and up again without once touching the rock, and laughs at the top of it while the women above, none of whom has ever gone that way without a hand out, laugh with him.
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 1,027** — *The steps of Seann Bhral* (Seann Bhral). Two hundred and twelve steps are cut up the cliff at Seann Bhral, from the shingle to the grazing above. Their treads are worn hollow in the middle. How many feet that took, none has reckoned.³
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 1,040** — *The steps above the shelf go slower* (Seann Bhral). Above the first shelf at Bral⁴ the rock runs harder and gives up fewer slabs, and a worker of the household spends a whole season on a stretch of a dozen feet that yields three steps.⁵
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 1,060** — *An old woman rests her hand on the topmost step* (Seann Bhral). An old woman of Bral⁶ sits of an evening on the shelf a third of the way up the cliff and runs her hand along the edge of the topmost step then cut, saying of the rock above only that it will come when it comes.
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,080** — *The two hundred and twelfth step is cut at Bral⁷* (Seann Bhral). The steps from the shingle to the grazing above Bral are finished at two hundred and twelve, cut across three generations of hands that never once all worked in the same season, the last stretch of hard rock giving up only three steps for a whole season's work.
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,090** — *The treads of Bral⁸ wear hollow* (Seann Bhral). The lower steps at Bral, cut soonest and used longest, wear a shallow dish into their middles before the upper steps have worn at all.⁹

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

3. → Caused by *The first slab set on the worst scramble at Bral*, 2 an Lùnastal, VE 962; → Caused by *The steps reach the first shelf at Bral*, 9 am Faoilleach, VE 1,005; → Caused by *A boy runs the finished stretch without a hand to the rock*, 7 an Gearran, VE 1,012.

4. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

5. → Leads to *The steps of Seann Bhral*, 30 an t-Iuchar, VE 1,027.

6. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

7. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

8. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

9. ← Follows from *The steps of Seann Bhral*, 30 an t-Iuchar, VE 1,027.

- 4 **AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,096** — *The dead of Seann Vell*¹⁰ go to Eilean dhearg (Eilean dhearg). The Seann-Dhaoine¹¹ of Seann Vell row their dead out to Eilean dhearg and lay them in stone boxes facing the mainland. Forty boxes are counted there. No grave of theirs of this time is found on the mainland.¹²
- 8 **AM MÀRT, VE 1,100** — *The recital said to a gathering that came unsent-for*. On the dark-of-the-year night the keeper of An Clachair¹³'s hearth stands to say the fathers' names before a gathering that has walked up from the lower valleys of its own will, without any household sending word ahead, and says Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹⁴ after as she has said it every year, and closes the bag again unopened.¹⁵
- 6 **AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,100** — *No grave left open through a night on Eilean dhearg* (Eilean dhearg). The households of Vell¹⁶ will not let a stone box stand open through a night; an unfinished box is covered with brush and stone until the true lid can be rowed across.¹⁷
- 22 **AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,131** — *A woman rows her mother out, then her daughter* (Eilean dhearg). A woman of the same shore rows her own mother's body to the island one autumn and her own daughter's the spring after, and is remembered to have gone to the boat the second time with a face that told the household this crossing was not, for her, a labour like any other.¹⁸
- 20 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,169** — *The fortieth box is counted at Vell*¹⁹ (Eilean dhearg). By whatever reckoning that shore keeps among itself, the box set in this season is counted the fortieth to stand on the low ground of the island, its lid laid last and turned, like every lid before it, back toward the water it was rowed across.
- 2 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,170** — *The fish-channel of Seann Toll*²⁰ (Seann Toll). At Seann Toll a channel is cut through a shelf of rock into a pool beside the Abhainn uaine, with a slot for a wattle gate. When the river falls the gate is dropped and the pool emptied by hand. The slot is sharp still.
- 19 **AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 1,175** — *The channel at Toll*²¹ cut through to the pool (Seann Toll). At Toll a household finishes widening a natural crack in a rock shelf into a channel between the still water above and a tide-fed pool below, following the crack's own line rather than cutting fresh through sound stone.²²

10. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

11. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

12. → Caused by *The first stone box raised for the dead of Vell*, 28 an Dàmhair, VE 964.

13. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

14. the Keeper's riddle

15. → Leads to *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890.

16. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

17. ← Follows from *The dead of Seann Vell go to Eilean dhearg*, 4 an Cèitean, VE 1,096.

18. → Leads to *The dead of Seann Vell go to Eilean dhearg*, 4 an Cèitean, VE 1,096.

19. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

20. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

21. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

22. → Leads to *The fish-channel of Seann Toll*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,170.

- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,176** — *The careful cutter begins his rows at Tarr*²³ (Seann Tarr). Along the pale cliffs above Tarr a man of that shore's trade begins cutting rows of signs into the standing rock with a flaked flint chisel and a small stone hammer, each stroke light enough to take the chisel through a shape without lifting it.
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,178** — *The slots cut for the wattle gate* (Seann Toll²⁴). Deep slots are picked into the rock on either side of the channel's narrowest place at Toll, true from above the river's highest mark to below its lowest, so that a woven gate can be driven home and drawn again season by season.²⁵
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,180** — *The Toll*²⁶ *gate first dropped* (Seann Toll). The wattle gate is driven home into the slots at Toll for the first time, one man in the channel to guide its foot and two above on the mallet, penning the fish left behind by the ebb in the pool below for the household to take by hand.
- 25 AM MÀRT, VE 1,183** — *Shell first carried out onto the sunken reed track* (Seann Warr²⁷). At the western shore of Loch chrom, after a wet season sinks the worn reed track sooner than most years, broken mussel shell is carried out and trodden into the worst of the sunken ground for the first time, rather than left by the shallows where it was worked.
- 24 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,185** — *A child learns the channel by her feet* (Seann Toll²⁸). A child of the Toll household is led by the hand along the smoothed floor of the fish channel at low water until her feet know which stretch stands firm and which gives, without a word for it.²⁹
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 1,190** — *A boy watches an afternoon of the cutting* (Seann Tarr³⁰). A boy sits a whole afternoon at the foot of the Tarr cliff watching the careful cutter's hand, and counts, by a later telling, near two hundred light strokes of the hammer to finish a single sign.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 1,197** — *The carrying of shell becomes yearly work* (Seann Warr³¹). What began as one season's answer to a bad sinking becomes, without any one choice remembered for it, a thing the loch household does each year: crushed shell carried out and packed into the worst stretches of the reed crossing on the same errand that gathers the day's mussel.

23. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

24. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

25. → Leads to *The fish-channel of Seann Toll*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,170.

26. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

27. the Old Ones' root (burgs 64, 128)

28. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

29. ← Follows from *The fish-channel of Seann Toll*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,170.

30. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

31. the Old Ones' root (burgs 64, 128)

- 8 AM MÀRT, VE 1,198** — *A boy loses two fingers to the mallet* (Seann Toll³²). Misjudging the moment to clear the mallet's swing at the Toll gate, a boy of the household loses two fingers of his left hand; he goes on working the gate in the years after with the hand that remains him.³³
- 7 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,200** — *The gate dropped three times in a dry summer* (Seann Toll³⁴). In a summer when the river falls low and stays low the Toll household drops and draws its gate three times before the autumn rains, and reckons the late summer by the droppings rather than by days.
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 1,210** — *Shell crushed before carrying* (Seann Warr³⁵). The loch household at Warr crushes the mussel shell underfoot on a flat stone kept by the water before carrying it out, having found that crushed shell packs and holds where whole shell slides.
- 24 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,220** — *The reed-marsh flood* (Seann Warr³⁶). A hard winter's water works thin the shell already laid on the western marsh crossing at Loch chrom, and the household spends the following spring re-packing the low places before the road can be trusted at a run again.
- 7 AM MÀRT, VE 1,233** — *The shell causeway of Seann Warr*³⁷ (Seann Warr). A road of crushed shell is laid across the reed marsh at Seann Warr, on the western shore of Loch chrom, a little over a mile long and raised a forearm above the reeds. It is the eldest made road on the island that may still be walked.³⁸
- 25 AM MÀRT, VE 1,236** — *A girl runs the whole shell road at once* (Seann Warr³⁹). Sent to carry word that the boats are wanted in before dark, a girl of the loch household crosses the whole finished length of the shell road at a run without once testing the ground with a toe, the first so remembered to trust it end to end.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,240** — *An old row cut over and broken* (Seann Tarr⁴⁰). Somewhere along the Tarr cliff a first cutting is found deepened and cut across by a later hand, worked with the same patient care as the row it undoes; no one of that shore is remembered ever claiming to know why.

32. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

33. → Leads to *The fish-channel of Seann Toll*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,170.

34. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

35. the Old Ones' root (burgs 64, 128)

36. the Old Ones' root (burgs 64, 128)

37. the Old Ones' root (burgs 64, 128)

38. → Caused by *Shell first carried out onto the sunken reed track*, 25 am Màrt, VE 1,183; → Caused by *The carrying of shell becomes yearly work*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, VE 1,197; → Caused by *Shell crushed before carrying*, 26 am Faoilleach, VE 1,210; → Caused by *The reed-marsh flood*, 24 an Gearran, VE 1,220.

39. the Old Ones' root (burgs 64, 128)

40. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 1,250** — *A northern-shore family comes to see the road* (Seann Warr⁴¹). A household from further round Loch chrom's northern shore walks the finished road from end to end and home again, but goes the long way about on their own crossing rather than tread the loch household's shell a second time.⁴²
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 1,260** — *The road left to its builders* (Seann Warr⁴³). The household that laid the shell road keeps it as a household keeps a hearth, and a stranger's foot on another household's shell is not a thing lightly done on that shore.⁴⁴
- 5 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,301** — *The script appears at Seann Tarr*⁴⁵ (Seann Tarr). Rows of signs are cut into the cliff above Seann Tarr, in the script that is found afterwards on the standing stones. It is not Dia-thiris, and none has read it. No sign of it has a meaning that all accept.⁴⁶
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 1,301** — *The first row cut on the cliff at Tarr*⁴⁷ (Seann Tarr). A man of the cliff shore at Tarr finishes a row of signs cut into the standing rock with a flint chisel, each sign some two hundred light blows of the hammer, and begins a second above it.⁴⁸
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 1,320** — *More rows cut at Tarr*⁴⁹ (Seann Tarr). By the time the careful cutter's hand has grown unsteady with age, the rows above Tarr run further along the face than any one person standing at its foot can take in with a single turn of the head, and no later hand takes up the cutting with the same close care.
- 15 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 1,330** — *A woman of Toll*⁵⁰ *walks the coast and finds the cliff* (Seann Toll). On an errand along the coast a woman of the Toll household comes to the cliff at Tarr⁵¹ and stands a while in the rain watching it darken the newest of the cut rows against the paler stone around them, before going on her way without speaking of it at either household she passes between.⁵²
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 1,344** — *Aodh born at Tobar dhireach*. Aodh is born into Clann a' Chlachair⁵³ at Tobar dhireach, into a hearth that has by then said Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁵⁴ at every recital for near five hundred years without once carrying gual òir⁵⁵ to the sea it is said to answer.

41. the Old Ones' root (burgs 64, 128)

42. → Leads to *The shell causeway of Seann Warr*, 7 am Màrt, VE 1,233.

43. the Old Ones' root (burgs 64, 128)

44. ← Follows from *The shell causeway of Seann Warr*, 7 am Màrt, VE 1,233.

45. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

46. → Caused by *The careful cutter begins his rows at Tarr*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,176; → Caused by *A boy watches an afternoon of the cutting*, 26 am Faoilleach, VE 1,190; → Caused by *An old row cut over and broken*, 23 an Giblean, VE 1,240.

47. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

48. ⇌ At the same time *The script appears at Seann Tarr*, 5 an Giblean, VE 1,301.

49. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

50. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

51. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

52. → Leads to *The script appears at Seann Tarr*, 5 an Giblean, VE 1,301.

53. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

54. the Keeper's riddle

55. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

- 5 **AN LÙNASTAL, VE 1,353** — *A traveller names the sea to Aodh*. A trader up from the eastern farms speaks in passing of grey water without a far shore, and Aodh, nine years old, asks him plainly whether he has seen it; it is the first time the boy understands the sea for more than a word said at the recital.
- 7 **AN T-IUCHAR, VE 1,360** — *Aodh works the harvest before going* (Tobar dhíreach). Asked by Muirgheal to wait until the barley is in and the beasts settled, Aodh works that harvest with more will than any before it, as a man works to leave a thing clean behind him.
- 2 **AN DÀMHAIR, VE 1,364** — *Aodh tells Muirgheal he means to walk north*. At twenty Aodh tells Muirgheal, keeper of Poit an Teine⁵⁶ at Tobar dhíreach, that he means to carry gual òir⁵⁷ to the sea before another generation lets Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁵⁸ lie; she does not laugh, and asks only that he wait until the harvest is in.
- 3 **AN T-SULTAIN, VE 1,369** — *Muirgheal bids Aodh take all seven* (Tobar dhíreach). Muirgheal tells Aodh to carry all seven pieces to the sea and not the gold alone, since the seven came out of the mason's tunic together and ought to go together, so that whatever answers answers among its own.⁵⁹
- 17 **AN GEARRAN, VE 1,370** — *Aodh sets out for the northern shore*. With the harvest under thatch and the beasts driven in from the high pasture, Aodh sets out alone from Tobar dhíreach with all seven coals of the vein wrapped against his chest, walking north across the moor toward a sea he has never seen.
- 6 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,370** — *Aodh's first sight of the sea* (Ceann thais). Aodh comes over the last rise of the moor and stands before the open sea for the first time in his life, understanding only then, by its slow endless heave, why no telling at any hearth had ever thought the word alone enough to carry it.
- 14 **AN T-SULTAIN, VE 1,370** — *The gold coal takes fire on the sea* (Ceann thais). Aodh of the Mason's line carries the seven coals of the vein down to the northern shore, below where Ceann thais now stands, and throws them into the sea one by one. The coal with the sheen of gold takes fire on the water and burns gold until the waves put it under; the other six sink. It is the first of the Seven Coals to be lit from its own spirit.⁶⁰

56. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

57. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

58. the Keeper's riddle

59. ◇ Same person *Aodh works the harvest before going*, 7 an t-Iuchar, VE 1,360.

60. → Caused by *Aodh born at Tobar dhíreach*, 14 an Dàmhair, VE 1,344; → Caused by *A traveller names the sea to Aodh*, 5 an Lùnastal, VE 1,353; → Caused by *Aodh tells Muirgheal he means to walk north*, 2 an Dàmhair, VE 1,364; → Caused by *Muirgheal bids Aodh take all seven*, 3 an t-Sultain, VE 1,369; → Caused by *Aodh sets out for the northern shore*, 17 an Gearran, VE 1,370; → Caused by *Aodh's first sight of the sea*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,370.

- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 1,370** — *Gual òir takes fire on the sea* (Ceann thais). Aodh throws na Seachd Guail⁶¹ of the vein into the sea one by one from the northern shingle; six sink as any coal sinks, and the coal with the sheen of gold takes fire on the swell and burns gold until a breaker rolls it under.
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 1,370** — *Muirgheal weeps at the telling of the gold*. Hearing Aodh's account at the hearth of Tobar dhìreach, old Muirgheal weeps before the gathered kin, near five hundred years since the grove, and says that Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁶² is proved true: each coal answers to its own element.⁶³
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 1,370** — *The name gual òir⁶⁴ said at the recital*. For the first time since the mason's own well a new line is added to the recital after the fathers' names, telling of gual òir's lighting on the northern sea; from that night the piece is called gual òir at every telling that carries it on.⁶⁵
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 1,370** — *Word of gual òir⁶⁶ spreads from Tobar dhìreach*. Households a half-day's walk and more from Tobar dhìreach send someone to ask whether the telling of gual òir is true, and for days Poit an Teine⁶⁷'s door stands open near the whole day to let in one more household wanting to hear it from Aodh's own mouth.⁶⁸
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 1,370** — *Aodh sleeps a night above the tideline*. Aodh does not throw the coals on the evening he reaches the shore, but sleeps in a hollow above the tideline and listens all night to a sound he has never heard before.⁶⁹
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 1,370** — *A new line added to the recital* (Tobar dhìreach). For the first time since the mason a new line is added after the fathers' names at the recital: that gual òir⁷⁰ was thrown into the northern sea by Aodh and burned gold until the water put it under.⁷¹
- 1 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,375** — *Aodh tries the six coals against ground, water and air*. In the years after the gold, Aodh carries the six unanswered coals to hilltop, black peat and standing rainwater within a day's walk of Tobar dhìreach, and once holds one to the bare air in a hard frost, and none of them answers him.⁷²

61. the Seven Coals

62. the Keeper's riddle

63. ← Follows from *The gold coal takes fire on the sea*, 14 an t-Sultain, VE 1,370.

64. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

65. ← Follows from *The gold coal takes fire on the sea*, 14 an t-Sultain, VE 1,370.

66. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

67. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

68. ← Follows from *The gold coal takes fire on the sea*, 14 an t-Sultain, VE 1,370.

69. ◇ Same person *Muirgheal bids Aodh take all seven*, 3 an t-Sultain, VE 1,369.

70. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

71. ← Follows from *The gold coal takes fire on the sea*, 14 an t-Sultain, VE 1,370; ◇ Same person *Aodh sleeps a night above the tideline*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, VE 1,370.

72. ← Follows from *The gold coal takes fire on the sea*, 14 an t-Sultain, VE 1,370.

- 30 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,381** — *Muirgheal dies at Tobar dhìreach*. Muirgheal, keeper of Poit an Teine⁷³, dies an old woman having lived to hear the sea answer and wept for it; she is carried out and laid as her own mother was before her, the hearth-fire kept burning the whole night through.⁷⁴
- 4 AM MÀRT, VE 1,395** — *The six held up in a hard frost*. Aodh holds the six dark pieces up on an open palm in a hard frost, as Diarmad was said to have held the rainbow to the sky, and the bare air does not answer.⁷⁵
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,412** — *Aodh dies at Tobar dhìreach*. Aodh dies at eight-and-sixty years with the six unanswered coals still kept under his own hand; the recital adds his name after the fathers' names down from Neachdan, and tells that six of the seven still wait to be answered.⁷⁶
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 1,420** — *New pieces of the vein found in the stream-bank*. A boy of Aodh's own house, following a strayed goat below Tobar dhìreach, finds the black vein showing bare in a stream-bank cut fresh by a hard season's rain, and the line for the first time since Neachdan holds more coal than the seven old pieces kept in the leather bag.⁷⁷
- 3 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,421** — *The new pieces passed hand to hand at the recital* (Tobar dhìreach). At the recital after the stream-bank finding the fresh pieces of the vein are passed round the gathered kin before the fire is banked, so that every soul there may hold a piece not yet tried against anything.
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,443** — *The fish-kilns of Seann Mhorn* (Seann Mhorn). Stone-lined pits with short flues are built above the beach at Seann Mhorn, to dry the catch over peat smoke. Seven are known. They are the first buildings on Dia-thìr made for a trade, and not for sleep or for the dead.
- 21 AM MÀRT, VE 1,446** — *The seventh kiln-pit dug at Morn*⁷⁸ (Seann Mhorn). A household of the Seann-Dhaoine⁷⁹ finishes a seventh stone-lined smoking pit above the shingle at Morn, each fed by a short turf-cut flue and kept for smoke and not flame, the first buildings raised on Dia-thìr for a trade rather than a hearth.⁸⁰
- 20 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,450** — *The kiln smoke seen from inland* (Seann Mhorn). Herders of the inland hearths mark a grey column standing over the coast on still mornings and take it for a weather of that shore alone, not knowing for some years that it is a fire kept low and smouldering on purpose, day upon day, to dry a catch too great for one winter's eating.⁸¹

73. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

74. ← Follows from *The gold coal takes fire on the sea*, 14 an t-Sultain, VE 1,370.

75. ◇ Same person *A new line added to the recital*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, VE 1,370.

76. ← Follows from *The gold coal takes fire on the sea*, 14 an t-Sultain, VE 1,370.

77. ‡ Legacy *The gold coal takes fire on the sea*, 14 an t-Sultain, VE 1,370.

78. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

79. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

80. → Leads to *The fish-kilns of Seann Mhorn*, 17 an Giblean, VE 1,443.

- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 1,455** — *A kiln is fed with dry peat only* (Seann Mhorn). The keeper of the kilns at Morn⁸² keeps a store of dry peat under an overhang of turf for the kiln fires alone, holding that green peat flares where dry peat smokes, and a flare undoes a season's catch.⁸³
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 1,461** — *The fourth pit drowned in a night's rain* (Seann Mhorn). A gale drives rain sideways off the bay at Morn⁸⁴ and puts out the fourth kiln before the keeper's last round; she lets the pit stand cold rather than relight it under a soaked load, and carries the spoiled catch to the gulls at the tideline.⁸⁵
- 15 AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 1,467** — *The ninth kiln set higher against the rain* (Seann Mhorn). The keeper of Morn⁸⁶'s kilns digs a ninth pit set higher on the rise than the first seven, its flue longer and angled harder against a driving rain, after a wet night once cost the household a whole pit's catch.⁸⁷
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,470** — *The keeper teaches the wet-night watch to her niece* (Seann Mhorn). The keeper of the kilns teaches her niece to watch a kiln past the hour she would go to bed on a night of gathering rain, since a fire low enough to smoke is near enough to going out that a hard rain can take it.
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,478** — *The first ramp-slab laid at Brenn*⁸⁸ (Seann Bhrenn). A household of skin-boat builders on the north coast begins laying flat slabs down a shelf of stone at Brenn from above the highest tide to deep water, meaning to draw down a load heavier than any hide boat's frame.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 1,483** — *A ramp-slab relaid twice at Brenn*⁸⁹ (Seann Bhrenn). Twice a slab of the new ramp at Brenn settles crooked overnight where the ground beneath it runs soft, and is levered up with poles of green oak and reset on stone packed hard by hand and heel, without complaint from the household doing it.
- 1 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 1,499** — *The first ramp at Brenn*⁹⁰ *finished* (Seann Bhrenn). The first ramp at Brenn stands finished its whole length, laid true enough that a loaded sledge runs it without a check, some years before the household raises anything heavier upon it than the skin boats they had always built.

81. ← Follows from *The fish-kilns of Seann Mhorn*, 17 an Giblean, VE 1,443.

82. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

83. ← Follows from *The fish-kilns of Seann Mhorn*, 17 an Giblean, VE 1,443.

84. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

85. ← Follows from *The fish-kilns of Seann Mhorn*, 17 an Giblean, VE 1,443.

86. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

87. ← Follows from *The fish-kilns of Seann Mhorn*, 17 an Giblean, VE 1,443.

88. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

89. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

90. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

THE YEARS VE 1,501 – 2,000

- 4 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,510** — *A dog lies across the finished ramp* (Seann Bhrenn). A dog of the Brenn¹ household lies full length on the finished ramp on warm days, and the household steps over it on the way down to the water rather than move it.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,512** — *The first plank-built hull framed at Brenn*² (Seann Bhrenn). The household at Brenn frames the first hull of planks pegged and caulked over a timber frame, a make no shore of Dia-thìr had built before, and raises it on rollers along the finished ramp to wait on the tide.
- 16 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,515** — *The slipways of Seann Bhrenn* (Seann Bhrenn). Long ramps of flat stone are laid down into the water at Seann Bhrenn, wide enough for hulls greater than any hide boat. Of the hulls nothing is left, nor any telling of where they went.³
- 1 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 1,520** — *The first bull launched down the ramps* (Seann Bhrenn). The household of Brenn⁴ walks its first plank-built hull down the finished ramp on rollers and lets it take the water at the height of the tide; it floats low and steady, and hands already aboard it work it out past the last stone shelf into open water.⁵
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 1,521** — *The first bull goes out past the last shelf* (Seann Bhrenn). The hull launched from Brenn⁶ is worked out past the last shelf of stone into open water, and of where it went, or what it was built to reach, nothing is told.⁷
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 1,522** — *A sail seen small from the height above Brenn*⁸ (Seann Bhrenn). A watcher on high ground along the coast near Brenn marks a dark sail standing out against the grey water and shrinking until it cannot be told from the sea it stands on, then turns back to the day's work once there is nothing left to watch.⁹
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 1,540** — *The first platform driven at Loch chrom* (Crannagan Loch chrom¹⁰). Oak piles are driven down through the shallows of Loch chrom to firmer ground beneath, and a floor of split timber raised across their tops, joined to the shore by a walk of planks lashed to crossbeams below; whose hands began it, no telling has kept.

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

3. → Caused by *The first ramp-slab laid at Brenn*, 18 an Cèitean, VE 1,478; ← Leads to *A ramp-slab relaid twice at Brenn*, 30 an Lùnastal, VE 1,483; ← Leads to *The first ramp at Brenn finished*, 1 an Lùnastal, VE 1,499; → Caused by *The first plank-built hull framed at Brenn*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,512.

4. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

5. → Leads to *The slipways of Seann Bhrenn*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 1,515.

6. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

7. ← Follows from *The slipways of Seann Bhrenn*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 1,515.

8. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

9. ¶ Legacy *The slipways of Seann Bhrenn*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 1,515.

10. the lake dwellings of Loch chrom (place 1003; spec name)

- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 1,560** — *The planks of the lake walks listened to* (Crannagan Loch chrom¹¹). A child of the Loch chrom platforms is sent along every plank walk each morning to listen for the sound of a plank gone thin under its light weight before a grown foot finds it the hard way.
- 7 AM MÀRT, VE 1,588** — *The lake dwellings of Loch chrom* (Loch chrom). Platforms on oak piles are raised in the shallows of Loch chrom and joined to the shore by plank walks. Whether the Seann-Dhaoine¹² built them, or some other people of those years, is not known.¹³
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 1,600** — *Eels first taken from beneath the platforms* (Crannagan Loch chrom¹⁴). The households of Loch chrom learn to lower baited traps through gaps left in the plank floors of their platforms, finding more eels gathered in the shade and stillness of the piles than any open bank of the loch had ever drawn to a hand's reach before.¹⁵
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 1,612** — *A child carries the first basket the length of the longest walk* (Crannagan Loch chrom¹⁶). A child of one household at Loch chrom is trusted, for the first time, to carry a basket of the day's eels the whole length of the longest plank walk alone, watched without a word by an elder who by then counts the crossing an ordinary errand.¹⁷
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 1,640** — *A shared meal for a new pile* (Crannagan Loch chrom¹⁸). The households of the lake platforms count a new oak pile driven and holding as an occasion for a shared meal on the nearest platform once the driving-frame is struck down.
- 25 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,650** — *A new pile driven at Loch chrom* (Crannagan Loch chrom¹⁹). Four or five hands together drive a fresh oak pile into the mud of Loch chrom in place of one worked loose by years of current, the heaviest labour that shore's households reckon their own, and mark it, once it holds, with a shared meal on the platform.²⁰
- 26 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,669** — *A second ramp begun at Brenn*²¹ (Seann Bhrenn). The household at Brenn lays a second ramp beside the first, wider and longer, and launches hulls from it in the years after the way any trade repeats what it has once learned, though none of those hulls draws the telling's eye as the first one did.²²

11. the lake dwellings of Loch chrom (place 1003; spec name)

12. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

13. → Caused by *The first platform driven at Loch chrom*, 26 an t-Sultain, VE 1,540; ← Leads to *The planks of the lake walks listened to*, 25 an Dàmhair, VE 1,560.

14. the lake dwellings of Loch chrom (place 1003; spec name)

15. ← Follows from *The lake dwellings of Loch chrom*, 7 am Màrt, VE 1,588.

16. the lake dwellings of Loch chrom (place 1003; spec name)

17. ⇌ At the same time *The lake dwellings of Loch chrom*, 7 am Màrt, VE 1,588.

18. the lake dwellings of Loch chrom (place 1003; spec name)

19. the lake dwellings of Loch chrom (place 1003; spec name)

20. ← Follows from *The lake dwellings of Loch chrom*, 7 am Màrt, VE 1,588.

21. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

22. ← Follows from *The slipways of Seann Bhrenn*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 1,515.

- 6 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,670** — *The whale-rib houses of Seann Dunn*²³ (Seann Dunn). A whale strands below the southern Seann Dunn, and its ribs are raised for the frames of three round houses roofed with turf. The ribs are set up again in new houses at least twice before they rot.
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,672** — *A whale strands below the southern Dunn*²⁴ (Seann Dunn). A whale comes ashore in an autumn gale below the southern Dunn, stranded beyond the tide's reach. It lives through a day and a night before its breathing stops, watched from a careful distance by the household nearest the shingle who first heard the surf change its voice.²⁵
- 22 AN T-ÌUCHAR, VE 1,672** — *The whale cut and shared along the shore* (Seann Dunn²⁶). Word of the stranding carries both ways along the shore, and households beyond the one that found it come down to Dunn to help with the cutting. The meat is salted and smoked, the blubber rendered in clay-lined pits, and no household that helped goes home with an empty basket.²⁷
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 1,673** — *The whale's ribs driven upright for house frames* (Seann Dunn²⁸). Once the meat and the blubber are taken, the whale's bared ribs are driven upright in the turf above the shingle and lashed together at the crown. Three round houses stand roofed in turf by the year's end, taller and wider than any frame of bent branch the shore had raised before.²⁹
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 1,675** — *Whale oil burned through two winters* (Seann Dunn³⁰). The oil rendered from the whale at the southern Dunn is kept in bladders and clay pots and burned in stone lamps through two winters at least, by more hearths than the one that first heard the surf change.³¹
- 9 AM MÀRT, VE 1,678** — *The first rib found cracked through* (Seann Dunn³²). A rib bearing the heaviest weight of turf is found cracked through in its fifth winter, salt and rain having told on the bone faster than they tell on green wood. It is shored with a driven stake lashed alongside it rather than taken down before the roof can fall.³³

23. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

24. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

25. → Leads to *The whale-rib houses of Seann Dunn*, 6 an Gearran, VE 1,670.

26. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

27. → Leads to *The whale-rib houses of Seann Dunn*, 6 an Gearran, VE 1,670.

28. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

29. → Leads to *The whale-rib houses of Seann Dunn*, 6 an Gearran, VE 1,670.

30. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

31. ← Follows from *The whale-rib houses of Seann Dunn*, 6 an Gearran, VE 1,670.

32. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

33. → Leads to *The whale-rib houses of Seann Dunn*, 6 an Gearran, VE 1,670.

- 8 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,720** — *The whale-rib houses raised a second time* (Seann Dunn³⁴). The original ribs having failed past shoring, the three houses at Dunn are raised again, this time on bone from a second, smaller stranding that had come ashore some way along the same stretch in the years between, cut by a household with no thought then of building.³⁵
- 6 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,731** — *A child turns up the buried foot of the first rib* (Seann Dunn³⁶). Digging in ground long since grown thick with turf, a child of the household turns up a length of bone gone soft and dark with years, and cannot say what it is until an elder names it: the foot of a rib from the first whale-rib house, sunk and near forgotten.³⁷
- 8 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 1,734** — *The round houses of the eastern Seann Vell*³⁸ (Seann Vell). At the eastern Seann Vell the Seann-Dhaoine³⁹ build round houses of dry stone, each with a hearth sunk in the middle of the floor and a drain running out under the wall. Fourteen house-rings are counted there.
- 7 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,740** — *A third raising on bone carried from the west* (Seann Dunn⁴⁰). The rib houses at the southern Dunn are raised a third time on bone carried along the shore from a whale cut further west, word of usable ribs travelling faster by then than word of strandings once did.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 1,758** — *The eastern Vell*⁴¹'s first dry-stone round house (Seann Vell). On ground thick with loose slabs above the eastern Vell, a household raises the first of what will become fourteen round houses, dry stone laid without mortar, each course fitted and refitted until it holds by its own weight alone, roofed at last by corbelled slabs closed with turf.⁴²
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 1,761** — *A hearth sunk below the sunk floor at eastern Vell*⁴³ (Seann Vell). A household of the eastern Vell cuts its hearth-pit deeper than the sunk floor around it and lines it with stone set on edge, keeping the fire below any draught the door might let in, and letting the smoke find its own way out past the corbelled roof's crown.⁴⁴
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 1,766** — *The first drain cut beneath a wall at eastern Vell*⁴⁵ (Seann Vell). A household whose floor stands wetter than its neighbours' through a wet winter takes up its own floor the following dry season and cuts a stone-lined channel under the wall to carry the water clear. Other households of the cluster, watching, take up their own floors in turn.⁴⁶

34. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

35. ← Follows from *The whale-rib houses of Seann Dunn*, 6 an Gearran, VE 1,670.

36. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

37. ← Follows from *The whale-rib houses of Seann Dunn*, 6 an Gearran, VE 1,670.

38. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

39. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

40. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

41. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

42. → Leads to *The round houses of the eastern Seann Vell*, 8 am Faoilleach, VE 1,734.

43. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

44. → Leads to *The round houses of the eastern Seann Vell*, 8 am Faoilleach, VE 1,734.

45. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

11 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 1,770 — *Drains cut under standing walls at Vell*⁴⁷ (Seann Vell). Households of the eastern Vell whose houses were built without a drain take up their floors in a dry season and cut the channel in under walls already standing, having watched their neighbours' floors stand drier.⁴⁸

16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,773 — *The fourteenth house finished at eastern Vell*⁴⁹ (Seann Vell). The last of the fourteen round houses stands finished on the eastern Vell's cleared ground, doors facing every way the ground allows, and every house of the cluster by now given its own dry outfall beneath the wall, a drier floor than the cluster's first years knew.⁵⁰

15 AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 1,796 — *A hollow-walled tower begun at the north-western Skell*⁵¹ (Seann Skell). A household of the north-western Skell, settled where the ground runs out to open water on three sides, begins a round tower of two dry-stone faces built together, a stair let into the gap between them, climbing the wall's own thickness rather than crossing any open floor.

19 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,804 — *A winter storm throws down the unfinished outer face* (Seann Skell⁵²). With the tower a third of its final height, a winter storm throws down the outer face of the stair while the inner holds. The household clears the fallen stone from the gap and sets the cross-stones binding the two faces closer together through the whole climb of what remains to be built.

10 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 1,806 — *The tower at the north-western Seann Skell*⁵³ (Seann Skell). At the least of the Seann Skell places, on the north-west coast, a single round tower of dry stone is raised, hollow-walled, with a stair in the thickness of the wall. It looks out over the water where the Sea-Watcher is afterwards seen.⁵⁴

18 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,810 — *The first night at the tower's crown* (Seann Skell⁵⁵). With the stair whole and the parapet laid, a household of the north-western Skell climbs to the tower's open crown by clear starlight and sees more of the sea at once than any of that shore had seen from any roof or headland before it.⁵⁶

46. → Leads to *The round houses of the eastern Seann Vell*, 8 am Faoilleach, VE 1,734.

47. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

48. ← Follows from *The round houses of the eastern Seann Vell*, 8 am Faoilleach, VE 1,734.

49. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

50. ← Follows from *The round houses of the eastern Seann Vell*, 8 am Faoilleach, VE 1,734.

51. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

52. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

53. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

54. → Caused by *A hollow-walled tower begun at the north-western Skell*, 15 an t-Iuchar, VE 1,796; → Caused by *A winter storm throws down the unfinished outer face*, 19 an Giblean, VE 1,804.

55. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

56. ← Follows from *The tower at the north-western Seann Skell*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, VE 1,806.

- 20 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,826** — *A fire lit on the parapet turns a boat from the rocks* (Seann Skell⁵⁷). In hard weather, a boat not of that shore is seen from the tower's crown standing in blind toward the rocks below. A fire lit on the parapet shows its crew the coast they are running for in time to bear off from the worst of it before the light fails.⁵⁸
- 21 AM MÀRT, VE 1,830** — *The stair walked after every storm* (Seann Skell⁵⁹). The household of the north-western Skell walks the tower stair from foot to crown after every storm, feeling along both faces for any stone gone slack in its bed.⁶⁰
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 1,858** — *Stone huts built in the dune's lee at Toll*⁶¹ (Seann Toll). A household of Toll builds a row of low stone huts against the slope of a dune tall enough to break the worst of the sea wind before it reaches a wall, turf-roofed and set close, the sand that blows loose in an ordinary gale cleared each morning as an ordinary chore.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 1,879** — *A wind rises off the sea that does not settle* (Seann Toll⁶²). A wind rises off the sea and holds through a full day and into a second, driving sand off the dune's whole face until the air itself thickens to the colour and near the weight of the ground it carries, and sand mounts against the huts faster than hands can clear it.
- 4 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,879** — *The household of Toll*⁶³ *leaves the buried huts* (Seann Toll). Before the storm's second night closes on them, the household carries what it can and goes inland to higher ground, none of them lost or badly hurt in the leaving. The dune moves forward the width of the huts and beyond, and the row is not seen again above the sand.
- 1 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 1,879** — *The huts of the northern Seann Toll*⁶⁴ (Seann Toll). At Seann Toll on the north coast a cluster of stone huts is built in the lee of a dune. The dune afterwards buries them whole, and the sand keeps them.⁶⁵
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 1,880** — *The dune moves the width of the huts* (Seann Toll⁶⁶). When the wind falls on the third day the dune at the northern Toll stands forward the whole width of the huts and beyond, a slope of new pale sand over ground where doors opened two days before.⁶⁷

57. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

58. ← Follows from *The tower at the north-western Seann Skell*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, VE 1,806.

59. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

60. ← Follows from *The tower at the north-western Seann Skell*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, VE 1,806.

61. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

62. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

63. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

64. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

65. → Caused by *Stone huts built in the dune's lee at Toll*, 31 an Dàmhair, VE 1,858; → Caused by *A wind rises off the sea that does not settle*, 30 am Faoilleach, VE 1,879; → Caused by *The household of Toll leaves the buried huts*, 4 an Gearran, VE 1,879.

66. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

67. ← Follows from *The huts of the northern Seann Toll*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 1,879.

- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 1,890** — *New walls raised inland from the buried row* (Seann Toll⁶⁸). After digging finds the buried huts still whole but past any hope of clearing, the household of Toll gives up the digging and raises new walls further inland, on ground it judges, by the coast's own long habit of wind and sand, unlikely to be claimed again in its own lifetime.⁶⁹
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,951** — *The eastern Seann Bhral* (Seann Bhral). At the Seann Bhral of the south-east coast the Seann-Dhaoine⁷⁰ keep a landing and a line of fish-kilns like those of Seann Mhorn. The two places lie within a day's rowing of each other.
- 16 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 1,951** — *Gormal takes up Poit an Teine*⁷¹. Past thirty and past the birth of the one daughter who lived, Gormal takes up Poit an Teine and the leather bag of the line's an gual dathach⁷² from an aunt with no living daughter of her own, having already buried a father, an aunt and two of her own age who died saying the sky-coal would never light.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,955** — *The middle kiln judged by smell* (Seann Bhral). The woman who minds the middle kiln at the eastern Bral⁷³ judges the smoke by its smell at first light and dusk and the fish by the give of the flesh under one finger, and teaches both by standing a child at her elbow.⁷⁴
- 11 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,960** — *Gormal's rule that the recital be kept*. Gormal rules that the fathers' names and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁷⁵ after them be said standing every dark-of-the-year night whether any of the gathered kin care to hear it or not, holding that a recital kept only while it is believed is not kept at all.⁷⁶
- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,965** — *Gormal learns the fathers' names at nine* (Tobar dhìreach). Gormal stands the fathers' names over to the aunt who keeps Poit an Teine⁷⁷ every evening of a whole winter until not a name comes out of its place, and asks, the first time she hears Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁷⁸ whole, why no one has tried from higher ground.⁷⁹
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,978** — *Three good harvests on the eastern slopes*. Word climbs to the high valleys of a third good harvest running on the farms of the eastern slopes, and the branch of the kin already drifting down toward that lower ground begins drifting faster, households following one another rather than waiting their own turn to go.

68. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

69. ← Follows from *The huts of the northern Seann Toll*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 1,879.

70. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

71. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

72. the coloured coal

73. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

74. ← Follows from *The eastern Seann Bhral*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,951.

75. the Keeper's riddle

76. ◇ Same person *Gormal takes up Poit an Teine*, 16 an Lùnastal, VE 1,951.

77. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

78. the Keeper's riddle

79. ◇ Same person *Gormal's rule that the recital be kept*, 11 an Giblean, VE 1,960.

- 10 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,980** — *The branch leaves with no coal of the vein.* The last households of the eastern branch load their gear onto ox-sledges and go down from the high valleys for good, carrying a coal from their own daily fire and not one splinter of the mason's vein, the first households of the line ever to leave it empty-handed.⁸⁰
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,981** — *Gormal names three hills for the sky.* At the recital after the branch's leaving, Gormal argues that the sky, like the sea, should be tried from the ground nearest it, and names three hills of her own judging, one south of the black well, one west toward Achadh dhìreach and a bare shoulder of moor she herself favours, though the kin cannot agree which of the three, or any other, truly stands highest.⁸¹
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 1,983** — *Gormal meets the branch at the sledges* (Tobar dhìreach). Gormal walks out to the yard where the last of the going branch lash their sledges and tells them that no household has gone from the line empty of the vein before; she does not ask them to stay.⁸²
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 1,985** — *The eastern Bral⁸³ kilns kept alight in relay* (Seann Bhral). At the eastern landing three fish-kilns are kept fed at any time while three stand cold and swept, a household's whole catch never dried on the same night lest a failed wind leave it with nothing, the kilns built and worked in the same way as the sister kilns a day's rowing to the south.⁸⁴
- 14 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 1,990** — *A girl reads the smoke at the eastern kilns* (Seann Bhral). A granddaughter of the woman who minds the middle kiln at the eastern landing notices, before anyone older has remarked it, that the smoke of that kiln runs paler than its neighbours in some seasons though the fire beneath is fed no differently, and is told only that the smoke says what the smoke says.⁸⁵
- 12 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,993** — *Dried fish given back for a stranded beast's oil* (Seann Bhral). When a beast comes ashore dead below the southern kilns, the eastern landing sends back a share of its own dried fish by the same boat that brought the word, the giving between the two places running both ways over the years without either side keeping any closer account of it.⁸⁶
- 13 AM MÀRT, VE 1,996** — *Sìomha softens the recital for her own children.* Gormal's daughter Sìomha, unable to move her mother from the fixed words, begins saying the fathers' names and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁸⁷ to her own children in gentler terms at her own hearth, without ever once letting the recital itself lapse.⁸⁸

80. ◇ Same person *Gormal learns the fathers' names at nine*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,965.

81. ◇ Same person *The branch leaves with no coal of the vein*, 10 an Cèitean, VE 1,980.

82. ◇ Same person *Gormal names three hills for the sky*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,981.

83. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

84. → Leads to *The eastern Seann Bhral*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,951.

85. → Leads to *The eastern Seann Bhral*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,951.

86. → Leads to *The eastern Seann Bhral*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,951.

87. the Keeper's riddle

88. ◇ Same person *Gormal meets the branch at the sledges*, 7 an t-Iuchar, VE 1,983.

11 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,998 — *The southern oyster mound stands taller than any household's reach* (Seann Mhorn). Along the southern headland the pile of raked and eaten oyster shell, built up by generations of the same households, comes to stand higher at its oldest end than a tall man can reach with his arm above his head, whiter at the crown where gulls have picked it clean.

28 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,000 — *Gormal adds her own words at her last recital* (Tobar dhìreach). At the last recital she stands for, Gormal adds to the fixed words that the line has not yet thrown from the one hill that matters, and that whoever finds it will do the line more good in an afternoon than the branch in ten generations.⁸⁹

89. ◇ Same person *Siomha softens the recital for her own children*, 13 am Màrt, VE 1,996.

THE YEARS VE 2,001 – 2,500

26 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 2,001 — *A worn rake laid on the southern mound* (Seann Mhorn).

A woman of the southern shore, famed along that coast for the truest oyster-rake anyone there remembers, dies leaving it to her strongest-armed granddaughter; when it wears past mending in its turn it is laid on the mound itself rather than burned or given back to the sea, by a custom the shore explains to no outsider.

15 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,004 — *Gormal's last recital*. On the last dark-of-the-year night of her life Gormal says Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹ standing as she has said it every year of her keeping, and adds, unfixed in the words, that whoever first agrees which hill stands highest will do the line more good than the branch that went down to the farms did it in ten generations of easier digging.²

14 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,004 — *Gormal dies*. Gormal dies that winter in the house she kept Poit an Teine³ in her whole life, her daughter Sìomha and a granddaughter at her bedside, the six dark coals laid out on the blanket at her own asking; the bag and the unanswered question pass to hands that had heard her say both enough times to say them back the same way.⁴

4 AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,025 — *The shell beds of the southern Seann Mhorn* (Seann Mhorn). At the second Seann Mhorn, on the southern coast, oyster, whelk and cockle shell is heaped over a whole headland, and there is little else. The oysters of its lowest layers are larger than any taken there since.⁵

11 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,050 — *The oldest shells of the southern mound run large* (Seann Mhorn). The raking households of the southern Morn⁶ find that the oysters of the lowest layers of their mound are broader by half than any taken from the same water in living memory, and do not trouble over why.⁷

12 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,090 — *A third ramp begun at the second Brenn*⁸ (Seann Bhrenn). Far to the north-east a household that first rolled boulders into its own river's current and walked hulls down over them, in the same way as a household on a river far to the west that bears the same name, begins a third ramp beside the first two, having hulls enough to want more room than two ramps give it.

1. the Keeper's riddle

2. ◇ Same person *Gormal adds her own words at her last recital*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, VE 2,000.

3. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

4. ◇ Same person *Gormal's last recital*, 15 an t-Sultain, VE 2,004.

5. → Caused by *The southern oyster mound stands taller than any household's reach*, 11 an Giblean, VE 1,998; → Caused by *A worn rake laid on the southern mound*, 26 am Faoilleach, VE 2,001.

6. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

7. ← Follows from *The shell beds of the southern Seann Mhorn*, 4 an Cèitean, VE 2,025.

8. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

- 5 **AN GIBLEAN, VE 2,097** — *The twin landings of Seann Bhrenn* (Seann Bhrenn). A second Seann Bhrenn, far to the north-east of the first, has the same long ramps into the water. Whether the two were of one people, or only the name was carried, is not known.⁹
- 31 **AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,097** — *A boy stands before the twin ramps of Brenn*¹⁰ (Seann Bhrenn). Sent one autumn morning to carry word along the bank that the tide has turned, a boy of the north-eastern Brenn household stands a long while looking at the two, then three, pale ramps running into the current before running his errand, and says nothing after of what he stood looking at.
- 11 **AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,135** — *Mathan born*. A second son is born to the household of Clann a' Chlachair¹¹ at Tobar dhìreach, three years before his brother Fearghas, a long-legged child who from the first is surer on wet rock than any of the kin his own age.
- 9 **AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,138** — *Fearghas born*. Fearghas is born at Tobar dhìreach into Clann a' Chlachair¹², growing up on Gormal's unsettled riddle of the three hills as every child of the line grows up on it, turning the six dark coals over in his own hands before he is old enough to feel either the wonder or the doubt older mouths bring to the same handling.
- 14 **AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,167** — *Mathan names the fault in Gormal's three hills*. Mathan says aloud, to his brother, what each of them has been turning over apart: that Gormal named her three hills from where she stood and never climbed higher than her own doorstep to judge between them, and that the line has legs enough to settle the question by walking rather than by arguing at the hearth.¹³
- 12 **AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,167** — *The brothers stand on the first of Gormal's three hills*. Fearghas and Mathan climb the hill south of the black well, the nearest of the three heights Gormal once named, and standing on its crown cannot agree between them whether the shoulder of moor she had favoured stands higher still, learning only that no one of the three can be judged fairly against the others without climbing each in turn.¹⁴
- 17 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 2,168** — *A herder of the southern moor points beyond the known ground*. An old herder driving his flock along a saddle of moor tells the two brothers of a further shoulder his own father swore stood higher than anything nearer the valleys, though the father himself never went to prove it, and sends them on with nothing but the names of a burn and a stand of thorn to steer by.¹⁵
- 16 **AN T-IUCHAR, VE 2,168** — *Two summers of walking ridges*. Fearghas and Mathan walk south in the fair months and come back before the hard ones, each season a little further, climbing hills that looked from a distance like the last word and proved to have a taller neighbour behind them.¹⁶

9. → Caused by *A third ramp begun at the second Brenn*, 12 an t-Samhain, VE 2,090.

10. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

11. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

12. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

13. ♦ Same person *Mathan born*, 11 an Dàmhair, VE 2,135.

14. ♦ Same person *Mathan names the fault in Gormal's three hills*, 14 an Lùnastal, VE 2,167.

15. ♦ Same person *The brothers stand on the first of Gormal's three hills*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,167.

28 AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 2,169 — *A climb lost to rain.* Fearghas and Mathan climb the shoulder the herder's father had sworn by and stand on it in a driving rain that shows them nothing of the ground beyond, coming down soaked and short-tempered with each other over whether the wetting had been worth it.¹⁷

16 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 2,170 — *The true height is sighted* (Binnean a' Chlachair¹⁸). In clearer weather three summers into their walking, Fearghas and Mathan come out from behind a shoulder of bare rock and see, standing above every other height in every direction, a grey summit with cloud dragging along its crown, and know without needing to say it that the walking is nearly done.¹⁹

12 AN GIBLEAN, VE 2,170 — *The brothers set out for the height* (Binnean a' Chlachair²⁰). Carrying the six dark coals wrapped against the wet in the leather bag, Fearghas and Mathan climb through the last night of summer toward the summit that stands clear over the whole island, sleeping little for the wind and going up with the first grey of morning.²¹

2 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,170 — *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air* (Binnean a' Chlachair²²). Fearghas of the Mason's line climbs to the highest ground of the island, above where Muileann gheal now stands, and lets the six unlit coals fall from the top. The coal flecked with white stars takes fire as it falls and burns white in the air; the others strike the stones cold. The summit is called after the kindred: Binnean a' Chlachair, the Mason's Point.²³

27 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,170 — *Mathan sets the first stone of the cairn* (Binnean a' Chlachair²⁴). Before the brothers leave the summit where gual sneachda²⁵ has just taken fire in the falling air, Mathan sets one loose stone from the crown atop another, a small cairn no higher than a hand, and says nothing over it that needs saying.²⁶

29 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,170 — *The telling reaches every hearth within a day's walk.* By the morning after Fearghas and Mathan tell it standing at Tobar dhìreach, with the four cold coals laid out on a cloth for any hand to turn over, word of the lighting on the height has gone out to every household within a day's walk, carried by whoever heard it first and could not keep from carrying it further.²⁷

16. ◇ Same person *A herder of the southern moor points beyond the known ground*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,168.

17. ◇ Same person *Two summers of walking ridges*, 16 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,168.

18. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

19. ◇ Same person *A climb lost to rain*, 28 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,169.

20. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

21. ◇ Same person *The true height is sighted*, 16 am Faoilleach, VE 2,170.

22. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

23. → Caused by *The brothers stand on the first of Gormal's three hills*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,167; → Caused by *A herder of the southern moor points beyond the known ground*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,168; → Caused by *The true height is sighted*, 16 am Faoilleach, VE 2,170; → Caused by *The brothers set out for the height*, 12 an Giblean, VE 2,170.

24. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

25. the snowflake coal, of air

26. ○ Same place *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air*, 2 an t-Sultain, VE 2,170; ◇ Same person *The brothers set out for the height*, 12 an Giblean, VE 2,170.

- 23 **AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,170** — *The sixth coal let fall for the telling* (Binnean a' Chlachair²⁸). After the snowflake takes fire, Fearghas lets the sixth coal fall from the summit for the sake of the telling, and it strikes the stones as cold as the four before it.²⁹
- 25 **AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,170** — *The snowflake left burning on the slope* (Binnean a' Chlachair³⁰). Fearghas and Mathan climb down to the white-burning coal and leave it where it lies, judging that it has found its own place as surely as the gold found the sea.³¹
- 26 **AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,171** — *The first stone left by a stranger's hand* (Binnean a' Chlachair³²). A herder of the high valleys, passing within sight of the grey summit for the first time since the telling went out, climbs to Mathan's small cairn and lays a stone of his own beside it, the first stone set there by a hand not of Clann a' Chlachair³³, beginning a custom that outlives everyone then living.³⁴
- 21 **AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,175** — *Herders' stones heap on the summit* (Binnean a' Chlachair³⁵). Within a lifetime the little cairn Mathan began on the summit of Binnean a' Chlachair is a heap of stones a man can see from some way off, each laid by a passing herder and none of them saying why.³⁶
- 23 **AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,185** — *Fearghas climbs the height with his son* (Binnean a' Chlachair³⁷). Fearghas, his hair gone grey, climbs the height a second time with his own son grown old enough for the way, and shows him the white fire still burning steady among the cold stones below the summit exactly as he had first seen it catch, unchanged in every particular.³⁸
- 12 **AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,190** — *Mathan dies*. Mathan dies of a fever that comes on him in a wet spring and will not break, five and fifty years old, and is buried at Tobar dhreach with the first cairn stone he ever set on the height closed in one hand at his own asking, having given the height, as he put it himself, three summers of his legs and his best notion.³⁹

27. ← Follows from *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air*, 2 an t-Sultain, VE 2,170; ◇ Same person *Mathan sets the first stone of the cairn*, 27 an Dàmhair, VE 2,170.

28. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

29. ← Follows from *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air*, 2 an t-Sultain, VE 2,170; ◇ Same person *The telling reaches every hearth within a day's walk*, 29 an Dàmhair, VE 2,170.

30. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

31. ← Follows from *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air*, 2 an t-Sultain, VE 2,170; ◇ Same person *The sixth coal let fall for the telling*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, VE 2,170.

32. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

33. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

34. ← Follows from *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air*, 2 an t-Sultain, VE 2,170.

35. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

36. ↓ Legacy *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air*, 2 an t-Sultain, VE 2,170.

37. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

38. ← Follows from *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air*, 2 an t-Sultain, VE 2,170; ◇ Same person *The snowflake left burning on the slope*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, VE 2,170.

39. ◇ Same person *The snowflake left burning on the slope*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, VE 2,170.

- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,190** — *Mathan buried with the first cairn stone* (Tobar dhìreach). Mathan is buried at Tobar dhìreach with the first stone he set on the summit closed in one hand, at his own asking.⁴⁰
- 24 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,197** — *Fearghas's last climb* (Binnean a' Chlachair⁴¹). An old man now, three days each way instead of two, Fearghas climbs to the height a last time alone and finds the white coal burning exactly as he left it every time before, and leaves a stone of his own on the crown before coming down for good.⁴²
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,199** — *Fearghas dies*. Fearghas dies at Tobar dhìreach in his sixty-second year, sure to the last of his own two feet on the height he had proved, and is buried within sight of Leac na Fèithe⁴³ that covers the mason's vein as every keeper and finder of the line is buried before him.⁴⁴
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,199** — *Fearghas's name is added to the recital* (Binnean a' Chlachair⁴⁵). At the recital said over Fearghas's grave, the reciter gives his name for the first time after his father's in the fixed words of the fathers of the line, telling how he climbed to the top of the island and let the six coals fall, and how the snowflake took fire in the empty air and gave the summit its name.⁴⁶
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,241** — *The long house at Tarr*⁴⁷ *set against the cliff* (Seann Tarr). A household of the north-eastern Tarr builds a single long house into a cleft of the cliff, the living rock its own back wall, needing to raise stone only where the cliff itself did not already stand higher than any wall the household could have built.
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,241** — *The cliff-house at Seann Tarr*⁴⁸ *in the east* (Seann Tarr). At the Seann Tarr of the north-eastern headlands a single long house is built into a cleft of the cliff, with the living rock for its back wall. The rock behind the hearth is black with soot to the height of a man.⁴⁹
- 17 AN GEARRAN, VE 2,246** — *The hearth blackens the rock behind it* (Seann Tarr⁵⁰). Years of the same fire kept against the same face of the cliff blacken the stone above the hearth to the height of a tall man standing, a stain the household never scrubs and never troubles to explain, holding a blackened rock over a hearth no stranger a thing than a blackened pot.⁵¹

40. ◇ Same person *Mathan dies*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,190.

41. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

42. ← Follows from *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air*, 2 an t-Sultain, VE 2,170; ◇ Same person *Fearghas climbs the height with his son*, 23 an Dàmhair, VE 2,185.

43. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

44. ◇ Same person *Fearghas's last climb*, 24 an Dàmhair, VE 2,197.

45. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

46. ← Follows from *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air*, 2 an t-Sultain, VE 2,170; ◇ Same person *Fearghas dies*, 22 an t-Samhain, VE 2,199.

47. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

48. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

49. → Caused by *The long house at Tarr set against the cliff*, 4 an Dàmhair, VE 2,241.

50. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

51. ← Follows from *The cliff-house at Seann Tarr in the east*, 25 an Dàmhair, VE 2,241.

- 18 AM MÀRT, VE 2,250** — *The hard winter at Tarr*⁵² (Seann Tarr). A wind out of the north holds the better part of two months without turning, and the household at Tarr lives on dried stores and shellfish taken between gales, burning at the last the timbers of a spare boat-frame kept against just such a want rather than let the hearth go cold.⁵³
- 16 AN GIBLEAN, VE 2,250** — *The calm morning after the hard winter* (Seann Tarr⁵⁴). The wind drops in a single night and swings out of the north at last; the household goes down to the shingle before light to stand out of the wind, and finds a run of small fish thick enough in the shallows to be taken by hand.⁵⁵
- 15 AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,258** — *The four houses raised at the Vell*⁵⁶ on the Abhainn bheag (Seann Vell). A short way above the river's mouth in the north-east, four houses and a boat-shed are raised on ground cut level into the steep bank; no dwelling of the shore-folk on the island is known to stand further to the north-east than this small place.
- 13 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 2,260** — *A girl measures her growing by the soot* (Seann Tarr⁵⁷). A child of the cliff-house at Tarr stands with her back to the soot-stain on the rock above the hearth each midwinter to see how far up it her crown reaches, until the year she stands as tall as the stain.⁵⁸
- 12 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 2,264** — *A flat-bottomed hull built for the river* (Seann Vell⁵⁹). The Vell's boat-shed is built to keep a hull dry between one season's use and the next; the household raises a boat flat enough in the bottom to be poled past the first rapids in a dry season, and takes it further upriver than any of the four households has gone on foot.
- 16 AN GIBLEAN, VE 2,270** — *A second small fire lit at the door in the dark months* (Seann Tarr⁶⁰). The household of the Tarr cliff-house keeps a second small fire lit just inside the door on the darkest days, more for its light than its warmth, the cliff keeping the sun from the doorway through the shortest months.
- 18 AM MÀRT, VE 2,290** — *A spring flood reaches the boat-shed* (Seann Vell⁶¹). Snow melting fast off the central massif sends the Abhainn bheag over its bank far enough to reach the boat-shed's lower course; the household clears the silted floor by the basket-load and raises the shed a course higher on its uphill side.

52. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

53. → Leads to *The cliff-house at Seann Tarr in the east*, 25 an Dàmhair, VE 2,241.

54. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

55. ← Follows from *The cliff-house at Seann Tarr in the east*, 25 an Dàmhair, VE 2,241.

56. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

57. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

58. ← Follows from *The cliff-house at Seann Tarr in the east*, 25 an Dàmhair, VE 2,241.

59. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

60. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

61. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

17 AN GEARRAN, VE 2,300 — *A girl of the river Vell⁶² stops at the river's mouth* (Seann Vell).

A woman grown up at the Vell on the Abhainn bheag stands at the river's mouth one evening looking at the open sea and goes no further, holding that a river's own child has no business beyond its mouth.

19 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 2,301 — *Dried fish carried south to kin without a river* (Seann Vell⁶³). The Vell on the Abhainn bheag spares a share of its eel and salmon catch, smoked over slow fires, to kin two days' walk to the south who keep no river of their own; a household comes up once in a lean year with little to trade and goes home with more than it brought.

26 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,312 — *The north-eastern Seann Vell⁶⁴* (Seann Vell). The Seann Vell on the Abhainn bheag, a short way above its mouth in the north-east, is a small place of four houses and a boat-shed. No Seann-Dhaoine⁶⁵ dwelling on the main island is known further to the north-east.⁶⁶

3 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,312 — *The eel-trap pattern taught to two children* (Seann Vell⁶⁷). An old woman of the Vell's youngest household teaches the willow-trap pattern she learned as a girl to a boy and a girl of the place, holding that a pattern known in only one pair of hands is one bad season from being lost to the whole Vell.⁶⁸

12 AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 2,320 — *The second Skell⁶⁹ begins its own curved mole* (Seann Skell). A household of a northern Skell some way along the coast from the first breakwater takes up the same work for its own water, laying stone out from a low headland in the same curve, carried down from a scree behind the shore rather than quarried fresh.

13 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 2,350 — *A swell breaks over the unfinished mole and moves nothing* (Seann Skell⁷⁰). A hard swell out of the north-west runs white over the second Skell's unfinished curve for two days; when it drops every stone is found still set where it was laid, moved a hand's width here and there but nowhere thrown clear.

15 AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,360 — *Each stone of the curved mole laid dry first* (Seann Skell⁷¹). The household building the second mole at the northern Skell lays each new stone dry against the course already set, working it back and forth until it sits without rocking, and only then sets it.

62. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

63. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

64. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

65. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

66. → Caused by *The four houses raised at the Vell on the Abhainn bheag*, 15 an Cèitean, VE 2,258; → Caused by *A flat-bottomed bull built for the river*, 12 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,264; ← Leads to *A spring flood reaches the boat-shed*, 18 am Màrt, VE 2,290; ← Leads to *A girl of the river Vell stops at the river's mouth*, 17 an Gearran, VE 2,300; ← Leads to *Dried fish carried south to kin without a river*, 19 am Faoilleach, VE 2,301.

67. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

68. ← Follows from *The north-eastern Seann Vell*, 26 an t-Sultain, VE 2,312.

69. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

70. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

71. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

- 22 AM MÀRT, VE 2,382** — *The northern Seann Skell*⁷² (Seann Skell). At the Seann Skell below the later Ros gheal, on the north coast, the Seann-Dhaoine⁷³ lay a second breakwater, shorter than the southern one and curved against the swell of the open sea. The two moles are built the same way, stone by stone.⁷⁴
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,382** — *The curved mole at the second Skell*⁷⁵ finished (Seann Skell). The second Skell's breakwater is carried out as far as the household judges worth the sheltering; a boat brought in behind the finished curve on a hard-weather day rides easier at its mooring than any boat of that shore had ridden before.⁷⁶
- 5 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,390** — *A traveller from the second Skell*⁷⁷ sees the first mole (Seann Skell). A man of the second Skell, grown from the boy who watched his own household's curve laid, comes within sight of the first mole on a journey south and finds the stone laid the same way, curve for curve, though no household of either shore had ever seen the other's work before it was finished.⁷⁸
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,401** — *The first clay-lined pit dug in the western dune* (Seann Vell⁷⁹). A woman of the western Vell digs and clay-lines the first of a line of storage pits cut into the dune's slope, closed with a heavy slab; households after her keep her spacing between pits without troubling to test her reasoning for themselves.
- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,418** — *A younger household cuts clay out of turn* (Seann Vell⁸⁰). A household new to the western dune cuts a clay bank two others had agreed to leave fallow a season; once the disagreement reaches her, the woman who keeps the unwritten turn among the banks settles it, and the younger household gives over a full pit's worth of its own dried catch.
- 16 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,430** — *The pits of the western dune spaced a body's length apart* (Seann Vell⁸¹). The woman who dug the first store-pit in the western dune at Vell sets her later pits a full body's length apart, holding that a pit dug too near another draws damp, and the households after her keep the spacing.

72. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

73. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

74. → Caused by *The second Skell begins its own curved mole*, 12 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,320; → Caused by *A swell breaks over the unfinished mole and moves nothing*, 13 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,350; → Caused by *Each stone of the curved mole laid dry first*, 15 an Cèitean, VE 2,360.

75. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

76. ← Follows from *The northern Seann Skell*, 22 am Màrt, VE 2,382.

77. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

78. ← Follows from *The northern Seann Skell*, 22 am Màrt, VE 2,382.

79. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

80. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

81. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

20 AN GIBLEAN, VE 2,451 — *The western Seann Vell*⁸² (Seann Vell). At the Seann Vell of the west coast the Seann-Dhaoine⁸³ dig a line of storage pits into the dune, lined with clay and lidded with slabs. Some held fish bones still when they were opened.⁸⁴

14 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,460 — *Fish bones found in a sealed pit* (Seann Vell⁸⁵). A pit left sealed longer than a season gives back fish bones picked clean and gone soft with damp that found its way past the clay; the households learn to trust a pit's seal less far into a second year and to empty a store before the season turns.⁸⁶

82. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

83. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

84. → Caused by *The first clay-lined pit dug in the western dune*, 13 an Dàmhair, VE 2,401; → Caused by *A younger household cuts clay out of turn*, 11 an t-Samhain, VE 2,418; ← Leads to *The pits of the western dune spaced a body's length apart*, 16 an Lùnastal, VE 2,430.

85. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

86. ← Follows from *The western Seann Vell*, 20 an Giblean, VE 2,451.

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- 6 AN GEARRAN, VE 2,505** — *Doors of the western shore turn from the sea* (Seann Vell¹). Without any of its own tellings naming a reason, household after household of the western shore sets its door and its hearth a little more toward the dune at its back than toward the water in front, a threshold that had always opened straight onto the beach coming to open sideways from it instead.²
- 7 AM MÀRT, VE 2,523** — *The last pit of the season sealed for winter* (Seann Vell³). The western dune's last pit of the year is dug, lined and lidded before the first hard frost, the sand banked back over its edges as every pit before it had been closed, the shore settling into a waiting none of its tellings say the whole of.⁴
- 24 AM MÀRT, VE 2,524** — *The spur first climbed and looked from* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire⁵). Two sons of a shore household climb the spur above the southern lowland to look, and come back saying a man standing on its crown can see the whole lowland below him and any thing that moves across it long before it reaches the coast.
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,524** — *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire⁶ raised* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire). On a spur above the ground where Cathair mhòr now stands, the Seann-Dhaoine⁷ build the walled outpost afterwards called Làrach an Dùin-fhaire. Its stones are dressed on the outer face only, and its single gate looks inland, away from the sea.⁸
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,524** — *The three rings begun on the height* (Làrach an Dùin⁹). On a height near the south-eastern coast a crew begins the outer of three ringed walls under a woman said to read the ground before a stone is laid, a work on a scale no household of that coast has raised to before.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 2,526** — *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹⁰'s wall dressed on its outer face only* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire). The mason who sets Làrach an Dùin-fhaire's first course dresses its stone smooth only where an enemy's eye might run along it, leaving the inner face raw, so that the wall stands smooth without and rough within through every season it is kept.¹¹

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

2. ← Follows from *The western Seann Vell*, 20 an Giblean, VE 2,451.

3. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

4. ← Follows from *The western Seann Vell*, 20 an Giblean, VE 2,451.

5. the watch-fort ruin

6. the watch-fort ruin

7. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

8. → Caused by *The spur first climbed and looked from*, 24 am Màrt, VE 2,524.

9. the fortress ruin

10. the watch-fort ruin

11. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire raised*, 19 an Cèitean, VE 2,524.

- I AN T-ÌUCHAR, VE 2,527** — *The inner face of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire*¹² *left rough* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire). The woman who sets the first course of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire wall dresses the stones on the outer face only, saying a wall need be smooth where an enemy's eye runs looking for a hold, and rough where a friend's hand rests going up the inner steps.¹³
- 5 AN GIBLEAN, VE 2,530** — *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire*¹⁴ *'s gate hung* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire). A heavy oaken gate is hung on a socketed post at Làrach an Dùin-fhaire, its single doorway facing inland away from the sea, and swings shut of its own weight for the first time to the doubt of an old fisherman who mistrusts a door built facing from the water.¹⁵
- 7 AM MÀRT, VE 2,531** — *Cattle first driven up the spur* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹⁶). Beasts used to level shore grazing are coaxed up the spur's steep ground for the first time, balking at the new gate, and settle within the wall to its thin grass within a few days of the climb.¹⁷
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 2,535** — *The gate argued before the lintel* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹⁸). An old fisherman argues that a gate facing away from the water is a gate built by people who have forgotten what the water was to them; the mason answers that whatever a gate here must watch for will not come rowing.¹⁹
- 4 AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,540** — *A watcher learns to prefer the quiet* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire²⁰). A woman who keeps Làrach an Dùin-fhaire's first winter watch longer than anyone of her household says afterward that the quiet of the spur had a weight unlike any quiet of the shore, and that she grew almost to prefer it.
- IO AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,545** — *The false watch on the lowland* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire²¹). A boy of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire raises the whole watch at dusk over shapes crossing the lowland from the west, taken for deer moving too evenly together; nothing is found by first light, and Làrach an Dùin-fhaire's watch is never again left to one pair of eyes.²²
- II AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,560** — *The cistern cut into the bedrock* (Làrach an Dùin²³). At the height's crown a basin is hollowed from the bedrock by heated stone cracked loose and cooled with water, a labour of two seasons that blisters more hands than the rest of the rings together.

12. the watch-fort ruin

13. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire raised*, 19 an Cèitean, VE 2,524.

14. the watch-fort ruin

15. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire raised*, 19 an Cèitean, VE 2,524.

16. the watch-fort ruin

17. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire raised*, 19 an Cèitean, VE 2,524.

18. the watch-fort ruin

19. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire raised*, 19 an Cèitean, VE 2,524.

20. the watch-fort ruin

21. the watch-fort ruin

22. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire raised*, 19 an Cèitean, VE 2,524.

23. the fortress ruin

- 6 AN GEARRAN, VE 2,570** — *The one who reads the ground stands over the cistern* (Làrach an Dùin²⁴). The woman who reads the ground for the three rings says the cistern must go deep enough to hold water through a summer no rain falls in, though no one living has seen such a summer.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 2,576** — *Làrach an Dùin*²⁵ *raised* (Làrach an Dùin). A greater work is raised on the height near Ceann mhin: three rings of wall, a cistern cut into the bedrock, and room within, as it was later reckoned, for four hundred people and their beasts. Whether the builders of the outpost built this also has never been settled.²⁶
- 8 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 2,590** — *The cistern first full* (Làrach an Dùin²⁷). The cistern fills for the first time from a spring the digging uncovers, and a child let down on a rope draws up the first measure, which the woman who read the ground tastes and says tastes of stone.
²⁸
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,600** — *Cattle first driven inside the three rings* (Làrach an Dùin²⁹). Beasts are driven up the steeper climb into the three rings for the first time, more lost to loose scree on the way than the spur's own herders ever lost, and a woman who loses two of her own says the rings charge dear for what they let in.³⁰
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,600** — *The wind within the rings* (Làrach an Dùin³¹). A household that moves up from the shore to one of the first houses within the innermost ring finds the wind there, filtered through three walls, gentler than any wind it knew at the water's edge.
- 21 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,610** — *The trodden way between the heights first paved* (Àth fhionn). A household along the worst stretch of the path between the spur and the height lays flat stones to keep its own feet dry, with no thought yet of any greater road, and others add paving of their own beside it.
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,622** — *The death of the woman who read the ground* (Làrach an Dùin³²). The woman who has read the ground for the three rings since the first course dies within the innermost ring at a great age and is buried there at her own asking, under a stretch of wall she named the soundest of her life.³³

24. the fortress ruin

25. the fortress ruin

26. → Caused by *The three rings begun on the height*, 26 an t-Sultain, VE 2,524; ← Leads to *The cistern cut into the bedrock*, 11 an t-Samhain, VE 2,560; ← Leads to *The one who reads the ground stands over the cistern*, 6 an Gearran, VE 2,570.

27. the fortress ruin

28. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin raised*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,576.

29. the fortress ruin

30. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin raised*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,576.

31. the fortress ruin

32. the fortress ruin

33. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin raised*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,576.

- 16 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 2,627** — *The kerbed way between the forts* (Àth fhionn). A kerbed track, a cart's width and paved with flat slabs, is laid through the ground near Àth fhionn toward both strongholds. It is the only road the Seann-Dhaoine³⁴ are known to have made away from the shore.³⁵
- 18 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 2,635** — *The kerbing of the way spreads* (Àth fhionn). Upright stones set along the paving's edges hold it firm through a wet winter better than the unkerbed stretches beside it, and the practice spreads along the whole track within a few more seasons.³⁶
- 16 AN GEARRAN, VE 2,640** — *The kerbed way paved household by household* (Àth fhionn). The track between Làrach an Dùin-fhaire³⁷ and the rings is paved stretch by stretch by the households nearest each stretch, pale stone and dark, broad slabs and small fitted stones, no one hand holding the whole plan of it.³⁸
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 2,655** — *The first cart driven the whole way* (Àth fhionn). A cart of dressed stone drawn by two yoked oxen crosses the whole kerbed way for the first time without a wheel sinking to the axle, a day's haul where the same load once took the better part of three over open moor.³⁹
- 26 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,678** — *The last slab of the kerbed way laid* (Àth fhionn). The final slab of the track is set tilted rather than level on the last steep rise, and the small crew that lays it turns, its work done, to look inland toward the high pale country rather than back toward the sea.⁴⁰
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,679** — *Làrach an Teampaill*⁴¹ *raised* (Làrach an Teampaill). A stepped platform of fitted stone is built in the eastern hills, with an altar block on its top step. The altar is set square to the central mountains. Every later temple on Dia-thìr faces some other way.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,681** — *The first steps of the platform laid* (Làrach an Teampaill⁴²). A household of the eastern hills begins laying flat stone in steps up the slope below the height, bedding each slab before the next is set above it, the first work of the platform that will in time carry the altar block on its topmost step.⁴³

34. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

35. → Caused by *The trodden way between the heights first paved*, 21 an t-Samhain, VE 2,610.

36. ← Follows from *The kerbed way between the forts*, 16 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,627.

37. the watch-fort ruin

38. ← Follows from *The kerbed way between the forts*, 16 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,627.

39. ← Follows from *The kerbed way between the forts*, 16 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,627.

40. ← Follows from *The kerbed way between the forts*, 16 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,627.

41. the temple ruin

42. the temple ruin

43. → Leads to *Làrach an Teampaill raised*, 14 an Lùnastal, VE 2,679.

- 12 AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,687** — *The great stone dragged up on rollers* (Làrach an Teampaill⁴⁴). The block meant for the platform's top step is hauled up the finished lower steps on rollers of trimmed timber, the same labour that raised Làrach an Dùin-fhaire⁴⁵ wall and Làrach an Dùin⁴⁶ rings, and set back from the step's outer edge to be dressed flat.⁴⁷
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 2,690** — *The first dawn at the altar* (Làrach an Teampaill⁴⁸). A household of the southern lowland climbs the finished steps at first light on the shortest morning of the year and stands about the great stone as the sun's light runs along its face toward the mountains it is squared to. No telling records what, if anything, was said.⁴⁹
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,696** — *Other households begin to climb* (Làrach an Teampaill⁵⁰). Seeing the first household return year on year to the shortest morning, other families of the eastern hills take up the same climb, until the one gathering at the platform draws more households together than any single one of them could climb the steps alone.⁵¹
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,700** — *The shortest morning climbed in cloud* (Làrach an Teampaill⁵²). In a year when cloud lies thick over the eastern hills through the shortest morning, the households climb the platform steps in the dark and the cold all the same and stand about the great stone the whole hour the light would have taken to cross it.⁵³
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,704** — *The last step laid flush with the moor* (Làrach an Teampaill⁵⁴). The lowest step of the platform is set flush with the level ground, closing the run years after the great stone above it already stood finished, and it is this easiest step, rather than any harder-won one above, that the households nearest it remember longest.⁵⁵
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,706** — *A carved bird left at the stone's foot* (Làrach an Teampaill⁵⁶). A woman carries a small carved bird up the platform steps once and sets it at the foot of the great stone, and goes down without it; no second such bird is ever found there.
- 26 AN GEARRAN, VE 2,711** — *A stranger turned away from the platform* (Làrach an Teampaill⁵⁷). A stranger up from the southern lowland asks a woman drawing water why the great stone is raised. She answers that a stone older than her grandmother's grandmother needs no explaining to one not born to it, and he does not climb the steps or come again.⁵⁸

44. the temple ruin

45. the watch-fort ruin

46. the fortress ruin

47. → Leads to *Làrach an Teampaill raised*, 14 an Lùnastal, VE 2,679.

48. the temple ruin

49. ← Follows from *Làrach an Teampaill raised*, 14 an Lùnastal, VE 2,679.

50. the temple ruin

51. ← Follows from *Làrach an Teampaill raised*, 14 an Lùnastal, VE 2,679.

52. the temple ruin

53. ← Follows from *Làrach an Teampaill raised*, 14 an Lùnastal, VE 2,679.

54. the temple ruin

55. ← Follows from *Làrach an Teampaill raised*, 14 an Lùnastal, VE 2,679.

56. the temple ruin

57. the temple ruin

58. ← Follows from *Làrach an Teampaill raised*, 14 an Lùnastal, VE 2,679.

- 27 AM MÀRT, VE 2,717** — *The digging begins at the eastern Toll-dubh* (Toll-dubh). On level moor in the south-east a household begins cutting a well-like shaft straight down through the rock, the work continuing past any depth a well would need and its walls smoothed by hand long after the digging alone would have left them rough.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,723** — *The baskets carried off and not returned* (Toll-dubh). Each evening the broken rock the digging throws off is carried away over the rise at the moor's edge, and no heap of it is ever afterward found anywhere near the shaft's mouth, though no telling says where it was taken.
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,730** — *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the south-east* (Toll-dubh). A shaft is sunk straight down through the rock at the eastern Toll-dubh, its walls tooled smooth as far as a lamp will show. No spoil lies beside it. Whatever was taken out was carried away, or nothing was.⁵⁹
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,731** — *A cord lengthened for the lamp* (Toll-dubh). The plaited cord that lets the lamp down to judge the smoothing of the shaft's walls is lengthened for the third time, the household gathering at the lip each time to watch the lamp go down further than it has gone before and come up still burning.⁶⁰
- 26 AN GEARRAN, VE 2,735** — *A young man hurt in the eastern shaft* (Toll-dubh). Sent down to free a caught basket, a young man of the household comes up with a gash along one forearm that keeps him from the heaviest carrying a season, and returns to the cord the following spring all the same.⁶¹
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 2,736** — *The cord hung inside the door* (Toll-dubh). The worn lengths of hide cord the eastern shaft was measured with are hung, when renewed, inside the household's door, where another household might hang a net.
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,740** — *The lamp lowered in the eastern shaft* (Toll-dubh). The lamp is let down further than ever before, its light at the bottom showing no more of the walls than a small patch no wider than two hands held apart, the rest standing dark above and below it; the digging is remembered to have stopped near this same evening.⁶²
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,742** — *A stone dropped and heard to fall nowhere* (Toll-dubh). After the digging stops, a stone let fall from the lip gives back no sound of striking anything below, and the household stands listening far longer than it kept silence for anything else in all the years of that work.⁶³

59. → Caused by *The digging begins at the eastern Toll-dubh*, 27 am Màrt, VE 2,717; ← Leads to *The baskets carried off and not returned*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, VE 2,723.

60. ← Follows from *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the south-east*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,730.

61. ← Follows from *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the south-east*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,730.

62. ← Follows from *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the south-east*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,730.

63. ← Follows from *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the south-east*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,730.

- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,745** — *A stone laid over the shaft at the first frost* (Toll-dubh). The household of the eastern Toll-dubh lays a flat stone loosely over the shaft's mouth at each year's first hard frost and lifts it after the shortest days, to keep a beast or a careless foot from the lip.⁶⁴
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,748** — *The digging begins at the western Toll-dubh* (Toll-dubh). Far across the island, on ground its own people likewise call Toll-dubh, a second household begins a straight, round shaft of the same make as the eastern one, with no telling saying that either household knew of the other's work.
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,761** — *A girl asks how deep the shaft will go* (Toll-dubh). A girl of the western household asks her mother whether the shaft is being dug down to wherever the mountains keep their roots; her mother answers only that the ground keeps its own matters, and that a household does well not to ask them aloud.
- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 2,765** — *An old man keeps the lamp trimmed at the western shaft* (Toll-dubh). A man of the western household, past the heaviest carrying, keeps the lamp trimmed each evening for whoever goes down to judge the smoothing of the western shaft.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,770** — *The lamp left to burn itself out* (Toll-dubh). The household at the western shaft takes up a habit of setting the lamp, still burning, on a stone by the lip each evening rather than snuffing it, letting it go out on its own, a small custom none of its own tellings gives a reason for keeping.
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,782** — *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the west* (Toll-dubh). A second shaft of the same making is cut at the western Toll-dubh, far across the island from the first. Stones thrown into either are not heard to land.⁶⁵
- 7 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 2,783** — *The last stone dropped at the western shaft* (Toll-dubh). On the evening the western digging is given over, the youngest of the household lets a stone fall and counts under his breath until he judges it must have struck bottom; when no sound comes, he looks to the faces around him rather than down the shaft.⁶⁶
- 5 AN GEARRAN, VE 2,795** — *The two shafts left open and shunned* (Toll-dubh). Both shafts stand unfilled and uncovered at the century's turn, and travellers of either coast come to walk wide of their mouths, letting a dropped stone go down into a silence no household troubles any longer to break by listening after it.⁶⁷

64. ← Follows from *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the south-east*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,730.

65. → Caused by *The digging begins at the western Toll-dubh*, 4 an Dàmhair, VE 2,748; ← Leads to *A girl asks how deep the shaft will go*, 19 an Lùnastal, VE 2,761; → Caused by *An old man keeps the lamp trimmed at the western shaft*, 21 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,765; ← Leads to *The lamp left to burn itself out*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, VE 2,770.

66. ← Follows from *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the west*, 11 an Dàmhair, VE 2,782.

67. ← Follows from *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the west*, 11 an Dàmhair, VE 2,782; ← Follows from *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the south-east*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,730.

- 6 AM MÀRT, VE 2,801** — *Bran born to the north-west shore.* Bran is born to a fishing hearth of the north-west shore, kin who keep Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁶⁸ as every hill hearth does but hear its westward part first, the part that names Tìr nan Òg⁶⁹, Magh Meall⁷⁰ and Taigh Dhuinn⁷¹ across the open sea.
- 15 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,815** — *Bran stands at the tideline at dusk.* Bran, near ten, is found by his mother at the tideline deep into the dark, looking at the place where it stops being water and starts being something else.⁷²
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,825** — *The best boatman of that coast.* Grown to a man, Bran is known the length of the north-west shore as the surest hand with a swell and a stitching-needle alike, mending hulls that no other boatman's seams will hold and reading weather other men cannot.⁷³
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,828** — *Bran mends every boat on the shore.* Neighbours bring Bran their boats from half a day's walk along the coast because his stitches hold where other men's let the sea in, and he asks no payment but a share of what the mended boat brings home.⁷⁴
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,829** — *Bran begins the great bull.* Bran starts gathering bull-hides cured harder and longer than any boat on his coast has needed, and sets ribs of hazel and ash closer than a hand's width, telling his kin at first only that he means a bigger boat for a bigger catch.⁷⁵
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, VE 2,830** — *The great bull decked with sealed skins.* Bran decks half the length of his great hull with skins stretched and sealed against green water and sets his ribs closer than three fingers apart, and the neighbours stop believing he builds only for a bigger catch.⁷⁶
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,831** — *Bran tells his mother the boat's purpose.* Two winters into the building, Bran tells his mother plainly that he means to sail west and prove Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁷⁷'s word of a land beyond the sea's edge true or false. She does not forbid him, though she warns him no telling yet has anyone to bring it home.⁷⁸

68. the Telling of the Making

69. the land of the young

70. the plain of delight

71. the house of Donn, where the dead go

72. ◇ Same person *Bran born to the north-west shore*, 6 am Màrt, VE 2,801.

73. ◇ Same person *Bran stands at the tideline at dusk*, 15 an Lùnastal, VE 2,815.

74. ◇ Same person *The best boatman of that coast*, 13 an t-Sultain, VE 2,825.

75. ◇ Same person *Bran mends every boat on the shore*, 12 an Dàmhair, VE 2,828.

76. ◇ Same person *Bran begins the great bull*, 10 an t-Samhain, VE 2,829.

77. the Telling of the Making

78. ◇ Same person *The great bull decked with sealed skins*, 21 an Giblean, VE 2,830.

- 20 AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,831** — *The great hull finished.* By the second spring Bran's boat stands finished on its trestles, broader and higher at the bow than any craft that coast has built, decked with sealed skins to throw off green water, built plainly for open sea rather than the shallows.⁷⁹
- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 2,831** — *Blàthnaid's promise asked and given.* The night before the boat puts out, Blàthnaid asks her brother Bran to tell her the truth of whatever he finds, if ever he has the chance. He promises it, a promise she keeps for the rest of her life though he never returns to be asked again.⁸⁰
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 2,831** — *Bran sails west.* In high summer Bran puts out from the north-west shore with four kinsmen, holding his bow south of the grey bank that never lifts off the northern sea and west into open water no boat of that coast has crossed before. The household sends them off in silence.⁸¹
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,831** — *Five put out west, the grey bank on the right hand.* Bran holds his bow west and a little south of the grey bank that lies on the northern sea, standing the whole first morning at the steering-oar and watching the bank fall away astern until it is nothing.⁸²
- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,833** — *The First Canoe.* Among the coastal Tuathaich families a half-forgotten telling of a voyage is kept, long hushed: a steersman with a name, and a first crossing to an isle of the blessed. Their church tells it as the voyage of Naomh Breandan. The druids of the Old Faith call it idle belief.⁸³
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,833** — *The crewman found on the southern shingle.* A season and more after the boat put out, a woman gathering shellfish finds the youngest of the crew, Bran's sister's son, alive but near dead on a stretch of shingle two days south of his home shore, sun-blackened and too parched to speak.⁸⁴
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,833** — *The boy's telling of the green land.* Over days of broken whispers the crewman tells of many days on open water, then a green land rising from the sea where fruit hung ready and a spring broke sweet from the rock, and a welcome from a people unmarked by age.⁸⁵

79. ◇ Same person *Bran tells his mother the boat's purpose*, 7 an Cèitean, VE 2,831.

80. ◇ Same person *The great hull finished*, 20 an Cèitean, VE 2,831.

81. ◇ Same person *Blàthnaid's promise asked and given*, 5 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,831.

82. ◇ Same person *Bran sails west*, 4 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,831.

83. ← Leads to *Bran born to the north-west shore*, 6 am Màrt, VE 2,801; ← Leads to *The best boatman of that coast*, 13 an t-Sultain, VE 2,825; → Caused by *Bran begins the great hull*, 10 an t-Samhain, VE 2,829; → Caused by *Bran tells his mother the boat's purpose*, 7 an Cèitean, VE 2,831; → Caused by *The great hull finished*, 20 an Cèitean, VE 2,831; → Caused by *Blàthnaid's promise asked and given*, 5 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,831; → Caused by *Bran sails west*, 4 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,831; → Caused by *Five put out west, the grey bank on the right hand*, 24 an t-Samhain, VE 2,831.

84. ← Follows from *The First Canoe*, 9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833; ◇ Same person *Five put out west, the grey bank on the right hand*, 24 an t-Samhain, VE 2,831.

85. ← Follows from *The First Canoe*, 9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833; ◇ Same person *The crewman found on the southern shingle*, 13 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833.

- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,833** — *Bran stays in the west.* The crewman tells that Bran, offered his freedom to turn home, chose to stay on the green shore, saying he would not turn from the question he had followed his whole life to answer now that his feet stood on it.⁸⁶
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,833** — *The crewman dies.* Eleven days after he is carried in from the shingle, Bran's sister's son dies with the door left open on the sea, saying to the last that the land had not been unkind and his uncle had not looked afraid.⁸⁷
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,834** — *The telling spreads along the coast.* Within a year of the boy's death the telling of the green land in the west has gone the length of the north-west shore and inland besides, growing surer in each mouth than the dying boy ever claimed it.⁸⁸
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,834** — *Strangers turned from the dying boy's door.* By the fourth day after the crewman is carried in, strangers come to the door asking to see the boy who crossed the western sea, and are turned away for his quiet.⁸⁹
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 2,838** — *A boy nearly follows the telling west.* A fifteen-year-old of the shore is found in the dark sitting in a coracle he has no business taking out, looking west, and is brought home and wept over, the telling's first plain harm.⁹⁰
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,838** — *The elders let the telling fall.* The elders of three shore households agree at a closed fire to starve the telling of the green land rather than forbid it outright, answering no stranger's question of it and teaching it to no child who has not already heard it.⁹¹
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,840** — *Blàthnaid tells her daughter, once.* An old woman by then, Blàthnaid keeps her promise the only way left to her, telling her grown daughter the whole of the boy's account at a covered hearth, and naming her brother at the end of it: Bran.⁹²
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,860** — *Blàthnaid dies.* Blàthnaid dies an old woman, having told the steersman's telling to no one but her own daughter, who carries it on in the same low voice at the same covered fire.⁹³
- I AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,870** — *Brian digs through frozen ground for a child* (Tobar dhìreach). When a child of the black-well household dies of a fever in Brian's twentieth year, he digs through frozen ground for the better part of two days without once cursing it, and sits by the raw earth a while after.

86. ← Follows from *The First Canoe*, 9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833; ◇ Same person *The boy's telling of the green land*, 15 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833.

87. ← Follows from *The First Canoe*, 9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833; ◇ Same person *Bran stays in the west*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, VE 2,833.

88. ← Follows from *The First Canoe*, 9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833.

89. ← Follows from *The First Canoe*, 9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833.

90. ← Follows from *The First Canoe*, 9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833.

91. ← Follows from *The First Canoe*, 9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833.

92. ↔ Answers *The First Canoe*, 9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833; ◇ Same person *Blàthnaid's promise asked and given*, 5 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,831.

93. ← Follows from *The First Canoe*, 9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833; ◇ Same person *Blàthnaid tells her daughter, once*, 29 an Dàmhair, VE 2,840.

- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,879** — *Brian marries Caoimbe* (Tobar dhìreach). Brian, grave-digger of the high valleys, marries Caoimhe of a herding household two valleys east, a quick-tongued woman known for setting a whole hearth laughing. Three children born to them die in their first winter, one after another.⁹⁴
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 2,880** — *Brian takes up the grave-digger's work* (Tobar dhìreach). Brian, of Clann a' Chlachair⁹⁵, becomes known through the high valleys as the one who digs the graves of the dead, a trade his father had kept before him. He is a plain, steady man, slow of speech, and the valley comes to trust his hands with its dead.⁹⁶
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,884** — *Brian thinks of the earth at a graveside* (Tobar dhìreach). Waiting at the edge of a fresh grave for the kin to bring the body down, Brian thinks that the dead lie still and the earth takes them, and that if the earth is to take a coal it must go deep and be left.⁹⁷
- 24 AM MÀRT, VE 2,885** — *Neighbours gather to watch the coals buried* (Tobar dhìreach). Word of Brian's digging draws watchers to the graveside through the evening: an old man who had tried the coals himself in his youth, two of Sireadh's grandchildren, a boy sent home twice who comes back a third time. The talk among them does not agree.⁹⁸
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,885** — *The burial words said over five coals* (Tobar dhìreach). Standing in the grave he has dug for five coals, Brian says over them the words said over every grave in the high valleys, asking the ground to hold gently what is given it.⁹⁹
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,885** — *The black coal warm in the ground* (Tobar dhìreach). Brian of the Mason's line buries the five unlit coals deep in the ground beside the slab at Tobar dhìreach. When he digs them up on the next day the black coal, as black as a wet crow, is warm in his hand and smoulders as the air comes to it; the other four are as cold as the clay.¹⁰⁰
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,885** — *Brian reasons the earth wants its own time* (Tobar dhìreach). Standing at a fresh grave, Brian reasons that as the sea took its coal by wading and the sky by the height of a throw, the earth might take its coal only if left buried deep and undisturbed, as the dead are left. He carries the thought to Sireadh, keeper of the bag.¹⁰¹

94. ◇ Same person *Brian digs through frozen ground for a child*, 1 an t-Sultain, VE 2,870.

95. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

96. ◇ Same person *Brian marries Caoimbe*, 30 an t-Sultain, VE 2,879.

97. ◇ Same person *Brian takes up the grave-digger's work*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 2,880.

98. ◇ Same person *Brian thinks of the earth at a graveside*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 2,884.

99. ◇ Same person *Neighbours gather to watch the coals buried*, 24 am Màrt, VE 2,885.

100. → Caused by *Brian thinks of the earth at a graveside*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 2,884; → Caused by *Neighbours gather to watch the coals buried*, 24 am Màrt, VE 2,885; → Caused by *The burial words said over five coals*, 13 an Lùnastal, VE 2,885.

101. ← Follows from *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air*, 2 an t-Sultain, VE 2,170; ◇ Same person *The burial words said over five coals*, 13 an Lùnastal, VE 2,885.

12 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,885 — *Sireadh gives Brian the five dark coals* (Tobar dhìreach). Sireadh, eldest keeper of the leather bag since Fionnghuala's day, gives Brian the five coals that have not yet answered, keeping back only her doubt that a grave-digger's guess will fare better than the trials that failed before it.¹⁰²

8 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,885 — *The black coal set in Teine a' Chlachair*¹⁰³ (Tobar dhìreach). Brian carries the warm black coal to the hearth at Tobar dhìreach and sets it among the embers of the fire Clann a' Chlachair¹⁰⁴ holds to have burned unbroken since Oidhche an Deal-anaich¹⁰⁵. It catches and burns on, and is not seen to go dark again.¹⁰⁶

24 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,885 — *Sireadh reads the black coal's answer* (Tobar dhìreach). Sireadh, the old widow who kept the bag sixty years, says at the graveside that the earth took the coal: the answering came at the rising out of the ground, not the lying in it.¹⁰⁷

12 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,886 — *Brian keeps the black coal in his own pot* (Tobar dhìreach). Brian makes a clay pot of his own, fired for the purpose, with a lid of fresh-cut turf, and keeps the black coal burning in it for the rest of his life, feeding it wood and heather and carrying it with him at his work through the high valleys.¹⁰⁸

13 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,895 — *Sireadh dies* (Tobar dhìreach). Sireadh dies an old woman, having lived to see the black coal warm in Brian's hand at the graveside by Leac na Fèithe¹⁰⁹.

110

9 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,915 — *Brian teaches the grave-digger's trade* (Tobar dhìreach). Grown old, Brian gives over the heaviest digging to younger hands he has taught himself, teaching them above all to line a grave true, so the sides will not fall on what is laid in it; he goes on keeping the black coal at his own hearth.¹¹¹

30 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,921 — *Brian dies at three-and-sixty* (Tobar dhìreach). Brian, grave-digger of the high valleys and finder of the black coal, dies at three-and-sixty, worn by his years of labour rather than by any illness the valley can name. He is buried beside Leac na Fèithe¹¹² at Tobar dhìreach, near the ground he first opened for the five coals.¹¹³

102. ◇ Same person *Brian reasons the earth wants its own time*, 26 an t-Sultain, VE 2,885.

103. the mason's fire, the first fire

104. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

105. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

106. ← Follows from *The black coal warm in the ground*, 17 an t-Sultain, VE 2,885; ◇ Same person *Sireadh gives Brian the five dark coals*, 12 an Dàmhair, VE 2,885.

107. ← Follows from *The black coal warm in the ground*, 17 an t-Sultain, VE 2,885; ◇ Same person *Sireadh gives Brian the five dark coals*, 12 an Dàmhair, VE 2,885.

108. ◇ Same person *The black coal set in Teine a' Chlachair*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, VE 2,885.

109. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

110. ◇ Same person *Sireadh reads the black coal's answer*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, VE 2,885.

111. ◇ Same person *Brian keeps the black coal in his own pot*, 12 an Dàmhair, VE 2,886.

112. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,921** — *The black coal burns at Brian's burial* (Tobar dhìreach). The pot holding the black coal is set beside Brian's grave, still burning, banked low, through the length of his burial; when the earth is given, Caoimhe lifts the pot herself and carries it home, and keeps the coal burning at her own hearth after.¹¹⁴
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,921** — *The count of the coals said new at the recital* (Tobar dhìreach). At the next night of the lightning the reciter of the line adds the black coal to the count: the sea has taken the gold, the sky the white-flecked coal, and now the earth the black, gual dubh¹¹⁵, slowly, in the dark. Four coals remain unanswered.¹¹⁶
- 20 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 2,930** — *Caoimhe dies* (Tobar dhìreach). Caoimhe, wife of Brian the grave-digger, dies nine years after him, having kept the black coal burning at her own hearth all that while and never remarried; the coal passes from her hands into other keeping, banked and fed as it had been from the first.¹¹⁷
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, VE 2,937** — *The stakes found in the tidal mud*. A boy minding his household's mooring finds a straight row of older stakes further out in the tidal mud below the north-western point, one still hung with a scrap of stitched hide. No household owns to having driven them, and who did, or from where, the mud never says.
- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,937** — *Stakes in the mud below Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). The first sure boats of the north-west coast leave their trace in the tidal mud below Ceann mhòr: a row of mooring stakes and a scrap of stitched hide. Who rowed them, and from where, is not known.¹¹⁸
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 2,940** — *The stakes shown to children with a shrug*. The line of old stakes in the mud below the north-western point comes to be called only the stakes, shown to children once by an older cousin with a shrug rather than a story.¹¹⁹
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 2,990** — *A back rises off the north-western point*. Four men working a mackerel net before dawn see a vast dark back rise smoothly from flat water off the north-west, longer than any whale known to that coast, and sink again without spray or sound. None can afterward agree how long it showed itself, only that it was greater than anything with business in water so shallow.
- I AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,990** — *The Sea-Watcher first sighted* (Uilebheist na Mara¹²⁰). Old sailors tell of a vast creature dwelling in the waters off the north-western coast. No wreck has ever been brought up to prove them wrong.¹²¹

113. ¶ Legacy *The black coal warm in the ground*, 17 an t-Sultain, VE 2,885; ◇ Same person *Brian teaches the grave-digger's trade*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, VE 2,915.

114. ◇ Same person *Brian dies at three-and-sixty*, 30 an t-Sultain, VE 2,921.

115. the black coal, of earth

116. ¶ Legacy *The black coal warm in the ground*, 17 an t-Sultain, VE 2,885.

117. ◇ Same person *The black coal burns at Brian's burial*, 29 an Dàmhair, VE 2,921.

118. → Caused by *The stakes found in the tidal mud*, 20 an Giblean, VE 2,937.

119. ← Follows from *Stakes in the mud below Ceann mhòr*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, VE 2,937.

120. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

121. → Caused by *A back rises off the north-western point*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,990.

5 AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,991 — *The sighting told at the hearths.* Within a day the four men's telling has gone the length of the coast, and within its second telling the creature has a name that will not leave it again: Uilebheist na Mara¹²². Not every hearth believes them, but the water off the point is from that year Uilebheist na Mara's water in every mouth, believed or doubted alike.¹²³

6 AN GIBLEAN, VE 2,995 — *The youngest of the four keeps the telling unaltered.* The youngest of the four men who saw Uilebheist na Mara¹²⁴ rise carries the telling word for word into his old age, adding nothing and taking nothing away, and the coast counts this for more than any argument of the doubters.¹²⁵

122. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

123. ← Follows from *The Sea-Watcher first sighted*, 1 an t-Sultain, VE 2,990.

124. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

125. ← Follows from *The Sea-Watcher first sighted*, 1 an t-Sultain, VE 2,990.

THE YEARS VE 3,001 – 3,500

- 8 AM MÀRT, VE 3,015** — *Criomthann born to the shore.* Criomthann is born into a household of net-menders and boatmen kin, at some remove, to the household that once sent Bran west over the open sea. He grows up knowing the shape of that older grief by its silences rather than by being told it plainly, and it leaves him wary of open water all his life.¹
- 7 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,020** — *Criomthann pulls a boy from a rip.* Criomthann, still a young man, pulls a boy from a rip current with his own hand while three grown men stand arguing on the shingle about the best way to go after him.²
- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,035** — *Two drown in water that shows no storm.* A boat close in below the point goes over in a swell no watcher on shore can account for, and two men drown within sight of their own hearth smoke. The loss is not laid to Uilebheist na Mara³, the water being the wrong water, but it teaches Criomthann, newly a father, that the sea gives little warning of the moment it means to take something.⁴
- 15 AM MÀRT, VE 3,042** — *Criomthann first climbs the headland with fire.* Sixteen years after the drowning below the point, Criomthann begins carrying driftwood and gorse to the last headland of that coast of an evening, less as a plan reasoned out than as a thing he finds his hands already doing, and lights a fire that will not go dark again in his lifetime.⁵
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,042** — *The beacon on the Baile chrom headland* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom⁶). A fire is kept on the headland where Taigh-solais Baile chrom now stands, and its ash lies a man's height deep. The tellings say it was lit to warn boats off the water where the Sea-Watcher was seen, and never to bring them in.⁷
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 3,044** — *The warning settles into few words.* Over repeated evenings calling down from the headland to boats working too far into Uilebheist na Mara⁸'s water, Criomthann's warning wears smooth into a saying his own children can say back to him in their sleep: Turn back. This water is not for you.⁹
- 7 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,060** — *A peat bank kept for the headland fire.* Criomthann's household keeps aside a bank of peat cut for the headland fire alone, touched for nothing else, so that the fire is never let go dark even in the leanest winter.¹⁰

1. ← Follows from *The First Canoe*, 9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833.

2. ◇ Same person *Criomthann born to the shore*, 8 am Màrt, VE 3,015.

3. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

4. ◇ Same person *Criomthann pulls a boy from a rip*, 7 an Gearran, VE 3,020.

5. ◇ Same person *Two drown in water that shows no storm*, 9 am Faoilleach, VE 3,035.

6. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

7. → Caused by *Two drown in water that shows no storm*, 9 am Faoilleach, VE 3,035; → Caused by *Criomthann first climbs the headland with fire*, 15 am Màrt, VE 3,042.

8. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

9. ← Follows from *The beacon on the Baile chrom headland*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 3,042; ◇ Same person *Criomthann first climbs the headland with fire*, 15 am Màrt, VE 3,042.

10. ← Follows from *The beacon on the Baile chrom headland*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 3,042; ◇ Same person *The warning settles into few words*, 12 an t-Samhain, VE 3,044.

- 8 AM MÀRT, VE 3,070** — *Criomthann's wife dies of a fever.* A fever that takes half the young children of the north-western shore in one bad season takes Criomthann's wife with them, and he keeps the headland fire nine years a widower.¹¹
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,078** — *Criomthann's strength fails the climb.* Nine years widowed, at three-and-sixty Criomthann can no longer carry wood up the last steep pitch of the headland, and his eldest son takes up the feeding of the fire, so that the flame he lit for no reason he could fully name burns on past the reach of his own life.¹²
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,079** — *Criomthann dies.* Criomthann dies at four-and-sixty in his own bed, three generations of his kin about him, having outlived every one of the four who first saw Uilebheist na Mara¹³ rise. At his own asking he is buried on the lower slope of the headland, within sound of the fire he kept.¹⁴
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,090** — *A calm summer fills the nets at Ros ruadh* (Ros ruadh). A run of flat, windless weather settles over the water off Ros ruadh, the kind of calm fishermen pray for and seldom get, and the settlement's boats work it harder than any season in memory.
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 3,090** — *The first boat fails to come home* (Ros ruadh). A boat with three men aboard, working water well inside what the settlement calls safe, does not return with the tide. No wreckage of it is ever found on any shingle the length of that coast.
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 3,093** — *The second boat fails eleven days after the first* (Ros ruadh). A second boat of Ros ruadh, with two men aboard, fails to come home eleven days after the first, from a different stretch of the same calm water, and again no wreckage is found.
- 24 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,094** — *Seven boats lost from Ros ruadh in one season* (Ros ruadh). Boat after boat fails to return through a summer of unbroken calm, until seven are lost from Ros ruadh with no storm to blame and no wreck or body ever recovered. Scarcely a hearth in the settlement is left untouched.
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,094** — *Seven boats lost off Ros ruadh* (Ros ruadh). Seven boats are lost from Ros ruadh in one calm season, with no storm to blame. It is the first loss laid at the door of the Sea-Watcher by name; before this it was feared only in general.¹⁵

11. ◇ Same person *A peat bank kept for the headland fire*, 7 an Gearran, VE 3,060.

12. ← Follows from *The beacon on the Baile chrom headland*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 3,042; ◇ Same person *Criomthann's wife dies of a fever*, 8 am Màrt, VE 3,070.

13. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

14. ← Follows from *The beacon on the Baile chrom headland*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 3,042; ◇ Same person *Criomthann's strength fails the climb*, 6 an Giblean, VE 3,078.

15. → Caused by *A calm summer fills the nets at Ros ruadh*, 14 an Dàmhair, VE 3,090; → Caused by *The first boat fails to come home*, 12 an t-Samhain, VE 3,090; → Caused by *The second boat fails eleven days after the first*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, VE 3,093; → Caused by *Seven boats lost from Ros ruadh in one season*, 24 an t-Sultain, VE 3,094.

20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,095 — *The widows name Uilebheist na Mara*¹⁶ (Ros ruadh). The widows of Ros ruadh are the first to say plainly, at every hearth that will hear it, that Uilebheist na Mara has taken their seven boats. It is the first loss on that coast laid at Uilebheist na Mara's door by name rather than only feared in its shadow, and the naming holds ever after.

¹⁷

19 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,096 — *Kin from three households feed the beacon together*. In the year after the widows' naming, the headland fire burns harder than in any year since Criomthann first lit it, fed now by hands from three households besides his own grandson's, as though a fire fed by more hands might answer for what seamanship could not.¹⁸

22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,120 — *The ash on the headland stands a man's height deep*. Fed and banked and fed again by hands born after the worst of the lost season, the beacon's ash has by now been heaped on the same ground for so many lifetimes that it stands a man's own height deep, deep enough that a boy sent to feed it can stand in the hollow of it and be seen from below only from the shoulders up.¹⁹

24 AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,146 — *Seven empty places on the shingle* (Ros ruadh). The shingle at Ros ruadh has by now shifted through enough winters' tides that it no longer holds even the memory of where the seven lost boats once lay drawn up among the rest, and only the headland fire and the widows' naming remain to say the seven ever went out from that shore at all.²⁰

30 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,147 — *The seal hunt moves south* (Caol mhòr). The hunters of the north-west leave the open water and work the southern side of the headlands, out of the Sea-Watcher's sight. The seal bones thin in the middens of the north-west and grow at Caol mhòr and Cuan bheag.

19 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,150 — *The open-water hunt gives way to the strait* (Bothan a' Chaolais²¹). Crew by crew, the boats of the north-west leave the open coast off the last headland for the sheltered water in its lee, keeping the whole of their ground in sight at once. The seal grounds at Ros ruadh and the outer skerries thin as the strait grounds fill.²²

21 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,155 — *An old steersman says the island's hand has drawn back* (Bothan a' Chaolais²³). An old steersman of the strait says, at a gathering for net-mending, that the sea has not grown smaller, only that the island's hand has drawn back from the part of it a man can no longer trust.²⁴

16. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

17. ← Answers *Seven boats lost off Ros ruadh*, 29 an Dàmhair, VE 3,094.

18. ← Follows from *The beacon on the Baile chrom headland*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 3,042.

19. ← Follows from *The beacon on the Baile chrom headland*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 3,042.

20. ← Follows from *Seven boats lost off Ros ruadh*, 29 an Dàmhair, VE 3,094.

21. the bothies of the strait; the north-shore seal camp on the strait (place 1010, site of burg 95)

22. → Leads to *The seal hunt moves south*, 30 an t-Sultain, VE 3,147.

23. the bothies of the strait; the north-shore seal camp on the strait (place 1010, site of burg 95)

- 26 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,160** — *The middens of Bothan a' Chaolais*²⁵ *outgrow the old grounds* (Bothan a' Chaolais). Shell and bone rise faster at Bothan a' Chaolais than they have ever risen, until the bothy folk say a winter's leavings there would wall a house. An old steersman of the strait says plainly what the coast has already done without saying it.²⁶
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,180** — *Eimhir born to a herding household of Doire uaine* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte²⁷). Eimhir is born into a herding family of the high pastures south of Tobar dhireach, in country the hill folk still call the green grove for the oaks it once bore. She grows to the flock and the ground before she grows to much else.
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,199** — *Signs cut in the Doire uaine hills* (Doire uaine). Inscriptions are cut on rock faces all across the Doire uaine hills, more than anywhere else on the island, in lines that run for yards. Some lines are cut over and defaced with the same kind of tool that made them.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,200** — *A ewe strays into a defile of the hills* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte²⁸). A ewe strays in the night up a narrow defile of the Doire uaine hills where the flock is not taken, and Eimhir follows it before first light into a fold of the hill she does not remember walking.²⁹
- 9 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,210** — *Eimhir finds the cut stone* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte³⁰). Following a strayed ewe up an unfamiliar defile before dawn, Eimhir comes on a rock face cut with lines of writing no hand of that country claims, running the height of the stone and further, in a hand unlike any boundary-mark or tally she knows.³¹
- 27 AM MÀRT, VE 3,210** — *Elders of the hills judge the writing older than living memory* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte³²). A small company of the hill country's elders climbs to see the cut stone for itself. One tests it with a flat palm and says nothing; another, walking its length twice, says she knows no hand that claims the writing, and holds that the country will come to know it in its own time.³³

24. ← Follows from *The seal hunt moves south*, 30 an t-Sultain, VE 3,147.

25. the bothies of the strait; the north-shore seal camp on the strait (place 1010, site of burg 95)

26. ← Follows from *The seal hunt moves south*, 30 an t-Sultain, VE 3,147.

27. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

28. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

29. → Leads to *Signs cut in the Doire uaine hills*, 8 an Cèitean, VE 3,199; ◇ Same person *Eimhir born to a herding household of Doire uaine*, 28 am Faoilleach, VE 3,180.

30. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

31. → Leads to *Signs cut in the Doire uaine hills*, 8 an Cèitean, VE 3,199; ◇ Same person *A ewe strays into a defile of the hills*, 25 an Giblean, VE 3,200.

32. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

- II AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,212** — *The hills come to a common telling of the writing* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte³⁴). Within two winters, gathered out of dreams two or three swear separately to the same shape and out of half-kept scraps no one can trace to a source, every hearth of that country can tell what the cutting is held to say: a thing that does not breathe, and falls on any fire it sees lit.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 3,212** — *Dreams of the same shape at several hearths* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte³⁵). Two or three people of the Doire uaine hills swear, without having spoken to one another, that they have dreamed in nearly the same shape of something walking the ridges without breath.
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,213** — *The second cutting is argued over at the hearths* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte³⁶). That parts of the writing were struck across afterward, by what seems the very tool that first cut them, divides the hill country's telling: some hold the writer came back to unwrite a part too dangerous to keep whole; others hold the thing named in the writing did the defacing itself.³⁷
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 3,215** — *Children go less often alone to the far pastures* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte³⁸). Without any rule said aloud, fewer households of the Doire uaine hills send a child alone to the farthest grazing after the finding of the writing, and fewer let a night fire burn low and unwatched when the wind comes strange off the high ground.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,230** — *Two herders see the walker on the ridge and live* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte³⁹). Caught by dusk driving beasts home, two herders of the hills see an upright figure walk the crest against the last light, breathing no cloud into the cold air. Neither has a fire lit or a light shown on the path, and both come home to tell it.
- I AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 3,230** — *The defile given a wide berth* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁴⁰). By common unspoken consent the defile where the cut stone stands is given a wide berth, and a strayed sheep is fetched from it only by daylight and never by a child alone.⁴¹

33. ← Follows from *Signs cut in the Doire uaine hills*, 8 an Cèitean, VE 3,199; ◇ Same person *Eimbir finds the cut stone*, 9 an Gearran, VE 3,210.

34. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearth (place 1007, site of burg 148)

35. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearth (place 1007, site of burg 148)

36. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearth (place 1007, site of burg 148)

37. ◇ Same person *Elders of the hills judge the writing older than living memory*, 27 am Màrt, VE 3,210.

38. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearth (place 1007, site of burg 148)

39. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearth (place 1007, site of burg 148)

40. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearth (place 1007, site of burg 148)

41. ← Follows from *Signs cut in the Doire uaine hills*, 8 an Cèitean, VE 3,199.

- 24 AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,250** — *Eimhir teaches her children the fire and the ridge* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁴²). Eimhir teaches her children that the writing is there, that no one reads it, and that a fire built where the ridge can see it is a fire built carelessly, whatever else a person believes.⁴³
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,251** — *The Hollow Man of Doire uaine* (Marbh-bheò⁴⁴ Doire uaine). The inscriptions of the Doire uaine hills tell of something that walked without breathing, and fell upon any who lit a fire in its sight.⁴⁵
- 26 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,260** — *The first hearth is dug and roofed at Doire uaine* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁴⁶). A household newly come to the eastern side of the hills digs its cooking fire into a pit and roofs it with a slab, showing no flame above ground. Mocked at first, the family's fire burns unremarked through a hard winter, and two more households follow within the year.
- 27 AM MÀRT, VE 3,261** — *Eimhir keeps her hearth open against the new custom* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁴⁷). With half the hearths of the hill country dug in or talking of it, Eimhir, old now, tells her daughter she will not hide the fire her family has always kept open to the sky, having touched the writing on the stone herself before any household thought to cover its light.⁴⁸
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,262** — *Eimhir dies* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁴⁹). Eimhir dies of no illness the hill country can name, worn out by a long life, and is buried above her family's grazing with a stone set on end and no other marker. Her daughter banks her hearth for the last time and does not build it open again.⁵⁰
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,300** — *The covered hearth spreads short of a rule* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁵¹). Within forty years an open fire on the bare floor grows rare enough in the Doire uaine hills that a child raised to one is asked after it at every gathering, though households on the country's quieter edges still keep the old way, and no rule yet binds the rest.

42. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

43. ◇ Same person *The second cutting is argued over at the hearths*, 28 am Faoilleach, VE 3,213.

44. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

45. → Caused by *The hills come to a common telling of the writing*, 11 am Faoilleach, VE 3,212; → Caused by *Dreams of the same shape at several hearths*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, VE 3,212; ← Leads to *The second cutting is argued over at the hearths*, 28 am Faoilleach, VE 3,213; ← Leads to *Two herders see the walker on the ridge and live*, 25 an Giblean, VE 3,230; ← Leads to *Eimhir teaches her children the fire and the ridge*, 24 an Cèitean, VE 3,250.

46. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

47. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

48. ◇ Same person *Eimhir teaches her children the fire and the ridge*, 24 an Cèitean, VE 3,250.

49. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

50. ◇ Same person *Eimhir keeps her hearth open against the new custom*, 27 am Màrt, VE 3,261.

51. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,304** — *Laoghaire begins the first pit-hearth* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁵²). On a shoulder of ground below his own house, Laoghaire digs a hearth a man's height into the earth, with a blind angled shaft down to it and a slab dragged over the top, and sleeps beside it the first night to learn whether it holds its heat and shows no light above.
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,304** — *The hill fires go under the ground* (Doire uaine). After the inscriptions the hearths of the Doire uaine hills are dug into pits and roofed with slabs. No open hearth shows in those hills for many lifetimes. The people stay, and hide their light.⁵³
- 22 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,304** — *The blind bend in the shaft* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁵⁴). Laoghaire cuts the way down to his pit-hearth as a slanting shaft bent near its foot, so that no glow from below can climb it straight, and leads the smoke out through a crack in the turf ten paces off.⁵⁵
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,304** — *Laoghaire sleeps the first night in the pit* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁵⁶). Laoghaire sleeps the first night the pit-hearth is whole beside its fire under Leac na Fèithe⁵⁷, listening for anything on the turf above, and comes up at first light with soot on his hands and nothing heard.⁵⁸
- 7 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,305** — *Two more households dig the like* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁵⁹). Within the season two households of Laoghaire's own kin dig covered hearths beside their own doors on the pattern he showed them, the first word of the pit under Leac na Fèithe⁶⁰ carried hearth to hearth the way any useful thing travelled in those hills.⁶¹
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,308** — *The line at Tobar dhireach is asked to cover its fire*. Kin by marriage from the Doire uaine households ask outright at Tobar dhireach why the household of the mason's own fire alone keeps an open hearth. The keeper of the pot answers that a fire never once let go dark cannot now be hidden without being treated as any lesser fire, and the line's hearth stays open.⁶²

52. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

53. → Caused by *The first hearth is dug and roofed at Doire uaine*, 26 an Gearran, VE 3,260; ⇌ At the same time *Eimhir keeps her hearth open against the new custom*, 27 am Màrt, VE 3,261; ← Leads to *The covered hearth spreads short of a rule*, 17 an t-Sultain, VE 3,300; → Caused by *Laoghaire begins the first pit-hearth*, 18 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,304.

54. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

55. ← Follows from *The hill fires go under the ground*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,304; ◇ Same person *Laoghaire begins the first pit-hearth*, 18 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,304.

56. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

57. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhireach

58. ◇ Same person *The blind bend in the shaft*, 22 an Lùnastal, VE 3,304.

59. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

60. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhireach

61. ← Follows from *The hill fires go under the ground*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,304; ◇ Same person *Laoghaire sleeps the first night in the pit*, 12 an Dàmhair, VE 3,304.

- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,310** — *The line keeps its hearth open* (Tobar dhìreach). The man who keeps the pot at Tobar dhìreach answers every neighbour who asks why the line will not cover its fire that Teine a' Chlachair⁶³ is owed better than to be hidden as a hillside peat-fire hides from its fears.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,320** — *The custom spreads through the hills* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁶⁴). Within a handful of years it is the open hearth that wants explaining and the covered one that needs none; households across the Doire uaine hills dig their own, some by Laoghaire's own hand, until no open hearth shows in that country any longer.⁶⁵
- I AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,325** — *A branch at Tobar dhìreach digs a hearth apart*. One branch of Clann a' Chlachair⁶⁶ digs itself a covered hearth away from the line's own house, keeping the open fire only for the recital nights. The compromise satisfies no one fully and is quietly let drop again within two generations.⁶⁷
- 20 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,330** — *Laoghaire digs for a widowed sister* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁶⁸). Laoghaire digs three more pit-hearths in his life, one for a widowed sister and two for households that beg it of him, for he alone seems to hold in his head how far the blind bend must run.⁶⁹
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,341** — *Laoghaire dies* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁷⁰). Laoghaire dies at six-and-sixty in his own house, having outlived two of his own children and dug covered hearths for kin across the hills. He is buried on the shoulder of ground above the pit he dug first, which his sons keep in use for three generations after him.⁷¹
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,351** — *The nine at the bill camp* (Muileann chiar). Nine people die inside a hut at the camp where Muileann chiar was afterwards built, and lie where they fell beside a hearth of fresh ash. No wound is found on any bone. The hut is never opened again, and none is buried from it.

62. → Leads to *The bill fires go under the ground*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,304.

63. the mason's fire, the first fire

64. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

65. ← Follows from *The bill fires go under the ground*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,304; ◇ Same person *Two more households dig the like*, 7 an Giblean, VE 3,305.

66. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

67. ← Follows from *The bill fires go under the ground*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,304.

68. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

69. ◇ Same person *The custom spreads through the hills*, 30 an Lùnastal, VE 3,320.

70. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

71. ← Follows from *The bill fires go under the ground*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,304; ◇ Same person *Laoghaire digs for a widowed sister*, 20 an Gearran, VE 3,330.

- 10 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,352** — *The hill camp found silent* (Muileann chiar). A shepherd going up to a wintering camp in the south of the massif, seeing no smoke rise from it, finds a hut's door standing open and nine people within lying dead beside a cold hearth, unmarked by wound or struggle. None who come after will go in to bury them.⁷²
- 8 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,352** — *The camp is left for good* (Muileann chiar). The hut with the nine dead in it is left standing, its door swinging, until the wattle rots and the roof falls over them. Other households drive their beasts wide of that shoulder of hill from that season on, and none resettles the camp.⁷³
- 9 AM MÀRT, VE 3,379** — *A family new to the hills builds an open hearth*. Kin from the eastern farms, new to grazing left unclaimed since the camp was given up, build their first house on the old pattern with the hearth open to the roof-hole, hearing the custom of the covered hearth only as a traveller's tale and keeping their fire open through their first autumn despite their neighbours' warning.⁷⁴
- 7 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,380** — *The empty house with the fire still burning*. A boy sent at dawn to borrow fire finds the new household's door standing open, the beds thrown back, and every soul of the house gone without blood, struggle or track in the fresh snow. The banked hearth burns on into the empty room exactly as it was left the night before.⁷⁵
- 6 AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,395** — *An old woman warns the newcomers twice*. An old woman of the next valley walks up twice in a summer to tell a family new to the hills that a people does not dig into its own ground for a hundred years over nothing; they thank her and keep their fire open.
- 4 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,400** — *Two herders see the walker on the ridge* (Muileann chiar). A man and his sister-in-law, out after strayed ewes above the old camp in failing light, see a shape walk the skyline like a man and give off no breath into the cold air. They neither call out nor light a fire near them that evening, and come home unharmed.⁷⁶
- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,407** — *The covered hearth becomes the hills' law* (Na Teallaichean Falaichte⁷⁷). By the year the two herders come down off the ridge, the pit under Leac na Fèithe⁷⁸ is no longer a new thing spreading household by household but simply how a hearth is built in that country; a child born there that year will grow old without ever seeing an open fire under any roof but the one at Tobar dhìreach.⁷⁹

72. → Leads to *The nine at the hill camp*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,351.

73. ← Follows from *The nine at the hill camp*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,351.

74. → Leads to *The hill fires go under the ground*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,304.

75. ← Follows from *The hill fires go under the ground*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,304.

76. ← Follows from *The Hollow Man of Doire uaine*, 9 an Giblean, VE 3,251.

77. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

78. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

79. ← Follows from *The hill fires go under the ground*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,304.

- 21 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,408** — *Coille Naomh Muileann chiar*⁸⁰ *set aside* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar). A forest is held sacred long before any order of the Old Faith claims it. The trees knew it first, the old telling says, and the people after.
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,420** — *The wood-carriers go the long way round* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar⁸¹). Households whose fields run up to Coille Naomh Muileann chiar carry their winter fuel from beyond the far shoulder of open ground, two journeys where one would serve, sooner than put an axe within the wood's bounds.
- 23 AM MÀRT, VE 3,470** — *No axe in the grove* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar⁸²). The families at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar carry their fuel a half-day's walk sooner than cut a branch within it. The charcoal in their hearths is of every wood but that one.⁸³
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,480** — *An uncle grumbles at the wood-carriers' long way round* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar⁸⁴). At the end of a hard winter month, one of Sadhbh's uncles says aloud, half in jest, that a tree is a tree wherever it grows and a fire does not ask where its wood was cut. No one answers him, and by the next carrying he goes the long way round with the rest.⁸⁵
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,496** — *Sadhbh asks what comes of a man who cuts there* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar⁸⁶). Sadhbh as a child asks her father what would come of a man who cut in Coille Naomh Muileann chiar, and is told that no one has ever found out and that he has no wish to be the first.

80. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

81. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

82. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

83. → Caused by *The wood-carriers go the long way round*, 2 an Giblean, VE 3,420.

84. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

85. ← Follows from *No axe in the grove*, 23 am Màrt, VE 3,470.

86. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

THE YEARS VE 3,501 – 4,000

II AM MÀRT, VE 3,513 — *The white stag of the grove* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar¹). Three hunters see a white stag at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar, and none of them draws. This is the first telling of it. The stag returns in the tellings again and again; in this age it has no god.

5 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,518 — *Sadhbh and two others meet the white stag* (Gleann nan Damh²). At the narrow turn of Gleann nan Damh, a white stag breaks from the treeline of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar³ rather than the open hill. Sadhbh, her cousin Oscar and a boy new to the drive all have clean sight of it and time to loose, and none of the three draws.

⁴

7 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 3,519 — *The tale of the stag goes hearth to hearth* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar⁵). The telling of the white stag passes from the nearest hearth outward, gathering colour but losing none of its bones. Some elders say the wood itself put the beast out to be seen; no one that first year gives it a name, god or otherwise.⁶

4 AM MÀRT, VE 3,521 — *Hunters begin letting the gully's beasts go rather than risk the wrong one* (Gleann nan Damh⁷). Carrying the tale of the stag with them, hunters at the glen let a drive go free more readily whenever it breaks for the treeline, at a real cost in meat foregone, rather than risk striking a beast they should not have struck.⁸

3 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,530 — *The white stag is seen again* (Gleann nan Damh⁹). Twenty-two years after Sadhbh's own meeting, a fresh pair of hunters born after the first seeing find a white stag standing at the same treeline. It is taken for the same beast, or near enough that none troubles to argue the difference, and from this second seeing the tale becomes the whole country's, not one hunter's alone.¹⁰

II AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,566 — *Sadhbh dies* (Gleann nan Damh¹¹). Sadhbh, hunter of the eastern households and one of the three who once let the white stag go unloosed at the glen's turn, dies an old woman, having spent her last years telling the tale at hearths that were not her own and refusing, each time she was asked, to make one cause of the stag's wood and the wood of the stones.¹²

1. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

2. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

3. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

4. → Leads to *The white stag of the grove*, 11 am Màrt, VE 3,513; ◇ Same person *Sadhbh asks what comes of a man who cuts there*, 30 an Cèitean, VE 3,496.

5. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

6. ← Follows from *The white stag of the grove*, 11 am Màrt, VE 3,513; ◇ Same person *Sadhbh and two others meet the white stag*, 5 am Faoilleach, VE 3,518.

7. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

8. ← Follows from *The white stag of the grove*, 11 am Màrt, VE 3,513.

9. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

10. ← Follows from *The white stag of the grove*, 11 am Màrt, VE 3,513.

11. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

- 9 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,570** — *Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag*¹³ left unclaimed (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag). A second forest, that seems older than the first, is never settled, never felled, and never walked from end to end.
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,575** — *Three paths end at the same line of stones* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁴). The three paths that run toward the second wood from three quarters are all found, without any household having agreed it, to stop at the same low line of set stones short of the trees.
- 16 AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,600** — *Children are taught the rule of the stones* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁵). Households near the second wood teach their children early and plainly to go as far as the low line of set stones and no further, and to let go whatever strays past it, for nothing lost beyond the line has ever been recovered.
- 14 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,610** — *Children told to let a lost thing go past the stones* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁶). Children of the country of the second wood are told early and plainly: go as far as the stones and no further, and whatever crosses the line ahead of you, a ball or a lamb or a hound, let it go.
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,618** — *The paths that stop at a line of stones* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁷). Tracks are worn toward Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag from three quarters, and all three end at a low line of set stones some way short of the trees. Beyond the stones the ground is not worn.¹⁸
- 19 AM MÀRT, VE 3,620** — *Muireall crosses the line of stones* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁹). Left watching for evening deer with other children at the line of set stones before Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag, the nine-year-old Muireall passes into the trees unseen and uncalled. The eldest child, turned away only a moment, finds her gone with no cry and no mark but a small gap in the undergrowth.²⁰
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,620** — *The whole country comes up with torches* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag²¹). Every household within half a day's walk comes with torches cut and lit before full dark, calling Muireall's name in a chorus that carries over the still evening. They reach the line of stones together and stop there; no torch and no foot crosses it.²²

12. ¶ Legacy *The white stag of the grove*, 11 am Màrt, VE 3,513; ◇ Same person *The tale of the stag goes hearth to hearth*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, VE 3,519.

13. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

14. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

15. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

16. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

17. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

18. → Caused by *Three paths end at the same line of stones*, 13 an Lùnastal, VE 3,575; ← Leads to *Children are taught the rule of the stones*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 3,600.

19. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

20. → Leads to *The paths that stop at a line of stones*, 12 am Faoilleach, VE 3,618.

21. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

22. ← Follows from *The paths that stop at a line of stones*, 12 am Faoilleach, VE 3,618; ◇ Same person *Muireall crosses the line of stones*, 19 am Màrt, VE 3,620.

- 9 **AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,620** — *Muireall's mother asks the wood to give the child back* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag²³). Held at the stones by her own kin, Muireall's mother asks the wood once, low enough that only those nearest her hear it, to return the child. No answer comes but the ordinary movement of leaves any wood gives back to any question.²⁴
- 8 **AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,620** — *The search narrows and ends at the stones* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag²⁵). For three days the country works every fold of ground on the near side of the line and finds no print, no scrap of wool, no trace of Muireall's voice on any wind. On the third day the search stops at the stones, not for want of looking, but because there is nowhere left to look that does not mean crossing a line no one in living memory has ever crossed and returned across.²⁶
- 13 **AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 3,621** — *The hearths say the sith took the child* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag²⁷). With nothing found on the near side of the stones, the hearths give the plainest telling that fits: that the sith, the people of the hills and mounds who held that country first, took Muireall across the line she crossed, and that no household has yet gone in after anything lost that way and come back the better.²⁸
- 11 **AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,621** — *Muireall's household sets a stone by its own threshold*. With no body to bury, Muireall's household cuts her name into a stone of their own setting near their own door rather than at the wood, so that whoever asks after it is told of a child lost at a line of stones on a fine summer evening.²⁹
- 26 **AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,630** — *A grown hand kept near the children at the stones* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag³⁰). After Muireall is lost no household lets its children watch for deer at that stretch of the line of stones without a grown hand near enough to close on a small arm.
- 25 **AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,639** — *The rule of the stones becomes unquestioned custom* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag³¹). A generation on from Muireall's loss, no household near the second wood lets its children watch for deer at the line without a grown hand near enough to hold them back, and children born since grow up knowing the rule before they ever hear the reason for it.³²

23. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

24. ← Follows from *The paths that stop at a line of stones*, 12 am Faoilleach, VE 3,618; ◇ Same person *The whole country comes up with torches*, 17 an Giblean, VE 3,620.

25. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

26. ← Follows from *The paths that stop at a line of stones*, 12 am Faoilleach, VE 3,618; ◇ Same person *Muireall's mother asks the wood to give the child back*, 9 an t-Sultain, VE 3,620.

27. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

28. ← Follows from *The paths that stop at a line of stones*, 12 am Faoilleach, VE 3,618; ◇ Same person *The search narrows and ends at the stones*, 8 an Dàmhair, VE 3,620.

29. ← Follows from *The paths that stop at a line of stones*, 12 am Faoilleach, VE 3,618; ◇ Same person *The hearths say the sith took the child*, 13 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,621.

30. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

31. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 3,640** — *Cormac born to the keeper's hearth* (Tobar dhìreach). Cormac is born the eleventh child and fourth son of the household that keeps the bag of dark coals and the recital at Tobar dhìreach, one child among many and not looked to for the line.
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,655** — *The keeping falls to Cormac* (Tobar dhìreach). Cormac's two elder brothers die within one season, one of a fever and one of a fall on the scree above the black well, and the bag of four dark coals and the recital pass to Cormac on his father's death soon after.³³
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,655** — *Cormac's brothers die in one season* (Tobar dhìreach). Cormac's two elder brothers die within a season of each other in his fifteenth year, one of a fever and one of a fall on the scree above the black well, and the learning of the recital comes to him.³⁴
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,660** — *Cormac marries Aoibheann* (Tobar dhìreach). Cormac takes Aoibheann of a herding household two valleys west, who keeps his hearth and, as they grow old together, his fire-pot and his temper both.³⁵
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,662** — *The red-brown coal buried a second time* (Tobar dhìreach). Cormac digs a second, deeper hole beside Leac na Fèithe³⁶ and lays the red-brown coal in it, thinking the earth wants more time than it gave Brian; it lies as cold as before.³⁷
- 1 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,665** — *Gual airgid carried to three rivers* (Tobar dhìreach). In one summer Cormac carries gual airgid³⁸ to three different rivers of the high valleys in turn, in case the Abhainn ghorm alone had been asked; each returns it dark.³⁹
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,669** — *Cormac thinks the grove may hold a leaving* (Tobar dhìreach). Through a wet spring while the lambs are born Cormac turns over the thought that the grove where Coimhdeach na Fine⁴⁰ stood may hold some leaving that would answer a coal as the ground at Tobar dhìreach answered Brian.⁴¹
- 10 AM MÀRT, VE 3,670** — *Cormac resolves on the grove* (Tobar dhìreach). Turning the failed trials over through a wet spring, Cormac comes to think that the grove where Coimhdeach na Fine⁴² once stood may hold in its ground some leaving that would answer a coal, and tells Aoibheann he means to carry the four dark coals north to it.⁴³

32. ← Follows from *The paths that stop at a line of stones*, 12 am Faoilleach, VE 3,618.

33. ◇ Same person *Cormac born to the keeper's hearth*, 23 an t-Samhain, VE 3,640.

34. ◇ Same person *The keeping falls to Cormac*, 26 an t-Sultain, VE 3,655.

35. ◇ Same person *Cormac's brothers die in one season*, 25 an Dàmhair, VE 3,655.

36. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

37. ⇌ At the same time *The black coal warm in the ground*, 17 an t-Sultain, VE 2,885; ◇ Same person *Cormac marries Aoibheann*, 28 an Lùnastal, VE 3,660.

38. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

39. ◇ Same person *The red-brown coal buried a second time*, 30 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,662.

40. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

41. ◇ Same person *Gual airgid carried to three rivers*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,665.

42. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

43. ◇ Same person *Cormac thinks the grove may hold a leaving*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,669.

- 15 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,670** — *The maul turns on the red-brown coal* (Doire ghlas). On the last morning of his month under the oaks Cormac sets the red-brown coal on a flat stone to break it open, and the maul turns on its hard curved face and comes down across the back of his left hand.⁴⁴
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 3,670** — *The blood of the misstrike* (Doire ghlas). Cormac of the Mason's line carries the four unlit coals to the grove at Doire ghlas, where the Keeper first spoke, and sets about breaking them there. His hammer misses and opens the back of his hand, and where the blood falls on the red-brown coal it takes fire. The kindred call it the coal of life.⁴⁵
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 3,670** — *Cormac sets out for Doire ghlas* (Tobar dhìreach). Cormac walks north from Tobar dhìreach with the four dark coals in a leather bag, oatcake and dried mutton over his other shoulder, and no company, reaching the oaks of Doire ghlas on the evening of the third day.⁴⁶
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 3,670** — *A month under the oaks* (Doire ghlas). Cormac keeps a small fire in the lee of a fallen trunk at Doire ghlas for the better part of a month, laying each dark coal in turn at the foot of every old oak he finds, burying them again, and once speaking to the grove outright; nothing answers him.⁴⁷
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 3,670** — *The blood of the misstrike* (Doire ghlas). In a temper at the month's end Cormac sets the red-brown coal on a stone to break it open; the hammer turns on the hard surface and lays open the back of his other hand, and where his blood falls on the coal it catches, burning quietly the colour of firelight through oak while he kneels the better part of a day and forgets to bind the wound.⁴⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 3,670** — *Cormac breaks camp* (Doire ghlas). With his hand bound and the coal of life gone quiet again, Cormac leaves Doire ghlas the same afternoon, judging that the grove itself had answered nothing and the finding had come out of his own blood and not the wood.⁴⁹
- 6 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,671** — *Cormac's return* (Tobar dhìreach). Four days on the road with his wound slowing him, Cormac comes down into the high valleys at evening; Aoibheann, who has watched the northern track for a week, meets him running in the yard, and hears the whole of it before he will go in to the fire.⁵⁰

44. ◇ Same person *Cormac resolves on the grove*, 10 am Màrt, VE 3,670.

45. → Caused by *Cormac resolves on the grove*, 10 am Màrt, VE 3,670; → Caused by *The maul turns on the red-brown coal*, 15 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,670.

46. ○ Same place *The Keeper in the grove*, 17 an Gearran, VE 890; ◇ Same person *The maul turns on the red-brown coal*, 15 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,670.

47. ◇ Same person *Cormac sets out for Doire ghlas*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, VE 3,670.

48. ○ Same place *The blood of the misstrike*, 20 an t-Samhain, VE 3,670; ◇ Same person *A month under the oaks*, 18 an Dùbhlachd, VE 3,670.

49. ◇ Same person *The blood of the misstrike*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, VE 3,670.

50. ← Follows from *The blood of the misstrike*, 20 an t-Samhain, VE 3,670; ◇ Same person *Cormac breaks camp*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, VE 3,670.

7 AM MÀRT, VE 3,671 — *The byname of the Misstrike* (Tobar dhìreach). The valley, which had long since stopped laughing at anything Clann a' Chlachair⁵¹ brought home from the grove, takes to calling Cormac by his scarred hand, Cormac of the Misstrike, and he wears the name and the scar both without complaint.⁵²

28 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,671 — *Cormac holds up his scarred hand at the recital* (Tobar dhìreach). At the next night of the lightning Cormac stands at the hearth with his scarred hand raised for the valley to see and speaks the new line: a fourth coal has answered, quick, out of a man's own blood.⁵³

5 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,672 — *The fourth coal named at the recital* (Tobar dhìreach). At the next telling of the Line on Oidhche an Dealanaich⁵⁴, Cormac holds up his scarred hand before the gathered valley and speaks the new line into the recital: the sea, the sky and the earth had answered, and now a fourth had answered out of a man's own blood, called gual donn-ruadh⁵⁵ and, oftener, the coal of life.⁵⁶

4 AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,690 — *A cousin tries the silver again* (Tobar dhìreach). Cormac gives gual airgid⁵⁷ over to a younger cousin to carry to the rivers in his stead, and lives to see that trial fail as his own had, and to laugh about it with Aoibheann.⁵⁸

20 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,700 — *Children shown the old scar in the firelight* (Tobar dhìreach). For some years children of the high valleys are shown the scar on old Cormac's hand in the firelight and told the coal that would not break and the blood that lit it anyway.⁵⁹

18 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,712 — *Cormac dies at his own hearth* (Tobar dhìreach). Cormac dies in his two-and-seventieth year at Tobar dhìreach, Poit an Teine⁶⁰ burning near him as it burned near every keeper before him, his last clear word a complaint of the old scar aching in the damp.⁶¹

51. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

52. ◇ Same person *Cormac's return*, 6 an Gearran, VE 3,671.

53. ← Follows from *The blood of the misstrike*, 20 an t-Samhain, VE 3,670; ◇ Same person *The byname of the Misstrike*, 7 am Màrt, VE 3,671.

54. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

55. the mahogany coal, of life

56. ← Follows from *The blood of the misstrike*, 20 an t-Samhain, VE 3,670; ◇ Same person *Cormac holds up his scarred hand at the recital*, 28 an Lùnastal, VE 3,671.

57. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

58. ◇ Same person *The fourth coal named at the recital*, 5 an Giblean, VE 3,672.

59. ◇ Same person *A cousin tries the silver again*, 4 an Cèitean, VE 3,690.

60. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

61. ‡ Legacy *The blood of the misstrike*, 20 an t-Samhain, VE 3,670; ◇ Same person *Children shown the old scar in the firelight*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 3,700.

- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 3,712** — *The bag passes on unnamed* (Tobar dhìreach). The leather bag with gual airgid⁶², the coal that has never yet been tried by fire, and gual bogha-froise⁶³ passes from Cormac's grave to a younger kinsman of the line, whose name the recital keeps but does not give to strangers.⁶⁴
- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 3,718** — *Aoibheann's last years* (Tobar dhìreach). Aoibheann outlives Cormac by six years at Tobar dhìreach, and it is from her telling, repeated at the hearth, that the valley's children learn the story of the coal that would not break and the blood that lit it anyway.⁶⁵
- 10 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,720** — *The deer-drives of the eastern forest* (Doire fhionn). Lines of stakes and brush are set to drive the red deer of the eastern woods into a gully near Doire fhionn, where they are killed with spears. The antlers of the greatest stags are stacked apart from the rest.
- 4 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,720** — *Dubhghall drives the gully alone for the first time* (Gleann nan Damh⁶⁶). At twenty-five, Dubhghall stands for the first time at the head of the deer-drive he has watched his uncle lead since boyhood, and takes a stag with a bad throw that his uncle and two others must finish for him, a failure the household forgets within the season.⁶⁷
- 8 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,722** — *The stand of antlers grows at the gully's mouth* (Gleann nan Damh⁶⁸). Two autumns running, a good drive leaves the stacked antlers at the mouth of the glen tall enough for a boy to stand in their shadow at noon, the household's plain mark of what the year's meat has cost the herd.⁶⁹
- 5 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,725** — *Dubhghall's throw goes wide* (Gleann nan Damh⁷⁰). In his first year at the gully's throat Dubhghall's throw strikes a young stag in the shoulder rather than the throat, and it takes his uncle and two others to finish it; he practises the throw all winter against a bundle of brush.⁷¹
- 7 AM MÀRT, VE 3,740** — *Dubhghall takes the head of the drive* (Gleann nan Damh⁷²). When his uncle's knees will no longer hold him through a whole autumn morning, Dubhghall takes the head of the line at the gully, exacting in one thing only: that no young man stand carelessly.⁷³

62. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

63. the rainbow coal, of spirit

64. ◇ Same person *Cormac dies at his own hearth*, 18 an Gearran, VE 3,712.

65. ◇ Same person *Cormac dies at his own hearth*, 18 an Gearran, VE 3,712.

66. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

67. ← Follows from *The deer-drives of the eastern forest*, 10 an Gearran, VE 3,720.

68. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

69. ← Follows from *The deer-drives of the eastern forest*, 10 an Gearran, VE 3,720.

70. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

71. ← Follows from *The deer-drives of the eastern forest*, 10 an Gearran, VE 3,720; ◇ Same person *Dubhghall drives the gully alone for the first time*, 4 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,720.

72. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

73. ◇ Same person *Dubhghall's throw goes wide*, 5 an Giblean, VE 3,725.

- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,750** — *Dubhghall's uncle dies* (Gleann nan Damh⁷⁴). Worn thin by winters and no longer able to stand a whole autumn morning at the gully, Dubhghall's uncle dies and is buried within sight of the glen's mouth, close enough that his grandchildren can point to the rise from the stand of horn.⁷⁵
- 4 AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,757** — *Dubhghall's grandson's dog dies* (Cnoc fhionn). A dog that has slept across the boy's feet every night since it was weaned lies down by the hearth one evening and does not rise the next morning, found stiff and cold before the household is properly awake.
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,757** — *The boy digs the dog a grave and sets a shell at its head* (Cnoc fhionn). On the dry rise above the house, the boy digs a grave the length of a dog, lays it on its side as a sleeping dog lies, and sets at its head a sea-shell kept idle on a hearth-shelf for years, telling no one beforehand and asking no leave.
- 1 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,758** — *An old woman questions the dog's grave* (Cnoc fhionn). At a gathering of the near hearths an older woman asks the boy, not unkindly, whether he means to give every lost lamb a shell as well; he answers only that the dog slept at his feet for nine years and a lamb never did, and she allows it is answer enough.
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 3,759** — *Dubhghall's grandson asks why no one hunts the geese* (Eilean ghorm). Watching the grey line come in over the water one still evening, the boy asks his grandfather why no household takes the geese of Eilean ghorm for meat; Dubhghall answers only that a people who stop leaving what they have always left are no longer quite the people they were.⁷⁶
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,760** — *Two more households bury dogs at Cnoc fhionn* (Cnoc fhionn). Within a few years of the first grave, two neighbouring households bury their own dogs the same way, a shell at the head and a proper grave dug, and the custom begins to travel hearth to hearth through the hill country.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,760** — *Dubhghall dies at Cnoc fhionn* (Cnoc fhionn). Dubhghall dies in his sixty-fifth year among his daughter's family, remembered at his own leaving for thirty autumns of driving the glen without losing a man to horn or wet ground; his grandson sets the last of his kept shells at the old man's head.⁷⁷
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 3,760** — *A shell set at Dubhghall's head* (Cnoc fhionn). Dubhghall's grandson sets a shell at his grandfather's head at his burying, the last of a small store kept since the dog's grave, saying the old man deserved no less than a dog.⁷⁸

74. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

75. ← Follows from *The deer-drives of the eastern forest*, 10 an Gearran, VE 3,720; ◇ Same person *Dubhghall takes the head of the drive*, 7 am Màrt, VE 3,740.

76. ◇ Same person *Dubhghall's uncle dies*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,750.

77. ‡ Legacy *The deer-drives of the eastern forest*, 10 an Gearran, VE 3,720; ◇ Same person *Dubhghall's grandson asks why no one hunts the geese*, 2 an t-Samhain, VE 3,759.

- 9 **AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,770** — *The young man of the northern moor builds a boat for Eilean ghorm* (Eilean ghorm). In a season of want, a young man of the northern moor spends a hard winter building a hide boat in secret and puts out alone one grey morning for the geese's island, telling no one what the boat is for.
- 5 **AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,771** — *The first dog graves* (Cnoc fhionn). At Cnoc fhionn in the east dogs are buried beside people, each with a shell at its head. No beast was given a grave on Dia-thir before.⁷⁹
- 14 **AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,771** — *The young man does not come back a hunter* (Eilean ghorm). The fate of the young man who sailed for Eilean ghorm is told three ways at three hearths and agreed by none of them; he is remembered not as one who found good hunting, but as a warning the country keeps without understanding it.
- 3 **AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,821** — *The geese of Eilean ghorm* (Eilean ghorm). The grey geese that winter on Eilean ghorm come into the tellings for the first time. They come in with the first storm and leave with the last, and none hunts them there.⁸⁰
- 12 **AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,822** — *The geese read for the turn of the winter* (Eilean ghorm). Households that watch the grey geese of Eilean ghorm close enough learn to read the turn of the winter in their leaving, which comes a day or two ahead of the year's last storm.⁸¹
- 10 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,870** — *The mole at Skell⁸² stands nine hundred years* (Seann Skell). Mended and lengthened season on season since the old stone-judge first set it, the mole at Skell runs further out into the Abhainn naomh than any one lifetime could have carried it, and a woman of the landing walks its length each evening to look for any stone the current has worked loose.
- 15 **AM MÀRT, VE 3,871** — *A woman walks the mole at Skell⁸³ each evening* (Seann Skell). A woman of Skell who keeps the mole's stones walks its length each evening at the turn of the tide, looking for any stone the current has worked loose.
- 4 **AN GEARRAN, VE 3,872** — *Every mooring taken at Skell⁸⁴* (Seann Skell). At Skell on the Abhainn naomh, the greatest landing of the people of the shore, every mooring behind the mole is taken one autumn, hulls lying three and four deep along its sheltered face, and the smoke of the landing's hearths hangs over the river's mouth from dawn to dark.

78. ◇ Same person *Dubhghall dies at Cnoc fhionn*, 4 an Dàmhair, VE 3,760.

79. → Caused by *Dubhghall's grandson's dog dies*, 4 an Cèitean, VE 3,757; → Caused by *The boy digs the dog a grave and sets a shell at its head*, 30 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,757; ← Leads to *An old woman questions the dog's grave*, 1 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,758; ← Leads to *Two more households bury dogs at Cnoc fhionn*, 5 an t-Sultain, VE 3,760; ¶ Legacy of *Dubhghall dies at Cnoc fhionn*, 4 an Dàmhair, VE 3,760; ¶ Legacy of *A shell set at Dubhghall's head*, 1 an Dùbhlachd, VE 3,760.

80. ← Leads to *Dubhghall's grandson asks why no one hunts the geese*, 2 an t-Samhain, VE 3,759; → Caused by *The young man of the northern moor builds a boat for Eilean ghorm*, 9 an t-Iuchar, VE 3,770; ← Leads to *The young man does not come back a hunter*, 14 an t-Sultain, VE 3,771.

81. ← Follows from *The geese of Eilean ghorm*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 3,821.

82. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

83. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

84. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

- 8 AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,872** — *The widest reach of the Seann-Dhaoine*⁸⁵ (Seann Skell⁸⁶). At their height the Seann-Dhaoine hold every coast of the island: the ten places whose names begin with Seann, and the islands off them. Their greatest landing is at Seann Skell, up the Abhainn naomh, where the mole already stands.⁸⁷
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,922** — *The warm springs used* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁸⁸). Stone basins are set into the springs at Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh. The people buried near them have old breaks that knitted clean. Here the sick of Dia-thir are first brought for healing.
- 24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,924** — *A leg set under the warm water*. At Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁸⁹ the keeper of the basins sets a leg broken through the skin under the warm water of the third basin, binds it tight with wet bark and cord, and turns the man twice a day for a season; he walks out on a stick before the winter turns.⁹⁰
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,930** — *The keeper of the basins judges a wound by its smell* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁹¹). The keeper of the warm basins tells by the colour of a wound, and its smell when the dressing comes off, whether it wants the second basin or the third or neither, and has no words for the telling.⁹²
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,949** — *The youth of the south-east asks to go down*. A youth not yet grown to his height asks to be the one let down into the eastern shaft at Toll-dubb, and two women of the south-east plait a rope for it from the hides of three oxen.⁹³
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,950** — *The lamp goes small in the eastern shaft*. The youth is let down into the eastern shaft on the plaited rope with a lamp of fat in a hollowed stone; the lamp goes small and the dark closes over it, the rope runs out to its last knot and hangs, and after a long while it jerks twice and is hauled up slowly.⁹⁴
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,950** — *The youth comes up ash-faced and silent*. The youth comes over the lip with his lamp out and his face the colour of ash, and never says, then or in all the years he lives, what was at the bottom; after him no one goes down again.⁹⁵

85. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

86. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it
 87. → Caused by *The mole at Skell stands nine hundred years*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,870; ⇌ At the same time *A woman walks the mole at Skell each evening*, 15 am Màrt, VE 3,871; → Caused by *Every mooring taken at Skell*, 4 an Gearran, VE 3,872.

88. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

89. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

90. ○ Same place *The warm springs used*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,922.

91. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

92. ← Follows from *The warm springs used*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,922.

93. → Leads to *The shaft of Toll-dubb in the south-east*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,730.

94. ← Follows from *The shaft of Toll-dubb in the south-east*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,730.

95. ← Follows from *The shaft of Toll-dubb in the south-east*, 12 an t-Sultain, VE 2,730.

- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 3,960** — *The young keeper takes up the turning.* The old keeper of the basins dies and is buried on the slope nearest the water; a young woman who came up as a girl with a father whose ribs were stove in takes up the setting and the turning the next morning, and sets three bones that day.⁹⁶
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 3,965** — *A child's broken skull mended by the first basin.* A child fallen from a kiln wall is carried two days to the springs by its mother with the bone above its ear broken; the young keeper lays it by the steam of the first basin, washes the break and binds it loosely, and on the fourth morning it wakes and asks for food.⁹⁷
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,970** — *Heated stones laid in the third basin in a dry summer* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁹⁸). In a dry summer when the water runs low from the three mouths, the keepers of the basins lay stones heated in a fire into the third basin to bring it back to the warmth the sick need.
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,973** — *The gate of the outpost walled up* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire⁹⁹). The single gate of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire is blocked with rubble from within. Those who did it left by another way, or did not leave.
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 3,973** — *The last stone set by lamplight.* One man, left alone at Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹⁰⁰'s gate at dusk after the others have gone to other work within the walls, fits the last stones into the gap by a lamp burning down, and presses the last one home with the flat of his hand. Where he went after is not told.¹⁰¹
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 3,990** — *The rope of the shaft cut up for mooring lines* (Toll-dubh). After the youth comes up silent, the plaited rope is cut up for mooring lines, and the grown people of the south-east walk wider of the shaft's lip than before.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,000** — *The youth will not let a lamp burn low* (Toll-dubh). The youth who went down the eastern shaft, grown and married at a landing two days south, is known for nothing strange except that he rises in the night to trim or put out any lamp burning low.

96. → Leads to *The warm springs used*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,922.

97. ← Follows from *The warm springs used*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,922.

98. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

99. the watch-fort ruin

100. the watch-fort ruin

101. ← Follows from *The gate of the outpost walled up*, 29 an Dàmhair, VE 3,973.

THE YEARS VE 4,001 – 4,500

- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,023** — *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire*¹ *abandoned* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire). The outpost is deserted. It lay in ruin before the first trusty chronicles, and it is older than any dwelling of the Dia-thìrich. Who built it none knows.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,030** — *The kerbed way greens over*. With no one going down off the spur, the grass creeps in over the slabs of the kerbed way from its edges, and the kerbs show through the turf like the bones of a thing half buried.²
- 21 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,074** — *A woman finds the cistern choked*. A woman of the three rings, going at first light to draw water for her sick father, finds the cistern full of whole cattle, unbutchered, their backs and bent legs breaking the dark water; no one of the rings can say who did it, and no one draws from it again.
- 4 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,074** — *The fortress cistern fouled* (Làrach an Dùin³). The cistern of Làrach an Dùin is choked with the bones of cattle, thrown in whole. Its water had served four hundred people. No one draws from it again.⁴
- 12 AM MÀRT, VE 4,075** — *Water carried up the height every morning* (Làrach an Dùin⁵). With the cistern of the three rings fouled, every household on the height carries its water up from the valley springs on its own back, a whole morning's labour every morning.⁶
- 11 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,100** — *The first households go down from the rings* (Làrach an Dùin⁷). Some households of the three rings tire of the water-carrying before they tire of the height, and go down the track to the lower valleys, saying they go only for the winter.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,123** — *Fewer fires burn along Làrach an Dùin*⁸ *wall* (Làrach an Dùin). Through a hard winter the coast-people left within the three rings let the farthest fires along the middle wall go dark first, feeding what fuel is left toward those nearest the gate, so that the chain of lights along the rampart burns shorter and thicker each week that passes.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,124** — *The last fire in the rings is let go down* (Làrach an Dùin⁹). The last of the coast-people still keeping Làrach an Dùin finds every other fire along the wall dark one morning, tends her own alone three days more, then spreads its embers thin across the stone and walks out through the gate and down toward the valleys, carrying nothing from the place she had not carried into it.

1. the watch-fort ruin

2. → Leads to *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire abandoned*, 27 an t-Samhain, VE 4,023.

3. the fortress ruin

4. → Caused by *A woman finds the cistern choked*, 21 an Gearran, VE 4,074.

5. the fortress ruin

6. ← Follows from *The fortress cistern fouled*, 4 an Giblean, VE 4,074.

7. the fortress ruin

8. the fortress ruin

9. the fortress ruin

- 6 AM MÀRT, VE 4,124** — *Làrach an Dùin*¹⁰ abandoned (Làrach an Dùin). The fortress is deserted in like manner, and is as much a riddle as the outpost. Whether both had the same builders has never been settled.¹¹
- 6 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,126** — *Grass in the threshold of the rings* (Làrach an Dùin¹²). Within a few winters of the last fire along the middle wall, grass finds a footing in the gate threshold of the three rings, where the feet of four hundred once kept the stone bare.¹³
- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,130** — *A grandfather of the western landing will not speak of the height* (Seann Skell¹⁴). An old man long settled among shore kin who never went up answers his grandson's question about Làrach an Dùin¹⁵ only with the cold and the wind that found a man through doubled wool, and will say nothing of why he left it or whether he meant, at the time, to come back.¹⁶
- 10 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,135** — *A household from the rings comes down to Morn*¹⁷ (Seann Skell¹⁸). A household of five comes down from the three rings to the kilns at Morn with nothing but what it can carry, its one ox lost on the scree; the landing takes it in, and the women are set to the kilns, where the younger learns in one morning that a kiln fire must smoke and not flame.¹⁹
- 13 AN CÈITEAN, VE 4,150** — *The southern middens grow faster than living memory* (Seann Chwen). As more of the coast-people settle at the shore than the shore has ever held, the middens of the southern landing thicken season on season with the ordinary leavings of a people's swelling numbers, and a landing once counted by the dozen comes to be counted by the score.²⁰
- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,150** — *The son's wife learns a kiln must not flame* (Seann Mhorn). The keeper of the middle kiln at Morn²¹ leads a woman new down from the heights by the wrist to a smouldering kiln and holds her hand over its rack until she understands what three tellings in words had not taught her.

10. the fortress ruin

11. → Caused by *The first households go down from the rings*, 11 an Gearran, VE 4,100; → Caused by *Fewer fires burn along Làrach an Dùin wall*, 13 am Faoilleach, VE 4,123; → Caused by *The last fire in the rings is let go down*, 13 am Faoilleach, VE 4,124.

12. the fortress ruin

13. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin abandoned*, 6 am Màrt, VE 4,124.

14. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

15. the fortress ruin

16. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin abandoned*, 6 am Màrt, VE 4,124.

17. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

18. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

19. ¶ Legacy *Làrach an Dùin abandoned*, 6 am Màrt, VE 4,124.

20. ← Follows from *Làrach an Dùin abandoned*, 6 am Màrt, VE 4,124.

21. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

II AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,160 — *A girl from the heights sees the sea* (Seann Mhorn). A girl of eight born within the innermost ring is lifted onto a rock above Morn²² by her grandfather and turned to face the sea, and asks, after a long look, whether it ever stops moving.

16 AM MÀRT, VE 4,170 — *A worked stone kept on a shore shelf* (Eilean dhearg). An old man come down from a height keeps on a shelf at the shore a worked stone no one there has a use for, and it is laid in the stone box with him when his time comes.

19 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,175 — *Three men climb to the temple with prising-bars* (Làrach an Teampaill²³). Three men of the last kin that still tends the temple climb its steps on a grey autumn morning with bars of seasoned oak shod with bone, the eldest of them a man past sixty who has climbed on the shortest morning every year of his life.

I AN GEARRAN, VE 4,175 — *The altar's top stone is prised free* (Làrach an Teampaill²⁴). Working the better part of the morning, two of the three break out the old clay from the sockets with the points of their bars while the eldest stands with his hands flat on the stone, and a while past noon they lift it whole from the sockets it has held since before anyone could remember.

5 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,175 — *The temple altar stripped* (Làrach an Teampaill²⁵). The top stone of the altar at Làrach an Teampaill is prised off and carried away; the sockets that held it are sharp still. It has never been found, and what was cut on it, if anything, is not known.

²⁶

I AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,175 — *The altar stone is carried west out of sight* (Làrach an Teampaill²⁷). Slung between the three in a net of hide rope on the same bars, the altar stone is carried down the platform steps and over the shoulder of the hill to the west; it is never found.

²⁸

27 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,180 — *The temple platform goes untended* (Làrach an Teampaill²⁹). No one of that kin climbs the temple steps on the shortest morning again; grass comes in between the platform's fitted stones, and the easy last step that every child of the valley once found with a bare foot in the dark is lost under turf.³⁰

22. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

23. the temple ruin

24. the temple ruin

25. the temple ruin

26. → Caused by *Three men climb to the temple with prising-bars*, 19 am Faoilleach, VE 4,175; → Caused by *The altar's top stone is prised free*, 1 an Gearran, VE 4,175.

27. the temple ruin

28. ← Follows from *The temple altar stripped*, 5 an Gearran, VE 4,175.

29. the temple ruin

30. ← Follows from *The temple altar stripped*, 5 an Gearran, VE 4,175.

- 28 AM MÀRT, VE 4,190** — *A cairn built below the empty sockets* (Làrach an Teampaill³¹). The eldest of the three who prised the altar goes up alone years after and spends most of a day building a small cairn of loose stone below the empty sockets, capped square, and comes down with his hands scraped raw, and does not say what it is for.³²
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,190** — *The easy last step lost under turf* (Làrach an Teampaill³³). The last step of the temple platform, flush with the moor, which every child of the valley once found with a bare foot in the dark, is lost under turf, and the climb begins now with a stumble.³⁴
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,196** — *Eòghann born to the keeper's hearth* (Tobar dhìreach). Eòghann is born the second child of the household that keeps the bag and Poit an Teine³⁵ at Tobar dhìreach, not first looked to for the keeping while his elder sister lives.
- 27 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,210** — *Eòghann counts the coals into his palm as a child* (Tobar dhìreach). Eòghann, free of the keeping as a younger son, counts the three coals into his own small palm long before anyone asks it of him, turning them over for the plain pleasure of a smooth thing in the hand.³⁶
- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,216** — *The keeping falls to Eòghann* (Tobar dhìreach). Eòghann's sister dies of a fever in her nineteenth year, and the bag of three dark coals and the recital pass to Eòghann on his father's death soon after; he is twenty.³⁷
- 26 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,216** — *Eòghann's sister dies and his father is buried* (Tobar dhìreach). Eòghann's elder sister dies of a fever in her nineteenth year, and his father is buried beside Leac na Fèithe³⁸ the same season, so that the keeping comes to Eòghann at twenty.³⁹
- 28 AM MÀRT, VE 4,220** — *Eòghann marries Dearbhail* (Tobar dhìreach). Eòghann takes Dearbhail of the lake-shore line, who keeps his fire-pot and his hearth through the long absences his walking keeps him to.⁴⁰
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,221** — *Gual airgid carried to the home river and two more* (Tobar dhìreach). In his first years of keeping Eòghann carries gual airgid⁴¹ to the Abhainn ghorm below Tobar dhìreach, to two rivers besides, and to a mountain tarn, in case the water nearest the hearth had never been fairly asked; none answers him.⁴²

31. the temple ruin

32. ¶ Legacy *The temple altar stripped*, 5 an Gearran, VE 4,175.

33. the temple ruin

34. ← Follows from *The temple altar stripped*, 5 an Gearran, VE 4,175.

35. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

36. ◇ Same person *Eòghann born to the keeper's hearth*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,196.

37. ◇ Same person *Eòghann counts the coals into his palm as a child*, 27 an Gearran, VE 4,210.

38. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

39. ◇ Same person *The keeping falls to Eòghann*, 29 am Faoilleach, VE 4,216.

40. ◇ Same person *Eòghann's sister dies and his father is buried*, 26 an Giblean, VE 4,216.

41. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

42. ◇ Same person *Eòghann marries Dearbhail*, 28 am Màrt, VE 4,220.

- 25 **AN CÈITEAN, VE 4,224** — *A mountain tarn tried for the silver.* Among the waters Eòghann tries gual airgid⁴³ against is a mountain tarn that is no river at all but holds, by the telling, water enough to be worth the asking; it does not answer.⁴⁴
- 2 **AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,225** — *Eòghann keeps the old custom of the shore* (Tobar dhìreach). With nothing newly occurring to him, Eòghann carries the three dark coals north to the shore his father once brought him to, to throw them into the sea in the old way, out of a custom kept past most keepers' belief in it.⁴⁵
- 4 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,225** — *The three coals thrown into the sea again for nothing.* Eòghann throws the silver, the untried, and gual bogha-froise⁴⁶ into the grey swell off the northern shore in the falling light, and wades in after them to find them as dark and salt-wet as they went in.⁴⁷
- 30 **AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,225** — *Eòghann walks home through two days of rain.* Eòghann turns south for Tobar dhìreach the morning after the casting, walking two wet days over moor and birch scrub with his mind on nothing beyond the ground in front of him.⁴⁸
- 21 **AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,225** — *The silver coal in the river* (Abhainn ghorm). Eòghann of the Mason's line drinks from the Abhainn ghorm below Tobar dhìreach and says, 'This water tastes different from the sea water.' He throws the three unlit coals into the stream, and the coal with the sheen of silver takes fire in the current and burns silver under the water. The coal of fire and the rainbow coal lie dark.⁴⁹
- 27 **AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,225** — *Eòghann kneels and drinks at the crossing* (Tobar dhìreach). Thirsty and tired on the last stretch of the road home, Eòghann kneels at the crossing of the Abhainn ghorm below Tobar dhìreach and drinks, and says aloud, to no one, that this water tastes different from the sea water.⁵⁰
- 28 **AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,225** — *Gual airgid catches under the current* (Tobar dhìreach). Eòghann throws the three dark coals into the river at the crossing without weighing the throw, and gual airgid⁵¹ catches beneath the surface, a pale fire standing in the current that the water cannot quench.⁵²

43. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

44. ◇ Same person *Gual airgid carried to the home river and two more*, 23 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,221.

45. ◇ Same person *A mountain tarn tried for the silver*, 25 an Cèitean, VE 4,224.

46. the rainbow coal, of spirit

47. ◇ Same person *Eòghann keeps the old custom of the shore*, 2 an Giblean, VE 4,225.

48. ◇ Same person *The three coals thrown into the sea again for nothing*, 4 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,225.

49. → Caused by *Eòghann keeps the old custom of the shore*, 2 an Giblean, VE 4,225; → Caused by *The three coals thrown into the sea again for nothing*, 4 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,225; → Caused by *Eòghann walks home through two days of rain*, 30 an Dàmhair, VE 4,225.

50. ○ Same place *The silver coal in the river*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,225; ◇ Same person *Eòghann walks home through two days of rain*, 30 an Dàmhair, VE 4,225.

51. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,225** — *The two dark coals found on a gravel bar* (Tobar dhìreach). Gual teine and the rainbow, rolled on past Eòghann by the current in the dark, are found at first light lodged cold against a bar of gravel a stone's throw below the crossing, and carried home in the bag as dark as they went into the water.⁵³
- 27 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,226** — *The fifth coal named at the recital* (Tobar dhìreach). At the next telling of the Line, Eòghann speaks the new line into the recital: the sea, the height, the earth and a man's own blood have answered, and now the river has taken the fifth, given rather than thrown to it, and the valley names it gual airgid.^{54, 55}
- 28 AM MÀRT, VE 4,226** — *The silver burns on under the crossing* (Abhainn ghorm). Gual airgid goes on burning under the current at the shallow crossing below Tobar dhìreach, a low pale light any traveller may kneel at the bank and see on a dark evening.⁵⁶
- 26 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,230** — *Travellers come to see the fire under the water* (Tobar dhìreach). Word of the pale fire standing under the current draws travellers to the crossing below Tobar dhìreach in numbers greater than the ford had ever seen, some kneeling to drink the same water Eòghann drank without finding it tastes to them any different.⁵⁷
- 25 AN CÈITEAN, VE 4,240** — *Eòghann tells the taste cannot be looked for* (Tobar dhìreach). Pressed to say what he tasted in the river, Eòghann owns that he cannot put it into words and holds that a man cannot go looking for that taste and find it sooner than he himself found it, kneeling thirsty.⁵⁸
- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,245** — *Eòghann tries gual teine⁵⁹ against flint* (Tobar dhìreach). In his later keeping Eòghann strikes gual teine against flint more than once, hoping the snap of a hand the tellers spoke of might be struck rather than fallen into, and gets from it no more than the ordinary spark any stone gives a blade.⁶⁰
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,262** — *Eòghann dies at his own hearth* (Tobar dhìreach). Eòghann dies in his six-and-sixtieth year at Tobar dhìreach, Poit an Teine⁶¹ burning near him, his last words not of the coals but of the crossing, asking whether the water still ran clear and the light still stood under it.⁶²

52. ○ Same place *The silver coal in the river*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,225; ◇ Same person *Eòghann kneels and drinks at the crossing*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,225.

53. ← Follows from *The silver coal in the river*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,225; ◇ Same person *Gual airgid catches under the current*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,225.

54. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

55. ← Follows from *The silver coal in the river*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,225; ◇ Same person *The two dark coals found on a gravel bar*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,225.

56. ← Follows from *The silver coal in the river*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,225.

57. ¶ Legacy *The silver coal in the river*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,225.

58. ◇ Same person *The fifth coal named at the recital*, 27 an Gearran, VE 4,226.

59. the fire coal, of fire

60. ◇ Same person *Eòghann tells the taste cannot be looked for*, 25 an Cèitean, VE 4,240.

61. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

62. ¶ Legacy *The silver coal in the river*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,225; ◇ Same person *Eòghann tries gual teine against flint*, 3 an t-Samhain, VE 4,245.

- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,262** — *The bag passes on with two coals still dark* (Tobar dhreach). The leather bag, with gual teine⁶³ and gual bogha-froise⁶⁴ still unanswered, passes from Eòghann's grave to a younger kinsman of the line, as it passed from Cormac's before him.⁶⁵
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,270** — *Fewer of the coast-people climb to the temple* (Làrach an Teampaill⁶⁶). In the years before the temple stands empty for good, those of the landings who still climb to Làrach an Teampaill go up fewer at a time and stay a shorter while at the top, as a household goes on setting a place at table for a while after the one who sat in it has stopped coming.
- 7 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,275** — *Làrach an Teampaill⁶⁷ abandoned* (Làrach an Teampaill). The temple is deserted. It is older than any faith that has a name, and its altar looks to the central mountains and the vein beneath them, away from the sea.⁶⁸
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,276** — *A woman climbs to the temple with empty hands* (Làrach an Teampaill⁶⁹). A woman of the landings climbs the temple's steps alone at first light and comes down again at evening with nothing in her hands either time, and no one after her is known to climb to Làrach an Teampaill again.⁷⁰
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,290** — *Grass takes the temple platform* (Làrach an Teampaill⁷¹). With no foot left to keep it short, the grass between the temple platform's fitted stones grows up thick, and the altar's empty sockets are left to fill and empty again with nothing but whatever season sends into them.⁷²
- 22 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,300** — *Whole kin-groups come down from the abandoned heights* (Seann Chwen). Where ones and single families once drifted down from the empty heights to settle at the shore, whole kin-groups now come down together, until the landing at Cwen⁷³ holds more people at once than any landing has held before.
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,300** — *A rower teaches the gulls' warning* (Seann Dunn⁷⁴). Rowers of Slighe-mhara àrsaidh⁷⁵ keep a plain word for anyone new to the stretch north of the cape: watch the gulls before you watch the sky, for the birds leave that water before a man in it feels what is coming.

63. the fire coal, of fire

64. the rainbow coal, of spirit

65. ◇ Same person *Eòghann dies at his own hearth*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,262.

66. the temple ruin

67. the temple ruin

68. → Caused by *Fewer of the coast-people climb to the temple*, 15 an t-Samhain, VE 4,270.

69. the temple ruin

70. ← Follows from *Làrach an Teampaill abandoned*, 7 am Faoilleach, VE 4,275.

71. the temple ruin

72. ‡ Legacy *Làrach an Teampaill abandoned*, 7 am Faoilleach, VE 4,275.

73. the Old Ones' root (burgs 36, 14, 139)

74. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,320** — *No new work raised out of sight of salt water* (Seann Chwen). After the high places are left, the people of the landings raise no new work anywhere out of sight of salt water, and the shore takes back all the labour the heights had drawn away.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,325** — *The Seann-Dhaoine⁷⁶ keep to the shore* (Seann Chwen). The high places are left, and every new work of the Seann-Dhaoine is made within sight of salt water. The middens at the southern Seann Chwen begin to grow as fast as those of Seann Dunn⁷⁷ once did.⁷⁸
- 25 AN CÈITEAN, VE 4,340** — *The midden at Cwen⁷⁹ outgrows the midden at Dunn⁸⁰* (Seann Chwen). The midden below the southern landing at Cwen, thickened season on season by the swelling numbers settled there, grows past the midden at Dunn, which had for a lifetime and more been the largest heap of shell and bone the coast could show.⁸¹
- 26 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,350** — *A landing once counted by the dozen is counted by the score* (Seann Chwen). Two rowers of the sea-way, meeting off a landing-stone, trade the season's news: more households at Cwen⁸² than either can remember from a single year before, and a landing further north near empty of the families that once worked it.⁸³
- 7 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,375** — *The ancient sea-way* (Seann Dunn⁸⁴). The boats of the Seann-Dhaoine⁸⁵ keep a lane along the south-east coast, from the river mouth below Seann Dunn round the cape where Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg⁸⁶ now stands to the bay of Ceann chaol. Flat landing-stones lie along it a day's rowing apart, some grooved still by hauled keels. The Dia-thìrich call it Slighe-mhara àrsaidh⁸⁷, the ancient sea-way, and the fishers of that coast keep to it yet.⁸⁸
- 28 AM MÀRT, VE 4,380** — *The sea-way's landing-stones grooved by keels* (Seann Dunn⁸⁹). Season on season of hauled keels wear clear grooves into the flat landing-stones of Slighe-mhara àrsaidh⁹⁰ along the south-east coast, so that a rower of that lane comes to know each stone by its wear as surely as by its place along the shore.⁹¹

75. the ancient sea-way

76. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

77. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

78. ← Leads to *Whole kin-groups come down from the abandoned heights*, 22 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,300; ← Leads to *No new work raised out of sight of salt water*, 23 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,320.

79. the Old Ones' root (burgs 36, 14, 139)

80. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

81. ← Follows from *The Seann-Dhaoine keep to the shore*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,325.

82. the Old Ones' root (burgs 36, 14, 139)

83. ← Follows from *The Seann-Dhaoine keep to the shore*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,325.

84. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

85. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

86. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

87. the ancient sea-way

88. ⇌ At the same time *A rower teaches the gulls' warning*, 20 an Lùnastal, VE 4,300.

89. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

90. the ancient sea-way

15 AN CÈITEAN, VE 4,390 — *A father teaches his son the sea-way stone by stone* (Seann Dunn⁹²). A rower of Slighe-mhara àrsaidh⁹³ carries his son in the bow through a whole season's rowing, naming each landing-stone as it comes until the boy's own eye can find the next one before his father's voice does, the same teaching the lane is given, before and after, to every rower's son.⁹⁴

13 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,400 — *Rathnait born to the valleys about the crack* (Àth gharbh). Rathnait is born the third child of a household two ridges east of Tobar dhìreach, of no line that keeps a fire-pot or counts fathers back to the mason by name, but of the valleys about the crack all the same.

18 AM MÀRT, VE 4,410 — *The valleys' dead laid facing the mountains* (Àth gharbh). The households of the high valleys lay their dead in the ground on their side with the knees drawn up and the face toward the central mountains, with an uncut stone set on end at the head and no mark on it.

10 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,425 — *The hill-folk of the vein* (Àth gharbh). In the high valleys about the crack dwells a people other than the Seann-Dhaoine⁹⁵, who call themselves Clann nan Dè⁹⁶, the godkin. They bury their dead in the ground and not on islands, and they cut no script. Whether they shared the island with the Seann-Dhaoine or came after them, no telling knows; their own word, later, is that they were always there.⁹⁷

2 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,425 — *An elder doubts the new name will last* (Àth gharbh). At Oidhche an Dealanaich⁹⁸ an old woman of the ford hears the households called Clann nan Dè⁹⁹ for the first time and will not say the word herself, having watched other names tried at other gatherings in her own long life and none of them outlast the fire that first warmed them into being said.¹⁰⁰

22 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,425 — *An old man of the west gives the name Clann nan Dè*¹⁰¹ (Àth gharbh). At the gathering on Oidhche an Dealanaich¹⁰² an old man of the western household answers a stranger's question with a word for the whole of the gathered valleys: Clann nan Dè.¹⁰³

91. ← Follows from *The ancient sea-way*, 7 am Faoilleach, VE 4,375.

92. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

93. the ancient sea-way

94. ← Follows from *The ancient sea-way*, 7 am Faoilleach, VE 4,375.

95. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

96. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

97. → Caused by *Rathnait born to the valleys about the crack*, 13 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,400; → Caused by *The valleys' dead laid facing the mountains*, 18 am Màrt, VE 4,410.

98. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

99. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

100. ⇌ At the same time *The hill-folk of the vein*, 10 an t-Samhain, VE 4,425; ◇ Same person *Rathnait born to the valleys about the crack*, 13 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,400.

101. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

102. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

103. ⇌ At the same time *The hill-folk of the vein*, 10 an t-Samhain, VE 4,425; ◇ Same person *An elder doubts the new name will last*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,425.

- 7 **AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,440** — *The name carried to hearths not at the gathering.* The name Clann nan Dè¹⁰⁴ is said the next night of the lightning at hearths that were not at the western gathering, carried to them as a coal is carried from one hearth to a cold one three valleys off.¹⁰⁵
- 12 **AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,450** — *Clann nan Dè¹⁰⁶ settles into ordinary use* (Àth gharbh). By the time Rathnait is old enough to sit among the elders at her own hearth's turn to hold the gathering, the name Clann nan Dè is said across the valleys about the crack as plainly and as unremarked as any older name tied to a single ridge or ford.¹⁰⁷
- 10 **AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,468** — *Rathnait dies among the valleys she named* (Àth gharbh). Rathnait dies at her own household's hearth, having carried the word she first heard tried at a stranger's fire into ordinary use across the whole of the valleys about the crack.¹⁰⁸
- 12 **AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,475** — *The first small burning* (Àth gharbh). At Àth gharbh a sliver of the coloured coal is burnt to a bead in a peat fire by a household not of the Mason's line. It burns black-flamed like any other coal, and the hearthstone round it is stained through with colour. No older burning of the coal by other hands is known. It is a small thing: one sliver, one fire.
- 21 **AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,475** — *Barabal burns the first sliver outside the line* (Àth gharbh). At Àth gharbh a woman named Barabal, keeping a bright stone given her as a child at a ford, sets it on her peat fire from idle curiosity; it burns black-flamed like any coal, and the hearthstone beneath it takes a stain of colour clean through its thickness.¹⁰⁹
- 13 **AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,476** — *Barabal's husband's mother knows the stained stone* (Àth gharbh). Barabal's husband's mother turns the stained hearthstone over in the daylight at the door and says she once heard that Clann a' Chlachair¹¹⁰ kept coloured stones just such as this.¹¹¹
- 11 **AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,482** — *Word of the stained hearthstone reaches Tobar dhìreach* (Tobar dhìreach). A fire-bearer carries the tale of Barabal's stained hearthstone to Clann a' Chlachair¹¹² at Tobar dhìreach, and the woman who then keeps the bag hears it out and says only that a piece small enough to fit a boy's palm was small enough to lose.¹¹³

104. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

105. ← Follows from *The bill-folk of the vein*, 10 an t-Samhain, VE 4,425; ◇ Same person *An old man of the west gives the name Clann nan Dè*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,425.

106. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

107. ¶ Legacy *The bill-folk of the vein*, 10 an t-Samhain, VE 4,425; ◇ Same person *The name carried to hearths not at the gathering*, 7 an Dàmhair, VE 4,440.

108. ¶ Legacy *The bill-folk of the vein*, 10 an t-Samhain, VE 4,425; ◇ Same person *Clann nan Dè settles into ordinary use*, 12 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,450.

109. ← Follows from *The first small burning*, 12 an Dàmhair, VE 4,475.

110. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

111. ← Follows from *The first small burning*, 12 an Dàmhair, VE 4,475; ◇ Same person *Barabal burns the first sliver outside the line*, 21 an t-Samhain, VE 4,475.

20 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,490 — *Giorsal born at Achadh dhìreach* (Achadh dhìreach).

Giorsal is born at Achadh dhìreach, ten miles west of the crack, to a household that keeps no fire-pot and counts no fathers back to the mason, and grows up on Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹¹⁴ as every child of the valleys does.

18 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,500 — *The stained hearthstone shown to travellers* (Àth gharbh).

The stained hearthstone at Àth gharbh is shown to travellers who ask after it and to children who do not, a plain curiosity, until a later hand splits it to see whether the colour runs all the way through.¹¹⁵

113. ← Follows from *The first small burning*, 12 an Dàmhair, VE 4,475; ◇ Same person *Barabal's husband's mother knows the stained stone*, 13 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,476.

112. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

114. the Telling of the Making

115. ‡ Legacy *The first small burning*, 12 an Dàmhair, VE 4,475.

THE YEARS VE 4,501 – 5,000

- 19 AM MÀRT, VE 4,512** — *Barabal dies at Àth gharbh* (Àth gharbh). Barabal dies in her two-and-seventieth year at her own hearth, remembered by her own valley less as the woman who first burned an gual dathach¹ than simply as an old grandmother among her kin.²
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,520** — *Giorsal's grandmother shows her the bright stone* (Achadh dhìreach). Giorsal's grandmother shows her as a girl the scrap of coloured stone kept in a box at Achadh dhìreach three generations, calling it only the bright stone and saying nothing of what it is.³
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,525** — *The stained cloth of Achadh dhìreach* (Achadh dhìreach). At Achadh dhìreach the hill-folk rub broken coal from the vein into the wool of the dead, and it takes streaks of a colour no plant dye makes. It is seldom done: one grave in some thirty.⁴
- 4 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,525** — *Giorsal begins rubbing coal into the wool of the dead* (Achadh dhìreach). Giorsal, who sees to the burials of her household, takes up the private habit of rubbing a little broken coloured coal into the wrapping wool of some of her dead, choosing perhaps one grave in thirty across her working years.⁵
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,540** — *Word of the stained wool reaches the line* (Tobar dhìreach). A trader carries the tale of Giorsal's stained burial-wool to Tobar dhìreach some fifteen years after it begins, and Clann a' Chlachair⁶ takes it as further proof that its own coloured coal is no longer the only piece the valleys hold.⁷
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,560** — *Giorsal dies and is given the office in her turn* (Achadh dhìreach). Giorsal dies in her seventieth year of a wasting sickness, and her own daughter, taught the office before her, rubs a sliver of the coloured stone into her mother's own wrapping as she had seen it done for others.⁸
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,560** — *A bright stone is found on the midden at Bral*⁹ (Seann Bhràl). A woman of Bral, sifting the midden below her household's huts, turns up a small hard thing bright with more than one colour, unlike any shell or stone the heap has yielded before; no one of that household can say how long it lay there or how it came.

1. the coloured coal

2. ¶ Legacy *The first small burning*, 12 an Dàmhair, VE 4,475; ◇ Same person *Word of the stained hearthstone reaches Tobar dhìreach*, 11 an Lùnastal, VE 4,482.

3. ◇ Same person *Giorsal born at Achadh dhìreach*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 4,490.

4. → Caused by *Giorsal born at Achadh dhìreach*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 4,490; → Caused by *Giorsal's grandmother shows her the bright stone*, 17 an Giblean, VE 4,520.

5. ← Follows from *The stained cloth of Achadh dhìreach*, 13 an t-Sultain, VE 4,525; ◇ Same person *Giorsal's grandmother shows her the bright stone*, 17 an Giblean, VE 4,520.

6. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

7. ← Follows from *The stained cloth of Achadh dhìreach*, 13 an t-Sultain, VE 4,525; ◇ Same person *Giorsal begins rubbing coal into the wool of the dead*, 4 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,525.

8. ¶ Legacy *The stained cloth of Achadh dhìreach*, 13 an t-Sultain, VE 4,525; ◇ Same person *Word of the stained wool reaches the line*, 25 an Dàmhair, VE 4,540.

9. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

9 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,561 — *Giorsal buried with a sliver rubbed into her wrapping* (Achadh dhìreach). Giorsal's daughter rubs a sliver of the bright stone into her mother's own wrapping at her burial, the office passing once from the hand that always gave it to the hand that had only received it.¹⁰

11 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,565 — *The stone at Bral*¹¹ *is kept among the household's trinkets* (Seann Bhrál). The bright stone found on the midden at Bral is never set to any fire; it is kept awhile among the household's small keepings, admired and set aside, and passes out of particular notice as such finds do.

15 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,575 — *A sliver in a Seann Bhrál midden* (Seann Bhrál). A chip of the coloured coal, still staining the shell about it, is thrown on a midden at Seann Bhrál on the far western coast. By gift, by trade or by theft a piece of the vein came to the Seann-Dhaoine¹²; which, is not known.¹³

18 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,625 — *The Children of the Question* (Tobar dhìreach). The households of the high valleys begin to call the Mason's line Luchd-ceasnachaidh a' Ghuail Dhìomhair¹⁴, the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal, for their long questioning of the two dark coals; the lists shorten it to Clann na Ceiste¹⁵, the Children of the Question. The kindred take the name, and Clann a' Chlachair¹⁶ is heard less after.

7 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,625 — *Oscar names the line in jest* (Àth gharbh). At the gathering on Oidhche an Dealanaich¹⁷, Oscar of Àth gharbh calls Clann a' Chlachair¹⁸ Luchd-ceasnachaidh a' Ghuail Dhìomhair¹⁹, the long questioners of the secret coal, meaning it half as a joke against their long, fruitless asking of the two dark coals.²⁰

8 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,625 — *Colla takes the name* (Tobar dhìreach). Colla, keeper of the bag at Tobar dhìreach and five and thirty that year, takes up Oscar's long name for his line without the laughter that first carried it, and gives travellers the short form, Clann na Ceiste²¹, the children of the question.²²

10. ¶ Legacy *The stained cloth of Achadh dhìreach*, 13 an t-Sultain, VE 4,525; ◇ Same person *Giorsal dies and is given the office in her turn*, 8 an Dàmhair, VE 4,560.

11. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

12. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

13. ← Leads to *A bright stone is found on the midden at Bral*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,560; ¶ Legacy of *The stone at Bral is kept among the household's trinkets*, 11 an Lùnastal, VE 4,565.

14. the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal

15. the Children of the Question

16. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

17. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

18. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

19. the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal

20. ← Follows from *The Children of the Question*, 18 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,625.

21. the Children of the Question

22. ← Follows from *The Children of the Question*, 18 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,625; ◇ Same person *Oscar names the line in jest*, 7 an Lùnastal, VE 4,625.

- 16 AN CÈITEAN, VE 4,626** — *Colla gives the long name to a traveller* (Tobar dhìreach). Asked by a traveller what his people call themselves, Colla gives back Oscar's long name without the laughter, and says the short form Clann na Ceiste²³ will serve.²⁴
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,640** — *Clann na Ceiste²⁵ settles into ordinary use* (Tobar dhìreach). The households of the valleys take up calling Clann a' Chlachair²⁶ simply Clann na Ceiste in their everyday talk, the older name Clann a' Chlachair heard less with each passing year.²⁷
- 19 AM MÀRT, VE 4,655** — *Colla dies and hands on the bag* (Tobar dhìreach). Colla dies in his five-and-sixtieth year, having kept the bag some thirty years, and hands the keeping before the end to a son whose name the reciters, as with every father along that stretch of the line, keep from strangers.²⁸
- 18 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,656** — *The mason's children heard for the last time as the line's own name* (Tobar dhìreach). At the recital held the winter after Colla's death, the reciters say both the old name and the new, Clann a' Chlachair²⁹ and Clann na Ceiste³⁰ together, before letting the newer name stand alone in every recital after.³¹
- 17 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,672** — *Carragh Cnoc bheag³² raised* (Carragh Cnoc bheag). A standing stone is raised, on which four words are afterwards found carved: Bha teine sa chloich, "there was fire in the stone."
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,672** — *Lughaidh finds a new-cut stone in the western grass* (Carragh Cnoc bheag³³). Driving his flock further west than his own hearth has grazed before, the shepherd Lughaidh comes on a standing stone raised so lately that the turned earth at its foot has not yet greened over, with no camp, path or tool-litter left by whatever hand set it there.³⁴
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,672** — *Two hands on one stone* (Carragh Cnoc bheag³⁵). Lughaidh reads a line of unfamiliar script on the stone's upper face, cut broad and level by one hand, and below it four words of his own tongue, Bha teine sa chloich, cut narrower and shallower by another; neither hand has left any other mark on the hillside.³⁶

23. the Children of the Question

24. ← Follows from *The Children of the Question*, 18 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,625; ◇ Same person *Colla takes the name*, 8 an Lùnastal, VE 4,625.

25. the Children of the Question

26. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

27. ¶ Legacy *The Children of the Question*, 18 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,625.

28. ¶ Legacy *The Children of the Question*, 18 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,625; ◇ Same person *Colla gives the long name to a traveller*, 16 an Cèitean, VE 4,626.

29. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

30. the Children of the Question

31. ¶ Legacy *The Children of the Question*, 18 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,625.

32. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

33. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

34. ← Follows from *Carragh Cnoc bheag raised*, 17 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,672.

35. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

36. ◇ Same person *Lughaidh finds a new-cut stone in the western grass*, 18 an Dàmhair, VE 4,672.

- 16 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,673** — *Lughaidh's find carried hearth to hearth*. The tale of the new stone in the western grass passes from Lughaidh's own hearth to the next and on beyond it, the four words kept exact in every mouth that takes them up while the stone's own size and the manner of its finding grow with the telling.³⁷
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,674** — *Lughaidh's father asks what he moved*. Told of the new stone in the western grass, Lughaidh's father asks first whether the boy left anything of his own behind or moved any stone, and Lughaidh, stung, says he moved nothing.³⁸
- 6 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,675** — *The words of the low cutting known at every hearth* (Carragh Cnoc bheag³⁹). By the winter after the western stone is found, every hearth that tells of it tells also what its four low words say, though no one of the valleys reads a sign and no one can say whose mouth first gave the words.
- 7 AM MÀRT, VE 4,676** — *A woman of the line sits three days before the western stone* (Carragh Cnoc bheag⁴⁰). A woman of Clann na Ceiste⁴¹ sits three days before the western stone to learn which of its two hands came first, and comes home saying both kept their counsel and she will not guess.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,680** — *Clann na Ceiste⁴² claims the fire, and leaves the older line unread* (Tobar dhìreach). Word of the stone's four words reaches Tobar dhìreach, and the line holds the fire they name for its own, Teine a' Chlachair⁴³, while the broader script above them goes on unread, no eye at the line or beyond it able to say what hand cut it or when.
- 8 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,700** — *A second stone found in the stony hills* (Colbh Cnoc chiar⁴⁴). A traveller crossing poor, broken ground further into the hills all but walks into a shorter stone before he sees it, and carries down word of three more words cut low upon it, Cuimhnich an teine, in what looks the same sure hand as the first stone's saying.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,705** — *The line answers for a bidding cut to no one* (Tobar dhìreach). Asked by travellers whether the second stone's plain command speaks to them any clearer than the first, Clann na Ceiste⁴⁵ answers each time the same: that the fire is theirs to remember whether the stone bade them or not, there being no other hand on the island that has minded it so long.

37. ◇ Same person *Two hands on one stone*, 23 an t-Samhain, VE 4,672.

38. ← Follows from *Carragh Cnoc bheag raised*, 17 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,672; ◇ Same person *Lughaidh's find carried hearth to hearth*, 16 an Lùnastal, VE 4,673.

39. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

40. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

41. the Children of the Question

42. the Children of the Question

43. the mason's fire, the first fire

44. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

45. the Children of the Question

- II AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,718** — *The older face of Carragh Cnoc bheag*⁴⁶ (Carragh Cnoc bheag). On the upper face of the stone runs a line of the unread script. The four Dia-thiris words lie lower, cut with a narrower tool by another hand. When that second hand came is not known.⁴⁷
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,720** — *Lughaidh dies at his own hearth*. Lughaidh dies in his own seventieth year, remembered by his own valley chiefly as the shepherd who first said the stone's four words aloud on the hillside where they stand.⁴⁸
- I AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,720** — *The four words said standing at the gathering* (Tobar dhireach). At that year's gathering a young man of the line says Bha teine sa chloich aloud, standing, before the whole crowd for what the tellers hold to be the first time, the saying having come to him by the same slow road as every other hearth, from mouth to mouth, back to a shepherd fifty years gone.⁴⁹
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,770** — *Colbh Cnoc chiar*⁵⁰ raised (Colbh Cnoc chiar). A second stone is raised, bearing only three words: Cuimhnich an teine, "remember the fire." Who is bidden, and why, none has ever said.⁵¹
- 30 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,770** — *The three words of the second stone taken as meant for the line* (Colbh Cnoc chiar⁵²). The line at Tobar dhireach answers every traveller who asks that the fire is theirs to remember whether the second stone bids them or not, and that they are glad enough to take the bidding as meant for them.⁵³
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,785** — *Mòrnait born at Tobar dhireach* (Tobar dhireach). Mòrnait is born into a household gathered about Clann na Ceiste⁵⁴'s own hearth without ever holding its coals, and grows up on Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁵⁵ and the two new sayings both, already part of the ordinary stock of what every child of the valleys knows by then.
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,805** — *Mòrnait carries fire to the second stone* (Colbh Cnoc chiar⁵⁶). Mòrnait makes the hard day's walk into the stony hills with a coal from the line's own pot wrapped close against the wet, and builds at the foot of Colbh Cnoc chiar a ring of fire-cracked stones in which she lights and keeps a hearth-sized fire.⁵⁷

46. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

47. ← Leads to *Two hands on one stone*, 23 an t-Samhain, VE 4,672; ¶ Legacy of *Lughaidh's find carried hearth to hearth*, 16 an Lùnastal, VE 4,673; ⇔ At the same time *The words of the low cutting known at every hearth*, 6 an Gearran, VE 4,675; ← Leads to *A woman of the line sits three days before the western stone*, 7 am Màrt, VE 4,676; ← Leads to *Clann na Ceiste claims the fire, and leaves the older line unread*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,680.

48. ¶ Legacy *Carragh Cnoc bheag raised*, 17 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,672; ◇ Same person *Lughaidh's father asks what he moved*, 14 an t-Sultain, VE 4,674.

49. ← Follows from *The older face of Carragh Cnoc bheag*, 11 an Lùnastal, VE 4,718.

50. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

51. ← Leads to *A second stone found in the stony hills*, 8 am Faoilleach, VE 4,700; ¶ Legacy of *The line answers for a bidding cut to no one*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,705.

52. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

53. ← Follows from *Colbh Cnoc chiar raised*, 9 an t-Sultain, VE 4,770.

54. the Children of the Question

55. the Telling of the Making

56. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

8 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,812 — *A ring of fire-stones round the pillar* (Colbh Cnoc chiar⁵⁸). The ground about Colbh Cnoc chiar is trodden hard in a ring and paved with fire-cracked stones. Fires the size of hearths are kept there again and again. Nothing else is left.⁵⁹

15 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,812 — *The ring at the pillar is kept and grows a path* (Colbh Cnoc chiar⁶⁰). Mòrnait returns to the ring at Colbh Cnoc chiar year on year, joined in time by others who come to sit an evening by the fire before going their own ways, until a worn path runs to it across the broken ground and the ash within the stones lies black and deep.⁶¹

12 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,820 — *Mòrnait holds the fire is kept, not questioned* (Colbh Cnoc chiar⁶²). Asked more than once whether her fire is some new trial of the old riddle, Mòrnait answers that the stone asked only to be remembered, not questioned, there being questioning enough already given the two dark coals by better keepers than herself.⁶³

9 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,830 — *Others come to sit by Mòrnait's fire* (Colbh Cnoc chiar⁶⁴). As word of the fire at the second stone goes about the valleys, others walk the hard day into the stony hills to sit a night or a day by Mòrnait's fire before going home.⁶⁵

24 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,850 — *Mòrnait's last walk to the ring* (Colbh Cnoc chiar⁶⁶). In her sixty-fifth year Mòrnait makes the walk to Colbh Cnoc chiar for the last time, and tells the few who sit with her that evening she does not know what the stone remembers, only that she has kept it as well as she knew how.⁶⁷

II AM MÀRT, VE 4,850 — *Mòrnait dies, and her daughter takes up the keeping* (Tobar dhireach). Mòrnait dies at her own hearth some weeks after her last walk, and her daughter, and after her the daughter's own children, take up the walk to the ring in her stead, less often than Mòrnait kept it but often enough that the fire does not go cold.⁶⁸

57. ◇ Same person *Mòrnait born at Tobar dhireach*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 4,785.

58. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

59. → Caused by *Mòrnait born at Tobar dhireach*, 3 an Lùnastal, VE 4,785; ← Leads to *Mòrnait carries fire to the second stone*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,805.

60. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

61. ← Follows from *A ring of fire-stones round the pillar*, 8 an Dàmhair, VE 4,812; ◇ Same person *Mòrnait carries fire to the second stone*, 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,805.

62. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

63. ▮ Legacy *A ring of fire-stones round the pillar*, 8 an Dàmhair, VE 4,812; ◇ Same person *The ring at the pillar is kept and grows a path*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,812.

64. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

65. ← Follows from *A ring of fire-stones round the pillar*, 8 an Dàmhair, VE 4,812; ◇ Same person *Mòrnait holds the fire is kept, not questioned*, 12 am Faoilleach, VE 4,820.

66. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

67. ▮ Legacy *A ring of fire-stones round the pillar*, 8 an Dàmhair, VE 4,812; ◇ Same person *Others come to sit by Mòrnait's fire*, 9 an Giblean, VE 4,830.

68. ▮ Legacy *A ring of fire-stones round the pillar*, 8 an Dàmhair, VE 4,812; ◇ Same person *Mòrnait's last walk to the ring*, 24 am Faoilleach, VE 4,850.

- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,851** — *Calbh Cnoc ghorm*⁶⁹ raised (Calbh Cnoc ghorm). A third stone is raised, and on it the whole of the saying: Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann. Here, it may be, the belief was first spoken.
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,851** — *Ciannait finds the third stone standing* (Achadh a' Chalb⁷⁰). Ciannait, driving her household's beasts down to the autumn stubble, finds a squared pillar newly standing on the rise by the drove-road where no stone had stood the year before, and reads aloud, alone but for a boy of her own kin, the four words cut low on its face and the whole saying beneath them.⁷¹
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,852** — *Ciannait's brother's boy asks if the stone will stand* (Achadh a' Chalb⁷²). Ciannait's brother's boy asks whether the new-found pillar will still be standing come morning; she tells him a stone is not a fire and has never yet been known to go out.⁷³
- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,853** — *The rise takes the name Achadh a' Chalb⁷⁴* (Achadh a' Chalb⁷⁵). The hearths that gather to look at the new pillar begin to call the rise Achadh a' Chalb⁷⁶, a name that settles into use before any household troubles to remember which mouth first gave it.⁷⁵
- 21 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,854** — *The whole saying said standing for the first time* (Achadh a' Chalb⁷⁶). At a gathering of some thirty households kept at Achadh a' Chalb on Oidhche an Dealanaich⁷⁷, an old woman of a neighbouring valley says the sayings of all three stones together before a crowd, and ties the third saying to Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁷⁸'s grass-people and the island as their only root.⁷⁹
- 22 AM MÀRT, VE 4,854** — *An old woman says the three sayings as one* (Achadh a' Chalb⁸⁰). At the first gathering kept at the pillar an old woman of a hearth two valleys east says the sayings of the three stones together for the first time, and says after them that the stone says in fewer words what Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁸¹ always said.⁸²

69. the column at Cnoc ghorm

70. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

71. ← Follows from *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851.

72. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

73. ← Follows from *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851; ◇ Same person *Ciannait finds the third stone standing*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,851.

74. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

75. ↓ Legacy *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851.

76. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

77. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

78. the Telling of the Making

79. → Leads to *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851; ◇ Same person *Ciannait's brother's boy asks if the stone will stand*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,852.

80. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

81. the Telling of the Making

82. ← Follows from *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851.

20 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,857 — *The gathering at the column kept a second year, and a third* (Achadh a' Chalb⁸³). More households come to keep the dark of the year at Achadh a' Chalb than came the winter before, and the ground about the pillar's foot begins to wear bare under their standing, so that within Ciannait's own lifetime the column becomes the one gathering-ground of that whole stretch of country.⁸⁴

19 AN CÈITEAN, VE 4,862 — *Seathan born to the keeper's hearth* (Tobar dhìreach). Seathan is born at Tobar dhìreach, the only son of the keeper of gual teine⁸⁵ and the rainbow, and has gual teine in his hands from earliest childhood as every child of that hearth has had it before him.

17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,865 — *A market grows up at the column's gatherings* (Achadh a' Chalb⁸⁶). Traders begin setting hides, salt and wool out on cloths spread over the trampled ground at Achadh a' Chalb on the two days a year the crowds are greatest, taking their goods up again each evening, for no one yet thinks to leave anything standing there overnight but the stone.⁸⁷

16 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,868 — *A boy of the keeper's hearth bears of the third stone* (Tobar dhìreach). At Tobar dhìreach a fire-bearer carries the first word of the pillar and its saying to the keeper's own hearth, and a boy not yet six turns gual teine⁸⁸ in his fingers as he listens, asking his mother whether the coal and the stone's saying come from the one place.⁸⁹

14 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,870 — *The saying carried to the northern shore* (Achadh a' Chalb⁹⁰). A woman of the northern shore, come south to trade hides for salt at one of Achadh a' Chalb's market days, hears the whole saying said at the stone and carries it home the length of the island, telling it first at her own hearth to a household that keeps no stone and no gathering-ground of its own.⁹¹

12 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,876 — *A north-western shepherd answers a trader with the saying*. A shepherd of the far north-western moor, asked by a passing trader what his own people hold of where they came from, answers with the third stone's four words, though he has never walked south to hear them said at Achadh a' Chalb⁹² himself.⁹³

83. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

84. ¶ Legacy *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851; ◇ Same person *The whole saying said standing for the first time*, 21 an Gearran, VE 4,854.

85. the fire coal, of fire

86. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

87. ¶ Legacy *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851.

88. the fire coal, of fire

89. → Leads to *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851; ◇ Same person *Seathan born to the keeper's hearth*, 19 an Cèitean, VE 4,862.

90. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

91. ← Follows from *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851.

92. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

93. ¶ Legacy *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851.

- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,880** — *Seathan's father tells him the waiting is part of the keeping* (Tobar dhìreach). Seathan's father tells the boy that the bag on its peg has waited longer than any stone in the south, and that a thing worth keeping is worth keeping without asking each year whether the keeping has come to anything.⁹⁴
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, VE 4,882** — *Seathan takes the bag over* (Tobar dhìreach). On his father's death Seathan takes the bag of two coals and the keeping in his twentieth year, and chooses, unlike his father before him, to keep gual teine⁹⁵ near the hearth rather than carry it abroad.
96
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,885** — *A trader woman walks ten days to the column* (Achadh a' Chalbh⁹⁷). A woman of the northern shore walks ten days south by the drove-roads to trade hides for salt at the column, hears many households say the same words together, and carries the saying home with the salt.
- 22 AM MÀRT, VE 4,888** — *Seathan marries Caitir* (Tobar dhìreach). Seathan takes Caitir, of a household two valleys east that keeps no coal of its own, and she comes to Tobar dhìreach knowing she marries a keeper and not only a husband.⁹⁸
- II AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,890** — *Ciannait says the saying to her children by her own fire*. In the last winter of her life, her joints too cold-bitten for the walk to Achadh a' Chalbh⁹⁹, Ciannait says the third stone's saying once more to her children at her own hearth, tying it plainly to Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹⁰⁰ of the grass-people grown from the island's own ground.¹⁰¹
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,891** — *Ciannait dies at her own hearth*. Ciannait dies in her one and seventieth year at the hearth where she was born, and is buried, as her own kin have always been buried, without any coal of the vein given her in the ground, that custom never having reached so far south-west in her lifetime.¹⁰²
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,895** — *Ciannait's children keep the walk to the column after her* (Achadh a' Chalbh¹⁰³). Ciannait's children take up the walk to Achadh a' Chalbh in her stead, not every year but often enough that the fire at the pillar's foot never goes long unlit in their own generation, and the saying she gave them at her hearth goes on being said by mouths that never stood at the stone itself.¹⁰⁴

94. ◇ Same person *A boy of the keeper's hearth hears of the third stone*, 16 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,868.

95. the fire coal, of fire

96. ◇ Same person *Seathan's father tells him the waiting is part of the keeping*, 17 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,880.

97. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

98. ◇ Same person *Seathan takes the bag over*, 19 an Cèitean, VE 4,882.

99. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

100. the Telling of the Making

101. ¶ Legacy *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851; ◇ Same person *The gathering at the column kept a second year, and a third*, 20 an Giblean, VE 4,857.

102. ¶ Legacy *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851; ◇ Same person *Ciannait says the saying to her children by her own fire*, 11 an Dàmhair, VE 4,890.

103. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

104. ¶ Legacy *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851.

- 16 AN T-ÌUCHAR, VE 4,896** — *Gual teine put into the pot itself* (Tobar dhìreach). Seathan puts gual teine¹⁰⁵ into the fire the line holds to be the mason's own, carried unbroken since Oidhche an Dealanaich¹⁰⁶, and it lies dark and cool through the flame as it lies in every other fire he has tried.¹⁰⁷
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,905** — *The fire in the fingers* (Tobar dhìreach). Seathan of Clann na Ceiste¹⁰⁸, who has handled the coal of fire all his days to no end, snaps his fingers when a thought strikes him, and the coal-dust on his hand takes fire. He beats it out against his coat and is not burned. So the sixth coal is lit, by the fire that is in the hand itself.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,905** — *Seathan snaps his fingers on the doorstone* (Tobar dhìreach). On a warm evening Seathan, breaking gual teine¹⁰⁹ into dust between his fingers and thinking of the mason and the lightning's crack, snaps his fingers without meaning to try anything, and the dust on his hand takes fire, red-gold, and leaves no mark on him.¹¹⁰
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,905** — *Seathan laughs until Caitir comes* (Tobar dhìreach). Seathan sits on the doorstone laughing until his wife comes out to him, and tells her, before he tells anyone else, that the fire has been in his own hand the whole thirty years he carried it.¹¹¹
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,905** — *The telling at the hearth* (Tobar dhìreach). Seathan tells gual teine¹¹²'s waking at the recital on Oidhche an Dealanaich¹¹³ that same year, plainly, as he told it to Caitir, and the valley begins to call the sixth coal gual teine.¹¹⁴
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,905** — *Caitir turns Seathan's hand over* (Tobar dhìreach). Caitir, coming to the door at Seathan's shout with her hands floury from baking, sits down beside him on the doorstone and turns his hand over herself to see that there is no mark on it.¹¹⁵
- 12 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,906** — *The children carry gual teine¹¹⁶'s waking to their mother's kin* (Tobar dhìreach). Seathan's children, having seen their father laughing on the doorstone, run to tell their mother's kin before they rightly understand what there is to tell, and the word goes to every hearth within a day's walk.¹¹⁷

105. the fire coal, of fire

106. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

107. ◇ Same person *Seathan marries Caitir*, 22 an Màrt, VE 4,888.

108. the Children of the Question

109. the fire coal, of fire

110. ○ Same place *The fire in the fingers*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,905; ◇ Same person *Gual teine put into the pot itself*, 16 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,896.

111. ← Follows from *The fire in the fingers*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,905; ◇ Same person *Seathan snaps his fingers on the doorstone*, 30 an Lùnastal, VE 4,905.

112. the fire coal, of fire

113. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

114. ← Follows from *The fire in the fingers*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,905; ◇ Same person *Seathan laughs until Caitir comes*, 19 an t-Sultain, VE 4,905.

115. ← Follows from *The fire in the fingers*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,905; ◇ Same person *Seathan laughs until Caitir comes*, 19 an t-Sultain, VE 4,905.

116. the fire coal, of fire

117. ◇ Same person *Caitir turns Seathan's hand over*, 27 an t-Samhain, VE 4,905.

- 10 AN CÈITEAN, VE 4,907** — *The rainbow thrown into the northern sea again.* Seathan carries gual bogha-froise¹¹⁸ to the northern shore in the old custom and throws it into the swell, and wades in after it to find it as dark and salt-wet as it went in.¹¹⁹
- 11 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,910** — *Dressed-up tellings of the snap corrected.* Tellers far from Tobar dhìreach begin to have Seathan snap his fingers on purpose, as a fisherman tries a new knot, and are corrected by those nearer the hearth who heard from Caitir that there was no purpose in it.¹²⁰
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,920** — *The rainbow tried at the river crossing* (Tobar dhìreach). Seathan and Caitir carry gual bogha-froise¹²¹ down to the crossing where the silver still burns under the current, and hold it and then throw it, and it lies cold and ordinary among the wet stones the next morning.¹²²
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,920** — *Caitir's saying of the rainbow* (Tobar dhìreach). Caitir says, after the river trial, that the rainbow holds every spirit and so belongs wholly to none of them, a saying that afterward passes among Clann na Ceiste¹²³.¹²⁴
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,921** — *Caitir goes with the rainbow to the sea and the river.* Caitir walks with Seathan to the northern shore and to the river crossing with gual bogha-froise¹²⁵, the only keeper's wife of the line remembered to have gone and not stayed by the pot.¹²⁶
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,934** — *Seathan dies at his own hearth* (Tobar dhìreach). Seathan dies in his three-and-seventieth year at Tobar dhìreach, Poit an Teine¹²⁷ burning near him, asking at the last to hold gual teine¹²⁸ once more rather than the rainbow.¹²⁹
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,934** — *The bag passes to Seathan's eldest son* (Tobar dhìreach). The bag, holding only the rainbow now, passes from Seathan's grave to his eldest son, a quiet man who never expected so great a charge while his father's hand was still warm.¹³⁰
- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,938** — *Caitir tries the rainbow once more* (Tobar dhìreach). Caitir, staying on at Tobar dhìreach after Seathan's death, tries the rainbow once more at the river for the comfort of doing something with it, and it lies as dark and unmoved as it lay in her husband's hand.¹³¹

118. the rainbow coal, of spirit

119. ◇ Same person *The children carry gual teine's waking to their mother's kin*, 12 an Gearran, VE 4,906.

120. ◇ Same person *Caitir turns Seathan's hand over*, 27 an t-Samhain, VE 4,905.

121. the rainbow coal, of spirit

122. ◇ Same person *The rainbow thrown into the northern sea again*, 10 an Cèitean, VE 4,907.

123. the Children of the Question

124. ◇ Same person *The rainbow tried at the river crossing*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,920.

125. the rainbow coal, of spirit

126. ◇ Same person *Caitir's saying of the rainbow*, 7 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,920.

127. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

128. the fire coal, of fire

129. ¶ Legacy *The fire in the fingers*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,905; ◇ Same person *Caitir goes with the rainbow to the sea and the river*, 10 an Dàmhair, VE 4,921.

130. ◇ Same person *Seathan dies at his own hearth*, 13 an Lùnastal, VE 4,934.

131. ◇ Same person *Seathan dies at his own hearth*, 13 an Lùnastal, VE 4,934.

- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,940** — *Caitir dies at Tobar dhìreach* (Tobar dhìreach). Caitir dies in her three-and-seventieth year, the same age Seathan reached before her, and is buried beside him near Leac na Fèithe.^{132, 133}
- 15 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,940** — *Caitir tries the rainbow once more at the river* (Abhainn ghorm). In the years after Seathan's death Caitir tries the rainbow once more at the river below the house, and puts it back in the bag without disappointment, having ceased to expect it to answer a woman who only wished it well.¹³⁴
- 19 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,951** — *The crowd at the column grows* (Achadh a' Chalbh¹³⁵). Word of gual teine¹³⁶'s waking spreads beyond the hill country's own hearths, and people begin coming to Achadh a' Chalbh in tens and then in hundreds to hear the recital said at the column, camping about the stone rather than passing it by.
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,951** — *The gatherings at the column* (Cnoc ghorm). People come to the column at Cnoc ghorm in numbers. The post-holes of shelters for some hundreds lie about it, used and rebuilt many times. Whatever was said there was said to a crowd.¹³⁷
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, VE 4,960** — *A nephew of Seathan afraid of the crowd* (Achadh a' Chalbh¹³⁸). The young nephew of Seathan sent to say the Line at the column sits apart from the fires the day before, sick with fear of so many faces, until an old woman tells him that a story kept in one hearth is safe from nothing but changing.¹³⁹
- 20 AN GEARRAN, VE 4,965** — *The first shelters built at the column* (Achadh a' Chalbh¹⁴⁰). The crowd that gathers to hear the recital builds the first low walls of turf and hide about Achadh a' Chalbh, taken down again when the telling ends, because no one yet thinks of the column's ground as a place a person lives.¹⁴¹
- 21 AM MÀRT, VE 4,970** — *Seathan's nephew gives the telling to a crowd* (Achadh a' Chalbh¹⁴²). Clann na Ceiste¹⁴³ sends a nephew of Seathan's to Achadh a' Chalbh to say the recital naming gual teine¹⁴⁴ to a hillside of strangers rather than a single hearth, and an old woman of the gathering tells him a story given to a crowd is safe from dying, whatever changes it gathers in the carrying.¹⁴⁵

132. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

133. ◇ Same person *Caitir tries the rainbow once more*, 11 an t-Sultain, VE 4,938.

134. ◇ Same person *Caitir dies at Tobar dhìreach*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,940.

135. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

136. the fire coal, of fire

137. → Caused by *The crowd at the column grows*, 19 am Faoilleach, VE 4,951.

138. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

139. ← Follows from *The gatherings at the column*, 17 an Giblean, VE 4,951.

140. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

141. → Leads to *The gatherings at the column*, 17 an Giblean, VE 4,951.

142. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

143. the Children of the Question

144. the fire coal, of fire

145. ← Follows from *The gatherings at the column*, 17 an Giblean, VE 4,951; ◇ Same person *The bag passes to Seathan's eldest son*, 8 an t-Samhain, VE 4,934.

19 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,980 — *The telling slowed for the crowd* (Achadh a' Chalb¹⁴⁶). For the crowd at the column the Line comes to be said more slowly, with a pause after each father's name long enough for those at the back to have it passed forward mouth to mouth.¹⁴⁷

21 AM MÀRT, VE 5,000 — *The shelters at the column rebuilt* (Achadh a' Chalb¹⁴⁸). The shelters at Achadh a' Chalb are rebuilt so many times over on the footings of the ones before them that a household coming for the first time can see, in the worn hollows and packed earth, that others have stood there before it and will stand there after.¹⁴⁹

146. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

147. ← Follows from *The gatherings at the column*, 17 an Giblean, VE 4,951.

148. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

149. ¶ Legacy *The gatherings at the column*, 17 an Giblean, VE 4,951.

THE YEARS VE 5,001 – 5,324

- 16 AN CÈITEAN, VE 5,010** — *Tuam Cnoc dhìreach*¹ *consecrated* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach). A burial-ground grows about a place that none remembers hallowing. Its oldest graves are older than the oldest names that can be read there.
- 20 AN GEARRAN, VE 5,020** — *The rainbow passed hand to hand at the column* (Achadh a' Chalb²). At a great telling at the column a keeper of the bag gives gual bogha-froise³ into the crowd, and it goes round from hand to hand by firelight through the whole night and comes back to him at dawn as dark as it went out.⁴
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 5,030** — *The bag passes down the line of fathers* (Tobar dhìreach). The bag holding gual bogha-froise⁵, passes down the line of fathers from Seathan's son, and a keeper whose name the recital keeps from strangers resolves to try it in the oak grove at Doire ghlas.⁶
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 5,050** — *The rainbow tried in the grove*. A keeper of Clann na Ceiste⁷ carries gual bogha-froise⁸ north to the oak grove at Doire ghlas and sits with it through a night by his own small fire as Diarmad once sat, waiting for any sign Coimhdeach na Fine⁹ gave before; the coal lies black and cold among the ash by morning, and the grove answers him nothing.¹⁰
- 15 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 5,067** — *Aoife's child born*. Aoife bears a living child after two she has already lost in their first winters, and lets herself believe, when it survives its own first winter thin but breathing steadily, that this one will live to walk; she sews it, for the first time, a coat cut to its own growing rather than one handed down.
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 5,068** — *Aoife sews a coat cut to the child's growing*. Aoife, trusting for the first time that a child of hers will live, sews in the last cold months a small coat cut to the child's own growing, a thing she had not let herself do for the two children before.¹¹
- 14 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 5,070** — *The black chip in the child's grave* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach¹²). A child is buried at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach with a sliver of the coloured coal closed in one hand. The sliver stains still the cloth it is kept in. No other piece of the vein is found with the dead of this age.

1. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

2. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

3. the rainbow coal, of spirit

4. ← Follows from *The gatherings at the column*, 17 an Giblean, VE 4,951.

5. the rainbow coal, of spirit

6. ◇ Same person *Seathan's nephew gives the telling to a crowd*, 21 am Màrt, VE 4,970.

7. the Children of the Question

8. the rainbow coal, of spirit

9. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

10. ← Follows from *Calbh Cnoc ghorm raised*, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851.

11. ◇ Same person *Aoife's child born*, 15 an t-Iuchar, VE 5,067.

12. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

- 18 AN CÈITEAN, VE 5,071** — *Aoife's child dies*. Aoife's child sickens in the spring and dies quietly in her arms, the third child she has lost and the first she does not hear cry out at the end, so that she says afterward she knew, before she was willing to know it, that this death would not be like the others.¹³
- 1 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 5,071** — *The child buried with the sliver of coal* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach¹⁴). Aoife closes into her dead child's hand the one sliver of an gual dathach¹⁵ her household still keeps, over her husband's mother's objection, and it is buried with the child at the western edge of Tuam Cnoc dhìreach, the only piece of the vein put into the ground with the dead this age.¹⁶
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 5,071** — *Words between two households over the sliver*. Aoife's husband's mother says a hearth ought not give a piece of an gual dathach¹⁷ to the dead while the living have use for it, and there are words between the two households that neither afterward cares to keep.¹⁸
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 5,080** — *The graves begin to keep a line* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach¹⁹). The newer graves at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach's western edge begin, without any household deciding it, to be set in a row facing the northern mountains, each new grave drawn to the line the ones before it have already kept, until a household bringing its dead looks for the row before it looks for empty turf.
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 5,080** — *A grave dug round an old swelling* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach²⁰). A young man digging his grandfather's grave at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach proposes levelling an old unnamed swelling in his row's path, and is rebuked by an elder digger, who tells him no man may open a grave whose occupant he cannot name; the row bends round it instead.
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 5,090** — *An uncle forbids the levelling of an old grave* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach²¹). A young man digging his grandfather's grave at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach proposes to level an old swelling in the row's path, and his uncle forbids it: a man who cannot say whose grave he opens has no business opening it.

13. ◇ Same person *Aoife sews a coat cut to the child's growing*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, VE 5,068.

14. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

15. the coloured coal

16. ← Follows from *The black chip in the child's grave*, 14 an t-Ògmhios, VE 5,070; ◇ Same person *Aoife's child dies*, 18 an Cèitean, VE 5,071.

17. the coloured coal

18. ← Follows from *The black chip in the child's grave*, 14 an t-Ògmhios, VE 5,070; ◇ Same person *The child buried with the sliver of coal*, 1 an Lùnastal, VE 5,071.

19. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

20. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

21. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 5,110** — *Aoife dies* (Tuam Cnoc dhíreach²²). Aoife dies in her seventieth year, forty years after burying her child, and is carried to Tuam Cnoc dhíreach and laid in the row nearest the western edge where the child already lies, the row bending as it reaches her grave to keep clear of the old swelling beside it.²³
- 13 AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 5,114** — *The rows at Tuam Cnoc dhíreach*²⁴ (Tuam Cnoc dhíreach). The graves at Tuam Cnoc dhíreach begin to be laid in rows, heads toward the central mountains. The first rows are straight. The later ones bend round older graves that no one will disturb.²⁵
- 20 AN GEARRAN, VE 5,150** — *The western face of the burial hill woven with bending rows* (Tuam Cnoc dhíreach²⁶). Seen from far enough off, the whole western face of Tuam Cnoc dhíreach shows no longer straight lines but a slow curved weaving of rows folding round the swellings no living hand made.²⁷
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 5,170** — *The panther roads*. The great cats of the island are first seen to keep their roads, crossing the mountains by fixed ways at fixed seasons. Why they do so no one has learned.
- 21 AM MÁRT, VE 5,192** — *Beithir finds the cats' road in the snow* (Imrich nam Pantar²⁸). A herder of the central mountains follows three strayed ewes into a high saddle and finds a line of prints worn into the frozen turf on both sides of it, running straight where the ground gave the beast no cause to turn; his own hearth's elders tell him their fathers knew the same line and the same two turns of year it is kept in.²⁹
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, VE 5,195** — *An old man tells Beithir the cats keep their roads* (Imrich nam Pantar³⁰). The oldest man of Beithir's hearth tells him that his father and his father's father said the same of that saddle: the great cats of the mountains do not wander the high ground but cross it, at some seasons and not others.³¹
- 20 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 5,219** — *The crossing season kept* (Imrich nam Pantar³²). The hill-folk learn the panthers' seasons and keep off the high passes while the cats cross. The camps in the passes stand empty at the same point in every year.

22. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhíreach

23. ◇ Same person *Words between two households over the sliver*, 30 an Lùnastal, VE 5,071.

24. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhíreach

25. → Caused by *The graves begin to keep a line*, 27 an Dàmhair, VE 5,080; ← Leads to *A grave dug round an old swelling*, 25 an t-Samhain, VE 5,080; ← Leads to *An uncle forbids the levelling of an old grave*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, VE 5,090.

26. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhíreach

27. ¶ Legacy *The rows at Tuam Cnoc dhíreach*, 13 an t-Iuchar, VE 5,114.

28. the panthers' crossing

29. → Leads to *The panther roads*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, VE 5,170.

30. the panthers' crossing

31. ← Follows from *The panther roads*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, VE 5,170.

32. the panthers' crossing

- 18 AN CÈITEAN, VE 5,220** — *The gatepost sign first cut* (Imrich nam Pantar³³). A household of the high valleys cuts a fresh mark into its gatepost at the turn of year the cats' smell and track return to the passes, and scrapes it away again once both are gone, so that a stranger walking the crossing weeks can read the closed season on every post without asking what the mark means.³⁴
- 9 AM MÀRT, VE 5,222** — *Àirighean a' Bhealaich*³⁵ *stand empty* (Àirighean a' Bhealaich). The herders' summer camps on the high passes are found stripped and shuttered at the same point in every year while the cats cross, a boy sent up in error by his father's lost count of days finding one already closed and coming down again with nothing worse than a wasted night's walk.³⁶
- 7 AN GIBLEAN, VE 5,225** — *The gatepost cut deep enough to read in the scraping* (Imrich nam Pantar³⁷). An old woman of the eastern slopes tells a new-married daughter that the crossing mark must be cut deep enough to be read even after it is scraped, so that a late-comer knows the season has been kept there before.³⁸
- 8 AN GIBLEAN, VE 5,226** — *A boy sent up in error to a stripped shieling* (Àirighean a' Bhealaich³⁹). A boy sent up to winter sheep at a shieling in the crossing season, his father having lost the count of days in a wet spell, finds it already stripped and shuttered by households that read the signs, and comes down the same evening.⁴⁰
- 10 AM MÀRT, VE 5,230** — *Thirty head lost to a broken custom* (Imrich nam Pantar⁴¹). A herdsman of the lower slopes, trusting his own count of the year over his neighbours' gatepost signs, keeps his cattle ten days past the crossing's start and brings them down to find thirty head missing from the herd, torn on the ground above the track in a way no wolf of that country tears ground.⁴²
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, VE 5,250** — *The cats turn back at the foothills* (Imrich nam Pantar⁴³). A family watching from a rise above the track sees the crossing cats turn from the eastern passes and go back down toward the western foothills for no cause the watchers can find, and the country reads the plain sign as a warning rather than let it pass unanswered.⁴⁴

33. the panthers' crossing

34. → Leads to *The crossing season kept*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 5,219.

35. the shielings of the pass; herders' summer camps on the high passes, left empty while the cats cross (place 1004)

36. ← Follows from *The crossing season kept*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 5,219.

37. the panthers' crossing

38. ← Follows from *The crossing season kept*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 5,219.

39. the shielings of the pass; herders' summer camps on the high passes, left empty while the cats cross (place 1004)

40. ← Follows from *The crossing season kept*, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 5,219.

41. the panthers' crossing

42. ← Follows from *The panther roads*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, VE 5,170.

43. the panthers' crossing

- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 5,250** — *The households store double* (Imrich nam Pantar⁴⁵). On the strength of the turning cats the country stores double against a hard winter that no other sign has yet shown, cutting peat and laying by grain and dried meat past what the ordinary count of mouths at each hearth calls for; the winter that follows proves hard enough to repay the extra carrying.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 5,251** — *The hard winter after the cats turned back*. The winter after the cats turn back lays snow to a grown man's waist in the lower valleys for the better part of two months, and every household that stored double says afterward the cutting and the carrying were worth it.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 5,271** — *A household scrapes its gatepost early* (Imrich nam Pantar⁴⁶). A household near the high passes, reading the geese's lateness as a slow season, scrapes its crossing mark bare a full ten days before the cats' smell returns to the saddle above it.
- 13 AN GEARRAN, VE 5,272** — *Cairbre and ten set out* (Teallaichean a' Chladaich⁴⁷). Cairbre leads ten men inland from Teallaichean a' Chladaich, reasoning by the coast's own geese, which have not yet gone over in their numbers that autumn, that the crossing season has not yet begun; a household nearer the mountains has scraped its own gatepost clean on the same late reading and by the same error.
- 14 AN GEARRAN, VE 5,272** — *The eleven do not come home* (Cnoc àrsaidh). Cairbre and the ten who went with him fail to reach the valley they set out for and do not return to the shore; no household along the mountains can say it saw them pass, and winter closes the high ground before any search can be made of it that year.⁴⁸
- 7 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 5,272** — *Eleven lost on the panther road* (Cnoc àrsaidh). A party of eleven from the southern shore goes up into the hills near Cnoc àrsaidh in the crossing season and does not return. Years afterwards their bones are found along the line the cats use still.⁴⁹
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 5,272** — *Word comes of a failed harvest inland* (Teallaichean a' Chladaich⁵⁰). Word reaches Teallaichean a' Chladaich that kin settled two valleys further into the hills than the shore's people commonly go have had their harvest fail badly enough that they will not see the winter through unhelped, and Cairbre resolves to lead ten of his own hearth up to carry it down to them.⁵¹

44. ← Follows from *The panther roads*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, VE 5,170.

45. the panthers' crossing

46. the panthers' crossing

47. the hearths of the shore; the southern-shore households from which the eleven went up (place 1006)

48. ◇ Same person *Cairbre and ten set out*, 13 an Gearran, VE 5,272.

49. → Caused by *A household scrapes its gatepost early*, 14 an t-Samhain, VE 5,271; → Caused by *Cairbre and ten set out*, 13 an Gearran, VE 5,272; → Caused by *The eleven do not come home*, 14 an Gearran, VE 5,272.

50. the hearths of the shore; the southern-shore households from which the eleven went up (place 1006)

51. ◇ Same person *The eleven do not come home*, 14 an Gearran, VE 5,272.

- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 5,272** — *Suibhne born at Tobar dhìreach* (Tobar dhìreach). A son is born to the household that keeps Poit an Teine⁵² and the bag of coals, a big child who closes his hand round a finger held out to him and will not readily let it go, so that they say of him he was born holding on; he is given the name Suibhne.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 5,273** — *Cairbre's wife watches the path thirty days* ('Teallaichean a' Chladaich⁵³). Cairbre's wife keeps the twelfth day and the fourteenth and the twentieth on the rise above 'Teallaichean a' Chladaich, and by the thirtieth has stopped telling herself anything, and only watches.⁵⁴
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 5,274** — *Two springs of searching find nothing*. The shore and the kin the eleven had set out to help each try the high ground in the spring after they go missing, and again the spring after that, and both times come down with nothing to show for the walking but blistered feet and a country too wide to give up eleven men for the asking.⁵⁵
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 5,285** — *Suibhne learns the Line standing* (Tobar dhìreach). Suibhne, a boy of the keeper's hearth, hears the whole of the Line said over him standing, as every keeper before him had heard it, and learns it.⁵⁶
- 9 AN GEARRAN, VE 5,290** — *The bones found along the cats' line* (Cnoc àrsaidh). A drover's dog worries a length of bone out of the turf off the marked track at the proper close of a crossing season, and searchers over the following days gather a scatter of bone strung along roughly the same course the cats are known to keep, with nothing of what the eleven carried found among it.⁵⁷
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 5,290** — *The eleven buried where they were found* (Cnoc àrsaidh). Unable to say with certainty which bones belonged to which man, the southern shore buries the gathered dead together high on the mountain rather than divide them wrongly among separate graves, and keeps alongside Cairbre's name the plainer lesson the country had already made of the matter: that the crossing months keep a count of their own that no household's calendar has yet learned to keep exactly with it.⁵⁸
- 10 AM MÀRT, VE 5,300** — *Ailean born to Tobar dhìreach* (Tobar dhìreach). A son is born to Suibhne of Clann na Ceiste⁵⁹ at Tobar dhìreach, heavier in arm and leg than the women at his birth can readily match against memory, and slow to close his hand on a finger held out to him and slower to let it go, so that his mother says he was born holding on.

52. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

53. the hearths of the shore; the southern-shore households from which the eleven went up (place 1006)

54. ← Follows from *Eleven lost on the panther road*, 7 an t-Sultain, VE 5,272; ◇ Same person *Word comes of a failed harvest inland*, 18 an t-Sultain, VE 5,272.

55. ◇ Same person *Cairbre's wife watches the path thirty days*, 16 an Dàmhair, VE 5,273.

56. ◇ Same person *Suibhne born at Tobar dhìreach*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, VE 5,272.

57. ← Follows from *Eleven lost on the panther road*, 7 an t-Sultain, VE 5,272; ◇ Same person *Two springs of searching find nothing*, 14 an t-Samhain, VE 5,274.

58. ¶ Legacy *Eleven lost on the panther road*, 7 an t-Sultain, VE 5,272; ◇ Same person *The bones found along the cats' line*, 9 an Gearran, VE 5,290.

59. the Children of the Question

- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 5,304** — *Ailean found by Poit an Teine*⁶⁰ *for whole mornings* (Tobar dhìreach). Ailean, able to sit upright, is found by Poit an Teine for whole mornings together, not reaching for it or troubling it, only sitting near enough to feel its heat and watching the low flame.⁶¹
- 11 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 5,306** — *Ailean grows slow of speech and broad of hand* (Tobar dhìreach). Ailean keeps to single words while children a season younger than him are stringing sentences, and some of his kin wonder aloud whether the line has thrown up a son too plain for the keeping, until his mother points to his hands, already broad at six years old, as proof enough of what manner of man he will be.⁶²
- 26 AN GEARRAN, VE 5,310** — *Ailean's mother answers the talk of his slowness* (Tobar dhìreach). Ailean's mother puts a stop to the kin's talk of a son too plain for the keeping, saying a slow tongue is no mark against a steady hand, and pointing to his hands.⁶³
- 27 AM MÀRT, VE 5,312** — *Suibhne drops the rainbow from Binnean a' Chlachair*⁶⁴ (Binnean a' Chlachair). In the second year of his keeping Suibhne climbs Binnean a' Chlachair and drops the rainbow from the height of his arm over the same steep side Fearghas used, and it falls to the stones without a flicker.⁶⁵
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 5,313** — *Suibhne lays the rainbow beside the burning silver* (Abhainn ghorm). Suibhne throws the rainbow into the river at the crossing where the silver still burns under the current, so that for a breath the two lie side by side, dark against bright, before the current carries it on.⁶⁶
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 5,314** — *Suibhne will not try the rainbow by blood* (Tobar dhìreach). Suibhne tries the rainbow by the sea, the height, the river and the earth, but will not try it by blood, telling his wife a man ought not open his own hand for a coal that has shown it wants no single element.⁶⁷
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 5,316** — *Suibhne carries the rainbow to Doire ghlas* (Doire ghlas). In his four-and-fortieth year Suibhne walks the three days north to Doire ghlas with gual bogha-froise⁶⁸, the first keeper to bring it to the grove where Coimhdeach na Fine⁶⁹ first spoke, and sits under the oaks a night and a day with it held loose in his open hand; it shows him no change of colour or warmth, and he carries it home cold.⁷⁰

60. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

61. ◇ Same person *Ailean born to Tobar dhìreach*, 10 am Màrt, VE 5,300.

62. ◇ Same person *Ailean found by Poit an Teine for whole mornings*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, VE 5,304.

63. ◇ Same person *Ailean grows slow of speech and broad of hand*, 11 am Faoilleach, VE 5,306.

64. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

65. ◇ Same person *Ailean born to Tobar dhìreach*, 10 am Màrt, VE 5,300.

66. ◇ Same person *Suibhne drops the rainbow from Binnean a' Chlachair*, 27 am Màrt, VE 5,312.

67. ◇ Same person *Suibhne lays the rainbow beside the burning silver*, 31 an Dàmhair, VE 5,313.

68. the rainbow coal, of spirit

69. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 5,316** — *Suibhne says he doubts the rainbow will answer him* (Tobar dhìreach). Suibhne tells his own hearth, and not the recital, that he no longer knows whether a man ought to go on asking a question already asked in every way his own life can think to ask it; his son Ailean, sixteen years old, hears it among the last things of any length his father says on the matter.⁷¹
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 5,317** — *Ailean marries Liobhan* (Tobar dhìreach). Ailean, seventeen, takes Liobhan of a household two valleys west that keeps no coal of its own; she comes to Tobar dhìreach a bride of fifteen and is taught by Suibhne's widow, in the short time left to teach her, how Poit an Teine⁷² is fed and the bag kept and what is and is not said of it to a stranger.⁷³
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, VE 5,318** — *Suibhne dies of a fever* (Tobar dhìreach). Suibhne dies in his forty-sixth year of a fever that takes him inside a fortnight, with Ailean, eighteen years old and already the broadest man of that hearth, sitting with him through the last nights; the bag of two coals passes to Ailean, though no word of keeping is said over him yet.⁷⁴
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 5,318** — *Gormshuil born* (Tobar dhìreach). A daughter is born to Ailean and Liobhan in the same wet autumn the household buries Suibhne, and is named Gormshuil for the blue of her eyes at birth, which her grandmother swears she has never seen come on so soon in any other child.⁷⁵
- 11 AN GIBLEAN, VE 5,322** — *Liobhan names the rainbow's want* (Tobar dhìreach). Liobhan says aloud to Ailean what he has half thought and not yet let himself say, that a coal made of every colour together may belong wholly to no single element, as a child of two households belongs wholly to neither; Ailean turns the thought over the whole of that winter until it settles into near certainty.⁷⁶
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, VE 5,323** — *Ailean tells the recital he means to light the six again* (Tobar dhìreach). At the recital in his three-and-twentieth year Ailean tells the reciters only that he means, in the year ahead, to light the six coals again by each one's own old way and carry them living to wherever the seventh might at last be answered; the reciters say they will wait to hear how it goes.⁷⁷
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, VE 5,323** — *Ailean wakes the gold on the northern sea*. Ailean carries a fresh piece of the vein's gold-sheened colour the day's road north to the shore and throws it into the autumn swell as Aodh once did; it takes fire bright gold on the water, and this time he wades in after it and carries it home still burning in a clay pot with a lid of turf.⁷⁸

70. ◇ Same person *Suibhne will not try the rainbow by blood*, 2 an Dàmhair, VE 5,314.

71. ◇ Same person *Suibhne carries the rainbow to Doire gblas*, 5 an Lùnastal, VE 5,316.

72. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

73. ◇ Same person *Suibhne says he doubts the rainbow will answer him*, 3 an t-Sultain, VE 5,316.

74. ◇ Same person *Suibhne says he doubts the rainbow will answer him*, 3 an t-Sultain, VE 5,316.

75. ◇ Same person *Suibhne dies of a fever*, 10 an Cèitean, VE 5,318.

76. ◇ Same person *Gormshuil born*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, VE 5,318.

77. ◇ Same person *Liobhan names the rainbow's want*, 11 an Giblean, VE 5,322.

78. ◇ Same person *Ailean tells the recital he means to light the six again*, 10 an Cèitean, VE 5,323.

- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 5,323** — *Ailean wakes the snowflake off the height* (Binnean a' Chlachair⁷⁹). Before winter closes Binnean a' Chlachair, Ailean climbs it in a bitter wind and lets gual sneachda⁸⁰ fall from the height of his own arm as Fearghas once let it fall; it catches fire white halfway down the steep side, and he carries both fires down off the summit together.⁸¹
- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 5,323** — *Ailean wakes the black coal in the earth* (Tobar dhìreach). In the last week before the ground freezes hard Ailean digs a grave-deep hole beside the old slab at Tobar dhìreach, lays the black coal in it as Brian once did, and finds it warm and glowing at dawn; three fires now burn under his roof through the shortest days of the year.⁸²
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 5,323** — *Ailean wades after the burning gold*. Where Aodh let the gold burn out on the water, Ailean wades in to the waist after it and catches it still burning between his cupped hands, and carries it home in a clay pot with a turf lid.⁸³
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 5,324** — *Ailean wakes the red-brown coal with his own blood* (Tobar dhìreach). In the yard behind his house on a frosted spring morning Ailean sets the red-brown coal on a stone and strikes it as Cormac once struck his; the hammer turns and lays his hand open, and where his blood runs onto the coal a deep warm flame comes up, leaving a scar to match the byname's own.⁸⁴
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 5,324** — *Ailean wakes the silver in the Abhainn ghorm* (Tobar dhìreach). At the crossing below Tobar dhìreach Ailean drinks from his own cupped hands as Eòghann once did and throws gual airgid⁸⁵ into the current; it takes fire beneath the running water, and he lifts it out still alight with a wicker scoop made for the purpose.⁸⁶
- 24 AN GEARRAN, VE 5,324** — *Ailean wakes gual teine⁸⁷ on his own doorstone* (Tobar dhìreach). Sitting on his doorstone at midsummer, thinking of nothing to do with fire, Ailean snaps his fingers over dust from the old fire coal without meaning to try anything, as Seathan once did by accident, and the dust flares red-gold and leaves no mark on him; the sixth fire is lit within the same year as the first five.⁸⁸
- 17 AM MÀRT, VE 5,324** — *Ailean sets out north with six fires on a pole* (Tobar dhìreach). In the last week of an t-Iuchar Ailean sets out from Tobar dhìreach for Doire ghlas, carrying the six relit coals in clay pots slung from a pole across his shoulders and the dark rainbow coal wrapped against his chest, with Liobhan and Gormshuil walking beside him as far as the last hearth before the moor.⁸⁹

79. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

80. the snowflake coal, of air

81. ◇ Same person *Ailean wakes the gold on the northern sea*, 22 an Cèitean, VE 5,323.

82. ◇ Same person *Ailean wakes the snowflake off the height*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, VE 5,323.

83. ‡ Legacy *The gold coal takes fire on the sea*, 14 an t-Sultain, VE 1,370; ◇ Same person *Ailean wakes the black coal in the earth*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, VE 5,323.

84. ◇ Same person *Ailean wades after the burning gold*, 7 an t-Iuchar, VE 5,323.

85. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

86. ◇ Same person *Ailean wakes the red-brown coal with his own blood*, 3 am Faoilleach, VE 5,324.

87. the fire coal, of fire

88. ◇ Same person *Ailean wakes the silver in the Abhainn ghorm*, 24 am Faoilleach, VE 5,324.

- 24 AN GIBLEAN, VE 5,324** — *Six fires kept under one roof* (Tobar dhìreach). Through the last weeks of summer six fires burn in six clay pots under one roof at Tobar dhìreach for the first time since the making of the world, and Ailean wakes at odd hours to see that none has failed.⁹⁰
- I AN CÈITEAN, VE 5,324** — *Gormshuil watches the lids lifted* (Tobar dhìreach). Gormshuil, six years old, kept from the pots by her mother's word, is found more than once crouched at a safe distance watching the lids lifted on the six low fires in their six colours.⁹¹
- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 5,324** — *Liobhan parts from Ailean at the last hearth*. Liobhan walks with Ailean as far as the last hearth before the moor with Gormshuil on her hip, and tells him only to mind his feet on the wet northern slopes and that she will keep the house fire until he comes home.⁹²
- 2I AN T-IUCHAR, VE 5,324** — *The rainbow coal lit by the Keeper* (Doire ghlas). Ailean of Clann na Ceiste⁹³, having lit each of the six coals again by its own way, carries them burning to the grove at Doire ghlas with the last coal, which his kindred have tried for more than four hundred years. The Keeper comes to him there and lights the rainbow coal, and for the first time all seven burn together, each from its own spirit. It bids him stay with them until they are cold.⁹⁴

89. ◇ Same person *Ailean wakes gual teine on his own doorstone*, 24 an Gearran, VE 5,324.

90. ◇ Same person *Ailean sets out north with six fires on a pole*, 17 am Màrt, VE 5,324.

91. ◇ Same person *Ailean sets out north with six fires on a pole*, 17 am Màrt, VE 5,324.

92. ◇ Same person *Six fires kept under one roof*, 24 an Giblean, VE 5,324.

93. the Children of the Question

94. → Caused by *Suibhne carries the rainbow to Doire ghlas*, 5 an Lùnastal, VE 5,316; → Caused by *Ailean sets out north with six fires on a pole*, 17 am Màrt, VE 5,324; → Caused by *Six fires kept under one roof*, 24 an Giblean, VE 5,324.

PART THREE

A Gazetteer of the Age

A

Achadh a' Chalbh¹ (the hill country south-west of Tobar dhìreach). Founded 7 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,851. Achadh a' Chalbh, is the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm², the third of the standing stones of the saying, on a low rise in the hill country south-west of Tobar dhìreach. Ciannait, a woman of a nearby hearth, found the stone standing on the rise where she had never seen it, and put her hand to it; within two summers the rise had its name. The whole saying was said standing there for the first time, Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann, and an old woman said the sayings of the three stones together and said after them that the stone said in fewer words what Aithris a' Chruthachaidh³ had always said. The gathering was kept a second year and a third, and a market grew up at it, traders walking in from the northern shore with hides to trade for salt. In the years after Seathan's snap the crowd at the column grew to some hundreds on the nights of the great tellings; shelters were built about the stone and rebuilt many times, and one of Clann na Ceiste⁴ was sent to say the Line there, slowly, with a pause after each father's name long enough for it to be passed back to those at the back. At a great telling gual bogha-froise⁵ went round the crowd hand to hand through a whole night and came back at dawn as dark as it went. At the close of the age the hill country reckons its year by the gatherings at the column. Known for the gatherings at the column and the saying said standing.

Achadh dhìreach (the high valleys, west of Tobar dhìreach). Founded 16 an Cèitean, VE 303. Achadh dhìreach, the straight field, holds the oldest hearths of the high valleys after the mason's own. Eachna, a young woman of a household near Tobar dhìreach, walked the level ground west of the well more than once, looking at it the way a woman looks at a thing she means to have, and in the end carried fire there in a clay pot and laid the first hearth of the place on stone, as the near hearths had learned to do. The hearths were of pine and heather charcoal, with scrapers of grey flint and the split bones of red deer about them; there was no coloured coal in them. Deer were hunted by torch across the straight field, and within a generation five hearths stood there. The first autumn store of roasted hazel-nuts on the island was put by at Achadh dhìreach, in a pit lined with bark. Late in the age the households of the straight field began to rub broken coal from the vein into the wool of their dead, and it took streaks of a colour no plant dye makes. Giorsal of Achadh dhìreach was the one who began it, after her grandmother had shown her a scrap of coloured stone kept in a box three generations and called only the bright stone; when Giorsal died, her daughter rubbed a sliver into her mother's own wrapping. It is seldom done, one grave in some thirty. At the close of the age some sixty souls live at Achadh dhìreach. Known for its oldest hearths and the stained wool of its dead.

1. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

2. the column at Cnoc ghorm

3. the Telling of the Making

4. the Children of the Question

5. the rainbow coal, of spirit

Àirighean a' Bhealaich⁶ (the high passes of the central mountains). Founded 13 an Lùnastal, VE 5,043. Àirighean a' Bhealaich, are the summer camps of the herders in the high passes of the central mountains, where the grass is sweet after the snow goes off it. Each household of the upland valleys keeps its own shieling there, a hut of stone and turf with a fold beside it, and goes up with its beasts when the lambs are strong enough to walk. Since the great cats of the mountains were first seen to keep their roads, crossing by fixed ways at fixed seasons, the households have learned the crossing season and keep off the passes while it lasts: the shielings stand stripped and shuttered at the same point in every year, and a crossing mark is cut on each gatepost and scraped when the season has been kept. A boy sent up to winter sheep in the crossing season, his father having lost the count of days in a wet spell, found his household's shieling already stripped by neighbours who had read the signs, and came down the same evening. The shielings are empty now in their season, and full in the rest of the summer. Known for the shielings left empty while the cats cross.

Àth gharbh (the high valleys, on the hill road east of Tobar dhireach). Founded 13 an Gearran, VE 4,424. Àth gharbh, the rough ford, lies a short walk from Tobar dhireach on the hill road, where the burn runs broad and stony and the drovers rest their beasts. Its households are kin by marriage to half the high valleys, and it was here that the valleys about the crack came to call themselves by one name: at the gathering on Oidhche an Dealanaich⁷, an old man of the western household answered a stranger's question with a word for the whole of the gathered valleys, Clann nan Dè⁸, and the name was said the next year at hearths that had not been at the gathering. Rathnait, born in the valleys about the crack, lived long enough to hear it in ordinary use. The households of Àth gharbh lay their dead in the ground on their side, knees drawn up, facing the central mountains, with an uncut stone at the head. It was also at Àth gharbh that an gual dathach⁹ was first burned outside the line. Barabal, a woman of a household of the ford, dropped a sliver of it into her peat fire, and it burned black-flamed like any other coal, and the hearthstone round it was stained through with colour. Her husband's mother turned the stone over at the door in daylight and said she had heard Clann a' Chlachair¹⁰ kept coloured stones such as this. The stained hearthstone is shown to travellers who ask after it and to children who do not. At the close of the age the ford holds some twelve households, and the drovers' beasts still churn the burn to mud at its crossing. Known for the name Clann nan Dè and the first small burning outside the line.

6. the shielings of the pass; herders' summer camps on the high passes, left empty while the cats cross (place 1004)

7. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

8. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

9. the coloured coal

10. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

B

Bothan a' Chaolais¹ (the strait of the north-western coast). Founded 5 an Cèitean, VE 3,126. Bothan a' Chaolais, the bothies of the strait, is the seal-hunters' camp on the quiet water of the north-western strait, south of the headlands, where the tide runs slow between the mainland and the near skerries. The hunters of the north-west came here when they left the open water for fear of Uilebheist na Mara², working the lee of the headlands out of its sight; the seal bones thinned in the middens of the open coast and grew here, shell on shell and bone on bone, until the middens of the strait outgrew the old grounds. An old steersman of the strait said at a net-mending that the sea had not grown smaller, only that the island's hand had drawn back from the part of it a man could no longer trust. The camp is kept through the seal season and the autumn fishing, and some households of Ros ruadh winter there now. At the close of the age it is the busiest seal-camp of the north-west, and its boats do not go out past the point. Known for the seal-hunt of the strait, out of Uilebheist na Mara's sight.

Bothan an Fhoghair³ (the skerries off Eilean fhada, on the northern coast). Founded 25 an t-Ògmhios, VE 609. Bothan an Fhoghair, the autumn bothies, is the camp of the north-shore hunters on the landward point of Eilean fhada, opposite the skerries where the grey seals haul out to pup in the autumn gales. Hunters went out in skin boats in that weather, the worst of the year, because the seals are there then and at no other time. Sàire, who went out with her father's crew from her sixteenth year and was master of his boat after his death, kept the camp in her day, and no one on that coast doubted that she read a north-shore sea as well as any man alive on it. The seal bones in the middens of the northern shore bear the same cut-marks as those of the camp. The bothies are low huts of stone and turf, roofed with hide in the season and left bare in the rest of the year. At the close of the age the autumn crossing is still made by some dozen boats, though since the loss of the boats of Ros ruadh the hunters go out only when the gulls are on the water and come home before dusk. Known for the autumn seal-hunt on the skerries.

1. the bothies of the strait; the north-shore seal camp on the strait (place 1010, site of burg 95)

2. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

3. the autumn bothies; the north-shore hunters' camp by the seal skerries off Eilean fhada (place 1002)

Bothan nan Ròn⁴ (Eilean mhin, off the south-east coast). Founded 5 an Dùbhlachd, VE 542. Bothan nan Ròn, the seal bothies, is the camp of the seal-hunters on Eilean mhin. The hunters came to the island by boat, the first on the island known to have crossed open water of set purpose: Oisean, who built his boat of hide over a frame of hazel, and his brothers after him, and then the young men of the neighbouring households, until the crossing in the calm months was a thing the shore simply did. They pitched their bothies of hide and turf on the green above the landing, kept them a season at a time, and left them standing when they went home, to be patched and roofed again the next year. The seals of Eilean mhin haul out on the flat rocks below the camp, and the hunters take them there with clubs and spears. By the close of the age the bothies have been kept every season since Oisean's own, and the ground beneath them is black with the fires of every season. Known for the first crossing of open water on purpose.

Bral⁵ (now Seann Bhral) (the south-eastern coast). Founded 30 an Lùnastal, VE 1,005. The eastern Bral is a landing on the south-eastern coast with a line of fish-kilns above its beach like those of Morn⁶, within a day's rowing along the coast. The woman who minded the middle kiln judged the smoke by its smell at first light and dusk and the fish by the give of the flesh under one finger, and taught both by standing a child at her elbow; a girl of the landing learned to read the smoke well enough to tell a kiln going wrong from the far end of the beach. The kilns were kept alight in relay by the households in the busy weeks, one household taking the night and another the day. When a whale stranded on the beach, the landing gave dried fish to the southern landings for a share of its oil, and the two kept up the giving for a generation. At the close of the age the landing holds some hundred souls, and the smell of its kilns reaches the grazing above the shore in any wind off the sea. Known for its line of fish-kilns in the south-east.

4. the seal bothies; the seasonal seal-hunters' camp on Eilean mhin (place 1001)

5. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

6. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

Bral⁷ (now Seann Bhral) (the far western coast). Founded 5 an Dàmhair, VE 196. Bral sits on the far western coast at the foot of a cliff, where a strip of shingle gives on to the sea and the grazing lies above out of reach. For generations the households went up and down by a scramble no child could climb alone. Then a household set the first slab on the worst of the scramble, and after it cut steps into the rock itself, a few in a season, until the steps reached the first shelf, a third of the way up the cliff. Above the shelf the rock ran harder and gave up fewer slabs, and a worker might spend a season on a stretch that yielded three steps; an old woman used to sit of an evening on the shelf and run her hand along the edge of the topmost step then cut, saying of the rock above only that it would come when it came. It came. The two hundred and twelfth step was cut in her grandchildren's time, and the grazing above was reached by a stair. The lower treads, cut soonest and walked longest, wore a shallow dish into their middles before the upper treads had worn at all. Late in the age a chip of an gual dathach⁸, still staining the shell about it, was thrown on the landing's midden; a household found it and kept it among its trinkets, a bright stone with no use. How it came to the western coast no one there asked. At the close of the age Bral is a landing of some eighty souls, going up and down its stair twice a day with the flocks. Known for the two hundred and twelve steps up the cliff, worn hollow.

Brenn⁹ (now Seann Bhrenn) (the northern coast, west of the Toll¹⁰ dune). Founded 12 an Giblean, VE 321. Brenn lies on the north coast where the rock shelves down into deep water in broad flat steps. Its households laid long ramps of flat stone from the shore into the sea, slab after slab, each one bedded on the one below and relaid where the sea shifted it; one slab was relaid twice before it held. When the first ramp was finished a dog of the household took to lying full length on it on warm days, and the household stepped over the dog on the way down to the water rather than move it. The ramps were wide enough for hulls greater than any hide boat, and on them the households framed the first plank-built hull on the island, launched it down the stone and watched it go out past the last shelf. A sail was seen small from the height above Brenn the next summer and not afterward. More hulls went down the ramps in the lives of their children and grandchildren, and of them nothing is left, nor any telling of where they went; a second ramp was begun beside the first when the first could not serve the work. By the close of the age the ramps stand clean and pale at low water, green-slicked at their feet, and the households use them for their own boats, which are small. Some sixty souls live there, fishing the rock ledges west of the landing. Known for the stone ramps into deep water and the hulls that left them.

7. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

8. the coloured coal

9. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

10. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

Brenn¹¹ (now Seann Bhrenn) (the north-eastern coast). Founded 15 an Lùnastal, VE 23. The second Brenn lies far to the north-east of the first, on a shore of the same shelving rock, and it has the same long ramps of flat stone laid down into deep water. The households of the north-eastern coast began their ramps after those of the northern Brenn had stood a long lifetime, and a third ramp was begun there when two would not serve. Whether the two Brenns were of one people, or only the way of building and the name were carried along the coast from landing to landing, the households themselves could not have said, and did not try. A boy of the landing stood once at the head of the twin ramps on a still evening and watched the water run up the stone and fall back, and asked his mother where the big boats had gone; she told him the sea had them, which was the answer every mother on that coast gave. No hull like those of the first Brenn is remembered to have been built here. At the close of the age the ramps serve small boats and the drying of weed, and some fifty souls live about them, fishing and gathering along the rocks on either hand. The landing lies within a day's rowing of the northern Tàrr¹², and the two keep an eye on one another's smoke. Known for its twin ramps into the sea.

Bruthach nan Teaghlach¹³ (the south-eastern valleys). Founded 27 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,574. Bruthach nan Teaghlach, is the scatter of hill-folk steadings along a long south-facing slope in the valleys of the south-east, above a river that runs down toward the coast of the kilns. The households came there from the high valleys in the lifetimes when the walls of the heights were being raised, herders looking for grazing that did not freeze, and they took the slope for its warmth and its springs. They were half a day's walk from Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹⁴ to the west, and some of their sick were carried there, and a day's walk from the empty platform of the temple in the hills to the north-east, which they did not climb. They keep a gathering of their own on Oidhche an Dealanaich¹⁵, and send one of their elders to Tobar dhìreach in some years to hear the fathers' names said at the mason's hearth. At the close of the age some twenty hearths stand on the slope, and they lay their dead in the ground on the ridge above it, facing the central mountains. Known for its warm south-facing slope and its many hearths.

11. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

12. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

13. the slope of the households; the hill households of the south-eastern valleys (place 1009, site of burg 315)

14. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

15. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

C

Cnoc fhionn (the north-east, in the sheltered hill farms). Founded 25 an t-Samhain, VE 3,715. Cnoc fhionn, the fair hill, is a hearth-kindred of the hill-folk in the north-east, on sheltered ground under a pale hill with deer forest to the south. Its households were hunters as much as herders, and went south in the autumns to the deer-drives of the eastern woods. Dubhghall, who drove the gully alone for the first time as a young man and took the head of the drive when his uncle's knees failed, lived his last years here. His grandson's dog died the year the boy was eleven, and the boy dug it a grave beside the family's own dead and set a shell at its head. An old woman questioned the grave; the boy's grandfather let it stand; and within a few years two more households of the hill had buried their dogs so. When Dubhghall died, his grandson set a shell at his head too, the last of the small store kept since the dog's grave, saying the old man deserved no less than a dog. Beasts had never had graves on the island before. At the close of the age some fifty souls live at Cnoc fhionn, and their burial ground holds more dogs than any other on the island. Known for the first dog graves.

Crannagan Loch chrom¹ (the shallows of Loch chrom). Founded 23 am Faoilleach, VE 1,533. The lake dwellings stand in the shallows of Loch chrom: platforms of split planks on piles of oak driven into the loch floor, joined to the shore by plank walks long enough to keep a household out of reach of anything that walks on four legs. The first platform was driven by a household that had cut the oaks on the shore above and floated them down, and the driving of a pile was work for every hand, the frame raised over the water and the weight dropped on the pile's head until it stood fast. A pile driven and holding was counted an occasion for a shared meal on the nearest platform once the driving-frame was struck down. Eels were first taken from beneath the platforms in baskets let down through the planks, and a child carried the first basket the length of the longest walk. Every morning a child was sent along the walks to listen for the sound of a plank gone thin under its light weight before a grown foot found it the hard way. Who built the platforms, the people of the shell road or some other people of those years, the tellings do not agree, and the households on the platforms do not trouble to settle it. At the close of the age some twelve platforms stand in the shallows, and a new pile is driven most summers. Known for the platforms on oak piles and the plank walks.

1. the lake dwellings of Loch chrom (place 1003; spec name)

Creag Ruadh² (the hill above the eastern shore of Loch chrom). Founded 14 an Dàmhair, VE 3,773. Creag Ruadh is Creag Ruadh above the eastern shore of Loch chrom, a steep hill of reddish rock with a shelf of good ground about its shoulder and springs on its south face. The hill-folk of the lake shore lit their first hearths there some lifetimes on from the raising of the lake dwellings were raised, coming west out of the high valleys with fire carried in a pot from hearth to hearth, and they took the crag for the view it gave of the loch and of anyone coming across the water. They were herders more than fishers, and grazed their beasts on the slopes below the crag and down to the reeds. What passed between them and the people of the platforms, or the households of the shell road on the far shore, no telling of the crag keeps: the crag's households say they watched the smoke of the platforms of an evening, and that was all. By the close of the age some eight or nine hearths stand on the shelf of the crag, lit from Teine a' Chlachair³ as every hearth of the hill-folk is, and their dead are laid in the ground below the red rock, facing the central mountains. Known for its red rock and its view over Loch chrom.

Cwen⁴ (now Seann Chwen) (the southern coast, east of the southern Cwen). Founded 29 an Lùnastal, VE 3,488. The third Cwen is a small landing a short way along the southern coast from the second, on a harbour sheltered by a reef that breaks the swell at half tide. Its households came to it from the southern Cwen in the lifetimes when the holy woods of the east were first set aside by the hill-folk, and they carried the name with them as a household carries its fire, so that the south coast had two Cwens within a morning's rowing of each other. They fished the reef and took shellfish from the pools inside it, and hunted seal on the skerries when the seals came. After the heights were left and the south coast filled with households come down to the shore, this Cwen grew with its neighbour; its landing stones were relaid and lengthened, and a second row of houses raised behind the first. At the close of the age some sixty souls live there. Known for its reef-sheltered landing on the south coast.

2. the red crag; the hearths of the lake-shore line on the red hill above Loch chrom (place 1011, site of burg 19)

3. the mason's fire, the first fire

4. the Old Ones' root (burgs 36, 14, 139)

Cwen⁵ (now Seann Chwen) (the southern coast). Founded 1 am Faoilleach, VE 1,236. The southern Cwen is a small landing on the southern shore, its boats drawn up on flat stones at the head of a sandy cove. For most of the age its midden grew slowly, a household's meals at a time. Then, once the heights were left, whole kin-groups came down from the abandoned rings and the lands about them, and some settled here; the midden began to grow as fast as the mound at the eastern Dunn⁶ had grown when it was young, and in the end outgrew it. A landing once counted by the dozen was counted by the score. The people of the landings raised no new work anywhere out of sight of salt water after that time, and the southern Cwen is the place where the turning is plainest to see. At the close of the age it holds some two hundred souls, more than any landing of the south but its namesake on the gulf, and a new row of houses stands behind the old. Known for the midden that outgrew the eastern Dunn.

Cwen⁷ (now Seann Chwen) (the head of the southern gulf). Founded 19 an Giblean, VE 32. Cwen is the larger of the landings on the southern gulf, a wide bay of quiet water where the fish come in on the tide in shoals. Its households fished with nets of twisted fibre and sank them with beach stones, and it was a net-maker of Cwen who began the long mesh, a net long enough to close across the bay's inner arm, and set it there with the help of every household on the shore. Households came from along the coast to see the closed net. Her weights were notched with three strokes each, cut with a hard stone into the soft beach pebble, so that a weight knew its own net; her daughter learned the groove, spoiled her first stones, and cut the three strokes true before her mother's eyes failed. The daughter took up a way of holding each finished weight a breath longer in the light than the work required, as though the three strokes were worth looking at for their own sake. Every weight of the Cwen nets was notched the same way after, and the three strokes are the eldest mark on the island made again and again of purpose. At the close of the age some hundred and fifty souls live at Cwen, the largest landing of the south coast, and the notched weights lie thick on the floor of the bay where the nets have torn. Known for the net-weights notched with three strokes, the eldest mark on the island.

5. the Old Ones' root (burgs 36, 14, 139)

6. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

7. the Old Ones' root (burgs 36, 14, 139)



Dunn¹ (now Seann Dunn) (the Abhainn chaol, a little above its mouth on the south-eastern coast). Founded 5 an Cèitean, VE 642. This Dunn lies on the Abhainn chaol a little above its mouth, where the river's brown water meets the sea's green, and low cliffs on either hand give nesting to the birds. Its gatherers took eggs from the ledges of those cliffs in the dry months, never so many from one ledge that the birds did not come back to it the next year. It is the northern end of Slighe-mhara àrsaidh², the lane Seann-Dhaoine³ boats kept along the south-east coast in the last lifetimes of the age, from the river mouth below Dunn round the great cape to the bay far to the south. Flat landing-stones were laid along the lane a day's rowing apart, and at Dunn the stones are grooved by keels. A father of the landing taught his son the sea-way stone by stone, naming each landing's look from the water and the look of the sky that meant a boat should lie up there. Rowers on that coast kept a plain word for anyone new to the stretch north of the cape: watch the gulls before you watch the sky. At the close of the age the landing holds some fifty souls and is busier with boats coming and going than its size would suggest. Known for the head of Slighe-mhara àrsaidh and its grooved landing-stones.

Dunn⁴ (now Seann Dunn) (the southern coast). Founded 28 am Faoilleach, VE 601. The southern Dunn is a landing on the southern coast at the head of a beach of fine sand, where the swell runs long and the whales go by in their seasons. A whale stranded below it one autumn, and the households of the whole shore came to cut it and share it out; its oil was kept in bladders and clay pots and burned in stone lamps through two winters at least, and its ribs were driven upright into the ground for the frames of three round houses roofed with turf. The first rib cracked through within a few years, and the houses were raised a second time on the sound bone; a child digging by the wall turned up the buried foot of the first rib and the landing kept it by the door. A third raising stood on bone carried along the shore from a whale cut further west, word of usable ribs travelling faster by then than word of strandings once had. The landing also has a short mole of heaped stone at the western end of the beach, where the boats lie in the worst weather. At the close of the age some ninety souls live there, in houses framed on whale-bone and on timber both. Known for the whale-rib houses.

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

2. the ancient sea-way

3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

4. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

Dunn⁵ (now Seann Dunn) (the eastern coast). Founded 22 an Dùbhlachd, VE 320. The eastern Dunn is where Seann-Dhaoine⁶ first leave a trace that can be followed: the great mound of their meals, limpet shell, seal bone and burnt weed, laid down over many lifetimes at the back of the beach until it stood taller than a man. A woman of the landing kept the heap as her mother had taught her, letting each bag of shell fall where the heap wanted it and working it level with her foot, with the burnt weed laid in thin; the heap's fire was kept through a three-day gale by a gatherer whose mother had died at the tide that same season, and she worked a season at the heap alone. An old scraper turned up in the heap one spring, of a shape no one living made, and the household that found it put it back. In time the heap stood high enough that the households climbed it to watch the sea for boats coming home. No tool in the lowest layers is shaped as any tool the hill-folk used. At the close of the age the heap runs the length of the back of the beach and more than a man's height, and the landing below it holds some sixty souls who gather, fish and hunt seal as their mothers did. Known for the great shell mound, the first sure trace of Seann-Dhaoine.

6

Gleann nan Damh¹ (the eastern woods). Founded 4 am Màrt, VE 3,487. Gleann nan Damh, is the gully of the eastern woods into which the hill-folk of the east drive the red deer every autumn, along lines of stakes and brush set out through the trees, and kill them at the gully's throat with spears. The antlers of the greatest stags are stacked apart from the rest at the gully's mouth, and the stand of them grew higher every year. It was at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar² above the glen that Sadhbh and two others first saw the white stag and none of them drew; afterward the hunters began letting the gully's beasts go when a pale one was among them, rather than risk the wrong one. Dubhghall drove the gully alone for the first time as a young man, threw wide at a young stag in his first year and practised all winter against a bundle of brush, and took the head of the drive when his uncle's knees would no longer hold him through a whole autumn morning; he was exacting in one thing only, that no young man should stand carelessly. At the close of the age the drive is kept every autumn by households from Cnoc fhionn to the edge of the woods. Known for the autumn deer-drive and the stand of antlers.

5. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

6. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

1. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

2. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood



Morn¹ (now Seann Mhorn) (the south-eastern coast). Founded 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 80. Morn lies above a beach on the south-eastern coast, where the catch comes in heavier than the households can eat. Its people built stone-lined pits with short flues above the beach and dried the fish over peat smoke: seven kilns in the end, the first buildings on the island made for a trade and not for sleep or the dead. The fourth pit drowned in a night's rain and was left; the ninth was set higher against the rain; the seventh was the last dug. The keeper of the kilns kept a store of dry peat under an overhang of turf for the kiln fires alone, holding that green peat flares where dry peat smokes and a flare undoes a season's catch, and she taught her niece to watch a kiln past bed on a night of gathering rain. The smoke of the kilns could be seen from inland on a still day. When the heights were left, a household that had lived within the rings came down to Morn, and the keeper of the middle kiln led the son's wife by the wrist to a smouldering kiln and held her hand over its rack until she understood what three tellings in words had not taught her. At the close of the age some sixty souls live there, and the kilns smoke through the summer. Known for the seven fish-kilns, the first buildings made for a trade.

Morn² (now Seann Mhorn) (the southern coast, on the oyster headland). Founded 31 an Cèitean, VE 784. The southern Morn lies on a low headland of the southern coast where the oyster beds are close enough inshore to be raked from the rocks at low water, and it has little else. Its households raked oyster, whelk and cockle and heaped the shells over the whole headland, until the mound stood taller than any household's reach and the houses were built on the shell itself. A worn rake was laid on the mound by the household that had used it longest when its owner died. The raking households found that the oysters of the lowest layers of their mound were broader by half than any taken from the same water in living memory, and did not trouble over why; the beds were raked every summer and never rested. At the close of the age the landing holds some forty souls, and the white of the headland can be seen from far out to sea, whiter than any cliff on that coast. Known for its headland of heaped shell and the great oysters at the bottom of the heap.

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

N

Na Teallaichean Falaichte¹ (the Doire uaine hills). Founded 13 an Giblean, VE 3,151. Na Teallaichean Falaichte, is the hamlet of the herders of the Doire uaine hills, a scatter of steadings in the folds of the hills south of Tobar dhìreach. The hill-folk found the rock faces of those hills cut all over with lines of signs, more than anywhere else on the island; Eimhir, a herder-girl following a strayed ewe up a defile before first light, found the first of them, and the elders judged the writing older than living memory. No one of the hills could read it; the tellings came to agree that it told of something that walked without breathing and fell upon any who lit a fire in its sight, and some lines were cut over and defaced by another hand. Dreams of the same shape came at several hearths, two herders saw a walker on the ridge and lived, and children went less often alone to the far pastures. Laoghaire dug the first pit-hearth, a fire under a slab at the foot of a slanting shaft bent near its foot so that no glow could climb it straight, with the smoke led out through a crack in the turf ten paces off. Other households dug the like, and within a few lifetimes the covered hearth was the hills' law. Eimhir kept her own hearth open to the last. At the close of the age no open fire shows in those hills. Known for the covered pit-hearths.

R

Ros ruadh (the north-western coast). Founded 21 an Dùbhlachd, VE 3,075. Ros ruadh is a harbour of the hill-folk on a red headland of the north-western coast, the furthest west the hearths of the north shore reach before the bare horn. Its households fished and hunted seal on the open water west of the headland, going out in skin boats in the calm months and coming home heavy. A calm summer filled its nets as no summer had, and in that same season seven boats of Ros ruadh went out on calm water and did not come home: the first on a still morning, the second eleven days after from a different stretch of the same sea, and five more before the autumn, with no storm to blame and no wreck-age found. The widows named what had taken them, and Uilebheist na Mara¹ entered the tellings of the shore by name for the first time. In the years after, the headland kept seven empty places on its shingle where seven boats had lain, and no household built on them. The hunters of the north-west afterward left the open water for the lee of the headlands and the strait, and Ros ruadh grew smaller. At the close of the age it is a landing of some thirty households who fish close inshore, keep an eye on the gulls, and do not speak of the water beyond the point after dark. Known for the seven boats lost in one calm season.

1. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

S

Skelll¹ (now Seann Skell) (the northern coast). Founded 19 an t-Samhain, VE 1,833. The northern Skell stands on a wide bay of the north coast, facing the open sea that the island's northern shore takes square on its chin. Its households knew of the great mole on the Abhainn naomh by telling long before any of them had seen it, and when they came to build their own they made it shorter and curved against the swell, since a river's push and the sea's roll are two different weights. Each stone was laid dry against the course already set and worked back and forth until it sat without rocking, and only then bedded; a swell broke over the unfinished mole in its first autumn and moved nothing, which the households took as the sea's own leave to go on. The curved mole was finished in the lifetime of the grandchildren of those who began it. A traveller from this Skell who went the long way round to the western river and stood on the first mole came home saying the two were built the same way, stone by stone without mortar, and that the western one was the longer and the northern the harder to lay. In the years when the heights were left, a household that had lived within the three rings came down to this coast and learned to live by the tide again. At the close of the age the landing is a village of several hundred, its boats in the lee of the curve, and amber from the bay's strands is kept in its houses as a thing pleasant to hold. Known for the curved mole against the open sea.

Skelll² (now Seann Skell) (the north-western horn). Founded 10 an Gearran, VE 1,404. The least of the three Skells sits on the far north-western coast, on bare ground where no tree grows and the gales off the open sea come in unbroken across low heather and bog. Its few households fished the grey water below the horn and lived close to the shore under turf, until one household raised a round tower of dry stone on the rock above the landing, with a hollow wall and a stair wound up inside its thickness. A winter storm threw down the unfinished outer face in the second year of the building, and the household set it up again course by course the next spring, feeling every stone into its bed. The first night anyone slept at the tower's crown was remembered as a night of stars and no wind at all, which on that coast is a rarer thing than a stranded whale. The household walked the stair from foot to crown after every storm, feeling along both faces for a stone gone slack, and one night a fire lit on the parapet turned a boat from the rocks below. The tower looks out over the water where Uilebheist na Mara³ was afterwards seen, and by the close of the age the households of the horn keep their boats out of that water as the hill-folk of the same coast do, each for their own reasons, neither knowing the other's. The landing holds a few dozen souls, the tower and some turf houses in its lee; nothing has ever grown taller than the tower there. Known for the hollow-walled round tower over the north-western water.

1. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it
2. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it
3. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

Skell⁴ (now Seann Skell) (the Abhainn naomh, above its mouth on the western coast). Founded 6 an Gearran, VE 173. The greatest landing of Seann-Dhaoine⁵ lies a short way up the Abhainn naomh from the western sea, where the river runs broad and brown past a low bank of gravel and the tide pushes up against the current twice a day. Boats lay there long before the mole, pulled up on the gravel and dragged higher at every flood. The mole was begun by an old man who chose each boulder by its weight in his hands and set it with his grandsons standing in the river to their chests against the push of the water; it was laid out from the bank without mortar, stone set against stone, and in its first winter it held against a flood that took boats from every other stretch of that bank. After that the households of the river asked for the same lee and built beside it, and the landing grew on the mole's shelter as a village grows on a spring. By the time Seann-Dhaoine held every coast of the island, Skell was the one place among them that a stranger would have called crowded: some three hundred souls at the height, every mooring behind the mole taken, smoke from forty hearths lying along the river on a still evening. A woman of the landing walked the mole's length each evening at the turn of the tide, looking for any stone the current had worked loose, and the stones she reset were set the old way. When the heights were left and the households that had gone up to the rings came down, some came here, and one grandfather of the landing never once spoke of what he had seen up there. At the close of the age the mole stands whole, its foot under water at the lowest tides, and the landing keeps to the river as it always kept. Known for the mole of unmortared boulders, the eldest work on the Abhainn naomh.

T

Tarr¹ (now Seann Tarr) (the eastern coast, under the cut cliff). Founded 25 an Giblean, VE 1,212. The eastern Tarr is a landing under a high cliff of fine grey rock on the eastern coast, and it is the place where the script was first cut. A man of the landing began rows of signs on the standing rock above the shingle with a flint chisel, each sign some two hundred light blows of the hammer, and worked at them a long life; a boy of the landing watched an afternoon of the cutting once and was sent off before he had seen a whole sign made. After the careful cutter, others cut more rows beside and above his, and an old row was cut over and broken by a later hand with the same kind of tool, for what reason the landing never gave. The first row cut on the cliff runs straight and even, and the rows above it less so. The signs are not the speech of the hill-folk, and none of the hill-folk could have read them; the landing's own people say only that the cliff has been cut. A woman of the midland Toll² walked the coast once as far as this cliff and found the rows, and went home with nothing to tell but that they were there. At the close of the age some seventy souls live at the landing, fishing the eastern water, and the rows stand pale on the grey rock over their roofs. Known for the rows of signs cut on the cliff, the first of the script.

4. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

5. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

Tarr³ (now Seann Tarr) (the north-eastern headlands). Founded 30 an Cèitean, VE 884. At the Tarr of the north-eastern headlands a household built a single long house into a cleft of the cliff, with the living rock for its back wall and a roof of turf and driftwood across the cleft's mouth. The hearth stood against the rock, and the rock above it blackened year on year to the height of a man. A child of the house stood with her back to the soot-stain each midwinter to see how far up it her crown reached, until the year she stood as tall as the stain. The house was built for the wind and it kept the wind out: in the hard winter that the whole north-east remembered, when the sea froze in the rock pools and no boat put out from that stretch the whole season, the household lived on what it had put by and came out on the calm morning after with every soul alive. In the darkest months, when the cliff kept the sun from the doorway, a second small fire was kept lit just inside the door, more for its light than its warmth. At the close of the age some thirty souls live in and about the long house and the huts below it, and the stain behind the hearth reaches higher than any of them. Known for the long house built into the cliff, black with soot behind the hearth.

Tarr⁴ (now Seann Tarr) (the north-eastern coast, below the headlands). Founded 17 an Lùnastal, VE 4,706. The lesser Tarr of the north-east is one of the last landings Seann-Dhaoine⁵ made, laid down once the heights were left, when every new work of theirs was made within sight of salt water. It lies on a small inlet below the headlands, a short row along the coast from the older Tarr, and it was settled by households that had outgrown the cleft-house and its huts. Its landing stones are flat slabs set into the shingle at the water's edge, bedded the way the stones of Slighe-mhara àr-saidh⁶ in the south-east are bedded, so that a laden boat may be drawn up on them without grinding its hide on the stones beneath. The households fish, gather weed, and trade dried fish along the coast to the older Tarr for what the cliff's shelter can give. At the close of the age it is a landing of a dozen households, young beside its neighbours, and its people still call it by the same root as the landing up the coast, as though the one name were enough for both. Known for its landing stones, among the last of Seann-Dhaoine' works.

3. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

4. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

5. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

6. the ancient sea-way

Teallaichean a' Chladaich⁷ (the southern shore, below the southern hills). Founded 23 an t-Sultain, VE 4,983. Teallaichean a' Chladaich, are the households of the hill-folk on the southern shore, a string of steadings on the slope above the beach, with barley in the small fields and boats on the shingle. They were lit from Teine a' Chlachair⁸ like every hearth of the hill-folk, carried south over the mountains in a pot. It was from here that a party of eleven, with Cairbre at their head, went up into the southern hills in the crossing season, the harvest inland having failed and the geese of the coast not yet gone over in their numbers, reading the season as a slow one. They did not come home. Cairbre's wife kept the twelfth day on the rise above the steadings, and the fourteenth and the twentieth, and by the thirtieth had stopped telling herself anything, and only watched. Their bones were found years afterward along the line the cats use, and were buried where they were found. At the close of the age the households of the shore keep the crossing season as strictly as any in the passes, and cut their gateposts deep. Known for the eleven who went up in the crossing season.

Tobar dhìreach (the high valleys, on the north side of the central mountains). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, VE 42. Tobar dhìreach, the straight well, is the hearth of Clann a' Chlachair⁹ and the place where fire came to the hill-folk. The well it is named for runs along a straight channel cut in the rock, and the old telling says it was on this ground, in the dead of a winter, that Neachdan the mason set his wedge in a seam he had not seen and broke into a vein of hard coal that showed every colour in the break; that the lightning struck the broken vein that night and it took fire; and that he carried a burning piece home, and his household sat by the first fire any of them had seen. From that hearth the fire was begged and given, carried in a clay pot banked with ash to the near hearths and then to the far ones, until there was no hearth of the hill-folk that was not lit from it, by one borrowing or another. The vein burned in its cut through the lives of the mason's son and grandson and beyond, watched through the dark half of every year from two flat stones above it. When it burned out, Muirne of the line would not let it be dug further: a flat slab was laid over the broken vein, no water was drawn beside it, and the well was cut again a stone's throw off. The black well and the young well, in the valleys on either side, each tell that the mason's well was theirs; Tobar dhìreach can show the capped shaft with a scorched stain on its lip, and the other two have only the telling. No house stands beside Leac na Fèithe¹⁰. The household keeps two things for the line: Poit an Teine¹¹, the clay pot said to hold the mason's first fire, kept alight by the women of the line from mother to daughter and aunt to niece; and a leather bag of coloured pieces broken from the vein before it was covered, with fresh pieces taken in each lifetime from where the vein shows in a stream bank above the well. Here Diarmad asked why the coal had colours,

7. the hearths of the shore; the southern-shore households from which the eleven went up (place 1006)

8. the mason's fire, the first fire

9. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

10. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

11. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

and came home from the grove with Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹² and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹³; here the fathers' names are said standing on Oidhche an Dealanaich¹⁴, and the lightings of the coals are told as they come: gold on the sea, the snowflake in the air, the black coal in the ground by Leac na Fèithe, the red-brown in blood, the silver in the river below the house, gual teine¹⁵ on the doorstone in Seathan's fingers. From the lifetime of Colla the line is called Clann na Ceiste¹⁶ by the valleys. At the close of the age some ninety souls live at Tobar dhìreach, and Ailean son of Suibhne has gone north to the grove with six fires on a pole, leaving Liobhan and the child Gormshuil to keep the house fire until he comes home. Known for Teine a' Chlachair¹⁷, Leac na Fèithe over the burnt vein, and the bag of na Seachd Guail¹⁸.

Toll¹⁹ (now Seann Toll) (the Abhainn uaine, in the midlands). Founded 8 an Gearran, VE 92. The midland Toll is a landing of Seann-Dhaoine²⁰ inland, on the Abhainn uaine, where a shelf of rock runs out into the river and the water pools behind it. Its households cut a channel through the shelf into a pool beside the river, with slots at the channel's mouth for a wattle gate; when the river fell the gate was dropped and the pool emptied by hand, and the fish left stranded in it were taken with baskets. A boy of the landing lost two fingers to the mallet in the cutting of the slots. A child of the landing learned the floor of the channel by her feet at low water, which stretch stood firm and which gave, long before she had a word for it. In a summer when the river fell low and stayed low the gate was dropped three times before the autumn rains, and the households reckoned the late summer by the droppings. A woman of Toll walked the coast once as far as the cut cliff at Tarr²¹, and came home saying the signs were there and no more. At the close of the age some sixty souls live at the landing, one of the two landings of Seann-Dhaoine a day's walk from salt water that were not left when the heights were, since their rivers run to the sea. Known for the fish-channel and the gate-slot cut in the rock.

12. the Telling of the Making

13. the Keeper's riddle

14. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

15. the fire coal, of fire

16. the Children of the Question

17. the mason's fire, the first fire

18. the Seven Coals

19. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

20. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

21. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

Toll²² (now Seann Toll) (the northern coast, under the dune). Founded 8 an t-Samhain, VE 1,033. The northern Toll takes its name from the sea-caves under its headland, where the water booms at the turn of the tide. Its households raised a cluster of stone huts in the lee of a great dune, which kept the wind off them for a lifetime. Then a wind rose off the sea that did not settle for three days, and the household left the huts with what they could carry; when the wind fell the dune stood forward the whole width of the huts and beyond, a slope of new pale sand over ground where doors had opened two days before. No one dug for the huts. New walls were raised inland of the buried row within the season, and the sand has kept the old huts whole ever since, hearths, doors and all. The households of the new walls keep a strict eye on the dune's face and plant marram on its brow, and children are told early not to dig in it. At the close of the age Toll is a fishing landing of some fifty souls, living inland of the sand, with the caves below the headland for shelter from the worst weather and for the drying of nets. Known for the huts the dune buried whole.

Toll²³ (now Seann Toll) (the north-eastern coast, in a cleft of the rock). Founded 19 an Giblean, VE 2,319. The north-eastern Toll is a harbour in a cleft of the rock, a narrow inlet between two walls of stone where the sea runs in quiet even when the open water beyond is white. Its households found the cleft in the generations when the rings and Làrach an Dùin-fhaire²⁴ were still lived in, and made it a landing by cutting the lowest shelf of the rock level with the water, dressing it flat with stone tools over many summers until a boat could lie alongside it and be unloaded dry-shod. The cutting of that shelf is the work the landing is known for, and it is cut in a manner of its own, the face of the rock taken down in long straight strokes. The households are few, fishing the rocks at the cleft's mouth and hunting seal in the season on the skerries to the south. Word of the northern Toll's buried huts came to them along the coast, and they built nothing in the lee of any sand. At the close of the age the landing holds a few households, perhaps forty souls, and its quay is the plainest and most lasting thing on that coast. Known for its quay cut level in the living rock.

22. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

23. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

24. the watch-fort ruin

V

Vell¹ (now Seann Vell) (the western coast, among the dunes). Founded 16 an Dàmhair, VE 1,197. The western Vell is a small landing on a coast of dunes and wide sand, where the fishing is good in autumn and poor in the late winter. Its households learned to put the autumn by for the lean months. A woman of the landing dug the first pit in the dune's flank, lined it with clay carried from a bank upstream and lidded it with a slab, and stored dried fish in it through a winter; the fish came out sound. She set her later pits a full body's length apart, holding that a pit dug too near another drew damp, and the households after her kept the spacing without asking why. A younger household once cut the lining clay out of turn and spoiled a season's store, and the landing kept the turns strictly after. The pits run in a line along the dune now, dozens of them, and some that were forgotten when a household died out still hold fish bones under their slabs. Late in the age the doors of the landing were turned from the sea toward the dune, for the wind. At the close of the age some forty souls live there on fish and the store-pits. Known for the clay-lined store-pits in the dune.

Vell² (now Seann Vell) (the Abhainn fhionn, above the lake country). Founded 1 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,673. The inland Vell is a landing on a river of the midlands, reached by Seann-Dhaoine³ boats poling up from the coast. Its households came to it in the lifetimes when the holy woods of the east were first let alone, settling on a shelf of gravel where the river runs slow and the eels are thick, and raised a few round houses there in the manner of the coast. They lived on eels and on what the river brought, and kept their boats on the gravel. When the heights were left and every new work of Seann-Dhaoine was made by salt water, the inland Vell was not abandoned, since the river runs to the sea and the landing's boats go down it every season; but it did not grow, and its young people went down to the coast. At the close of the age it holds a few households only, some twenty souls. Known for its gravel landing on the river.

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1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)
 2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)
 3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

Vell⁴ (now Seann Vell) (the south-eastern coast, opposite Eilean dhearg). Founded 4 an t-Ògmhios, VE 396. The eastern Vell lies on the south-eastern coast facing Eilean dhearg across a short sound. Its households built round houses of dry stone, each with a hearth sunk in the middle of the floor and, beneath that, a drain running out under the wall; the first house was raised on a knoll above the landing, and the first drain cut beneath a wall came after the floor had stood wet through a winter. Households whose houses were built without a drain took up their floors in a dry season and cut the channel in under walls already standing, having watched their neighbours' floors stand drier. Fourteen houses were finished in the end. The dead of the Vell were rowed across the sound to Eilean dhearg and laid in stone boxes facing the mainland, and no box was left standing open through a night: an unfinished one was covered with brush and stone until its lid could be rowed across. Forty boxes are counted on the island. At the close of the age some hundred souls live in the house-rings, and the boats that carry the dead still go out from the same stone. Known for its round houses with sunk hearths and drains, and its dead on Eilean dhearg.

Vell⁵ (now Seann Vell) (the Abhainn bheag, above its mouth in the north-east). Founded 1 an Gearran, VE 1,698. This Vell stands a short way above the mouth of the Abhainn bheag in the north-east, where the ground slopes steeply to the water and each household had to cut its own level ground into the slope before it could raise a wall. Four houses were raised there and a boat-shed, and the households built a flat-bottomed hull for the river that could be poled up the shallows where a sea-boat would ground. A spring flood once reached the boat-shed and lifted the hull off its blocks, and the households hauled it back with ropes and raised the shed a step higher up the slope. The river gave the landing what the open sea further along the coast could not always give: eels in their seasons, trout, and water that never failed. The eel-trap pattern was known only in one pair of hands until an old man taught it to two children at once, lest one bad season lose it to the whole landing. A girl grown up at the Vell stood at the river's mouth one evening looking at the open sea and went no further, holding that a river's own child had no business beyond its mouth. No dwelling of Seann-Dhaoine⁶ on the main island is known further to the north-east. At the close of the age some thirty souls live there. Known for its four houses and boat-shed, the furthest north-east of Seann-Dhaoine' landings.

4. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

5. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

6. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

W

Warr¹ (now Seann Warr) (the southern shore of the gulf). Founded 15 an Gearran, VE 2,245. The eastern Warr is a small landing on the southern shore of the gulf, across the water from the eastern Bral² and in sight of its kiln smoke. Its households were fishers and weed-gatherers who came to it from the west of the gulf in the lifetimes when the long house was built into the cliff at the north-eastern Tarr³, and they carried with them the name of the shell-road landing on Loch chrom, though no road was ever made here. They fish the quiet water inside the gulf and dry their catch on racks rather than in kilns, and trade what they dry across the water. At the close of the age it is a landing of some thirty souls, content with the gulf's shelter, whose boats go out in weather that keeps the open-sea landings ashore. Known for its sheltered landing on the gulf.

Warr⁴ (now Seann Warr) (the western shore of Loch chrom). Founded 27 am Màrt, VE 725. Warr lies on the western shore of Loch chrom, behind a broad marsh of reeds that stood between the dry ground and the open water. Its households fished the loch and gathered mussels in the shallows, and crossed the marsh on a track of trodden reed that sank a little every year. A household first carried shell out onto the sunken track and found that it held a foot where reed would not; within a generation the carrying of shell was yearly work for every household, and the shell was crushed underfoot on a flat stone by the water before it was carried out, since crushed shell packs and whole shell slides. A flood of the reed-marsh in a wet year drowned the road's middle length and the households raised it again a forearm above the reeds. The road runs a little over a mile, white in the sun, from the dry ground to the water's edge, and a girl of the landing was the first to run its whole length at once without stopping. A family of the northern shore came once to see it, having heard of a road made of shells, and went home saying it was so. The road is kept as a household keeps a hearth: a stranger's foot on another household's stretch is not a thing lightly done. At the close of the age the landing holds some seventy souls. Known for the shell road across the reed marsh.

1. the Old Ones' root (burgs 64, 128)

2. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

3. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

4. the Old Ones' root (burgs 64, 128)

PART FOUR

The Appendices

APPENDIX A

Sloinneadh a' Chlachair

The only roll this age kept was a roll of names said aloud. Sloinneadh a' Chlachair¹ is the pedigree of the mason's line from An Clachair² himself down to the father then living, said standing at the hearth of Tobar dhìreach on Oidhche an Dealanaich³, the dark of the year when the vein first took fire. Diarmad fixed its form in the years after he came home from the grove, gathering the names from old women who had kept four and five fathers back without being asked, and from then on it was said the same way every winter, with nothing added but the name of each father as he died and the line for each coal as it answered. This appendix gives what the line let strangers hear, the named fathers with their deeds, and the women who kept Poit an Teine⁴. The years beside each name are the years of the annals of this volume; no one living in the age counted them so, and Appendix C tells how they did count.

The rule of the recital

The recital is said standing, by the father who holds the bag, or by one he chooses when he cannot stand. It opens with the mason and closes with the father living. Between the two it gives every father's name, but to strangers the line gives only the named fathers, each with his deed, and says of the rest only how many stood between: *and so many fathers whose names we keep*. The counts between are said as numbers and the names are kept. After the Line comes the telling of the coals, one line for each lighting as it came, and after that Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁵, said once in the old words and once in plain speech, and left unanswered. In Gormal's day the recital was softened, at her daughter Siomha's asking, so that a small child might leave the fire when the fathers' names were done instead of being held through Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich; the full recital was kept for the grown. In the lifetimes of the gatherings

1. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

2. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

3. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

4. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

5. the Keeper's riddle

at the column, the recital came to be said there too, slowly, with a pause after each named father long enough for the name to be passed back through the crowd.

The short form

This is the Line as it was given to strangers at the close of the age, in plain speech:

Neachdan the mason, who broke the vein and carried the fire home; Conall his son, who kept the vein burning. Thirty-four fathers whose names we keep. Diarmad, who asked, and heard Aithris a' Chruthachaidh in the grove. Eighteen fathers whose names we keep. Aodh, who gave the seven to the sea, and the gold burned. Thirty-one fathers whose names we keep. Fearghas, who let the six fall from the height, and the snowflake burned in the air. Twenty-eight fathers whose names we keep. Brian, who gave the five to the ground, and the black coal was warm. Thirty fathers whose names we keep. Cormac of the Misstrike, whose blood lit the red-brown. Twenty-one fathers whose names we keep. Eòghann, who tasted the river, and the silver burned under the water. Fifteen fathers whose names we keep. Colla, in whose days we were called Clann na Ceiste. Ten fathers whose names we keep. Seathan, who snapped his fingers, and the fire came. Fifteen fathers whose names we keep. Suibhne, who carried the rainbow to the grove. Ailean his son, who lives.

The named fathers

Neachdan, An Clachair⁶ (died VE 38). A mason of the high valleys north of the central mountains, splitting rock for a well in the dead of a winter when the old spring had failed. His wedge went into a seam he had not seen and the rock broke open on a vein of hard coal that showed every colour in the break. The lightning struck the broken vein that night and it took fire, and he carried a burning piece home in his hands wrapped in a sodden hide. His wife Sorcha was the first to be burned by a hearth and the first to feed one heather. He died in the thirty-eighth winter after the lightning, an old man for that age, and is the first of the dead buried within sight of the vein.

Conall mac Neachdain (died VE 71). The mason's son, eleven when he ran barefoot through the rain with his mother's water-pot to bring fire home from the vein to the dead hearth. He kept the winter watch at the burning vein from two flat stones above it for most of his life, and gave fire to any hearth that sent for it. His sister Ailbhe

6. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

carried it to the hearths further off. He is the last father named before the long count of kept names.

Diarmad (VE 862–931), the thirty-sixth father. A boy who would not stop asking why the pieces in the bag held colours, and a young man who went north three days alone to the oak grove at Doire ghlas with gual bogha-froise⁷ and asked Coimhdeach na Fine⁸, which came to his fire out of the smoke of the gale. He came home with Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁹ and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹⁰, and fixed the recital: the Line said standing, then Aithris a' Chruthachaidh, then Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich. He died in his seventieth year at Tobar dhìreach. His wife Niamh said Aithris a' Chruthachaidh at his hearth before she believed it; his daughter Deirbhile kept it word for word and taught it.

Aodh (VE 1,344–1,412), the fifty-fourth father. At Muirgheal's bidding he carried all seven coals down to the northern shore, slept a night above the tideline, and threw them into the sea one by one. Gual òir took fire on the water and burned gold until the sea put it under, and a new line was added to the recital for the first time since the mason. He brought the other six home and tried them against everything in reach for the rest of his life. In his last years he first took fresh pieces of the vein from where it shows in a stream bank above the well.

Fearghas (VE 2,138–2,199), the eighty-sixth father. With his brother Mathan he walked the ridges south for two summers until there was no taller hill behind the one they stood on, and on the summit of Binnean a' Chlachair¹¹ he let the six unlit coals fall one by one. Gual sneachda took fire as it fell and burned white; they left it burning where it lay. Mathan set the first stone of the summit cairn. Fearghas died at sixty-one.

Brian (VE 2,858–2,921), the hundred and fifteenth father. The grave-digger of the high valleys, who dug through frozen ground for other households' dead without cursing it. The old widow Sireadh, who had kept the bag sixty years, gave him the five dark coals, and he buried them deep beside Leac na Fèithe¹² with the words said over every grave in the valleys. When he dug them up the next day the black coal was warm in his hand and smouldered as the air reached it. He kept it burning at his own hearth and taught the grave-digger's trade to younger men, and died at sixty-three. The black coal burned at his burial. His wife was Caoimhe.

Cormac of the Misstrike (VE 3,640–3,712), the hundred and forty-sixth father. The keeping fell to him at fifteen when both his elder brothers died in one season. He

7. the rainbow coal, of spirit

8. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

9. the Telling of the Making

10. the Keeper's riddle

11. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

12. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

carried the four unlit coals to the grove at Doire ghlas to break them there, reasoning that the grove might hold some leaving that would answer; on the last morning of a month under the oaks the maul turned on the red-brown coal and opened the back of his hand, and where his blood fell on it the coal took fire. He came home with his hand bound and held it up at the next recital. His wife was Aoibheann. He died at seventy-two at his own hearth.

Eòghann (VE 4,196–4,262), the hundred and sixty-eighth father. A younger son who came to the keeping at twenty when his sister and father died in one season. He carried gual airgid¹³ to river after river, and one evening, kneeling to drink at the crossing below Tobar dhìreach, said that the water tasted different from the sea water, and threw in the three unlit coals. The silver caught under the current and burned there, a low pale light any traveller could kneel and see; the two dark coals were found again on a gravel bar downstream. His wife was Dearbhail, of the lake-shore line. He died at sixty-six.

Colla (VE 4,590–4,655), the hundred and eighty-fourth father. He held the bag when the valleys, half in jest, began to call the line by a long name for its long questioning of the two dark coals, and he gave the long name back to a traveller without the laughter, and the short form, Clann na Ceiste¹⁴, with it. It stuck. He died at sixty-five, and the old name Clann a' Chlachair¹⁵ was heard for the last time as the line's own name within a generation of him.

Seathan (VE 4,862–4,934), the hundred and ninety-fifth father. He took the bag at twenty and kept it more than fifty years, and handled gual teine¹⁶ every day of them, and put it at last into the pot itself. On a doorstone at the age of forty-three he snapped his fingers when a thought struck him, and the coal-dust on his hand took fire; he beat it out against his coat and was not burned, and laughed until Caitir his wife came to the door with her hands floury from the baking. With her he tried the rainbow at the sea and the river. The bag passed to his eldest son. He died at seventy-two.

Suibhne (VE 5,272–5,318), the two hundred and eleventh father. He learned the Line standing as a boy and tried the rainbow by the sea, the height, the river and the earth, but would not try it by blood. In his forty-fourth year he walked the three days north to Doire ghlas with it and sat a night by his own small fire in the grove; nothing answered. He said at the next recital that he doubted the rainbow would answer him, and died of a fever two years later, at forty-six.

13. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

14. the Children of the Question

15. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

16. the fire coal, of fire

Ailean mac Shuibhne (born VE 5,300), the two hundred and twelfth father, living at the close of the age. A big young man, slow of speech and broad of hand, who sat by Poit an Teine¹⁷ for whole mornings as a child. He married Liobhan at seventeen. At twenty-three he told the recital he meant to light the six again, each by its own way, and over the better part of a year he did it: the black coal in the earth, the gold out of the sea where Aodh let it burn, the snowflake on the height, the red-brown with his own blood, the silver in the Abhainn ghorm, gual teine on his own doorstep. In the last week of an t-Iuchar, at twenty-four, he set out north with six fires in six clay pots slung on a pole, and on the evening of the twenty-first day, in the grove at Doire ghlas, Coimhdeach na Fine came and lit the rainbow, and all seven burned together. Liobhan and their daughter Gormshuil, then six, were at Tobar dhireach.

The women of the pot

Poit an Teine¹⁸, the clay pot said to hold the mason's first fire, was never in the keeping of the father who held the bag. It passed among the women of the line, most often from a woman to her brother's daughter or her sister's, to whoever of the household had the steadiest hands with a live coal and the patience to rise in the night. The recital does not name them; the tellings of the hearth name some.

- **Ailbhe nic Neachdain** (VE 3–82), the mason's daughter, first child born by a hearth, who walked the fire in its pot to more hearths than anyone counted.
- **Muirne** (VE 112–181), who kept the watch of the vein when it burned low, would not let it be dug further, and bade them lay Leac na Fèithe¹⁹.
- **Fionnghuala** (VE 838–897), Diarmad's mother, who took the pot from the old aunt the household called only the aunt.
- **Deirbhile nic Dhiarmaid** (VE 894–968), who kept Aithris a' Chruthachaidh²⁰ word for word and made every child of the line say it back to her a section at a time.
- **Muirgheal** (VE 1,290–1,381), who bade Aodh take all seven to the sea and wept at the telling of the gold.
- **Gormal** (VE 1,930–2,004), who kept the pot and the recital in the lean years when a branch of the line went away from the vein, and added her own words at her last recital.

17. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

18. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason's line keeps what it holds to be the mason's first fire

19. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhireach

20. the Telling of the Making

- **Siomha** (VE 1,958–2,030), Gormal's daughter, who softened the recital for the children.
- **Sireadh** (VE 2,825–2,895), who kept the bag sixty years as a widow and gave Brian the five dark coals.
- **Mòrnait** (VE 4,785–4,850), of Clann na Ceiste²¹ though not of the narrow line, who kept fire at the ring about Colbh Cnoc chiar²².
- **Caitir** (VE 4,868–4,940), Seathan's wife, the only keeper's wife remembered to have gone with the rainbow to the sea and not stayed by the pot.
- **Lìobhan** (born VE 5,302), Ailean's wife, who named what the rainbow wanted, and kept the house fire while he went north.

The count of fathers at a glance

FATHER	PLACE IN THE LINE	YEARS (AN- NALS)	AGE AT DEATH	COAL
Neachdan, An Clachair	1st	died VE 38	an old man	the vein takes fire
Conall	2nd	died VE 71	an old man	
Diarmad	36th	VE 862–931	69	Aithris a' Chruithachaidh and Tòimh-seachan a' Choimhdich
Aodh	54th	VE 1,344–1,412	68	gual òir, of the sea
Fearghas	86th	VE 2,138–2,199	61	gual sneachda, of the air
Brian	115th	VE 2,858–2,921	63	gual dubh, of the earth
Cormac	146th	VE 3,640–3,712	72	gual donn-ruadh, of life
Eòghann	168th	VE 4,196–4,262	66	gual airgid, of the river
Colla	184th	VE 4,590–4,655	65	the name Clann na Ceiste
Seathan	195th	VE 4,862–4,934	72	gual teine, of fire
Suibhne	211th	VE 5,272–5,318	46	

21. the Children of the Question

22. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

FATHER	PLACE IN THE LINE	YEARS (ANNALS)	AGE AT DEATH	COAL
Ailean mac Shuibhne	212th	born VE 5,300	living, 24	gual bogha-froise, lit by Coimhdeach na Fine

APPENDIX B

The Telling, the Riddle and the Lightings

Three things were said at the hearth of Tobar dhìreach on Oidhche an Dealanaich¹, and the whole faith of the high valleys in this age grew out of them: the Line of the fathers (Appendix A), Aithris a' Chruthachaidh², and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich³. To these the line added, one at a time over more than four thousand years, a line for each coal as it answered. This appendix tells how Aithris a' Chruthachaidh was kept, gives Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich, sets out the lightings in order, and describes the other reverences of the hearths, which were kept by households that had never heard Aithris a' Chruthachaidh whole. It ends with what is not known of the holy things of Seann-Dhaoine⁴.

How the Telling was kept

Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁵ came to the island in one night. Coimhdeach na Fine⁶ gave it whole to Diarmad in the oak grove at Doire ghlas, in the gale, sitting by his fire under a fallen trunk: the gods and their line, each god making a world of what was dearest to him; Caoran an Dia Òg⁷, youngest son of an Dagda⁸ and Danu, who chose coal; the making of the stars and the sun and the moon out of its sparks and ash, and last of all the island, born out of the sea from drops of fire; An Dia-shluagh grown up out of the heather; Na Seachd Guail laid under the mountains, each colour locked with its own key; the Tuath Dè who came down to see the island, and what each of them loves; Coimhdeach na Fine itself, the smoke of the first coal given a mind and a charge; and

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1. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing
 2. the Telling of the Making
 3. the Keeper's riddle
 4. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich
 5. the Telling of the Making
 6. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'
 7. the Young God, Caoran
 8. the Good God, father of the gods

the forgetting of the coal by an Dia-shluagh⁹, who threw the coloured stones away as the mountain's droppings.

Diarmad walked home saying 'Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹⁰ over and over to keep it; Aithris a' Chruthachaidh he carried home in his head unspoken, and it took him most of a winter to lay it out at the hearth in the order Coimhdeach na Fine had given it. His wife Niamh said it after him at the first standing of the Line, though she did not yet believe it. His daughter Deirbhile learned it from him word for word and made each of her own children say it back to her a section at a time until they had it as clean as she did, and taught it so to any of the kin who would sit still for the whole. From her the line has it. It is said sitting, unlike the Line, and it is said by whoever of the household says it best. A trader who had heard it once told it back to Diarmad, some years after, with the sea and the sky changed places and the earth dropped out; the line took this as a warning, and never let Aithris a' Chruthachaidh be said at the hearth in any words but the kept ones.

Outside the line Aithris a' Chruthachaidh went out in pieces. Every hearth of the high valleys knew by the close of the age that the island was born of fire from a young god's hand, and that the colours in the coal were his gift, locked; fewer knew the names of the Tuath Dè in their order; hardly any outside Tobar dhìreach could have said the whole. At the gatherings at the column, from Seathan's time, the line's reciter said Aithris a' Chruthachaidh to crowds of some hundreds, and many heard it whole there for the first time.

The riddle

Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich¹¹ was given last, after Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹², when Diarmad asked whether an Dia Òg¹³ had been angry at the forgetting. Coimhdeach na Fine¹⁴ answered that he was not, and gave 'Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich, and would give nothing more:

Tha spiorad fa leth san speur, san talamh agus sa mhuir. Meascaich na spioradan agus bidh iad uile-chumbachdach. The sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit. Merge the spirits, and they become almighty.

9. the godfolk; lit. 'the god-host'

10. the Keeper's riddle

11. the Keeper's riddle

12. the Telling of the Making

13. the Young God, Caoran

14. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

The line said it at every recital after Aithris a' Chruthachaidh, once in the old words and once in plain speech, and left it unanswered. For eighteen fathers after Diarmad they tried the coals against the three things Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich names as they understood them: held to the sky, pressed into the earth, dropped into sea water carried home in skins; in the hearth, in the rain, all seven together. Nothing answered. What no one of the line understood until Aodh was that each coal wanted its own element in the element's own body, the whole sea and not a skin of it, and that each lighting would be a step of that kind: the coal taken to what it holds. Even then Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich's last line stayed shut. Liobhan, Ailean's wife, is remembered as the one who first said at the hearth what the rainbow wanted: the other six, burning, together.

The lightings

Each lighting added a line to the recital. A coal once lit burned until it burned out, and the line relit from the bag, which held pieces of every colour broken from the vein before it was covered and, from Aodh's time, fresh pieces taken from where the vein shows in a stream bank above the well, a handful a life.

COAL	HOLDS	LIT BY	WHERE	HOW	ANNALS
the vein	fire of the lightning	the storm	the mason's well, Tobar dhìreach	lightning on the broken vein	VE 1
gual òir, the gold	the sea	Aodh	the northern shore	thrown into the sea; burned gold on the water	VE 1,370
gual sneachda, the snowflake	the air	Fearghas	Binnean a' Chlachair	let fall from the summit; took fire falling and burned white	VE 2,170
gual dubh, the black	the earth	Brian	beside Leac na Fèithe, Tobar dhìreach	buried a night deep in the ground; warm when dug up	VE 2,885
gual donn-ruadh, the red-brown	life	Cormac	the grove at Doire ghlas	the maul turned; his blood fell on it	VE 3,670
gual airgid, the silver	river water	Eòghann	the Abhainn ghorm below Tobar dhìreach	thrown into the river; burned under the current	VE 4,225
gual teine, the fire	fire	Seathan	his own doorstone, Tobar dhìreach	the dust on his fingers caught at a snap	VE 4,905

COAL	HOLDS	LIT BY	WHERE	HOW	AN- NALS
gual bogha- froise, the rain- bow	spirit	Coimhdeach na Fine	the grove at Doire ghlas	the six burning in a ring about it	VE 5,324

Ailean relit the six over the better part of his twenty-fourth year, each by its own way: the black coal in the earth by Leac na Fèithe¹⁵; the gold where Aodh let it burn, wading after it and catching it still burning between his cupped hands; the snowflake on the height; the red-brown with his own blood; the silver in the Abhainn ghorm; Gual teine on his own doorstone. Six fires stood in six clay pots under one roof at Tobar dhireach through the last weeks of summer, and on the twenty-first day of an t-Iuchar they stood in a ring under the oaks.

The bag and the pot

Two things were kept at Tobar dhireach for the whole line. Poit an Teine¹⁶, is a squat clay pot with a turf lid, said to hold the mason’s first fire; it has been remade more than once as clay pots crack, and each time the fire was moved from the old pot to the new before the old was broken up, so that the fire in it has never been let go dark. It stood by the hearth and was kept by the women of the line (Appendix A). The bag is a pouch of greased leather on a peg by the door, holding the pieces of an gual dathach¹⁷: pieces of every colour broken from the vein before Leac na Fèithe¹⁸ was laid, and fresh pieces taken in each life from where the vein shows in a stream bank above the well. Children of the line played with the pieces when they were small enough not to know better, and learned the colours so. The bag passed from father to son with the Line, and the father who held it said the recital.

A coal that answered was left to burn where it had answered, as the gold burned on the sea and the silver under the river, or kept in a pot of its own, as Brian kept the black coal, until it burned out. The line did not grieve a coal that went out; the bag held more of the same colour, and the way of lighting it was now known. What the line guarded was the knowing, and the knowing was in the recital.

15. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhireach
16. the pot of the fire; the clay pot in which the Mason’s line keeps what it holds to be the mason’s first fire
17. the coloured coal
18. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhireach

The reverences of the hearths

These were kept by the hill-folk at large, most of them by households that knew Aith-ris a' Chruthachaidh¹⁹ only in pieces.

Leac na Fèithe²⁰. When Teine na Fèithe²¹ burned out, Muirne of the line would not have it dug further. A flat stone was laid over the broken vein, no water was drawn beside it, and the well was cut again a stone's throw off. No house stands by Leac na Fèithe, no bucket is set near it, and the turf at its edge is kept whole against the rain. Children of the line are brought to lay a bare palm on it in the dark half of the year.

The fire given. Every hearth of the hill-folk was lit from 'Teine a' Chlachair²², by one borrowing or another, carried in a clay pot banked with ash. A fire was never sold. A household whose hearth died begged a coal from the nearest living one, and was never refused.

The dead in the ground. The hill-folk lay their dead in the ground, on the side, knees drawn up, facing the central mountains, with an uncut stone set on end at the head and no mark on it. At Tuam Cnoc dhìreach²³ on the south coast the graves came to be laid in rows, heads toward the mountains; the first rows are straight, the later ones bend round older graves no one will disturb. At Achadh dhìreach, in one grave in some thirty, coal of the vein is rubbed into the wool the dead are wrapped in. At Tuam Cnoc dhìreach a child was buried with a sliver of an gual dathach²⁴ closed in one hand, and there were words between two households over it.

The covered hearth. In the Doire uaine hills the fire is kept in pits under slabs, with a blind bend in the shaft, against the thing that walks without breathing (Appendix E). The line at Tobar dhìreach would not cover its own fire, holding 'Teine a' Chlachair owed better than to hide.

The uncut woods. Two woods were let alone: Coille Naomh Muileann chiar²⁵, from whose edge no household cut a branch, and Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag²⁶ in the west, never walked from end to end, where three paths stop at a line of set stones.

The stones and their sayings. Three standing stones were found in the west and south-west within some two hundred years, each bearing words in the tongue of the hill-folk: Carragh Cnoc bheag²⁷, *Bha teine sa chloich*, "there was fire in the stone," cut

19. the Telling of the Making

20. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

21. the fire of the vein; the burning of the broken vein in the mason's well, VE 1 – 151

22. the mason's fire, the first fire

23. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

24. the coloured coal

25. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

26. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

27. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

low beneath a line of the unread script; Colbh Cnoc chiar²⁸, *Cuimbnich an teine*, "remember the fire"; and Calbh Cnoc ghorm²⁹, *Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann*, "we did not come; we were here." None of the hill-folk could read a letter. How the words came to be known at every hearth is a riddle the tellings leave as they found it; known they were, and said the same way at every hearth that told of them. At Colbh Cnoc chiar a ring of ground was trodden hard and paved with fire-cracked stones, and fires the size of hearths were kept there. At the column the saying was said standing, and the gatherings grew.

Oidhche an Dealanaich³⁰. The dark of the year, when the vein first took fire, was kept at every hearth that had heard of it with a fire built high and the fathers' names said by whoever knew them. At Tobar dhìreach it was the night of the recital. By the close of the age, in the hill country about the column, it was the night of the great telling.

What is not known of the Old Ones' holy things

Of the faith of Seann-Dhaoine³¹ only what they built remains, and what they built does not explain itself. They rowed their dead to Eilean dhearg and laid them in stone boxes facing the mainland, and no box was left open through a night. They raised a stepped platform of fitted stone in the eastern hills with an altar block on its top step, set square to the central mountains, with its back to the sea; the top stone of the altar was prised off and carried away, and the platform left. Two shafts were cut straight down through the rock at the two Toll-dubhs, far apart, smooth-walled, with no spoil beside them; stones thrown into either are not heard to land. A script was cut on the cliff above their landing at Tarr³²; the same script stands on the rocks of the Doire uaine hills and on the upper face of Carragh Cnoc bheag³³, and who cut those is not known. No one of the hill-folk could read a sign of it. They notched their net-weights with three strokes. Whether any of these things was holy to them, and to what, no telling of the hill-folk says, and Seann-Dhaoine' own tellings, if they had any, are not known.

28. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

29. the column at Cnoc ghorm

30. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

31. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

32. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

33. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

APPENDIX C

CUNNTAS NAN ATHRAICHEAN

No one in this age counted years. There was no tally, no notched stick kept for the purpose, no stone cut with marks, and no number of years from any beginning was said at any hearth. The dates in the annals of this volume, from 20 am Faoilleach VE 1 at the breaking of the vein to 21 an t-Iuchar VE 5,324 in the grove, are the dates of the annals of the island, set against its master record; the people of the age would not have understood them. This appendix tells how they knew time instead: by Cunntas nan Athraichean¹, by the turning of the year, by Oidhche an Dealanaich², and by the beasts and birds that keep their own seasons.

The count of fathers

The only long measure the age had was Cunntas nan Athraichean³, and only the mason's line kept it whole. A father, in this count, is a span as much as a man: the time from a father's taking the bag to his son's. Asked how long ago a thing was, an elder of the line answered in fathers, *so many fathers back*, and a listener who wanted it closer could ask *in whose father's time*, and be told a name if the name was one the line gave to strangers, or a count if it was not. The line itself reckoned a father at about the time it takes a boy to grow and have a son of his own grown, and the count held true enough that the named fathers, set against the years of the annals, stand spaced as the recital says (Appendix A).

Other households counted fathers too, but shorter. Most hearths of the hill-folk could give four or five fathers back, and a few old women could give eight or nine; past that a household said *long ago*, or *in the mason's time*, or *before the fire*, which meant the same as *never*. Diarmad, gathering the names for the Line, found that old women who had never troubled over his question had kept names back without being asked, and were glad to give them to someone willing to carry the weight of remembering them. Among Seann-Dhaoine⁴ no count of any kind is known.

1. the count of the fathers; the only long measure of time in the age, a father to about twenty-five years

2. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

3. the count of the fathers; the only long measure of time in the age, a father to about twenty-five years

Cunntas nan Athraichean made spans easy to say and dates hard. The line could say that Aodh gave the seven to the sea eighteen fathers after Diarmad went to the grove, but not how many winters Aodh had seen, except by counting them in his own lifetime at his own hearth. Ages were known within a household by the winters a person had lived through, counted on the fingers and remembered by the hard ones: *she was born the winter the seed rotted; he was a boy of ten winters when the whale came ashore*. The ages given in this volume for the people of the line are the annals' ages; the households themselves would have said them in winters, and would not always have agreed.

The turning of the year

The year was known by its halves and its marks. The dark half ran from the first frosts to the lambing, and the light half from the lambing to the frosts. Within them each household knew the year by its own work: the peat cut and stacked, the barley sown in the small fields and cut, the flocks taken up to the shielings and brought down, the seals hauling out on the skerries in the autumn gales, the eels running in the rivers, the kilns smoking on the south-east coast through the summer. A woman of the shore might say a thing happened *at the second hauling-out* and be understood along the whole of that coast and nowhere else.

The dates of the annals name the months, from am Faoilleach in the dead of winter to an Dùbhlachd at the year's close. The hill-folk of the age named stretches of the year and not fixed counts of days, and a stretch began when the weather that named it began. The shortest day was marked at the temple platform in the eastern hills by Seann-Dhaoine⁴, who climbed the steps in the dark and stood about the great stone the whole hour the light took to cross it; the hill-folk marked it, if at all, by a fire.

The night of the lightning

The one night of the year that the whole of the high valleys kept on the same night was Oidhche an Dealanaich⁵, in the dark of the winter, when the vein first took fire. At Tobar dhìreach the Line was said standing that night, Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁷ after it and Tòimhseachan a' Choimhdich⁸ after that, and any new line for a coal was added.

4. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

5. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

6. the night of the lightning; the dark-of-the-year night on which the Line of the Mason is said standing

7. the Telling of the Making

8. the Keeper's riddle

At other hearths the fire was built high and the fathers' names said by whoever knew them. As the age went on the night gathered other things to it: the gathering at Àth gharbh where the valleys first named themselves Clann nan Dè⁹; the ring of fires about Colbh Cnoc chiar¹⁰; and, from Seathan's time, the great telling at the column, to which some hundreds walked from every quarter of the hill country. By the close of the age the hill country about the column reckoned its year by the gatherings there, one in the dark of the year and one at midsummer, and a thing done between them was said to be done *between the gatherings*.

The beasts that keep their seasons

Where Cunntas nan Athraichean¹¹ was too long and the year too short, the hill-folk measured by the beasts.

The salmon came up the rivers in their great runs at much the same season each year, and the weirs on the Abhainn ìseal were renewed in the same holes for the runs, so that the households along that river knew the late summer by the salmon before they knew it by anything else.

The geese of Eilean ghorm came in with the first storm of the winter and left with the last, and households that watched them close enough learned to read the turn of the winter in their leaving, which came a day or two ahead of the year's last storm. The geese of the southern coast, going over in their numbers in the autumn, told the southern households that the season had turned; in the year the eleven went up from Teal-laichean a' Chladaich¹², the geese were late, and the shore read the season as a slow one.

The seals hauled out to pup on the skerries off Eilean fhada in the autumn gales, and on Eilean mhin in their own season, and the hunters went out when the seals were there.

The great cats of the mountains crossed the high ground by fixed ways at fixed seasons, and from Beithir's time the households learned the crossing season and kept off the passes while it lasted. A crossing mark was cut on each shieling's gatepost when the season came, and scraped bare when it had been kept, so that a latecomer knew the season had been kept there before. It was the nearest thing to a tally the hill-folk made, and it counted one thing only: that the cats had passed.

9. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

10. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

11. the count of the fathers; the only long measure of time in the age, a father to about twenty-five years

12. the hearths of the shore; the southern-shore households from which the eleven went up (place 1006)

The white stag of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar¹³ was seen at long intervals, and the hunters who saw it did not draw. A household of the east might say a thing happened *the year the stag was seen*, and be understood.

The span of a life

No one in this age lived long. A child who lived past its fifth winter might hope for fifty or sixty more; a man or woman of seventy was old, and one of eighty was a wonder spoken of along a whole valley. The named fathers of the line died between sixty and their early seventies, most at their own hearths; Suibhne died of a fever at forty-six. Many children died before they could walk, and fevers took the young in bad seasons along whole shores. A household reckoned its strength by how many of its children had lived to be grown, and a woman who had lost children young and trusted, at last, that one would live, sewed it a coat cut to its own growing.

Because lives were short and Cunntas nan Athraichean¹⁴ long, the tellings of this age are a relay: no one lived to see more than one or two of the lightings, and the line's knowledge of the coals passed from hand to hand across two hundred fathers with no one to say from memory how a thing had first been done. What a keeper knew of the lightings before his own was what the recital gave him, and what the recital gave him was what the fathers before him had chosen to keep.

Spans in this volume

Because the age had no count, spans in the Books of this volume are given as the tellers of the age would have given them: in fathers, in lifetimes, in winters, or in the seasons of the beasts. Where the annals give a year, it is the annals' own year. The two do not quarrel: a father in the recital is about twenty-five of the annals' years, a lifetime some sixty to seventy, and the line's own boast that the bag had waited *longer than any stone in the south* means a little over four thousand of them.

13. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

14. the count of the fathers; the only long measure of time in the age, a father to about twenty-five years

APPENDIX D

The Peoples of the Shore and the Hills

Two peoples lived on the island in this age, and no telling of either says that they met. The hill-folk, who called themselves Clann nan Dè¹ from the time of the gathering at Àth gharbh, had fire from the mason's vein, buried their dead in the ground, and cut no script. Seann-Dhaoine² kept every coast, rowed their dead to the islands, built in stone, and cut a script of their own that the hill-folk could not read. Things passed between them, a chip of an gual dathach³ on a midden at Bral⁴, a second hand on a standing stone, but how is not told. This appendix sets out what is known of each: where they lived, how many they were, and what they made.

Numbers

At the breaking of the vein there were perhaps a few thousand souls on the whole island. By the time the walls of the heights were raised there were some ten thousand, and at the close of the age some eighteen thousand, of whom Seann-Dhaoine⁵ were perhaps a third. No one of the age counted them. The largest place on the island was Skell⁶ on the Abhainn naomh, with some three hundred souls at its height; Tobar dhìreach held some ninety at the close; most hearth-kindreds of the hill-folk were of twenty to eighty souls, and most landings of Seann-Dhaoine of thirty to a hundred. The three rings of Làrach an Dùin⁷ were built with room for four hundred people and their beasts, and are the only place of the age made for more than a landing's worth. A crowd at the column on the night of a great telling was some hundreds.

1. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

3. the coloured coal

4. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

5. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

6. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it

7. the fortress ruin

The Old Ones

Seann-Dhaoine⁸ left their first sure trace at the eastern Dunn⁹, in the great mound of shell, seal bone and burnt weed that the households there laid down over many lifetimes. From there, by the evidence of what they built, they came to hold every coast of the island, and at their widest reach they had landings at every good harbour from the north-western horn to the south-eastern cape. The hill-folk of the close of the age did not say *Seann* before the landings' names, and called each by its bare root, the only words of Seann-Dhaoine' speech that have come down.

The ten roots. The landings go under ten names, several landings to a name:

ROOT	LANDINGS IN THIS AGE	KNOWN FOR
Skell	on the Abhainn naomh in the west; the north-west- ern horn; the northern coast	the mole; the hollow-walled tower; the curved mole
Dunn	the eastern coast; the Abhainn chaol in the south-east; the southern coast	the shell mound; the head of the sea-way; the whale-rib houses
Cwen	the head of the southern gulf; two on the southern coast	the notched net-weights; the midden that outgrew Dunn's
Bral	the far western coast; the south-eastern coast	the two hundred and twelve steps; the fish- kilns
Morn	the south-eastern coast; the southern coast	the seven fish-kilns; the headland of heaped shell
Brenn	the northern coast; the north-eastern coast	the stone ramps and the great hulls
Toll	the northern coast; the Abhainn uaine; the north- eastern cleft	the buried huts; the fish-channel; the quay cut in the rock
Vell	the south-east; the Abhainn bheag; the western dunes; an inland river	the round houses; the four houses and boat- shed; the store-pits
Warr	the western shore of Loch chrom; the southern shore of the gulf	the shell road
Tarr	the eastern cliff; the north-eastern headlands; a north- eastern inlet	the cut script; the cliff-house; landing stones

Their works. Seann-Dhaoine built in stone without mortar, stone set against stone, and their building held: the mole at Skell¹⁰ stands with its foot under water at the low-est tides; the steps at Bral¹¹ are worn hollow; the round houses at the eastern Vell¹² stand in their rings. They made the first buildings on the island for a trade, the fish-

8. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich
9. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)
10. the Old Ones' own root for their landings (burgs 489, 16, 132); the hill-folk do not yet say Seann before it
11. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)
12. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

kilns at Morn¹³; the first made road, the shell causeway at Warr¹⁴; the first quay, the mole; the first ramps for hulls greater than hide boats, at Brenn¹⁵. They sank their nets with notched stones, the eldest mark on the island made again and again of purpose, and they cut a script on the cliff at Tarr¹⁶.

The heights. In the middle lifetimes of the age some of Seann-Dhaoine went up from the shore. They raised the walled outpost of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹⁷ on a spur above the southern lowland, its stones dressed on the outer face only and its single gate looking inland; the three rings of Làrach an Dùin¹⁸ on a height some way from it, with a cistern cut into the bedrock; a kerbed way paved with flat slabs toward both; the stepped platform of Làrach an Teampaill¹⁹ in the eastern hills, its altar set square to the central mountains; and the two shafts of the Toll-dubhs, south-east and west, cut straight down and smoothed. Whether the builders of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire and of the rings were the same people is not known.

The going down. Then the gate of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire was walled up with rubble from within, and Làrach an Dùin-fhaire left; the cistern of the rings was choked with the bones of cattle thrown in whole, and the rings left; the top stone of the altar was prised off and carried away, and the temple left. The households of the heights came down to the shore, to Skell and Morn and the southern Cwen²⁰ and the northern Skell, and after that Seann-Dhaoine made no new work anywhere out of sight of salt water. Their last lifetimes in this age were lifetimes of the shore: the middens of the south grew as fast as Dunn's once had, landings once counted by the dozen were counted by the score, and a lane of flat landing-stones a day's rowing apart ran along the south-east coast from the river mouth below Dunn round the great cape. Who walled the gate, who fouled the cistern, who took the altar stone, and why, is not known.

Their dead. Seann-Dhaoine of the eastern Vell rowed their dead to Eilean dhearg and laid them in stone boxes facing the mainland; forty boxes are counted there. No grave of theirs of this age is found on the main island.

The hill-folk

The hill-folk were the people of Teine a' Chlachair²¹: every hearth of theirs was lit from the vein, by one borrowing or another. They lived in households of twenty to eighty,

13. the Old Ones' root (burgs 186, 465)

14. the Old Ones' root (burgs 64, 128)

15. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

16. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

17. the watch-fort ruin

18. the fortress ruin

19. the temple ruin

herding sheep and cattle, hunting deer, growing barley in small fields, and gathering; they built in turf and timber and laid their hearths on stone. They buried their dead in the ground facing the central mountains. They cut no script and read none. They had no king, no chief over more than a household, no war and no walled place; a quarrel between households was settled by the elders of both, or not at all.

The high valleys, about the crack on the north side of the central mountains, were the heart of them: Tobar dhìreach, the black well and the young well, Achadh dhìreach, Àth gharbh and the hearths between. Here the Line was said and Aithris a' Chruthachaidh²² kept, here the valleys first named themselves Clann nan Dè²³, and from here the fire went out.

The Doire uaine hills, south of the high valleys, were herding country, full of rock faces cut with lines of the unread script. After the hollow thing was first told of there, the households of those hills put their fires under the ground (Appendix E), and kept them there to the close of the age. Na Teallaichean Falaichte²⁴ is their largest hamlet.

The east was deer country. The households of the eastern woods drove the red deer into Gleann nan Damh²⁵ each autumn and stacked the antlers of the greatest stags apart; they let Coille Naomh Muileann chiar²⁶ alone, and there the white stag was first seen. At Cnoc fhionn they first buried their dogs beside their people.

The south-east valleys, the slope of Bruthach nan Teaghlach²⁷ above the river running down toward the kilns, were settled by herders from the high valleys in the lifetimes of the heights; some of their sick were carried to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh²⁸.

The south-west hill country, about the column, was the country of the three stones and, from the finding of Calbh Cnoc ghorm²⁹, of the gatherings at Achadh a' Chalb³⁰.

The northern shore was seal country. Its households hunted seal on the skerries off Eilean fhada from Bothan an Fhoghair³¹ in the autumn gales, fished from skin

21. the mason's fire, the first fire

20. the Old Ones' root (burgs 36, 14, 139)

22. the Telling of the Making

23. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

24. the hidden hearths; the hill hamlet of the Doire uaine hills with its covered pit-hearths (place 1007, site of burg 148)

25. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

26. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

27. the slope of the households; the hill households of the south-eastern valleys (place 1009, site of burg 315)

28. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

29. the column at Cnoc ghorm

30. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

31. the autumn bothies; the north-shore hunters' camp by the seal skerries off Eilean fhada (place 1002)

boats, and watched the grey on the northern and eastern sea that never lifts. The north-western coast, from Ros ruadh to the strait, was Uilebheist na Mara³²'s country after the seven boats were lost, and its hunters moved into the lee of the headlands and the strait at Bothan a' Chaolais³³. A warning fire was kept on the north-western headland.

The southern shore was the country of the first boats: Oisean crossed to Eilean mhin from it, and the seal-camp of Bothan nan Ròn³⁴ was kept there every season after. Teallaichean a' Chladaich³⁵, the households from which the eleven went up into the hills, lay on this coast, and the burial-ground of Tuam Cnoc dhìreach³⁶ grew above it.

The lake shore about Loch chrom held the lake dwellings of Crannagan Loch chrom³⁷, whose builders are not known, and the hearths of the hill-folk on Creag Ruadh³⁸ above the eastern shore. Eòghann's wife Dearbhail was of the lake-shore line.

How the households lived

No one on the island in this age worked metal. The hill-folk and Seann-Dhaoine³⁹ alike cut with flint and chert, split with wedges of antler and hard stone, and dressed stone by pecking it with harder stone; a maul was a rounded cobble lashed to a haft of ash. A household's wealth was its beasts, its store of food against the dark half of the year, its boats if it had any, and the skill in its members' hands.

Houses. The hill-folk built round and oval houses of turf on a footing of stones, roofed with heather thatch over a frame of birch or, as the oak came in, of oak; the hearth stood in the middle of the floor on a flat stone, and the smoke went out through the thatch. Seann-Dhaoine built in dry stone where they could and in turf and driftwood where they could not: round houses with sunk hearths and drains at the eastern Vell⁴⁰, a long house in a cleft of the cliff at Tarr⁴¹, huts in the lee of a dune at the northern Toll⁴², and, where a whale gave them the chance, frames of rib. On the lake shore the platforms stood on oak piles over the water.

32. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

33. the bothies of the strait; the north-shore seal camp on the strait (place 1010, site of burg 95)

34. the seal bothies; the seasonal seal-hunters' camp on Eilean mhin (place 1001)

35. the hearths of the shore; the southern-shore households from which the eleven went up (place 1006)

36. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

37. the lake dwellings of Loch chrom (place 1003; spec name)

38. the red crag; the hearths of the lake-shore line on the red hill above Loch chrom (place 1011, site of burg 19)

39. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

40. the Old Ones' root (burgs 94, 97, 127, 162)

41. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

42. the Old Ones' root (burgs 37, 313, 404)

Food. The hill-folk ate mutton and beef, venison, barley bread and porridge, milk and curds, hazel-nuts roasted and stored, berries and roots in their seasons, and fish where they had water. Meat was cooked on stones heated at the fire's edge from the first years of the mason's hearth, and in pits of heated stones for a gathering. Seann-Dhaoine ate from the sea: shellfish above all, as their middens show, and fish, seal, seabirds and their eggs, and whale when one came ashore; they dried and smoked fish in their kilns and stored it in clay-lined pits.

Fire. Every fire of the hill-folk was *Teine a' Chlachair*⁴³, lent from hearth to hearth and carried in clay pots banked with ash. A household that let its hearth die begged a coal from the nearest living one. Hearths burned wood, peat and heather; before the first small burning at *Àth gharbh* no household outside the line burned an *gual dathach*⁴⁴, and after it very few did. How Seann-Dhaoine came by fire the tellings do not say.

Boats. The first boats were of hide stretched on a frame of bent hazel, greased against the wet; Oisean's was of that kind, and the north-shore hunters went out to the skerries in the like. Seann-Dhaoine built bigger boats of the same kind and, at *Brenn*⁴⁵, the first plank-built hulls, launched down stone ramps; of those hulls nothing is left. River landings kept flat-bottomed hulls for poling up the shallows.

Cloth. The hill-folk wove wool from their sheep and wore sealskin and deerskin cloaks in the cold; at *Achadh dhìreach*, late in the age, the wool of the dead was streaked with the colour of the vein. What Seann-Dhaoine wore the tellings do not say.

What passed between them

No telling keeps a meeting. The tellings keep three things that passed. A chip of an *gual dathach*⁴⁶, still staining the shell about it, was thrown on the midden at *Bral*⁴⁷ on the far western coast, late in the age: by gift, by trade or by theft, a piece of the vein came to Seann-Dhaoine⁴⁸. On the upper face of *Carragh Cnoc bheag*⁴⁹ runs a line of the unread script, and the four words of the hill-folk lie lower on the same face, cut with a narrower tool by another hand; which hand came first is not known. And the same script that Seann-Dhaoine cut on the cliff at *Tarr*⁵⁰ stands on the rock faces of the

43. the mason's fire, the first fire

44. the coloured coal

45. the Old Ones' root (burgs 328, 440)

46. the coloured coal

47. the Old Ones' root (burgs 47, 110)

48. the Old Ones, the people before the *Dia-thìrich*

49. the obelisk at *Cnoc bheag*

50. the Old Ones' root (burgs 249, 34, 402)

Doire uaine hills among the hill-folk's pastures. Whether the two peoples shared the island knowingly, no telling knows.

APPENDIX E

OF FEARS, BEASTS and Holy Places

The hill-folk of this age feared few things by name, and named them late. For most of the age a fear was a place a household did not go, a thing a child was told not to do, or a custom kept without a reason given; only toward its close did the fears gather names, and even then the names were few. This appendix gathers the fears, the beasts that the tellings keep, and the places that were let alone or kept holy, with what the tellings say of each and what they do not.

The fears

Uilebheist na Mara¹. Old sailors of the north-western coast told of a vast creature dwelling in the water off the north-western horn. Four men of that coast saw it rise once, and the youngest of them kept the telling word for word into his old age, adding nothing and taking nothing away; the coast counted this for more than any argument of the doubters. No wreck was ever brought up to prove the tellers wrong. For a long while Uilebheist na Mara was feared only in general, as a thing out there; then, in one calm season, seven boats of Ros ruadh went out on still water and did not come home, and the widows of Ros ruadh named it. It was the first loss laid at its door by name. After that the hunters of the north-west left the open water for the lee of the headlands and the strait, where the seal bones grew in the middens of Bothan a' Chaolais², and Criomthann kept a fire on the north-western headland, from a peat bank cut for it alone, to warn boats off the water where Uilebheist na Mara was seen. The fire was never lit to bring boats in. Its ash lies a man's height deep. What Uilebheist na Mara is, the tellings do not say; the households of Seann-Dhaoine³ tower on the north-western horn kept their boats out of the same water, and no one knows why.

Marbh-bheò⁴. In the Doire uaine hills, where the rock faces are cut with lines of the unread script more thickly than anywhere else on the island, the tellings came to

1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

2. the bothies of the strait; the north-shore seal camp on the strait (place 1010, site of burg 95)

agree that the writing told of something that walked without breathing and fell upon any who lit a fire in its sight. How the hills came to know what the writing said, when none of them could read a sign, is a riddle; known it was, and told the same way at every hearth. Some lines were cut over and defaced by another hand with the same kind of tool. Two or three people of the hills dreamed, without having spoken to one another, of something walking the ridges without breath; two herders saw a walker on a ridge and lived. The hills' answer was the covered hearth: Laoghaire dug the first pit-hearth, the fire under a slab at the foot of a slanting shaft bent near its foot so that no glow could climb it straight, and within a few lifetimes no open fire showed in those hills. Eimhir, who found the first cut stone, kept her hearth open to her death. Whether Marbh-bheò is, or was, the tellings do not say. The hills say only that a fire built where the ridge can see it is a fire built carelessly.

The camp of the nine. At a hill camp nine people were found dead inside one hut, lying where they fell beside a hearth of fresh ash, with no wound on any of them. The hut was never opened again and none was buried from it; the camp was left for good. The hills did not agree on a cause. Some laid it at Marbh-bheò's door, some at the fire itself, burning in a shut hut; the tellings keep both and choose neither.

The line of stones. Children of the country about Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag⁵ were told early and plainly: go as far as the stones and no further, and whatever crosses the line ahead of you, a ball or a lamb or a hound, let it go. A girl named Muireall went past the stones after a young deer and was never found. After her no household let its children watch for deer at that stretch without a grown hand near enough to close on a small arm.

The grey on the sea. On the northern and eastern sea lies a grey bank that never lifts. Scaire of the north shore saw it first from the skerries and would not steer toward it. Bran, a steersman of the north-west, sailed west with the grey bank on his right hand in search of an isle of the blessed, and did not come back; one of his crew came home, and died within days. The hill-folk name the western lands of the dead from Aithris a' Chruthachaidh⁶: Tìr nan Òg⁷, Magh Meall⁸, Taigh Dhuinn⁹. What lies in the grey, no telling says.

4. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

5. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

6. the Telling of the Making

7. the land of the young

8. the plain of delight

9. the house of Donn, where the dead go

The beasts

The great cats. The great cats of the mountains were known from the beginning of the age as a danger to flocks and lone walkers. From the time of Beithir, a herder of the high shoulders who first read their road in the snow, the tellings say that the cats keep their roads, crossing the mountains by fixed ways at fixed seasons. The households learned the crossing season and kept off the passes while it lasted, leaving the shielings of Àirighean a' Bhealaich¹⁰ stripped and shuttered and cutting a mark on each gatepost that was scraped when the season had been kept. Eleven of Teallaichean a' Chladaich¹¹ went up into the southern hills in the crossing season, reading the geese as late and the season as slow, and did not come home; their bones were found years after along the line the cats use, and were buried where they lay. Why the cats keep their roads, no one has learned.

The white stag. Three hunters of the east, Sadhbh and her cousin Ruadhan and one other, saw a white stag at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar¹², and none of them drew. It was seen again at long intervals, and the hunters of the gully began letting a beast go if a pale one was among the drove, sooner than risk the wrong one. Aithris a' Chruthachaidh¹³ says that Flidais keeps the wild things and that the white stag of the wood is hers; no one of this age tied the stag at the wood's edge to that line of Aithris a' Chruthachaidh, and in this age the stag has no god.

The red deer. The deer of the eastern woods were driven each autumn into Gleann nan Damh¹⁴ and killed at the gully's throat; the antlers of the greatest stags were stacked apart. The deer of Eilean dhubh, cut off when the sea drowned the neck, grew smaller in the lifetimes that followed.

The seals. The grey seals haul out to pup on the skerries off Eilean fhada in the autumn gales, and on Eilean mhin in their season. They were the first quarry for which anyone on the island crossed open water of set purpose.

The whales. A whale stranded below the southern Dunn¹⁵ was cut and shared along the whole shore, its oil burned through two winters and its ribs raised for house frames. Word of usable ribs travelled faster, by the end, than word of strandings once had.

The geese. The grey geese that winter on Eilean ghorm came in with the first storm and left with the last, and none hunted them there. A young man who sailed for

10. the shielings of the pass; herders' summer camps on the high passes, left empty while the cats cross (place 1004)

11. the hearths of the shore; the southern-shore households from which the eleven went up (place 1006)

12. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

13. the Telling of the Making

14. the glen of the stags; the deer-drive gully of the eastern woods (place 1005)

Eilean ghorm to hunt them is told three ways at three hearths, and remembered as a warning.

The dogs. At Cnoc fhionn a boy buried his dog beside his family's dead with a shell at its head, and within a few years two more households of that hill buried their dogs so. No beast had had a grave on the island before.

The crows and the wrens. The crows of the island are as black as the black coal, and Aithris a' Chruthachaidh gives them to the Morrigan; the hill-folk let them be. A wren came along the fallen trunk to within a hand of gual bogha-froise¹⁶ on Diarmad's second morning in the grove, looked at it and at him, and went about its business; the line tells it at the recital as a sign of nothing, and keeps it all the same.

The holy places

Leac na Fèithe¹⁷ over the vein at Tobar dhìreach, with no house beside it and no water drawn near it (Appendix B).

The grove at Doire ghlas, three days north of Tobar dhìreach, where the oaks came in on ground that had been open heath when the vein was broken. Coimhdeach na Fine¹⁸ came to Diarmad there, Cormac's blood lit the red-brown there, Suibhne sat a night there with the rainbow, and Ailean brought the six there at the close of the age. The line did not build there.

Binnean a' Chlachair¹⁹, the highest ground of the island, where Fearghas let the six fall and the snowflake burned; herders passing the summit each lay a stone on the cairn Mathan began.

Coille Naomh Muileann chiar²⁰, from which no household cut a branch; the households at its edge carried their fuel from beyond the far shoulder of open ground, two journeys where one would serve.

Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag²¹, the second wood, older-seeming than the first, never settled, never felled, never walked from end to end; three paths stop short of it at a low line of set stones.

Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh²², Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh south of the high valleys, where stone basins were set into the springs and the sick of the island were

15. the Old Ones' root (burgs 18, 295, 347)

16. the rainbow coal, of spirit

17. the slab of the vein; the flat stone laid over the burnt vein at Tobar dhìreach

18. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

19. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

20. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

21. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

22. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

first brought for healing. The keeper of the basins judged a wound by its colour and its smell, and in a dry summer heated stones were laid in the third basin to bring back its warmth. The dead buried near the springs have old breaks that knitted clean.

The three stones and their sayings: Carragh Cnoc bheag²³, Colbh Cnoc chiar²⁴ with its ring of fire-cracked stones, and Calbh Cnoc ghorm²⁵ with the gathering-ground of Achadh a' Chalbh²⁶ about it (Appendix B).

Tuam Cnoc dhìreach²⁷, the burial-ground on the south coast that none remembers hallowing, where the rows bend round older graves.

Seann-Dhaoine²⁸ **places.** The platform of Làrach an Teampaill²⁹ in the eastern hills; the two shafts of the Toll-dubhs, into which a youth of the south-east was once let down on a plaited rope and came up silent; the boxes on Eilean dhearg. The hill-folk of this age did not go to them. What they were to their makers is not known.

23. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

24. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

25. the column at Cnoc ghorm

26. the field of the column; the gathering-ground about Calbh Cnoc ghorm (place 1008, site of burg 392)

27. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

28. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

29. the temple ruin